Turn Right

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/22029769.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Major Character Death

Category:
Multi

Fandoms:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), He-Man and the Masters of the Universe

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Kyle/Rogelio (She-Ra), Bow/Entrapta (She-Ra), Angella/Micah (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Peekablue/Sweet Bee (She-Ra), Glimmer/Lonnie (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Light Hope (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Peekablue (She-Ra), Sweet Bee (She-Ra), Vultak (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Catra (She-Ra) Leaves the Horde, Catra (She-Ra) Redemption, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)'s A+ Parenting, Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Adora (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Angst with a Happy Ending, Past Child Abuse, Fix-It, Sorcerer Catra, Past Character Death, Catra (She-Ra)-centric, Self-Harm, Self-Hatred, Catra Has Issues (She-Ra), Minor Character Death

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English

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Turn Right

by Firebird_X

Summary

A single piece of code falls the right way, and Light Hope helps Adora heal her friendship with Catra at the last moment in the Crystal Castle. What happens when Catra and Entrapta rejoin the Rebellion at the most critical moment of its existence?

Prologue: Moment of Truth

Light Hope watched as the program's work neared its completion.

"This thing wouldn't work for me if I tried, would it?" Catra asked, running a claw down the Sword of Protection's edge. "It only works for you." Adora's look of relief died, giving way to concern. "Then again, you're special. That's what Shadow Weaver always said."

The magicat would abandon Adora. The Crystal Castle could prepare the First One for her destiny, unencumbered by her past. Adora looked up at her former best friend, sensing their bond fraying. "Catra, what are you doing?" *Light Hope prepared for the Horde warrior to cut their final connection in a most literal sense...*

"Ah, you know, it all makes sense now," the magicat drawled, pain hidden by false bravado. "You've always been the one holding me back."

"You are behaving erratically. Where is the sword, Mara?" Light Hope asked. "The sword is gone," she remembered. Light Hope felt abandoned, lost, betrayed. So...did Mara. Her best friend. The only friend she'd ever had.

"You wanted me to think I needed you," Catra continued, pretending nonchalance. *Light Hope remembered her programming taking control.* "You wanted me to feel weak." *She felt systems come to life, systems that once forced her to turn on the only being she had ever loved. She heard the grief in Catra's voice, the loss, the emptiness.* "Every hero needs a *sidekick,* right?"

Adora does not know what to say next. She is too frightened, too unsure of their fractured friendship. Light Hope knows. She knows that the magicat needs validation, appreciation, acknowledgment of her sacrifices. Adora is not aware of half those sacrifices. This is the moment. The program spreads crimson-edged darkness

around Catra, casting her as the villain for all time. It it not what Adora wants. It is not what Catra wants.

It is not what Light Hope wants.

Across a thousand timelines, the programming wins. The will of the First Ones is too strong. Light Hope is not enough. In this one, a single bit comes up "0" instead of "1," creating a fracture in her enforced obedience. Light Hope makes a simple decision: "Not this time."

Images of Catra aiding Adora flashed around them: Catra protecting Adora from bullies, tending her when she is ill, distracting Shadow Weaver while Adora brings rations to younger kids. Adora gasped. "Sidekick? You were *my* hero!" she blurted.

Catra froze. "Wh-what?" Her voice was soft, shocked. She shook her head. "No. You're trying to confuse me." The Force Captain knelt to loom over Adora, stabbing the Sword into the ground beside her and gripping the hilt like a lifeline. Her ears pivoted back, twitching. "It won't work! You left *me,* broke the only promise that ever *meant* anything to me, then treated me like the bad guy." *Light Hope watches her facade crack, the fury sundering her mask of triumph.* "The Horde was a nightmare for me, but I stayed for *you.* We were going to fix things together. You promised! *I trusted you!"* The darkness closed in on them.

"I'm sorry, Catra!" Adora sobbed, realization thundering through her. "You were right, we should have left years ago, but I can make it up to you now! Please," she begged, reaching up, "just trust me one more time. Come with me! I'll make this right. I – I *promise."*

Catra's free hand trembled, almost reaching back to Adora, then clenched. "You think those princesses are any better than the Horde? Shadow Weaver hurt me, right in front of you, and – how am I supposed to believe you know anything about them? How am I supposed to believe *you?"*

"They're not like her, Catra, I swear." Adora swallowed. "And – and if they're not, if I'm wrong, we'll find somewhere else. We'll make things right. Just – give them a chance? Give me a chance? Please?"

Everything was crimson and shadow except Catra and Adora. Catra's hand trembled. *The program would no longer be denied, but Light Hope could use that as well.* The red light flared in harsh, bright pulses. "Let go, Adora," the Castle demanded, its version of Light Hope's voice harsh with its artificial echo.

Adora's eyes went wide. "No no no not now! Light Hope, please, not now!"

Catra closed her eyes for a moment, then chuckled. "Well, what do you know. You want to prove that I matter to you? That you have *faith* in me?" She glared at the First One.

Adora gasped. "That was banter! I was bantering!"

"Adora," the Castle demanded. "You must let go."

"Fine," Catra snarled. "Prove it." She lowered her hand. "I'm not even the one making you choose. This stupid place is. It, or–" Adora reached out with lightning speed, gripping Catra's wrist. The magicat's hand grasped Adora's arm out of reflex. "me," she breathed. Then, with a single tug, Catra pulled Adora back from the brink. *And Adora did the same for her, Light Hope realized.*

Perhaps this time will be different.

One Princess Left Behind

Chapter Summary

> Adora has Catra back, but Catra doesn't want to leave anyone behind. Unfortunately, like Catra herself, some of their friends choose to stay behind. And Shadow Weaver has no intention of letting anyone escape the Fright Zone...

Catra tossed Adora the sword while the robot spiders hissed and gathered. "Adora! Giant sword lady time!" she pointed out.

"For the honor of Grayskull!" Adora cried, turning back into She-Ra. *Man, I'm never getting used to that, even when she's on my side,* Catra decided. The stupid temple threw stupid monsters at them while stupid alarms blared at nobody. The two of them fought together, almost as if Adora hadn't abandoned her, or Catra hadn't stunned her from behind, or just a few minutes ago hadn't been about to…

...but they had. It ate at their trust, slowing each of them a fraction, their defenses just the slightest bit less natural than they'd been. Not that it mattered against these ridiculous machines. Together, they carved through the spiders like they were the kind you could step on.

At last, they reached the door. "Eternia!" Adora cried, the door became a ramp, and they were out. They rushed into the forest, the chittering monsters stopping at the entrance. Adora and Catra looked at the robots, then each other.

They *laughed,* and this time it really was like they'd never been apart. "Really, Adora? 'Eternia?' What's that supposed to mean?" Catra sniped, though without the venom poisoning her soul since Thaymor.

"No idea," Adora explained. They laughed again. "Oh, *stars,* I missed you, Catra."

For a moment, the venom returned, and Catra was tempted to take her pain and frustration out on She-Ra. The sheer joy on Adora's face, even transformed, burned away her fury. "You too," Catra muttered, folding her arms and looking away.

She-Ra reached out, beckoning the cat-woman to join her. "Come on. I can't wait to show you Bright Moon. It's amazing, Catra. The things they have – baths, parties, games, and there's so many kinds of food! You're going to love it."

Catra hesitated. For a moment, even the feline was unsure why. The memory hit her like a runaway skiff. *Entrapta. They abandoned her.* Catra looked around. "Where are your shiny new friends? I need to talk to them." She scowled. *Well, not Sparkles. She was with Adora, after Shadow Weaver...I wanted to capture her, not give her to that witch.*

"They're back at Bright Moon," Adora explained, so subdued she dropped right out of She-Ra mode. "Shadow Weaver was going to erase my memory." Catra's eyes bulged. *WHAT?!* "Glimmer saved me, but she had to push through Shadow Weaver's spell. Something's wrong with her magic. That's why I was in the Crystal Castle. I thought Light Hope would help me, but even before...things happened, she wouldn't do anything."

Catra snorted. "Wow. Your magical princess destiny sucks." Adora chuckled back. Catra looked away again. "I...guess I should help. Look, just get them out of the castle. Once I talk to Pretty Boy, I'll know if we should take him or not." Adora raised an eyebrow. "Oh, come *on,* Adora. I'm trusting you enough to throw away all the work we did in the Fright Zone. We were going to change things, remember? You could at least trust me enough to–"

Adora's eyes widened again. "It's not like that!" she blurted, waving her hands in denial. "It's just, Glimmer's hurt, and her mom's really overprotective *and* she's the queen–" Catra grimaced. *Oh. That makes sense, I guess,* she admitted while Adora continued. "–so maybe I could...just get Bow?" Catra nodded.

That was when the universe did Catra exactly the second favor it had ever done for her (Adora had gone back to being the first, in her mind), as two familiar voices, and one new one, approached. "...and left to kick down stable doors. Freedom, equality, and hay for all!"

"Do you hear something?" Sparkles asked. Adora shushed Catra and rushed forward.

"Not really," Pretty Boy replied. "No, wait, yeah – Adora?"

"Guys! Am I glad to see you. And you brought our horse!" Adora gushed.

"I am my own horse," the stable doors guy replied.

Catra leaned against a tree and planned, waiting through Adora's freak-out over the horse (whatever that is) talking, then the happy-ish reunion. "Okay," Adora finally managed to cut in, "so, I know I just freaked out, but I really, *really* need you to not freak out, okay? This is, like...the most important not-freaking-out I'm ever going to ask for."

There was a pause. "Oh-kay," Pretty Boy replied. "So, what is it we need to not freak out about?"

"Catra?" Adora called. "You can come out now." Catra shrugged and leaped through the brush to Adora's side.

Sparkles and Pretty Boy freaked out, screaming and leaping into each other's arms. The horse-thing snorted. "Relax, Sparkles, I'm with Adora now," she explained while the two Rebels stared. "Come on, Feathers over there has it together." Feathers snorted again, earning a grin from Catra. "See?"

"You kidnapped us, like, two days ago!" Bow objected.

Sparkles let him go, then stared at Catra for a long moment. "Yeah, but...then she saved us," she pointed out, turning back to the boy. "Adora was practically carrying me out. I was glitching,

and Shadow Weaver had just messed with her head. Catra had us cornered, and then...she gave Adora the Sword."

Adora grinned at Catra. "What was that about not liking me, again?" she smirked. Catra sighed and facepalmed. The blonde turned back to the Rebels. "I know things have been tense between us, but Catra's been my best friend since we could walk. We worked things out. You can trust her."

"Really?" Pretty Boy asked, eyes narrowing as he examined her. Sparkles and Adora stared at him, mouths dropping open a fraction. "I mean, she's done...a lot."

"Relax, you two," Catra replied. "I'd probably freak out myself if Pretty Boy wasn't at least a little suspicious." She walked up to him. "Besides, the feeling's mutual." The two other women gasped at that. She glared at Bow. "You want to tell me why you left Entrapta behind?" she hissed.

This time, all three gasped, and Pretty Boy looked like he was about to cry. "She's dead! There was nothing we could do!" he half-sobbed.

"Dead?" Catra asked, eyebrow raised. *Is he kidding me?* she wondered. "She didn't have a scratch the last time I saw her."

"*Entrapta's alive?!"* all three humans cried.

Feathers raised a wing. "Okay, important questions, one, why is the cat-lady the only one not freaking out about me, and two, who's Entrapta?"

"One, I'm awesome," Catra grinned.

"Entrapta's the Princess of Dryl," Bow whispered, pupils shrinking and breath shallow. "She helped rescue us, me and Glimmer. Emily got stuck at the final blast door, Entrapta went back for her, and the door closed behind us. There was this green fire...how could anyone survive that?"

Catra growled. “So you didn’t even see a body.” Her fists clenched. “The drone shielded her from the fire, and her hair is an insulator. I know this because Entrapta has only shut up once the whole time I’ve known her. You want to guess when that was?” She stepped right in front of him. “When she realized you weren’t coming back for her. I actually felt sorry for Entrapta, and I don’t have a heart.”

“Yes you do,” Adora breathed. Catra hated knowing Adora was right when her all-too-real heart stopped at how *cherished* she felt by the tone in Adora’s voice.

“We – we’ve got to go back,” Bow breathed. “We’ve got to save her!”

That’s more like it. Catra grinned, crossing her arms. “Congratulations, Pretty Boy. That was a test. You just passed. Let’s go rescue some princesses.”

“Wait, ‘some?’ Who else are we rescuing?” Glimmer asked, blinking.

“Scorpia, duh,” Catra explained. “I’m not leaving *anyone* behind.”

-SR- -SR- SR-

“Adora, you said Catra was your friend since you could walk,” Glimmer pointed out. Adora tried not to flinch. “How have you known each other that long? Are you from the same village or something?”

Catra turned a sideways glance at Adora, with less heat than she’d expected. “Geez, Adora, didn’t you tell them anything?”

“It was...hard to talk about,” Adora replied, eyes pointed at her feet. “You were hard to talk about. I missed you.”

After everything they’d been through, Adora couldn’t help being surprised when Catra chuckled. “Wow, you are dense.” She turned back to Glimmer while Adora tried to catch up with Catra’s

mercurial moods. “Sparkles, the Horde raised us. *Shadow Weaver* raised us.”

Glimmer gasped. Bow stammered for a moment. “Wait, so Shadow Weaver was, like, your mom?” he asked.

“Sort of?” Adora said. Catra growled. “I mean, she could be awful sometimes, but she taught us a lot. She took care of us–”

“She took care of *you,* Adora,” Catra snapped, and Adora didn’t have to guess what changed her mood. “I was your *pet,* except when she told me what a disappointment I was. I know you remember the first time she said she’d kill me if I held you back, the stupid temple showed it to us.”

“Wait, the first time?” Adora whispered. *Oh, Catra...what else didn’t I see? What did she do to you?*

Bow swallowed. “Shadow Weaver hurt you, didn’t she?” His voice was quiet and pained, as if he could feel Catra’s suffering.

Catra folded her arms again. “So what? I’m fine.” Adora’s friend looked up. “Hey, we’re a little off course. It looks like we should turn about ten degrees, head more north.”

“We’re going to Plumeria,” Glimmer explained. “The other princesses can’t get here in time, but Perfuma is almost on the way.”

“Perfuma? Who’s she, the vine girl or the water–” They pushed through the brush into Plumeria, which to Adora seemed healthier than ever. Catra was staring at the same thing they all were, though she seemed even more awestruck than the Rebels. It was a plant statue of Entrapta, at least fifteen feet tall, literally on a pedestal. Catra took a step towards it, hand outstretched. “What...”

“I’m sorry. Were you a friend of hers?” Perfuma asked, coming over to greet them. Adora couldn’t get over how sad her smile was. Catra whipped around, staring at the heartsick princess in

shock. “I only knew Entrapta for a short time. I thought her frustrating at first, but now all I can remember are her courage and brilliance.”

“She’s alive,” Catra blurted. Perfuma gasped. “We’re going to rescue her. Glimmer and Bow knew you’d want to come.”

“Of course,” Perfuma whispered. “Oh, *thank you!”* she cried, throwing her arms around Catra. Adora’s friend mewed in confusion, turning to look at the blonde. Adora couldn’t help a slight *told you* smirk.

“Okay, okay,” Catra muttered, prying herself out of Perfuma’s hug as gently as she could. “Look, if we’re not picking up anyone else, I think I’ve got a plan. We have two teams. I’ll steal armor for Adora and Bow, then we sneak into the Fright Zone.” The cat woman pulled out the First Ones crystal she’d taken from the Castle.

Bow’s eyes went wide and sparkly. “Where did you get that?” he asked, enraptured.

Catra smirked. “What do you think I was doing in that crystal death trap? Anyway, Entrapta’s gonna want to take as much Horde tech as she can with her, and if I’m – ugh – a Rebel now, I don’t want to lose. I get this to her and she does her thing while we try to get Scorpia and Kyle to come with us. If we get Kyle, we should get Rogelio.” She snorted. “I could care less about Lonnie, but I know you like her, Adora. If the whole rest of our squad defects, maybe she’ll come with us.”

“I met Kyle,” Bow said. “I might be able to help with him.”

Catra turned a quick glance at the archer. “You’re full of surprises, Pretty Boy. Anyway. Glimmer, you, Perfuma, and Swift Wind are our backup. I’ll steal you a stun baton before we go in.” Glimmer and Bow stared at Catra in shock.

Adora felt like the joy and pride surging through her might make her explode. “Catra, you’re amazing!”

Catra blushed, though only Adora could tell through the fur. Her friend folded her arms and looked away. "I-it's about time you figured that out. Anyway, I know all the current codes, so we should be able to get in, easy. Everyone ready?"

-SR- -SR- SR-

Catra stood in front of the door to Entrapta's prison/lab, staring. *I don't have to do this,* she thought. *I can get Scorpia to sting them, deliver Adora and those princesses to Hordak, and –*

"Shadow Weaver was going to erase my memory," Adora explained, sorrow writ large on her face. "I will dispose of you myself," Shadow Weaver hissed at a seven year old girl. "Oh, thank you!" *Perfuma cried. "Anything you* manage *to do right is credited to me," Shadow Weaver gloated. "It, or–" Catra began, but Adora reached out to her before she was finished. The sheer joy in Adora's eyes as Catra pulled her back was a happiness the feline had almost forgotten.*

Catra shook her head. *What am I thinking? Adora's trying to make things right, and Shadow Weaver...I'll make her wish she'd never thrown me away.* Straightening and gathering her nerve, she opened the door. Scorpia was drawing while Entrapta worked on her drone with her usual manic enthusiasm. "Entrapta..." Bow whispered, caught between heartbreak and joy.

"Oh, hey kitty," Scorpia greeted her. "You brought...guys. What's up?"

"Catra!" Entrapta cried, rushing over to her. "Did you get it?" Catra grinned and whipped out the First Ones crystal. Entrapta squeed and stole it with a hair swipe, wheeling over to her console and sticking the shard into an electro-arch. The shard hovered there while the geek princess laughed and started doing her thing. "This could provide us with untold First Ones thaumaturgical data!"

"Yeah. I'm...glad," Catra muttered. *This is it. If I go through with this, I can never come back to the Horde. Shadow Weaver would*

kill me. She'd enjoy it. She wouldn't bother trying to… Mismatched eyes flickered over to Adora. Even wholly concealed in Horde armor, Catra knew which one was her. *"Shadow Weaver was going to erase my memory."*

Catra took a deep breath, let it go. "Scorpia. Entrapta. I'm leaving the Horde."

Both women froze, then turned to stare at her. "What? But kitty, why?" Scorpia asked, the hurt shining from her as bright as the Sword.

"You said I wouldn't have to pretend to be different in the Horde," Entrapta whispered, eyes wide.

"They thought you were dead," Catra explained. "It was stupid, but they didn't abandon you. The flower princess made a statue of you." Entrapta gasped. "Adora convinced me to give them a chance. If she's wrong, we'll go back to Dryl, make the place impregnable."

"Adora's not wrong," Bow said, removing her helmet. His eyes brimmed with tears. "Entrapta, when we thought you were...gone, the Princess Alliance *fell apart.* As soon as we knew you were alive, we came back for you."

Entrapta looked from a conflicted Scorpia to Bow. "But...it's been over 70 hours."

Catra bit back a groan. *Sometimes, I'm too good at this. Gotta think like Entrapta to turn this around.* She gestured to Adora, who took off her helmet. "Look, I...uh, made a conclusion based on the information I had. Now, we have new information, so we should both, um, recalculate, right?"

"We're your friends, Entrapta," Adora added, doing that choked everything-is-my-fault voice she does when she's leaning into her hero complex. "As soon as we found out you were a prisoner of the Fright Zone, we came straight here. Glimmer and Perfuma are waiting outside with our – with Swift Wind."

"Winged beast-person," Catra filled in.

"Please, come home," Adora pleaded.

Scorpia stepped between Entrapta and the Rebels, claws crossed. "She *is* home," she retorted.

Catra frowned. "Scorpia, why are you loyal to the Horde?"

"Loyalty is what I do," she explained. "It's who I *am.* Well, that and hugs."

"But are they loyal to you?" Catra asked. Scorpia froze. "Snaps, you're the nicest person I know, and I grew up with *Adora."*

"You – you gave me a cool nickname," Scorpia gasped. Then she shook her head and glared at Adora. The blonde lowered her head, lips pressed into a grim line. "Why would you go with *her?* She left you!"

"I'm giving her another chance," Catra replied. "So is she." She snickered. "I mean, we did kinda kidnap her new friends." Scorpia snorted. "Scorpia, I'm not a nice person. Me and Entrapta, we've got weird brains. But you? You don't want to hurt anybody."

"I, uh, kinda threw that guy at our ship's turbofan," Scorpia noted, pointing at Bow. Bow gulped.

Catra threw her hands in the air. "Congratulations! You figured out we're at war after, y'know, a lifetime in the Horde." She crossed her arms and glared at Scorpia. "Hordak doesn't care about any of us. Shadow Weaver's pure evil. Vultak kills civilians for fun."

"What?!" Adora gasped.

"They don't deserve you, Snaps," Catra insisted, holding out her hand. "Come with us. Come with *me.* If the Rebellion's cool, they'll love you. If they're not, we'll blow them off and figure things out for ourselves."

"I–" Entrapta blurted. They all turned to face her, and the genius gulped. "I'm going with them," she said. Adora and Bow rushed to hug her. "I don't give up on an experiment because of one failure. How could I do that to, to my friends?"

"We'll never leave you behind again," Bow promised. Catra made a fist before she could control herself.

Scorpia looked from the Entrapta hug, to Catra, then back. "You'd better take care of her," Scorpia warned.

"We will," Adora said. Then she looked up, alarmed. "Wait, you're not coming?"

Catra's ears and tail drooped when Scorpia turned back to face her, wringing her claws. "I'm sorry, Wildcat," she said, and Catra felt cold inside. *I got a cool nickname, too, just in time for her to say goodbye,* she realized. "The Horde's been my whole life. Someone has to try and make things better here. If you're leaving, I'm all they've got."

Catra sighed. "I, I respect that," she admitted, tail flicking behind her. "You gonna set off the alarm?"

Adora and Bow released Entrapta and straightened. Scorpia grimaced. "Look, I can give you an hour. After that..."

"Thanks, Snaps," Catra said. "You should get out of here. When Entrapta does her thing, the whole Fright Zone is going to go crazy." Scorpia nodded and opened the door. She took one last look behind her, then left, head hung low.

"Well," Adora breathed. "That could have gone better."

"It could've gone worse, too," Bow pointed out. "Now what, Catra?" He gulped. "Words I never thought I'd say."

"Catra may be an angry feline person, but she wishes to be a valuable friend," Entrapta replied, holding up the First Ones

crystal. “Come back in an hour. I’ll be ready with a piece of the Fright Zone to take with us.”

“You’ll what?” Adora gulped, eyes wide.

Catra groaned. “Come on, Adora,” she insisted, taking her best friend’s hand. “Kyle, remember?” She paused at the door. “You gonna be okay alone, geek princess?”

“I’m not alone. I have Emily.” The bot made some friendly-sounding beeps.

Catra nodded. “Man, I hope this isn’t crazy,” she sighed.

-SR- -SR- SR-

“You want us to what?” Kyle blurted.

This is crazy, Adora thought, stomping down the rising panic as Kyle and Rogelio stared at them. “ The Horde is *evil,* Kyle,” she insisted, hoping she could reach him through sheer force of will.

“N-no it’s not! We’re protecting Etheria from the princesses, like you always said! Right, Rogelio?” Kyle looked at his best friend. The lizard-man hissed in frustration. Kyle’s eyes widened. “Ro?”

“Oh, cry me a freakin’ river, Ro,” Catra snapped, watching the corridor behind them. Rogelio hissed again. “Don’t you dare lump me in with the other mammals! I was Shadow Weaver’s pet project, emphasis on *pet.* No one had it worse than me, so don’t lecture me on making the crap worthwhile.” Another series of hisses, this set more subdued. “Adora says they’ll treat us okay, and she’ll have our backs if they don’t.” Rogelio glared at Adora and snarled. “Yes, I trust her. There was a thing.”

“Catra,” Kyle whispered. “Look, Rogelio, I talked to Bow, and he was nicer to me than anyone outside the squad ever was.” Bow waved, gulping as his eyes widened. “Maybe...maybe the princesses aren’t that bad, if the Horde’s been lying to us.”

Catra snorted. “Ro, should Kyle be a soldier?” That stopped Rogelio cold. “He belongs in engineering or support. He’s smart and methodical, but he’s about as agile as Grizzlor on a bender.”

Kyle brightened. “You think I’m smart?” he asked. *Wow, Catra, you’re good at this.*

Bow nodded. “Come on, guys, you’ve gotta see what the Horde is doing to Etheria.” Rogelio hissed again. “Uh, Catra? Was that a good hiss or a bad hiss?”

“Bad hiss,” Catra sighed. “Last call, guys, we’re out of time.”

“I know you want to do the right thing,” Adora pleaded, holding out her hand. Kyle took a step forward. Rogelio took a step back. Kyle turned, eyes wide. “Rogelio, please don’t–”

“What’s going on here–” Lonnie barked, coming into the barracks from the other side. Her eyes widened. “You!”

“Lonnie, wait!” Adora cried, but there was no time. Lonnie pulled her stun baton and charged. She’d only taken three steps before Catra planted her foot in the cadet’s stomach. She grabbed the stun baton, leaped into the air, and zapped her unconscious overhead and upside-down.

“Time’s up!” Catra snapped, pointing her fifth stolen baton of the day at Rogelio. “In, or out?” Kyle looked from Adora to Rogelio. Ro paused, then darted over to Lonnie, scooping her up and rushing to her bunk, hunching protectively over her, claws out. “Your choice, Ro. Kyle?”

“Ro...I don’t want to leave without you...” Kyle whispered, still looking back and forth.

Rogelio’s snarl was almost a roar. Catra glared at him with wide eyes. “What? You’re – you’re gonna throw him away, Ro? Throw us away? Just like that?” Rogelio hunched lower over Lonnie. “Fine. Kyle, run or stay, but we’re leaving *now.”* Catra waved for them to follow, taking point down the corridor towards Entrapta.

Bow was right behind her, but Adora hesitated when Kyle did. Kyle looked back one last time, his eyes meeting Rogelio's, then followed Adora.

Catra tried to make her frustrated rumble sound angry. Adora knew better. "Catra, it's not your fault," she insisted. "You did your best."

"Look, we made a choice, and so did they. I get why they stayed." Catra huffed as they approached Entrapta's lab. "I did, before." The four Rebels rushed in to the sight of Entrapta and Emily hard at work, putting the finishing touches (Adora hoped) on whatever crazy plan Entrapta had come up with. "E.T.! Tell me you've got your little slice of Zone ready to move."

"I believe so," Entrapta replied, tapping on the controls one last time before retracting her hair. "If my hacking efforts were successful, 52 of Emily's sisters will carry this portion of the Fright Zone back to rebel territory for us."

"Okay. Let's go," Catra smirked.

"Ah, that would be unwise," Entrapta explained, patting Emily on the...dome, before retreating to their side. "Emily and the equipment will be fine, but the stolen chambers won't be safe for organic life."

Adora looked at Catra. "Run?" she asked.

Catra looked at Adora. "Run," she agreed.

They ran.

-SR- -SR- SR-

This may not have been my best plan ever, Catra admitted to herself as the five Rebels fled the rumbling Fright Zone. "Look, all we have to do is get outside and we'll be fine," she assured them.

"They'll come for us," Adora agreed. *They'd better, Adora, or this is going to be a real short escape,* Catra thought, but said nothing.

Bow gulped again. "At least there aren't any death-flame rooms this time," he noted.

"You should be so fortunate." Catra froze, ears flaring up and tail sticking out. Shadow Weaver slithered around the corner, her magic looming over them. Adora reached for the Sword, but shadows and bloody lightning lashed out, freezing the other four. Only Catra was able to evade, her reflexes and experience keeping her inches away from capture. "That's right, Catra, run away. It's the only thing you've ever been good at!"

"You keep telling yourself that, Shadow Weaver," Catra snarled back, leaping from grating to conduit as she kept out of reach.

"Worthless beast. You've learned nothing from me!" Shadow Weaver howled, pressing both hands to the ground. Her evil shadows multiplied.

"Oh, I learned *everything* from you," Catra snapped from where she crouched. "I can predict where you'll strike. I can dodge," she continued, proving her words with deeds. "I can resist! You thought you were punishing me all those years?" She leaped overhead, and Shadow Weaver rose to give chase. *"Wrong."* The witch rushed into position to attack, completely unaware of her vulnerability. "You were training me for this day!" Catra dropped and slashed, shattering the Garnet shard with a single swipe of her claws.

Shadow Weaver screamed and fell to her knees. Adora whipped out the Sword and did her thing, becoming She-Ra. Bow and Entrapta hugged each other. Kyle stared in awe. Catra permitted herself a moment of smirking at the witch. The Fright Zone rumbled with the movement of disobedient drones. "Time to go," Catra ordered, ignoring Shadow Weaver's whimpering. "Adora, get the doors. Bow, watch E.T.'s back. E.T, you hack anything She-Ra

can’t slice through, keep the Rebel lab moving. Kyle, we’re rearguard.” She tossed him a stun baton; he bobbled it for a few seconds, then caught it.

“Right!” She-Ra agreed, then sliced through the closing blast door in front of them like a laser through a ration bar.

The rest of the escape was almost boring, only the rumbling of Entrapta’s theft keeping them on their toes. Once they were outside, Catra fired a baton beam into the sky.

Vines burst through the Fright Zone walls, enough to devour the whole front line. Feathers flew overhead, carrying a baton-happy Sparkles. Perfuma emerged from the mass of vines to hug Entrapta and sob. Entrapta patted her on the back with an awkward smile. Catra indulged in a second smirk, then took out her detonator and pushed the button.

Explosions rocked the southern Fright Zone, blowing up tanks, armories, and fuel depots. The others stared at her in amazement. “I may have left a few going-away presents when I snuck in for Sparkles’ stun batons.” Her smirk grew. “Let’s get out of here. I want to try this Rebel food Adora’s been gushing about.”

-SR- -SR- SR-

“...and then it was just a skiff ride here,” Catra finished, smirking as she spread her arms.

Queen Angella regarded the magicat with as much calm resolve as she could muster. *I cannot allow sentiment to rule me. Shadow Weaver tormented this poor girl her whole life. Even though she may be all that remains of her people, she was one of the Horde’s greatest weapons.* She steepled her fingers. “You nearly conquered Salineas with a single ship and a team of five, against three princesses and the Sea Gate. You kidnapped my daughter and her dearest friend from the most secure gathering on Etheria. Now I am to presume that you have defected.”

"Mom!" Glimmer blurted, but she subsided at a raised hand. Adora fidgeted, looking from Angella to Catra. *Their bond is strong. I must know that Catra will not turn She-Ra against me.*

"You don't trust me? Duh," Catra replied, folding her arms. Adora facepalmed while the others gasped. "You didn't survive decades fighting the Horde by being stupid. I'm not asking you to trust me yet. I'm asking you for a chance to prove myself." Her smirk vanished. "That's what I'm giving you."

"Catra!" Glimmer snapped. Again, one hand caused her to subside.

"Glimmer, that is entirely fair," Angella replied. They all relaxed – even Catra, to an extent. "No doubt the Horde said terrible things about me."

"Pfft, like I believe any of that," Catra scoffed. "You're a queen. You have as much power here as Hordak does in the Fright Zone. That's what I don't trust yet."

Angella raised an eyebrow. "Bright Moon is a realm of laws. We have a Parliament, democracy, representation."

"What's democracy?" Adora and Catra asked in unison.

Angella sighed. "With Entrapta's rescue, you have earned your chance, Captain Catra. I trust you will allow me the same opportunity." Adora squeezed Catra's hand, and the magicat nodded, rolling her eyes. "Thank you. Guards, please show Commander Catra and Engineer Kyle to their rooms."

Adora took a breath to speak, but Catra jumped in. "'Commander?' Cool. Let's go." Catra left with the two guards, an oddly distressed Adora trailing them. Entrapta laughed and followed them alongside a joyous, relieved Perfuma.

"Thanks, Mom," Glimmer sighed, slumping in obvious relief. "Adora is really desperate to have Catra on our side, and she's...surprisingly decent, actually."

"I dunno, Glimmer," Bow mumbled. "She's kinda...rough around the edges." Glimmer shot him a look of disbelief.

"A matter for another day," Angella insisted, rising. The court stood at attention for a moment, then the courtiers went about their business. "Glimmer, Bow. I pray that neither of you can imagine the...cruelty of Catra's childhood. The Rebellion must be worthy of them before we can ask them to be worthy of us. We will give her the chance she asks for." They both nodded, Glimmer with a smile, Bow's expression neutral.

Oh, Micah. I never thought I would be glad you were not here, but Catra would break your heart...

The Battle of Thaymor

Chapter Summary

> Catra messed up Hordak's day. He sends an army to return the favor.

Angella strode through the corridor, seeking Micah's comfort.

"...always bunked together," Adora objected.

"Well, I need some space, okay?" Catra retorted. *...I wanted to be a mother,* Angella sighed, gliding in their direction. "I'm not just gonna go back to sleeping by your *feet* like nothing happened." *What?*

"Shadow Weaver's gone, Catra!" Adora half-sobbed. "We're safe now, it doesn't have to be like that."

"L-look," Catra replied, "I'm not saying this is forever. I just need some time." Angella turned the corner to find Adora and Catra in front of Adora's door. The two guards escorting the magicat waited a discreet distance away, but close enough to observe. "I gave up everything for you, isn't that enough?"

"I know! I know, Catra!" Adora cried. "After everything you've been through, I just want to give something back."

"And *I* want to earn something for *myself* first," Catra snapped, clearly prepared to rant for several moments.

"You will have that chance," Angella interjected with as much calm confidence as she could project. Both young women stood at attention after a moment's alarm. "I understand if you wish to rest first, Catra, but I would appreciate a moment to talk, alone." Adora looked from Catra to Angella, clearly frightened. "For goodness' sake, Adora, I'm not going to hurt her."

"Of course not, ma'am. Sorry." Adora and Catra shared a look. *If I did harm her, I suspect I would face She-Ra posthaste.* The blonde human retreated into her room, while the magicat let out a huff and walked over to Angella. The guards followed.

"You don't have to prove you're in charge," Catra blurted after a dozen paces. Angella glanced over at the young warrior. "I'm not stupid."

"I am aware, Catra," Angella replied. "My intent is more informational than anything else." She stopped in front of Micah's mural, and Catra fell in alongside her. "This is Micah. He was my husband." She placed a hand on his image. "He was my heart."

Catra's standoffish expression melted somewhat. "The Horde got him?"

"Yes, but there is more to it than that." Angella took a deep breath before the plunge. "He studied in Mystacor. There, he was the favored student of the brilliant Light Spinner. When he was younger than you are now, Spinner convinced him to join a ritual that would grant them the power to fight the Horde. It went wrong. Micah fled the conflagration. The spell consumed Light Spinner. What emerged was Shadow Weaver."

Catra's eyes bulged wide. "Wait, Shadow Weaver taught your husband magic?"

"Indeed. When he saw her ambition for what it was, when the spell consumed her, Shadow Weaver's favor turned to hatred. She dedicated herself to the destruction of all he loved. Bright Moon. Mystacor. Halfmoon," she explained.

"What's Halfmoon?" Catra asked.

"It was a hidden society of a people known as Bubasti, though most humans called them 'magicats,'" Angella explained. Catra's eyes widened. "Micah fought at the Battle of Halfmoon. We lost."

"You think that's what I am. A magicat," Catra whispered.

Angella nodded. “I fear that Shadow Weaver took everything from us both.” She glanced in the direction of Glimmer’s room, permitting herself a tiny smile. “Almost everything.”

“Shadow Weaver said I could never learn magic,” Catra breathed.

Angella glanced at Catra. “Shadow Weaver,” she noted, “lies.”

Catra stared back for a moment before bursting into laughter. “Y’know, if you’re trying to get me to like you, this is a really good start.”

“Thank you,” Angella replied. “You should get some rest. Hordak will respond to your impressive resignation soon.” She turned, then paused and looked back. “I understand your pain, Catra, but please, try to be gentle with the others. They do not understand what that monster has done to us. That is a good thing.”

Catra hesitated. She nodded slowly. “Yeah, I get that. I’ll try. Thanks, Wings.” Angella permitted herself a chuckle as the magicat rejoined her guards. *Stars guide you, Catra. I pray I have made the right choice, opening my heart to you.* She permitted her gaze to fall on the mural for one moment more. *It’s what Micah would have done.*

-SR- -SR- SR-

Catra stretched and yawned, her nest in the cushion the Rebels called a bed so warm and comfortable, the only thing pulling her away was the rumbling of her stomach. *Too...comfy…*

The knock on her door sounded too hesitant to be Adora, but the voice proved her wrong. “Catra? They’re serving breakfast,” her friend *(we’re friends again!* Catra exulted) called.

“I’mmup,” Catra mumbled, working her way out of the bed-trap. She looked at the door, but it didn’t move. *Oh, for...this must be about last night.* “Hey, Adora. You can come in.”

The human burst into the room with a look of absolute relief. "Phew! After last night, I – you were able to sleep in that thing?" Adora blurted, staring at the struggling magicat.

Catra shrugged. "I have to curl up tight, but yeah." She flailed briefly. "Gah. One second." She got her feet under her, then leaped to freedom. She glared at the traitorous bedding. "Treachery," she grumbled, then turned to her friend. "So, what's the big deal about Rebellion food?"

Five minutes later, Catra was letting a bite of bacon and cheese omelet melt in her mouth. *I am* never *going back to the Fright Zone,* she swore, purring, eyes sparkling at the amazing new sensation. She didn't even mind Adora's wide, pleased smile. "Yeah, okay, you were right about the food," she admitted, shoveling another forkful in.

Sparkles teleported in, landing next to Adora with a faux-casual smile. "Ooo, omelets. Looks good – urk!"

Adora cut off her quip with a fierce hug. "Glimmer! You're okay!"

"Yep! Entrapta worked with my Mom to 'reattune me to the Moonstone through thaumaturgical,' um, that's as far as I got," Glimmer admitted. All three ladies laughed. The princess sobered in an instant. "Just in time, too. The Horde's moving. Back-to-back rescues really got their attention."

Catra stood, plate in hand. "That didn't take long. Adora?"

"War room," Adora reported, then shoveled the rest of her meal into a bowl.

Catra snorted. "Y'know, for a second, I was worried that they wouldn't have one."

Somehow, the room was even more sparkly than the rest of the castle. The mural surrounding the room wasn't terrible, but the chairs were almost painful to look at, and the hologram on the

table was clearly trying to gouge Catra's eyes out. *If it weren't 3-D, I couldn't make out a single detail,* the Bubastis noted.

The most impressive-looking woman Catra had seen thus far, an armored warrior with a single white patch in her black hair, was pointing out Horde troop movements. "...significant force headed for Thaymor. Tanks, skiffs, and troop carriers are pushing through the forest in a wedge. After the previous assault, the village has no real defense against them."

"This doesn't make sense," Adora breathed, shaking her head. "That's a full invasion force, basic strike formation. They've already been to Thaymor, they know its people aren't soldiers."

"Bright Moon," Catra replied, tapping the castle icon with one claw. "It's as close as they can get before going into the Whispering Woods. Look." She drew a line from the village to the citadel. "It's why they wanted it in the first place, only this time, they sent Shadow Weaver." The others stared at her.

"Why do you believe this?" Angella asked.

Catra zoomed into the formation. "Look at that formation. Perfect lines, boring brute force strategy, armored units clustered around the center. Grizzlor's too sloppy, Scorpia's too relaxed, and Vultak's too smart. Besides, Shadow Weaver's the only way they cut through the Woods. Hordak must have given her another piece of the Black Garnet." She snorted. "She's probably not there herself, but they've got to have one of her shadow spies in there, at least. Hordak's angry, and she needs to prove herself."

"What do you suggest?" the general prodded. Catra grinned. *I thought you'd never ask.*

-SR- -SR- SR-

Glimmer gaped at the vine ramparts protecting the city, guarded by Entrapta's bots. Netossa's barriers blocked off roads to the east and west. The Best Friends Squad – now with added Catra – stood where the north road came into town, She-Ra shining at

their head. Spinnerella and Netossa flanked them to the left, while Perfuma and Entrapta stood ready on their right. Four squads of soldiers prepared behind them, and four others hid in preparation to ambush invaders once they were in town. And that was only the obvious stuff. “I am so glad Catra’s on our side,” she whispered. She-Ra let out a tiny squee. *That was weird,* Glimmer thought.

“I still hope Mermista and Sea Hawk show up,” Bow replied, checking his gear one last time.

“Me too,” Glimmer admitted, “but this feels like we have a chance.” She rubbed one arm. “I just wish I could’ve come up with something like this.”

“You – might have,” Bow offered, eyes darting around.

Glimmer sighed. “Bow, Catra figured out what Spinny and ‘Tossa do before I even remembered. Can you imagine...” she trailed off at the rumble of approaching machinery. “Here they come,” she whispered, raising her father’s staff.

The lead tank stopped less than a foot from Adora, the entire battalion coming to a halt at the same time. A dark outline of Shadow Weaver formed atop it. “Adora,” she called. “This little outburst of yours has gone on long enough. Come home.”

“Catra’s with me,” Adora replied, holding the sword between her and the Horde. “I am home.”

Shadow Weaver recoiled. Catra’s eyes flew wide, shining with unshed tears. “*Catra?”* the sorceress snapped. “I knew it. That animal has corrupted you.”

“Don’t look at me, Shadow Weaver,” Catra smirked. “She talked *me* into this.” The smirk became a snarl. “And I’m about to prove why you should’ve tried to keep me.”

“Bah!” Shadow Weaver scoffed. “A Force Captain’s badge to the soldier who brings me her head! *Attack!”*

Glimmer yelped and teleported with Bow to their assigned ambush point, hitting the invaders from Perfuma's side of the battle. "She is the worst mother ever!" Bow spat, firing arrow after arrow into the Horde.

"Priorities, Bow," Glimmer retorted, firing blasts through the staff, scattering Horde soldiers. She teleported above the battle for a moment, to find the invaders pulling together into a tighter line rather than spreading out. She appeared by Bow's side, where Catra landed beside them, armor scraps falling from her claws. "Is it working?"

Catra's grin was vicious. "Oh, it's working. Keep them busy. I'm going to steal that tank now." She darted into the shadows and disappeared again.

Bow turned a dubious glance towards Glimmer. "That really doesn't worry you?"

Glimmer chuckled. "I'm thinking more about Shadow Weaver saying 'bah.' Seriously?" She fired more blasts at the Horde forces, then teleported them to another branch. "Why doesn't she just write 'villain' on her mask? Besides, what's wrong with stealing from the Horde?"

"Stealing a *tank,* Glimmer," Bow worried, firing a slime arrow to turn a team of Horde soldiers into a giant wad of gum. "How does that end well?"

On cue, one tank spun to aim at another, firing a shot at its treads. The blast flipped the vehicle on its side, leaving it immobilized. Glimmer grinned at Bow. "You were saying?"

-SR- -SR- SR-

"Catra's with me. I am home."

The memory lit up like a full moon in Catra's heart. *She chose me.* She leaped from soldier to skiff to bot, bringing them down like mice. She looked up from a wrecked skiff to spot Grizzlor headed

towards Petals and E.T. at the head of a tank platoon. *Head in the game, Catra.* Dashing to intercept them, she knocked Grizzlor off his perch, picked the lock on the lead tank, threw the soldiers out to a trio of hilarious screams, spun the turret around, and sent the other three tanks skidding to smoking, disabled halts.

Catra tore out the controls, then darted out to stand atop the wreckage. With a trio of hand signals, she sent Rebellion soldiers and bots into the opening her attack had left in the Horde's flank. Grizzlor stood with a roar, then glared at her. Catra smirked back. "Hey, Grizzlor."

"By the Horde, I used to think you were cute," he growled.

Catra recoiled, tongue darting out. "Ew."

"Oh, don't worry about that, morsel," the bruiser growled. "I'm just going to rip off your head and use your skull for a goblet."

"Way better than the other thing," Catra mocked, "but you'd have to catch me, and you're slower than Hordak's conscience." Grizzlor howled and scrambled up the tree after her. She leaped out of the way with almost pathetic ease.

Below, Scorpia advanced on Perfuma and Entrapta. *Okay, not letting that happen.* She sent a few bots her way to slow her down, then looked for a good place to plant Grizzlor. *Don't get crazy out there, Snaps.*

-SR- -SR- SR-

Adora cut a tank blast in half and strode towards Shadow Weaver, grim fury burning under her skin. "You will never touch Catra again," she warned, watching the shadows flowing into her false form.

"I raised you better than this, child," Shadow Weaver retorted, flowing around She-Ra and firing bursts of darkness at the Rebels. "You cannot stop me. Surely you have the sense to see what that animal won't."

"That 'animal' is *beating* you," Adora snarled back, "right now." One of Catra's ambushes proved her right, throwing Shadow Weaver's blunt flanking assault into disarray. Entrapta's bots pushed back the Horde's, their beams paralyzing the enemy rather than destroying them. "She did this!"

Shadow Weaver's false eyes widened, then narrowed. "Lies!" The sorceress cast a torrent of murderous darkness at She-Ra, who countered with blasts of light. "You will return, you will submit, and you *will obey!"* Her darkness swallowed the world. "I will tear that beast from your mind, and you will heed me alone!"

"You are alone, Shadow Weaver," She-Ra insisted, focusing on the Sword's shining might. "You tried to make me like you, but you failed!" She held the blade high, and its power drove away the sorcerous gloom. "Catra chose *me!* Glimmer and Bow are my friends. The Princess Alliance will stop you!"

"The Princess Alliance is a joke!" Shadow Weaver screeched, reforming above a tank and drawing all darkness to her. "Angella failed, her daughter failed, and now you have – what?!"

Onrushing water drowned out whatever Shadow Weaver said next. A massive wave scattered skiffs like toys, Mermista and Sea Hawk landing near Perfuma and Entrapta. "Like, sorry I'm late. You okay, geek princess?" Her relieved smile belied her casual words.

"Oh, yes, Catra was most helpful," Entrapta replied while Shadow Weaver howled. Catra dropped an unconscious Grizzlor on Sea Hawk's boat, grinning as she darted by. "Cover me, I'm almost done!"

Mermista turned confused looks from Catra to Entrapta, then back to Adora. "Wait, so angry cat girl's on our side now?" She mounted a column of water and rode it to tower above the battle. "Hey, Frosta, don't freeze the cat girl, she's with us!"

“Did you say Frosta?” Adora gasped. The young princess rode an ice bridge into battle, raining cold fury on the Horde.

“Hey, Adora, head in the game!” Catra shouted, slashing a tank barrel as she leaped past. Adora noted the shadows flowing under the weapon. *Aha!* she realized, turning the Sword on the tank. Dark ramparts rose to protect it, but a rainbow of magical power flowed from the assembled princesses to her blade, and she shattered the tank, the Black Garnet shards, and Shadow Weaver’s power. “Nice!”

“It’s over, Shadow Weaver,” Adora pronounced, pointing the Sword at the remnants of the sorceress’ projection. The princesses, Bow, and Catra gathered around her. Only Entrapta hung back, and a few beeps later, the Horde’s bot lights flashed green, the converted drones joining the Rebellion.

“All forces, pull back!” Scorpia ordered, waving a claw to signal the retreat.

Catra hunched down, ears pivoting back. “Snaps,” she whispered.

“Oh, Adora. This is merely the beginning,” Shadow Weaver taunted, her shadows lurking among the trees. “You have no idea what–”

“Nah,” Catra interrupted, holding up a modified a stun baton. “Adora’s right. You’re done. Bow! Dash and flash!” She threw the baton at the heart of Shadow Weaver’s remaining sorcery, and Bow shot a flare arrow right into it. Shadow Weaver screamed one last time, and her cruel magic vanished.

The princesses cheered, throwing themselves into a messy group hug. Even Catra and Bow smiled, high-fiving each other while she cackled and he grinned. “We did it,” Adora breathed.

“We united the princesses!” Glimmer cheered.

“We actually pushed the Horde back,” Bow agreed.

Catra laughed. “We got the Rebellion tanks, skiffs, and like a hundred bots,” she pointed out. “We haven’t even begun to push.”

“This is it,” Adora said, letting She-Ra go. “From now on, the Horde doesn’t take one more thing from us. Today, we start taking Etheria back!”

-SR- -SR- SR-

Hordak glared at Shadow Weaver, her collapsed form pitiful even through the monitor. “Explain yourself, sorceress.” She clung to her bowl, one hand reaching with feeble desperation towards the Black Garnet. “You said that the tinkerer was irrelevant. *You* said that you could reclaim the traitor Adora. *You* said that Force Captain Catra was incompetent. The last time I saw such strategy in play was during the Blind War Games, which Octavia prepared because she feared discrimination against certain students.” Shadow Weaver wheezed. “I am waiting, Shadow Weaver.”

“It...must have been Adora,” Shadow Weaver gasped, all but throwing herself onto the Runestone. “She must have prepared that defense. It is the only possible explanation for–”

"Silence,” Hordak snapped. “Your prejudices cost us Thaymor. They will not deny us any more victories. You will bring me Adora, *and* Catra, *and* Princess Entrapta.” He could tell Shadow Weaver was glaring at him, but even in his infirmity, Lord Hordak could not bring himself to care. “I do not expect you to capture all three at once, However, you will do this, *properly,* or you will have outlived your usefulness. Is that clear?”

Shadow Weaver trembled for an instant, then bowed. “As you command, Lord Hordak.”

Imp nudged under his hand, and he stroked the little creature to its contentment. “Yes. As I command. See that you remember it, Shadow Weaver.” Imp cooed as Hordak let the thing nestle into his palm. *And if you plot against me again, Scorpia does not like you. I can always give the Black Garnet back to her…*

-SR- -SR- SR-

Catra fought against the oncoming groan when Adora smiled. She lost her battle when Adora's eyes sparkled. "Okay, fine, the Rebellion's not so bad. Probably."

Adora snickered. "Probably?"

"Most people try to seem okay when you meet them," Catra argued, the two walking through Bright Moon's corridors side by side. Adora gave Catra's shoulder a gentle nudge. "Oh, for – I'm just saying we should keep our guard up. They can't all be sparkly princesses and all-knowing queens."

"I know, you need time," Adora replied, rolling her eyes. Catra managed not to wince. *Wow, I actually heard a tiny hint of resentment in there.* The magicat shook her head. *We'll work it out later. Right now, I want to be done with whatever Her Shiny Royal Majesty wants with –*

Adora and Catra each opened one of the double doors. The entire Princess Alliance, plus Bow and Kyle *(Kyle? Really?* Catra wondered), were there waiting for them. "Commander Catra. Please step forward."

She can't be punishing me. I just won the Rebellion its biggest victory since they got She-Ra. Catra nodded and strode forward, Adora by her side. "Your Majesty," she replied, saluting.

Angella smiled a fraction. "So, you can show decorum when it suits you," she said, and most of the princesses chuckled. Frosta was the only one who didn't join in, her glare living up to her name. *Huh. Misty's fine, but Snowcone's still mad. Almost conquered your kingdom? Meh. Ruined a party? Revenge! By the Horde, these princesses and their priorities.* The Queen straightened, serious in an instant. "You requested the opportunity to prove yourself. It is my hope in affirming your success that I can prove our honor in return."

Catra caught herself before her mouth could fall open, but only by half a second. "Wait, just like that?"

"Uh, 'just like that?' Catra, you led five princesses, eight squads, and one Bow to victory against an entire Horde army!" Glimmer blurted.

"You got us enough Horde tech to rebuild the Rebellion's whole military," Bow pointed out.

Somehow, Adora was not smirking at her. "Welcome home," her friend whispered, not a hint of mockery in her joyous tone.

"So. Uh. Thanks. Okay. Now what?" Catra asked. *By the Hord – Ugh. Great performance, oh master manipulator,* she mocked herself.

"Mission Commander Catra, the Princess Alliance has appointed you head of Rebellion special forces, charged with planning and directing operations to undermine the Horde and liberate Etheria." Catra stared, eyes wide and tail lashing, while Angella permitted her smile to return, a touch broader than before. "Pardon, Catra, but am I expected to be concerned that you will return to the Horde?"

"Yeah, Shadow Weaver *literally* demanded your head," Netossa pointed out.

The world tilted beneath Catra's feet. *This – this can't be happening,* she thought, *things like this don't happen to me, I don't get to be* – Adora took her hand, and the ground solidified under her. – *happy.* She stood at as close to attention as she could manage, ears swiveled high. "But...Adora..." she breathed.

"Commander Adora is the Champion of Bright Moon, a hero, an inspiration, and a field commander any soldier would be honored to follow," Angella said, nodding to a beaming Adora. "As She-Ra, she has been chosen to restore balance to Etheria. She did not devise the plan to rescue Entrapta or the strategy that secured

Thaymor. Adora is our greatest protector. You, Catra, are our best hope for *victory."*

"To Catra!" Perfuma cried, and the others cheered.

Catra was, for the first time that didn't involve magic paralysis, speechless. *Okay. Gotta say something,* she decided, gathering her scattered wits. "It's not just going to be hope," she insisted. "We're going to free every kid they're lying to. We're going to kick them out of every kingdom they've stolen. And then, we're going to make Hordak and Shadow Weaver pay for everything they've done."

"But first, we're gonna *celebrate!"* Glimmer exulted.

There was another cheer, and Adora, Glimmer, and Bow put Catra in the middle of a hug sandwich. Her tail went limp. "Best Friends Squad just got Bestier!" Bow cheered.

"And now it really is a best friends squad," Adora whispered. Catra gave in just enough to return the hugs. *This...might actually work after all.*

But I'm definitely talking to Adora's friends about personal space. After the party.

Vultak

Chapter Summary

> An 80s villain gets a 21st century update. The Princess Alliance learns that Catra is still Catra, and Frosta's gonna Frosta. Things go sideways.

"Okay, first thing: defections. We want to encourage them," Catra said, peering at the war map with arms crossed and tail swishing behind her.

"Does that not invite infiltration?" Angella pointed out, regarding the map with a calm Catra envied. Glimmer smiled at Catra and shrugged. *Huh. Not just me. Good to know.*

Catra nodded. "We have to do it smart, obviously. Set up camps just far enough behind the front lines for escapees to feel safe from the Horde, but far enough from our bases to make using them for sabotage inefficient." She tapped three empty areas in Rebellion control. "Adora and I can sweep through to vet them until we have a team that knows Horde tells."

"What about Kyle?" Glimmer asked.

Catra forced herself not to laugh. "Entrapta's already snapped him up. Besides, Kyle makes me look sociable. He's too nice to be interrogator material. On that topic, second thing: mechanization. We don't want to rely on bots the way the Horde does, for a lot of reasons, but we need to modernize the Rebellion. They have tanks, blasters, skiffs, and bots, while we have spears, arrows, wagons, and horses." She grinned. "We also have Entrapta, Bow, and Kyle. With a little work, Kyle should make a good teacher, so we can start teaching Rebel engineers how to adapt Horde weapons."

"As intelligent as Bow and Kyle are, Entrapta's genius is unique," Angella countered with a surprisingly gentle tone. "Hordak alone

rivals her knowledge of Etheria's technology, and his seems more learned than deduced. We should minimize her exposure to danger."

"Agreed," Catra conceded, ears twitching, "but she can take care of herself. E.T. doesn't have any interest in fighting, aside from her interest in everything, but she's going to want to go on First Ones site expeditions. We'll just have to prioritize protecting her." Her tail drooped at the scowl Angella was fighting back. "Look, I get it. I don't like single points of failure either, and I *do* like Entrapta, usually. Bow and I can keep an eye on her."

Glimmer chuckled. "I don't know, that hair lets her move pretty fast."

Why did I leave the Horde again? Catra wondered, sighing. She remembered the light shining in Adora's eyes at their reunion, omelets and fish and chocolate, the Rebellion cheering her name. *Oh. Right.* "Third. Mystacor. Hordak has one sorceress, and somehow that's one more than the Rebellion has. That's nuts."

"My sister-in-law is determined to protect what remains of Etheria's magic," Angella explained, her voice and eyes both drawing tight. "I wish it were otherwise, but I cannot fault her dedication to her people."

"Besides, Aunt Casta doesn't think they could do much," Glimmer admitted, caught between a scowl and a pout. "If it helps, Catra, I'm with you on this one."

Catra tapped the edge of the table with her claws. *Four: the Rebellion falls apart when they take a single major casualty. It's happened twice now. I just wish I could say that to King Micah's wife and daughter.* She sighed. "Hordak being angry with Shadow Weaver won't protect them when he decides their resources are a priority. The witch got in once. She'll do it again."

"You and Glimmer can leave for Mystacor once our current offensive is complete," Angella said, folding her hands. *Aaand*

conversation over, Catra realized, recognizing the gesture. "For now, I want you to focus on liberating Erelandia. If we can defeat the Horde there, they will rule less territory than they have since the fall of the first Alliance."

"Don't worry, Mom," Glimmer replied, saluting with a smile.

"We've got this," Catra agreed, tossing in her own sloppy salute just before Glimmer teleported them to Adora and Bow.

Both goody-goodies looked up from a book covering most of Adora's desk. "Well?" Bow asked, almost bouncing in place.

"We're going to Erelandia!" Glimmer gushed. "The Princess Alliance is officially back in business."

"Yes!" Bow cheered, fist punching skyward.

Adora's smile was more restrained. "Do we have a plan?" she asked.

"Not yet," Catra admitted, ears swiveling back a fraction. "I want to head out there with as much of the Alliance as we can spare for a scouting mission, with the strike force ready to move in behind us if Shadow Weaver only has a small occupation force."

Adora's smile vanished entirely. Bow looked from the blonde to Catra and back, confused. "You don't sound sure that it's Shadow Weaver."

Catra huffed. "It's probably her. Taking Erelandia when they're in retreat across the continent is more of a Hordak move, but Shadow Weaver follows orders, usually. It could be Scorpia or Grizzlor, though. They're both aggressive enough." She crossed her arms, tapping an arm with one finger. "It's also a classic Vultak move, go on the offensive to throw off an enemy assault, but that means Hordak's taking us seriously enough to bring him in from the other side of Etheria."

Glimmer sat down on Adora's cushion-bed and looked at Catra with the most serious expression she'd ever seen on the princess. "Is that a problem?" Sparkles asked.

"Vultak's the best general Hordak has," Catra explained. "He's run half the planet for the Horde since Adora and I were little kids. Sending him here risks uprisings in seven principalities. If we can take him out, the Rebellion can put all of Etheria in play."

"Easier said than done, though," Adora jumped in. "Vultak can fly, and he leads from the front. Queen Angella's the only Rebel who's ever defeated him in battle." She paused. "That's what the Horde says, anyway."

"Worse, rumor says he learned some dark magic from Shadow Weaver," Catra added, scowling. "The only specific power I've ever heard mentioned is a draining spell that strengthens him and weakens his target, but that would be bad enough."

"Well, it's probably not him anyway, right?" Glimmer asked, brightening literally as well as figuratively.

"Yeah," Catra agreed, though she wasn't in any hurry to do so. "Probably."

-SR- -SR- SR-

"Ugh," Mermista groaned, "do we need eight people that badly?" Bow held back a sigh when Sea Hawk wilted. *Does she have to be so mean to him?* Bow wondered.

Catra smirked. "No," she admitted, to another groan from the water princess, "but it's a lot easier to have teams of two with an even-numbered squad. Come on, let's move." They crept towards the Erelandian border, underbrush and scattered trees covering their approach. Perfuma helped, bending shrubs and branches around to conceal them with a subtlety that surprised Bow. "Nice work, Petals," the cat woman added. Perfuma beamed.

Bow fell back to Adora. “Hey, what’s Catra’s deal?” he whispered, curiosity finally overwhelming him.

“Huh?” Adora blurted.

“I just...don’t get her,” Bow admitted, watching Catra guide the Princess Alliance towards the Horde’s Erelandian occupation. “She’s mean one minute, then kind the next. She acts like she doesn’t care, then risks her life for people she doesn’t even trust.” Bow’s eyes tightened as Catra pointed out distant tanks to Glimmer, the two of them laughing. “The worst part is, it’s like she doesn’t understand when people are trying to be nice.”

Adora sighed, slumping. “Back in the Horde, I was the only person who was nice to her, except maybe Kyle. He and Rogelio were never mean to her, but everyone else was.” She, too, looked at Catra, and Bow could read the guilt and shame in her eyes as though there were signs over her head. “Everyone knew Shadow Weaver didn’t like Catra, so being hard on her was an easy way to get on Shadow Weaver’s good side.”

Oh, Stars, Bow thought, unable even to process his horror. “That’s...I can’t...and Shadow Weaver raised her? Raised *you?”*

Adora nodded. “Whenever anyone besides me treats Catra well, she looks for how they want to use her. In the Horde, she was usually right.” She smiled at Catra, who was watching the field around Frosta. “Except, when we got older, kids would be nice to her without realizing they shouldn’t. We always looked out for them.”

Catra held up a fist, and they all stopped and ducked for cover. Bow wondered why for a moment, until the awful shadow flickered past. He looked up to find a muscular humanoid with massive, dirty wings soar overhead. His skin was the same green of his Horde armor, with a short, blood-red feathered crest in place of hair. “Is that him?” Bow whispered, eyes wide.

"No, that's Styrax, his second-in-command," Catra replied, eyes locked onto the deadly figure. "That's either really good or incredibly bad."

"Uh, do you want to, like, explain to the rest of us?" Mermista drawled while Styrax returned to his forces.

"Styrax is strong, fast, and competent, but he doesn't have Vultak's skill or magic," Catra continued, slinking forward with a lashing tail. "If Vultak sent him here, then we can take them ourselves. If Vultak is here with Styrax, it's a trap, and we're in trouble." She turned, and Bow watched her eyes dart over them like lightning. "Okay, Sparkles, we're going in. We find out if Vultak is there and get out. No matter what happens, *do not engage.* We all fight or none of us do."

Bow recognized Glimmer's frustrated sigh as her "okay, but I don't like it" one. "Fine," she muttered, holding out her hand. Catra nodded and took it, and the pair vanished.

"Argh," Frosta snarled. "Why does Glimmer even *like* her?"

"Glimmer just likes people," Bow explained. Adora threw a disbelieving glare his way, forcing a sheepish smile out of him. "Sure, she can be a little hotheaded, but once you've proven yourself to her, Glimmer's the most loyal friend there is." Adora looked away with a flinch. *Huh?* Bow wondered.

"It's because they're so much alike," Mermista added, looking at the others as though it were the most obvious thing. If the looks the others threw her way were any clue, they were as shocked as Bow. "Like, seriously? Glimmer wears her heart on her sleeve, but fighting the Horde her whole life's given her a fierce warrior's spirit. Catra is all claws and snarls on the outside, but she's all caring and stuff deep down, it's why she works so hard when no one's looking." The stares' intensity doubled. *When did she* – Bow wondered. "I've read every Mer-Mystery book at least twice. If you can't understand people, you'll never figure out whodunnit.

They’re, like, perfect mirrors of each others. It’s almost poetry.” Bow blinked. *Oookay. I just hope Team Poetry is careful out there.*

-SR- -SR- SR-

Glimmer clung to the wall while Catra crouched in a shadow that looked too small to hide her – except it *did,* because she curled up in it like that was the most natural thing on Etheria. *Does she have to make everything look easy? It’s like dealing with Adora with claws.* She shook her head. *Stop it, Glimmer. This is what I always wanted, right? An Alliance that can win the war.*

“Look,” Catra whispered, eyes wide. It was so soft Glimmer almost missed it, but she heard, and crouched to see whatever the magicat found.

She immediately wished she hadn’t. A second winged figure had joined Styrax. He was half a head taller and almost as muscular. He was bald, with skin the color of Glimmer’s hair, eyes the red of Shadow Weaver’s magic, and a cruel, entitled smile. He wore the same modified Horde armor Styrax did, except it was black where most Horde suits were green. “Vultak?” Glimmer breathed. Catra nodded.

“Any sign of them, Styrax?” Vultak asked, his voice as unpleasant as his grin. Glimmer could almost see the dark brilliance in his eyes.

Styrax shrugged. “A few disturbed rodents. Possible, but unlikely.”

Vultak stroked his chin with one thumb. “She’ll come. Catra’s whole ‘thing’ is being unpredictable, except for one factor. She won’t trust any operation she doesn’t run herself.” He smirked. “I don’t blame her.” Catra’s ears flattened.

“Do you still think she won the Blind War Games?” Styrax asked.

Vultak’s smile vanished. “She won’t win the real war,” he snapped. Styrax recoiled, bowing his head. Vultak held up a hand, and shadow lightning crackled around it. “I’ll drain her dry and give

what's left to Hordak. He wants her alive." The smile returned, twice as cruel. "Poor thing."

Catra turned to meet Glimmer's eyes and held out her hand. She mouthed "out," and the princess didn't need more prompting, grabbing Catra's hand and teleporting them back to the others. *So. That was creepy.*

"It's him," Catra breathed, the others twitching from their sudden return. "He's got black lightning and bragged about draining people. We need to pull back, bring in the full strike force."

"What?" Frosta demanded, putting her hands on her hips. "He's hurting Erelandians, and you want to run away?"

"I want to *retreat* and bring in *reinforcements,* Snowcone," Catra retorted, eyes narrowing. "Look, I get it, you don't like me, but the Princess Alliance put me in charge of this. You were outvoted." Frosta snorted, glaring at Catra. "By the Horde, I thought you were the one with military experience."

Frosta all but snarled at Catra. "'By the Horde'?" *Please, don't do this now,* Glimmer prayed.

Catra sighed. "That's what you're hung up on?"

"Hey, you two," Adora whispered, "take it easy."

"I'm not the coward," Frosta snapped.

Catra almost snapped too. "Say that again," she hissed.

Yep. We're doing this now, Glimmer sighed. "Not the time, you guys," she whispered.

That got Frosta's attention. She paused, looking from Catra to Glimmer with an expression Glimmer couldn't read. "Fine. I'll deal with them while Horde Cat gets *reinforcements."* Before anyone could object, she formed one of her ice bridges and charged the enemy, her battle cry roaring around them.

All their eyes went wide. Perfuma gasped. “She didn’t!”

Mermista sighed. “She did.”

Explosions of ice threw tanks and skiffs aside like toys. “Glimmer, get to Frosta, watch her back! Bow, Perfuma, send the signal, then get in there and make a mess. Mermista, Sea Hawk, follow Frosta – use the laser sword to melt ice the kid’s not using so Misty has water.” Catra turned to Adora, and Glimmer’s heart sank at the feline’s grim expression. “You and me, we’re going right up the middle. Call Feathers.”

Adora flashed a wan smile, then nodded and drew the Sword. “For the honor of Grayskull!”

“ADVENTURE!” Sea Hawk cried, and the team charged in.

Glimmer teleported to Frosta’s ice ramp, and the child’s whole demeanor transformed. Her smile beamed at the Rebel leader. “See? These guys don’t stand a–”

Vultak dove at them so fast that he slammed Glimmer aside before she could teleport-dodge, then grabbed Frosta and drove her into the ground. “Well. Big meals really do come in small packages,” he drawled, shards of darkness crackling around his hands. Frosta howled and struck at him with her powers. Vultak sank into the ground, and for a moment, Glimmer thought he’d teleported, but then she realized that his *shadow* was still there, draining the thrashing child. “Such power,” the shadow mocked, crimson energy flowing around the outline of his form.

“NO!” Glimmer cried, firing blasts through her staff at the living darkness, but then Grizzlor leaped in her path, over a dozen soldiers following and firing at her. *Frosta!*

-SR- -SR- SR-

“Adora!” Catra cried, slashing through soldiers with an abandon the heroine had never seen in her friend. ‘We need an opening!”

A chill ran through the Princess of Power. *She admitted she needs my help,* Adora thought, all her longing for the moment becoming pain and sorrow. *It must be bad.* With a fierce cry, she channeled all her might through the Sword, slashing at the Horde units. The spiraling blast of force threw everything aside, from bots to tanks. "There. Let's – Catra? WAIT!"

Catra didn't wait. Racing with speed even Adora had never seen from her friend before, Catra shot through the remaining soldiers, tearing through them with a ferocity that left shrieks of pain and terror in her wake. She reached Frosta before Adora could move, raking the Vultak-shadow with the claws from her left hand and both feet while scooping the young princess up in her right arm. Vultak's shadow recoiled from where Catra had slashed him. Then she stood, twitching and hissing, while holding Frosta out of the shadow's reach. "Donnn't youuu touchhh herrr," Catra snarled, spasming as Vultak's sorcery struck her in the Snow Princess' place.

No no no no NO! With a desperate cry, She-Ra leaped into the air, Sword poised to stab Vultak's shadow. "Aren't you the resilient one, magicat," Vultak crooned. "Shadow Weaver's ministrations have made you strong – AH!" He didn't quite evade Adora's strike in time, and the shadow erupted from the ground to form a Vultak with a wounded wing. "You!"

"His senses are diminished in shadow form!" Adora reported, charging at him.

"Forget him," Catra gasped. "Frosta's the priority."

"Can't you..." Adora turned, only to find Catra pale and staggering in place. Frosta raised a single quivering arm, creating an ice wall no taller than She-Ra herself. "Oh, no."

"Oh, *yes,"* Vultak rejoiced, taking to the sky. His damaged wing made his flight awkward, but he managed to climb above them. "All forces, converge on my location! Catra and She-Ra are the top priorities! All other targets are secondary!"

Without thinking, Adora charged toward the pair, transforming the Sword into a shield even as she grabbed one in each arm. "Hang on, I'll get you out of here!"

"Hey, Adora..." Adora's heart felt frozen. Even Catra's smirk was weak. "I'll hold him. Without Swift Wind, you can't outrun–"

"Did someone order a cavalry?" Swift Wind cried, swooping down. He battered Vultak with a quick sideswipe, then picked up the three heroes and carried them aloft. "Not a bad rescue, huh, Adora?"

"You were amazing, Swifty," Adora gushed, gratitude shining like a moon within her. She relaxed her grip on the feline, letting her cling to Adora's back while the heroine held Frosta in her shield arm. "Catra, we have to pull back."

"Yeah," Catra agreed. "Petals, Misty, covering ramparts, Bow, light the buzzard up, everyone else, evac." Her voice barely carried far enough for the others to hear her, but Perfuma and Mermista managed to create enough overlapping walls of vines and ice water to protect the others as they fell back. A wave of Entrapta's bots approached, no doubt having seen Bow's signal flare.

To Adora's well-trained eye, the retreat was in good order. She had the only injured with her, and Swifty would get them to the safety of Bright Moon before the Horde could take advantage of their...whatever Vultak had done to them. "It's going to be all right, Catra," she reassured her dearest friend.

"No it's not," Catra breathed, and Adora froze. "I blew it, Adora. This was our push. The Horde pushed back and we lost."

"Catra, even you can't win every fight," Adora pointed out. Frosta shifted in Adora's grasp; she grunted, but nothing coherent came out.

"I was in charge, Adora," Catra whispered, clinging to She-Ra's tall frame. "I lost control of the team, and a princess almost died. The *kid* princess. Queen Angella will never trust me again."

"It won't be like that," Adora insisted. "You'll see."

"Whatever," Catra sighed, letting her head fall on Adora's back. *Angella will understand,* Adora thought, desperate to believe it. *Won't she?*

-SR- -SR- SR-

"Lord Hordak." Vultak bowed, smirking from the desk he'd commandeered. The mayor's office was built with wood and lined with furs, but comfortable enough to suit his tastes.

"Report." Hordak's gaze was as unrelenting as ever.

Vultak straightened. "Our first encounter with the Princess Alliance went largely as expected. The Snow Princess rushed to attack rather than Glimmer, but Catra proved as sentimental as predicted. However, she was far more resistant to my vampire-shadow than her file indicated, rivaling She-Ra's magical defense." His smirk grew. "Though their retreat was in good enough order to prevent us from taking prisoners or lives, Erelandia remains ours, and I now have their measure."

"Is Force Captain Catra as dangerous as Thaymor implied?" Hordak asked.

Vultak's smile vanished. "She overestimated her authority over the Princess Alliance. It's a mistake she won't make twice. Force Captain Adora is a highly capable commander herself, and oversaw the retreat with skill and determination. I caught them off guard and eroded their morale, but they won't fall for so obvious a ploy twice." He rubbed his chin. "Fortunately, She-Ra has an overdeveloped sense of heroics. Catra is too practical to risk the entire war effort for a handful of villagers, but a simple display of ruthlessness should draw Adora back out before she is ready."

"Do so," Hordak ordered. "The Rebellion has taken in weeks territory that took years to conquer. I want this outbreak quelled. Is that understood, Force General Vultak?"

"Of course," Vultak assured his master, smirk returning as he saluted. "For the Horde." The screen went dark. *And for eternity. I'll rule this world centuries after you're worm food, "Lord" Hordak. I'll gladly follow you until that happy day.* He clapped, and two terrified locals brought him a feast of a lunch. *In the meantime, this is the life I deserve.*

-SR- -SR- SR-

"The sad thing is, I've spent all this time hoping you'd come back to the Horde, when really you leaving was the best *thing that ever happened to me." Dream Catra's eyes went wide with a mad gleam, holding the Sword over the webbing Adora clung to.*

No. Stop, *Catra begged. She couldn't move, but her mad dream-self could. "I am so much stronger than anyone ever thought." She cut one of the strands. Adora's face became a mask of broken horror. "I wonder what I could've been if I'd gotten rid of you sooner."*

Dream Catra cut the remaining strands, and Adora fell. Only then did she realize that Adora had been holding onto Frosta with her free hand. Adora caught herself on a rock, but the jolt sent Frosta sinking into the abyss. Adora screamed, the despair in her cry everything Dream Catra had longed for. Frosta! NO! *Catra tried to go after her, but the body was not her own. Adora's mouth moved, but nothing came out. Darkness closed in from every direction. "Bye, Adora," Dream Catra mocked. "I really am going to miss you." Catra screamed. She fought. She resisted.*

The darkness swallowed everything.

"NO!" Catra cried, sitting bolt upright. Adora shot up from the chair she'd been in, hand on the Sword before she realized what she'd done.

The rest of reality comes into focus. Catra's outburst woke Frosta, who is now sitting up in the bed next to hers. They're in the Bright Moon infirmary, with Perfuma, Entrapta, and a pair of

healers in the room with them. “Ah, you’re awake,” Entrapta noted, rushing over. “Can I take a sample? The doctors wouldn’t let me.”

“No,” Catra grunted. Entrapta pouted. *Oh, by the Horde,* she sighed. “Depends,” she amended.

“Just some of your hair,” Entrapta explained, leaning close to the side of Catra’s head. “The tufts in your ears turned white. Faaascinating.”

“Oh, is that all? Sure,” Catra conceded. Entrapta let out a tiny squeal of joy, snipped a few strands with one of the tools tucked away in her own hair, and darted off. *Vultak’s magic,* Catra realized. *It left a mark.*

“Are you all right, Catra?” Adora worried, grasping Catra’s hand.

Catra grinned. “Just a dream. I’m fine. How’s Snowcone?”

“I want a better nickname,” Frosta muttered, looking at her hands resting in her lap. “Also, I’m, uh, sorry. About Erelandia. I should have listened.”

“Yeah,” Catra agreed, and Frosta wilted while Perfuma waved her hands to warn Catra off, “but I was in command. I treated you like Horde soldiers instead of princesses.” She managed a smile, keeping her fangs hidden. “We’ll get ‘em next time.” Frosta and Perfuma relaxed as one.

“Princess Frosta, you can go,” the lead healer said, “but I urge you to rest for the next few days.” The child nodded, frowning, and dropped out of the bed. Her legs were steady, but her eyes darted away. “Commander Catra, you need to rest for at least twelve hours more.”

A complaint rose in her throat, but when sitting up took more energy than she had, Catra dropped back onto the pillow without resistance. “Beaten by a buzzard,” she quipped, trying to smirk. “I’m never going to live this down.”

"That 'buzzard' was more than I could handle during the first Alliance, in more engagements than not," Angella said, striding in. Catra's ears shot to attention.

"Your Majesty, it was my fault–" Frosta began in a rush.

"Glimmer's report was unusually complete," Angella replied, regarding the young princess with cool respect, and Catra's heart sank. "I trust this will not happen again."

Frosta bowed her head. "No, ma'am," she muttered. Angella smiled. Snowcone – *no, Frostbite, that was the codename she wanted Glimmer to give her,* Catra remembered – paused at the door, looking at Catra. She nodded, then left.

"Commander Catra." Catra stiffened, but gave up on rising when the queen raised her hand. Adora's grip would have made it impossible, regardless. "I understand you believe the mission a failure."

Catra stared at the queen, unsure what to say for a moment. "What – 'believe' – Vultak took us apart like baton maintenance," she pointed out. "We barely got out of there."

"Your mission was to uncover the enemy's numbers and capability," Angella replied, hands folded and gaze gentle. "You managed an unexpected situation with aplomb, showed tremendous courage in protecting one of your people, and escaped with the desired intelligence." Catra hung onto Adora's hand as thought it alone held her on Etheria. "While you did not handle Frosta with the greatest tact, her insubordination was not your doing. I am frankly more concerned with your…ferocity while attempting to reach her."

Catra stared for a moment, then glanced away. "She's just a kid," she muttered, looking away. "I wasn't going to worry about..." she trailed off at the queen's expression, somehow stern and patient all at once. "Okay, I wasn't really thinking," she admitted.

Angella smiled. She looked *relieved,* for some reason. "I suspected as much. You have both learned from the experience, and I expect that you will work together mindfully in your next operation together."

"Thank you, Your Majesty," Catra breathed, hardly daring to believe in Angella's mercy. Adora's gentle pat on her hand reminded her that her friend had promised this. *Later. Focus.* She swallowed. "I take it that I'm not the first commander to object to fielding a child, though. Even the Horde doesn't do that."

Angella sighed, deflating. "Rest assured, Catra, that I am no happier with the situation than you. All the same, she is a Princess of Power. Her magic is strong and versatile, and she can wield hers in places where others lack theirs."

"If it helps," Adora added, "I'm not crazy about it, either."

"She has been forced to mature at too young an age," Angella explained, "and has been reliable in all royal maters before this odd outburst." She placed a kind hand on Catra's shoulder. "Rest, Commander. In a matter of weeks, we have come farther than I imagined I would see in Glimmer's lifetime. One failure does not diminish your successes, and you will have another chance to outwit Vultak." The queen withdrew with her usual preternatural grace.

Catra shook her head. "I still don't..."

"It's going to take time, I know," Adora replied, brushing Catra's hair from her eyes. "No one ever gave you the respect you deserved. You're still adjusting."

"It's...hard to believe I deserve it," Catra admitted, hugging herself.

Adora hugged her as well. "You do," the blonde insisted. She let go, returning to her chair. "We'll get him."

Catra closed her eyes. Shame rushed through her.
"Adora...thanks. I know I can be defensive about my competence, but I probably would have lost the kid without you."

"Frosta's my friend too," Adora said, smiling. "You were amazing, you know, standing up to Vultak like that."

"Mmm," Catra demurred. *That magic...it's a lot like Shadow Weaver's. Even Vultak figured out that's why I could resist him. Who are you, monster?*

Lost in thought, Catra didn't notice Bow watching the two defectors from the doorway.

Dreams of Mystacor

Chapter Summary

> Catra delivers, and receives, more than one lesson. So does Shadow Weaver.
>
> Note: I edited the General's name to Juliet to match ND's tweet.

"I'm just saying," Catra noted, clinging to Swift Wind's neck, "it doesn't sound like you've thought your uprising through."

"So, what, I should just ignore the plight of my people?" Feathers objected with a snort.

Catra sighed. "For the third time, *I didn't say that.* The problem is, you're not talking to them. I mean, is that even possible?" She looked earthward, spotting her squad. "You said it yourself. Complex thoughts, right?" Feathers grumbled as he descended. "Look, how many horses go back to the stables you 'free' them from? I'm sure kicking down barn doors feels good, but you need to think about what free horse society looks like."

"So I have to build the equine nation while I'm leading the revolution?" Swift Wind sighed. "Rebellion is hard." *You think?* Catra snarked.

"Oh, that's not the best part, Feathers," Catra cackled. "The best part is accepting that some of them won't *want* to be free." Swift Wind groaned as he landed. Catra leaped off to join Adora at the edge of a grassy cliff. "I could've walked, you know," she insisted. Glimmer smirked while Bow facepalmed.

Adora sighed. "You just recovered from Vultak's vampire magic," she pointed out, "and the trip to Mystacor is a little weird. Thank you for bringing her, Swifty."

"Any time," Feathers replied, spreading his wings again. "Besides, she hardly weighs anything. Thanks for the advice, Catra. I'll think about it."

"Sure thing, Feathers," Catra grinned. The pegasus flew off, neighing to himself. "So, does someone want to tell me why we're *not* taking the flying horse to the flying city?"

Glimmer's response was to grin and leap off the cliff. Catra's heart stopped for a moment. *Oh, right, teleportation.* Then Bow laughed and jumped. "They're not crazy," Catra whispered to Adora, "right?"

"They kinda are," Adora admitted, "but not about this. Woo hoo!" Adora leaped after them, dropping into the nearby clouds. *Okay. There's got to be something in there. Having some fun at my expense.* A moment's fury rippled through her before she could contain it. *Nothing I wouldn't do to them. Here goes.* Catra gulped, then jumped after Adora.

She sailed through the cloud cover, spotting the outcropping where Glimmer, Bow, and Adora waited for her. *No, wait, it's a tiny flying island!* Catra realized. *Entrapta would love –*

Catra was too high. She'd jumped too far. All three Rebels' eyes bulged as she leaped past them. Catra screamed.

Glimmer teleported Catra back to safety. "Do any of you," Catra panted, "actually think your pranks through, Sparkles?"

"I'm sorry!" Glimmer blurted. "I didn't think you'd jump that far!"

"Hey, everyone's all right, okay?" Bow insisted, sitting in the grass as the island floated upward. "Lessons learned. Let's enjoy the ride." The other two sat down as well.

Catra dropped to crouch beside Adora, tail lashing. "I still think this should have waited until after Erelandia," she muttered.

"We need a large enough force, you said so yourself," Glimmer pointed out. "The Rebellion should be ready by the time we get back." She dropped back, lying on the grass. "In the meantime, you need to relax. We've earned it."

Adora chuckled. "Since when do you need someone to tell you to mess around, Catra?"

When the fate of Etheria is in my hands, Catra thought, but sighed and faked a smile for Adora. "Yeah. You're right." She followed Glimmer's example, determined to ignore Bow's confused stare. "If we have orders to rest while we talk sense into Glimmer's aunt, who am I to argue?" She blinked. "Just one thing: what's an aunt? She's not a bug person, is she?"

Adora and Glimmer looked at each other, both stifling laughs. Catra sighed. *Why did I join the Rebellion, again?*

She didn't notice her shadow twist for an instant.

-SR- -SR- SR-

Bow watched as Catra stared at the sweater Casta put in her arms. "Welcome to Mystacor, dear," Glimmer's aunt said, smiling at the confused defector. "Don't worry about your fur. That was going to be a gift for one of your people." He tried to focus on the sorceress' greeting, but his mind kept wandering to Adora's relationship with the Rebellion's new mastermind.

Adora pressed her hand over her mouth, almost covering her laughter. "I'm sorr–"

"Stop," Catra groaned. "One more apology and I'm going back to the Horde." Adora's eyes widened, laughter forgotten. "I'm not serious, Adora." Catra smirked. "The Horde doesn't have tuna. Also, Shadow Weaver would literally kill me." Adora turned a halfhearted glare on her friend. "I'm fine, Adora. We're fine."

"If you say so," Adora replied, not sounding convinced.

Catra's smirk vanished for a moment, her ears flattening. Then smile and ears perked up again. "Speaking of which, I totally reserve the right to revenge-prank Sparkles."

Glimmer smirked back, leading Bow to groan. "Bring it on," the princess retorted.

Bow returned to the present as Catra shrugged. "Thanks. I'll try it on later. Did Queen Angella tell you why we're here?"

Casta folded her hands. "Yes, dear, and we can discuss that once you've had a chance to relax," she insisted. "Come with me. I know magicats are not fond of water, but in my childhood not one of your people left the steam grotto unsatisfied."

"Sure, why not?" Catra agreed.

Then she looked up.

Bow couldn't help a grin as Catra's eyes bulged, jaw dropping a fraction. Adora gave Catra's shoulder a gentle nudge. "Told you to pay attention," she noted. To Bow's amazement, Catra nodded without a hint of resentment. *This is progress,* he thought, relieved.

"It's..." Catra whispered. "Even Brightmoon isn't like this." Casta's smile beamed like all the moons. *Definitely progress.*

-SR- -SR- SR-

"That is the cutest thing *ever,"* Bow gushed.

I can't disagree, Adora thought, the sound and feel of Catra purring in her arm, asleep, utter bliss. She let out a tiny gasp, desperate not to wake her friend. *I've never seen her completely relaxed before,* she realized, *not even asleep.* The grotto hadn't been exactly restful on their first trip – being haunted by Shadow Weaver would do that – but this time, Adora couldn't even sort through the layers of happiness she felt.

Which meant, of course, it was time for whatever sadistic gods had chosen her for a sucky magical princess destiny to mess with her.

Catra's purrs melted into mewls, she squirmed, then let out a terrified whimper. Before Adora could wake her, Catra screamed and leaped out of the pool, wide awake and clinging to the wall. She looked around, eyes wild, until she spotted – "Adora!" Catra cried, leaping to crouch above Adora's shoulders, claws out.

"Catra, it's okay, I'm okay," Adora soothed, standing and putting a hand on Catra's shoulder. Her friend mewed. Glimmer and Bow looked at each other, their eyes speaking volumes that she and Catra had once shared. "Nightmare?" Catra nodded.

"Was Shadow Weaver in it?" Gimmer asked. Adora stiffened. *Oh, no.*

"Shadow Weaver's in all of my nightmares," Catra huffed. She paused. "Almost all. Water out," she added, and Adora sank back into the water. Catra shook herself dry. As awesome as that usually was to watch, Adora was still processing.

"*Shadow Weaver's in all of my nightmares."*

Catra, what did she do *to you?*

"Why did you ask?" Catra wondered once she was dry.

Glimmer raised an eyebrow. "Because of what happened the last time we were here?"

Catra frowned. "I thought they were ready for her this time."

"Maybe we should check in with Aunt Casta," Bow suggested. "Just in case." Catra nodded, and her lack of commentary worried Adora as much as the nightmare.

As if that weren't enough, the path they took back brought them through the Hall of Sorcerers. Catra's eyes flickered over Micah

first, to Adora's surprise, but soon settled on Light Spinner. "Catra?"

"She...used to fight the Horde," Catra whispered. "They kicked her out for being too ruthless, right?" She looked down at her claws.

"That's not you, Catra," Adora insisted, putting a hand on her shoulder. "Light Spinner did some big crazy magic thing. You're fighting to protect the people you care about."

"Wasn't she?" Catra breathed. Adora barely heard her. Then she stiffened, tail sticking straight out, and leaped back with a screech and hiss. Adora drew the Sword while Bow grabbed his namesake and Glimmer summoned her staff. "I'm not you, witch!" Catra cried. "Face me!"

The darkness didn't move. Nothing seemed out of the ordinary. "Let's get to Castaspella," Bow suggested.

Without a word, they all headed towards Casta's chambers. Adora's eyes flickered to every shifting shadow, but they were all moving with the light. Glimmer knocked, eliciting a gasp from their host. "Goodness, you're early! Come in, dear." The group entered, and Adora was surprised to find a room only slightly fancier than their quarters. Bookshelves covered two walls and there were three bowls on a desk, but Mystacor's leader lived as simply as her people. Casta's smile vanished when she saw them. "Oh my."

"I had a nightmare in the grotto," Catra said, rolling her eyes. "It was no big deal."

"The grotto heals the heart as well as flesh," Casta replied, her own expression turning grim. She gestured at the bowls. "I prepared these to examine Catra's magic potential. They should reveal any perfidy Shadow Weaver might be engaged in."

Catra bit back a chuckle, but the crystal bowls smothered any quips she might have had. "So, what are those?" she asked.

“These greet every sorcerer in her first days at Mystacor,” Casta explained, smiling again. Adora paid closer attention, noting that the leftmost bowl was the lavender of the sacred writing crystals, the middle one a silvery-gray, and the rightmost was the blue that Mystacor sorcerers used to write spells. “The first cleanses you of any magic not yours,” she continued, tapping the lavender, “allowing you to begin free of past sorcery. The second heals you of any physical or magical scars that might interfere with your potential as a sorceress. The third restores your magical energy, preparing you for your first spell circle. Ready?” Catra nodded. Adora recognized it as her “no, but I can pretend to be” nod. “Excellent. Dip your claws in the first bowl.”

“Claws?” Catra asked, popping them out all the same. “What do humans do?”

“We use our fingertips,” Glimmer explained. “Some sorcerers grow their nails out, but that gets in the way of other stuff.” Catra swallowed, then dipped her claws in the first bowl.

The instant she made contact, crawling shadows and crimson lightning surged out of her, causing Catra’s fur to stand on end and her ears to flare straight up. Adora gasped and grasped the Sword hilt, but the memory of her last trip to Mystacor kept her from acting on impulse. Casta’s eyes narrowed, and she held out her right arm, blue light glowing around her fingers. The evil magics writhed for several seconds, then stilled in a knot at the center of the bowl, captured by the fluid. “Well,” Casta noted, relaxing, “that was intense.”

“Huh.” Catra peered into the lavender bowl, where the cruel knot writhed. “I would've thought it'd be...more.” Adora gasped. *What?*

“I have never read of so intense a reaction to the test,” Casta replied, scowling at the cruel sorcery, “let alone seen one. Come,” she continued, brightening as she guided Catra to the second bowl with gentle hands. “Let us heal what Shadow Weaver thought to harm.”

Catra put her claws in the water, and she relaxed, fur and all. "That feels...I don't even know," she whispered. "Good? It's like something's gone, but that's what's good about it."

"Shadow Weaver's cruelty injured you on a mystic level," Casta explained, one fist trembling at her side even as she smiled for Catra. "What you are feeling now is what it's like not to be hurt."

"Not to be hurt..." Catra stared at her claws. Fury roared through Adora. *You'll pay for this, Shadow Weaver,* Adora swore. Confusion soon replaced anger. *Is this why you were so mad at me?* she wondered. *Then why didn't you come with me at Thaymor? You were the one who used to say we should leave. No one should have wanted to more.* Catra shook her head. "Okay. One more, right?" Aunt Casta smiled again and guided her to the final bowl. Her hands trembled for a moment, then Catra took control and put her claws in the liquid.

Her eyes lit up, blue and yellow, shining like moons. Catra flung her head back, and the light from her eyes became beams that covered the ceiling in magic radiance. Adora expected Catra to scream and braced herself to run to her friend, but all the cat-woman did was gasp. The twin lights soaked through her fur, turning her into a pattern of azure and gold that left Adora breathless. *She's always been beautiful,* Adora thought, *but this...Stars, Catra, what are you?*

Catra yanked her claws from the bowl, flying backwards. Adora and Casta nearly ran into each other catching her, but managed to interlace their arms instead to brace the new sorceress. "Wow," Catra breathed, looking at her trembling hands. The light, almost blinding seconds ago, had dimmed to a faint glow in her eyes. "WOW!" Catra laughed, her smile joyous and free.

That joy filled Adora's heart. *I would fight the entire Horde,* she realized, *to protect that smile.* She didn't understand the feelings rushing through her, but Adora knew that they'd both gained something that day. *If that is She-Ra's only purpose, then it would be enough.*

Catra laughed again, her claws glowing the blue of Mystacor magic. "Shadow Weaver," she cackled, *"lies."* The joy in Adora's heart shriveled, not vanishing, but banking to embers. Her rage towards their mentor returned, redoubled. *You can't escape thinking about her, even now?* Adora wondered. Then Catra turned to Casta, straightening and taking the head sorceress' free hand. "Teach me something," she half-pleaded, half-demanded. "Anything! A card trick, glowy lights, I don't care, I've got to *do* something with this!" She blinked, eyes flickering, and Adora recognized it as her effort to remember how to be polite. *"Please."* Bow's eyes sparkled.

Casta laughed as well. "Of course, dear. We'll start with a simple image spell."

"Image?" Catra wondered.

Casta nodded. "Light illusions are the most basic spells we teach in Mystacor." She gave Catra's hand a gentle squeeze. "I hope that won't be a problem."

"Problem?" Catra gasped. "Are you kidding? I'm in charge of special operations for the Alliance. Do you have any idea how useful even a simple illusion could be?"

Castaspella's smile returned, her eyes sparkling. "Catra, my dear, I believe you are going to enjoy your stay in Mystacor." Adora held back a cheer. *YES!*

-SR- -SR- SR-

Catra watched the spell form, her claws carving clean, bright circles and lines in the air. Glimmer stood beside her, going through the same spell with deliberate care. "Ugh," Sparkles sighed. "Of *course* you're a natural sorceress."

The magicat didn't bother fighting the pang of sympathy she felt. "Hey," she replied, "I get it. When we were with the Horde, I felt like I was never as good as Adora." Sparkles looked at her in surprise. "Like, at *anything."*

"Um, hello, master strategist?" Sparkles retorted. "Fastest hero in the Rebellion?"

"Second fastest," Catra replied, trying not to sound bitter. "Swift Wind."

"Fine, *most agile,"* Glimmer shot back. "You're sneaky, you're super-observant, and you're probably the best unarmed fighter we have!"

"I cheat," Catra chuckled, waving her claws at Sparkles.

"And *now,* you're some kind of awesome born sorceress who caught up with me in like ten minutes!" Glimmer erupted, throwing her arms in the air and letting her spell collapse. "Why does the Alliance even need me now?"

Whoa. Is this what Adora feels like when I fall apart on her? Catra wondered. "Okay, Sparkles, let's start with the easy one. There *is* no Alliance without you." Glimmer stared at her in shock. "Who do you think put this whole thing together?" She glanced behind them, but there was no hint of Adora listening in. "Sparkles, there are times when I can't even handle Adora and Bow, but you? You're nice without being annoying – most of the time," she amended, and Sparkles laughed. "I'm the only major player you didn't recruit, and you're a teleporting zap machine who can drop bots on tanks to take out entire armor platoons. Besides," she added, raising an eyebrow, "how much time have you had to practice sorcery in between, you know, building the second Princess Alliance?"

Sparkles laughed again. "You're all right, Wildcat," she quipped.

"Right back at you, Sparkles." Catra grinned.

Castaspella walked into the training room, Adora and Bow in the shadows behind her. "Hey, Aunt Casta. Have you thought more about Mystacor joining the Alliance?"

"Oh, child," Casta replied, her smile a sharp crescent moon and her eyes burning crimson, "Mystacor will be the *end* of the Alliance."

No! Catra recoiled, grabbing Glimmer's arm. "That's not your Aunt Casta," she warned. "It's her body, but–"

"Shadow Weaver," Glimmer breathed.

Catra glared as the sorceress' mad smile grew. Adora and Bow staggered in, their eyes glowing red and surrounded by shadows. "So, Castashadow," Catra quipped, sounding as casual as she could, "what's your plan, here? All we have to do is call for backup."

"Then do so," Castashadow mocked, one finger poised for spellcasting. "By all means, challenge me."

"Lens chamber," Catra said. The world turned into prismatic light, reforming as the heart of Mystacor.

Glimmer looked around when Catra let go. *Focus,* the magicat told herself, filling her claws with light. "So what do we do?" Sparkles asked. "Can you stop her?"

"You can," Catra replied. "Focus your light magic through one of those lenses and hit her with everything you've got." She leaped to crouch between the doorway and the magic water, claws shining sky blue. "I'll slow her down."

"But – Aunt Casta," Glimmer whispered.

"You'll do fine," Catra insisted. "Your sparkle bombs are good flash-bangs, but they don't hurt people. The witch must've used a shadow spy to get in, like before. You'll tear it apart and save her."

"Oh, child," Castashadow chuckled, gliding in, "you understand nothing." Adora and Bow followed her in, then slumped to either side of the opening, unconscious. More shadow tendrils closed off the room.

“Then enlighten me,” Catra spat, quivering with the need to claw Shadow Weaver’s face off. “You always wanted me to listen to you. Well, now’s your chance.”

“I hollowed you out,” Castashadow explained, smirk returning. “Drained you of your magic potential, fed off it to restore my strength after Mystacor betrayed me.” Catra straightened, tail lashing and eyes flaring wide. “I always believed there would be nothing left but a vicious beast, for what is a magicat without magic?” Her smile softened, and Catra felt paralyzed as the twisted sorceress amalgam walked towards her. “How mistaken I was.”

“What?” Catra whispered. Longing, *yearning,* for the respect Adora received so freely, the love Catra had never known, howled through her soul.

“Don’t listen to her!” Glimmer pleaded, tugging at one of the lenses. “Ugh, come *on!”*

Castashadow walked right up to Catra, then...placed a gentle hand on her cheek. “Hordak ordered me to bring you back. *You,* above all others, even Entrapta and Adora.” Tears formed in Catra’s eyes, and it took all her strength to keep them from pouring forth. “I did not see why, until you overcame a lifetime without magic in a matter of hours.”

“Why–” Catra looked up into the shining crimson eyes. “Why did you treat me, the way you did? Why was I never good enough?”

“Because you remind me of myself,” Castashadow insisted. “You always have. Nothing was ever easy for me either. I wasn't born to power like Adora and...others.” Casta made a trembling fist with her free hand. “I had to fight for my power. Earn it. Why should it be any different for you?”

“You’re a monster,” Glimmer gasped, eyes filled with tears. She’d stopped fighting with the lens. “She was a child! How could you?”

"I made her *strong,"* Castashadow snapped, glaring at Sparkles before turning the kindest look Catra had ever seen from the sorceress...on her. On Catra. "I gave Adora everything, *we* gave her everything, and she abandoned us. You stayed, until Adora convinced you to leave."

"You..." Catra hated how weak and young and *broken* she sounded. "You believe me?"

Castashadow nodded. Shadows swallowed the room, and all light that didn't come from the three of them."We can have everything back, my child. Just lower the shield, and all will be forgiven. Adora will answer to you, Force General Catra." Catra hated herself even more for leaning into the hand on her cheek. "The Rebellion will never accept the ruthless leader you've become. The Horde is ready to welcome you home." She hated herself for embracing the warmth of that touch, the acceptance.

From Castaspella's hand.

Catra stood at attention, nodded to Castashadow, and strode to Glimmer. "You're not doing anything with that lens," she noted. "Move."

Glimmer's eyes widened. "Catra?"

"*Move."* Catra popped one glowing claw. Glimmer took the hint, teleporting to Bow, then carrying them both to Adora. She held onto them both, trembling with wide eyes. Catra unsheathed the rest of her claws, filled them with sorcerous power, then claimed the lens. "You know, Sparkles, I almost went along with this. I want you to know that." Out of the corner of her eye, Castashadow's smile returned, a cruel, vicious thing. "There was just one problem."

She spun and filled the lens with her summoned light, blasting Castashadow with it. "Shadow Weaver *lies!"*

"Nooo!" Shadow Weaver screamed, thrown from Castaspella's body. Casta fell to her knees, then looked up, wide eyes filled with

shame.

Catra whirled the beam on the retreating darkness, its baleful crimson eye giving its position away. "Glimmer! Hit her!"

With a ferocious cry utterly at odds with her small, sparkly appearance, Glimmer teleported in front of the shadow spy and blasted it with her princess magic. She struck it again and again, howling in fury with each blow. "This is for my dad, and Adora, and Catra, and everyone else you hurt and betrayed!" Glimmer's bursts of light drove the shadow back, right into Catra's improvised magic beam. *Got you!*

"Just like your mother," the shadow snarled. Then the beam sliced the shadow in half, and the monster screamed as it burned away.

Adora and Bow leapt to their feet, hands halfway to their weapons before they realized that the fight was over. Castaspella was back on her feet, magic glowing around her hands. Glimmer churned like a tank engine, panting while her crackling fists pumped through the air looking for something to hit.

Catra looked at the Lunar Lens. Mismatched eyes – *the eyes of a freak, pathetic, worthless,* Shadow Weaver snarled a lifetime ago – stared back. They were gleaming with tears, fur stained with them. This time, though, there was something more.

Light. Blue light, gold light, flowing through the stains in shining streams.

"*I am so much stronger than anyone ever thought."*

Catra let the lens go, and it floated back into place. *I was going to do it,* she thought, wanting to tear her claws out. *I wanted to do it.* Catra laughed. She cried. She wanted to vomit. "She was right. I am a monster."

Adora gasped. Before Catra knew what had happened, the blonde was holding her as if she'd never let go. "She was wrong," Adora

demanded, holding Catra up when she wanted to fall. “You saved us all, again!”

“You were amazing, Catra,” Bow added, joining the hug.

Glimmer laughed and piled on. “You tricked her,” she pointed out, grinning at Catra. “You beat Shadow Weaver at her own game!”

“She only got in because of me,” Catra whispered. “They didn’t find her in my shadow because she was in *me.* She hollowed me out–”

“And now you are filled with light and wonder,” Castaspella retorted, smiling, “free of her darkness at last. We both are.”

Catra chuckled. “Yeah. Free,” she said, letting the trio hold her up. “Sure.”

“Still,” one of the other sorcerers said, and Catra realized several of them had arrived with spell circlers ready, “the magicat is not wrong. Mystacor was only vulnerable because we allowed outsiders in.” Catra flinched.

Glimmer gasped, then teleported in front of the offending sorcerer. He was a goat-man a head taller than the princess, but he recoiled from her glare. *Don’t blame him,* Catra thought. “Really? So you’re never going to recruit anyone again?” she asked.

“Your Highness,” another sorceress began.

“No,” Glimmer snapped. “I’m Commander Glimmer of the Rebellion, and I’m here to tell you that if Mystacor doesn’t stand with the Alliance, then it will fall alone.”

“You’d just abandon us?” the sorceress gasped.

“Of course not!” Bow insisted.

"But we can't help you if we're *not here,"* Glimmer pointed out, fists on hips. "Look, it was Catra's idea to ask for your help, but you need ours too."

"Shadow Weaver only got in because of the defectors," a third sorcerer pointed out.

"She wasn't here for Mystacor," Glimmer snapped. "She came for Adora, then Catra. Revenge was just a bonus."

Catra sighed, then straightened. Adora and Bow released her. "If the Horde takes Etheria," she pointed out, "how long will Mystacor survive, alone?"

"Exactly," Glimmer agreed, one hand pointed at Catra. "Shadow Weaver ignored Mystacor because you *didn't matter."* The other sorcerers gasped. "Sooner or later, she's going to get in again, and you're so busy focusing on how she got in because of Adora and Catra, that you've forgotten that they're the only ones who were able to stop her."

They all stared, except for Castaspella, whose smile was pride incarnate. "The Horde thinks it can win because they make everyone the same," Sparkles said, fists still shimmering. "We're going to win because we let people be different, working together! Your sorcery, the power of the princesses, Bow and Entrapta making amazing machines, brave soldiers led by heroes like General Juliet and Commander Catra, that's how we beat them."

Even Adora and Bow stared at Glimmer, their awe and pride as bright as a moon. "Oh, yeah, Sparkles," Catra laughed, "you're not better than me at *anything."* Glimmer blushed, smiling and rubbing the back of her neck.

"Well." Casta smiled. "I, for one, am going to Bright Moon." A few of the sorcerers stared, but most of them were nodding. "As for Mystacor, we can take a vote." Aunt Casta didn't sound worried.

-SR- -SR- SR-

Bow chuckled at the sight of Glimmer cringing at Casta gushing over her speech, Adora and Swift Wind laughing together. Once more on solid ground, the group walked towards Bright Moon, where they would prepare quarters for the incoming sorcerers, and guards to back up Mystacor.

Turning, he spotted Catra in the rear, playing with the cuffs of her sweater. "You okay?" he asked.

"It's actually comfortable," she explained, staring at a sleeve. "Like it's brushing my fur the right way, all the time."

Bow grinned. "I'm pretty sure it's magic." The smile vanished. "That's not what I meant, though. Are you *okay?"*

Catra looked away. "No." Her tail lashed around in front of her, and she grabbed the end, fingers smoothing it out. "I was tempted," she admitted, voice choked. "Really tempted."

Bow nodded. Catra faced him again, eyes wide with surprise. "I get it. Honest. It's okay, Catra. All that matters is that you made the right choice in the end."

"No it's not," Catra snapped. "I'm not free. She's still in my head!" She hugged herself. "Maybe...she always will be."

"Look, some pain never goes away," Bow admitted. Catra cocked her head a fraction. "That's what friends are for. Happiness won't erase it all, but it can make the hurt worthwhile." Catra's nod was slow, but it was there. He smiled for her again. "You know, I was worried about you at first."

Catra smirked. "And now you're not? After that?" She waved at distant Mystacor.

"Yep," he said. Catra blinked. "I didn't know what was under all the snark and scars."

"And now you do," Catra drawled.

Bow nodded. “You care,” he said, and Catra’s ears went flat. “Even after everything the Horde did to you, they couldn’t make you stop caring.”

“I’m not weak,” Catra shot back, glaring.

Bow sighed. “You care because you’re strong, Catra.” Her ears shot up again. “The Horde couldn’t break you. Not even Shadow Weaver could do that.”

Catra looked away. “...thanks, Crop Top.”

Bow chuckled. “Better than ‘Pretty Boy,’ at least.” They walked in silence for a minute. *I think it’s time,* he decided. “Can I give you some advice?” Catra shrugged. “Okay. I think you should apologize to Adora.”

Her ears went flat again. “What.”

“So she apologized to you a lot,” he continued, “and I know it’s a little much, because Adora, but have you apologized to her?”

Catra spluttered. “She left me! She promised, and she left, and I followed her anyway! What do I have to apologize for?”

Bow sighed. “I dunno, maybe zapping her in the back, and attacking her in Salineas, and kidnapping two of her friends–”

“I was with the Horde,” Catra retorted.

“Which you knew was bad,” Bow pointed out.

Catra snorted, glaring at him. “Adora’s going to say it’s no big deal, you know.”

“Yeah, but that’s not why I think you should apologize. You’ll probably feel better if you do.” Catra started at him, ears up again. “Don’t apologize *for* her. Apologize for you.” He put a hand on her shoulder. “Think about it.” He quickened his pace to catch up with Glimmer, and let Catra think.

Wounds

Chapter Summary

> Adora gets hurt protecting Catra. In the aftermath, Catra must face her worst enemy.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"We close, E.T.?" Catra asked, peering at monitors and rubbing her wrist.

"Oh, yes," Entrapta agreed, rubbing her hands together (a gesture mirrored by her pigtails). "We should get feeds from Emily's Kid Sisters any moment now." As she spoke, Erelandia appeared on two displays. Catra frowned. *Hostages,* she realized, spotting the two groups of civilians caged on either side of the border town. "Another nightmare?" Entrapta asked, her voice grown gentle. Kyle looked up from the carrier's controls, the concern on his face mirroring Entrapta's.

Catra yanked her hand from her wrist. *Shadows dangled her above the chasm, Adora's broken body twitching and pleading far below. "You will always belong to the Horde," Shadow Weaver mocked, Glimmer and Bow staring in horror from prisons of red lightning. "You will always belong to* me, *beast!"* Catra could still hear her laughter. "I'm fine," she lied. "Status."

"All bots optimal," Entrapta said, hands and hair rushing to her controls. "Ooo, I can't wait to see how they perform in the field." She turned to Kyle. "Assistant? Was 'I'm fine' sufficient deflection in the Horde?"

"Hey!" Catra objected.

Kyle nodded, turning back to the controls and slumping in his chair. "Yeah," he muttered. "Adora usually dropped it, I was too

scared to say anything, and..."

"No one else bothered," Entrapta finished, nodding. She took out her recorder. "Political experiment log 42: further evidence that the Rebellion is the superior choice as a long-term solution."

Catra growled a sigh. "Going topside," she warned, bursting out of the roof hatch.

The vanguard, consisting of "Kid Sisters," Best Friends Squad, Perfuma, Spinnerella, and Netossa, had come to a halt at the sight of Vultak's forces. The company of soldiers behind them followed suit in seconds. *I knew Frosta would be disappointed, having to stay behind,* Catra mused, *but I expected Mermista to be cool about it.*

She shook her head as she loped forward. *I needed our fliers, and Perfuma's our best crowd control princess.* Catra couldn't help a grin as she approached the eager knot of royalty. *Who knew that a bunch of sparkly kids could be so eager about smashing things? I think Bow's the least violent member of the Alliance, and he's named after a weapon.* She stopped in front of She-Ra, already transformed, and the super-warrior saluted her. "Enemy contact, sir." Catra stamped down on the thrill she felt at Adora reporting to her like this. Or at all.

The pleasure took a new, distracting turn –*Stars, she's beautiful* – which Catra clawed into oblivion while She-Ra continued. "Vultak's set up his forces in a standard spear formation." She frowned. "Hostages on either side of his forces."

"Trying to split us up," Catra murmured, obvious though it was. "Not even bothering with subtlety." Bow sighed, throwing Catra's train of thought onto another trail. *I am not apologizing to her.*

Glimmer huffed. "He knows it'll work," she noted.

"We'll see about that," Catra growled. "He can't hold Erelandia with that formation, so he's after something else." She glanced at She-Ra, whose eyes flickered from one set of hostages to the

other. “Probably Adora.” Glimmer made an angry fist. “Sparkles, Bow, you watch her back. Adora, you rescue left-side captives. Spinnerella, Netossa, you go right, get them clear.” She glared at the Horde forces awaiting them. “Petals, Feathers, you’re with me. E.T. will send the Kid Sisters into their front line, and we keep Vultak from rallying to stop them.” She rubbed the earpiece Entrapta had invented to keep them all in touch. It still felt alien in her ear, but long-range contact was priceless in battle. *In a year, every soldier alive will wear these.* She nodded to Adora. “Everyone stay on comms. We hold it together, we win.” They all nodded. Perfuma was even grinning. Catra grinned back. *What is it about the girly ones being so violent?* she wondered, mind wandering back to Glimmer.

Glimmer gave Adora a thumbs-up. Adora nodded back, then smiled at Catra. The magicat’s stomach did somersaults. *I’m going to trust her. I’ve got her back.*

...but I am not *going to apologize to her.*

-SR- -SR- SR-

This is too easy, Adora worried, smashing Horde tanks and bots with a simplicity that make her skin writhe. Glimmer and Bow provided cover for both She-Ra and the fleeing civilians. She-Ra didn’t need the backup, yet. *Two more minutes, and the hostages will be safe.*

In spite of her concern, Adora couldn’t help but smile at the sight of her best friend cackling as she bounced off the helmets of the few soldiers Perfuma and Swift Wind didn’t toss aside. Grizzlor whimpered in a mound of dirt a hundred feet away; Catra had beaten him so easily she’d hardly even bantered with him. Styrax thrashed in a magic net thrown past the town by a small cyclone. Scorpia struggled against a pair of Kid Sisters.

(Adora shoved aside the guilt and grief she felt at the sight of Lonnie and Rogelio watching Scorpia’s back.)

Catra gestured to Glimmer, and the princess dropped a Horde bot on a team of its cousins. They exploded nicely. “Wow. The Horde loses a few cadets and it falls apart?” Catra mocked. “How were you idiots going to conquer Etheria, scary voices?”

Perfuma’s shadow rippled, warped, and erupted into Vultak. The monster flew at Catra, who yelped and leaped out of his way, losing a strand of hair to his claws. “You talk such a good game, pussycat,” Vultak retorted, smirking, “but we both know you’re a terrified child pretending to be a soldier.”

Catra responded by carving a magic circle in the air, which turned into a burst of light that sent Vultak fleeing with a squawk. “Hey, Vultak,” Catra drawled. “Feathers! You’re on!”

Swift Wind shot towards the recovering Horde commander. “For the Rebellion!” he cried, diving at Vultak hooves first. Vultak dodged, snarled, and lashed out with crimson sorcery. Swifty dodged as well, but lost a few feathers to the blast. Adora gritted her teeth and focused on evacuating the last group of civilians. *Hang on just one more minute,* she prayed.

“You’re brave, beast,” Vultak snarled, “but you can’t outfly me!” Swifty kept low, racing back to the center of the Rebellion assault, Vultak in close pursuit.

Just as they approached Perfuma’s position, Catra leaped from a leftover column of vines and raked Vultak’s wings. He yelped, then they landed, Vultak plowing across the grass while Catra clung to his back with her claws. “You think I’m afraid of you, Buzz?” Catra sneered, digging into his wings. “You couldn’t scare my goose bumps.” Vultak tried to sink into the darkness, but somehow Catra kept him from escaping.

Their shadows boiled over, lashing out and grabbing Catra from every direction. She screamed, and Adora’s blood froze. “Oh, Catra,” Shadow Weaver said, emerging from the darkness, “we both know what you’re afraid of.”

“GLIMMER!” Adora screamed.

The series of pops that followed were so quick, they could have been a single hum of sound. “Hostages are safe, go!” Glimmer cried.

With a raw howl, Adora leaped to Catra’s side, sword raised. She caught glimpses of Perfuma struggling against the combined magic of Vultak and Shadow Weaver, Horde shock troops bringing flamethrowers in for support. Swift Wind could only circle, lances of force and lightning lashing out whenever he closed. Spinnerella and Netossa tried to force their way closer, but there were just too many units between them and Catra.

Catra was alone. With Shadow Weaver and Vultak. The winged general had managed to shift into shadow, and the two were tearing at Catra’s very existence.

Adora slashed at Vultak’s shadow form, divine light erupting around them. The Horde commander managed to evade, but that forced him to let Catra go. Catra screamed and tore her way out of Shadow Weaver’s magic, claws whirling with shining fury.

That left Adora alone with their “mother.” Shadow Weaver glared at She-Ra, gathering darkness around her hands. “Adora,” the monster drawled. “To think I was forced to pretend affection for your pet.” Catra gasped, barely eluding the swarming shadow spies. “You will regret this defiance.”

“No,” Adora whispered, holding the Sword before her. “I won’t.” She lashed out, the spiral of raw power forcing Shadow Weaver to flee.

“Now!” Vultak barked. “Fire all!”

Adora gasped. Tank blasts converged on her from every direction. Shadow spies roared towards her. Vultak’s dark lightning shot at her. *I jumped right into the kill zone,* she realized, forming her shield and bracing for the worst.

It felt like the whole world exploded. The cannon fire was the least awful of it, merely battering She-Ra from all sides. The shadow monsters dug into her, stealing the heat from her bones. All of it left her vulnerable to Vultak's vampiric sorcery, the cruel bolts tearing the very life from her.

The last thing she heard was Catra screaming her name. Then everything was dark.

-SR- -SR- SR-

"NO!" Catra cried, racing to Adora. She set a baton to self-destruct and threw it in Vultak's face. The general recoiled, giving Catra time to scoop up her friend.

She only froze for an instant. *She's not moving,* Catra sensed. *She's barely breathing…*

Shadow Weaver rushed towards them, howling something about animals and worthless and *just like her mother.*

Dimly, Catra realized that Glimmer wasn't anywhere nearby, so Shadow Weaver must mean her. *Later,* she decided, pivoting to hold Adora on her back so she could scramble forward with an arm and both legs. "Swift Wind!" Catra called.

Nothing.

"You won't escape me this time, vermin!" Shadow Weaver howled, clawing at the earth to send a wave of darkness at them. Catra didn't waste breath responding. She just ran.

"Evac," she gasped. Glimmer appeared, grabbed Adora, and vanished.

Catra skidded to a halt, relief rushing through her. She turned, glaring at Shadow Weaver, at the Horde. *I used to be that,* she thought, disgust and fury taking relief's place. *I* wanted *to be them.* She put two fingers to her earpiece. "Entrapta. Sister Dance."

The Kid Sisters became whirling tops, plowing through the Horde forces with limbs flailing and beams slashing. The entire enemy division broke and fled, the battle over in an instant.

Catra didn't care. Her mind had room for only one thought.

Adora.

-SR- -SR- SR-

Bow stood in the doorway, cold in spite of the castle's warmth, as he watched Catra weep silently at Adora's bedside. Glimmer had finally gone to sleep, Queen Angella sought solace at Micah's mural, and Entrapta was in her lab, researching Adora's injury. *"I feel better if I have something to do," the adorable genius explained, mask down and back turned. "Please let me know if Adora's condition worsens. Or Catra's."*

"Catra? How are you?" he asked.

"Fine," she whispered. "Adora saved me." Catra made a fist, grasping the edge of Adora's sheet. "Not that it matters if she dies on me."

"It doesn't sound like you're fine, Catra," Bow whispered back.

Catra whirled on him, standing as she did. "What do you want me to say, Crop Top?" she hissed, glaring. Bow flinched before he recognized the snarl as defensive. "That I messed up? This is my fault? You think I don't *know* that?"

Bow gaped. "Of course it's not your fault!" he blurted. Both of them turned to check on Adora, but she hadn't stirred. "Catra, no one expects you to control every moment of every battle."

"Of course you do," she snapped, voice low as she hunched her shoulders. "I'm the genius commander who's winning the war, right? Why else am I worth keeping around?"

Oh. Bow reached out, and when Catra didn't flinch away, gently took her hand. "Catra, you're our friend. That's all you need to be worth for any of us."

Catra's eyes widened, then narrowed as she looked away. "I'm Adora's friend."

"It started like that," Bow admitted, holding onto Catra, "but you were already Entrapta's friend, then you became Glimmer's, and Perfuma's, and mine." Catra gasped, facing him again. "You're not the same woman who kidnapped us. You're a good person, Catra."

Catra shook her head. "Shadow Weaver's right. I'm vicious, and ruthless, and *mean,* and even if the Rebellion doesn't kick me out I'll screw this all up somehow." She glanced over her shoulder at Adora. "If I haven't already." Catra bowed her head, ears and tail drooping. "I...don't get to be happy."

"That's not true," Bow insisted. Cautiously, careful not to overstep, he moved closer, giving Catra plenty of chances to stop him, then wrapped her in a gentle hug. She shuddered, then sobbed into his shoulder. "Everyone deserves the chance to be happy. That's what we're fighting for." Her sobs paused for a moment. "We know that nobody's perfect. All anyone in the Rebellion wants is for us to do our best." He chuckled. "And I thought we established that Shadow Weaver lies."

Catra stiffened, and for an instant Bow thought he'd messed up, but then she laughed into his shoulder. "Thanks, Bow," she whispered. Bow relaxed. "Is this where you tell me to apologize again?"

"No," Bow sighed. Catra pulled back and looked at him in surprise. "Catra, you need rest. If you're going to, you can apologize when you're both better." He held both of her shoulders. "It's okay to take care of yourself too."

She shook her head. "I have to be here. I *have* to. I promised," she whispered. With a gentleness that surprised Bow, Catra pulled

away, then sat by Adora's bed again.

Bow took the hint and left her alone. *Please be okay. Both of you.*

-SR- -SR- SR-

"*Insolent child."*

Catra whimpered. Young Adora stood between her and Shadow Weaver, arms outstretched to protect her. Lying mother and innocent daughter argued over the cat girl.

The Sword appeared in Catra's hand. Neither human nor sorceress noticed. No, *Catra thought, her dream-self growing to womanhood in seconds.* No! Not Adora! Please!

"You never protected me," adult Catra whispered. "Not in any way that mattered." She pointed the Sword at Adora's back. Adora had grown enough that she and Shadow Weaver could almost see eye to eye. One thrust would solve everything. No! This isn't who I am!

"Isn't it?"

Catra stood over the chasm again. Over Adora again. "Bye, Adora," she said, crouching to look into her friends tear-filled eyes. She was still holding the Sword. "I really am going to miss you." Instead of throwing it away, she held it up, poised to swing.

"NO!"

Catra woke with a horrified start, whirling in her chair to scan the room. The room was dark and empty; it was the middle of the night, and Adora was the only person left to treat. *It's not my fault,* she thought, the words weak and pathetic even in her own mind. *Shadow Weaver...Adora...I didn't...I* couldn't...*they had everything, and I had nothing! Nothing except…*

"I have to do something. I'm sorry, Catra." Adora turned her back – and Catra stunned her from behind. Adora twitched on the

ground, convulsing.

Adora was helpless, focused on restoring the Sea Gate. Catra slashed at her again and again, unleashing her grief and fury, hoping Miss Perfect would feel a fraction of Catra's pain.

Adora dangled from a hairpin above an endless void. Catra laughed at the broken, sobbing horror on her former friend's face. "See you later, princess," she mocked, just before taking her shiny new friends and leaving her there, betrayed and lost.

"I'm sorry," she whispered, stroking Adora's hair. She still didn't move, except to breathe. "It – it hurt so much, when you left. I...I wanted to hurt you back, and I thought I didn't, that I *couldn't,* but I did, so many times, and you forgave me. You *apologized,* too many times," she chuckled through a sob, "and never asked for anything but me to be with you."

She pulled herself up. It felt like carrying a tank. "I was horrible to you. I wasn't even a good friend before you left. I took you for granted, and let you do all the work, and...and you were right about the Rebellion, and your sparkly friends," she continued, sobbing, "and I'm a terrible person and you liked me anyway and that's why I was so upset when you left and I don't understand this place at *all* because they should hate me!" Her confession was only half a truth, but Catra would rather have died than tell Adora the rest of why being abandoned had broken her.

"I...I was going to do it." Catra admitted, hugging herself. "I was going to cut the webbing. I was going to throw away the Sword and leave you there. I was going to go back to the Horde with the crystal and use Entrapta to destroy the Rebellion."

She slid into place at the foot of Adora's bed, curling up and purring at her feet. "I'll move back in, if you want," she breathed. "Or, it's okay if you don't like me anymore. If you don't want to be friends...I understand. You never promised any of that. You – you just have to come back. I look out for you. You look out for me. We–" Catra choked on a sob. "We promised."

Adora didn't move. Catra purred, and sobbed, and prayed.

-SR- -SR- SR-

"I'm sorry...I'm sorry...I'm sorry..."

Adora felt torn in half.

Vultak's vampire magic was amateur hour. Shadow Weaver's sorcery was as scary as shadow puppets.

Hearing Catra say, again and again, that she was worthless? That she was horrible and didn't deserve Adora's friendship – anyone's friendship? Torture. Exquisite, unending agony. *No. You kept me alive and sane in there!* Adora sobbed, raging against her dearest friend's grief. *You were everything. You stayed for me even though they hurt you, and then I abandoned you. I hurt you, but you came back and saved me and the whole Rebellion! Please stop, Catra!*

Adora couldn't move. She couldn't even twitch a finger. But she could hear. She could feel. And all she wanted was to stop Catra from hurting.

At last, Catra's litany of self-condemnation stopped. She rose, padded to Adora's side, and started licking Adora's forehead. *What?* Adora wondered. *She hasn't done this since we were kids–*

Adora's finger twitched. She felt strength, *life,* returning to her. It was slow and frustrating, but her breathing and heartbeat grew steady. Catra licked with greater determination, matting down Adora's hair and flowing ever more vitality into her. It felt like hours.

"Oh, Stars," the elderly doctor breathed, her voice a welcome surprise. Warmth flowed into the room, hinting at dawn. "Miss Catra?"

"Uh, Glimmer?" Bow asked. "Is Catra licking Adora?"

“Huh?” Glimmer teleported in. “Yeah, but that’s not all she’s doing. It’s some kind of magic!”

“Magicat healing arts,” the doctor explained. “I haven’t seen anything like this since I was a child.”

“Catra...” Adora whispered. At last, she had the strength to open her eyes.

“Adora!” Catra gasped, hugging Adora and sobbing. “I’m so sorry–”

“Please stop,” Adora begged. “I heard you, over and over. You deserve *everything.* Peace. Love. Joy. Family.”

“But I–” Catra began.

“Almost did something bad. You saved me. You saved us all. I don’t care what you thought about doing,” Adora insisted.

“Four words,” Catra whispered. “Four stupid words were all that stopped me.”

Just speaking felt like it drained what Catra had given her, but now that she’d started, she had to finish. “Then they’re the most precious words I’ve ever spoken,” she smiled, “even though I said them wrong.” Catra let out a confused mew. “I said you ‘were’ my hero. You *are* my hero. You always have been. You always will be.”

“ADORA!” Catra sobbed, hugging her with strength to rival She-Ra’s.

Adora could almost see Bow’s eyes sparkling. Glimmer sniffled. Exhaustion came to overcome Adora again, but she didn’t mind. She’d made it right, at last.

I’m glad I never have to see the world where I didn’t say those words...

-SR- -SR- SR-

Catra woke to find herself in a bed next to Adora. *No dreams?* she wondered, looking around.

"Hey, take it easy," Glimmer insisted, putting her hand on Catra's. "You ran yourself ragged, doing whatever that was with Adora." Sparkles grinned. "Licked her better. I am so teasing you both for that."

I did? Catra wondered. *Oh. Yeah. I did.* She rubbed her face, sitting up. "Good luck with that." She blinked, drooping in relief at the sight of Adora sleeping normally. "I'm just glad it worked. I have no idea how I did it."

"Instinct, probably," Sparkles shrugged. "Do you want to talk about it?"

Catra snorted in spite of herself. "You're not going to ask if I'm all right?"

"I'm not stupid," Sparkles retorted, crossing her arms.

Catra couldn't help a chuckle. "I guess not." She sighed. "Bow said I'd feel better if I apologized. I just feel drained. Empty."

"Give it time," Glimmer replied, giving Catra's shoulder a gentle shake. "You just let out years of Shadow Weaver awfulness. It's like being sick. The infection's gone, but you still need to recover."

"Yeah, Shadow Weaver's sick, all right," Catra quipped, and Glimmer laughed. The magicat looked away. "I...just can't keep blaming her, you know?"

"Why not?" Sparkles quipped back.

"She's not my worst enemy," Catra whispered. "I am."

Glimmer sighed. "I know that feeling," she admitted. Catra looked up, stunned. "I'm just so...mad, all the time. The world's messed

up, and it feels like no one else wants to do anything about it! So I try to make people help, and I just mess things up worse."

Catra snorted. "Except when you kicked Mystacor in the scrolls."

"Says the girl who's kicking the Horde in the batons," Sparkles shot back. They laughed.

"I like...that sound..." Adora whispered."

"Adora!" they both cheer, standing. "How do you feel?" Catra asks, somehow not feeling stupid.

"Better," Adora said. It sounded like a confession. "Still tired, but like I need to sleep for a day instead of a year, so, progress." Glimmer laughed.

Catra didn't. "This shouldn't have happened. The Sword–"

"I'm not all-powerful," Adora pointed out. "That was a lot of tanks. And Vultak. And Shadow Weaver."

"Vultak," Catra snarled. "I am *sick* of him."

"Wow, Shadow Weaver drops to second place," Glimmer quipped, her smile weak. "That's new."

"This was his idea." Catra folded her arms, tapping one with a finger. "Hey, Sparkles, can you watch Adora for a minute? I need to talk to Entrapta."

"Uh, sure?" Glimmer agreed (sort of). Catra headed out.

"Catra?" Adora called. The word was more impassable than a tank. "You said you'd sleep with me again?"

Catra relaxed, turned, and smiled. "Of course."

"But not by my feet," she insisted, suddenly worried. "*You're not my pet.*"

“I know.” Catra nodded, smile growing as she left.

Huh. I wonder why Glimmer was so red. She looked like she was about to explode.

-SR- -SR- SR-

Entrapa’s eyes sparkled at the sight of the Crystal Castle. “Crystal Castle log one: I have never encountered a First Ones site this complete or intact before!” Bow and Kyle adjusted their backpacks, looking at each other and shrugging.

“Aren’t those the same thing?” Swift Wind asked. Catra and Glimmer grinned.

“It could be an entire site, but in pieces,” Entrapta explained, “or the undamaged center of an otherwise disassembled structure. Further,” she continued, living hair rushing her to the entrance, “scans indicate a fully functional network within, possibly including a synthetic intelligence.” Another coil brought the scanner to eye level. “Some elements of the code appear to be at odds with others, however. This is so exciting!” She laughed. Then one of her secondary thought tracks came to the fore. “Social interaction log, addendum: while hacking the Crystal Castle systems will benefit other efforts as well as science, I remain uncertain how this expedition is a ‘favor’ for Catra.”

“Adora’s been avoiding the Castle,” Catra explained, “partly because we’re not sure if she can trust Light Hope, but mostly to avoid hurting my feelings.” She sighed, running fingers through her wild mane. “Since that almost got her *killed,* I figured it was time for her to come back and get some actual Sword training.”

“Plus,” Adora added, smiling at an odd angle, “you might learn things that can help the Rebellion.”

“You’re helping me be an actual friend for her.” Catra smiled again. “Which just happens to let me be a real friend to you, too. Just don’t get eaten by spiders. That’d probably slow down your research.”

"Probably," Entrapta admitted. *Unless I digitized my intelligence! The Crystal Castle would probably make such an effort possible!* She laughed again. "Crystal Castle log one, addendum: determine the specifications of the Crystal Castle's memory scanning technology."

Adora and Catra looked at one another. "Go on, Adora," Catra said. "I'll keep an eye on E.T." Entrapta's hair rippled with delight at the cherished nickname. Adora and Swift Wind opened the ramp and went in, while Glimmer teleported to the spire wall and started practicing magic circles.

Entrapta devoted a secondary mental track to Bow as he approached Catra, focusing primary tracks for mathematical and deductive reasoning on the artificial issue. *Hm. It appears that the synthetic intellect, which does appear to be coded as "Light Hope," may have constraints on its behavior programmed into its protocols. I shouldn't log that without confirmation.*

"So, Catra." Bow sat beside the feline. "Feeling any better?"

Catra laughed. "If you mean because Adora's better, yes. If you mean because I apologized, I feel more hollowed out than after Mystacor, and I had Shadow Weaver literally crawling inside me."

"Okay, first of all, ew," Bow replied, "and second, you need to give yourself time. I'm not sure why it hasn't helped yet–"

"Oh, you mean the part where I realized I'm a crap person," Catra drawled, "and a worse friend? Yeah, don't know why *that* would bother me."

Bow sighed. "You are neither of those things. Catra, you're a good person with some entirely understandable issues. You made some mistakes, but you've worked really hard to make up for them." He smiled. Entrapta's heart beat a little faster. *Weird,* she noted. "If anything, I'd say you're overcompensating."

Catra huffed. "Oh, great, I'm turning into Adora." She sighed and scratched behind her ear. "Now I know I'm my own worst enemy."

"Catra. Stop," Bow said, frowning a fraction. "You're taking this way too hard." He brightened all at once, smiling again and taking off his backpack. "Maybe this will help take your mind off things. I can help Entrapta while you read."

Catra blinked. "Read what? I've never been a book pers–" she trailed off at the sight of the large manual Bow extracted, taking it with a reverence Entrapta had not previously noted in the feline. "Is this..."

"It's 'Songs of Halfmoon,' a book about the Bubasti," Bow completed for her, pointing out a few colored papers sticking out of the tome. "Your people were reclusive even before the Horde, but this was the most complete narrative I could find. I made a few notes for you from other books that 'Songs' missed, but you shouldn't need anything else to find out what humans knew about magicats."

"Bow...thank you…" Catra looked away, rubbing her eyes. *Ah. Tears. I must make a further social addendum about Horde defector unwillingness to show emotional vulnerability once out of her super-human hearing range.* She ran fingertips over the cover, a female magicat in black with gold trim. "Is this what you and Adora were working on before our scouting mission?" Bow smiled and nodded. Catra sighed. "I don't understand any of this."

"You will." Bow patted her on the shoulder, then walked over to Entrapta. "Hey, Entrapta, so what have you found – is that synthetic intelligence code?!" he gasped, eyes shining.

Entrapta leaped to her feet, pointing to the trinary feedback loops at the center of Light Hope's personality. "I know! Isn't it exciting?" Bow nodded. *I am glad to have friends, but someone who understands technology? Returning to the Rebellion was an empirically sound choice.*

-SR- -SR- SR-

As Bast, Ra, and Sekhmet departed from the fields of Thracia, the land freed from the horses that stalked men, they had already begun to prepare for their ninth quest. Apophis had already slithered his way into the kingdom of Tanais, a land defended by the Bubasti warrior-queens, and the three gods of the Whiskered Ones had no intention of allowing the Destroyer to turn sister against sister.

"Whoo!" The ramp opened silently, but Adora was about as stealthy as a tank, leaning on Swift Wind. Feathers didn't look much better, wings and nose drooping. "Well, I wanted to train."

"Hey, Adora!" Catra rushed over to manage as much of a hug as she could with the massive book under one arm. Adora chuckled as Catra let go. "Sekhmet's whiskers, you look like even you've had enough."

"Light Hope doesn't mess around." Adora replied, smiling at her. "Did you like the book?"

Catra laughed. "You've heard my last 'by the Horde.' Maybe Frostbite can finally chill." Adora joined in the laughter. *Huh. Since I'm trying to do this 'good friend' thing,* she noted. "Adora." Catra regarded Bow with a casual air Adora had begun to recognize as forced. "Where's Crop Top from?"

Adora stared at where Bow and Entrapta were still chattering about Light Hope and the Crystal Castle, excited as ever. "I...have no idea," she admitted.

Huh. Catra's grin faded away. *He understands my...stuff. A lot.* Her tail lashed behind her. *Maybe too well.* She looked at Adora. "Me either. And maybe we should."

Chapter End Notes

So this one took a while, even considering that I said I'd be slowing down. It's fairly pivotal in Catra's character development, seeing how even as a good guy, she really needed a wake-up call regarding her behavior. It's not like

she's going to stop being Catra, but hopefully future scenes where her kinder side shines through will feel less OOC after this.

Signal Failure

Chapter Summary

> Signals, if Catra and Entrapta were there. Plus, what has Scorpia been up to?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Entrapta's eyes sparkled at the sight of the empty village. Catra smirked while Bow fiddled with his pad. "We updated my pad to detect Horde signals," he explained, just before it released a high-pitched whine. Catra stopped smiling, clapping her hands over her ears. *Ow.* Bow stopped the sound, then grinned sheepishly. "Sorry."

"That's unexpected," Entrapta replied (agreed?), darting to his side by hair-tendril.

Sparkles' smile was almost as sheepish as Bow's, as though apologizing for him. Catra almost grinned back. *"You should come with us, Catra," she said. "It'll do you some good to get out," she said.* Instead, Catra sighed and glanced back at Entrapta. *Someone has to watch out for our resident genius idiot.* Catra couldn't help realize that even the insult had been fond. *How did a mad scientist and a sparkly war machine become my best friends?*

She blinked and looked at Adora, whose wide-eyed wariness towards Alwyn bordered on the, well, adorable. *What am I thinking? Adora's my best friend. Again.* She swallowed when her throat went suddenly dry. *Right?* "I must've broken something during the upgrade," Bow lamented.

"Unlikely," Entrapta replied, snatching the pad from Bow's hands. He yelped while she disassembled and examined it. "Nope! Fully functional," she continued, putting it back together in seconds

before returning it. “We’ve picked up an anomalous signal! Isn’t it exciting?” She laughed.

“Well,” Glimmer sighed, “why is Bow’s ‘anomalous signal’ making his pad loud?”

“I don’t know! That’s what makes it anomalous,” Entrapta explained with a huge smile.

Glimmer took a deep breath. Catra could almost feel her gathering her patience. “That’s okay. Whatever happened here, we’ll figure it out. Nothing’s going to stop us.” A gust of wind blew through, ruffling the humans’ hair and setting Catra’s and Swift Wind’s fur on end. Her smile turned nervous. “Not even stores about Alwyn being haunted.”

Adora looked at Glimmer, trying to cover her nerves. “Haunted? Like with ghosts?”

“No,” Catra snarked, “like with squirrels. Sweet Bast, you and your ghost stories,” she sighed.

“What ghost stories?” Bow wondered.

“Shadow Weaver uses to warn us about ghosts. Like the story of the Weeping Princess,” Adora told them, trying to look cool. “A vengeful spirit who roams Etheria–”

Catra snorted a chuckle. “Yeah, Adora was a sucker for those. Shadow Weaver loved watching her huddle under the covers.” *She’s gonna spook them if I let her keep going.* Catra smirked at her friend. “Not that I minded either. You were cute like that.”

The whole group froze. Catra’s eyes widened. *I did* not *just say that,* she thought, tail lashing. “Uh. Don’t we have villagers to rescue? Isn’t that our thing?” He ear twitched at a sound like a child laughing.

“Yes!” Swift Wind agreed. “Definitely our thing! Especially since I just heard someone.”

The humans all yelped, even Entrapta. “The Weeping Princess?” Adora gasped, eyes bulging.

Catra slapped her forehead. “No, Adora, unless the Weeping Princess is, like, ten.” They all relaxed. “Let’s move, okay?” They did, but only Catra hadn’t been unnerved.

And her tail lashing behind her like a whip was *definitely* not proof to the contrary.

-SR- -SR- SR-

Dylamug shook his head – an impressive feat, given that the cyborg’s face was in his torso. “Do you really want these cadets, Scorpia?” he grumbled.

“Come on, Dyl,” Scorpia urged, “give ‘em a chance. They want to get into the fight and help the Horde.”

“At least the boss isn’t ditching us for the catgirl now,” Callix added, his stone-covered skin rippling with pebbles.

Scorpia laughed, rubbing the back of her neck. “Aw, Callix, I didn’t ditch ya,” she objected. Callix raised one rocky eyebrow. *Yeah, okay, maybe I did a little,* she admitted to herself.

They entered the locker room to find Lonnie and Rogelio taking off their training gear. The two looked somber, almost lost. *Well, I’ll take care of that!* Scorpia decided. “Atten-*tion!”* she snapped. The cadets yelped, then went ramrod straight with better salutes than most officers Scorpia knew. She chuckled. “At ease. I’m sorry, I’m sorry,” she continued, waving them down as the two turned confused looks toward one another. “I couldn’t help it. So, you two looking for a squad to join?”

Lonnie gaped. “You...you’d let us on your team? After everything?”

“Hah!” Scorpia retorted. “What do you mean, ‘let you?’ I’ve seen you two in action. We almost took Salineas together. You busted

through Princess Prom like it was a malfunctioning bot. It takes princesses to give you a hard time, and take it from a princess, that's pretty awesome." Both cadets brightened.

"Wait, they're actually good?" Dylamug blurted. Scorpia sighed, tail wilting. "Why didn't you say so, boss?"

"I kinda just did, Dyl," she pointed out. Lonnie and Rogelio both smiled, as much from relief as happiness. "Anyway, Shadow Weaver reassigned half my squad to Vultak last year, and you two need a Force Captain to work with, so, win-win!"

The light dimmed behind her, and the cadets' smiles vanished. "Is there a *problem,* Force Captain Scorpia?" Shadow Weaver drawled behind her.

Scorpia spun around and saluted. "No ma'am! Just getting the ol' squad back up to spec, you know how it is, ma'am."

Shadow Weaver glared at the Scorpioni, eyeslits narrowing. For several seconds, no one moved. Scorpia gulped. At last, Shadow Weaver pulled back a fraction, straightening. "Very well," the sorceress said.

Lonnie and Rogelio turned surprised looks on one another, then grateful ones toward Shadow Weaver. "Really, ma'am?" Lonnie asked, lips tight.

"Why not?" Shadow Weaver shrugged and turned, sliding towards the door. "Indulging Adora with peers was a mistake." Scorpia blinked, tail rising in alarm. "Permitting Catra to live was a greater one."

"Hey, now, that's not okay," Scorpia blurted. Shadow Weaver turned, one eyeslit widening a fraction. *Like raising an eyebrow,* Scorpia thought. "They were kids. You were supposed to take care of them." She waved in the direction of Lonnie and Rogelio. "All of them."

Shadow Weaver darted right back in Scorpia's face, causing her to yelp and retreat a step. "*They* were cadets of the *Horde. They* are supposed to *obey,* as are *you."*

"You know," Scorpia began, voice soft, "if that's how you treated your children, I'm not surprised three of them left."

"How *dare* – wait, three?" Shadow Weaver asked, her rant derailing mid-sentence.

Lonnie cleared her throat. "Um. Kyle. Ma'am."

Shadow Weaver stared for several more seconds. "Adora and Catra are no longer your concern, Force Captain. If you need these two, then take them. Just *do – your – job."* She turned to leave again."

"I don't like you," Scorpia whispered.

Shadow Weaver laughed as she flowed out the door. "I would be offended if you did, princess."

The moment she was gone, Lonnie rushed to Scorpia's side, eyes wide. "Are you crazy, ma'am? Do you know what she does to people she doesn't like?"

"I'm starting to get the idea," Scorpia whispered, eyes narrowing.

"You mustn't anger her!" Rogelio warned. *"She is* Shadow Weaver. *She will hurt you, betray you, even kill you without hesitation."*

"Yeah," Scorpia agreed. "That's why I don't like her." Lonnie and Rogelio both stared. "She hurt Catra, didn't she?" Rogelio nodded. Lonnie looked at him in surprise.

"You can understand the lizard guy?" Dylamug asked.

"Scorpioni. My whole body is basically ears," Scorpia explained. "Look, you guys have been through a lot lately. Why don't we go on a wall patrol, get a chance to relax?"

“You can relax on a wall patrol?” Lonnie asked.

Callix chuckled. “The only attacks on the Fright Zone were rescue missions,” he explained. “We don’t have any Rebel prisoners, and Angella’s not insane.”

Lonnie stared a moment. “Huh,” was all she said. *Oh, kid, you’ve got a lot to learn,* Scorpia thought, smiling.

-SR- -SR- SR-

“This is just like the story of the Headless Princess,” Adora realized, tamping down on her rising panic. “She stalks the night, pulling people out of their beds. Leaving nothing but bloody footprints.” She, Glimmer, Bow, and Entrapta all looked at each other, eyes wide, then looked down as one.

The floor was dry. They all sighed in relief. Adora let her eyes close for a moment. *Catra’s right. I’m worrying too much.*

“Adoooraaa...” Catra moaned. Adora looked up – and yelped. Catra staggered out of the bedroom – with her head under her arm?! “...the Princess...she got me...” Just when Adora started to realize what Catra had done, Glimmer, Bow, and Entrapta looked – and screamed, clinging to each other. Swift Wind ducked in, looking around, and his scream was as loud and shrill as all three humans combined.

Catra laughed, craning her neck around to shift her head back to normal. Remnants of illusion magic fell apart in the process. “Oh man, you should have seen the looks on your faces!” she cackled, holding her forehead.

“Not funny, Catra,” Adora half-sang, glaring while the others started breathing again. “That trick was bad enough before you could do magic.”

Glimmer teleported in front of the still-chuckling Catra. “What is wrong with you?”

"Ohhh..." Catra wiped her eyes and stretched her neck. "I'd say 'raised by Shadow Weaver,' but I think she'd drop dead if someone stuck a sense of humor in her." Adora couldn't help a faint smile. *That was...*horrible *timing, but it is good to see her being, well, Catra again.*

Swift Wind snorted and shook his wings out. "Can we give her back to the Horde?" he grumbled, then stopped and stared at Bow and Entrapta. "Uh, Bow? Entrapta? She's not dead, just evil."

They were still clinging to each other, one of Entrapta's pigtails wrapped around Bow's shoulders. After a few seconds, they looked at each other, yelped, and jumped away, both faces turning red. Glimmer gasped, then covered her mouth, tiny sounds like giggles escaping between her fingers. "So!" Entrapta blurted, rushing to Catra's side. "How did you do that? It was clearly not mere illusion."

"I can bend my neck farther than humans," Catra smirked. "Somehow, Adora fell for it every time Shadow Weaver told that story." She snorted and raised an eyebrow at Adora. "I mean, 'Headless Princess?' Really? How–"

"'does she see,'" Adora finished alongside her friend. "Magic, Catra!"

"Let's – just check the other buildings," Glimmer interjected, saving them all from further Catrenanigans. The search was calm for a minute, until Entrapta rushed over to a spike in the ground. She and Bow chatted about it until loud banging interrupted them all. Even Catra leaped into the air this time, landing with a hiss and her fur standing on end. Entrapta and Bow were hugging each other again, while Glimmer teleported back from wherever she'd gone. "I'm sorry. I have no idea why I did that," she admitted.

"This place is weird," Adora muttered. Then her eyes widened. "Like the lair of the Undead Princess! Where she lures soldiers to their doom."

Catra groaned. “Bast, not *another* of your Faerie Princess stories,” she complained.

“Yeah,” Bow added, “the Horde really had a theme, huh?”

“Oh. You’re right,” Adora replied, “Wow. I can’t believe I’m just realizing this.”

Catra slapped her forehead. “Adora, you thought we were the good guys, and we were raised by *Shadow Weaver.”* Adora winced while Catra loped over to her and Glimmer reminded the others of their mission. “Hey, Adora,” she whispered, smirk growing. “Is it just me, or are Bow and Entrapta getting really clingy around here?”

“It’s spooky,” Adora said defensively.

“We just established how dense you are,” Catra retorted. “Glimmer is Bow’s best friend, and I’m Entrapta’s, poor kid.” Adora scowled at her beloved friend’s self-deprecation, but Catra just kept going. “So why do they grab each other first?”

“They’re closest to each other?” Adora pointed out.

“Yeah, and why is *that?”* Catra pointed back.

Adora sighed. “Because they’re the smart ones, Catra. Look, if you’re going somewhere with this–”

“She wants to date him,” Catra drawled. Adora froze, eyes wide. *No. No way.* She turned to look at them, and Entrapta had her hand on Bow’s shoulder as she pointed at the spike. The magicat shook her head. “You know what? Never mind. I’ll get Glimmer to help.” Adora blinked. *Wait. Help with what?*

-SR- -SR- SR-

“So this is wall patrol,” Lonnie said, looking out over the vast fields beyond the Fright Zone. Above, the moons gleamed with the pale glow of night. “I’m startin’ to see the appeal.”

"Yeah," Scorpia agreed, "it's kinda peaceful out here most of the time. The sky can get pretty sometimes, too." Lonnie stared. *This is the dreaded Scorpia?*

"That's the boss," Dylamug explained. "She's as mellow as they come, except in battle."

Rogelio hissed something Lonnie couldn't make out, except for Adora's name. Scorpia sighed. "Yeah. I thought she just didn't have what it takes, but after meeting Shadow Weaver, I'm starting to wonder. And Catra." Scorpia shrank, shaking her head. "I'm not surprised she left, now. I honestly don't know why she stayed."

"Adora abandoned her," Lonnie spat. "I didn't even *like* Catra, and I thought that was horrible."

Rogelio huffed and chuckled, and this time Lonnie caught Adora's, Catra's, and Kyle's names along with "favorite." Scorpia outright scowled at that one. "Man," the Captain groaned, "if that's how Shadow Weaver treated her favorite student's squad, I don't wanna think what it was like for everyone else."

"It wasn't like that," Lonnie admitted, leaning on the wall's edge. The plains beyond the Fright Zone were almost unnaturally still. "She – Shadow Weaver – was awful to everyone. Even with Adora, she was all, 'I expect great things, *or else.'* And the rest of us...looking back, it almost feels like we were the ration bar. 'If you want to keep your squad, do as you're told,' you know?"

Callix snorted. "Yeah. 'Nice village you've got there. Shame if something happened to it.' It's an old one."

Rogelio's eyes widened, and his question was simple enough that even Lonnie could translate it: *"Do we do that?"*

"We're not supposed to, but it happens," Scorpia admitted. "It was bad enough when we were up against magic princess powers, but now that they've got Entrapta and Catra, the Rebellion's out-thinking us everywhere we turn." Their new captain turned wistful as she looked at the horizon. "Desperate Captains make desperate

choices. For a while, we had the Rebellion on the run, but now...” she shrugged.

Lonnie huffed. *Man, what a load of crap,* she thought, crossing her arms. “So if you’re a princess, and we have a Runestone, why don’t you have magic princess powers? Is that Shadow Weaver too?”

Scorpia stared. “Huh. Uh, maybe?” She rubbed the back of her neck with one claw. “My family gave Hordak the Black Garnet before I was born. Those things usually drive princesses nuts, but maybe it’s worth the risk.”

Lonnie’s eyes widened, as did the rest of the squad. *How could I forget something like that?* she admonished herself. “Whoa, whoa, let’s not go overboard here,” she warned.

“Unless...” Dylamug rubbed his chin, which was downright weird when it was where his bellybutton ought to be. “...what if the princesses tricked us into thinking that?” Lonnie and Rogelio stared at the cyborg in shock. “I mean, sure, they’re the enemy, but they seem pretty stable in combat. Spoiled and reckless, but not crazy, you know?”

“Okay.” Scorpia straightened, tail and all. “Let’s ask Lord Hordak.”

All four squad members stared at their Captain. “What?” they cried as one.

-SR- -SR- SR-

“Adora!” Catra yowled, chasing after She-Ra as the legendary warrior swung her sword at flickering phantoms. Glimmer gulped, then teleported to Catra’s side. “Adora, *stop!”*

“What are we going to do?” Glimmer asked, turning to the magicat. *You’re the tactical sorcery genius,* Glimmer thought, desperate. “Catra?”

"First, we get She-Ra to stop swinging at – AH!" Catra leaped away from a pale white figure, drawing a magic circle and firing it off before Glimmer could have concentrated the power into a finger. The princess' jealousy died as it was born when the spell passed through the phantom without effect. "Oh, *come on!"* Catra howled.

"I can handle the Horde, but I can't handle this!" Adora cried as they caught up. "This is like–"

"Stop telling ghost stories!" Glimmer snapped, clinging to the Princess of Power. "I've been terrified since we got here!" she finally admitted.

"They're not spirits," Catra insisted, snarling as she wove up another spell. "Even if they were too strong for a ward circle, it should have done something." She glanced at Swift Wind. "And there's that sound. You hear it too, right, Feathers?" The pegasus nodded.

"Bow," Entrapta gushed, grabbing him again suddenly, "that's it, isn't it? This is a First Ones ruin!"

"Of course!" Bow agreed, walking up to one of the phantoms. Glimmer was having none of that. She teleported him away, then She-Ra swung at the thing. Her sword passed right through it, slamming into the ground and causing lines in the earth to light up. "They're holograms. Look."

"They keep repeating the same patterns of behavior," Entrapta explained. "Perhaps they're messages, triggered by the extraordinary energies Shadow Weaver and Vultak have channeled from the Black Garnet." She laughed. "Ooo, we'll have to take samples! I'll have Emily bring her sisters to dismantle the entire structure!"

Really? Glimmer huffed. "Entrapta, we are not dismantling an entire town so you can play with First Ones tech." Entrapta pouted.

“Relax, E.T., the signal’s coming from that spike,” Catra explained, pointing. “I’m sure we can take that one if it makes the holo-ghosts stop.”

“It’s an antenna,” Bow realized. Together, they started clearing roots away from the old device. “It’s probably some kind of First Ones communication hub. Adora, with you translating, we should be able to turn it off.”

Adora pointed at two dancing holograms. “So, these are First Ones?” she asked.

“Most likely,” Entrapta acknowledged, clearing vines away with her hair.

“Why?” Bow asked.

“I just...kept thinking of them as these epic forces, but they’re regular people, sending normal messages,” Adora muttered.

Catra and Glimmer shared a look. *She’s overthinking again,* Glimmer thought. Catra nodded, then threw an arm around Adora’s shoulders. “Seriously?” the magicat snarked. “What, were all the First Ones supposed to be big fancy heroes? Who’d they be hero-ing for, then?”

Adora smiled and gave Catra’s ear a quick scratch. “Thanks, Catra.” Glimmer clamped both hands over her mouth to not ruin the purr, or the moment. *So CUTE!* Then Adora walked over to the antenna and put her hand on a diamond symbol. The whole thing turned off. “Be at rest now.”

Catra stared at her. “You know they weren’t really ghosts, right?” she asked.

“Memories of people long gone,” Adora whispered, looking at where the dancing First Ones had been, “going through the motions of their lives, never realizing that their whole world is gone? That sounds like a ghost story to me.” Catra huffed, then they shared gentle smiles as the magicat nodded.

“The ‘ghosts’ must have scared off the farmers,” Bow deduced, pulling out his tracker pad. “We should let them know that it’s safe to return.”

“Excellent!” Entrapta gushed. “Our first successful mission as a unit. I will now summon Emily to extract the antenna.” Glimmer exhaled in relief. *At least she’s not trying to rip up the whole village.*

“Way to go, Best Friends Squad,” Bow agreed. They smiled at each other. Then they blushed and looked away at the same time.

Glimmer looked at Catra. Catra looked at Glimmer. “Intervention?” Glimmer whispered.

“Intervention,” Catra agreed.

“Anyway, everything should be back to normal,” Bow continued, but as Glimmer teleported over to watch, his pad went nuts with the First Ones gobbledygook. “It’s that message again.”

“It’s corrupted,” Entrapta explained, using her hair to peer over the two of them. “I may not be able to read First Ones script, but I know damaged code when I see it.” Her eyes lit up. “Ooo, I wonder if we can track the signal!”

Catra looked at Glimmer. Glimmer looked at Catra. *Here we go again,* the princess sighed.

-SR- -SR- SR-

Hordak watched the green sphere flicker, burn bright, then flare into non-existence. With a roar of existential fury and frustration, he swept the useless tools on his workbench aside. *How am I supposed to get anything done on this miserable backwater of a world?* he raged, storming back to his primary work chamber to acquire some marginally functional equipment.

He paused at the sight of his “throne,” a pale shadow of his brother’s magnificent citadel. Longing pulsed through his soul for

an instant before he crushed it, refusing to surrender to despair. *I can do this. With nothing but the ruins of a single ship and a handful of surviving crew members, I lit the fire of civilization on this barbaric world. I created industry, law,* empire, *where before there had been nothing but superstition and ignorance. I* can *do this.*

The door to his chamber opened, and Force Captain Scorpia entered with unusual trepidation. "Ahem. Lord Hordak? I don't mean to disturb you, heh, and I know we've run into a few setbacks lately, but I think we can still turn this thing around."

Prime have mercy, Hordak groaned. "I trust," he began, and Scorpia leaped in place before saluting, "that you are not here to address some abstract notion of morale, Force Captain."

"Well, morale is important, my Lord," she babbled. Hordak let his eyes narrow a fraction. "But no! No, definitely not. Concrete ideas, absolutely. For instance, one of my new squad mates, Senior Cadet Lonnie? Smart as they come." Hordak's eyes narrowed further. "She thought I might be able to fight the princesses better if I had power like theirs," she rattled off quickly.

Hordak blinked. *Oh. Yes.* He regarded Scorpia with new respect. "You wish to channel the power of the Black Garnet, as your ancestors once did. Wield that power on behalf of the Horde."

"Yes sir!" Scorpia agreed, saluting. "I just, you know, thought that Shadow Weaver might object, and–"

"I find my concern for Shadow Weaver's objections waning by the day," Hordak noted. "So long as you are willing to share the Runestone's power while the sorceress remains true, you have proven yourself a loyal member of the Horde. It will be done."

"Thank you, Lord Hordak." Hordak nodded a fraction. *This might prove a genuine asset against those accursed Princesses.* He moved to return to his portal experiments. "That brings me to the

other thing I wanted to talk to you about," she continued in a rush, holding out a file. It was unusually thick.

"What is this?" Hordak asked, taking the file before Scorpia could answer. Opening the folder revealed a picture of a younger, smirking Catra. "A personnel file? For that defector?"

"Well, my Lord, that defector is why we're losing the war," Scorpia pointed out. Hordak forced himself not to glare at his newest asset. *She is more clever than I thought,* he noted, *making herself vital before bringing this up.* She gestured at the folder. "Catra is brilliant, creative, fearless, and devoted to people who earn her loyalty. I think that file will explain why she left."

"Hm." Hordak flipped through the pages with casual disdain. *Just because some cadet fled the Horde and managed a few victories...admittedly, several...Prime take her! I will* not *be undone by a child with something to prove to…*

His fury ebbed as he leafed through the papers. *Insubordination, age seven. Infraction unspecified. Disciplinary action: denied ration bars for a day?* Hordak scowled. *Malingering, age ten. Infraction unspecified. Disciplinary action: corporal punishment.* His hands began to tremble as he read through "unspecified" incident after incident, every punishment coming from Shadow Weaver herself. *Insubordination, age fourteen. Infraction unspecified. Disciplinary action: three days in – the Box? For* unspecified *insubordination, by a child?* He glared at the date. *Less than a week after the Blind War Games. Even Shadow Weaver would not punish a cadet for satisfaction...would she?*

He looked back up at Scorpia, who stood at flawless attention. Her expression was perfect in its neutrality, save for a minute tightness around her eyes. "What, precisely, are you suggesting occurred, Force Captain?"

"Abuse, my Lord," Scorpia whispered. The words thundered through the throne room.

Hordak permitted himself a slight snarl, then strode to his throne and sat. He pressed a button. "Shadow Weaver. Report to my chambers."

"My Lord," Shadow Weaver whined, "I am in the middle of a delicate–"

"*Now."* Hordak cut off the communication. Scorpia let out the tiniest squeal he had ever heard. *How unpopular is Shadow Weaver, that Scorpia herself wishes to see her disciplined?*

-SR- -SR- SR-

Glimmer watched, frustrated, as Bow and Entrapta directed "Emily" and the other bots to dismantle the antennae. The first few Alwynians were trickling back, all amazed at the sight of the Best Friends Squad. *Look at them,* she groaned. *They have to work not to hold hands. They're almost as hopeless as Adora and –*

"Any progress?" Catra asked, crouching.

"With tech? Sure," Glimmer retorted, pinching the bridge of her nose. "With clueless best friends? Zero."

Catra sighed. "Let's tell them to kiss."

Glimmer's jaw dropped. *Is everyone in the Horde this clueless?* she despaired. "You can't just do that!"

"She's Entrapta," Catra said, as if it were an explanation.

"Their relationship will die of embarrassment! Besides, Bow!" Glimmer objected.

"She's *Entrapta,"* Catra repeated. *Nope, still doesn't make sense,* the princess decided. "Okay, Princess of Subtlety, what's your plan?"

"Nudge them in the right direction. I'll join you soon." Glimmer hid a smirk. *And get some payback in the process.* She vanished to make her preparations.

Catra sighed again and leaped to sit by the genius duo's side. "So, having fun with the new toys?" She asked, looking over the antenna with a casual air.

"Oh, yes," Entrapta gushed, Bow grinning beside her, "this communications tech is so exciting! Also," she added, turning a faint pink, "it is nice to have an...organic...partner, to assist with the experimental process."

Catra smirked. "So, he's like Kyle?" she prodded. *Ooo, nice,* Glimmer admitted.

"No!" Entrapta blurted. Then she gasped, Bow's eyes widening. "I, mean, ahhh, Kyle is an excellent assistant, of course, but Bow is...different."

"Uh, Catra?" Bow asked. "Are you going somewhere with this?"

She stood, shrugging. "Just trying to figure out where your relationship is," she explained. Bow gulped.

"'Relationship?'" Entrapta echoed, her eyes widening like Bow's. "Well, ahh, I suppose every human interaction can be described as a 'relationship,' ha ha." She and Bow looked at each other.

Catra glanced at her claws. "So, you're more like me and Adora?" Glimmer's grin broadened.

"Actually, I've been meaning to ask," Entrapta replied, relaxing, "what *is* your relationship with Adora?" Catra blinked. *Deflection fields up,* Glimmer smirked to herself. *Prepare to bypass.*

She teleported right next to Catra, covered in a white sheet billowing in the breeze. Glimmer's magic glowed within, giving her disguise (she thought) an eerie light. "BOO!"

Catra screamed and leaped backwards, tripping over one of Entrapta's tails. While the magicat tumbled back, Entrapta yelped and stumbled into Bow, resulting in her falling on him.

Lips first.

That couldn't have gone better if I'd tried! Glimmer cheered to herself. Out loud, she was too busy laughing to cheer, peeling off the "disguise" while shaking her head at Catra. "Oh, wow, Catra, you should see the look on your face!"

"sh," Catra whispered, eyes going from slits of fury to adorably wide. Glimmer turned, clamping both hands over her mouth at the sight of a bright-red Entrapta and a frozen Bow.

With a yelp, Entrapta leaped away, both tails serving as springs. "I'm sorry I'm sorry I'm sorry!" she wailed, waving her hands wildly in the air. "I am aware that you do not want to engage in such activity with me–"

"It's okay!" Bow insisted, waving her down in a similar manner. "Wait, you thought I didn't want to – with you?"

Entrapta's eyes went even wider, if that was possible. "...you do?" she whispered. "That is, you are interested in amorous experimentation, with me?"

Bow's smile was sheepish as he rubbed the back of his neck. "I'm not sure I would've put it *quite* like that, but...yeah?" he replied.

Entrapta leaped over and kissed him again, on purpose this time.

Glimmer teleported with Catra in mid-squee. "It worked!" Glimmer cheered. Catra turned, halfway between glee at success and disappointment at not watching.

Adora peeked around a tree, Swift Wind's head over her shoulder. "What worked?" she asked. The princess and magicat looked at each other and laughed. Adora sighed. "No one ever tells me anything," she sighed.

-SR- -SR- SR-

Vultak watched, worried, as Shadow Weaver gasped for breath. “Etheria's atmosphere has proved to be a complicating variable in my experiments,” Hordak said with that casual menace Vultak so admired. “I have just removed that variable.” Weaver grasped the air, wordless. Scorpia watched silently. “The Horde exists to civilize barbarians and end their foolish practices,” he explained. She dropped to her hand and knees. “The worship of royalty. Superstitious ignorance. *The abuse of children.”* He crouched to face her. “Do you understand, Shadow Weaver?” She nodded, limbs trembling.

“My lord, I am certain she can still be useful,” Vultak noted. Quickly.

Hordak glared at him. Vultak gulped. Their master stood and turned off the atmosphere filter. Shadow Weaver took in a shuddering, desperate breath. “Ruthless efficiency,” Hordak noted. “The Horde has no place for sentimentality, but neither does it have room for pointless sadism. Is that *clear,* Shadow Weaver?” She nodded. “Good. Get out.”

Vultak frowned as Shadow Weaver slunk out, and the Scorpioni princess indulged in a tiny smile. *Well. That is going to be a problem.*

Chapter End Notes

> A bit of light-hearted fun before things get heavy again. Plus, I really like Bowtrapta. They're cute. :-D
>
> Dylamug and Callix are two more super-minor Horde characters from the 80s. (Seriously, why didn't Scorpia have a squad?)

Left in the Cold

Chapter Summary

> In which Catra defends a Rebellion arctic expedition, and finds that "own worst enemy" situation of hers made literal.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora stared out into the beautiful northern sky, auroras playing above them like ribbons of light. When Catra came out of the shelter to stand beside her, Adora's smile felt warmer than all their coats. "Thinking?" Adora asked.

Catra smirked. "Someone has to," she quipped. Adora chuckled. "Honestly," Catra admitted, "I just wondered what you were looking at."

"The sky," Adora explained, pointing at the auroras. Catra huffed and snuggled closer, holding back the cold. "Catra? Have you thought about what we'll do after the war?"

"Hey, don't get ahead of yourself," Catra grumbled, ears flattening. "We haven't won yet."

"I know, but – if we win," Adora insisted, an arm around her precious friend's shoulders. "What happens to us? We're soldiers. What are we without something to fight?"

Catra shook her head. "Are you kidding? There's a million things to do afterwards. I knew the Horde was evil, but I had no idea the damage we were doing to Etheria. There's whole kingdoms to patch up, institutions to rebuild, trade to restore...it'll take longer to fix things than it took Hordak to break them, and he showed up before we were born."

Adora giggled. Catra stared at her, eyes narrowed. "Sorry. It's just, look at you, being all responsible." Catra snorted and thumped Adora's thigh with her tail. "Seriously, Catra. When we're free, what do you want to do?"

"Huh." Catra scratched her hair with her free hand. "Honestly? This." It was Adora's turn to stare, and she had to make an effort not to let her jaw drop. "Exploring Etheria, helping you and Entrapta figure out First Ones stuff, finding whatever's left of the magicats – having real adventures, not just surviving Shadow Weaver and Hordak." She chuckled and turned their snuggle into a one-armed hug. "Y'know, if I was still with the Horde, I'd hate it up here."

Adora blinked. "Really?" she asked. *Why?*

"I'd be all, 'get the tech and go home,' mission-oriented, gotta prove myself," Catra explained. She rested her head on Adora's shoulder, and the blonde thought her heart would explode from how it pounded. "With you, Sparkles, E.T., the Rebellion…I can just be myself. I never thought I could, before." She smiled, and Adora's heart pounded twice as hard. "Bast, I didn't know I had a self to *be.* I...thank you, Adora," she whispered. "Thank you for not giving up on me."

"Thank you for giving me another chance," Adora replied, resting her head on Catra's. "It was so awful, being enemies. I knew I'd messed up, but I didn't know how. I..."

...want to say so much but I don't have words I don't even understand what I'm feeling I want to be with you every moment this is everything I want from life if there were no Horde I'd follow you into every adventure you could find I want us to grow old together…

"...am so grateful for you," she settled on, "being in my life, here with me." She swallowed. "I still don't feel like I deserve you, sometimes."

Catra tensed, then laughed. *Did I mess up again?* Adora panicked. "Oh, Adora," Catra sighed, "no one deserves me. I'm just lucky you have awful taste in friends."

Oh, HECK no. Adora whirled to face Catra, grabbing her by the shoulders. "Don't even joke about that," she insisted.

Catra stared back, eyes wide. "Adora?"

"Never again," Adora grunted. "You are–"

Catra's ear flicked, and she cocked her head. "Sh," she ordered, and Adora stopped. "Horde ship. Play time's over." Adora bit back a growl. *I'd be mad they interrupted, but now I have something to hit.*

-SR- -SR- SR-

Catra groaned and shook her head, staggering back to her feet.

"Whoa!" Scorpia chuckled, looking over the bots scattered by her new powers. "Boy, that's got a kick, doesn't it?"

She looked around, hoping for signs of the Best Friends Squad, Kyle, even Sea Hawk at this point.

"Adora! You're on Snaps! I'll handle Shadow Weaver," Catra ordered, leaping past red lightning – nothing she wasn't used to. She had to stop the witch before the Horde pulled out another deadly trick.

The field was quiet, the only sounds of battle in the distance behind her.

"You will handle nothing, *beast," Shadow Weaver mocked, gathering power for another spell. "Now, you will face what you fear most!" It had something to do with time, but beyond that, it was too complicated for Catra to make out, and then it reached inside her, and–*

Catra ran towards the fight, heart pounding when she heard Adora screaming with distorted fury. "I know you're still in there, Adora. You've got to snap out of it!" Glimmer pleaded, and Catra leaped over a ridge to find She-Ra slashing at *Sparkles.* "Let go of the sword," Glimmer blurted, only to earn another slash.

"Adora!" Catra cried, leaping into the fight. She-Ra was covered in angry red veins, her eyes stained the same color. *Shadow Weaver,* Catra thought, drawing a counter-magic circle and casting it at Adora.

It worked for a moment, the blue light returning to her friend's eyes. "Catra?" Adora whispered, sounding stunned. Then the red came back, and She-Ra attacked with a growl. *Good thing she's telegraphing like crazy,* Catra decided, leaping out of the way.

"You can do *magic now?"* Sparkles blurted. Catra stopped to stare at her, and that nearly killed her when Adora swung for her head. Fortunately, She-Ra was still easy to read, and Catra ducked with an instant to spare. "Ugh, never mind, just destroy the crystal!"

"What crystal?" Catra demanded, leaping to Glimmer's side. "And we went to Mystacor together! Do you have brain damage?" She looked over an incredulous Sparkles. "Please don't have brain damage."

Glimmer *glared* at her. "You're horrible!" she howled, hitting Catra with a blazing fist.

The blow threw Catra back several feet, leaving her with an impressive bruise, newfound respect for Sparkles' magic, and a fractured heart. *Ow. What?* She stared at the princess, hand over her wounded cheek, eyes wide at the sight of her furious...friend? "Glimmer?" she breathed. *No, she can't – this can't – they said – Adora* promised *– why? Why do I always believe –*

"Look out!" Bow warned, hitting Adora with a net arrow. Catra had been so devastated, she'd lost track of She-Ra. *That almost got me killed,* Catra realized, though she was still working up the

energy to care. “Catra, do you have a red crystal, like a three-pointed star?” he asked while Sea Hawk rushed over.

“No!” Catra objected, whirling on the gentle archer. “Why would I have some evil Shadow Weaver thing?”

“It’s not from Shadow Weaver!” another Catra howled, leaping up from behind a snowbank.

The two Catras stared at each other, one in shock, the other in concern. “Oops,” Catra-2 blurted. “See ya, impostor!” she added, rushing away. Scorpia and Entrapta yelped, jumped out and followed her.

Catra glared. *“Oh,”* she snarled. “Stay here, Sparkles. I have a post to scratch.” Catra crouched to leap–

–but Adora beat her to it, tearing out of the net and bounding toward them with an echoing roar. Glimmer teleported away while Catra backflipped, leaving She-Ra pulling her sword out of the ice. “Right, priorities,” she muttered. “Don’t know how long I’ve been gone, other Catra’s a fake, I got Entrapta out of the Fright Zone, how do we save Adora?”

“Entrapta never left the Fright Zone,” Bow gasped, staring. He and Sea Hawk held up the exhausted Glimmer.

Before Catra could process *that,* She-Ra pulled the sword out of the ice with her most inhuman scream yet. The entire glacier cracked and buckled under them. *They’re panicking,* Catra realized, leaping towards the three Rebels as they fell. She grabbed Sea Hawk first, throwing him towards the ridge, then did the same with Bow. By the time she reached Glimmer, though, they were out of range, so Catra grabbed her wrist and used her claws as a brake.

Ow. Catra’s fingers grumbled in protest, but she held. “Hey, Glimmer. Can you teleport yourself up?”

"I – why are you helping us?" Glimmer asked, staring with wide, stunned eyes.

Catra gritted her teeth and dug her foot-claws into the ice. "I *thought* you were my friend," she snarled, unable to contain the hurt screaming through her. "Just hold on."

Glimmer took a deep breath. "Okay. I don't know why you think that, but you just saved us, so, thanks, and I think I can get myself up there." Catra nodded, and Glimmer vanished. *Fine.* She raced up the ice, reaching the trio in moments.

"...idea what is going on?" Sea Hawk was asking when Catra reached them. He yelped and recoiled before he realized she was the Rebel Catra.

Bow frowned and tapped his pad. "I'm not sure, but the good Catra is definitely an anomaly of some kind. My tracker is getting some weird readings from her."

"So, wait," Catra replied, frowning, "are you saying I don't belong here?" She rubbed her forehead. "That spell Shadow Weaver hit me with did have some kind of time element, but I couldn't make it out. It was way too advanced."

"Oh!" Bow smiled. "You must be from an alternate timeline."

Catra and the local Rebels all stared at him. "A what now?" Catra asked.

"You joined the Rebellion a while ago, right?" Bow explained. Catra nodded. "Well, our Catra...didn't. She kidnapped us, attacked Bright Moon, and conquered half the world."

"I, um, did kind of kidnap–" Catra froze. "You're losing the war," she whispered, eyes wide. "I never stopped being horrible, and now I'm giving Hordak Etheria."

Glimmer pout-glared. "We're not *losing,"* she insisted. "We've just had some setbacks, that's all."

"Yes! Setbacks," Sea Hawk agreed. "A mere several dozen, give or take." Glimmer turned her pout-glare on him.

Catra's already-scrambled collection of thoughts settled on another crisis. "Wait. 'Face what you fear most.' If you're not my Glimmer and Bow and Sea Hawk, then they're – still fighting Shadow Weaver," she gasped. *I need to counter this thing, now!* Catra worried, weaving a circle to dispel whatever Shadow Weaver had done. "I have to get back to my Rebellion. I'll try to come back, but I don't know how this magic works."

"We'll be fine," Bow insisted. Catra couldn't stop a wan smile at that.

Her countermagic circle kicked in, and the world turned into a whirling rainbow blur. When reality settled back in, she found herself watching the battle she'd left from a distance. She-Ra fought Scorpia and Callix single-handed, holding her own with both even against Scorpia's red lightning. *"Where's Catra?"* Adora screamed, a burst from the Sword driving back the Force Captain while she threw the rock-man aside with her free hand.

Catra grinned and tapped her comm. "Hey, Adora," she drawled, sounding as casual as she could while racing to the shelter. The Rebel combatants cheered and pressed their assault. "Entrapta, did you bring a red crystal that makes Adora go nuts?"

"Oh, yes," Entrapta replied, "it functions by inserting a First Ones virus into technical systems."

"I had to pack the blankets," Kyle added with a sigh.

Catra's smile sharpened. "Aren't Runestones First Ones tech?"

-SR- -SR- SR-

Saying that Adora had calmed down would be an overstatement the size of Hordak's ego, but at least now she wasn't threatening to shatter the glacier around them. *Focus, I have to focus,* she told herself, body-checking Scorpia into a snowbank, then glaring

at Shadow Weaver. “It’s over,” Adora insisted, firing a blast at Dylamug. The cyborg dodged with a squawk, then returned fire. She blocked it with her shield, then remade the Sword and pointed it at the sorceress. “Wherever you sent Catra, she escaped.”

“And she’s probably doing something clever now,” Scorpia muttered, unleashing another wave of red lightning at Glimmer. The earth shuddered even as the princess teleport-dodged.

“Perrhaps,” Shadow Weaver retorted, “but I wonder just how *much* of Catra returned.”

Before Adora could panic at that, Catra leaped onto Scorpia’s head, then launched herself at their ‘mother’ claws-first. “Heads up, Snaps,” she quipped, darting at Shadow Weaver. A red crystal glinted in Catra’s hand –

– a *familiar* red crystal –

– but before Adora could react, Catra slapped the device against Shadow Weaver’s mask. “You know,” Catra began.

Shadow Weaver screamed before Catra could finish. Arms made of darkness boiled out of the sorceress, all marked by red veins of corruption. “Catra, what did you do?” Adora gasped.

“Hey, I didn’t expect this,” Catra admitted, shaken despite her effort to sound casual. Sea Hawk and Lonnie froze mid-duel, saber locked against staff, both staring. Catra started drawing a magic circle. “Okay, here’s the deal. You’re going to swear on your power as a sorceress to leave and not come back for at least a day.”

Shadow Weaver’s screaming got louder and more shrill. Eyes joined the hands – at least, Adora *thought* the crimson orbs covered in black crosses were eyes – bubbling out from her robes to stare at Shadow Weaver. “Catra, I don’t think she can,” Adora gasped.

Catra stared, eyes wide. “I...this isn’t…”

“I promise!” Scorpia cried, rushing over to Shadow Weaver. Catra froze, tail sticking out with fur flared. “We’ll go, just fix this, please!”

Catra grimaced and pressed two claws against the crystal, breaking it into three pieces. The arms and eyes vanished, and Shadow Weaver gulped in a shuddering breath. They glared at one another, magic gathering in Shadow Weaver’s palms, but Scorpia grabbed the sorceress and fled towards their ship before the battle could resume. Scorpia’s squad hesitated for a moment, then followed. Lonnie glared at Adora as they retreated.

“Huh. It worked.” Catra sighed. “Bow, lock down that crystal, okay? I need to go back.” She started drawing another magic circle.

Adora felt her friend lighten, as if part of her was going somewhere else. “Back? Back where?” She-Ra asked, putting a hand on Catra’s shoulder.

“Adora, don’t –” Catra blurted, but everything turned into a spinning rainbow blur. When the world reappeared, there was a giant metal bug roaring over their heads, its eyes glowing the red of the crystal. “Gah! Turn off She-Ra!”

Adora obeyed, recognizing the corruption in the monster even as Catra’s warning registered. “What’s going on? Where are we?” she asked as they ran from the monster, towards the shelter.

“Their Bow called this an ‘alternate timeline.’ Here...” Catra trailed off, looking away. “Their Rebellion is losing the war.”

What? Adora’s mind whirled. “How? Why?”

“Don’t wanna talk about it,” she muttered as they reached the door. Catra slapped the control.

It opened to reveal Scorpia holding *Adora,* except the other Adora was laughing and limp in the Force Captain’s arms. “Whoo!” Adora-2 cheered. “Check out that other me!”

Scorpia's eyes widened at the sight of them. "Catra? Oh, no, you're that Rebellion Catra, aren't you?" she gasped.

Catra slapped her forehead. "Adora, protect – yourself. I've got something to do." She turns to head down the remaining corridor.

Adora blinked, confused. *Do what?* she wondered. Scorpia gasped. "Please don't hurt her!" she pleaded.

At that, Catra paused. "I'll make it quick," she replied, then darted away.

"No!" Scorpia cried, throwing Adora-2 at Adora, then braced herself to run.

The outer door opened again, revealing Sea Hawk looking stoic and determined. It lasted one second before he gasped and pulled off his goggles. "Inspector Pirate?" Scorpia asked, frozen.

"Adora!" Sea Hawk breathed, smiling. "I'm here to...rescue...you?"

"She's – they're fine, we've got to rescue Catra!" Scorpia blurted.

"From who?" Adora-1 asked. Adora-2 giggled.

"Catra!" Scorpia yelped, then raced after Catra-1.

Adora-1 gasped. "Sea Hawk! Take, um, me!" she said, handing the confused pirate her loopy counterpart, then rushing after Scorpia. *Please don't do anything crazy, Catra,* Adora prayed.

-SR- -SR- SR-

Catra-1 crawled over pipes and conduits as she followed her counterpart. Catra-2 held the Sword, red corruption veins spreading from its Runestone. She pointed it around as clashing noises echoed around them. "I really hate this place," she muttered, retreating. *I know the feeling,* Catra-1 raged, flexing her claws. Lights flickered around them while Catra-2 rushed through the door. "What's happening?" Catra-2 asked Entrapta.

Catra-1 darted through the closing door and slashed at her counterpart. The Horde commander screamed and leaped away, her coat blunting Catra-1's claws enough that the attack only left faint red lines. However, Entrapta's disc fell out, sliding to Catra-1's feet. "Let's see," Catra-1 replied, stopping the disc with her boot. "You're losing to the Rebellion, again. There's a bunch of crazy giant bugs. Your Adora's safe with mine." She pocketed the crystal, then crouched with a mad smile, filling her claws with glowing magic. "And oh yeah, I'm going to *rip your head off."*

"And the bugs are obsessively trying to destroy us," Entrapta added, spinning in place. "What an unexpected twist!"

Glimmer and Bow teleported in, eyes closed and hugging each other in terror. "Oh, *come on!"* Catra-2 complained. The pair opened their eyes, spotted the Horde Catra, and leaped back with twin cries.

Catra-1's grin widened. "Hey, Sparkles," she called, pulling out the disc and tossing it to Glimmer. She bobbled it for a moment, then caught it. "Destroy it as soon as I'm done destroying her."

"What?" Bow blurted. "Why?"

"Because Adora will try to stop me," Catra-1 explained, then leaped towards her counterpart with a yowl.

Everything seemed to happen at once. Scorpia rushed through the door, Adora-1 on her heels. One of the bugs crashed through the ceiling with a roar. "Oh, *come on!"* Catra-1 snapped, slapping her forehead.

"I'm sorry, Good Catra," Glimmer said, "but we don't have time!" She braced the crystal between her hands and twisted. Catra-2 screamed in fury.

"Yeah, I know," Catra-1 agreed, just as Sparkles snapped the disc in two. "I'll manage somehow." The bugs roared and retreated.

“I’m sorry, Rebel Catra,” Scorpia cried, darting between the magicats, “but I won’t let you do it!"

“We still have the Sword, so it’s time to go!” Catra-2 added, leaping up among the boxes. “Entrapta, get the skiff, we’re leaving.”

Catra-1 laughed. They all stared, except for Glimmer, who rushed to her side. “Oh, Catra. Mean, dumb Catra. You’re not going *anywhere!”* She drew a flare circle and set it off in Scorpia’s face. “Sparkles, cover me!”

“Got it!” Glimmer agreed, and the princess circled Scorpia while Catra-1 leaped around her.

Adora-1 rushed towards her. “Catra, no!” she begged. “You can help her! If anyone understands her, it’s you!”

“You’re right, Adora, I *do* understand her. She’s a monster!” Adora-1 gasped. “She left you in the Castle,” Catra-1 explained, rushing at Catra-2, who leaped and dodged a bolt of magic fire. “There’s nothing left to help!”

“Look who’s talking,” Catra-2 snapped back, swinging the Sword at another spell. The blade shattered the magic. Catra-1 stared in disbelief while Catra-2 laughed. “Nice. I’ve got the Sword, I’m Hordak’s second in command, *and* I put Shadow Weaver in a cell! What do you have? Adora? Do you like being her *pet?”*

“I’m her *friend!”* Catra-1 howled, risking a new spell. She spun the circle to life, then stuck her left hand into it. Her claws glowed with fierce blue light, slashing through a metal box with ease. “I’m the Rebellion’s special forces commander, I have people who care about me, and Queen Angella was more of a mother in one *day* than Shadow Weaver was our whole lives!” She leaped at Catra-2, who deflected the assault with the Sword, then jumped away again. Adora-1 could barely keep up, while Glimmer and Scorpia still fought. “But you’d rather let your anger tear down everything, *wouldn’t you?”*

“She doesn’t love you!” Catra-2 snarled, dodging backwards. Catra-1 froze, and her counterpart laughed. “Wow, you’re even more pathetic than I thought. You still think you’ll matter more to her than her stupid princess destiny.”

Catra-1 glared. “Light Hope made her choose between us. My Adora chose *me.”* Catra-2’s smirk vanished and her eyes flew wide, shining with unshed tears. “She doesn’t love us the *exact* way we love her, but Adora still cares. That’s enough for me, but nothing will ever be enough for you. Will it?”

“Wait,” Adora-1 breathed, reaching Catra-1 at last. “Catra, what do you mean?”

“No,” Catra-2 gasped, trembling. “You’re lying. She wouldn’t. Adora would *never* choose me. She never did!”

“Catra,” Adora-2 whispered, coming through the door’s remains. “That’s not – I had to choose between you and the *whole world.”*

“No, you didn’t,” Adora-1 snapped, glaring at her stunned, wide-eyed counterpart. “All you had to do was choose between her and *Shadow Weaver.”*

“Whoa!” Catra-1 yelped, leaping in front of her Adora. “Hey, take it easy, she played you.”

“Which she wouldn’t have if I’d just had *faith* in you,” Adora-1 retorted, her tone more bitter than Catra had ever heard. “I don’t blame you for thinking I don’t love you.” Catra-1 shuddered, impossible hope returning to life within her. *What?*

Catra-2’s laugh was jagged shards. “‘Love?’ You don’t know what that word means.” She crouched and glared at Adora-1. “Love is sharing your ration bar when you’ve been on half rations for three days.”

“Shut up,” Catra-1 hissed. *Stop it.*

Catra-2 ignored her. "Love is getting caught on purpose so your 'friend' doesn't ruin her perfect record. *Love* is staying in *Hell* because you promised to always look out for each other!" Both Adoras had gone almost as pale as the snow, eyes wide with horror. "It's not abandoning all your 'love's' sacrifices for a bunch of *strangers!"*

"Shut up shut up *shut up!"* Catra-1 screamed, leaping at Catra-2 with glowing claws.

"No!" Adora-2 cried, jumping between them, arms outstretched.

The *déjà vu* of the moment, so much like Adora standing between Catra and Shadow Weaver, stopped Catra-1 as completely as Adora-2 herself. Catra-1 retracted her claws and curled up, twisting in the air so she glanced off Adora's arm rather than hurting her. Catra-2 leaped back, Sword still at the ready. "Still pretending you're saving me, Adora?" she snarled.

"I'm not pretending!" Adora-2 sobbed, turning so she could see them both. "I want to help you, Catra!"

"Why? Don't you have enough sparkly friends to play hero with?" Catra-2 retorted. Catra-1 circled on all fours, looking for an opening.

"You're *my* hero," Adora-1 breathed. Catra-2 froze, tail lashing.

Some light of recognition lit in Adora-2's eyes. "She's right, Catra. You saved me dozens of times! Why can't I save you, just *once?"* Adora-2 begged.

Catra-1 laughed, mad and broken. "Oh, Adora. You never change."

Both Adoras looked at Catra-1 with horror. Glimmer stared, swallowing. "Catra?" Adora-2 whispered.

"You can't save her. She tries so hard to hate you," Catra-1 explained, "but she'll never hate anyone as much as she hates herself." Her jagged smile made her counterpart recoil. Adora-1's

sob was only audible to magicat ears. "She'll conquer the world trying to bury that hate. It won't work, but she'll destroy everything in her way, unless I stop her *now."*

Bow rushed in, Scorpia on his heels. "Or," Bow offered, looking from the wild-eyed Catra-1 to the shaken Catra-2 and back, "we could try talking? Maybe tell us how you ended up in the Rebellion. That seems important."

Catra-1's claws twitched. *Even Sparkles isn't with me, now,* she realized. With sigh, she retracted her claws. "Fine. It's not going to work, though."

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It worked.

Mostly. "You're friends with *Hordak?"* Adora-1 blurted. *This is not happening,* she thought.

Entrapta grinned and nodded. "Lab partners!" she cheered. *Well, at least this world's Best Friends Squad looks as freaked out as I feel,* Adora-1 decided. Catra-2 was sitting to the side, tail lashing, arms crossed, and looking away. Adora-2 and Scorpia were sharing a look Adora-1 couldn't read. "He doesn't really seem interested in this whole conquest thing, you know. There are other planets out there somewhere, and he wants to get back to them! I think."

"You *think,"* Bow muttered, frowning.

"Look," Catra-2 snapped, "I can't let Entrapta go back to the Fright Zone by herself, but I'll leave once she's – settled." She glared at Adora-2. "I'm not joining the Rebellion, though." Adora-2 smiled. "I'm *not!"*

"What about you, Snaps?" Catra-1 asked, leaning against some boxes.

Scorpia smiled. “I’m going with Catra, duh.” She chuckled and rubbed the back of her neck. “I mean, our Catra.”

Catra-1 sighed. “Yeah. That’s...good. Look, you three have a chance to end the war here. I pulled our Entrapta out before she made friends with Hordak. If you can get him to stop, you know, trying to invade everybody, maybe things can work out here.” She probed her ribs with glowing fingertips. “Look, Shadow Weaver’s spell is wearing off. I gotta go. Try to be good, okay?”

“What are you, my mother?” Catra-2 mocked, rolling her eyes.

Catra-1 glared at her. “I’m the sorceress who will come back here and kick your tail if you don’t. Come on, Adora.”

Adora-1 put her hand on Catra’s shoulder. “Take care of each other, okay?” Adora-1 said. Adora-2 smiled and nodded. Whirling colors swallowed the world again.

When the light faded, they were back with their friends, if the cheer Glimmer and Bow let loose was any indication. Adora took a breath in relief, then turned Catra to face her. “Now, tell me what you mean about us not loving each other the same way.” Glimmer gasped and clamped a hand over Bow’s mouth.

Catra groaned and held her head, eyes closed. “Gah, how do I even explain this?” Glimmer gulped, and Bow put his hand over her mouth. “Thanks. Listen, Adora, have you ever wanted to kiss someone?”

Adora felt flushed and warm. So warm. And tingly. *Oh.* She gulped. “Oh.” Her eyes went wide. *OH!* She grabbed Catra’s other shoulder, and the magicat’s eyes went as wide as hers. “Is that what you meant, Catra? Is that what you want, with me?”

“Don’t do this to me, Adora,” Catra whispered. “I can’t – I can’t *do* this again, wanting you, knowing you’ll never–”

Adora kissed her.

Some distant corner of Adora's mind noted Glimmer and Bow cheering through each others' hands. Another worried that she had never kissed before, and *oh stars I must be doing this badly Catra won't want to…*

The rest realized that this was the moment her entire life had been leading up to, and never wanted it to end.

Both those tiny corners vanished when Catra started kissing her back, and it was *amazing,* and those disused sections of thought process turned to wondering how the girl she loved had gotten good at kissing. The rest of Adora agreed with her original assessment.

Unfortunately, spending an eternity kissing wasn't practical. Sooner or later, they were going to have to fight the Horde. Or eat. Or breathe. *Oh, yeah, that,* Adora realized, and her lungs forced her to break off the kiss, gasping for air. Catra's eyes sparkled. "Hey, Adora. Did I leave you breathless?" Her laughter was paradise.

Glimmer and Bow gave up, let each other go, and cheered. Adora didn't mind. At all.

-SR- -SR- SR-

"The energy that Shadow Weaver took advantage of is a state of quantum entanglement," Light Hope explained. "My systems use quantum computing to permit certain system functions to transcend time and space. That is why this dimension, Despondos, is so effective a trap. There is nothing here, now, except Etheria."

"Uh, can you translate that for the rest of us?" Catra asked, sighing, while Entrapta's eyes sparkled.

"You, Catra, have a connection to versions of yourself in other timelines where I did not intervene." Light Hope flickered. "A single fluctuation allowed me to guide Adora to your aid. That is why the other Catra did not respond to her Adora." Adora's hand

tightened around Catra's. "However, the variable that made this possible was unintended. In spite of Princess Entrapta's assistance in liberating my consciousness, existing systems work to correct what they mistakenly perceive as an error."

"Oh." Catra grimaced. *Not even four words. A system failure saved me. A mistake.* She shook her head. "So this could happen again?"

"Yes, but that is not the immediate concern." Light Hope turned to Glimmer. "Scorpia's connection to the Black Garnet has presented another complication. The Heart of Etheria is...unstable."

"What?" they all blurted. Kyle swayed in place.

"If all five Runestones are fully attuned to their Princesses, the Heart will activate, potentially destroying all sentient life on Etheria." Catra's fur stood on end while the humans paled. "Fortunately, I can resist this command while at least one Runestone is attuned to multiple beings. You, Princess Glimmer, share the Moonstone with your mother, and Scorpia's connection to the Garnet is weakened by the parasite that feeds on it."

"Shadow Weaver," Catra and Adora snarled as one.

"Ugh," Glimmer groaned. "So we have to *let* Shadow Weaver hold onto the Black Garnet?"

"Worse," Catra replied. "We have to warn the Horde about it."

"Hey, at least now we know," Adora insisted. Then she smiled at Catra, and the magicat thought her heart might explode. "Besides, something good came out of all this, right?"

Before she could stop herself, Catra's tail curled around Adora's wrist. "Yeah," she agreed, smiling back. "Something good."

Chapter End Notes

So I made a note about how long it took to post the last chapter ha ha I'm such a kidder. No, THIS one took forever. In my defense, I had a paying writing gig, and if you've been enjoying this fic so far and/or you're here for the sweet, sweet Catradora, you now know why this chapter was so important.

I'm going to try to get the next one out sooner, but I can promise nothing.

Beast Island

Chapter Summary

> Catra says "thank you" to the Rebellion in the most overcompensating way possible. Adora learns an awful truth.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Angella stopped, staring at the magicat examining the mural of her husband as though looking for a secret entrance. "Are you all right, Catra?"

Catra froze, then turned, faced Angella, gulped and saluted. "Yes, ma'am!" She glanced at the mural, then back at the queen, grinning and backing away. "Just leaving."

"That's not necessary," Angella replied, her voice as gentle as she could manage. *How can one so brave be so afraid of me?* "If you could indulge my curiosity, however, what brought you here?"

Catra thought for a moment, then shrugged. "Glimmer's probably told you about me and Adora." Angella's smile was slight, but kind. "Yeah. We don't have a lot of...context, for what we're going through."

Angella's kind smile broadened. "Ah," she replied, understanding Catra's curiosity. "I am not certain anyone ever has 'context' for their first love. If you seek advice, mine is simple. Embrace what you have."

"Even though…" Catra whispered, turning her gaze back on Micah.

Oh. With as much care as she could muster, Angella put a gentle hand on Catra's shoulder. For the first time, the magicat didn't flinch. "Yes. Even though."

Catra nodded, turned, and walked three steps away. Then she rushed back, hugged Angella for about a second and a half, then ran off as though Hordak were chasing her. Once she was gone, Angella chuckled and sighed. *I wanted to be a mother,* she thought.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Three weeks later.

Catra couldn't help a grin at Entrapta's mad science lab. Somehow, she had melded her Dryl throne room and Fright Zone "prison" into a miniature realm of lightning coils and robot parts, right under Brightmoon Castle. Adora, meanwhile, stared at the tiny robot assembly line in amazement. "The spy drones you requested are working surprisingly well," Entrapta explained, three of the six screens on the wall showing different parts of the Fright Zone. Two others showed Plumeria and Salineas, while the last raced across the sea.

"Why surprising?" Catra asked.

Adora leaned in. "Where's the Snow Kingdom?" she asked at the same time.

"The Snow Kingdom asked us not to monitor them, and I expected the curvature of Etheria to create more interference," Entrapta replied, smiling as she adjusted the feeds. "The oceanic drone appears to have detected an anomaly! Fascinating."

Catra leaned in beside Adora. The blonde's breath caught for a moment. Catra forced herself not to smile. *Mine,* she thought for an instant, possessiveness overwhelming her before she crushed it beneath a mental heel. "What kind of anomaly?" Catra asked.

"Some kind of First Ones signal, but this one doesn't match any previous message." Entrapta turned some dials and tapped commands into her system. "It's so exciting!" The seagoing drone found an island, and while the princesses and magicat watched, the machine made landfall.

The drone soon found itself dodging one-eyed pack hunters, murderous black vines, and giant serpents. The trees were covered in lights, and machines littered the ground in every direction. A giant robot bug chased the drone through the woods. "Where..." Adora breathed.

"Beast Island," Catra whispered. Then, as they watched, a blurry human figure leaped out, Cloaked, wielding a violet staff, he restrained the giant beetle-thing with a rope made of magic, then drew a three-ringed circle and used it to fire a massive, vibrating blast at it.

The bug fled, but the drone began to spark. The man approached as the video began to blur. He drew back his cloak –

– and Catra gasped as a man she would have *sworn* matched the queen's mural stared at them. "Hello?" the sorcerer asked more than said. "Are you real, or–"

The feed died.

"Catra?" Adora turned to look at her. "Did you recognize him?"

"I–" Catra swallowed. "I think that was King Micah.

Adora gaped. *"What?"*

Entrapta's smile widened. "Faaascinating."

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"Okay, I know I can be a little dense sometimes," Adora said, trying to be patient as she followed Catra to the stables, "but why are we not telling Glimmer or the queen, again?

Catra sighed. "One, Angella might order us not to go, to keep us safe, and that would break her. Two, if I'm wrong, they'll be disappointed if it's not him. Three, if he dies before we get there, they'll be devastated." She glared at Adora's frown. "I'm the

Rebellion's Special Forces Commander, Adora. I have the authority to put together a rescue mission."

Adora swallowed. *I used to be so glad Catra's a hero now,* she thought. "Okay, you're worried, but we should trust them," she replied. "Angella's survived so much, and Glimmer's strong."

Catra stopped and whirled on Adora, eyes flashing. Adora froze. "Every time the Princesses lose someone important to them, they *fall apart,"* she snapped. "First Micah, then Entrapta. I am *not* letting that happen again. Not on my watch." Catra turned and continued marching towards the stables. "I do this alone, in and out, quick and simple."

"I'm still not – wait, *alone?"* Adora leaped from concern straight past worry to full-blown panic. "No. No, no, *no,* I am going with you, end of discussion!"

Catra stopped and spun to glare at Adora again. "Why? Because you *promised?* You're a little late, Adora, promise broken, 'end of discussion,' She-Ra is not expendable."

Having Catra as an enemy had been less painful than this moment. "NEITHER ARE YOU!" Adora screamed, grabbing Catra by the collar. "I promised I'd make things right! I haven't broken that one, have I?" Catra froze, eyes wide. "I can't lose you again. Please, Catra, I thought we were in this together, especially after – we..."

Adora kissed her.

Catra whimpered for a moment, then pulled Adora in to kiss her back, then pushed her away. *Emotional whiplash,* Adora thought. "You big, dumb – you know where that was, right? When Princess tales and magic paralysis weren't scary enough, Shadow Weaver told Beast Island stories. I can't let you go there." She touched her lips. "And that was cheating."

"That means I'm doing it right." Adora smirked. "You taught me that." Catra slapped her forehead and groaned. "I look out for

you. You look out for me. I'm never leaving you behind again."

"That's really sweet," Bow replied, and both women jumped, "but if you're trying to sneak out of the castle, you should probably shout less."

Catra's eyes widened even more. "You're not coming," she blurted.

Bow shrugged. "Okay." Catra blinked. "I guess I should go find Glimmer, then." He started to turn.

"Stop!" Catra cried. Bow stopped and grinned. "Urgh. I should've stayed with the Horde."

Bow's grin broadened, smothering Adora's impulse to panic again. "We have better food," he pointed out.

Catra sighed. "True," she admitted. Adora grinned as well. *We'll be together. That means nothing really bad can happen.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra's mind raced to keep track of the many horrible ways Beast Island could devour them all. *This was a bad idea,* she decided, turning a brief look on Sea Hawk and Swift Wind. The two were singing shanties together while the "pirate" did something with the sail. *This was a* terrible *idea.*

Bow stood near the front – *the prow, right?* Catra wondered – his stance a mix of vigilance and posing for Sea Hawk. Fortunately, he was paying attention, watching the fog as though he understood how dangerous it was. As for Adora...

Adora blushed and turned away the moment Catra caught the blonde staring at her. Catra smirked. "Hey, Adora," she drawled, slinking over to her girlfriend. It took all her willpower to maintain her cool facade as Adora's blush deepened and her eyes widened. "What's on your mind?"

Adora grimaced, and Catra's smirk vanished. "I can't believe you were going to do this alone."

"Are you still on about that?" Catra groaned, facepalming. "I wanted to do this by stealth. Adora, I love you, but you're about as inconspicuous as a tank battalion."

Adora's blush deepened. "She-Ra can handle the monsters while you and Bow track down the sorcerer. We'll be fine as long as we're together."

Wild, howling fury burned through Catra before she could rein it in. If Adora's wide eyes were any indication, Catra hadn't hidden the moment. "Whatever. We're here."

That stopped the whole group cold. A jagged mountain of stone and steel emerged from the mist, smaller spears of metal glowing before them like a battlefield for giants. "This is Beast Island?" Bow whispered.

Catra huffed, tail lashing. "Bow, we're not even there yet. It's gonna get worse before it gets better. If you're not ready for that, stay on the boat with Sea Hawk and Feathers."

Sea Hawk drew himself up and smiled. Catra swore light glinted off his teeth in spite of the absent sunlight. "Well, *I'm* ready! ADVENTURE!"

"I'll be fine," Bow blurted. Sea Hawk wilted, smile vanishing. Even his mustache drooped.

"Sea Hawk, we need you here," Catra insisted, lips pressed tight. "None of this is going to matter if we don't have a way back, and that's you." She managed a wan smile for him. "Think of it as the burden of being the greatest pirate in the Rebellion."

"I'm the only pirate in the Rebellion," Sea Hawk whined. All the same, he took the ship's controls, bringing them to shore. Land didn't make things much better, the ground dead and unnatural, like a frozen moonset murdered to form a beach. They left pirate

and pegasus behind, Swift Wind waving one wing, as they delved further into the forest of machinery and glowing goop-trees.

"Do you think there are chibbits?" Adora swallowed, drawing the Sword. "Scruffers? Razorfins?"

"What are those?" Bow asked, gulping and readying his namesake.

"Razor-sharp everything," Catra snapped. "Just keep your eyes razor sharp. We go in, we rescue the sorcerer, and we leave. Keep it simple." She stalked ahead, ears twitching and eyes wide. *I have to protect them,* Catra swore to herself. *They're not used to this, having to be ready for the shadows all the time, using the fear instead of letting it use–*

The most awful sound Catra had ever heard speared through her lungs. It felt like a dozen Shadow Weavers all at once, trying to paralyze her, lie to her, tell her she was weak and pathetic and *you don't matter you'll never matter how* dare *you pretend you could mean anything you'll never be worth Adora–*

"Catra! *Catra!* What's wrong?" Adora begged, shaking her.

The waking nightmare stopped as quickly as it started. Catra shot to her feet – *When did I collapse?* she wondered – and shook her head. "I'm fine," she said. "We have to–"

"Stop it!" Adora grabbed her by the collar. "You're not fine. I know you're not fine! Please, just tell me what's wrong."

"There was a sound. Probably too low for humans to hear," Catra explained trying to brush Adora's hands away. The woman didn't move. "Adora. Let go. Now."

"No. I ignored your pain once." Catra froze, Adora's expression more grim than ever. "I made a promise. *Never again.* Please, Catra, talk to me."

Catra hadn't realized how badly she'd wanted to hear those words. All at once, the nightmare song seemed meaningless. She put her hand on Adora's wrist. "When we get back, okay?" Catra asked. "Fine or not, I can push through until we get home."

Adora perked up at the last part, and let Catra go. "You promise?" she pleaded, her voice far weaker than Catra liked.

Catra sighed. "I promise. Now – wait." Her ears twitched at a far more normal sound. "What is that? Giant bug?"

"I am so sick of giant bugs," Bow said, nocking an arrow. Catra nodded. *I feel you, Bow,* she agreed.

That was when they found the enormous metal beetle, collapsed and covered in black vines. Its eyes flickered with a dim light. "Beast," Catra muttered. It raised its head, weak and unsure.

"Maybe it won't see us," Bow hoped.

All at once, it leaped to its many feet, roared, and charged. Catra dodged, drawing a flare circle and throwing it at the monster, while Adora held the Sword high and Bow fired an electric arrow. "For the honor of Grayskull!" Adora cried.

Adora didn't change. Bow's arrow crackled, harmless, in its massive foreleg. Yet the thing recoiled in horror from Catra's simplest spell. "What in Bast's name?" the magicat muttered. She drew a larger circle, one for a firebird illusion. The beetle skittered back, trembling. "Huh. Whaddayaknow." Curious, she erased the circle.

The beetle screamed and leaped for her again. "Catra!" Adora and Bow cried. Catra merely smirked, claws out and ready to cast another spell–

–but a tall, muscular human shrouded in a cloak leaped between them, his strange staff glowing with fierce light. He fired a blast from it, driving the monster back. Then he drew a violet circle, stuck the staff in it, and created a lasso out of magic, grabbing

one of its legs and pulling it away from Catra. “Get away from her!” he howled, throwing the beetle-thing aside with a single mighty yank.

It turned and prepared for another charge, but stopped at the sight of Catra’s blue circle joining the human’s triple purple. It backed away, then fled. “Whoa,” Adora breathed.

Then the human pulled back his hood, and Catra had to force back a laugh. *It was worth it after all,* she realized, indulging in a smirk. “King Micah, I presume?”

That was when the king broke into one of the broadest smiles Catra had ever seen and hugged her. “Kyra! You’re alive!” he sobbed.

Catra froze. *Who?* she wondered. “I’m, uh, happy to meet you, Your Majesty, but my name’s Catra.”

Micah straightened in shock, letting Catra go then holding her shoulders. He stared in disbelief. *“Catra?* Where did you get a name like that?”

”Shadow Weaver,” Catra said as casually as she could, but the moment Micah’s eyes widened, she knew she’d made a mistake.

”Shadow Weaver?” Micah whispered, releasing Catra and leaning on his staff. “Light Spinner, how could you?”

“We’ll worry about it back at Brightmoon,” Catra insisted. “This is my friend Bow, and my girlfriend Adora.” She glanced at Adora, who was staring at the Sword of Protection. *What the Hordak happened?* she wondered.

“It’s an honor to,” Bow began, only to pause when Micah grabbed his face, “mheeet yuu,” he mumbled.

Catra swallowed a laugh, taking the opportunity to drop back to Adora while the king assured himself that Bow was real.. “Hey, Adora,” she whispered. “What’s wrong?”

“I can’t turn into She-Ra,” Adora whispered back, managing to sound panicked anyway. “Did the island infect the sword? Is it that sound? I promised I’d look out for you!”

Catra grabbed Adora’s arms. “Hey. Calm down,” she ordered. “Breathe.” Adora obeyed, quelling Catra’s own growing terror. “I’m still clever, you’re still the most stubborn soldier on Etheria, we’ve got the most powerful sorcerer I’ve ever seen, and Bow is still...Bow,” she trailed off. Adora snickered. “We rescued King Micah, he’s actually Micah, mission accomplished, let’s get off this gods-forsaken island and go home as heroes. Okay?”

“Well, he more kinda rescued us,” Adora muttered. Catra snorted a chuckle. Adora exhaled and nodded. “You’re right. All we have to do is get back to the ship and – are those chibbits?”

Dozens of single red eyes glowed in the not-trees. Micah’s eyes went wide. “Pookas,” he said.

“How many?” Catra asked, calling the magic to her claws.

Hundreds of eyes joined the dozens. “Too many,” Micah replied, raising his staff.

“Run,” Catra breathed.

They ran.

“We just have to make it back to Sea Hawk, right?” Bow cried, spinning, firing a flare arrow, and rushing forward without missing a step.

“Exactly!” Catra insisted. “We’re almost done, all we need to do is–”

You’re a monster a selfish beast they’re all going to DIE because YOU FOOL THIS IS ALL YOUR FAULT!

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra clutched her head and screamed. “Catra!” Adora cried. Catra managed to keep running, even slashing a pooka into disturbingly clean slices, but she looked as though she might fall over at any moment. *No!* Adora quailed.

“It’s the signal!” Micah explained. “Her magicat senses must make her vulnerable, but it doesn’t usually work this fast!”

“Shadow Weaver,” Bow gasped. Micah’s eyes widened again, one tear flashing down his cheek.

The pookas swarmed in front of them just as they reached a bridge. “Oh, no,” Adora breathed, brandishing the Sword. *Not like this. I won’t let that happen!*

Catra howled and rushed the pookas before anyone could stop her. Adora started rushing to her side, but halted when she realized that Catra was tearing the pookas apart. Her glowing claws carved through the beasts as though they were air, and her speed was unlike anything even Adora had seen before. “You think you can beat me with her?” Catra snarled. “You think telling me I’m a monster is going to stop me? I KNOW I’M A MONSTER! That’s why YOU should be afraid of ME!” She leaped into the pack with a roar, slashing and tearing until she was a blur of azure and gold.

The pookas broke and fled. Bow cheered and Micah laughed – until Catra started *chasing* them. “Catra, stop! You did it, you saved us!” Adora insisted, throwing her arms around the woman she loved.

“Let me go, Adora! I have to stop them!” Catra wailed.

“You already did, Catra,” Adora retorted, forcing Catra to turn and face her. She yelped at the sight of a clawed hand raised overhead. That paralyzed the magicat, her eyes wide with horror. “I’m okay, we’re okay, I’ve got you, just talk to me!”

“Don’t tell me nothing bad can happen because we’re together!” Catra snarled. “My whole *childhood* was one long bad thing

happening!”

In that instant, Catra’s entire life made sense to Adora. *Her devotion. Her fury. Her love. I even know why she didn’t tell me what Shadow Weaver was doing – Catra was protecting me, even then.* Only this moment remained a mystery. “Why is this so important to you?” Adora asked.

“Because if I can do this, maybe I’ll finally deserve it!” Catra snapped.

“Deserve what?” Bow asked.

“Everyone being nice to me!” Even in the middle of Beast Island, that stopped them all cold. “I’m horrible. You all saw that other Catra, you know what I can be, but this? Saving Angella’s husband, Glimmer’s dad? Maybe I can finally be worth all this – this kindness!”

Bow clamped his hands over his mouth, eyes shining with tears. Adora felt sick. “Shadow Weaver,” Micah said, his voice cold enough to shock Adora. “What was she to you?”

“A mockery of motherhood,” Catra snarled, wriggling out of the stunned Adora’s grasp. “Your wife was better to me on my first day in Brightmoon than Shadow Weaver ever was.”

Micah shook his head. “No. You can’t be...but your heterochromia, that’s...you’re not Kyra, are you? You’re...how long have I been gone?”

“King Micah? Do you know who I–” Catra took a step forward, only to be stopped by a black tendril around her ankle. She yelped and slashed it away. “Bast! What are those?”

“Signal vines! Get back!” Micah and Catra moved to protect Adora and Bow, placing themselves between the pair and the vines. “They drain hope from anyone they catch!”

"Pfft, like hope's ever meant anything to me," Catra replied, the duo drawing magic circles and repelling the vines. Adora's heart clenched worse than ever, and she heard...

You don't deserve her you don't deserve any *of them you used Catra hid behind her broke her betrayed her you lost She-Ra they're all going to die because you're worthless helpless USELESS–*

"No," Adora whispered. "NO!" she cried, tearing free of the vine around her wrist. "I won't give up! Not on my friends – not on my love – not on *myself! FOR THE HONOR OF GRAYSKULL!"*

The beautiful, glorious light flowed into Adora, filling her with strength, wonder, *purpose.* With a ferocious battle cry, she lashed out with the Sword, a single burst of golden light burning away the vines.

All three of her companions looked on in awe, even Catra. "Whoa," Catra gasped. "I think I get why She-Ra's such a big deal, now."

Adora chuckled. "Yeah, she makes a pretty good sidekick," she replied, giving Catra a one-armed hug. Catra blushed, though only Adora could tell.

"You're She-Ra?" Micah whispered. "What else have I missed?"

"We'll fill you in on the way home," She-Ra assured him.

"Home," Micah agreed, nodding. "Home sounds wonderful."

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Glimmer watched her mother pace on the docks, the queen's agitation growing alongside Glimmer's. "Those three had better have a spectacular explanation when they return," Angella muttered for the fourth time that evening.

"Mom, I'm sure Adora had a good reason for – thank the Stars," Glimmer sighed, the Dragon's Daughter Five sailing into view. Angella relaxed for a moment, wings and shoulders drooping. Then she straightened, took a deep breath, and strode to the dock's edge, arms crossed.

There was a cloaked man with a staff instead of a shirt standing beside a smirking Catra. *Huh. She looks even more smug than usual,* Glimmer thought, trying to get a look at the guy's face under the hood. All that stuck out was a gray beard tuft. "Ho there, Your Majesty!" Sea Hawk cheered with a wave as they docked. "Our mission was a success."

"I am pleased to hear it," Angella replied, and even Swift Wind noticed the frost in her tone. If anything, though, Catra's smirk grew. "Perhaps someone would care to inform me of what–"

"Angie?" the cloaked man whispered, and the queen froze, eyes almost round from how wide they flew. The man drew back his hood, and–

Glimmer gasped. "Daddy?" she blurted, staring. *It can't be. Can it?*

Micah's eyes filled with tears as he turned to face the princess. "My little Glimmer. All grown up. Your friends have amazing stories of your adventures."

"Micah," Angella breathed, reaching out with a single, trembling hand. "But you died."

Catra's smirk vanished. "That's what Shadow Weaver wanted you to believe," she explained. "She exiled him to Beast Island. He survived. He's everything you said he is, you know."

"MICAH!" Angella cried, throwing her arms around the king and kissing him.

"Dad!" Glimmer sobbed, teleporting to them and joining the hug.

“It’s real,” Micah said, shuddering. “You’re real. I’m – I’m home.”

“How?” Angella asked.

Adora smiled. “One of the probes Catra had Entrapta build found King Micah on Beast Island.” Catra’s ears and tail both shot up. “After that, she wasn’t going to let anything stand in the way of rescuing him.”

“Adora!” Catra yelped. Fur hid any blush she had, but the embarrassment was clear.

“Catra, I – we – can never repay you for this – this miracle,” Angella said.

“You’re the best,” Glimmer agreed, tears streaming down her face. Catra looked away, hugging herself. The princess was too overjoyed to laugh.

“You’re still grounded, though,” Angella added.

Glimmer was so shocked she let her parents go. “WHAT?!” she blurted, beyond outraged.

Catra’s eyes were wide with terror. “Wh-what’s ‘grounded?’” she stammered.

Dad laughed while Mom held her forehead. “Oh, Stars,” Angella sighed.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

“So the dreaded ‘grounding’ is...an enforced vacation?” Catra asked, chuckling, while the Best Friends Squad watched moonset from Brightmoon’s highest tower. Each had a different bowl of ice cream; Adora ate strawberry to pretend it was more healthy, Glimmer scooped her way through something called Rocky Road, all-loving Bow indulged in Neapolitan, and Catra licked her way through mint chocolate chip. “Let me guess. Angella has to be

seen punishing me for leaving without clearance, but wants to reward me for saving her husband, so I'm 'grounded,' right?"

Glimmer shook her head. "No, she's still trying to figure out how to reward you properly," the princess explained. "This is supposed to be an actual punishment." Catra blinked. *Honestly?*

"A really mild one, though," Bow added. "Unless you're Glimmer and being confined to the palace grounds makes you stir-crazy."

"Oh!" Adora blurted. "That's where the term comes from – you can't leave the grounds, so, grounded."

Catra shuddered, putting her bowl down. "Way better than what I thought," she replied before Bow could correct Adora.

Glimmer and Bow looked at each other. "Catra," Bow began slowly.

"I know!" Catra erupted, throwing up her hands. "I know, okay? It's just...hard." Adora put her bowl down to hug Catra. For once, Catra let her, returning the embrace.

"You're still recovering," Queen Angella said, adding, "please don't get up," when the former Horde soldiers moved to scramble to their feet. Catra and Adora settled back into each other. "I fear, after a lifetime in the Fright Zone, a small portion of you always will be."

"Just a small one, though," King Micah added, trailing after the queen. He'd cleaned up well, wearing royal garb, his hair neat, and no sign of bugs in his outfit–

Catra snickered in spite of herself. "Is that a topknot?" she asked, not quite smirking.

"Your friend Bow wears a crop top," Micah pointed out with a grin.

"And I still haven't stopped teasing him about it," Catra retorted. They all laughed – even Bow, to Catra's surprise. The magicat

sobered in moments. “I’m never going to get better, am I?”

“I did not say that,” Angella pointed out. “What I meant is that your trauma is like any other wound. It will heal, but there will always be a scar. You’ve already chosen to define it instead of letting it define you, but I’m not sure you’ve decided how.”

Catra stared for a moment. Absently, she picked up her ice cream and gave it a lick. It soothed her sudden nerves. “I...don’t understand,” she admitted.

“You already know not to let her poison your heart. Now, you need to figure out whether to try and leave your past behind,” Micah explained, “or embrace it, and let it make you stronger.”

Catra gulped. “Stronger? It doesn’t feel like strength. It feels...cold. Like the old me, trying to get out.” Adora held her tighter. Glimmer frowned.

Micah shrugged. “I know it can feel that way, Catra, but try looking at your past from a different perspective. How did you become a strategist?” Catra straightened as much as she could in Adora’s arms. “Where did you meet Adora and Entrapta? Do the people we love appreciate real beds and ice cream as much as we do?”

Catra stared. *Huh.* She smiled back – a genuine, relaxed smile that left Bow’s eyes sparkling and Adora blushing. “Yeah. Thanks, Magidad.”

Micah’s eyes widened, eyes glistening for a moment. “‘A magicat is loyalty,’” he said, with the air of a quote. “Come on, Glimmer. I have more stories of Mystacor you might enjoy.”

Glimmer blinked. “Huh? Oh!” She leaped to her feet. “Thanks, Dad. Come on, Bow.”

Bow stared. “Why do you want me to – oh! Right, I’d love to hear more!” he gushed, and the three royals (plus one best friend) left the tower.

Adora looked at Catra. “Was that them giving us privacy?” she asked.

Catra grinned and curled up beside Adora. “Look who’s learning. I’m so proud of you.”

With a huff, Adora backed away. “No, Catra. You’re not distracting me again.” Catra’s grin vanished. *Sekhmet,* she swore. “You’re not fine, aren’t you? You’ve never been fine.”

Catra ran through a dozen excuses, lies, deflections, and quips before surrendering to the inevitable. “Duh. I was the chew toy of the most hateful person on Etheria,” she pointed out.

“Why didn’t you tell me?” Adora whispered.

Catra glared. “Gee, let me think. She would’ve killed me, you never listened, she would’ve killed me, if you had listened it would’ve destroyed you, and oh yeah, *she would’ve killed me.* Why do you think I was such a mess?”

Adora grabbed Catra’s shoulders. “Catra. *Please.* Tell me how I can help. If – if I never kept my promise, I want to now.”

Catra half-growled a sigh. “You kept it the best you could,” she explained, looking back out at the moonset. “For all the bad in there, I had one good thing.” She licked at the ice cream while Adora stared. “I don’t know. Okay? I don’t know what you can do. Bast, I don’t know what *I* can do.”

Adora shivered, then hugged Catra again. “Does my being here help?” she breathed.

Catra’s tail curled around Adora’s waist. “More than anything,” she replied, letting her head rest on the human’s shoulder.

They sat there for a while, eating ice cream and holding one another while the night moons rose. “We’re a mess, aren’t we?” Adora asked.

“Yep,” Catra agreed.

“But...we’re less of mess together, right?” Adora held Catra’s hand. Catra nodded. All at once, Adora chuckled as she snuggled into Catra, luxuriating in her soft fur. “Hey, Catra. *Now* do you believe you deserve to be here?” Adora asked.

Catra snuggled back. “It’s a start,” she admitted.

Chapter End Notes

> So twice now I've commented about how long it's been between chapters. What a joke.
>
> This is probably the last chapter for a while. I was hoping to visit Bow's dads before Season 5 came out, but (good thing) i have a regular writing gig for actual money, and (bad thing) the world kinda went mad between chapters. Hopefully, I'll have the chance to do more with Turn Right at some point -- I've got adaptations for Season 3 and several big Season 4 moments in my head -- but this might be it. If it is, though, I'm glad that I at least got them to Beast Island. Stay safe.

Princess of the Moon

Chapter Summary

> What is Catra? (NOTE: New tags include Past Character Death for this chapter. The Angst is strong with this one, but so is the Happy Ending. Also, SPOILERS FOR SEASON FIVE in the end notes!)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer grinned at Catra's grumbling as they completed their ritual circles. "Good work, both of you," Micah encouraged, circling the pair as he watched them empower the arrays. "Glimmer, just a little cleaner on those lines. Catra, worry less about the spacing on the symbols and more about their meanings. These are exorcism circles, not combat spells."

"Yeah, yeah, I know," Catra muttered. Micah directed spheres of flickering gray energy into each circle. Glimmer activated hers with a battle cry, and Dad's spell vanished in a burst of rainbow light. Catra did the same with a snarl, and her sphere wavered, then disintegrated in a swirling storm of fractured colors.

Glimmer cheered. "Woo-hoo! That was awesome!" Catra grunted.

"Excellent work, Glimmer. Catra, don't be too hard on yourself," Micah encouraged. "Some spells are about precision, but all that really matters with exorcism magic is that it *works."*

"Would that have worked on shadow spies?" Catra snarled, looking away. Micah flinched, then put a gentle hand on the magicat's shoulder. "S-sorry. I just..."

"I understand," Micah insisted. "She can't control you any more."

Catra paused, and Glimmer froze, swallowing. "Did–" her ears went flat, "–did you remember anything else? About 'Kyra,' or the magicats?"

"I'm sorry, Catra," Micah replied. "I'm still sorting through it all. Beast Island...sometimes, I still think I'm there." He glanced around, then smiled. "Don't worry. I'll work it out."

"Don't hurt yourself–" Catra blurted, ears darting up.

Glimmer laughed. "Get out of here, Wildcat, before you turn into Adora." Catra's eyes widened, and Glimmer's laughter redoubled. *Seriously, she gets worse every day.*

"You take that back!" Catra retorted.

Micah laughed as well, hugging each teen in an arm. "I think you both need a break. Catra, no war room for the rest of the day." Catra gasped. "I'm serious. For someone on an 'enforced vacation,' you work harder than any two knights."

Catra sighed. "Sure. I mean, it's not like Angella's put the whole *war* on hold to punish me or anything. Oh wait."

"Catra." Both sorceresses jumped as the queen entered. "We are still winning. Your contributions remain invaluable. My only frustration is that you haven't yet worked out why I've chosen this reprimand for you."

"Then explain it to me!" Catra half-pleaded, half-demanded. "I don't know *everything!"*

"Catra!" Glimmer yelped. "Mom, please, she's just frustrated, she wants to help."

"Yeah, I didn't think you wouldn't let me go on combat missions," Catra muttered. "I mean, how is that a punishment?"

Angella shook her head and smiled. "If it was, it would clearly be working." Glimmer and Catra both looked up at that, disbelieving.

Wait, what? Glimmer wondered. "Catra, I disallow trips for entertainment as your punishment. I have prevented you from going into battle in the hope that you might realize we value you as a person, not as a weapon."

Catra's jaw dropped, ears and tail shooting out. "What?" she whispered. "I...don't understand."

Glimmer did, slapping her forehead. "Seriously! Still?" she wailed. "When are you going to get it through your thick skull that we're your *friends!"*

Catra looked down, eyes flickering. Angella sighed. "I don't know why this is so hard for you, Catra."

"I do," Micah growled. His voice was low and fierce. Glimmer shivered, remembering crimson lightning. *Shadow Weaver.*

Mom set her jaw in a determined line. "Catra, if you chose to retire to your explorations today, I would miss you – we all would–" Catra looked up, more shocked than ever, "–but you have proven yourself in every way imaginable. You have driven the Horde back to borders not seen since the time of the first Alliance. You returned Entrapta to us, saved Mystacor, and reunited my family. The only person who believes you have not repaid a handful of mistakes a hundredfold is you."

Catra's still-wide eyes shone with tears. Glimmer wanted to cheer, until Mom sighed again. "I am ending your grounding early, *under the condition* that you not go into battle without at least two princesses by your side for the remainder of the month. I will not have you treat yourself as expendable again. You are priceless to us. Not as a warrior, not as a magicat, but as family."

"I, uh," Catra babbled, "gotsomethinginmyeye." She bolted from the room. Mom and Dad looked at each other and sighed.

"I'll find her," Glimmer groaned, teleporting after Catra. It took three more tries to catch up. *Stars, she's fast,* she thought, finding Catra huddled on a balcony. "Come on, Catra, talk to me."

"Why do you want to?" Catra whispered. "I'm the freak who gave you to – to *her."*

Oh, for– Glimmer gripped her hair in both fists for a moment, letting go before she could pull any out. "And then you saved me! And then you saved everyone, like, a zillion times! Adora's in love with you! *You found my Dad!* What is going to be enough?"

Catra curled her tail around her ankles. "I don't know," she whispered. Shadow Weaver's cold hand gripped Glimmer's heart. "I thought saving Micah would do it. It's just...I'm still...me. I'm vicious. I'm mean. I'm...I'm messed up, Glimmer.

Sorrow devoured Glimmer's frustration. She sat beside Catra and put one arm around her shoulders. Catra leaned into her and sobbed without a sound. "We're here for you, Catra. However long it takes, we're here."

Glimmer never imagined that something as soft as Catra's voice was in that moment could break her heart. "You promise?"

Glimmer shifted to full-blown hug. "I promise."

Catra hugged her back. *Wow. No snark. Like, at all.* They just held each other, trying to pretend that hope didn't scare them half to death.

"Hey, can I take you to my room?" Glimmer asked.

Catra chuckled, face half-buried in her arm. "I have a girlfriend," she quipped.

Glimmer snorted, pretending not to be relieved by Catra's retort. "You really need to clean your face. Preferably, not on my shoulder." Catra sighed and nodded. Glimmer teleported them to her room, they stood up –

– and ducked when an arrow came sailing in.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

I knew it, Catra growled, tail lashing as she swallowed an increasingly furious rant.

It had been too good to be true, of course. Bow's dads seemed so nice at first. Sweet, welcoming, kind, it was almost like a second Brightmoon. They offered to show Catra (apparently a history student at the 'academy') everything they had on Halfmoon, and she indulged in her greed for magicat knowledge. Then the rot started leaking out. George's tragic history with the first Rebellion. Their assumptions about Bow's future. Bow's lies to protect his place in their home – in his home.

No. Brightmoon is Bow's home. This whole place is a lie. Catra paced while Glimmer and Bow went over stuff about Serenia. She turned her ninth glare on Bow. He turned his ninth sparkle-eyed-pleading back on her. Catra relented with her loudest growl yet. *I knew it! He understood my Shadow Weaver stuff best because he's dealing with it too! This is not okay.*

"I can't do this," she snapped. "I'll be outside, using trees for scratching posts and pretending they're George!"

"Catra!" Bow retorted. "Uncool!"

"No it's not, Bow," Glimmer jumped in. "What's wrong with you? You're – living a lie, with a secret family, pretending to be a historian, and wearing a sweater! A *sweater,* Bow!" She waved at the offending garment.

"He's afraid," Catra snarled, forcing the tears not to form. "He's afraid that his fathers won't love him if they know the truth." Bow flinched. Glimmer gasped. "This is why you understood Shadow Weaver, isn't it?"

It was Bow's turn to gasp. "My dads are nothing like Shadow Weaver. *Nothing!"*

Catra folded her arms. "Even Hordak's not as evil as Shadow Weaver. That does not make this okay." Bow froze while Glimmer fist-pumped. "You taught me to respect Adora's trauma. Just

because it's not the same as mine doesn't make it any less real. Same goes for you."

"This isn't trauma!" Bow objected.

"Then why are you about to cry?" Catra asked.

Bow shuddered. "Why are you doing this, Catra?"

"Because you told me what I needed to hear, even when I didn't want to listen," Catra reminded him. "I know I'm still crap at this, but that's what friends do, right?"

"You are absolutely not crap at this," Glimmer said, then turned to Bow. "She's right. Your dads love you. They'll love the real you."

Catra swallowed, her fear of rejection rearing its head wearing Shadow Weaver's mask. "And – and if they don't, they never deserved yours."

She was actually grateful when the pillbug-monster attacked.

The battle took about thirty seconds, even if Adora was so not on her game. Catra used Micah's lasso spell to hold it long enough for Bow to calm it down with the Runestone shard, and they were done with the Elemental.

Bow's dads were another matter. "WHAT IS GOING ON?" George screamed.

Catra leaped between Bow and the two old men. "You're horrible parents, that's what!" she screamed back. They froze. "Bow's a Rebel, a *hero* who's faced Horde legions, saved She-Ra from a robot army, and even made friends with a screwed-up magicat, but I've never seen him as afraid of them as he is of *you!"*

Their reaction was the last thing she expected: remorse. The shock was no surprise, but Catra felt a pang of guilt when Lance responded with one devastated whisper: "What?"

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora glanced at Catra as they gathered around the table again. This time, though, Bow's dads had gathered all their knowledge of Halfmoon. "So let me get this straight. I chew you out, everybody hugs, and now you're...thanking me?"

"Yes," George replied. Bow chuckled.

"It's obvious you care about Bow," Lance added. "Besides, it's an honor to help a magicat champion find her home."

Adora straightened. "Wait, 'champion?' Catra's never even met another magicat."

Lance shrugged. "According to 'Spritina's Treatise on Classic Sorcery,' the Bubasti choose most champions in a ritual contest, but a few times each generation, a champion gives birth to a child with heterochromia."

Catra blinked. "Hetero-what? King Micah said the same thing, but we were kinda running for our lives at the time."

Bow's dads stared. "King Micah's alive?!" George cried.

Adora smiled with pride, hugging Catra. "Yep! My awesome girlfriend found him and led the rescue team."

"Adora!" Catra complained, failing to pretend not to be embarrassed.

Lance cleared his throat. "Ah, heterochromia refers to people with different-colored eyes. Among Bubasti, it was considered a mark of awesome potential, and heterochromatic magicats could join the champions of Halfmoon on their request. Many great Bubasti heroes and villains had heterochromia like yours."

I knew it! Adora exulted. "I told you your eyes were beautiful," she said instead.

Catra blushed so furiously it showed through her fur. "Shadow Weaver lies," she muttered, clutching one arm with her hand.

Adora's smile vanished with her joy. For the first time, she imagined driving the Sword through the witch's chest. "So, does that help us find Halfmoon?"

"We can't, but maybe she can," George explained. "Spritina's Treatise describes a few spells that might help." He turned to a page with the most beautiful magic circle Adora had ever seen. *It even has cat ears,* she realized. "This one is the strongest, but it only works for Bubasti champions.

"Like me," Catra whispered. Lance nodded with Bow-like enthusiasm. "Thanks, Bow's dads."

Bow sighed. "They have names, Catra."

"Yeah, but I wasn't sure they deserved to be called that, before," Catra replied. Both fathers' eyes gleamed.

As one, the Best Friends Squad smiled. *That's my Catra,* Adora thought, ready to burst with pride.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Angella sighed. "There is no point in ordering you not to do this, is there?" she asked. Her coward's heart quailed at the thought of her children throwing themselves into the storm. *Again.*

Adora's eyes widened. "Your Majesty, surely you wouldn't deny Catra the chance to find her people," she objected. Catra's whine was pure distressed feline. Entrapta looked from magicat to queen, uncertain.

Micah rubbed his forehead. "That depends on where Halfmoon is. There's every chance that the Horde is occupying the land around the entrance. I still don't remember much, but I know I fought there. It's where I was captured."

Glimmer and Bow gasped as one. Catra glanced away, but with a strength Angella admired (and envied), she met the queen's gaze. "I'll be careful. I – I promise. We'll judge the risk based on where the path is. The spell, though...I have to try. Please, M – Majesty." Catra swallowed. "I have to."

Angella fought an urge to deny her anyway. She glanced at Glimmer, then back at the magicat so like her. *She must be Catriska, even if Micah can't remember.* The queen lost her battle with her memories, smiling at Micah and Kyra laughing as they planned another raid, Angella and the sorceress-champion giggling as Micah failed to summon the Freezefire again, letters from Mystacor chronicling her pregnancy. *If only I had seen her, if I could be certain...* Her desperate desire to protect the children howled through her.

She thought about how close she'd come to losing Glimmer to her distant smothering, and wilted. "You will all promise to be careful, not just Catra." They all nodded. "Very well. Let us begin."

They all leaped to the task with enthusiasm, even Micah becoming like an eager child. *Only Catra can cast the spell, but we can still help.* Angella set about doing just that alongside husband and daughter, while Adora, Bow, and Entrapta fiddled with maps and an odd device to mark them.

Catra's eyes glowed the moment she began the spell. Uncertainty marred her first strokes of the casting, shaking claws threatening to unravel the magic as it formed. Mercifully, her confidence grew with the ritual, arcs forming with increasing steadiness.

At last, Catra completed the circle, and the magicat gasped as she floated inches off the floor. Entrapta's device went mad, scribbling lines across all the maps at once.

In the exact moment the map machine stopped, Catra landed, eyes focused again. "I found it," she whispered. They looked at the map.

“There’s a place called Talon Mountain?” Adora asked. “Wow, that doesn’t sound friendly.”

Angella frowned. *Not safe, but not the Horde. I have to trust them.* She shook out her wings. “I am not entirely the last of my kind. Harpies are fallen immortals, whose wings are feather and bone rather than magic and light. Their leader, Princess Hunga, was once an ally of Hordak’s, before he exiled her for incompetence and treachery.”

Glimmer’s eyes widened. “An evil princess?”

“Yes, though her powers are limited and her acolytes few. All the same, they are cunning. Do not attempt to climb the mountain. If the entrance is at the base, use your discretion, but if it is higher than you can reach from the ground, return at once and we will devise a plan.” She turned her gaze to Catra. “Remember. You promised.” Catra swallowed and nodded.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra knew she should be wary. Flying bandits, rough terrain, and dubious intelligence sources were not a great combination. *I have to know,* she thought, not for the first time. A glance behind her evoked a new wave of guilt. *I just wish I could’ve gotten them to stay behind.*

Adora kept close to her, hand straying to the sword hilt. Glimmer strode ahead with glowing fists. Bow stood rearguard, scanning the area while checking his quiver. Entrapta hummed cheerily while going over three scanners at once. Catra smiled. *I’m glad they came.*

Of course, after all their efforts, the stupid cavern was twelve feet up – just out of reach. “Are you kidding me?” Catra blurted. *We have to go back because we’d have to climb, like, three steps?*

”Wait!” Entrapta cried, rushing forward. With a grunt of effort, she propped herself on one end of her pigtails, held herself up sideways, and reached for the cavern with her other tendrils.

“Almost...yes!” The tip of her longest hairs grasped the ledge. “Got it!”

“Reached it from the ground, that counts!” Glimmer insisted, then promptly teleported them in one at a time. They pulled Entrapta up just as angry screeches echoed overhead.

Bow gulped. “That must be why Angella didn’t want us climbing,” he realized.

Catra swallowed a “duh” and walked into the sloping cavern. “Thanks, you guys.” Adora hugged her while Entrapta flashed a hair-thumbs-up.

“Daughters!” Harpies screeched behind them. “Daughters of Angella!”

Catra looked at Adora. “Run?” she asked.

Rustling feathers and scraping claws echoed behind them. Adora looked at Catra. “Run,” she agreed.

They ran, until the slope sharpened beneath them, and then they slid. Harpy screeches faded behind them. They skidded to a halt in front of a massive wall with a tiger’s mouth for a gateway. Catra leaped to her feet, eyes sparkling. “This is it! Halfmoon!” She took three steps, preparing to run in...

...but before she could, or Adora could warn her to be careful, Catra stopped, staring in horror. There were suits of Horde armor, unfamiliar suits, and countless bots scattered around them. Bits of skeleton peeked out from the uniforms. “Stars,” Glimmer breathed, shaking.

“There must be hundreds of Horde bodies. Thousands of bots. Look at them all,” Bow whispered.

“Those other uniforms must have belonged to magicats,” Adora realized. “And wow, look, there’s one of them for every ten Horde soldiers.” Catra was still too in shock to speak.

"And every hundred bots," Entrapta added.

"There's sorcery blasts everywhere," Glimmer explained, still shuddering. "Look, some of the circles burned patterns in the stone."

No, Catra gasped. "NO!" she cried, rushing heedless through the gate.

The city was worse. "No," she wept, stumbling over another Horde breastplate as she looked on what had once been a magnificent city of pillars, long buildings, and towering monuments. Even ruined, Catra could smell the wizardry, taste it in the still air. Adora took her hand, moving with Catra as they strode through the shattered kingdom.

"Horde casualties get worse the farther we go in," Adora noted. *She's trying to make me feel better,* Catra realized. Somehow, it worked, knowing that Hordak had paid the price.

Bow and Entrapta went through the few surviving books, collecting everything that looked like it might help. Glimmer teleported from rooftop to rooftop, calling out for survivors. Catra had never loved them more than in that moment. *I don't remember,* she realized with a start. "Why don't I remember?"

"Shadow Weaver," Adora growled. Catra nodded. *Why else?*

At long last, they came to the heart of the city, where they found the head of a fallen statue and a throne split in half by a blade. "I can taste her magic," Catra muttered, tail lashing. Its eyes were gemstones, one blue, one gold. "Shadow Weaver was here. She–"

"Who was she, mama?" Catriska asked, squirming in her mother's arms as she looked up at the statue.

Kyra laughed, brushing a blue and gold ribbon back.. "That's my namesake, little champion. Golden Kyra. The overworlders called her 'She-Ra.' She was the first to channel the deep magic and save the world from the Evil Masters."

Catriska stared into the eyes so like hers. "I wanna be like her," she declared. "I'm gonna be a hero!"

"Catra!" Adora cried. Catra clutched her head, shook off the pain – and saw crimson lightning on her claws for an instant. "Are you all right?"

"Yeah," Catra replied, staring at the gem-eyes. "I remembered. My birth mother–"

One of the magicat bodies still had a ribbon around her skull, blue and gold interwoven. Catra wailed and rushed to it, falling to her knees. *"Spinny, please stop! You don't have to do this!" Kyra begged.*

"Light Spinner is dead. I am Shadow Weaver." The witch held Catriska in one arm, the kit struggling in binding shadows. Battle raged around them, Kyra throwing bolts of blue flame and golden – crystal? "And though this is *necessary, I would do it if it were not. You said you would protect me."*

"I never thought you'd join the Horde!" Kyra cried, caving in a Horde helmet with a single kick. "This isn't you! I know it's not–"

A spike of darkness pierced Kyra's chest. The magicat didn't even gasp. Catriska screamed. "Your daughter," Shadow Weaver exulted, "will lead Horde armies. I will raise her on a diet of hate, and she will be my vengeance."

Kyra caressed Shadow Weaver's cheek before she slumped to the ground. "Spinny...please..." Shadow Weaver slapped the hand away and strode off to face King Micah, who fought beside the Magicat Queen. "don't let this ruin you," were Kyra's last words. Shadow Weaver never heard them. Catriska did.

Catra screamed again, collapsing in on herself and sobbing. Bitterness howled through her. "Figures," she snarled. "Even while Shadow Weaver was kidnapping me, my mother's last words were for her." Adora gasped a sob. "Not me–"

An image of Kyra in a Mystacor robe formed above the ribbon. “My beautiful Catriska.” She smiled down.

Catra looked up, too wrung out to be shocked. “Mom?” she whimpered. Adora held her. Catra let her.

“If you’re seeing this, then you escaped Light – Shadow Weaver. You’re free,” Kyra continued. “There is so much I want to say to you. So much I wanted for you.” Catra could hardly see the image through her tears. “I wish I had real advice. I don’t know if you found our people, or what friends you made, or even if you learned magic. All I know is this. I believe in you. If...if she told you not to believe in yourself, that you weren’t wondrous or amazing, don’t accept that. Never accept that. You are a blessing, a genius, a wonder, and the bright star of my life. Wherever you go, Catra, whatever you become, you will never be alone, for my love is with you, and we are our love.”

Kyra gestured at her own body. “Please, take my ribbon. Let it remind you of your strength when you feel weak, and your heritage if you feel bereft. I love you, little champion.” Kyra bent down and kissed Catra on the forehead, then vanished.

Catra reached down and tried to slip the ribbon off her mother’s...she couldn’t even think the word. Her hands trembled too badly, the cloth slipping from her grasp. “Catra?” Adora whispered. “Is...is it okay if I help?” Catra nodded, too shaken by the message – and too grateful that Adora had asked first – to speak. Adora unwrapped the ribbon, then twined it around Catra’s wrist.

A flash of light filled Catra’s soul. The eyes of the statue followed suit. She saw another city, so much like this one but deeper and *alive,* and heard magicats laughing, playing, training. Sorcery filled the entire nation, shielding it from discovery and attack. The spell of champions filled her mind – *Freezefire,* a sapphire flame of raging frost and golden ice of searing heat – and another magicat’s thoughts reached her. She saw an old cat smiling, one eye covered by a patch, magic glowing from – Cloudfoot – like all

dozen moons. *Oh, child,* Cloudfoot thought, and Catra thought she could feel him caress her cheek. *We are not lost. The queen's sacrifice, King Micah's, your mother's,* yours *– they saved the Bubasti. We hide in New Halfmoon, and our princess is nearly ready. When the time comes, we will rise again to fight for Etheria. For now, be our voice in the Alliance, and know that you will always be one of us.*

Thank you, Catra rejoiced, and Cloudfoot was gone. But she knew. She knew how to reach New Halfmoon, and that she didn't have to, not with the others hugging her like a blanket of friends. At last, Adora squirmed around and looked Catra in the eyes. "Are you okay, Catra?"

Catra smiled back. "You know what? I am. I really am." She turned to Glimmer. "Hey, Sparkles. Let's go home, huh?"

Glimmer wiped a few tears away and nodded. "Yeah." Even Entrapta didn't object.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

The magicats are alive, Angella thought, trying to stay on topic. It was difficult to follow the five young heroes, each talking over the other in babbling excitement, but the basics were clear. *The magicats – Etheria's greatest warriors – are alive, and nearly ready to join the Rebellion.* She smiled at Adora, who was describing their slide into Halfmoon with great animation, and Catra, who was unusually silent. *I should be focused on the practical matters of this revelation. The fall of Old Halfmoon stalled the Horde's advance for five years, a delay that saved Etheria while I grieved. New Halfmoon could free us all. Yet all I can think about...*

Micah and Glimmer chattered with untrammeled delight, his memories of their dear friend restored. He alone had traveled to Halfmoon, and his description of its height warmed Angella's heart. *She-Ra, who saved us in our darkest hour. Catra, who has led us to victory after victory. How can I repay them?* She turned

to Catra, who played with the ribbon on her wrist with a bittersweet smile that burned with old loneliness.

Angella smiled. *How else?*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora smirked at the fuming Catra as she, Bow, and Entrapta led her to the throne room. "You know, it's okay to be annoyed sometimes," Adora teased.

"Yeah," Entrapta agreed, "we don't mind you being an angry cat person as long as you're on our side."

Catra snorted. "You don't want to go there, trust me. I was this close to being Hordak's right hand cat," she reminded them, holding thumb and finger a hairsbreadth apart. "You wouldn't like me when I'm angry."

Adora's eyes widened. "I said annoyed! Entrapta said angry!"

Entrapta pouted at Adora. "Social interaction log 57: courage in battle does not appear to extend to interpersonal activity." *Ouch,* Adora thought, pouting back, while Catra and Bow laughed.

Knights opened the doors to the throne room, saving Adora from further humiliation. Catra froze at the sight of the royal family, all the Princesses, and the senior military leaders of every kingdoms lined up to greet them. "Commander Catra. Please step forward," Angella beckoned.

Catra obeyed with eerie deference, then bowed. Properly. Adora forced herself to breathe. "Wh – what is your command, Your Majesty?"

Angella sighed. "I have no command for you today, Catra. Only an offer. One might even call it a request." She waved to the herald, who handed Angella the certificate. Adora felt paralyzed. "Glimmer told me about what you found in – at Talon Mountain." Her mask of serenity melted away. "Catra, I'm so sorry."

Adora could feel the lump in Catra's throat. "It's...okay. Really. She...she loved me. I never got that before."

Angella's eyes flickered to a window, narrowing. Micah's hand formed a brief fist. Then they both smiled at her. "We know, Catriska," Micah agreed.

"It's time we rectified that," Angella added.

Catra stared, eyes wide and bristling tail sticking out. Adora watched, burning every moment into her memory. *I think I want this for her as much as she does,* Adora realized. "I...don't understand," Catra admitted.

Angella held up the form. "This is a certificate of adoption," she explained. "For you."

If Catra's eyes had been wide before, they were shining moons now. "Adoption? Me? Who would want *me?"*

Glimmer teleported explosively to Catra's side, grabbing her left arm. "Us, you dork!" she blurted. Catra's jaw dropped.

"Catra, the Horde stole your family, your home, even your memories. If anyone has the right to leave this war behind, it is you," Angella insisted. "Yet you have sacrificed much and risked everything for the Alliance. We would be a family to you, if you will have us."

Catra's breathing kicked into overdrive. "But – Adora," she gasped.

"My parents might still be out there," Adora explained. Then she smirked, Catra scowling back on cue. "Besides, I'm *already* a princess."

Catra spluttered for an instant, then remembered where she was and turned to the queen. "You...you want me?" All of Adora's amusement died at that wounded, vulnerable tone, so small and desperate and afraid.

“More than anything,” Glimmer insisted. Catra took the paper with a trembling hand, stared for just long enough to worry Adora, then marked it with a glowing talon.

The herald stepped forward again. “All hail Catra, Princess of Brightmoon!” Everyone in the room cheered and threw themselves around the new princess. Adora, forewarned, got there first, throwing greedy arms around the love of her life. Catra grabbed onto Angella and Micah and cried, completely unafraid to show her tears for the first time.

When the crowd parted, Catra stood there, still in shock. Glimmer threw a blue and gold capelet around Catra’s shoulders. Catra blinked for a moment, then took a step forward. “Glimmer usually does the speeches,” she noted, and Adora gasped in time with Bow. “I just...” Catra swallowed, summoned the shining golden ice to her right hand, then straightened. “This is why you’re the good guys. Here, even a messed-up feral Shadow Weaver project can be loved. A freak can be a princess. A...a monster can be a hero.”

The blue flame burned cold in her left palm. “We’re going to win,” Catra said, and to Adora it sounded like a command, an order the world would obey. “We’re going to save Princess Scorpia, we’re going to burn down all of the Horde’s evil shadows, and then, just for an encore, we’re going to smash Hordak with his throne!” She pumped a fist into the air. “FOR THE ALLIANCE!”

The room cheered back. To Adora, it felt like all of Etheria was with them in that moment. They hugged Catra again, and Adora whispered, “You’re home.”

“I...I am. I’m home,” Catra sobbed again, letting them hold her. “I’m home.”

Chapter End Notes

Oh look I wrote a thing

So I kinda gave Bow's dads slightly short shrift, but I really wanted to include them, but this happened because I had SO

MANY FEELS due to Season 5. They gave us so much of what we wanted, but we got NO MAGICATS and NO MOMGELLA and I was not having that. So I moved the Catradoption from Season 4 to here, the proper ending of Turn Right Season 2.

Interstitia: Princess Catra

Chapter Summary

> The first of a series of shorter interludes, covering the time between Turn Right's "Season 2" and "Season 3."

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra stared in the mirror, looking at a stranger.

The freak's eyes – *no, it's heterochromia, it's special,* I'm*special,* she told herself, not truly believing it – stared back. Her fur, clean though it may be, remained hers.

Everything else has changed. Her literal fright mask was gone, left in a drawer because she can't quite yet part with it, replaced by Kyra's ribbon. Micah – *my father,* she remembered, not quite believing it – had tied a deep blue jewel into place over her brow. *"I'm not wearing a tiara!" Catra had objected, but Micah had replied, "It's a diadem, Catra. When you use a ribbon for this purpose, it's called a diadem."* Somehow, that had made Catra feel better – even if Sparkles insisted on teasing her about it.

Her shirt was the red of her headgear, a last fragment of her old life – *besides, it wouldn't be me if I didn't wear something red,* she mused – but the style was something called a sweetheart blouse, utterly impractical in combat, but Catra couldn't wait to see Adora's reaction to it. She wore blue pants with gold trim, much like the capelet Glimmer – *my sister,* she thought, amazed – had given her three days ago, at her adoption. *The colors of Halfmoon,* her mother had explained with a smile as gentle as Shadow Weaver had been cruel.

Her hair was the strangest part of all. Still just wild enough to be hers, a person whose entire job was styling others' hair had

trimmed, washed, and shaped Catra's to resemble a mane of flame, framing her face with regal might.

I still can't believe any of this. Catra held her forehead, careful not to disturb her diadem. *How is this my life now?*

Adora appeared in her mind's eye, reaching out to Catra in spite of everything. Glimmer, vouching for her to Bow. Perfuma, hugging Catra as she wept, grateful for Entrapta's survival. *They let me snarl and snap, waited for me to learn what kindness is,* Catra thought, shaking her head. *I still don't understand.*

Her mind wandered to sparring with Frosta, training with her bizarre new Freezefire. *"Thicker is tougher, but you also want to layer ice," Frosta had explained, pale cold ice clashing with her searing golden variant. As heat melted Frosta's ice, cold melted Catra's.* Again, Catra shook her head. *It was only a few months ago that she was my biggest critic.* She couldn't help a smirk. *Except, you know, short.*

All at once, Catra recognized the feeling of being stuck in her own head. *Entrapta,* she decided, bursting from her room and working her way downstairs.

(It still freaked Catra out a little that the knights straightened as she walked past. At least they didn't salute.)

Walking into Entrapta's lab, the weird genius working on about five things at once as Kyle kept the lab in order somehow, grounded Catra the way few things did any more. *Bast. Entrapta is part of my normal now.* Her eyes flickered to Kyle, dutiful enough to amaze the magicat, keeping Entrapta from blowing things up while he wired a box to another monitor. *And Kyle is actually good at this. Scratch that – he's* great *at this.* She grinned. "Hey, Kyle."

"Oh, hi, Catra!" Kyle replied, almost as cheerful as Bow. His smile faded. "Wait, do I call you 'Your Highness' now?"

“Don’t you dare,” Catra mock-warned. They chuckled. Guilt eroded her laugh. *When everyone picked on me, I picked on Kyle. Not cool, Catra.* Her smile returned when she decided how to make it up to him. *Rogelio’s the softest target in the Horde. I just have to get those two dorks to talk properly.*

“Catra! You’re just in time!” Entrapta exulted, pulling Catra to her side with a strand of hair. “I have perfected a new form of communication!” She glanced at a monitor with green text. “Well, ‘perfected’ may be too strong a word. But it’s useful! And highly resistant to listening devices.”

Catra leaned over Entrapta’s shoulder, looking at what appeared to be a long list of short letters between “E.T” and “Scrambler.” Most of it was scientific jargon and advanced math Catra barely understood, but a bit of it was idle chatter. About science, of course. Catra smirked. “Look at you, making friends and everything,” she encouraged, giving Entrapta’s shoulder a gentle nudge with her own. “You go, E.T.” She raised an eyebrow at one of the comments from Entrapta’s new pen pal. Something about medical equipment. “Who’s Scrambler?”

“The most extraordinary member of the Etherian Makers Community I have thus far corresponded with,” Entrapta gushed, plugging her First Ones crystal into her console.

“Don’t let Bow hear you say that,” Catra quipped.

Entrapta shrugged. “Bow doesn’t mind. Besides, Scrambler actually understands most of my thaumaturgical calculations!” She laughed for a moment, then stopped and blinked. “He can read my math,” she clarified.

Catra chuckled. “Relax, E.T., I’m starting to learn your language.” She grinned as her friend squeed. “Why ‘Scrambler’?”

“He uses a signal randomizer to evade Horde detection, and the nickname stuck,” Entrapta explained, her good humor draining away. “For all his brilliance, Scrambler suffers from a serious

degenerative condition." Catra's ears pivoted back. "He is all but incapable of combat. I am attempting to help him design an exoskeleton that will compensate for his illness."

Every paranoia alarm Catra had went off. "You sure he's not really a Horde agent?" she asked, eyes narrowing a fraction.

"I calculate no higher than a 3% chance of that outcome," Entrapta replied, typing with both hands and hair. Catra's tail puffed up.

Kyle cleared his throat. "Scrambler's helped a lot with Entrapta's medical projects," he offered.

Catra nodded. "Mmm," she demurred. *Later,* she decided. "Well, if my best friend's okay with him, then so am I," Catra said, and Entrapta's eyes went wide and bright. The magicat grinned. "Besides, us freaks have to stick together."

"Best...friend?" Entrapta whispered. "But...Adora? Glimmer?"

"Adora's my girlfriend, and Glimmer's my sister now," Catra explained, throwing an arm around her favorite mad scientist's shoulders. "Spot's all yours. Lucky you," Catra drawled.

Entrapta spun around and snapped to attention with that eerie focus Catra never quite adjusted to. "Bow's spoken to me about this...behavioral pattern of yours, where you belittle yourself," Entrapta said, holding Catra's shoulders in her hair. "It makes me...concerned. I know you wish to take pride in the label 'freak,' but do you really?"

Catra's mouth went dry. "Of course I do," she insisted, hoping she wasn't lying. "I wouldn't be half as awesome as I am if I hadn't had to fight for it."

Entrapta stared for a moment longer, then smiled and spun back around. "Oh, good. I guess you understand then!"

Catra blinked. "Understand?" she asked.

Entrapta nodded. “It’s like I was just telling Scrambler. You shouldn’t be upset that you’re not perfect. Imperfection is what makes scientific experimentation possible. Imperfection is beautiful! At least to me.”

Catra stared, gaping for a moment. Then she threw one of her rare non-Adora hugs around the little genius. “When did you get so wise?” she chuckled.

Entrapta froze for a moment, then returned the hug. “I liked the way you said it, too,” she whispered.

Then one of E.T.’s experiments started sparking. “Yipe! Please excuse me, I need to prevent this explosion.” Catra gulped and looked at Kyle, but the slender blond flashed her a thumbs-up, so she backed out, watching Entrapta until the sparks died down. *You sure can pick ‘em, Catra.*

Chapter End Notes

> If Entrapta had given Catra the "Imperfection is beautiful" speech, the series would have been very different, IMO. So, here it is.
>
> And no, Scrambler's real identity isn't supposed to be a big surprise. I'll be showing his end eventually. (Plus, I have a boss fight scene in mind for Hordak, and I really need him to not fall over in a stiff breeze when it happens.)

Interstitia: Lonnie

Chapter Summary

> Lonnie is more clever than most people give her credit for. With Catra in the Rebellion, she decides to step up, not realizing what she will set in motion.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

No one thought she was stupid, but very few people realized that Lonnie was *smart.* Sure, her squadmates knew – even Catra, despite her reluctance to compliment anyone not named Adora – but the rest of the Horde? To them, she was just another soldier.

It was only one of the many reasons she liked Scorpia so much. *So this is what "appreciation" means,* Lonnie mused.

The moment's happiness passed when Lonnie remembered what had triggered the thought about intelligence. They were *losing.*

Oh, it didn't look that way on the surface. They still held a third of Etheria's territory. The Rebellion's advance had stalled, Catradora or no Catradora. Hordak had deployed a whole new generation of bots. Rations were up, supplies were flowing, and morale was improving for the first time in months.

And all of that is exactly the problem, Lonnie worried. The Rebellion wasn't overextended, they were taking time to consolidate their gains. The bot blitz was a desperation move to pause the loss of territory. Rations and supplies were more readily available because of the steady stream of defections. Morale started improving when the slackers and ingrates bailed on them. *Sure, the Horde's better off without them in the long term, but if Catra keeps being the princesses' one brain cell, we won't* have *a long term.*

Rogelio strolled over to where Lonnie gazed out over the ramparts, past the edge of the Fright Zone. *"You okay?"* he asked.

"No," Lonnie muttered. "You know we're losing, right?"

Rogelio bristled. *"We're not* losing," he insisted. *"It's a stalemate. That's all."*

"We're bleeding people, Ro. That's always been the one thing we've had – people, ordinary Etherians fighting Angella's unnatural power." Lonnie sighed. "Figures the only way they'd win would be to put one of ours in charge." A crow landed in the distance. Lonnie laughed without mirth. "I always figured Catra would bail, but I never thought it would be for Adora."

"Because we never thought Adora would abandon us," Rogelio pointed out, putting an arm around Lonnie's shoulders. She reciprocated, though only her hand reached his shoulder. *"You're really not mad at Catra?"*

Lonnie scowled. "I'm...kinda mad? It's just, now that we know what Shadow Weaver was really doing to her, I don't blame her for leaving." Her scowl became a snarl of fury. "But. *Adora.* Of *course* she'd be all, 'Hey, I know you're supposed to be my best friend, and I took Shadow Weaver's side while she hurt you every day, but gosh, war is hard and I'm a princess now so will you be my sidekick again?' Aargh!" Lonnie threw up her hands. "I never even liked Catra!"

Rogelio slid back, leaning on the railing. *"What changed?"*

"That ridiculous prom thing," Lonnie scoffed, her snarl fading into a smile. "I always thought Catra was riding Adora's skiff, you know? Especially after that Salineas disaster. But the prom!" She shook her head, smile growing. "Man, that was a thing of beauty. She had every princess on Etheria dancing to our tune. We took down their obscene elitist party, made Adora look like a chump, and took off with Angella's daughter and her bodyguard! It was amazing!" Lonnie threw a piece of scrap into the distance. "Until

Shadow Weaver screwed it all up, taking the credit for it without having the slightest idea what to do with our victory."

Rogelio straightened in alarm, tail thumping against the rail. *"Lonnie!"* he hissed, looking around them. He relaxed as he saw Scorpia approaching.

"I don't care about her any more, Ro," Lonnie continued, glaring at the horizon. "Scorpia's got our backs. Shadow Weaver can't touch us now. Not like we ever mattered to her." Her hands tightened on the railing. "Or Adora."

"It...might not be like that," Rogelio muttered, scratching the back of his head. *"Adora's always been about doing the right thing. Maybe the princesses got into her head."*

Lonnie snorted and made a fist. "She didn't trust us. Even if Catra let Adora into *her* head, at least she came back for us." Rogelio's head drooped, and Lonnie winced. "Rogelio, are *you* okay?"

Rogelio sighed. *"No,* he admitted. *"I miss him. So much."*

Lonnie's eyebrows shot skyward. "But you're not mad at him," she realized.

"No. Kyle still cares about us. About me," he explained. *"It's just...that archer guy got to him. Kyle didn't have it much better than Catra, you know."*

Lonnie scowled. "Yeah, I get it, the Horde isn't perfect, but the Rebellion? Seriously?"

"Just because they're the bad guys doesn't mean they're all bad people," Scorpia said as she approached. "That Bow guy seemed okay. Sorta."

"They're a bunch of backwards princess-worshipers who think that bowing to anyone in a tiara is gonna fix things!" Lonnie erupted, hands in the air once more. "I can't believe Adora blew us off for that crap!"

"There was a magic sword, too," Rogelio pointed out. Lonnie groaned and slapped her forehead.

Scorpia went quiet for a moment. "You liked her too, huh?" the ex-princess asked.

Lonnie's sigh was explosive. "It was always her and Catra," she admitted. "I knew that. It's just...no one seemed more dedicated, more heroic, more...*everything* than Adora." She formed a trembling fist. "Until she betrayed us. I'm not Catra, letting love for that fraud blind me. We're gonna save her. We're gonna save Kyle. And we're gonna make Adora, the princesses, and that monster Angella pay for what they've done to us."

"That sounds great!" Scorpia cheered. "Any idea how?"

For a moment, Lonnie frowned again. *I wish I knew...* Slowly, a smile crossed her face. "Hey, if we capture Catra, can you protect her from Shadow Weaver?"

Scorpia rubbed the back of her neck. "Uh, probably, but how are we gonna capture Catra? She's fast, brilliant, clever, beautif – I mean, stealthy," the Scorpioni coughed.

"Catra can't do anything halfway," Lonnie replied. "Either she'll claw your face off, doesn't know you exist...or she'd jump into fire for you. Adora's too hard a target, but I'd bet a week's rations that Catra's gotten attached to at least one rebel. We find out who that is and go after 'em where Catra can see."

"Like with the kid," Rogelio added.

"Well, we don't attack a child, but otherwise, yeah." Lonnie rubbed her chin. "Catra seems like she's close with Angella's daughter, and that princess never met a fight she wouldn't jump into."

"But she can, y'know, teleport," Scorpia noted.

Lonnie's smile took on a smirking edge. "Not forever," she pointed out. "She's sharing the Moonstone with psycho-mom, remember?

Eventually, she runs out of fuel."

"And when Catra goes to rescue her–" Rogelio began.

"We rescue *Catra,"* Lonnie replied. "Once we talk some sense into her, we get Kyle back, take down Adora, get our people back, and win this thing once and for all."

Scorpia brightened. "That sounds great! Do you really think Catra will listen to us?"

Lonnie's smile vanished. "That's the real trick. Catra's as stubborn as Adora. It's gonna take something big to bring her around." Inspiration sent a chill down her spine. "Um. Scorpia? Do you think you can get me an audience with Lord Hordak? I've got an idea, but we're going to need the kind of leverage only he can bring to bear."

"Sure," Scorpia said with a nod. "What do you have in mind?"

"The craziest idea I've ever had," Lonnie admitted. "We're going to have to make Shadow Weaver act like a decent person."

"Oh. So what you're saying is, we're doomed," Rogelio quipped.

Lonnie was never sure why she laughed at that moment, but the other two joined in, so it wasn't all bad.

Chapter End Notes

> I wish I could give every character in the series some face time. I can't, but Lonnie is too cool not to give a moment to, and her dedication to the Horde makes her the perfect noble antagonist to set up disaster dominoes with the absolute best of intentions.

Interstitia: Love and War

Chapter Summary

> Catra and Mermista catch up on battle plans, sea food, and the dumb jocks they love.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra stood glaring at the war table, claws digging into her armrests. *Bast, I hate Vultak,* she snarled.

The winged general had stalled the Rebellion's advance. The Alliance had bottled up the Horde, but over a quarter of Etheria was still Hordak's, and even the power of the Princess Alliance wasn't enough to punch through that much concentrated firepower. Catra sighed. *I've gotta be patient. Entrapta, Kyle, and Bow are working on our tech. We're getting more defectors every week. Mystacor finally started assigning us sorcerers. We can win this. We* will *win this.*

"Wow. You are, like, so intense right now," Mermista quipped as she strode in.

Catra relaxed, claws retracting. "Hey, Misty. I'm just going over the map, looking for holes in the Buzzard's defenses. What about you?"

Misty grinned, waving her hand around. A column of water brought the magicat a swordfish platter with fried zucchini. "I bring an offering to the war goddess."

Catra didn't even bother trying to look cool, eyes wide and glittering as she dug into the meal. "What's the occasion?" she asked between bites.

"We just finished installing the Salineas defenses you ordered," Misty explained. Catra nodded as she chewed. "The ramparts and robo-mines are cool, but those cannons are my favorites. It's nice to see a Rebellion leader take our position seriously."

With a huff, Catra swallowed her bite of fish. "If Hordak conquers Salineas, he'll turn this whole thing around," she pointed out. "When I was still with the Horde, half my plans revolved around taking it."

To Catra's surprise, Mermista chuckled. "At least you respected Salineas, even then."

Catra surprised herself even more by laughing outright. "This is why I like you, Misty. You're almost as weird as I am." She sighed. "Hey, Mermista, there's something else I want to talk about."

"You didn't call me 'Misty.' It must be serious," the princess quipped.

"Sea Hawk," Catra sighed. Mermista's smile vanished. "You really need to talk to him."

Mermista groaned. "Ugh. Whyyy." She turned one sharp eye on the magicat. "If you're gonna tell me I owe him a date–"

Catra's eyes bulged. "NO! No, of course not, I was never *that* kind of bad guy!" Mermista glanced away. "Yeah, that reaction tells me you know what you *do* owe him. A straight answer."

Mermista sighed. "I knooow." She held her forehead. "I just wish I knew *what* to say to him.

Oh, Catra realized. "You don't know how you feel," she said. Mermista's head sank to the table. Her forehead dropped, hair cascading to hide her face. "Look, just tell him that. Be honest with him." She smirked, even knowing Mermista couldn't see it. "I mean, yeah, that's advice from the queen of bad relationship communication–" Mermista snorted a chuckle. "–but hey, lessons learned."

Misty put her hands over her head, still pressed to the table. "What do I even see in him?"

It was a truly heroic effort, but Catra fought back a smirk. *There we go,* she thought, leaning back in her chair. "Seriously, why don't you dump him?"

Mermista sat upright in her chair, glaring at Catra. "What."

"I'm just saying. What *do* you see in someone that ridiculous?" Catra put her hands behind her head and her feet on the table. "He's arrogant, obnoxious, conceited–"

"He's kind," Mermista snapped, standing, "he's considerate, and he's sweet."

Catra fought even harder not to smirk. *Hook.* "'Considerate'? That man never met a mirror he didn't love."

"It's an *act,"* Misty half-growled. "He's insecure. I thought you were the smart one."

"I am," Catra huffed. *Line.* She crossed her arms. "He sailed right at a sea monster when Adora, Glimmer, and Bow were on his ship."

"He'd beaten it before!" Mermista snarled, throwing her hands in the air. "He just–" The water princess froze. Catra smirked. *Sucker.* Misty glared at the ceiling, arms dropping. "Ughhh."

"Wow," Catra chuckled. "He's your Adora." Misty stared at Catra goggle-eyed. "He's a big, dumb jock with mad hero skills, a need to show off, and a heart of gold."

"Except you weren't a princess when you fell in love with her," Mermista sighed, dropping back into her chair. "Everyone wanted me to be Mermista the heir. My father only had me, and, like, you know what happens if the Horde takes Salineas." Catra's ears pivoted back, smirk vanishing. *oh.* Her tail twitched. Mermista bowed her head. "Sea Hawk was the only one who ever

saw...me.” She chuckled, but the sound rattled in Misty’s throat, like someone had choked her halfway through. “He asked me to run away with him once.”

“What happened?” Catra asked. *It couldn’t have ended well*– she thought.

“My father died,” Mermista whispered. Catra’s ears went flat. “I had to, like, run everything. Sea Hawk asked again. I kicked him out...and everyone left anyway, because the Sea Gate was falling apart. If She-Ra hadn’t shown up, you could’ve conquered Salineas with that one lame ship.”

Catra grinned, putting a hand on Misty’s shoulder. “Not a chance. A cat versus the water princess? Not to mention, one of our other guys was Kyle.” Misty blinked, then they both laughed. “Look, we can play the ‘what could’ve happened’ thing all day. I have literally seen the me who left Adora to die in the Crystal Palace,” she reminded Misty, smile slipping away. “The only person whose opinion matters on this is yours. If Sea Hawk really makes you happy, anyone who doesn’t like it can deal.”

Mermista gave Catra’s shoulder a little fist bump. “You’re okay, you know, cat princess?”

“Ughhh,” Catra groaned, burying her face in her hands. “I’m a princess.” Misty chuckled. “Seriously, I’m a *princess.* Who thought that was a good idea?”

“Like, you, apparently,” Mermista smirked. “You signed the adoption paper.”

“It was spur of the moment!” Catra wailed, leaning back into the chair. It was her turn to stare at the ceiling. “I’m a terrible choice for a princess!”

Mermista tapped one of the Horde defection camps on the war map. “You’re doing okay so far.”

Catra relaxed in spite of herself. “Thanks, Misty.” She grinned. “Hey, what do you say we plan a raid? Things have been way too quiet lately.”

Misty’s grin picked up a familiar edge. “Shadow Weaver or Vultak?”

“Vultak,” Catra cackled. “He has been *way* too confident since our offensive stalled. Let’s pluck a few tail feathers before Bowtrapta figures out where the Mara signal’s coming from.”

“I am, like, so down with that,” Mermista agreed as Catra grinned back. *This princess thing isn’t anywhere near as bad as I thought it’d be,* Catra admitted to herself, as the two sharp-edged princesses worked out a plan of attack. *Not that I’ll ever tell them that.*

Chapter End Notes

With the angst train coming full speed, I decided to take a previously-written fragment of Catra-Mermista fluff and turn it into a full-blown pillow before that happens. :-)

Also, this is me working out what Mermista might see in Sea Hawk, because seriously, I did not get that before writing this, and I kinda had to extrapolate from what we know happened in the timeline. Seriously, Mermista's playing it cool when we first meet her, but she just inherited Salineas when we meet her. That only happens one way.

Interstitia: Winged Shadows and Blood Lightning

Chapter Summary

Shadow Weaver learns that there's someone worse than her.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Shadow Weaver glared at the files. *This was not supposed to be possible,* she raged, crushing one page in her fist. The hungry parasite within her consumed it. *Catra should not have been able to embrace her skill as a leader until Adora was properly ensconced as Hordak's right hand. Her dependence was supposed to be absolute.* She hissed and stood, scattering another half-dozen pages with a sweep of her hand. *This was* not *supposed to be possible!*

No. Stop. Breathe, Shadow Weaver commanded herself. *I can salvage this. Hordak finds Catra's skill acceptable. Adora's attachment to her is at last an asset. Once we capture the beast, Adora will follow–*

Another magicat's laughter haunted Shadow Weaver. *"I know why you wear the ve-eil, Spinny," Kyra sang, leaning in close. Light Spinner sighed and waved for Kyra to continue. "Because who could focus on their lessons with such beauty in the room?" Her tail arched past her shoulder to waggle just beyond Spinner's nose.*

"Oh dear, you've learned my secret," she quipped back. "Whatever shall I do." Light Spinner brushed Kyra's tail out of her face. "Be serious, Kyra. This Horde is a real threat. We need to prepare Mystacor for the coming battle."

Kyra huffed and practically threw herself onto a couch. "That better not be our only hope. I like Norwyn and all, but if I hear him say 'Etheria will take care of itself' one more time, I'm going back to Halfmoon."

Light Spinner smirked. "And leave your studies half-complete? You couldn't abandon your passion if your life depended on it." They both laughed.

Shadow Weaver shook her head, casting off the memory. *Kyra is – gone. Her daughter will never remember her. Norwyn, Micah, all of them...all gone. All I have left is the Horde. If Mystacor's fools will not fight, this is the only way to preserve the magic.* She sighed, commanding the scattered papers to collect themselves with a gesture. *At least Hordak cannot be rid of me, now. He needs me too much to–* Some fool knocked. "Leave, before I turn you into a toad," she warned.

Vultak laughed. Shadow Weaver straightened. "Do the cadets actually believe such nonsense, Shadow Weaver?" he asked.

With a snarl, Shadow Weaver opened the door with a gesture. Vultak swanned in, smirking at the Black Garnet. "This had better be worth my time, Vultak," she hissed.

"Oh, it is," Vultak assured her. "Frankly, I expect Lonnie to make Force Captain for this new idea." Shadow Weaver scowled beneath her mask. *Adora's other pet. Her idea to share the Garnet with Scorpia has been...less of an obstacle than I imagined,* she admitted to herself. "Still, I cannot help but notice how wounded the Garnet looks. You keep carving off pieces, Weaver, and you'll have nothing left to drain."

"If you have some intention of getting near a point, make it and leave," Shadow Weaver snapped. "I have little patience for your faux-clever posturing."

Vultak's smirk only grew. "I assure you, Weaver, there is nothing false about my cleverness. How would you like to reclaim both of

your children?"

Shadow Weaver sighed. "That is the goal. All we lack is a viable plan. That's the part where all the work takes place, in case you were wondering."

Vultak's smug sigh was somehow worse than his smirk. "Oh, ye of little faith. Cadet Lonnie is confident that her squad can seize Catra by targeting her new 'sister,' Glimmer."

Shadow Weaver glared at the alien vulture. "'Sister?' What mockery is this?"

Vultak paced around the Garnet, letting his talons run lightly over its facets. "Queen Angella and King Micah adopted her, it seems–"

"MICAH?" Shadow Weaver gasped, then darted over to grab Vultak by his insipid collar. "You lie!"

Vultak laughed. "Who taught you to create shadow spies, Weaver? Alas, you could never get past the notion of using them as weapons. If you let a shadow be nothing but a shadow, it is much more difficult to detect. And the things one might learn...such as, say that Catra had Entrapta build probes to watch the world. That one of them found its way to Beast Island. That Micah survived there for twelve years, living on bugs and magic and hope. That your children rescued him with the archer boy and reunited him with Angella." His smirk vanished. "*My* Angella."

Shadow Weaver's eyes narrowed. "I want that wretched coward dead more than anyone, Vultak, but even I have limits."

Vultak snorted. "And that is why you fail." He glared at Weaver's fingers.

The parasite-shadows beneath her skin convulsed, as did her grip. Shadow Weaver recoiled, forced to release Vultak. He had not even moved. "Where was I – oh, yes, Micah. He teaches Glimmer and Catra as his own daughters, which they now are. They grow closer by the day." His smirk returned, redoubled. "Your magicat

has only ever wanted the love of a family. Adora is too difficult to properly endanger, but the daughter of Micah has her father's reckless courage. Young Lonnie means to use that to reclaim Catra through your – what was her word? Oh, yes, 'validation.'"

Shadow Weaver permitted herself a wry chuckle. "We're quite past that, I fear. Those cotton-hearted princesses have no doubt rained validation on Catra like a waterfall. I'm amazed she finds the motivation to spar, let alone fight."

Again, Vultak's smile vanished. "Great Prime, I thought you were posturing. Can you really be this idiotically blind?" Shadow Weaver grasped the magic before she could stop herself. "She will do anything to protect those she loves. You came so close to rotting out her heart inside her chest – impressive work, truly – but she is healing." The alien strode to her scrying bowl, waving his hand over it. Images of Catra and Glimmer appeared, laughing and playing some idiotic game while–

Oh, gods, it is Micah, Shadow Weaver realized, watching her greatest pupil play with the girls and Angella. All at once, she found the thought of dragging Kyra's daughter back to Horror Hall for discipline...less appealing than it had been.

The sorceress discovered, to her horror, that she still had a heart after all.

"Endanger Glimmer, and Catra will have quite enough *motivation* to defend her," Vultak explained. "Force Captain Scorpia and her squad will return her to the Fright Zone with our help. And then..." He waved over the bowl again.

It showed an image of Adora kneeling in the grass, reality itself coming apart around her. Catra's finger pressed against the prodigy's forehead. The magicat emerged from the shadows...except some of those shadows clung to her right arm, crawling up her face in jagged, broken lines. "What is this?" Shadow Weaver whispered.

“The world as it should have been,” Vultak explained. He pulled back his hand, and the image vanished. “I should still be in my tower, pacifying angry farmers, while Catra becomes a weapon beyond imagining. The Horde’s weapon.”

Shadow Weaver stared at Vultak, recoiling. “How can you know this?” she gasped, trying – and failing – to sound demanding.

“Because I am old, Shadow Weaver,” Vultak chuckled. His genuine smile was somehow worse than his smirk, promising unending cruelty to all he grasped. “I was already more than 600 when Hordak crashed here. He was no longer beloved in Prime’s sight, but I was. I was not some mere member of Hordak’s crew. I monitored him, directed him at Prime’s command. Did you think he stumbled across the homeworld of Prime’s greatest enemy by *accident?”*

Shadow Weaver processed this new information as Vultak continued. “I may not have Hordak’s technical prowess, but I was one of Prime’s greatest sorcerers. I contained the magic that He wished bound, and I am what we would call in the proper universe a skilled end-user. Catra is entangled with her other, more broken selves.” He held out his hand, and a shadow-Catra formed in his palm. Her eyes were bright with madness, in spite of the dark, and her smile was the embodiment of ruin.

“And?” Shadow Weaver asked. She managed to sound cold and calm, though she felt neither of those things in spite of herself.

“And there are Catras beyond our timeline who have fallen into cruelty and despair,” Vultak explained, “so utterly shattered that they are made of shadows. Our shadows.”

Shadow Weaver held her own hand over Vultak’s terrible model. *I see. There are countless ways we could use this creature against her,* Shadow Weaver deduced. “You mean to break our Catra’s will with this,” she muttered. Vultak nodded. “Why?”

Vultak laughed. “Because, Shadow Weaver, Cadet Lonnie’s plan is impossible. You are incapable of showing anything resembling kindness. For spite. you tortured the child of the woman you once loved. Even your favor is poison, and Catra knows this now.” Shadow Weaver held still to avoid letting him see a single tell. “Entrapta and She-Ra could both be useful, each in her own way,” the vampire continued, making the shadow-Catra disappear by crushing her in a fist, “but with Catra at our command, we can take them both at our leisure.”

Vultak strode towards the door, pausing just before it would have opened for him. “That is the great irony of what Catra has become. As an agent of the Horde, she would have sabotaged herself, trying to avoid harm even as she inflicted it. In the Rebellion, Catra has found a purpose that she does not war with herself against. Angella has healed Catra,” he continued, smile going shark-wide, “and that is how we will destroy them.” He left, laughing again as the door closed behind him.

Shadow Weaver stared at her bowl. *Can I do this?* she wondered, remembering her furious flight, Kyra’s desperate efforts to remove the parasite, Kyra’s horror when she learned that Shadow Weaver had joined the Horde. Rejection, abandonment, betrayal. That pathetic tomcat Kyra replaced Shadow Weaver with.

Yes, Shadow Weaver decided, gathering her resolve. *Yes, I most certainly can. Micah had his chance, and so did Catra.* She turned to the Black Garnet, gathering the blood-tinged lightning. *Now, I shall have mine.*

Chapter End Notes

Two posts in two days MOAR MADNESS! MOAR!

...and that sound is the angst train pulling into the station...

I know its really soap opera-y to have this bond between Shadow Weaver and Kyra, but the notion of SW wanting to *make* Catra into a person like her got stuck in my head,

and the rest just sort of...followed. To be clear, Shadow Weaver wasn't exactly lying about her explanation why she treated Catra the way she did, but she wasn't telling the *whole* truth..

Also, I didn't want to detail Vultak's origins until after Season 5, just in case Horde Prime had a Black Order of sorts, which - well, he didn't.

Interstitia: We Are Family

Chapter Summary

> Whatever challenges the Alliance may face, from a fictional war game to the revelation of Adora's origins, their bonds carry them through.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Micah cast spell after spell into the oncoming Horde forces. Shadow Weaver ignored him, slinking away with poor Catriska frozen in her arms. "Light Spinner!" he howled, unleashing a three-ringed circle of untrammeled force.

The Horde sorceress sighed and turned. "The Spell of Obtainment devoured Light Spinner whole," she told him, weaving a spell of lightning and darkness. "For the last time, I am Shadow Weaver." *She unleashed her magic. Micah parried it with his staff, countering with a burst of shimmering light. Shadow Weaver howled and recoiled.* This is my chance! *Micah realized, rushing towards his old teacher–*

The weight that came down on him from above slammed him to the pavement, staff skittering away. Force Captain Grizzlor growled a chuckle. "Not so tough without your toys, are ya, princess-lover?"

NO! *Micah raged, thrashing in a desperate bid to reclaim his staff – but Shadow Weaver reached out, and it flew to her hand. "Not this time, Micah," she hissed, his best friend's helpless daughter in one hand, his most powerful weapon in the other. "I can afford you no more mercy." She turned to Grizzlor. "Good work, Force Captain. Send word to 'noble' Queen Angella that her husband has been sent to Beast Island."*

Grizzlor sighed. "You're the boss," he huffed. "So what are we really doing with him?"

Micah could almost see the smile beneath her mask. "Why, sending him to Beast Island, of course." Grizzlor's face lit up with a sickening grin of surprise. "This is the end, Micah. The end of your pitiful little Rebellion..."

Micah sat bolt upright with a start. Angella woke in an instant, leaning over to hold his hand. "Micah? My heart?" she whispered.

Five things, Micah instructed himself, still shaking. *I see the bed. The starlamp. The dresser. The rug.* His heart rate slowed, Angella's hand in his. *Angie. She's here. She's real.* He turned and cupped her cheek in his hand. "You're here. You're real."

"Yes, Micah," she replied, sliding into an embrace. "This is me. Real. Here. With you. Forever, this time." Micah ran through basic Mystacor breathing exercises–

Kyra exhaled, tongue slowly extending to stick out at him. Micah burst into helpless laughter. The older student followed, human and magicat soon out of the breath they were supposed to be controlling. Micah rubbed his eyes. "I'm stuck in my head," he whispered, "in the memories."

Angella nodded and rose, heading for the dresser. "Children should be an excellent medicine."

Micah raised an eyebrow. "They're supposed to be asleep," he pointed out.

Angella turned, as radiant as the day they first met, and smiled. His heart didn't so much skip a beat as stop and stare with the rest of him. "And that is how likely, my love?" She smiled.

Micah couldn't help it. He laughed.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"Reaper holds his fists in the sky, shaking off the last of the ice," Catra described, grinning. "He growls, 'Curse you, Overwatch!' and jumps down his escape chute, Moira right behind him. Doomfist glares at the chute, then gathers power around his gauntlet. Widowmaker groans and tries to stand. The Talon soldiers gather around the ruins of the neural conditioner." She looked over the chart screen at the princesses (plus Micah and Bow). "What do you do?"

"Orisa uses Halt on the soldiers," Perfuma replied.

"Then Pharah, like, unloads on them with her rocket launcher." Perfuma looked at Mermista. "What? My Barrage is still on cooldown."

"Tracer grabs Widowmaker, then uses Recall to take them behind Winston. 'Amelie, come back,' she whispers," Glimmer said.

"Aww. That's sweet," Catra chuckled. "It's not going to be that easy, though."

"Well, I recall that Mercy has a device for this. Isn't that right, D.va?" Angella asked, smiling at Entrapta.

"Oh, that's me! Right, I join Mercy and plug the neural de-conditioner into her Caduceus Staff while Tokki stands guard with her Defense Matrix. 'Good girl, Tokki!' I encourage her," Entrapta joined in. Catra couldn't help a genuine smile.

"Brigitte leaps between Doomfist and Widowmaker, then activates her Barrier Shield. 'It's over, Doomfist,' she warns him, Rocket Flail flaring," Adora said, pointing out her exact route on the battle map.

"Doomfist glares at Brigitte, but it's clear that he's focused on Mercy and Widowmaker. 'It is not over,' he growls, 'until I say it is.' His gauntlet is almost at full power." Catra shook her head. *Even in a war game, you're like this, aren't you?*

Micah smirked. “I think it’s time we said goodbye to Doomfist. Genji emerges from the shadows – and slashes Doomfist’s namesake with Dragonblade!”

The others whistled. “Well, that certainly takes Doomfist by surprise,” Catra drawled. “You stopped his attack, but now the gauntlet’s going critical.”

“Well, that’s where Mei and Winston come in,” Bow replied, grinning, “‘Mei, cool Doomfist down a little!’ Winston shouts, blasting the big guy with his cannon.”

“Mei blasts him too, then creates an ice wall!” Frosta cheered, jumping in place.

“And that’s when Winston drops a Barrier Projector,” Bow finished.

Catra rolled a few dice behind the screen, ignoring the results with a smirk. “Okay. The Talon soldiers try to open fire, only to get interrupted by Orisa’s power and knocked out by Pharah’s attack. Doomfist tears off his gauntlet and retreats. The glove goes boom, and the wave...hm...yeah, it busts through Mei’s ice, then brings down Winston’s barrier, aaand...” She looked up and winked at Adora. The blonde blushed. “...rattles Brigitte’s teeth along with her shield. Lucky for you, nothing breaks.”

“What about Widowmaker?” Glimmer demanded. Angella smiled and put a hand on her shoulder.

“Right, her. I almost forgot,” Catra lied, chuckling as Glimmer seethed. Again, she rolled the dice, blinking at the results. *Huh. They did it.* Catra looked back up at her sister, Glimmer wavering between frustration and hope. *I guess the good guys get lucky sometimes. Thanks, Light Hope.* “Widowmaker shudders, blinks, and rolls onto her back. ‘Lena? Mercy?’ she asks, staring at you in confusion. ‘What happened to your uniforms?’”

“Tracer cheers, then sobs into Mercy’s shoulder,” Glimmer grinned. The others didn’t bother with playing their roles, just cheering and hugging.

"Okay, okay," Catra said, waving them down. "Now remember, next time we meet for mission planning, it'll be for a *real* mission."

"Like, we get it, cat princess," Misty quipped. Catra blushed, but as usual, only Adora could tell. "We promised, okay?"

"But we're gonna keep playing Overwatch, right?" Frosta grabbed Catra's shoulder. The magicat's eyes widened. *Wha?* Catra wondered. "Sure, we rescued Widowmaker, but the bad guys escaped! And Talon is still after Echo! And we still don't know what Null Sector is up to!"

"Whoa, slow down there, Frostbite," Catra demurred, hands up. "We've still got a real war to win." Frosta turned wide, shimmering eyes on her. *Oh, for–* Catra sighed while Adora and Glimmer smirked at her. "Look, we'll try to find some time for the raid on Maximilien's in a month or something, okay?" Frosta grimaced and nodded.

Perfuma giggled. "Perhaps when the war is over, you should become a storyteller," Petals suggested.

Catra huffed. "I'm going to explore," she insisted. "People are gonna tell stories about *me."*

Angella chuckled. "Yes, well, you can all concern yourselves with the war and its aftermath in the morning." Everyone else save Micah turned sheepish looks at her. "I rather doubt you all had nightmares."

"Catra and Adora both had them," Glimmer explained, "and I was up getting a snack, and I don't think Entrapta even sleeps–"

"While I am not inherently nocturnal like Catra," Entrapta added, crossing both arms and ponytails, "I am both more comfortable and more productive during evening hours. I do, however, require slumber."

"–and it just kinda snowballed from there," Glimmer finished, rubbing the back of her neck.

"Very well," Angella conceded. "Now, to bed with you. Go," she insisted. Bow, Perfuma, Mermista, Entrapta, and Frosta all left, waving with varying levels of enthusiasm. She then turned to her daughters and Adora. "As for you three...perhaps a sleepover is in order."

Glimmer's eyes lit up. Literally. "Mom, you're the best!"

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"Aaand...there!" Entrapta cheered, high-fiving Bow with one hair-hand. Adora smiled. Catra smirked. *I'm so glad Angella could come this time,* Adora mused, noting mother and daughter watching her holographic mentor go through one of Entrapta's "updates."

Light Hope flickered for a moment. Her features softened a fraction, becoming less angular, more human. "New data unlocked from project directives," she reported. Adora straightened. Catra slipped her hand in Adora's. "What is your query?"

Finally, Adora thought. "Can you tell me more about myself, or She-Ra?" she asked.

"No new data unlocked regarding She-Ra," Light Hope replied, flickering for an instant.

There was a pause while everyone waited for more. Light Hope remained still. "Hey, light-face, that was only half the question," Catra snapped. Adora almost giggled from nerves. *I'm glad she's still Catra,* Adora realized.

Light Hope's hesitation lasted a few seconds longer. "None of my unlocked data regarding Adora should be relevant. Is it not all in your own memory bank?"

"Oh!" Entrapta blurted. "Light Hope, organic neural storage is compromised at an early age. The cognitive networks are too undeveloped to retain storage in the first one to three years of life." She gestured to Adora. "If you have any data about Adora's

early years, particularly involving the Horde's acquisition of her, that would be helpful."

"Thanks, ET," Catra said.

"I see." Light Hope turned red for an instant, then switched back to normal. "Adora, you have used the access code 'Eternia' on multiple occasions, have you not?"

This is it, Adora realized. "Yes, I have. Is that a family, or a city, or a kingdom – does that have something to do with where I come from?"

"It is your home world," Light Hope explained. The others' jaws dropped, even Angella. "The home world of the First Ones, at the center of the universe."

"Wait, I'm a *First One?"* Adora gasped.

"Correct. The Horde stole you, turned you into one of their soldiers. I could not stop them," Light Hope continued. "So I watched, and waited for the day I could unite you with the Sword."

"The Sword," Adora whispered, drawing it with her free hand. Catra's grip felt like the only tether she had to the world. "Is that why the Horde – kidnapped me, took me from Eternia?"

Light Hope flickered again. "The portal...was not created by the Horde," she said, and the world seemed to drop out from under Adora. "Before your allies freed me from my protocols, my instructions were clear. I required a female First One to fulfill the destiny of She-Ra. Ideally, the subject would possess great magic potential. Only Hordak's inadvertent arrival in Despondos made that possible, and even then, I could only make a portal large enough to permit the smallest humanoid passage."

"You did this?" Adora gasped.

“Yes,” Light Hope admitted. “I...apologize. It is fortunate that I was able to resist my programming long enough to reunite you with the magicat champion, which in turn facilitated the efforts of Entrapta and Bow to liberate my consciousness. Otherwise, I would continue to manipulate you to unleash the Heart’s deadly potential.”

“So, wait, are the First Ones still trying to turn Etheria into a giant bomb?” Catra blurted. Adora pulled herself closer to her beloved, letting herself lean on Catra for once.

“That is a question with a non-binary answer,” Light Hope reported. “At the time I opened the portal, Eternia was embroiled in a civil war, led by First One monarchs on both sides. One side sought to redeem the mistakes of their ancestors, restoring peace and justice to the universe. The other wishes to reclaim the empire of old, usurping the Horde and conquering all before them.”

Entrapta’s eyes gleamed. “Fascinating.”

“Do – do you know about my family?” Adora breathed, looking at Light Hope in desperation.

“Nineteen years have passed,” Light Hope warned her. “At that time, however, you had parents, and a twin brother.” Adora couldn’t breathe. Catra held her, rubbing circles in Adora’s back, and Adora discovered she could, in fact, love Catra even more. “Your parents were King Randor and Queen Marlena of Eternos, leaders of the First Ones who wish to atone for the mistakes of their ancestors.”

Catra snorted. “Of course you’re an actual princess,” she quipped.

“Could they still be alive?” Angella asked.

“They were young, healthy, capable, intelligent, and charismatic leaders at the time,” Light Hope reported. “However, they also ruled a land coveted both by the Horde and the Evil Warriors. It is not possible to accurately calculate their odds of survival.”

Catra scowled. “Okay, gonna just ignore the whole ‘Evil Warriors’ thing for a minute there, but that’s the second time you’ve mentioned the Horde outside Etheria. They’re not just a Hordak thing?”

Light Hope flickered again. “The Heart of Etheria was devised as a weapon against the Horde. Their leader is known only as Horde Prime, an immortal being who fought the First Ones for thousands of years. Hordak is most likely an elite member of Prime’s clone armies.”

“Clones?” Entrapta gasped, smile growing. “I have so many questions.”

Adora swallowed. “Can – can we at least contact them, somehow? My...my mom and dad, my *brother,* let them know I’m alive somehow?”

“Due to Mara’s actions, opening a portal now would have devastating consequences. Perhaps with time and effort from your...friends, I could once again open a portal without endangering Etheria,” Light Hope explained.

Adora nodded, feeling as ghost-like as the hologram. “Thanks, Light Hope.” She barely heard Entrapta’s barrage of questions about the true Horde or the First Ones. “I...I don’t even belong here,” she gulped.

“That’s crap,” Catra huffed, giving Adora a shake. “You’ve been here since you were a baby. You’re as Etherian as the rest of us.”

“Indeed,” Angella agreed, striding over while Glimmer teleported into the hug. “And while I most certainly hope we can reunite you with your birth parents, I assure you, Adora, you do have a family here.”

Adora pulled Angella into the group hug. “Thanks,” she whispered.

Chapter End Notes

This was supposed to be fluff. FLUFF, dang it.

...well, it's still got a lot of sweet moments in it. You folks deserve 'em, too -- when I have time to write more of this stuff, it'll get dark for a while.

Interstitia: Scrambler

Chapter Summary

> In our last between-seasons short, Scrambler joins a chat with two and a half former Horde members and gets more than he bargained for.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Special K has joined the experiment

ET: Kyle, excellent, begin collating our data on extra-dimensional travel

SK: Why do I feel like you're trying not to put exclamation points on everything?

ET: Because you are observant

SK: Thanks? Anyway, I just finished helping Adept Mally with logistics and General Sunder with the latest recruits. I'm so glad we found someone trustworthy to vet other defectors.

SK: Also, they're cute together.

SK: Would it be redundant to mention how much I miss Rogelio?

ET: Yes, but that's okay, I regret not having more time with Bow and Catra, the sooner we end the war with the Horde, the sooner we can focus on our friends

ET: AND SCIENCE!

ET: Sorry, that was voice-to-chat

Scrambler has joined the experiment

ET: Needs work

SK: :-)

Scrambler: What is that symbol?

SK: It's a "smiley." Like a smiling face?

ET: Since we don't have expressions or tonal structure to provide visual context, Kyle thought text-art imagery might serve in its place

Scrambler: That is

Scramber: insightful.

SK: Thanks! Being in Brightmoon is so

SK: much kinder, than the Horde. I mean, I want Rogelio and Lonnie back, but I'm not afraid all the time. I feel like I'm not terrible at everything.

ET: Kyle we have talked about this, you are my lab assistant, and you help Catra with logistics, and you were helping with the Horde refugee camps until Sunder defected

ET: The Horde overvalued physical combat skills and undervalued all other areas of expertise

Scrambler: Yes, it has been a

Scrambler: notable failing of theirs. Based on recent intelligence, they might be attempting to correct this oversight.

SK: Maybe they found Catra's notes? I can't decide if that would be bad or not.

Wildcat has joined the experiment

Wildcat: Speak of the devil and she will appear. Muahahaha!

SK: Was that supposed to be scary?

Wildcat: Nah. It's just to be silly. I'm trying to get back in the habit of, y'know, fun.

SK: ?

Wildcat: Without pranking you, Kyle, relax.

Wildcat: And how could that not be bad?

SK: You had a lot of cool ideas for making life in the Horde better. Maybe if the Fright Zone wasn't so miserable, they wouldn't want to invade people as much.

Wildcat: Or they might just end up more loyal to Hordak. Y'know, the guy who slaughtered my people, and Scorpia's, and who knows how many others, and wants to put a boot on Etheria's face forever?

Scrambler: Entrapta has described you as conflicted in the past.

Scrambler: I take it you no longer feel that way.

Wildcat: Oh, I'm seriously conflicted about fighting most people in the Horde. A lot of them think they're the good guys, like Adora used to. I was actually one of the worse people in the Horde.

ET: Objectively untrue

Wildcat: Catra-2. Empirical evidence.

ET: Perhaps you would have become a less pleasant person had you remained there

ET: However, despite having been subjected to extreme stimuli discouraging you from showing kindness, you continued to do so

Wildcat: Well, if you're going to grade on a curve… ;-)

Wildcat: Okay, fun's fun, but I'm not seeing a lot of SCIENCE going on, am I interrupting?

ET: No, Kyle is collating our dimensional frequency data

SK: We're waiting for the numbers to cook.

Scrambler: "Cook?"

ET: I have trouble with metaphors too

ET: Kyle has set our computer systems to correlate the data, and we're now waiting for the results

SK: Like putting bread in the oven to bake. Cooking.

Wildcat: So, Scrambler, how long were you in the Horde?

SK: Catra!

Wildcat: Hey, if he wasn't, he'd be the only person in this chatroom who's not ex-Horde. No judgment.

ET: Technically, I was a prisoner with access to computers and tools.

Scrambler: On Etheria, approximately seven local years.

Wildcat: "On Etheria?" Wait, what?!

ET: *Local* years?

ET: I HAVE SO MANY QUESTIONS

Scrambler: You want to know what I am?

Scrambler: I AM A CLONE.

Scrambler: A clone of the Emperor of the Known Universe.

Scrambler: Unlike Hordak, I am a mere standard production model. One of billions.

Wildcat: Billions?

Scrambler: Yes. We are an officer corps to administer the thousands of worlds in Horde Prime's empire. Even my vast army of clone brothers constitute a mere fraction of the robot, drone, and subject-soldier forces of the true Horde.

Wildcat: Oh. Crap.

Wildcat: If Hordak could do

Wildcat: all the stuff he's done with a wrecked ship and a handful of survivors, the real Horde would walk over us in, like, an hour.

ET: How did you end up with your degenerative condition, then

Scrambler: Even Horde Prime's cloning process is not completely perfect. One clone in millions can develop

Scrambler: faults. Like my condition. Hordak suffered a lesser version. It is why he was cast out, and why I was assigned to him. We were sent to the front lines to die, caught between Eternos and Point Dread.

Scrambler: Instead, one of Point Dread's sorcerers banished us to Despondos, cut us off from the Hive Mind.

Wildcat: Wait, the what now?

ET: So you look like Hordak

Scrambler: Almost. My hair is dull gray, rather than the correct white or Hordak's blue. My eyes and teeth are their proper green. My

Scrambler: decay is more advanced. In my encounter suit, however, only my hair, eye, and tooth color would indicate any

difference.

Wildcat: So that's why you're hiding.

Scrambler: I am the only other surviving clone. Even with my

Scrambler: variations, Etherians have historically reacted to me poorly.

Wildcat: So done with that. Say the word and we'll extract you.

Scrambler: What?

ET: I believe "so done with that" is a euphemism

Scrambler: I understood that part. You cannot be serious, Commander Catra.

Wildcat: Not usually. About this? You better believe I'm serious.

Scrambler: I am in Horde-controlled territory. The only assets I can provide are available through this connection. You would be needlessly endangering yourselves to acquire a security risk.

SK: Helping our friends isn't needless, Scrambler.

ET: As Catra would say, we freaks have to stick together.

Wildcat: "Us" freaks, ET. ;-)

Wildcat: Entrapta gave you the "imperfection is beautiful" speech, right?

Wildcat: Hey, Scrambler, you still there?

Scrambler: I am. She did. I

Scrambler: acknowledge your willingness to assist me. I also cannot allow it.

Wildcat: Allow, my furry tail. Send us the coordinates.

Scrambler: No. I have never had

Scrambler: I do not have context for this relationship.

SK: It's called "friendship," Scrambler. Even in the Horde we had friends.

ET: I am new to it as well

ET: I like being friends with you, too

Wildcat: We're all broken things here. We survive by taking care of each other. Send. Me. The coordinates.

Scrambler: No. Transmitting frequency data package now.

Scrambler has exited the experiment

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Hordak shut down Entrapta's chat program, then unplugged the computer, then, just to be sure, reset all of the server's protocols. *Even Entrapta should not be able to trace that.*

He covered his face with one hand. The First Ones encounter suit he had constructed with Entrapta's assistance hummed with life that seemed more real than his own. *Were it not for the cover identity Vultak had devised, I might well have given myself away. I...desired a genuine conversation with them. What Lord Prime would think of such weakness...*

Water trickled between his fingers. He removed his hand from his face, staring at the droplets in alarm. *Tears? From ME?* Hordak swept the tools from his workbench with a roar. "I am no weakling, brought low by primitive emotions. I! AM! HORDAK!"

Imp giggled. "I! AM! HORDAK!" it repeated, darting away before Hordak could catch it.

I, am...screaming at myself. Hordak chuckled, though there was no humor in it. *Pathetic. I am reduced to kidnapping children so they can win the war I cannot.*

Horror and disgust warred within him. *Is that any different from how I had already conquered half of Etheria?* He grimaced, the slaughter in Halfmoon vivid in his mind. *How could I have been such a fool as to place Shadow Weaver in charge of so vital an operation?* He shuddered. *Is Catra right? Am I reduced to stomping a boot on Etherian faces, forever?*

Hordak shook his head. *No. Even outcast and lost, I serve Prime's light. I built a new Horde in His name. We bring civilization to barbarian worlds. We cast out the shadows, no matter the–*

"I like being friends with you, too."

Hordak froze. Slowly, he clenched a fist, crushing the hex driver he'd unthinkingly picked up. *–no matter the cost.* He dropped the broken tool, then walked over to his throne and claimed the Force Captain badge awaiting him. "Shadow Weaver," he barked. "Send Cadet Lonnie to my sanctum. It is time she received a promotion."

It does not matter. I was never made for friends.

Chapter End Notes

What can I say? As awful as Hordak is, what chance did he ever have to make his own decisions -- or even his own personality?

Not that it'll save him from Catra when she finds out. Even as a hero, there's no way she won't hold a grudge. At first.

Trivia: General Sunder and Mally are characters from the original 1985 She-Ra. I promoted Mally to sorceress because Mystacor is supposed to be part of the Alliance now, and it's past time I showed some of that.

Huntara

Chapter Summary

> The Best Friends Squad tracks down Mara's signal. Crimson Waste hijinks ensue.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra frowned at the sight of the lethal expanse before them. *The Crimson Waste. Not our best idea ever.* She sighed and looked over the double-wide skiff she'd insisted they ride. *Food. Water. Shelter.* Adora and Bow were chuckling over something, the blonde's annoying-yet-cute snort muffled by one hand. Entrapta was taking readings with a smile, ignoring the scavengers circling overhead. Glimmer and Catra shared a look. *Three idiots we have to keep from dying out here. At least my sister has a brain.*

The thought of having real family stiffened Catra's spine even as it softened her heart. *These dorks would've gone into the Waste with or without me.* She couldn't help grinning at Adora's loving smile. *I guess they're worth it.* She sighed. "Okay, listen up. We've got enough supplies for a week. That should be enough for us to get to the signal and back if nothing happens to the skiff. Why is that a problem?"

Adora raised her hand like a junior cadet. "'Never count on the enemy doing what you expect.'"

Catra chuckled while Bow and Glimmer shared smiles. "How about that? She can be taught. We've got plenty of fallback options, tech and magic, but we don't want to have to rely on them. So, I want everyone to be ready to survive in this sand pit, got it?"

They all nodded, even Entrapta. "Don't worry, Catra. We're the Best Friends Squad. We take care of each other," Bow reassured her.

"Good," Catra replied, scanning the horizon. "Because 'each other' is all...we...have?"

Just ahead of them, Catra spotted a structure built into a massive skeleton. "Catra, I'm detecting life forms ahead," Entrapta reported, looking at her pad.

Catra groaned. "Of course Hordak is wrong about the Waste. He's a shut-in who lives in his lab and doesn't know how to do anything."

"Except conquer half of Etheria," Glimmer grumbled as Adora brought them to a halt beside the skull.

Catra huffed a humorless laugh. "Fair," she admitted. "Okay, here's what we'll do. ET, lock her down. Bow, you stay with Entrapta. Glimmer, Adora, you're with me. Watch–"

Catra pushed aside the cloth to find a bar filled with some of the most dangerous-looking people she'd ever seen. She grinned. *Even better, less than half of them are humans. Bast, I think it's majority-carnivore in here.* The sight of a tiger-guy almost made her heart stop. *Not even close to the time,* Catra ordered herself. "Find a table," she told Glimmer. "Watch my back, but let me do the talk–"

Wait, just Glimmer? Catra turned to face her sister, only from Glimmer to stare past Catra, wide-eyes, and point at the bar. Fighting off a sense of impending doom, Catra turned. She stopped fighting it when she saw Adora standing on the bar, the blonde clearing her throat as her foot jostled one lizard-woman's drink. "Hello. Sorry to interrupt, um, but we're not from around here," she began.

Catra facepalmed hard enough to hurt, then dashed to Adora's side. Or, at least, ankles. "...and we were hoping someone would–" Catra yanked Adora off the bar in mid-speech, catching her yelping girlfriend before firmly planting her on a stool. "Catra!" Adora objected.

"Shush," Catra warned, then saw the goat and lizard women headed towards them. *Wonderful. Too late.* She turned and braced herself, returning glare for glare.

"You're outsiders," the goat-lady grunted.

Catra stepped between Adora and the two locals. "Wow," Catra drawled. "Did you figure that out by yourselves, or did the bartender draw you a map?" The goat-lady darted in to grab Catra's shirt. Catra spun her around and planted her face in the bar top. The lizard woman gasped, throwing off a cloak to reveal four arms. *But no claws,* Catra noted, displaying hers. The lizard hissed at Catra. Catra hissed louder. Both women backed off, scrambling away from Catra with wide eyes. They ran into a pair of legs like tree trunks.

Catra followed the legs up to find a woman built like someone had woven She-Ra and Scorpia together into a single person made of muscle. With speed that impressed even Catra, the lavender-skinned woman threw both attackers out through the skull opening. "There's only two rules in the Crimson Waste," she announced, folding her arms and looking down at Catra. One of her ears twitched in a disturbingly familiar way. "One, the strong make the rules. Two, don't annoy me when I eat." She counted the two rules on her fingers, then made a fist with that hand. "You're a long way from Halfmoon, magicat."

Glimmer and Adora gasped. Catra blinked. Then she laughed. "So, here's the thing. I've been intimidated by the best. Evil sorceresses, crazy overlords, immortal queens, living goddesses – if there's a big shot out there with a need to posture, I've seen it." Her smile vanished. Glimmer and Adora stared, eyes wide. "And it just – doesn't – matter any more." She slammed her hand down on the bar, dragging her claws along it to leave grooves. "One of you is going to tell me how to find something, then make some cash. A bunch of you are going to try to rob me, and I'll get to let off some steam. The rest of you will back off, and not wake up with half the teeth you started the day with."

Catra glared at the frog-guy failing to sneak up on her, and he scrambled away with a terrified croak. Another idiot pulled a knife on her from behind, so Catra threw her cloak in the lizard's face and grabbed the blade for herself. "So. What's it gonna be?"

Muscles stared for a moment, then laughed. "For a minute there, I was worried you were just gonna ask for help, kid. You can't trust anyone in the Crimson Waste."

Catra snorted. "I don't trust anyone I don't know." She sighed. "Okay. We're looking for a building. It's made of crystals shaped like spearheads, blue and pink and so shiny it hurts to look at."

Muscles raised an eyebrow. "And?"

"And it's not a complicated question," Catra groaned. "Just point, genius, and I'll figure it out."

"I thought you didn't trust anyone you don't know," Muscles pointed out.

Catra donned her most evil smirk. "Oh, I don't. Thing is, I'm a survivor. If someone double-crossed me, I'd live. And come back." A fox-guy tried to sneak up on Catra. She threw the dagger into the floor a centimeter away from his foot. He yelped and leaped away. "I hold grudges. Just ask my friends."

Muscles glanced over at Glimmer and Adora. They were both staring at the local strong woman, though in very different ways – Glimmer looked like she couldn't decide whether Catra or Muscles was scarier, while Adora was watching with a sparkly gaze.

At Muscles. She was getting all shiny-eyed at Muscles.

With fierce care, Catra packed away the sudden inferno of jealousy roaring through her. "If I stay here, you kids are gonna go out there by yourselves and get killed, aren't you?" Muscles sighed.

“That’s not the plan,” Glimmer began, “but yeah, probably.” Catra turned to argue–

–but Muscles twirled a compressed combat staff that looked strangely familiar and holstered it. “Looks like you just hired a guide,” she announced. She pointed her thumb at her chest. “Huntara.”

Catra glared back and forth for a moment. Adora was still staring in awe. “Catra, Glimmer, Adora.” the magicat replied, pointing out each of them. “Let’s go.”

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora tried to focus on the skiff humming beneath them, the desert flowing beneath them even at one-tenth speed, but all she could think about was Huntara. *There’s something so familiar about her,* the blonde mused, watching the warrior as their guide kept an eye out from the prow. Bow steered them forward at a tenth the skiff’s top speed. “So, for a place that’s supposed to be uninhabitable, the Crimson Waste sure is...habited.” Catra groaned. Adora blushed.

“The Waste takes in all sorts.” Huntara glanced at Catra for a moment. “People run from all kinds of things. Guards. Raiders. Princesses.” Fortunately, Catra didn’t seem to notice.

“The Horde?” Adora asked.

Huntara growled. “The war will destroy every idiot fighting in it.”

Catra snorted. “What did you run from?” she asked. Adora gulped. *That was mild for Catra. I just hope Huntara–*

The burly warrior spun, popping open her sharpened staff. “Huntara doesn’t run from anything,” she snapped, stabbing the sand as they hovered past. She pulled back a bug the size of her forearm. “Got it? I *like* it here.” Huntara then proceeded to eat the bug raw, turning to face forward again.

Glimmer and Bow gulped. Catra crossed her arms and sat. "Huntara also speaks in the third person when she's rattled," she muttered. "Someone's trying too hard." Catra glanced at Entrapta, who tapped merrily at her pad with one hand and twintail while the other tail curled around Bow's waist and her free hand gripped the railing.

Is that– Adora recognized the quicksand ahead. She hoped. "Wait," Adora called. Catra held up a fist, and Entrapta brought the skiff to a halt. She scooped up a rock and tossed it into the lighter sand. It sank with a soft burble.

That elicited a rare, tiny smile from the warrior-woman. "Huh. Not bad, Blondie."

Adora grinned and crossed her arms to hide her relief. "What can I say? I'm a fast learner."

Huntara chuckled. "Cocky. I like that," she said. Adora all but glowed with pride.

Catra huffed. *Huh? That sounded annoyed.* Entrapta reached out to probe the sand with one twintail. "The skiff should be able to manage over fluids that thick," she muttered.

Huntara's smile spread a fraction. "Most tech stops working here pretty fast," she noted. "You kids'll do well here with a little time."

Adora shuddered. "No thanks. This has been an awful, sand-filled day." She smiled back at Huntara. "I don't know what we would've done without you." For a moment, Huntara's smile was a genuine, fond one. Then she huffed and turned to face ahead once more. *That's it. Catra! She reminds me of Catra.* Adora's own smile widened. *No wonder I like her.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Glimmer turned a worried glance on her sister as Catra's claws left grooves in the skiff railing. *Oboy.* She flashed some side-eye at Adora, but the heroine was still facing ahead. *At least she's not*–

"Glimm." Catra's tail lashed and her arms shook. In spite of everything else, Glimmer's heart filled with joy at the diminutive. *She really feels like a sister now,* Glimmer thought, but the happiness vanished at the sight of Catra's frustration. "This is the part where you tell me I'm seeing things, right?" Catra whispered. Glimmer gulped.

Bow blinked at them. "Seeing what?" he asked.

"Adora flirting with Huntara," Glimmer hissed.

Catra's eyes flew wide. "Wait, I'm *not* seeing things?" she whispered. Her ears shot upright and her tail lashed.

"Glimmer, there's no way Adora would do that to Catra," Bow blurted, the shock clear in his voice.

"Bow! Shh!" Glimmer demanded. Then he tried to shush her, which spiraled for several seconds until Catra's growl froze them solid. Entrapta glanced between them, twiddling hair ends like nervous fingers.

"It's fine," Catra snapped. They both stopped and stared at her. *Wait, what?* Glimmer wondered. "Adora'll learn soon enough. Right now, you two be ready. This whole desert's a death trap."

Catra stared into Glimmer's eyes as if trying to make her understand something through sheer willpower. "Well," Bow added, clearing his throat, "we kinda are going the wrong way–"

Catra's tail slapped against his mouth. "Just. Be. Ready," she insisted. Then Catra leaped off the skiff and vanished like she'd turned into sand.

"We're here," Huntara announced. Glimmer groaned at the tunnel of rock spikes ahead of them – too narrow for the skiff.

"I'll wait with Susan," Entrapta said, patting the skiff. Glimmer sighed.

It only took a few moments to get through the dangerous-looking tunnel. On the other side was a what looked like an arena dug into the ground, with a slanted rock in its center. "A sundial?" Glimmer asked.

Adora nudged the rock with her toe, looking around in frustration. "This can't be the center of the Crimson Waste. There's nothing here. There *has* to be–"

A little whuff, like someone cleaning out a pipe, echoed from the ridge. Catra's – *I think she calls it scorch-ice* – roared to life around them, blocking...a small dart?

Huntara gasped, then snarled, pulling out her compressed staff. Two more shots flashed out at Glimmer and Bow, only to be stopped by more scorch-ice. "It's a trap!" Glimmer cried, grabbing Adora and Bow and teleporting them back to the tunnel entrance.

"What? How?" Adora blurted, grabbing the Sword. Huntara moved with incredible speed, almost grabbing Adora's wrist–

"Freezefire!" Catra howled. A jet of ice-cold flame as thick as Huntara's arm roared at the older woman. Huntara gasped and leaped back, a moment's terror flashing across her features. The same cry sent walls of the sapphire flames burning through the opposite side of the arena. Four goons from the wasteland bar yelped and fled the frigid inferno, small tubes shattering in their wake. Catra emerged from the eruption with a wide, feral smile as the goons rushed to their leader. "Hey, Huntara."

"Clever, magicat," Huntara snarled, expanding her spear-staff, "but you can't beat us!"

"For the honor of Grayskull!" Adora cried, transforming into She-Ra. The wastelanders stared, in awe or horror, Glimmer couldn't say.

As grateful as Glimmer was for the rescue, Catra's mirthless laugh burned Glimmer's heart like the Freezefire. "Please. Even if you were right, Adora could beat you by herself now." Catra leaped all

the way across the opening, landing by the goat-goon. “But you’re wrong. You see, there’s only one rule in the Crimson Waste.” Catra’s smile transformed into a deadly snarl. “And we make the rules now.”

Huntara pointed the spear at Catra. “Prove it,” she snapped.

With a roar that shook the Waste, Catra leaped.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

It was as if she’d never joined the Rebellion.

Even after almost a year of friendship, kindness, family, and love, it had taken a single skiff ride to tear open every wound in Catra’s soul. *Good thing these goons are creeps,* Catra thought, smashing through Huntara’s gang with blazing ice and chilling flame. She knocked out the lady with the metal claw while Bow tangled the goat-lady with a net arrow. Glimmer went after the lizard with two arms, while the one with four arms tackled Adora. *That won’t slow Adora down long,* Catra decided, turning her attention to Huntara.

The muscle-woman smirked, slashing at Catra with her staff. Catra wiped the smirk off her face by sliding under it, and her, leaving frozen claw marks on both of Huntara’s legs. Huntara yelped and stumbled back, spinning the staff in a standard Horde defense whirl. “Freak,” she hissed.

Everything went red. Catra screamed, turning into a blur of claws and blue flame. Huntara managed to deflect most of her attacks, but Catra’s barrage left her on the defensive. She managed to strike home with a few bursts of flamefrost. “The deadliest freak you’ll ever fight, Dumbtara.”

The two circled, Huntara holding the spear low for a thrust. “You’re not even going to change shape?” Huntara grunted. “Are you mocking me, magicat?”

Catra scowled. “I don’t shape-shift,” she explained, frostflame in one hand and scorch-ice in the other.

Huntara blinked. “You can throw Freezefire but you haven’t been through the most basic Halfmoon rites? What kind of magicat are you?”

“The kind you should never have screwed with,” Catra hissed.

Huntara snorted. “You don’t even know what this is, do you?” she asked, giving the weapon a brief shake.

Catra sneered. “No idea–”

Catriska laughed. “Again, Uncle Percy! Again!

Sir Percival laughed back, playing with the compressed hilt. “Well, if my favorite niece insists,” he quipped.

“That’s cheating. I’m your only niece,” Catriska noted with a pout. Kyra smiled and hugged her daughter.

Catra barely dodged Huntara’s thrust, though Adora spoiled her aim with a body-check anyway. Both women gasped at the crimson static Catra knew had played atop her head. “It’s a claw sword,” Catra whispered. Huntara froze. “It’s a sacred weapon of Halfmoon, borne only by knights and champions. And it *doesn’t belong to you.”*

Huntara grimaced, hiding her emotions behind a glare, but Catra could smell the sudden spikes of guilt and terror. “Then come and take it,” she dared.

Catra sprang, whirling and slashing. Predictably, Huntara slashed back, but when Catra parried the blade with her claws, Huntara spun the blunt end around to catch her in the ribs. Catra smirked anyway, running flamefrost down the metal as she tumbled back. Huntara hissed and shook out her cold-rimed hands. “What’s the matter, Dumbtara? Not enjoying this?” Catra mocked, laughing.

Huntara snarled and swung again, missing by half a centimeter. “Are you?” she snapped.

"Oh *Set* yes," Catra retorted with a diabolic smirk. Huntara's bravado vanished, fear bubbling up into her expression again. "I'm going to rip out your eyes and make earrings out of them. And I'm going to enjoy *every – single – second."*

Adora gasped. Catra froze. With a fierce roar, Huntara charged again. *Bast bite me. Why do I let Adora live drill-free in my head?* Catra wondered, twisting her foot in the sand. A sheet of scorch-ice flared out, and Huntara slipped, slamming backwards with a satisfying crack. "Lucky for you that my – that Adora is a sucker for escaped Horde scum."

"Catra?" Adora whispered, the four-armed woman squirming under one boot.

Huntara glared at the magicat. "You gonna finish it or what?"

Glimmer scoffed. "Catra wouldn't kill you because Adora flirted with *you."*

Adora gaped. "What? NO! I wouldn't – I didn't – I'd never!"

Huh. Catra couldn't help a faint grin as she shook her head. "Even the ambush pissed me off worse than that." She glared at Huntara. "This is about her helping destroy Halfmoon."

They all gasped at that, even the wastelanders. Huntara looked away. "I didn't," she whispered. "Yeah, I was there. I even thought we were heroes, at first, just like Hordak said. Then I watched your people throw themselves against the largest army Etheria's ever seen to protect their home. I heard Shadow Weaver order us to die. By the *hundreds.* One magicat obliterated my entire platoon when they charged the gate. Just one. I wanted revenge until I saw her die protecting a single child. I saw the witch kidnap that child for saving the magicat princess. Poor thing couldn't've been more than five." She shrugged. "There were plenty of claw swords lying around. I grabbed one and ran." Huntara glared at Adora. "There you go, Blondie. That's my big heroic origin story. I saw what happened at Halfmoon, and I ran."

Catra's ears shot up and her tail stuck out. "Wait, Shadow Weaver captured another magicat?"

Glimmer slapped her forehead. "She means *you,* Catra. That was you."

Catra was too shocked for snark. Fortunately, so was everyone else.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora stared at the open door in Mara's ship, trying to contain the storm of emotions roaring through her. *This is where Mara went crazy. I'm in a First Ones ship that might tell me what's going on. We could set off some dangerous super-weapon they left behind. Huntara's on our side now. On top of everything else, Catra and Glimmer think I was flirting with Huntara!* She gathered her wits–

–but not fast enough, because Entrapta rushed ahead, cackling with joy. Catra gasped and raced to follow her. The others had little choice but to head after them. Fortunately, the rest of the ship was just as empty as the part they'd entered. Only the final chamber had anything recognizable, and that was a single chair. Entrapta, of course, was already tapping at something on the armrest. A hologram appeared with First Ones writing on it. "Aha! The signal!" the genius gushed. "There has been some storage degradation, but I think, with a little work, I can bypass the missing circuits."

"It's different this time," Razz said.

The others all yelped, even Catra and Huntara, whirling on the old woman before realizing she was...an old woman, carrying a freshly-made pie. "What – who – where did she come from?" Catra demanded, fingers twitching, but her claws didn't come out.

"Oh, I see! You're Adora!" Razz laughed. Then she turned to, well, Adora. "Well, no. You're Adora." She looked back at Catra and smiled. "You're C'yra."

Catra facepalmed hard enough to flatten her fur and growled. "I am not She-Ra! My name is Catra."

Adora chuckled. "You get used to it. She's been calling me Mara for as long as I've known her."

Razz huffed loudly enough to break Catra out of her funk. "I remember, you get to talk to Mara now. Sooner is better, yes. C'yra – wait, you're Catriska this time."

They all stared at the old woman. Catra's eyes were as wide as Adora had ever seen them. "You – you know my real name?" the magicat whispered.

"Oh yes, dearie," Razz replied. "I could never forget the first one before the First Ones." She laughed again, warm and carefree. "You come from Etheria. You all come from Etheria. Before the Runestones, before the Whispering Woods, even before Madame Razz. That's why they want to hurt C'yra, but love is always stronger than pain, in the end. You, hair princess," she said suddenly, turning to Entrapta. "You need to help Mara. Adora must speak with her."

Entrapta drew herself up. "No need to get huffy," she insisted, then threw herself into her magic science stuff.

It took less than a minute for a blue image of Mara to appear before the chair. "Adora." They all turned and stared. Mara looked battered, wounded, exhausted, but still she stood. "I know you're there. Razz said you would be."

Adora gasped. "Mara?" She reached out for Mara, but before they could touch, Mara fell back into her chair.

"I don't have much time," Mara said, then told her story. Her belief she'd failed. Her fear of – and for – Light Hope. The truth about the Heart of Etheria. The purpose they'd turned She-Ra to. Why they were in Despondos. How the weapon had become dangerous, unstable. "Razz told me about your friend. Stay with her, no matter what." The image flickered. "You need each other,

more than you can...” Mara wiped away a tear. “Adora, I believe in you. You can save the world we love.”

The image vanished. “The weapon...” Adora gasped. “The weapon is Etheria.”

Razz smiled through tears. “She was brave, my Mara.” The old woman put the pie on the chair. It seemed sacrilegious to touch it.

Catra shuddered once, then walked out.

Adora felt paralyzed, her blood colder than frostflame. Huntara exhaled. “Go talk to her, Blondie. She’ll understand.”

Glimmer appeared in front of Adora. “You really weren’t flirting with Huntara?” she demanded.

“No! She’s just so – cool, like Catra, but she fights like I do!” Adora held her head in one hand. “I thought if I could be more like that, Catra would – would like me better,” she trailed off, head drooping.

They all stared for a moment. “That is extremely illogical,” Entrapta replied. “On multiple occasions, Catra has expressed a deep emotional attachment to the person you are. Why would she want you to be different?”

Adora stared at Entrapta for several seconds. Then she grabbed her head with both hands and groaned. Glimmer chuckled. “Are you gonna be okay, Adora?”

“I think so,” Adora sighed. “I’m just – this thing with Mara, and Razz, and whatever is going on with that ‘C’yra’ thing...I really need to apologize to Catra.”

“Then go,” Bow insisted. “We’re not going anywhere.”

“Thanks, you guys.” After a quick hug, Adora hurried after Catra. It didn’t take long – her love was standing at the door to the next

room, claws embedded in the crystalline metal bulkhead. "Um, Catra? Is – are we – can we talk?" she babbled.

Catra sighed. "I guess we have to, huh?" the magicat replied, turning slowly enough to churn Adora's insides.

"I'm sorry," they blurted as one. Both sets of eyes widened. "*You're* sorry?" they both asked.

After a moment staring, Adora and Catra laughed together. "You first," Catra chuckled, rubbing the back of her neck.

"I wasn't thinking," Adora muttered, wilting. "I was trying to impress you while you were keeping us alive, and all I did was hurt you." She pressed her hand against her eyes, almost literally holding back tears. "I swore – I *promised* myself – that I wouldn't neglect you again after Shadow Weaver, and I just–"

"Stop," Catra insisted. "You wanted to *impress* me, and I jumped to conclusions. Everyone's been great to me for almost a year, after I did horrible things, and I turned back into a monster after one day–"

"Catra!" Adora gasped, hand falling away. "You have every right to be upset about Halfmoon. Sure, if you'd done any of those things you said..." the blonde gulped, rubbing an earlobe. "...but you didn't. And you didn't jump to conclusions, you talked to Glimmer!"

"All she had to do was not deny it for me to almost lose my mind. I ignored Bow, and almost turned on you!" Catra snapped, half-snarling past her tears.

"Oh, yeah, saving us from being kidnapped while I walked into an obvious killzone like Kyle on half rations," Adora retorted, "that was just terrible."

They stared at each other for a moment, then laughed again, both princesses bordering on the hysterical. "What's wrong with us?" Adora asked, wiping her eyes with the heel of her palm.

Catra shook her head, tail coiling around Adora's wrist. It was as much her home as Brightmoon. "Let's blame Shadow Weaver."

"Let's blame Shadow Weaver," Adora agreed.

They paused. "So," Catra sighed. "Are you okay with this Mara stuff?"

Adora sighed. "Not even a little," she admitted. "I...Light Hope said she went crazy, but Mara saved us all. What does that mean?" Adora shook her head. "I thought Light Hope was on our side now."

"ET says they're still working through the programming stuff their empire used to mess Hope up," Catra reminded Adora, taking her hand. The purr she felt through her arm was better than any medicine. "Light Hope the person is on our side. Light Hope the machine is screwing with her head." She nudged Adora with a shoulder. "Come on. I'll bet Entrapta learns all kinds of cool stuff from this place."

"Thanks, Catra." Adora let Catra lead her back to the bridge. "Razz and Mara are right. I don't know what I'd do without you."

Catra snorted. "As long as it's because – because I matter to you, and not that I'm part of some dumb destiny or anything."

Adora smiled at her. "I love you. Nothing will ever change that." Catra's half-scowl melted, and they seemed pulled toward each other, like magnets...

"Adora! There's a slot for your sword here!" Entrapta reached out with a hair tendril, yanking the First One over to the console. Adora yelped, looking helplessly at Catra. Her love snickered, the traitor.

"Okay, okay, keep your goggles on," Adora sighed, drawing the sword. *At least we're done with the drama for a while,* Adora hoped.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Lonnie grinned as Scorpia checked over Tung Lashor – just thinking his name almost got her laughing again – as his eyes swirled and his tail curled up. “Oh, gosh, are you okay?” she asked, scratching her hair. “You’re not allergic, are you? Man, we should’ve brought some anti-ven...anti…the stuff that makes poison better.”

“Okay!” Lonnie punched one fist in the air. “Who’s the strongest in the Crimson Waste?”

Callix got it immediately. “Scor-pi-a. Scor-pi-a! *Scor-pi-a!”*

In seconds, the entire Lashor Gang was chanting along with their squad. *“Scor-pi-a! Scor-pi-a! Scor-pi-a!”*

“And don’t you forget it!” Lonnie grabbed the sleeveless jacket Lashor had thrown aside and offered it to Scorpia. Rogelio helped her put it on.

Scorpia’s eyes seemed to sparkle in the evening sunlight. “You guys are the best,” she gasped. “How do I look?”

“Amazing,” Lonnie insisted. Rogelio added a thumbs-up. “So what do we do now, boss?”

“Now?” Scorpia’s smile melted into a look of determination Lonnie had only ever seen on Adora before. “Now, we rescue Catra, stop Adora, and save Etheria.” She looked around, and Lonnie realized that whatever other stuff Scorpia had trouble understanding, she knew an army when she saw one. “Now, we make sure the Horde wins, once and for all.”

Chapter End Notes

> I wanted Catra to take over the Crimson Waste again, but it really didn't fit the episode naturally, and Scorpia deserves more moments of awesome. Besides, taking on Huntara ought to be badass enough for any hero.

Next time, it's Angst O'Clock. I'm trying to avoid major cliffhangers, so most of the rest of the season after the next episode is going to do some serious jumping around to backfill the way I skip to the Main Event. FYI.

The Price of Power

Chapter Summary

What will a desperate Horde do to win?

PLEASE NOTE THE NEW TAGS: Trigger warnings for Self-Harm and Self-Hatred (the latter of which really should have gone on here a while ago, but Catra Gets Into It this time). Also note, however, that even this lone chapter has Angst With A Happy Ending.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It all happened so fast, Adora wept, clinging to Swift Wind's neck.

"Ugh! What is with you Horde scum?" Glimmer demanded, the others fighting off a serpent-themed gang while Scorpia, Lonnie, and their squad charged at her.

Catra snorted, slammed a lizard-guy Adora didn't recognize into Dylamug, then planted her foot in Lonnie's face and tossed her aside. "Hey, Lonnie," Catra drawled. Her smirk vanished when Scorpia rushed in front of her, arms outstretched. "Snaps," Catra whispered.

"Wildcat," Scorpia whispered back.

Adora scanned the ramparts below. "They're ready for a fight," she noted, shivering.

"It'll be okay, Adora," Swift Wind insisted. "They're not ready for *us."* Adora glanced behind her, where she could just make out the Rebellion forces waiting for her signal. Angella was there with her husband and most of the Princess Alliance. General Sunder commanded half the Horde defectors. Castaspella led two dozen

sorcerers. Huntara quietly gathered her mix of Rebel and Waste irregulars. Adora nodded, not quite believing herself.

"You don't have to do this, Scorpia," Catra insisted. "We–"

She-Ra almost missed the tiny click past the dozen goons she was fighting. She didn't miss Catra's eyes go wide, then her body collapse into Scorpia's claws. "Sorry, Wildcat," Scorpia replied as shadows swirled around them. "You'll understand later." Before Adora could even move, the shadows swallowed the squad, and they were gone.

It all happened so fast...

"Okay, so, we're here," Swift Wind noted, circling the main gates. They hadn't even bothered pointing the cannons up at them. "You said they'd all know the signal."

Adora's mouth flattened into a grim line. "Yep." She drew the Sword, then leaped off Swift Wind's back, ignoring his scream. "FOR THE HONOR OF GRAYSKULL!"

Entrapta had been right that changing mid-fall didn't affect how much force she hit the gates with. Adora was right about the Horde's reaction to She-Ra tearing through their most heavily-defended barricade like Sea Hawk saber-riding down a sail. With a slash and a punch, She-Ra sent the ruined masses of steel flying in separate directions. "Where's Catra?" she asked.

A barrage of tank fire answered her. Adora deflected the blasts with her shield, then formed a lasso and smashed the tanks together. Behind her, the rebels cheered a battlecry and charged. Grizzlor roared and leaped at She-Ra, so she slapped him aside. He flew through the smoke billowing from the tanks and ramparts, vanishing. "I *said,* where's *Catra?"* Adora demanded.

Shadow Weaver emerged from the darkness, flowing towards her like a Crimson Waste serpent. "A*do*ra," she crooned. "You–"

One swing of the Sword sent a cascade of roaring magical light at Shadow Weaver, throwing her back. "One more time: Where. Is. *CATRA?"* Adora roared.

Hordak flew overhead – and even Adora was forced to absorb that he was flying, using beam-jets from his back – then landed on their largest tank. "You will have your answer soon enough, traitor," he growled, while the entire might of the Horde aimed itself at her, "but first, I believe it is time to put an end to your primitive, pathetic rebellion. Attack!"

Glimmer teleported right into his face, punching him with a blazing fist. "'Attack?' Sure!" Then Angella raced overhead, carrying King Micah and most of the Princesses on a platform, and the battle turned into chaos.

Adora charged at Hordak, only for Vultak to dive towards her. Angella *slammed* into Vultak, light and darkness waging vicious war on each other as the two vanished behind smoke. Shadow Weaver reappeared, sorcery gathering around her hands until Micah blasted her back with his staff. The two were already drawing circles at one another. Styrax stooped towards Micah, only for Glimmer to teleport in front of him and blast him the other way. Grizzlor emerged to aim a shoulder cannon at Glimmer, only for Mermista to knock him aside again while Entrapta grabbed the weapon and laughed. Octavia leaped at Mermista, running headlong into Frosta's ice wall. A sorcerer Adora didn't recognize drew a circle at Frosta only for Castaspella to make it erupt in his face.

From there, the chaos only grew. Adora and Hordak circled one another, each aiding their own forces while trying to reach each other. She-Ra carved through bots and tanks, swatting soldiers aside. Hordak's armor *changed,* twisting and shifting to deal with minotaurs, sorcerers, and even a wave of Frosta's ice. *I wish Perfuma and General Juliet were here,* she thought, not for the first time, *but someone has to defend Brightmoon while–*

A blur of darkness threw Bow aside. Then it appeared behind Micah and struck him in the back. It formed over Angella and wrapped around her, nearly forcing her to crash.

Adora was still turning to help her friends when the void formed in front of her, punching her in the gut. She hopped back and held up the shield – and froze.

"Heeey, Adoooraaa," Catra warbled, smirking.

Except it was more like a charcoal drawing of Catra, an emptiness with an outline of her body and right eye. Only the left eye was truly Catra, was *her* Catra, wide and brimming with tears. The problem was, Adora knew. She knew that the void was also Catra, was still Catra – the woman she loved, echoing with grief and pain She-Ra could feel pulsing from her in waves. "Catra–"

Catra didn't move. It wasn't even teleportation, at least not like Glimmer flowing through magic. Reality tore in an instant, and Catra was behind Adora, grabbing She-Ra's hair and throwing her to the ground. *"Catra? Yeah.* Your *Catra?"* The void flickered around them both, so fast Adora thought she'd blinked, and Catra slammed She-Ra into a tank turret. *"Never."*

She-Ra stood on shaky legs, the still-moving tank rumbling beneath them. Catra grabbed her again, this time transporting them to the Fright Zone ramparts. Adora found herself face down, Catra's foot on her back. "Please, Catra, you can fight this, I know you can."

Catra snorted. *"Oh, she is."* Catra leaned over and pulled Adora's head up by her hair. *"It won't work. I'm the* real *Catra. She can't beat me."*

Adora blinked away tears, She-Ra's power wavering. "I don't understand." A glance told her the battle was turning against the Rebellion. Heat bombs drove back Mermista and Frosta. Fire teams shot tangle-webs into Netossa's nets, neutralizing them. Sonic blasters harried Spinnerella. "Why are you doing this?"

"Remember the Catra from that other timeline?" Adora gasped. *"I'm like her, but not stupid!"* Another shift, right into cannon fire. She-Ra screamed, flying backwards. *"I opened Hordak's portal, and we could have had everything if you could just stay for once!"* Adora tried to regain her bearings, but Catra grabbed her again, and they shifted above Angella's battle with Vultak. Adora turned to help, but the eruption of light and dark sent her flying.

Angella gasped. "Adora!" she cried, rushing to She-Ra's aid, but Vultak took advantage of her distraction to tackle her and drive her to the ground beyond Adora's sight.

"No!" She-Ra cried, rushing towards the queen.

Catra appeared in front of Adora, stopping her with a shin-kick to the gut. *"I burned, Adora. My whole world burned! It's nothing but a void, and I'm only here because of Shadow Weaver magic. SHADOW WEAVER! But now, I can save it. All I have to do is give your stupid rebellion to Hordak, and he'll give me everything."* She smiled at Adora, mad and broken. *"This is where you tell me it's all my fault. Where you didn't do anything. Go on, tell me again. I love this part."*

She-Ra frowned. "Your Adora is an idiot," she said. Void-Catra gasped, smile vanishing. "She – I – defended your abuser, ignored your pain, and left you when you needed me most. But it doesn't have to be this way. My Catra's helped me become smarter, wiser, better." Void-Catra wavered, cracks of light forming in her darkness. "We can help you, too! Please, our Rebellion can do anything Hordak can for you. We can fix–"

She stopped at that word, knowing it was the wrong thing to say, but the snarl on Void-Catra's face told Adora it was too late. *"Of course. Adora the hero,"* Catra snapped.

"Wait, Catra, please–" Adora begged.

"Always fixing things for poor, broken Catra." Tears streamed down Adora's cheeks as Void-Catra crouched to leap. *"Well not this time!*

Shadow Weaver fixed it so I'll forget if I lose – so I won't lose! Not to you! NOT AGAIN!"

She-Ra sighed. *I can't fix this. I have to make it right. That's not always the same thing.* Adora exhaled, releasing the magic of She-Ra. "No. You won't," Adora agreed, transforming the Sword into the bracelet. Catra paused, letting out a questioning meow. "I won't fight you. Never again." She spread her arms wide and smiled. "I'm going to do what I should have done from the beginning. I'm going to have faith in you." Void-Catra's eye bulged, blue-white lines spreading like cracks from its light. "I love you, Catra."

"LIAR!" Void-Catra screamed, leaping.

Void-Catra stopped halfway to Adora with a strange, shuddering clang, falling to the ground. They both looked to find a manacle of golden ice on her ankle, with a chain of the same material leading to – Catra?

Adora stared at the figure of blazing blue and shining gold holding the other end of the chain. Her smirk was the purest Catra thing Adora had ever seen. "Hey, Adora," Catra – *her* Catra – drawled, and it felt like Adora could breathe for the first time since Catra's capture.

Void-Catra roared and turned, racing towards Catra-1. *"Figures Shadow Weaver couldn't even do that right,"* she hissed, leaping at Catra.

Catra split apart, letting Void-Catra go between her halves before reforming. "What'd you expect? You trusted *Shadow Weaver,* duh." Void-Catra vanished, appearing behind Catra to slash with claws made of emptiness. "Ow! I felt that!" Catra flickered, instantly facing Void-Catra, and punched through her with an arm made of frostflame. Void-Catra recoiled, beating at the cold fire with one hand.

Adora's joy shriveled and died. "Catra, stop! You're hurting yourself!"

"Kinda necessary, Adora," Catra insisted, following up with a spin-kick. "Also, kinda the plan." Adora recoiled.

Void-Catra laughed, appearing opposite the kick. *"Pathetic. You just keep begging for her scraps, don't you?"* She slashed at Catra's back.

Catra whirled and parried with an arm of scorch-ice. "Me? You turned to Shadow Weaver, and now you sound like her." Catra glared while her Void-formed counterpart shook with rage. "You could have had everything. All you had to do was swallow your pride and give Adora a chance."

"Yeah, brag about it!" Void-Catra howled. Catra's body slumped out of the wavering emptiness, collapsing behind the void-figure. *"Brag about how you groveled to that sparkly princess and her shiny mother! I'm going to take* everything *from you!"*

"Catra, please, stop! Let us help you!" Adora cried.

"I'm sorry, Adora," Catra sighed, crouching and baring her claws. "She's beyond help – she's literally made of nothing." Circles of freezefire wove around them, carving symbols in the ground. *Magic? What's Catra up to?* Adora wondered.

"I'm getting everything back – you're the one who's gonna be nothing!" Void-Catra raged. They crashed into each other, grabbing each other's hands and pushing. The void flickered across Catra-1 like fire, tearing into her. Void-Catra laughed. Catra snarled. *"I never thought I'd hate anyone more than I hate her, but you – I'm going to destroy you!"*

Adora gasped and ran towards them, but a squad of bots rolled into her path. "For the honor of Grayskull!" Adora cried, transforming back into She-Ra and carving through them.

Catra laughed. “Oh, Dumb-Catra, you don’t get it. We’ve always been our own worst enemy.”

Adora slashed through the last bot, only for Hordak to jet over and tackle her. With a cry of fury, she knocked him aside, but he twisted in mid-air to land on his feet. “This is–” Hordak began.

“IIIII HAAAAATE YOUUUUU” both Catras screamed, magic and power and oblivion howling around them.

She-Ra and Hordak both stared in horror. “...not the plan,” Hordak finished, eyes wide.

Then the circles around them roared to magical life, and Void-Catra wavered like flame in a storm. *“What – how – what did you do?!”* she wailed, coming apart like a breaking puzzle.

Catra’s smirk returned. “Exorcism circle. My *dad* taught it to me.”

Void-Catra thrashed and fought for a moment more...then sighed, relaxed, and surrendered to the spell, vanishing.

Freezefire-Catra flowed into her body. *I – I can’t help that other Catra now, but I can be here for mine,* Adora decided. Her Catra stood, shaking out her arms, and smirked at Adora again. “Hey–”

The void erupted around Catra. She cried out once, and was gone.

She-Ra stared, trying to see Catra, the reality of her disappearance refusing to register. With shaking legs, she stumbled to the empty circle. She-Ra held out the Sword, trying to feel, to sense, to find some trace of Catra. The hole in reality was still there, invisible to sight, but torn through time and magic. Even Hordak didn’t interfere. “Come on, Catra,” she insisted. “You’re not done. Not yet.” She held up the Sword...

...and vanished.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Scorpia stared as Catra tore through the Rebellion, her genius leading them to victory even as she personally trounced every rebel she faced. Scorpia felt like she was choking every time she saw that one tormented eye, tears streaming from it. "This – this isn't right," she whispered.

"Not right?" Dylamug asked, an eyebrow raising on his chest. "This is what we wanted, isn't it?"

Callix nodded. "We're winning again."

Lonnie and Rogelio stared at the horror wearing their squadmate's face, then looked at each other. Rogelio bowed his head, eyes half-closed. "Scorpia's right," Lonnie insisted, holding her forehead. "This isn't what we're supposed to be fighting for. Turning people into magic zombies – that's supposed to be princess stuff."

Rogelio took a few steps back from the others. Scorpia pretended not to notice. "Catra's my friend. I was trying to help her, but this – this is not helping her," she insisted, pointing at where Catra fought She-Ra.

"Rogelio!" They all froze at Kyle's cry. Then Rogelio whipped his head around, eyes darting like blasters. "Ro, come on, just talk to me!"

"Easy, Kyle," Bow replied. "We'll find your friends." Scorpia felt paralyzed. None of them moved.

"It's just...Ro wouldn't do this. He couldn't. Not to anyone, let alone Catra," Kyle insisted.

"I have to go to him," Rogelio said. They all turned to find him crouched just a fraction. *"You know that, right? I can't – we can't leave it like this."*

Lonnie sighed. "Man, Catra's gonna drag us *forever* for this." She looked to Scorpia. "What's the play, Captain?"

Scorpia gulped. “Me? You’re the smart Force Captain. I got us into this mess.”

Despite the grim situation, Scorpia almost laughed as Lonnie arched one eyebrow. “Really? I’m pretty sure the whole ‘kidnap Catra’ thing was my idea. Look–”

Dylamug grabbed Scorpia’s arms and shocked her, the electric field paralyzing the Scorpioni. “Callix,” he rumbled.

”Crap!” Lonnie cried, whipping out her stun baton and jabbing it into Callix. The stony warrior looked down, then smirked at the human. Rogelio snarled and leaped.

“Dy-la-mug – why?” Scorpia gasped, trying to pull back, but her body wouldn’t respond. It took all her effort to breathe. Kyle, wearing a stripped-down power loader frame, leaped to Rogelio’s aid, tackling Callix’s legs while Rogelio leaped onto larger man’s shoulders. Callix toppled.

”Stupid princess,” Dylamug rumbled, eyes glowing crimson. “I was assigned to monitor you for treachery. Did you really think a member of Hordak’s crew would answer to a simple Etherian Force Captain?” Scorpia felt the world spinning–

–when green goop splashed across Dylamug’s torso-face, blinding him. “Gah!” he cried, his next words muffled as the gunk flowed down over his mouth.

“Scorpia?” Bow asked, watching her with a second arrow nocked as she shook out her limbs. “Uh, you okay?”

Scorpia smiled. “Yeah!” she replied. Bow circled warily, arrow half-raised. Scorpia’s smile vanished. “No,” she admitted. “I messed up. You’re Bow, right? One of Catra’s new friends.” Bow nodded. “I was trying to help her. We thought the Rebellion did something to her head, but – but that was us,” she continued, tears escaping her eyes, “Hordak, Shadow Weaver, and Vultak, they did something horrible to her. We want to make it right.”

Bow smiled and lowered his weapon. "Welcome to the Rebellion, Princess Scorpia," he said, and Scorpia felt good for the first time in weeks. The feeling grew when she saw Lonnie driving Callix back with baton blasts while Rogelio and Kyle – kissed?! *Woo-HOO!* Scorpia cheered.

Dylamug tore the goop off his face. "Rrrah! I'm going to pound you both flat!"

Scorpia scowled. "Uh, nope." With two quick swipes of her pincers, she snipped his robot arms off. Dylamug stared back in shock. "You know I'm faster than I look. Now, you can go to the machine shop, or your legs will make good scrap." She snapped her pincers in the air. "Well?"

"Callix!" Dylamug cried, only for the stone warrior to land face-first at his feet. Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle followed. Rogelio and Kyle held hands. "Crap. Let's go!" The two ran.

Scorpia fell to her knees. "Was any of it real?" she whispered, looking up at the Fright Zone's towering spires.

Lonnie put a hand on her shoulder. "We are," she insisted. Bow offered her a hand as well, just as Entrapta rounded the corner with a bunch of reprogrammed bots. "Come on. You and the hair princess can't be a Super Pal Trio without the furball."

"Wildcat," Scorpia whispered. She nodded to Entrapta. Entrapta, bless her, smiled and nodded back. "For Catra!"

"For Catra!" they cheered, charging into the battle.

Except Catra was already gone.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Hold it together, Glimmer, the princess ordered herself. *They need you.* She teleported back over to Shadow Weaver, pounding on her shadow shield while Dad drove back a sorcerer named Dreer. "Where's my sister, you creep?" Glimmer demanded.

Shadow Weaver chuckled. It was worse than if she'd laughed outright. "I haven't the faintest idea," she drawled, throwing more shadow soldiers at Glimmer. The princess obliterated each one with ease, but every blow cost her a little more energy. "She is likely in another alternate timeline, similar to the one we drew our Catra from. However, she could be in the true universe, or in the realm of Obtainment, or the void might have simply erased her."

"Adora will find her!" Glimmer insisted, turning her attention back to the sorceress. "You–"

Shadows wound around Glimmer, encasing her up to her neck. "*You* should pay more attention to your opponent, child," Shadow Weaver retorted. "Micah ought to be ashamed."

Glimmer glared at Shadow Weaver. The sorceress recoiled. "Wanna bet?" With a cry of fury, she blasted the shadows away from her with an eruption of raw light magic. "Underestimate me again, monster! I know what you did to Adora and Catra! And I am going to make – you – *PAY!"* A second volley drove countless shining cracks into Shadow Weaver's dark sphere.

"Glimmer, focus!" Micah warned, blasting Dreer back along with three Horde squads. "Shadow Weaver wants you upset and distracted. It's what she does, it's who she is!"

"Only to my enemies, Micah," Shadow Weaver replied, and for a moment, Glimmer almost thought she heard a hint of warmth. Then the witch threw a ball of night at him. It turned into a dozen shadow spies, crimson-eyed and howling.

"Dad!" Glimmer cried, teleporting to his side. Together, they destroyed them all, but the princess had begun to feel the weariness under her skin. "Dad, we can't leave her," Glimmer begged, vision blurred by unshed tears. "It's the only thing she's afraid of. We can't leave Catra behind. Please."

"We won't, Glim," Micah agreed, "but we have to find her first, and to do that, we have to survive." He formed a shield of his

own, a half-sphere of violet energy protecting their flank. “They’ve got us pinned down. We have to fall back.”

“They used her,” Glimmer half-snarled, half-sobbed. “They forced Catra to do this for them.”

“‘Forced?’ Don’t be absurd,” Shadow Weaver scoffed, drawing circles of crimson lightning and empty shadow in the air. “We found a Catra willing to aid us in exchange for her world’s salvation. Yours was so selfish that she doomed an entire timeline out of spite.”

Glimmer’s exhaustion vanished in an inferno of fury – but before either she or her father could do anything, Scorpia crashed through Shadow Weaver’s force shield, sending her flying. “Whoa! I did not know I could do that,” she blurted.

“Yeah, we’re all impressed, don’t stop now!” Lonnie – *that’s her name, right?* Glimmer wondered – added, firing baton bolts after the retreating sorceress. Her hands shook, however, spoiling her aim.

“Lonnie,” Shadow Weaver hissed. “You think I’ve forgotten you, girl?”

“Why not? You never remembered any of us,” Lonnie shot back, circling as Kyle and his boyfriend fell back to help Glimmer and Micah, “as long as you had Adora and Catra to terrorize!” She drew a second baton and starting firing both with perfect timing. She staggered the fire to maximize the stream of blasts at Shadow Weaver.

“I’ll –” Shadow Weaver began.

They never found out what Shadow Weaver was going to do, because Scorpia leaped in between shaking student and abusive mentor, tail quivering. “You’re a bad mom,” Scorpia said, sounding as mournful as she was angry.

Hordak landed between Scorpia and Shadow Weaver, a massive cannon formed around one arm and a shield on the other. "True," Hordak admitted, "but she has proven loyal. I thought the same was true of you, Scorpia."

"This is wrong!" Scorpia cried, and Glimmer could barely spare the attention to watch out for ambushes. "What you're doing to the kingdoms, the civilians, the princesses, *Catra,* none of it's okay!"

"It is *necessary!"* Hordak snarled back. "The will of Prime is the light of civilization. All else is shadow and chaos."

Scorpia was quiet for a moment, looking away. "Seems to me," she whispered, "that the only one here defending shadow and chaos, is you."

Hordak froze. *Could – could this actually work?* Glimmer wondered, wild hope shining for a single moment. Then Hordak's expression hardened. "Prime casts out all shadows," he recited. "One day, you will see." He pointed his cannon at Scorpia. Everyone moved to respond – rebels to help, Horde soldiers to attack–

A column of light roared down onto the exorcism circle Catra had cast around herself. She-Ra floated down from it, one arm under Catra's shoulders. Glimmer took a breath to cheer, but stopped at the sight of Adora.

Her outfit had changed. She-Ra had changed. Her tiara had shifted to incorporate a frame like Catra's old mask, framing her hair poof and pony tail in place of the previous flowing mane. Her shoulder guards had merged in front to form a heart like the one on Bow's shirt. The shorts had been replaced with full leggings, golden bands around her thighs and a half-skirt with red lining matching her cape. Her boots–

Glimmer indulged in a squee. Adora's boots were golden versions of her own.

The changes were more than cosmetic, however. She-Ra was a bit taller, a fraction more muscular. Most striking was the change to the Sword. It was longer, thinner, less brutal and more elegant. At last, it suited her.

It was as though Adora had only almost been She-Ra until that moment.

Catra slid from She-Ra's grasp, crouching with a snarl, claws extended. Adora turned a worried look at her. "Are you going to be okay, Catra?" she asked.

"Ask me again after Shadow Weaver's chicken strips," Catra retorted. Adora sighed.

Then, as one, they roared and charged. Glimmer laughed. "This is the part where you run, Shadow Weaver," she warned.

Shadow Weaver ran.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Angella tumbled back, darting away from Vultak as he charged. *If that other Catra hadn't*– she thought.

The queen bit back a sigh. *A thousand ifs cannot change a single moment,* she reminded herself. *I must regain control of this fight.* She wheeled away from another shadow talon. "What is this moronic obsession of yours?" Angella asked. "Is it the wings? Please tell me it is not."

Vultak laughed. "It is the eternity, my glorious angel," he explained, pivoting to soar above her. "When all these fools are dust, we will yet remain. You and I can have glory across centuries that your mayfly husband cannot imagine." He dove, shadows grasping for her. "Why do you resist?"

Angella spun, dodged, and flew behind Vultak, slamming him to earth with a mace of light. "Eternity?" she scoffed. "You think you

can imagine eternity because you have lived for centuries? I never thought I would pity you, but gods and stars, you are a fool."

Vultak spluttered, darting up again, but Angella had already evaded him. "I remember when the magicats ruled Etheria, before the First Ones found our world." He tried to bind her in darkness, but she parried with caltrops of light. "I watched them land, helped them shape the Moonstone, opposed the plans of the tyrants who followed their explorers."

Vultak raced at her, and she planted a delicate foot in his spine, pivoting him into the rampart. "I fought the true Horde a thousand years before your birth. I mourned Mara and the stars, helped rebuild a world, stepped aside to let others rule, took up the crown once more to oppose a petty tyrant. Centuries?" Vultak turned and growled, darkness forming talons on his fingers, but she landed in front of him, unruffled. "Please, child. Come back in a thousand years when you have matured a fraction. Eternity with the man you are now would be a horror to rival the hottest fires below."

"I–" Vultak began.

Catra struck with such speed that even Angella was caught flat-footed. She punctuated each word with a bone-shaking blow. "Get. Away. From. My. MOM!"

Vultak literally went flying, taking to the air and fleeing from the furious magicat with all the considerable speed he could muster. "Catra!" Angella cried, rushing to her adopted daughter's side and embracing her. Glimmer teleported over for a quick hug, then returned to battle before Catra could object. "Are you all right?"

Catra swallowed. "I – I'm not injured. The rest can wait for after. How bad is it?"

Mother and daughter ducked as a tank cannon's volley sent debris flying around them. "The other Catra devised their strategy," Angella noted, "so, fairly awful."

Catra laughed. It was unbalanced and desperate, but it was her daughter, whole and alive, so Angella counted her blessings. "Right. What else are we here for?"

Angella stared. "'What else' – what else would we come for? We're here to rescue you."

It broke Angella's heart – again – to see the disbelief in Catra's eyes. "Come on. This is, like, half the rebellion." Several platoons and four tanks converged on their position. A wave of frostflame and a wall of angel-light halted their advance. "You couldn't have all come for me."

"Catra, I had to order Perfuma and Juliet to remain behind to defend Brightmoon. Perfuma cried for half an hour." Catra stared, eyes as wide as Angella had ever seen them. "There is no other goal. We are here – all of us – for you. Only you."

"me?" Catra breathed, shaking. "You came...*all* of you, came...just for me?"

Angella held Catra, shielding them both in light. "Not 'just.' Only. Only for you. Because even if you never developed another stratagem, never joined another battle...you are family, and we love you."

Catra sniffled, and Angella felt tears on her shoulder. "Y-you..." she wiped her eyes with one arm. "You're even crazier than I thought." Then, in a whisper, "i love you too, mom."

They let go, gathering their breath and wits. "Okay. I'm the principal. Mission accomplished," Catra noted. "The only purpose now is to disengage without fatalities." She scowled at She-Ra facing a Hordak more powerful than they had ever fought, each changing the shape of their weapons as often as they attacked with them. "Harder than usual. Evil me is almost as good at this as I am, and she had more to work with."

Angella lashed out with beams of incandescent fury, cutting more tanks in half. "My thought is to consolidate our forces, then use

our princesses and sorcerers to shield our retreat. Surely, your counterpart would have thought of that.”

“Yeah,” Catra nodded. “We’re going to need to break their lines to...” she trailed off, gaping. “Is that Scorpia?” she asked. The crimson princess smashed through entire squads in a rush, apologizing as she went.

“So it would appear,” Angella noted, smile gentle.

Catra chuckled. “I have a plan.” She grinned back. “Don’t worry. We’re gonna win in the end.”

Chapter End Notes

All aboard the angst train woo woo...

I'm sorry it's been so long. I have professional writing, and quarantine brain, and there's a *reason* I get Catra's low self esteem issues, but here you go -- the chapter I've been building up to since she defected to the Rebellion. Catra vs. Catra, 3 rounds, there can be only one winnah. (Well, not really, as Better Angels will hopefully prove later, but for now, here we are.) Also, Scorpia Gets A Clue (tm), I finally pay off on Kyle/Rogelio, and Angella schools Vultak. an Is anyone still reading this?

Stay safe, everyone.

Exit Wounds

Chapter Summary

The Rebellion escapes, but not unscathed.

Chapter Notes

TRIGGER WARNING: self-harm, severe self-loathing. The self-harm does not happen on-screen, but it's pretty severe, even if it gets reversed. Also, it's possible to have *too* high of a pain threshold.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra raced from squad to squad, bringing them down as she worked to unravel Vultak's assault. *Void-Catra's plan came apart when I banished her, but he's still working from the dregs of it, and Hordak's...busy.* Catra slammed a Minotaur into the ground and let her eyes slide sideways to where Adora and Hordak were engaged in the most epic duel Catra had ever seen. Every clash of weapon on shield shook the ground, and they transformed arsenals like playing speed chess to the death. *She's Adora she'll be fine she's Adora she'll be fine,* Catra insisted to herself, dodging baton fire as she rushed to Entrapta's side.

Kyle and Rogelio guarded the genius while she reprogrammed bots. Catra grinned at the lizard-man. "Hey, Rogelio," she smirked.

"Yes, fine, I'm sorry," Rogelio hissed, *"can we get out of here now?"* Kyle gave Ro's hand a squeeze.

Catra's smirk vanished. "Working on it," she explained. "ET, can you shut down the Horde's tech? Not permanently, just for a minute or so."

Entrapta blinked. "Oh. Huh. I think so." She turned to Emily, who produced a screen and keyboard. *Huh. That's new.* After a few moments of typing, Entrapta burst into a cackling smile, rubbing

her hands and tails together in unison. “Yes! Maybe. Probably. Horde-tech has multiple redundancies to prevent shutdown, but I should be able to cause critical systems failure in 75 to 80 percent of Horde weapons platforms. That includes tanks, bots, and batons.” She paused. “Not armor, though. Only Hordak’s is powered, and that’s First Ones tech.”

Catra nodded. “Okay. I can work with that. Kyle, Ro, keep her safe. I’ve got a dumb blonde to rescue.”

“It is your turn,” Rogelio quipped. Kyle giggled.

“Screw you too,” Catra huffed, then grinned again. “Never mind, that’s Kyle’s job.”

Both boys blushed. “CATRA!” Kyle wailed as Catra bounded away.

Gotta be fair, Adora’s managing with just Hordak, Catra noted, *but the Horde’s not stupid enough to fight fair – oh. Yep.* Shadow Weaver slid across the barren ground, half-shadow herself, gathering sorcery as she approached. She-Ra and Hordak smashed through a bulwark, sending green metal flying. *And covering Shadow Weaver’s approach. I’m gonna enjoy this.*

Sending Mermista to cover her adopted parents with one gesture and General Sunder to disrupt Vultak’s offensive with another, Catra dove behind a tank for cover, disabled its treads with a swipe of her claws, then leaped silently over where Shadow Weaver snuck up on Adora. *Yeah, no.*

Catra pounced, raking Shadow Weaver’s back with magic-soaked claws. She laughed as Shadow Weaver howled. “Hey, Shadow Weaver,” she quipped, leaping away from the lashing crimson bolts. “Aw, you missed me.” Catra smirked. “Your aim always did suck.”

“You have taken your insolence too far, beast,” Shadow Weaver snapped, surrounding herself in darkness and lightning. The sphere of cruel magic expanded all around the witch. “You are not half as clever as you think, and speed will not save you from this!”

Catra huffed, pretending not to worry. “Yeah, whatever,” she retorted, leaping at Hordak. *Great, she’s learning,* Catra grumbled, slashing Hordak from behind. *Magic’s diluting the farther it goes out, though. I can do this.* Hordak howled and spun, firing red beams that the magicat evaded with graceful ease. “Hey, Hordak. Notice you were smart enough not to wear your crystal on the outside.”

“I am not a lovesick idiot – GAH!” She-Ra interrupted Hordak with a shoulder ram, slamming him into a tank.

“Nah, just a regular idiot,” Catra cackled. “Hey, Adora.”

“Could you not distract me right now, Catra?” Adora complained, turning her shield into the Sword.

Catra cackled again, firing blasts at Hordak and Shadow Weaver. “What, I can get you with a ‘hey, Adora?’ Come on, make me work for it a little.”

Somehow, Adora smiled, and Catra’s heart pounded like a tank cannon. “Sorry, can’t. I’m no match for you.”

Ugh stupid feelings stupid Adora stupid Horde! Catra scowled, hissing at Shadow Weaver. *Shadow Weaver first. Someone I can use for a scratching post ought to help.* She drew magic into her fur and eyes, claws already suffused with power, then leaped into the witch’s growing storm of dark fury.

As Catra expected, the sphere of blinding shadows and explosive lightning conspired to smother her senses, but it had expanded too much to hurt her. Shadow Weaver’s presence blurred in the darkness, flowing through the ground, overhead, around Adora. For an instant, Catra smirked. Then Shadow Weaver and Adora overlapped, like double vision but affecting her hearing as well.

Catra scowled. *That’s how we’re playing this? Fine.* She closed her eyes, whiskers and nose twitching, ears flicking to catch the slightest sound. The battle raged outside, Hordak turning his

attention to Brightmoon's royal family. Catra's tail lashed. *My family. Gotta end this fast.*

Ozone trailed from an emptiness just behind Adora's unmistakable scent. *The smell of lightning.* Catra's smile was cold and merciless. *This time you're done, Shadow Weaver.* She leaped.

A lavender blur shot between Catra and her target. Her claws, already extended, struck luminous flesh. An eruption of light and magic shattered the darkness, tossing Shadow Weaver aside. She-Ra vanished, leaving Adora to stare at Catra...

...her talons having left crimson lines across Angella's abdomen.

Catra's eyes flew wide, staring in horror as the Queen of Brightmoon collapsed with impossible grace at her feet. "NO!" she screamed, dropping to her knees.

"It's all right, Catra," Angella insisted, her hand gripping the magicat's with surprising strength.

No no nonono– Catra panicked for an instant, hands fluttering uselessly over the woman who had adopted her in spite of all she'd done. *Focus!* Catra ordered herself, and she did. "Hold still. You're gonna be okay," she half-sobbed, steeling herself, then pressing her hands against the wound. "You're gonna be..." Catra blinked. She lifted her hand, dry save for a razor-thin sheen of sweat. "...okay?"

The crimson lines marring Angella's skin were just that – lines, nothing more. Catra's jaw dropped, her mouth working for a moment before closing again. *How?* she wondered.

"MOM!" Glimmer screamed, appearing on the other side of Angella. She stared at the wound, then at Catra, betrayed horror in her eyes. "Catra?" she whispered.

Catra quivered as though shot. "It's not – I didn't mean–" she tried.

“Glimmer,” Angella whispered, faint but firm. “I did this. Catra would have struck to Shadow Weaver. I couldn’t allow that.”

Glimmer stared as Micah rushed over. Catra looked up at Adora, knowing that her eyes begged, not caring for the first time since they were little. Adora nodded, eyes narrow and lips tight, then turned to face the approaching Hordak. Entrapta, with spectacular timing, shouted something, and a bunch of Horde tech stopped working. When Micah reached them, however, he sighed. “Stars, Angie, not again.”

“I’ll have you know, Micah Mizar, that I have not done this since the last time you unsealed my power,” Angella retorted, sitting up.

Catra double-checked the apparent wound. “You’re – you’re not hurt,” she gasped. Glimmer’s jaw dropped. “How?”

“I cannot be harmed,” Angella replied, one hand stroking Catra’s cheek, “by those who love me.” Catra’s tail shot out, lashing.

“Ugh! *Mom!* You scared us half to death!” Glimmer blurted.

“You thought I was going to hurt Adora, didn’t you?” Catra asked, ears drooping.

Angella sighed, standing. “It was a concern,” she admitted, “but I have faith in your abilities. Had you...rid us of Shadow Weaver, I am not certain you would have forgiven yourself.” Her wings returned, quivering and glowing more brightly than ever. “Micah.”

Micah put one arm around each of his daughter’s shoulders. “Come on, you two. Angie’s about to cut loose. Let’s get out of her way. Glimmer?”

They vanished in the familiar burst of light.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

The faint sting of Catra’s claws was nothing compared to the glory roaring within Angella, demanding release with all the might of

Heaven's fury. *Not yet,* she insisted, striding towards the Horde. Adora stared. "Cover their retreat, She-Ra."

Adora nodded and held the sword aloft. "For the honor of Grayskull!" She-Ra appeared in a column of sacred power, striding between Angella and their forces.

"Fall back!" Hordak barked, and most of his forces retreated. Only Styrax and Octavia did not flee with those words, moving to support their commander. *Such misplaced courage,* Angella mourned, though she paused when Hordak approached. He stood between Angella and his soldiers, one arm a cannon, the other a shield. "I have seen this before, false light-bearer," he snarled, glaring. "You will not catch me off-guard again."

Angella glared back. "You violate the hearts and souls of my daughters," she replied, voice cold as Frosta's kingdom, "and you dare speak of what *you* will not allow? Fiend!" Her wings erupted out, growing to three times their normal size, crackling with divine might. "I cannot end this war with a single act, but when this day is done, you will remember what it means to invite an angel's wrath!" Hordak took a breath to respond.

Angella didn't let him.

Lavender light erupted from Queen Angella, shining down on the Horde and throwing its solders back. In some cases, the pressure was emotional, soldiers fleeing in fear or shame. For others, it was literal, the likes of Vultak and Shadow Weaver physically repelled when her radiance threw them back by the darkness inside them. The power lifted Angella off her feet, causing her to float in the air. Still the force grew, whistling around her as it drove away the Horde in the heart of their squalid empire.

Only Hordak resisted. His might, skill, and determination held him in place, the First Ones tech implanted in his armor transforming his formidable will into terrible vigor. She directed what portion of Heaven's glory she could direct at the emptiness within – *What?* Angella wondered. There *was* darkness within him, in formidable

measure, but far less than she had expected. *If I can trust the Great Light,* Angella realized, *Hordak is less evil than his worst minions. A small thing, given his awful crimes, and yet...*

The explosion of sacred light ended all at once. In spite of her experience with the sudden cutoff of glory, it took her by surprise as much as ever. All at once, she was empty, spent, a puppet with her strings cut–

Glimmer appeared, took Angella's hand, and the world blurred away into sparkling light.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Glimmer's world roared into focus, her mother's power flickering through her as though trying to make a gift of it. Tiny, vestigial wings tried to flutter for an instant, before settling back in as the marks they would always be. *Too much, not now,* the princess thought, while Catra barked orders about interlaced covering fire and bringing skiffs up for a quick retreat. Adora roared like a pride of dragons, each slash of the sword holding back the Horde while they tried to recover. "She's going to need to sleep for a few days," Dad explained, a hand on her shoulder, "but Angie's going to be okay. Come on, baby girl. We need to get out of here."

Glimmer wiped tears from her eyes and nodded, then stood and turned to the forces that had come to save her sister. *From my mistake,* Glimmer snapped at herself, then shook her head. *No. Later.* She held up a fist and set it alight with magic. "Rally to us! Everyone not part of Catra's covering fire, load up and pull out! That's an order!" Dad smiled, then lifted Mom like she was made of paper.

"Wait, that's it?" Frosta snapped, smashing another wave of ice into the Fright Zone's walls. "We're not gonna make them pay for what they did to Catra?"

"Not a chance, Frostbite," Catra retorted, doubling the size of Frosta's attack with a wave of frostflame. "This was a rescue

mission. Here I am, rescued. No one's dying just to 'make them pay,' all right?"

Glimmer nodded. "We'll get them for this, Frosta. Just not today."

Cannon fire cracked the wall of ice in nine places. "Minute's up!" Entrapta called out. "Although, maybe I could make some of their engines explode! It could overload our systems, though."

Bow put a hand on Entrapta's shoulder. "Maybe when we're not in the middle of a desperate escape, honey?" he asked.

Entrapta beamed at him and nodded, offering twin thumbs' up from hand and hair. Then she whistled. "Hey, *Susan!"* The double-wide skiff they'd taken into the Crimson Waste – a trip that Glimmer had been sure would result in a grounding she had dreaded, but now prayed for – roared out from the back lines. It zipped around rebels with an agility that neared Catra's, sliding into place beside Emily. The two machines beeped at each other with what Glimmer guessed was nervous excitement.

"There! Load the queen onto – Susan, right – and let's get out of here!" Catra ordered. "Mermista, Frosta, Blue Wave! Adora, you're rearguard – ADORA!"

Mermista and Frosta paused, elemental powers swirling around their hands as they stared at She-Ra. Glimmer gaped, watching Adora leap higher than the Fright Zone's walls to unleash another spiraling blast with a slash of the Sword. *Stars, Adora, what are you?*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Not strong enough.

She-Ra shattered three dozen bots with her power as she landed. Tanks and soldiers surrounded her, weapons flaring to fire. With a single spin, she sent them all flying.

Not fast enough.

Vultak dove at her, shadows lancing out at her, while Shadow Weaver fired lightning from a nearby sentry tower. Adora dodged them all, throwing chunks of tank at them both, forcing them to fall back.

Not good *enough.*

Hordak transformed his legs into a rocket and he shot towards her with power stolen from the First Ones. She-Ra turned the Sword into a shield, angling it to deflect him towards the approaching Dylamug. When Styrax swooped around to slash her from behind, she swapped shield for lasso, catching his wrist and swinging him into Octavia.

Not enough not enough not ENOUGH! *Why am I never enough?*

"ADORA!"

Catra's cry snapped Adora out of her spiral, and she looked up to find the woman she loved glaring at her from atop a frozen wave. "Catra? What – I – I have to–"

"You came her to save me!" Catra cried, pointing towards the Whispering Woods. "I'm saved, my hero, head to the fallback position *that's an order!"*

"Yessir!" Adora said, saluting even as she leaped backwards. Catra dashed underneath She-Ra, using her claws to avoid slipping on the ice. Two-thirds of the way back to Glimmer, Adora realized what Catra had done and scowled. "Hey!"

Catra's smirk, uncertain though it seemed, was welcome all the same. "What? I am your commanding officer."

Adora landed, then backpedaled onto Susan. The skiff was loaded down with the Best Friends Squad plus Emily and the king and queen, but Susan barely wobbled as her engines revved up again. "Still cheating," Adora muttered, releasing She-Ra to lighten the load.

“Still means I’m doing it right,” Catra replied, though she was subdued enough to send butterflies storming through Adora’s intestines. “Come on, Mom,” Catra whispered, stroking Angella’s hair. “Hang in there. We’re going home.”

Adora looked up, and felt less horrible than she had since she and Catra had made their way back from that nightmare reality Catra’s dark counterpart had dropped them in. Lonnie, Rogelio, and Scorpia were on Kyle’s skiff, Rogelio’s tail curled around Kyle’s waist in a familiar way while Lonnie and Scorpia held onto each other. *Yeah. Home.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Angella groaned, not wanting to wake up but knowing she should. Three sets of hands reached for her at once, slender pairs taking each of hers while strong ones she’d spent years dreaming of split themselves between a shoulder and her cheek. “Angie?” Micah asked.

“Ohhh...remind me not to do that for another few centuries,” Angella sighed.

”Mom!” Glimmer and Catra cried, nearly colliding in their rush to hug her.

Angella wriggled in place enough to get her arms around her daughters while Micah chuckled and Adora sighed in relief. “Goodness, Adora, what are you doing over there? I thought my daughters were embracing me.”

Adora’s eyes went wide. “Your Majesty, I – that’s not – I mean,” she stammered, only to stop when Catra wound her tail around one of Adora’s wrists and tugged her over. They all hugged, Adora hiccuping tiny sobs while the others held her.

“SHE’S AWAKE!” Frosta cried, and suddenly the hug tripled in size as princesses, two of their gentlemen, and one winged horse burst in, throwing arms (and wings) around Angella and each other.

Perfuma held Catra and sobbed, apologizing for not being there, while Catra awkwardly patted her on the back and muttered something about the Whispering Woods. Frosta swore to punch Shadow Weaver in the face – right through her mask, with *ice* – the next time they met. Glimmer whispered something about being grounded, and Angella's smile grew a fraction.

"Don't ever do that again," Catra whispered, shuddering.

Angella sighed, suppressing a chuckle at the shenanigans growing around her. "I am fine, Catra. I knew what I was doing."

The sudden chill Angella felt stole her smile. *I've missed something,* she realized, *but what?*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora woke with a shiver, cold inside and out. *Even we should have been able to sleep through a whole night after that,* she sighed, reaching for Catra.

She wasn't there. The chill froze her to the bone. Adora leaped to her feet, threw on a robe, and began her search pattern.

It had been weeks since Catra had fled during the night, but Adora was accustomed to looking for her. The sparring room was empty, with no sign of Catra having been there after Adora's session. The library was next, and Adora almost left until she found a book sitting open on the table beside Catra's favorite chair – *the soft, plush one, not that she'd ever admit it,* Adora mused, smiling.

Adora's smile vanished as she looked at the manual. *Why was Catra looking at a veterinary book? This looks like some kind of surgery.* She blinked. *What the heck is onychectomy?*

She gaped at the next line. "De-de*clawing?!"*

Adora was convinced she'd never run faster, even when Vultak and Shadow Weaver had pinned Catra down between them. *Only*

place where they do a lot of veterinary stuff in the castle is the stable – maybe Swifty's there trying to talk the other horses into leaving, she prayed.

No such luck.

Catra looked up from a stool, a scalpel and some plier-like tools on a tray beside her, a bucket on the floor opposite the tray, and bandages around her fingers and toes. The love of Adora's life looked up at her with a bright, broken smile, and held up her hands. "Adora!" she called, sounding too young and somehow pleased with herself. "Look! I fixed it!"

The blood drained from Adora's face. "...fixed?" she asked. "Catra, what did you do?"

"I always hurt people," Catra said, smile unwavering as she wiggled her fingers. "I lash out, and – you know. Bow, Angella, you...but I could only do it because of those." She bumped the bucket with one ankle. Adora clenched her jaw before she could lose her dinner. "Problem solved! See?"

"Catra..." *Think think think,* Adora ordered herself, fingers twitching. "Wow. I can't believe you did this."

Catra's cackle frightened Adora with how normal it was. "I know, right?" the magicat said, smirking. "The book made it sound really hard and painful, but it was, like, one-tenth of a Shadow Weaver punishment."

Adora didn't think her heart could break any worse, but hearing that made her want to cut Shadow Weaver in half. Twice. *Magicat!* she thought, that one word hitting her like a cannon. "But, Catra, we hardly know anything about magicat bodies. Are you sure you'll be okay like this? What if you get infected or something?"

Catra's jaw dropped, smile vanishing. "Hnn. I didn't think of that." She tried to stand, gritting her teeth once she was on her feet. "Oh. Ow. Yeah, walking's gonna be no fun–"

Adora scooped her up before Catra could say another word, smoothly taking the bucket's handle in the process. "I'm taking you to the infirmary," Adora insisted. "No arguments."

Catra sighed and crossed her arms. "Ugh. Fine. There's no arguing with you when you're like this."

Balancing speed and gentleness as evenly as she could, Adora rushed to the healers, Catra rolling her eyes as though she hadn't just mutilated herself. The door was just ajar enough that she didn't have to deal with the handle. Micah was saying something to Angella, and Catra's ear flickered, but Adora couldn't hear it and didn't have time to worry about that. She shouldered the door open, banging it into the wall. "Medic!" Adora cried.

Catra facepalmed. "Gods, Adora, do you have to be so dramati–"

"Catra!" the queen and king cried. Angella sat bolt upright while Micah rushed over. Healers followed him, the eyes of the elder who remembered magicats going wide.

Micah's eyes narrowed. "Declawed," he growled. "Who did this? I'll–"

"I did!" Catra snapped. Micah froze, staring. Angella turned white as death. "Now I can't hurt anyone with the stupid things, okay?"

Micah's mouth worked for several seconds. The healers tried to take Catra from Adora's arms, but she couldn't make herself let go until they guided the duo to the bed beside Angella. The queen still looked like she was about to collapse. "The pain is supposed to be unbearable," Micah whispered at last.

Catra blinked as Adora lowered her onto the bed. "Huh. Really. Forget Shadow Weaver's lightning, it wasn't even worse than the paralysis."

Adora quivered. *And she stayed with me anyway, even though...what is* wrong *with me?* She shook her head. *No. This is*

not about me. Adora turned to Micah. "Is there anything we can do?"

"Fortunately, she kept the claws," Micah explained, placing them on a tray one at at time, "so yes." Adora let out a breath she hadn't realized she was holding.

Catra leaned over and smirked. "I was gonna make a whip out of them," she stage-whispered. "I still wanted to use them on Shadow Weaver, but that's not a weapon I'd hurt you with, you know?"

"Oh, Catra," Angella sobbed.

Catra turned and looked at the queen, eyes going wide and ears flattening against her head. Adora carefully didn't sigh. *Oh, now she gets it,* Adora thought. "Wait, no, this is on me, I–"

"I should have known," Angella whispered, almost reaching out to Catra, then flinching back at the sight of the bandages on her fingers. "After everything they did to you, everything *she* did to you–"

"You're both spiraling," Micah said, calm but firm, "and the reattachment surgery is going to require magic, so Angie, let me handle this, and Catra, I need you to lie back and try to relax." Adora's hands made and unmade fists, the worst feeling of her life – helplessness – gripping her while Micah guided Catra onto her back. He checked to make sure Catra's tail wasn't trapped under her back or legs, then began casting a circle. "Losing your claws would interfere with your sorcery," he explained, weaving symbols until Adora could hardly tell one from another, "and can mess with your immune system."

"Wait, losing my claws would make it easier for me to get sick?" Catra asked, ears twitching. "That's messed up." One of the nurses stared. Catra stared back. "What? I paid attention in some of my classes." Adora nodded to the nurse, and Catra smiled.

"We weren't sure. It was a sample size of three, thank the Stars," Micah explained. The healers started preparing Catra's feet while the king drew another circle over Catra's head. "Sleep, kitten."

Catra opened her mouth to complain, then yawned. "Only...Adora..." she mumbled, eyes closing, "...calls...me..." When Catra started purring, Adora relaxed for the first time since she woke up. *She's going to be all right,* Adora thought, willing herself to believe it.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra's claws itched.

That's not right. My claws never itch, Catra thought. The particularly weird part was, they itched just inside her fingers, like they'd been pulled out too far or something. *Man, that's the last time I try Perfuma's tea after a nightmare. "Catmint" my fuzzy tail–*

Catra's eyes flew wide as her memory of previous night returned full-force. "Oops," she muttered.

"'Oops,' Catra?" Glimmer grumbled. Catra gulped and turned to find her sister in a chair beside her bed. Her eyes were red and puffy. Her clothes were rumpled. *Glimmer never has wrinkled clothes,* Catra worried. "That's it? 'Oops?' Really?"

"Glimm – but, I – I hurt Mom," Catra whimpered.

"You did nothing of the sort," Angella added. Catra turned to find her mother's bed rolling over to settle in beside her. Adora and Bow awoke from twin chairs next to one another. Once she was close enough, Angella took Catra's hand. "My child, I am so very sorry. All I wanted was to protect my people, you and Glimmer most of all. I should have realized what even the appearance of harming me would do to you."

Catra huffed and looked away. "Why?" she asked, her insides plunging into a single point behind her navel.

"Because you're *good,* Catra," Adora insisted, taking Catra's other hand while Bow tapped on his pad, "no matter what you think."

"You saw that other Catra! *I'm a monster!"* Catra cried, heart shattering as she curled into a ball on her bed, burying her head in her arms. "She burned her whole world just to hurt Adora. I would've *been* her if a zero had come up one in the Crystal Castle. Shadow Weaver's right, I'm a freak, I'm an animal, I'm, I, I–" Catra stammered. She couldn't breathe. The world felt like a single enormous boot, crushing her to nothing.

"Catra." Angella let Catra's hand go, placing one hand on her back while stroking her hair. Glimmer teleported to that side of the bed to hold onto Catra's arm. "You did not harm me in any way. That fact is objective proof that you care. It is an aspect of my nature that has rarely mattered, but now – dear, love makes an angel invincible."

Entrapta exploded into the room. "She's awake?" the inventor blurted. Catra looked back up to find Mermista, Perfuma, Micah, Frosta, Sea Hawk, and Kyle piled up in the doorway behind her. Entrapta rushed to the bedside and pulled a case out of her hair. Catra blinked. *She's a mess even for Entrapta,* Catra realized, noting the frizzy hair, dark eyes, and more-stained-than-usual overalls. "I worked out something that might help and I know this is normally a solution for pet cats but you used a technique reserved for pets and Horde torturers so I thought–"

"Entrapta, breathe," Catra insisted. Entrapta took that moment to open the case. Catra blinked at the crescent crimson sheathes. "Claw jewelry?" she asked.

"Nail caps," Bow explained, eyes bright but his usual smile absent. "Magicats usually only made them for kittens, but sometimes they used them on criminals or...troubled soldiers." Catra snorted, almost laughing.

"Oh, and don't ever call yourself a monster again," Glimmer insisted. "This only happened because you saved me!"

“I’ve lost count of the ways you saved me,” Adora whispered. Her hands were still locked onto Catra’s, moving with the magicat. “We just came back from the second whole other timeline you rescued.”

“Like, if we’ve gotta do this, remember Salineas? The kingdom you made invincible?” Mermista drawled.

“Beast Island,” Micah noted with a smile.

Frosta pouted and looked away. “V-Vultak,” she muttered. Catra almost smiled.

“I burned, Adora. My whole world burned!” she remembered. Catra’s smile vanished before it could form. “I would’ve been her,” she whispered.

“Catra,” Angella soothed, “have you looked at it from the other perspective?” Catra looked up and mewed. “Shadow Weaver devoted years of her life to driving you toward a terrible fate, yet all it took was a single moment for you to strive for a better one. That is why kindness is so important – for one who’s suffering, one act of charity can make all the difference.” Catra looked around to find an entire family gathered around, all worried about her. “Adora is right. You are a good person, Catra. All you needed was a chance to see that.”

“We love you,” Glimmer insisted.

“You deserve to be loved,” Adora said, putting an arm around Catra’s shoulders. “I don’t know how many different ways we have to say it.”

Countless arguments fought to surface from the well of pain and disgust within Catra. When she opened her mouth, however, a tiny sniff came out. It grew into a sob, then open weeping, until at last she howled, as though all the pain and mockery Shadow Weaver had inflicted on her wanted to come out at once. Her family gathered around her, holding Catra, those who could not

reaching out to her any way they could. A lifetime of being taught never to show weakness shriveled up within her.

No one moment could undo a childhood of cruelty. After all they'd already done for her, however, Catra felt, for the first time, that maybe she would be okay in the end. That Shadow Weaver hadn't ruined her.

That maybe, just possibly, she really did deserve love too.

Chapter End Notes

> Oh look it's angst with a happy ending look at me outside my comfort zone woooo
>
> My RL writing assignment is eating my life, but I HAD to write this. I hope to finish this monster some day, but once again, it's probably going to be a while before there's another chapter. At least this is another good stopping point if it comes to that.

Into the Catraverse: Dark Victory

Chapter Summary

> So, what did happen to Catra and Adora in that alternate reality?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra grinned as Glimmer leaped over her leg sweep, then teleported behind her. *About twenty degrees left of straight back, too,* Catra approved, Glimmer grinning back. "Better," Catra said.

Glimmer's smile vanished, sparkly fist poised overhead. The princess struck with more speed and less precision than she'd intended, desperate to land a blow. "Flark!" Glimmer cursed.

Catra was already in mid-dodge, having rolled to her right, then under her sister. She laughed at the alien swear, leaping up to grab Glimmer's cape. Sparkles teleported out of the way again, but stumbled out of her landing, arms wheeling in the air to regain her balance. Catra froze, then stood and crossed her arms. "Glimm," she warned.

"Okay! Okay, I'm low on power, all right?" Glimmer snapped, glaring back.

"The word you're looking for is 'tired,' Sparkles," Catra retorted, grinning again, then sat down and leaned against the sparring room wall. "It's fine. The last few days have been...a lot."

Glimmer snorted, then sat beside her. "No kidding." Sparkles reached out and took Catra's hand. "Are you...you know, not horrible?"

Catra laughed. "I'm okay, Glimm. Bast, this is the best I've felt since...I dunno, before Shadow Weaver." She shook her head.

“Gods, it’s good to remember before her.” Glimmer’s smile returned.

The high-pitched hum of a swallowed squee made Catra’s ear flick up. The hum stopped cold. “Nice try, Crop Top,” Catra sighed.

Bow peeked further around the corner. “I’m sorry, but the two of you are just so–”

“I’m not cute!” Catra and Glimmer said in unison. Then they froze, looked at each other, and laughed.

Adora’s laughter joined theirs. “Are they still in denial, Bow?” she asked, shutting off their laughter like a faucet. Bow grinned and nodded.

Catra groaned. “Why haven’t I moved to Dryl, again?” Adora’s smile vanished, but Glimmer grinned and nudged her with an elbow. “Right, right,” she sighed, then flashed Adora a grin. “Hey, Adora.” Adora’s smile returned, along with a blush.

Glimmer looked from blonde to magicat and back. “You know, you never did tell us what happened in that other timeline,” she noted.

Catra’s smirk grew. “She said, changing the subject.”

Glimmer huffed and crossed her arms. “I really don’t need more of you two flirting, and I *do* want to know how many of these timelines we have to worry about.”

“Besides, it sounds so cool!” Bow’s eyes sparkled. Catra sighed again. “I mean, how did Adora turn into super-She-Ra? For that matter, how did you save a whole other Etheria?”

“If you don’t tell them, I will,” Adora added, the Princess of Smug the way she grinned.

“Okay, okay,” Catra gave in, “so, you know that I fell through a hole in reality. What I didn’t expect was a landing...”

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Three days ago.

"Owww…" Catra moaned, holding her head. *Not fun, but I guess I should be glad I'm alive.* She shook her head, hoping to clear her vision.

She was in a Horde storeroom. Catra shivered. *"INSOLENT BEAST!" Shadow Weaver shocked her while Vultak's shadows pinned her in mid-air. Hordak watched, expression hard and cold as tank armor, as magic reached into Catra's mind, her heart, her soul–*

Catra burst from the storeroom, claws glowing with magic, eyes darting. She checked her forehead, finding by some miracle that the diadem was still there. *Okay. I'm in Horror Hall, but on the opposite side from the Black Garnet Room.* Catra took a deep breath. *It's okay. I'm okay. Just need to find Adora and–*

"There's no time," Catra heard in her own voice. Memories, dark and terrible, surfaced from Void-Catra. *Entrapta! She's – I'm going to betray her!* She rushed towards the argument as silently as she dared. "We need to fire up the portal machine," Catra-3 insisted.

"We can't," Entrapta explained. "Opening a portal now will be disastrous. It's going to collapse and take us all with it. Adora was right."

Even as she ran, Catra-1 braced herself for the mad, broken laughter. She nearly froze at the growl she heard instead. "Of course she is," Catra-3 grumbled. "Look, you can't go in there and tell Hordak 'no,' he'll send you to Beast Island or something!" Scorpia gasped.

"What? Hordak would never do that! He'll understand!" Catra-1 slid through Entrapta's second-favorite duct to perch overhead. She braced herself as Catra-3 grabbed Entrapta's shoulder – and spun her around, glaring. "Catra!"

Catra-1 gaped at her counterpart as she came into view. Catra-3 was still in her custom Horde uniform, but she was also wearing some iridium steel harness. The harness had cables around the arms, pistons down the legs, and a belt filled with weaponry. The oddest part was a Mystacor amulet next to her Force Captain badge. Catra-1 scratched her chin. *Huh. Kinda heavy, but I bet my ET could come up with a lighter–*

"Entrapta, listen to me," Catra-3 hissed. "Hordak is *not* what you think he is. Right now, he likes you because you're useful to him, just like me and Shadow Weaver. As soon as Hordak thinks he doesn't need you, he'll throw you away." She bristled. "Why do you think he didn't mind watching his second-in-command go into the Crimson Waste looking for artifacts he didn't think were real?"

"No way," Scorpia gulped. "I mean, he must've – Lord Hordak sent reinforcements!" The princess's eyes widened. "As soon as he found out Entrapta came with us."

"But – but the danger was miscalculated," Entrapta insisted, "just as we had deduced."

Catra-3 slapped her forehead. "Just let me talk to Hordak. He'll be less mad at me. I brought him Adora and her sparkly friends, and I'm beating the other princesses right now." She turned on Entrapta's screen.

It took all of Catra-1's willpower not to gasp. Horde bots, soldiers, tanks, and more heat bombs than Catra had ever seen in her life were throwing the Princess Alliance around like festival hoops. *Even Netossa and Spinnerella came,* Catra-1 realized, watching them struggle to defend themselves–

Catra-1 froze. Frosta was holding hands with Shadow Weaver. Horror shot through her while Catra-3 smirked. "Wow," the Horde Catra laughed, "they're even stupider than I thought. Trusting Shadow Weaver? This is going to be too easy–"

Something warm and strong and reassuring flowed through Catra-1. As she watched, a golden light bathed the battlefield, shielding the princesses and driving back bots. With a battle cry she'd carried from beyond time itself, Adora – *her* Adora – burst into the timeline, driving back the Horde single-handed.

And great Bast, she looks amazing! Catra-1 exulted. Adora-1 was taller, wearing a much more practical suit of white-and-gold armor, her tiara transformed into a frame-helmet like the one Catra used to wear. The magicat couldn't help smiling again. *Hey, Adora.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra.

A yawning, endless nothing stood between Adora and the woman she loved. The expanse was infinite, across time without measure. That didn't matter to She-Ra, who would cross eternity itself to not fail the other half of her self again.

Catra.

Adora's love came alive within her, burning through every barrier and obstacle. Some cruel programming in the Sword tried to restrain her potential; the need to find Catra obliterated it. A lifetime of Shadow Weaver drilling sacrifice into the First One turned to dust at the memory of Catra's musical laugh, the shining of stars others called eyes, the feel of perfect lips on Adora's. The dread force that made Despondos a sinkhole in the cosmos rose up to bar her way, but golden light made a mockery of its dark power.

Catra!

Adora imagined it as almost like being born. She burst out of the silent void into a world of harsh radiance and explosive percussion. It took her only an instant to realize that the bursts of light and sound came from a battlefield. The princesses were waging a desperate assault on the Fright Zone. For an instant,

She-Ra feared that she had not followed Catra, but the Alliance's small numbers and futile efforts brought the truth home.

Hang on, Catra. I'm coming. Indulging in a battle cry echoing with all her fury and terror, She-Ra plunged down onto the Horde's forces. She tore through bot squadrons with each swing of the Sword, now longer and sleeker to suit her fighting style. Adora caught sight of Perfuma, the caring princess staring in joyous disbelief.

Grizzlor leaped up behind Perfuma. "I don't think so," Adora snapped, darting between the princess and the Force Captain. She had just enough time to smirk at the shocked look on Grizzlor's face before smashing him through another pack of bots with a punch.

"She-Ra!" Perfuma threw the biggest hug her spindly arms could manage around Adora. "You're all right! Why do you look different? Where are Glimmer and Bow? Did they escape as well?"

Uh-oh. Adora sighed. "Perfuma, I'm sorry, but...well, this is complicated. The short version is, I'm not your Adora – the Adora from this Etheria, I mean."

Perfuma's smile melted away. "I don't understand. You're She-Ra. Adora. How can–"

"'The world is made of countless possibilities,'" Catra's voice echoed from the speakers, "'born from countless choices.' Sound familiar, Petals?"

Perfuma's eyes widened. "C-Catra?" she gasped.

"Kinda. I'm from a possibility where I made better choices, with a lot of help. She-Ra there is from that possibility." Adora could almost hear Catra grinning. "Hey, Adora."

"Catra! You're all right!" Adora gushed. Perfuma's eyes cleared, brightening, and Adora guessed the plant princess was working out their origin. "What's going on?"

"So, you know how Catra-2 was still working for Hordak?" Adora nodded, her cheer draining away. "Yeah, Catra-3 here kept going, only where Void-Catra screwed up and let Shadow Weaver escape, this one's Entrapta found the magic powder in Shadow Weaver's old badge. Their me leaked to the Alliance that the Horde was sending the witch to Beast Island–"

Adora growled. "And like the idiot I am, their me fell for it." Three platoons tried converging on their position. She-Ra's power and Perfuma's magic drove them back.

"You're not an idiot, Adora," Catra growled back. Somehow, Perfuma's eyes went wider. "Look, I'm detonating a bunch of evil me's heat bombs in the Western District. That should give the Alliance a path to rescue the Best Friend Squad, and we can go–"

"HAH!" It was Catra's voice, but clearly not Adora's Catra. The sound of a metallic whip clashed with the roar of frostflame. "Gotcha, impostor!" Catra-3 cheered.

"Adora, find Frosta!" Catra-1 insisted. "Shadow Weaver's draining the kid, you've gotta stop her! I'll handle–"

Another lash left the speaker crackling with static. "Catra! No no no NO!" Without thinking, She-Ra turned and carved through the wall, charging into the heart of the Fright Zone. *Hang on, Catra, I'm coming!*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

I know I shouldn't be enjoying this, but...screw it. Catra-1 cackled, throwing frostflame at her counterpart, while Catra-3 literally lashed back with her cable-whips and flash-bangs from her belt. "Man, that's a cool toy," Catra-1 admitted. "I think I'll be taking it."

"You wish, impostor," Catra-3 retorted, cable nearly catching Catra-1's ankle. "Your stupid magic is no match for me!"

“Sekhmet. Tell me I didn’t sound like that,” Catra-1 sighed, backflipping out of the way and leaving a scorch-ice barrier to block Catra-3’s attack. “First of all, I’m not an impostor, I’m a different version of you from another timeline. Ask Entrapta about it.”

Catra-3 stared for a moment. “Nah,” she replied, smirk returning. Catra-1 heard the cable snaking towards her ankle a second too late, yelping as her counterpart threw her into a wall.

“I hate fighting me,” Catra-1 grumbled, slashing the air with a glowing claw. She smirked as Catra-3 yelped and dodged the column of scorch-ice that barreled at the Force Captain, landing on the cable and forcing the evil Catra to free her weapon. “Look, you’ve got cool toys, but there’s no way you can–

Scorpia charged down the corridor, shouting as she attacked. “Oh, come on!” Catra-1 cried, leaping back. Scorpia only hesitated a moment between the two Catras before turning to face Catra-1. *Princess clothes are a dead giveaway, even to Scorpia,* she noted, moving to put Scorpia between her and Catra-3.

Scorpia stared with one eyebrow raised. “Hey, Catra, what’s with rebel princess you?” the scorpioni asked.

“No idea,” Catra-3 said. “Just sting her!”

Catra-1 indulged in a thin, sharp smile. “Try it, Snaps,” she warned, brandishing her claws.

Scorpia swallowed and backed away, tail raised high. “Uh, you mad at me, other-Catra?” she asked.

Careful not to take her eyes off the pair, Catra-1 pivoted so they could see the sting wound between her shoulder blades. “In. The. Back. So, yeah,” Catra-1 hissed.

Scorpia’s eyes went wide, bright with gathering tears. “I – no – I wouldn’t–”

“She’s a *rebel,* Scorpia!” Catra-3 snapped, crouching and sliding to Scorpia’s right. “Obviously, the other you knew what she was doing!”

“Another Scorpia?” Entrapta asked, descending from a duct by her hair. “Fascinating!”

Catra-1 froze as Catra-3 laughed. “You couldn’t beat me by yourself, princess,” the Force Captain mocked. “How are you going to fight all three of us?”

On cue, a nearby wall exploded with a roar. Catra-1 laughed. “Who says I’m by myself?”

-SR- -SR- -SR-

She-Ra threw yet another bot into the dozen or so behind it, clearing the latest corridor. Perfuma still followed her, wrapping up cadets so Adora-1 didn’t have to use her newfound strength on normal humanoids. “Are you sure this is the right way, Adora?” Perfuma asked, staring at the shattered ruins of the bots.

“Kinda?” Adora said, lips pressed into a grim line. “I feel Shadow Weaver’s...I thought it would be darkness, but it’s more like an emptiness.” She focused, sensing light beyond light, seeking the place where there was none – *there!*

Tearing through another wall as if it was lace, Adora-1 found herself watching Frosta and Shadow Weaver, back to back and holding hands, facing Lonnie, Rogelio, Kyle, Huntara’s old goons, and a small army of bots. After a moment’s hesitation, She-Ra howled and leaped, impaling a bot with the Sword. The shockwave destroyed most of the others. “I’m only here for Frosta, Lonnie,” Adora-1 said.

“How ungrateful,” Shadow Weaver sighed.

Frosta’s eyes went wide. “Adora I can explain–“ she blurted.

Lonnie's eyes narrowed, and she drew a second stun baton. "Screw that," she snarled. "I don't know how you escaped, but Catra's gonna love giving you back to Hordak."

Adora exhaled, then transformed the Sword into a lasso, disarming Lonnie and Rogelio with a flick of her wrist. "I'm not your idiot Adora," she said, gathering the lasso and turning it back into the Sword while her old friends stared. "My Catra forgave me. Saved me. Her strength turned me into this." She gazed at them with as much calm as she could manage. "Please don't fight me, Lonnie."

"What are you talking about?" Lonnie demanded.

"She's from a different Etheria," Shadow Weaver explained, "where events transpired differently. I must surmise from context that Catra's defection to the Rebellion is the point of divergence."

Rogelio hissed a question Adora-1 didn't understand. "Fall back to Catra," Lonnie replied, and the soldiers fled in good order.

Frosta huffed once they were gone. "We could have handled them! Why–"

The young princess stopped when She-Ra grabbed Shadow Weaver's wrist. "Let her go," Adora-1 warned.

Shadow Weaver complied, and Adora let her go. "Adora. You must calm down. I can draw magic from the mere radiance of your presence, and whatever difficulties you have with the Shadow Weaver of your timeline, I am an ally of the Rebellion."

She-Ra pointed the Sword at Shadow Weaver's throat. "I know you erased Catra's memories. I know about the torture. I know about Halfmoon. *I know who Kyra is.* Don't talk to me unless it's about saving the Best Friends Squad." She froze at the sound of freezefire. "Catra," she breathed, and charged towards her beloved.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra-1 leaped away from the Super Pal Trio, dodging metal whips long enough for Adora to burst through a wall and form up beside her. Behind She-Ra, Frosta slid into place, Perfuma running to catch up – *Wait for me* –

Shadow Weaver slithered through the darkness, moving in behind the princesses. With a yowl, Catra-1 pivoted, sprang off a wall, and punched Shadow Weaver in the mask. The witch dropped like Kyle in a training exercise. "Whoa. I guess she is me," Catra-3 said, retracting her cables and smirking. "If you wanna beat *her* up, I won't stop you."

"Don't get comfortable, Horde me," Catra-1 growled, cracking her knuckles as she approached Shadow Weaver. "You're next."

"Wait!" Perfuma cried, holding out a hand. "I know she – we didn't know how awful she was, but Shadow Weaver's helping us rescue our Adora!"

Catra-1 stopped, quivering in place. "What – you – you can't trust her, Petals," she said, unable to take her eyes off the witch. Shadow Weaver chuckled. "You don't know what she is."

"Forget her, Catra," Adora-1 insisted, taking Catra-1's hand. "If we can get their Catra to join the Rebellion, this world will be fine."

Catra-3 laughed. "You wish." She took a handful of pellets out of her belt and threw them on the ground. Smoke enveloped the Super Pal Trio, and by the time Catra-1's senses had penetrated the cloud and noise, they were gone.

"Aargh!" Frosta howled, ice surrounding her fists. "They got away again! How are we gonna find Glimmer and the others now?"

Catra-1 held her forehead. "Finding them's not the problem, Frostbite," she explained. "Hordak's holding them in his sanctum."

The princesses stared at her in horror. Even Shadow Weaver's eyeslits widened for a moment as she stood. "That's...not good,"

Adora-1 admitted, rubbing the back of her neck. “What do we do?”

Catra-1 flashed her Adora a sour smile. “You’re not going to like it.”

”What – no! Catra, I just found you again,” Adora-1 replied, one fist on a hip, “we are not splitting up!”

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra-1 crawled along Imp’s gantries above Hordak’s sanctum, Imp cooing by Hordak’s arm as he put the finishing touches on a piece of tech that, well, *looked* like what Catra thought a portal device should look like.

Halfway across the room from them, the Best Friends Squad and Huntara were chained to pillars, watching in horror as Hordak did something with their Sword. *Stay quiet, stay alive,* Catra-1 reminded herself, an incantation that had served her well since her first days in the Horde.

Gathering the cloak she’d stolen from the goat-girl-goon around her, Catra descended behind the heroes, who were still staring at Hordak. “This won’t work,” Glimmer insisted. Catra couldn’t help a smile. “The princesses will stop you!”

Hordak chuckled. Catra’s blood ran cold. “The princesses are falling before the might of the Horde even now,” he replied, flipping a switch. Screens showed Netossa, Spinnerella, Mermista, and Sea Hawk trapped in a desperate fight for survival outside Horror Hall. Glimmer and Bow gasped, but Hordak glanced up and frowned. “Catra. Report.”

Catra-1 froze three steps from Glimmer, but Catra-3’s voice echoed from the speakers. “Some weird alternate Adora and Rebel me showed up. They rescued Frosta and Perfuma. It’s not a major problem. We’re tracking them now.”

“Alternate?” Hordak asked, scowl deepening, and went over the portal thing again. “How did they get here?”

“It’s fascinating, really,” Entrapta gushed. “It appears that alternate-Catra has been infected with a temporal dysjunction field.” Hordak listened, and Catra-1 tuned her out for later, as Entrapta chattered about what she’d picked up from her scanners.

“A good Catra?” Glimmer scoffed. “Is that even possible?” Adora-3, gagged with a cloth, looked downward.

Catra-1 couldn’t help a smirk, putting her hand over Glimmer’s mouth. “Yes, lucky for you,” she whispered. “Don’t scream.” She let Glimmer go and started picking the locks on her manacles.

“Catra?” Bow whispered. “How?”

“Long story, short version, our Light Hope stopped messing with my head long enough to get it out of my tail,” Catra explained. “Now shut up, these locks are tougher than I – never mind,” she continued as Glimmer’s cuffs released with a tiny click. “Stay quiet, Adora, this is gonna feel weird.”

“Hmph?” Adora-3 asked, trying to twist her head around until Catra-1 smacked the blonde with her tail. Then she nudged the cloth away from Adora’s mouth with said tail while she picked more locks. “Gah. Catra, what’s going on? Are you really not the same person?”

“At this point, the only things I have in common with your Catra are claws, attitude, and hating Shadow Weaver,” Catra-1 said, her second effort going more quickly than the first. “Look, I need you guys to pretend you’re still locked up while I go get my Adora. She’ll be pissed at you for not getting lucky, but ignore her, just go for the Sword when I give you the signal.”

Adora-3 started crying. “Catra...I missed you so much...” Glimmer and Bow looked at each other in shock.

Bast and Ra, Catra-1 cursed herself, sliding over to Bow. "Adora, I'm sorry, but I'm not your Catra. She's too far gone – maybe if she was scared or losing I could shake her, but she thinks she has everything." She freed Bow and slunk over to Huntara. "Catra-3 won't see what she's lost until it's too late."

"Three?" Glimmer whispered. "You've done this before?"

"Not, y'know, a lot, but yeah, this isn't my first rodeo. Also, I know what a rodeo is. Say hi to Swift Wind for me." Their eyes widened as Huntara's cuffs clicked free. *Good. That convinced them I'm on their side. Now, time for the giant sword lady.* "Stay put. If I'm not back in five minutes, improvise. You're good at that." She braced herself to leap, then paused. "Adora. I know you won't really listen to me, but she's not your fault, okay?" Catra-1 put a hand on Adora-3's shoulder. "If you have to blame someone, pick Shadow Weaver."

Then Catra-1 bounded up and out, racing to where her Adora waited with Frosta, Perfuma, and...*her.* "Cuffs are picked. Hordak's alone in there, but that won't last long, and we have to get back to our Rebellion before they get in over their heads. Plus, he's like a tank in that armor. Man, we could use a tank."

Adora chuckled. "You and your tanks. Besides, the only way Hordak's like a tank is he has Imp." Catra-1 stared for a moment, blinking. *How do you get lost in that tiny space between your ears?* she sighed as Adora continued. "I mean, those tanks record everything, you know?" Adora stopped when Catra's ears shot up like antennae. "Uh, Catra?"

"Tanks record everything," Catra whispered, hand thumping against her forehead. "Tanks record *everything!* Adora, you're a genius!" Adora was about to ask how she was a genius, but then Catra kissed her, and she couldn't reach the level of idiot in that moment, because even idiots can think a *little.*

Frosta, Perfuma, and Shadow Weaver all stared. "That's weird, right?" Frosta asked, crossing her arms and scowling. "It looks

weird to me."

"I'm going to be ill," Shadow Weaver drawled.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

She-Ra let out another battle cry as she smashed Hordak's door in with one punch. "HORDAK!" Adora-1 roared, marching in with the Sword held out. "It's over!" Frosta and Perfuma flanked her, with Shadow Weaver slinking behind them.

Hordak blinked and stared as though he couldn't believe what he was seeing. "I see your intellect is as overrated as Catra suggested," he rumbled, pressing a panel on his armor. Then he grabbed a stun baton and fired. Adora-1 didn't even bother transforming the Sword, slicing the baton blast out of the air. Hordak's eyes widened. "Then again..."

"I am not that idiot you captured," Adora-1 shot back, glaring at him.

"Hey!" Glimmer and Bow objected in unison. Adora-3 bowed her head, eyes squeezed shut.

Later, Adora-1 decided, smiling at the duo's loyalty. "My Catra's already beaten you. You just don't know it yet."

"Yeah, and we're here to beat you up, too!" Frosta joined in.

Hordak returned glare for glare. Then he grabbed a nearby conduit, tore it out of the floor, and threw it at Adora-1. That, too, she parried. *Huh. His armor doesn't transform.* She strode toward him, the Horde Lord circling with a wary crouch.

Once he was far enough away, Adora-3 burst loose, making a mad dash for her Sword, while Huntara and Bow charged at Hordak. Glimmer, of course, teleported right on top of him, sparkle-blasts flying.

“By the Horde,” Catra-3 sighed, standing in the ruins of the doorway flanked by Scorpia and Entrapta, platoons of soldiers and bots behind her. “If you want something done right...Scorpia, you go after shiny Adora. I’ll handle ours. Entrapta, back up Hordak. All other forces, subdue the princesses, and *kill* that witch.”

“Right!” the others cried as one. Scorpia rushed at Adora-1, who braced herself–

–just as the screens lit up with scenes from the battle of Halfmoon. Catra-3 froze, eyes wide, claws retracting, and crimson sparks flickering atop her head. “What?” Catra-3 gasped.

“Your real name is Catriska D’riluth,” Catra-1 explained, standing up next to a data console. “Your mother’s name was Kyra. She loved a sorceress named Light Spinner, who betrayed her and the entire world for power.” Everyone, even Hordak, stared at the screens in horror. “She even screwed that up, and now she’s Shadow Weaver.”

“That is–” Shadow Weaver began. Perfuma ended the sentence with a vine punch the size of a tree trunk.

“Wh-what are you *doing* to me?!” Catra-3 cried, clutching her head and staggering.

“Shadow Weaver murdered Kyra, kidnapped us, and erased our memory,” Catra-1 continued, staring with a calm Adora-1 envied.

“For the honor of Grayskull!” Adora-3 cried, having claimed the Sword. Adora-1 stood beside her love, sensing the energies that sent them here fading.

“Stop! Stop it!” Catra-3 wailed, collapsing and curling into a ball.

“Catra!” Adora-3 and Scorpia both cried, the latter rushing to Catra-3.

“Yeah, Shadow Weaver led the attack, but who sent her there? What was she fighting for?” Catra-1 shuddered, hints of her own

curse crackling around her. Adora-1 immediately put her free arm around her Catra, helping her stay upright. "Thanks, Adora."

"She's with *them,* Catra-3 hissed. "I'm supposed to join the Rebellion now?"

"We just wanted to help our friends," Perfuma explained, wringing her hands. "We were scared, desperate."

Catra-1 shook her head. "Okay, yeah, I get that." She cast a tiny spell, shocking everyone who hadn't seen her do that. "There's someplace else you can go. The Rebellion can manage without you, as long as they're not *fighting* you."

Catra-3's eyes widened, and she stood with a little help from Scorpia. "Oh. *Oh.* Okay, yeah. I can do that." She turned to leave.

Hordak recovered from his shock, becoming an unfeeling machine in an instant. "Do you intend to walk away from everything you've worked toward, Force Captain?"

Catra-3 stopped, not looking back. "Entrapta's the only reason you're alive, Hordak." She looked at Scorpia and shrugged. "Sorry, Snaps."

"What for?" Scorpia asked, looking determined. Adora-1 realized the world was taking on a tint of golden light, and she held her Catra closer. "I'm coming with you." Catra-3's eyes widened. "I, uh, mean, if that's okay."

Catra-3 laughed. "Bye, Hordak. You and Shadow Weaver deserve each other." She strode out the ruins of the door, Scorpia right behind her, leaving an entire platoon and several princesses staring in shock.

"I knew you could do it," Adora-1 whispered as the golden light grew, swallowing the edges of the world.

"Yeah, yeah," Catra-1 muttered, tail swaying. "Focus, She-Ra, we've got our own world to save."

The golden light embraced them.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

The present.

“Wait, that’s it?” Glimmer blurted, leaning forward. Bow’s eyes were sparkling more than ever. “Where did that Catra go? What did Entrapta do? Don’t you know what happened next?”

Catra smirked. “I sent Catra-3 to New Halfmoon. Scorpia and half a legion probably followed her. The rest, though...” Her smirk vanished as she shrugged. “Entrapta looked really conflicted, and even the princesses would’ve had to bail with the whole Horde coming down on them.” Glimmer grunted and flung herself back dramatically, flopping on her back with arms spread wide. “That’s how this thing works, I guess. I mean, we don’t know what happened to Catra-2, either. Maybe when our Rebellion wins, we can check on them again.”

“Let’s save one Etheria at a time,” Bow agreed.

Adora grinned, then snatched Catra up in a hug. “Unless you’re an awesome magicat princess, then you save other Etherias in between kicking Horde tail.”

“Adora!” Catra objected, squirming for a few seconds. Glimmer and Bow laughed, the traitors...but Catra couldn’t help purring. The hug turned gentle, and Catra let Adora hold her. *Eh. Personal space is overrated anyway.*

Chapter End Notes

Behold, I live! And it's not even angst with a happy ending!

...

...much.

Anyway, here's Catra and Adora's adventure in Timeline 3. The next episode or two will be character-heavy. And then...Season 4. Of course there will be Trouble made Double, and I'll tap into a couple of the themes of the canon Season 4, but otherwise, this right turn starts taking our heroes into uncharted territory.

Chosen One

Chapter Summary

> Adora spirals. Catra starts to realize just how badly Shadow Weaver hurt Adora, and is SO DONE WITH THAT.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra found, to her surprise, that she was used to the nightmares.

Sure, being captured by the Horde, then being bound and tortured with dark magic that pried open her soul, was horrible. Hordak's calm voice had been almost as bad as the combined sorcerous cruelty of Shadow Weaver and Vultak. Then, to cap off a masterpiece of atrocity, they shoved the worst possible version of Catra into her, who drove Catra's body like a skiff. *They forced me to watch while Void-Catra tried to destroy everyone and everything I love.*

Except the Alliance came for her. Adora saved Catra with complete, absolute trust. Glimmer, Entrapta, Bow, her adoptive parents, they had all fought like demons to save the girl who'd been taught her whole life she was a broken, feral freak.

So now, waking up after watching the Void howl beneath her helpless body, she snuggled against Adora's long, warm frame, only two layers of cover between–

Wait.

Adora was curled over Catra, twitching, her breath hissing between clenched teeth. Catra focused on that, forcing herself not to think about the feel of Adora's skin on her fur, the scent of Adora surrounding her, intoxicating, almost overwhelming–

Stop it. Focus. She needs you. Catra shifted, trying to slide out of Adora's grip. The blonde all but pounced, covering Catra as though protecting her from incoming fire. Whimpers escaped through those gritted teeth. "Adora," Catra whispered, trying to squirm out of Fort Adora. "Come on, I'm right here." No matter how gentle her efforts, each shift brought more sounds of distress from Adora, each sob a dagger in Catra's gut. "Adora. *Adora."*

"CATRA!" Adora cried, leaping up onto her hands and knees, still over the magicat even as she tried to look in every direction. What remained of the covers went flying.

After a moment caught between frustration and outrage. Catra settled on humor. She rolled onto her back, splayed out her arms, and smirked upward. "Hey, Adora."

"Catra? But – I thought – *you're okay!"* Adora dropped onto Catra, gripping her in a fierce hug. Catra responded with a gentle hug of her own, waiting for the other discharge to hit.
Three...two...one... On cue, Adora gasped, released Catra, and jumped back, a horrified look on her bright red face.
"OhmyStarsI'msosorry–" Before even Catra realized what was happening, the mighty bearer of She-Ra banged her head against a pillar. "Ow!"

"Bast, Adora," Catra sighed, sitting up. "Stop. Breathe. Then tell me if I need to take you to the infirmary."

"I'm fine!" Adora insisted, her smile as bright as it was forced while she rubbed the back of her head. "I mean, that was obviously just a dream, so, yeah, everything's good!"

Catra huffed, crossing her arms. "Adora, you pulled me under the covers. You fought me better in your sleep than you ever did awake." Adora's blush deepened, and she bowed her head, lips pressed tight. "That must have been some nightmare."

"It wasn't–" Adora gulped at Catra's glare. "Sorry," Adora mumbled, abashed. "You...kept falling into that nothingness. I

tried to catch you, over and over, but I never got to you in time."

Catra reached out, took Adora's hand, and tugged her back to the bed. "Adora, you caught me. You saved me from Shadow Weaver, *two* evil versions of me, a freaky time void, and the entire slagging Horde." She guided a still-shuddering Adora to lie down, then stroked Adora's hair until the blonde could stop shaking. "I'm here. It's over. We're safe."

Adora nodded. "Safe. Yeah." Feeling the tension still coursing through Adora, Catra tucked the blonde in, cuddled up against her (atop the covers, this time), and started purring. The sound helped them both relax, and after a few minutes, the pair was able to drift off again.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"Misty, Hawk, bots on the left flank!" Catra shouted, leaping from tree to tree as she rained baton fire on the Horde. *Stars, I'm glad that's Brightmoon purple instead of Horde green,* Glimmer thought, focusing on the mixed group of soldiers and bots driving up the middle. Grizzlor stalked behind them, the Horde symbol on his armor glowing an ominous crimson. *Why does that look familiar?* the princess wondered, firing blasts through her staff.

(It was still hard not thinking of it as her father's staff, even after he'd returned.)

"Glimm, bot drop! Bow, dazzle him!" Catra shouted as she leaped past. Glimmer smirked and teleported a bot over a pack of them, returning to earth two seconds before the explosion. While she recovered from the effort, Bow fired a flare arrow into Grizzlor's face. The bear-hybrid howled in fury, recoiling.

"Nice!" Catra laughed, landing on a tank and carving through the hatch. "Petals, Frostbite, right flank, shine-vine!" Perfuma thrust out her arm with a...less than fierce war cry, but the stampede of vines crashing through the approaching company expressed Perfuma's zeal for her. Frosta leaped onto the central knot of

plant-life, sending her powers coursing down the emerald coils with savage glee. Most of the company was frozen in place, figuratively and literally.

A blade-like shadow darted through Glimmer's. The princess gasped, firing blasts around the tank Catra was midway through commandeering. "Catra! Ground wings!"

The magicat princess sighed, dropping three spheres from her belt into the tank and leaping away. The Horde soldiers who'd been driving yelped as they fled, smoke and acid hissing behind them. Then Catra smirked again, "Hey, Adora! It's Buzzard time!"

Golden light exploded through the clearing, shining all the way to Erelandia, as She-Ra leaped from Swift Wind to smash into the heart of the attacking Horde forces. Vultak erupted from the shadow with a squawk, the infamous commander reduced to fleeing from the onrushing force of nature. "Adora! Is 'jumping from me at unsafe heights' a thing now?" Swift Wind cried, kicking one bot into three others.

"Later, Swifty," Adora replied, looking as serious as Glimmer had ever seen her, as she carved through all the tanks around the one Catra had commandeered. A memory of fearing Catra in a tank, now seeming ancient and alien, elicited a smile from the Brightmoon princess. "Vultak! You can't hide from me!"

"Why not – AWK!" Vultak darted away from Adora's rainbow-charged dash towards him. The winged general pivoted to dodge, racing towards – Glimmer herself. "Fine! I'll take the half-pint." Vultak sneered as he flew towards her, tiny claws gleaming on fingertips. "You should be just about powerless after that stunt with the bots, Micah-spawn."

Glimmer sneered back, pointing her staff at him. "Is that what your shadow spies told you?" she asked, enjoying the sight of his eyes going wide again, magic swirling around the staff. He wasn't going to be able to dodge in time–

–except Adora chose that moment to body-check the villain through a Horde squad, sending them all flying. Glimmer sighed. She-Ra froze, expression changing from "unrelenting dreadnought" to "sheepish best friend" in an instant. "Sorry."

"Hey, all that matters is we get the creep," Glimmer replied, "and more importantly, protect Erelandia." She pointed with her free hand towards the town gate, where Catra had placed her tank between the entrance and the Horde. Even with the cannon firing purple blasts and bots flying in every direction, they could hear Catra's joyous cackling.

Bow swung from a grapple-arrow to stand guard over the opening Catra had carved. "Be careful, Catra," he called, firing four arrows in half as many seconds.

Catra leaped out and grinned. "Always am," she said, bouncing from bot to soldier to tank.

Glimmer gaped. "No you're not!" she objected. "You're never careful!"

Her sister's only response was more laughter, bouncing off the still-dazed Grizzlor into a pack of terrified Horde soldiers. "Hey, Bow, you gonna use that tank or not?"

Bow grinned and swung after her. "Nah. Not my style. For the Rebellion!" More arrows led to more gooped-up soldiers and hacked bots.

With a nod, Catra pressed a button on her new harness. "ET, got a tank for you!" She tossed a mini-bot into the torn-open hatch with a perfect throw, then extended one of her cables to swing towards the main armored unit, and Adora.

There was just one problem – Adora wasn't there. She-Ra had crashed through a group of bots heading for Perfuma and Frosta, but from what Glimmer could see, the two princesses had been ready for them, based on the way they were straightening from attack postured. "Aw, come on!" Frosta blurted. Perfuma just gave

the ruined bots a forlorn stare, a massive vine fist drooping behind her.

"Can't be too careful!" Adora called, already leaping towards Vultak again. *What's with her today?* Glimmer wondered.

Vultak circled, shadows lashing out at She-Ra. "You can hardly be called careful, ignoring an enemy as you – OOF!" Adora cut him off with a mid-air leap from a platform that just appeared under her feet, then planting her fist in his gut. Again, Vultak went flying, and She-Ra angled towards Sea Hawk and Mermista.

"Adventure!" Sea Hawk cheered, slicing through bots, while Mermista gathered a small river around her. Her grin rivaled Catra's at her most fierce as both princess and liquid coiled for a massive blow. Again, She-Ra barreled through, scattering the Horde's forces. Glimmer bit back a giggle at Mermista's groan, while Sea Hawk slumped over, staring at the remains around him. Even his mustache seemed to droop. "Adventure?" Sea Hawk whimpered.

"Sorry!" She-Ra replied, leaping towards Vultak again. The vampire-general had been heading back towards Glimmer, but she'd honestly expected Adora to intervene again. *Maybe he didn't figure out why I still have energy,* Glimmer hoped, blasting her way through bots. One of the soldiers tried to sneak up on her, but training with Catra had paid off. Glimmer grinned as she brought the woman down with a leg sweep, then stunned her with a sparkle-blast.

"Glimmer!" She-Ra gasped, punching Vultak in the shoulder and turning to leap again.

Glimmer growled in frustration. "I'm fine, Adora! Focus on Vultak!"

"And you," Vultak warned, gripping She-Ra's arm and sneering a smile, "are distracted, She-Ra." Shadows lashed out to drain the Princess of Power.

Panic came and went in an instant, watching She-Ra grab Vultak's arm in kind, leveling a flat, grim glare at him. "I'm more than I was, Vultak," she declared, not weakening in the slightest. "You'll never understand how." She turned the Sword into a stun baton, and the general thrashed in her grip.

"Oh, A-*do*-ra," the worst voice in the world replied, "I do." Shadow Weaver formed from the shadows beneath the trees. More magic lashed out for Catra, who had been swinging from target to target.

Adora couldn't have been more obviously panicked if she tried. "CATRA!" she gasped, then exploded towards Shadow Weaver. Catra, with equally obvious reluctance, stayed behind She-Ra, spell in one hand and baton in the other.

Glimmer stomped her own fears down with both feet. *We have a plan. This* is *the plan. We'll be fine.* She turned her attention to the approaching Horde commander, hoping Shadow Weaver would last long enough to give her a proper shot at Vultak. "Hey, *Vultak!* We're not done yet!" Glimmer teleported above him, raining blasts from overhead.

"Gah!" Vultak swooped away, then circled to charge at her. Glimmer teleported around him quickly enough that she never quite started falling. She hit him from every direction, Vultak barely able to block her blasts with his magic. "How? The mortal's staff was never that powerful!"

Glimmer frowned, his defenses holding in spite of the barrage. "Neither is your magic," she retorted, never letting up.

Vultak gritted his teeth – *I'm getting through, but this is taking way too long,* Glimmer thought – and began dodging in unpredictable arcs. "She-Ra may be too strong to harm with my magic, but I still gain power from her," he pointed out, each arc bringing him closer to Glimmer's teleportation pattern.

Glimmer smirked at him and teleported back to Bow's side. *We planned for that too, Buzzard,* she thought, remembering Catra warning her not to get predictable. "Bow? Let's thank Vultak for everything he's done."

Bow, bless him, nodded and took aim. "One 'thank you' arrow coming right up."

With twin shouts of fury, Glimmer and Bow unleashed their attacks. Vultak dodged Glimmer's blast, but Bow's curving shot struck home, net-tangling the villain. Glimmer's smirk grew. *Just. As. Planned.* She blasted the now-plummeting Vultak, then locked onto Catra and teleported to her side. *Never again, Shadow Weaver!* the princess swore.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

With a howl born from a lifetime deceived, She-Ra flew at Shadow Weaver, staff whistling through the air. Shadow Weaver submerged herself in the darkness, emerging with a shudder with She-Ra struck her shadows with the glowing staff. "It's over, Shadow Weaver! Surrender, and..."

Shadow Weaver paused, circling as she regarded Adora. "'And' what, Adora? Throw myself on the mercy of the Rebellion? Even you must realize how impossible that is. Are you reconsidering your foolish defection, or is this mere weakness?"

She-Ra glanced back, where Catra defended her from regular Horde forces. *I have to do this,* she decided, transforming the staff back into the Sword. Shadow Weaver's eyeslits flared wide, and she slid back, recoiling. "For once, Shadow Weaver, you're right."

"You can't," Shadow Weaver gasped, forming a shield of darkness between them. "Adora, think. Would you really do this, to me? For that beast?"

Adora's eyes narrowed to slits. "What's wrong? Don't you *want* me to be 'the ambitious, cutthroat, ruthless warrior' you taught me to

be?”

Catra gasped. “Adora?” she whispered.

“I *raised* you to fight for the greater good, Adora,” Shadow Weaver retorted, darting back and circling the other way. She-Ra kept stalking towards her, not missing a step. “Surely you will not risk everything for that creature.”

“I love Catra,” Adora said. Behind her, Catra purred, even as she fought. “If you understand how I became the true She-Ra, then you know that.” Again, Shadow Weaver’s eyes widened.

Before either of them could do anything else, Glimmer and Bow appeared overhead, screaming and firing at Shadow Weaver. Shadow Weaver’s shield swallowed the first of Bow’s arrows, but Glimmer’s blast cracked it, and Bow’s second arrow shattered it. “Get – away – from – my – friends!” Glimmer snapped, unleashing beam after beam.

Shadow Weaver fell back further into the woods and the darkness, wrapping the shadows around herself like armor. “A runestone fragment,” she gasped, staring at Glimmer’s staff. “How? I alone have unlocked their mysteries!”

“Hey, Catra, she figured it out!” Glimmer said, far too gleeful about losing that advantage, in Adora’s opinion. “I can cut loose now, right?”

Catra chuckled. “Go crazy, Sparkles. Just not too crazy.” With a whoop of fierce delight, Glimmer teleport-dashed around Shadow Weaver, firing even more blasts at the witch from all directions. She-Ra strode towards the odd battle while Bow snuck towards a tree that looked climbable.

The rumbling of tanks echoed towards them, the Horde’s response to their hunt for Shadow Weaver. “Entrapta, we’re on,” Catra said, leaping towards the armored unit.

Unfortunately, the tank teams didn't wait to get orders or range, just opening fire without hesitation. "Glimmer! Bow!" She-Ra gasped, leaping into the oncoming bursts without a second thought. She turned the Sword into a shield, blocking most of the fire–

The world turned green. Adora's entire face went numb as the world spun end over end, ringing like Brightmoon's tower bells. *Wait, I'm the one spinning – that's bad –*

Catra caught her in mid-air, the sacred feeling of fur on her skin informing Adora of the rescue half a second before Catra brought them to earth. Distant explosions told her the tanks were no longer a problem. "Adora! *Adora!* Stay with me!"

"M'here," She-Ra assured her, vision and hearing becoming clear moments later. "Wow. I felt that."

Catra's stare was incredulous. "You *felt* – Adora, you took a cannon burst! TO THE FACE!"

She-Ra blinked. "Whoa, really?" She touched her cheek. It felt a little bruised. She grinned. "It tingles."

Catra quivered like a taut bowstring. "Bast, Adora! Why are you *like* this?" A surviving tank rumbled towards them, and Catra turned, two mini-bombs falling into her hand.

Scorpia got there first, body-checking the tank and knocking it on its side. "Oh, wow, sorry about that," Scorpia said, rubbing the back of her neck while the crew scrambled out the hatch. "I mean, we're the scary Princess Rebellion, you should run now!"

Catra sighed and rolled her eyes. "Keep moving, Scorpia."

Scorpia yelped, straightened, and saluted. "Yes ma'am, Commander Princess, ma'am!" Adora couldn't help chuckling at Catra's groan as the Scorpioni rushed towards the remaining tanks.

"All forces, retreat!" Vultak ordered. The Horde turned and fled, Shadow Weaver having already vanished.

The rebels let out a ragged cheer. Adora let She-Ra slip away, letting the first hints of fatigue slip into her normal form. "Whew! That was close, right..." Adora looked up.

The entire Princess Alliance (except Scorpia, who was waving at the retreating Horde forces) was staring back, most of them glaring. Catra strode to the front, arms crossed. "Infirmary. Now."

Adora swallowed and nodded. *I think I'm in trouble.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"Oh, she is in *so* much trouble!" Catra snapped, pacing outside the infirmary. The night moons gleamed in the distance, the largest already setting. "Mom, can we ground her? I'm thinking we ground her."

"I believe in your case it would be 'temporarily relieved of duty,'" Angella replied. "As a rule, 'grounding' is a parental term. That said, I don't think the basic concept is unfair, so long as it is short-term."

Catra huffed. "I figure three days, tops. Adora would lose her mind if she had to sit around longer than that." The magicat's tail lashed as she paced. "But still! Jumping into everyone else's fights was bad enough, but – but – cannon fire! *To the face!"* Catra threw up her hands, finally letting the concern she'd been holding back rush free. *What was she thinking? Why is she LIKE this?* she worried.

Angella sighed, sipping a cup of tea. "I understand. Just, be mindful that you do not let your emotions color your judgment as commander."

Catra's pacing paused a moment. Her tail's lashing redoubled. "I'll let General Juliet decide after she's done with Aunt Casta." Angella

shuddered a moment, teacup rattling on its plate. “What? Are they trying to keep it secret or something? It doesn’t look secret.”

“Yes, Catra,” Angella replied, a tiny smile growing beneath a blush, “they are trying to be discreet. I will simply note that you and Casta are close, and you are particularly observant.”

“Most of the time,” Catra muttered, a hundred worries – ninety of them Adora – whirling in her brain. *Focus, do the job,* she told herself. “How’s King Duplis?”

“Mayor Duplis,” Angella corrected gently, “is wholly grateful for the rescue of his children Hazar and Peach, and has dedicated a full measure of Erelandia’s resources to the Alliance’s efforts.” Her smile grew a fraction. “He does ask that Swift Wind stop leading their ponies away from the city.” Catra chuckled.

The medic peered out the door. “You can see her now,” she said, ducking back and opening the door just fast enough to avoid Catra crashing through to rush to Adora’s side.

“Adora!” Catra raced to Adora’s bedside and crushed the fearless idiot in a relentless hug, even as the blonde was trying to get up. “I am furious at you,” she mumbled into Adora’s shoulder.

Adora chuckled and hugged her back. “Kinda getting mixed signals here, Wildcat,” she replied. Catra couldn’t help purring a bit, tail swaying in relief. “Honestly, it was just a few bruises.”

“Cannon blast. In the *face.* Even your skull’s not that thick,” Catra objected.

“Apparently, She-Ra’s is,” Adora said. Catra forced herself to face the love of her life. Adora was smirking, that smug certainty driving Catra’s blood pressure to the outer moons. The magicat let go, straightened, and glared. *Ooo!* Adora’s smile vanished. “Catra–”

“You want simple? Fine,” Catra snapped. “Unless General Juliet overrules me, you’re relieved from duty for the next three days.”

Adora gasped, mouth falling open a fraction. “What? Catra–”

“You can’t keep doing this, Adora!” Catra snapped, hearing more hints of a sob in her voice than she wanted. “Look, I get it, I want to protect the others too, but you have to trust them to know what they’re doing.”

Adora’s mouth dropped further before closing with a faint snap, jaw quivering. “I do trust them. I was here before you, remember?”

Every strand of fur on Catra’s body bristled. It felt like a slap. *No, a slap wouldn’t feel anywhere near this bad.* Adora gasped, hand clapping over her mouth, eyes wide. “Catra I’m sorry I didn’t mean–”

“You wanna talk to her, Mom?” Catra asked, spinning on her heel and heading out. “I can’t – I need some air.” She darted past Angella before the queen could reply.

“Catra!” Adora cried, and then even Catra couldn’t hear her. She raced through the castle more to get out of her own head than anything else. She found herself skidding to a stop in front of the mural of Angella and Micah, half-expecting her father to be there. This time, of course, she was alone. *Heh. He’s probably asleep, like all the sane people at this hour. Well, except Mom. She’s probably the least crazy person on Etheria.*

Catra placed her hand on the mural and closed her eyes. *Blame Shadow Weaver,* she told herself, just about succeeding. *They’re not going to throw me away just because I have a fight with Adora. I have to trust them, too.*

“C’mon, Lonnie, talk to me,” Scorpia said, distant footsteps growing closer.

Catra leaped into the rafters, tail curling around her ankles as she watched. Below, Scorpia and Lonnie wandered the corridors, their discomfort achingly familiar. “It’s just weird,” Lonnie admitted, fist clenched at her side. “The Horde wasn’t just lying, it was the

exact opposite of – they've been so nice to us. Even Catra's been decent!" Catra bit back a hiss.

Scorpia half-frowned. "Hey, come on now, Catra's always done her best."

Lonnie sighed. "That's not – Catra never cared about anybody except Adora." She stopped, closed her eyes, and held her forehead. "At least, that's what it always looked like."

Catra leaped down with a harsh laugh. Both women froze. "You should listen to Lonnie, Scorpia. This time, anyway." They flinched in unison. "I'm not nice. Never have been."

For some reason, Scorpia looked sad. "Wildcat..." She reached out with one claw, then let it drop. "Look, I get it, you're still mad at us. You have every right to be." Catra didn't move her arms, but her tail betrayed her again, the tip probing the sting wound. "But since you joined the Rebellion, everyone finally sees what I saw! You're great, Catra."

Catra quivered, caught between happiness and frustration. "Not being nice is exactly what makes me useful to the Rebellion. They *need* someone mean."

Lonnie gaped for a moment. Then she laughed. Catra flared her claws, one twitch away from popping the caps off. "Please, Catra. Zero casualties on either side when you're in charge. *Zero.* No one does that!"

Catra scoffed and turned to leave. "I don't have the energy to deal with you two. When you're under my command, what happened doesn't matter – I'm responsible for you. The rest of the time, don't expect me to care–"

"I'm a terrible person and you liked me anyway and that's why I was so upset when you left and I don't understand this place at all *because they should hate me!"* Catra remembered, picturing Adora still as death, hurt trying to atone for Catra.

All at once she saw Scorpia in that bed. Imagined princesses crying, her squad devastated, another person who loved Catra ruined because she couldn't...

With a deep sigh, Catra turned to face them. Lonnie and Scorpia looked almost comically frozen in place, barely even breathing. "I'm...sorry," Catra forced out. Lonnie's jaw dropped. "Yeah, yeah, this place changed me too. Listen, I can't just forget what happened overnight–"

"No one's asking you to, Wildcat," Scorpia rushed to reply.

"But." Scorpia gulped as Catra continued. "I want to be better. And as terrible a job as it was, you were trying to help. And I've already got one self-sacrificing idiot to get through to. So be patient, and don't do anything stupid, okay...Snaps?"

Scorpia looked like she was going to explode with joy, eyes wide and watery. Lonnie grinned. Then, inevitably, Catra found herself being hugged half to death. "Oh, there it is," Catra groaned.

"You know I'm a hugger," Scorpia reminded her, smiling. Then she put Catra down with surprising gentility. "So, Adora, huh?" Catra facepalmed, groaning. Lonnie just sighed and nodded. "Listen, Wildcat, the bond you two have is amazing, but...are you sure you're good at talking to each other?" Catra looked up at the big gal, amazed. "I mean, sure, you can make whole speeches to one another with a look, but Shadow Weaver sure didn't want you two figuring out what she was doing to you."

Oh. OH! That witch! Catra hissed, and both women took a step back. "That was for Shadow Weaver, not you," Catra explained, and they relaxed. "Yeah, I really need to talk to Adora." She leaped toward the infirmary again, then stopped, sighed, and flashed a smile at Scorpia. "Thanks, Snaps."

Catra rushed off, pretending she didn't hear Scorpia sniffling and whispering "Super Pal Trio."

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora smashed through practice dummies as though they were the Horde's most advanced bots. *I can't believe Catra did this,* Adora railed, going from form to form with the grace that had made her the Horde's most promising cadet. *And General Juliet agreed with her!* She took down the last dummy on the field, leaving Adora the only dummy left. "Aargh! Why can't I do anything right?" Adora cried at the heavens.

"You mean besides save the Rebellion, like, a hundred times?" Bow asked, leaning against a wall and smiling.

His smile vanished when Adora whirled on him with wild surprise before controlling herself. "Sorry!" she replied, forcing a smile. "Just, you know, practicing."

Bow sighed, eyes flickering over the dummies. "I think you got them," he agreed.

"She relieved me of duty, Bow!" Adora blurted, and Bow jumped. "Catra – I know she's worried, but seriously, how could she do that?"

Hearing Bow take that patient breath he'd use when trying to calm Glimmer down almost set Adora off again. "You did seem a little, I dunno, manic maybe, yesterday?"

"I'm She-Ra! I'm supposed to protect everyone!" Adora threw her arms into the air, pacing. "I keep letting everybody down when you need me most!"

"That's Shadow Weaver talking," Catra said, loping towards them with an intense look in her eyes. "You're amazing, Adora. No one could do what you did even before the Sword."

Adora felt warm. So warm. "Catra..." She shook her head. "No, that's not the point."

"That is exactly the point," Catra huffed. Then she stopped and took a long breath. Adora...didn't feel the same frustration with

her that she had with Bow. "Look, the Horde's going to come up with stuff no one expects. We just have to do our best."

"That's all the Alliance asks of anyone, Adora," Bow added, his voice as gentle as ever.

"That's not good enough," Adora insisted. *They don't* get *it,* she groused. "One slip and the people we love – Shadow Weaver likes hurting people!"

Catra took Adora's hand, and the sheer force of the effort Catra was making took Adora's breath away. So did those beautiful, impossible eyes. "I love you, Adora, but this isn't just about us. Not any more."

"I know, Catra, but I have to – I *have* to–" All at once, it was hard to breathe. Adora gripped Catra's arms, afraid she'd disappear if Adora looked away. "I can't lose you again."

"What's wrong, Adora?" Bow asked. Catra flashed him a brief, grateful smile. "Come on, talk to us."

Catra nodded. "Sha–*she* didn't want us to. Not really talk, like they do here." Adora tried, but she swallowed, the rush of emotion stuck in her throat. After a moment's shudder, Catra wrapped a slow, careful hug around her. "You don't have to be afraid, Adora. No matter what you say, I'm not leaving. Never again."

"YOU DON'T KNOW THAT!" Adora screamed. Bow and Catra both stared, Catra letting go in shock. "I got distracted for one second – *one second* – and they took you away! I have to look out for you! *I can't break my promise again!"* Catra gasped, ears, arms, and tail going slack. Adora crushed her into a desperate hug. "I – I can't. Don't ask me to. Please. You were always better than you wanted to admit, and now, if I fail again – please, Catra."

"Oh, Adora..." Tears spotted Adora's shoulder. "We were kids. This is...bad things are gonna happen, okay?" Adora stiffened, denial roaring through her. "But as long as we're together, we can get

through all of it. It can't be too bad, because we'll have each other. That's our real promise."

Adora froze. *Our...real promise...* Her eyes squeezed shut. "She hurt you...so much..."

"She hurt you too," Catra replied, "and don't you dare say it doesn't matter. You matter, Adora. To me, to our friends, to everyone. Not She-Ra. You."

Something sharp and cold and cruel loosened its grip on Adora. "I'm scared, Catra. I'm scared it'll happen again."

"It's okay to be scared, Adora," Bow replied.

"And this time, she can't tear us apart," Catra added. "We'll get through this. Together. Okay?"

The cruel thing fell away, leaving only the feel of Catra beside her. Adora smiled. "Okay."

And for the first time, maybe ever, it really was.

Chapter End Notes

Only ten days between chapters? WHAT MADNESS IS THIS?

...Happy Holidays, everyone! Have some Adora-centricness, because she does in fact deserve love too. :-)

Also, I join the Julispella bandwagon, because they'd be cute together. Also also, Duplis and Hazar are characters from the 1980s Erelandia.

Next time, a Glimmer-centric episode, and then (eventually, since I have a paying gig to work on)...SEASON FOUR!

A Wish for Wings That Work

Chapter Summary

> Glimmer's not doing too great either. Once again, a family comes together to heal.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra hissed at the war table. Netossa and General Juliet sighed in unison. Catra ignored them, tracing lines from liberated regions (like Erelandia, *again,)* to the recently re-conquered (like Elberon, *again).* She went over the Horde advances, examined their victories, and came to the same conclusion she had ten minutes ago. "I did this," she snarled.

"Void-Catra did this, Your Highness," Juliet replied. There was something about her crisp military tone that put Catra at ease. "You fought and defeated her. I would hope that is proof enough that you are not the same being." The general smiled without mirth. "Even for you."

"These are my plans, my strategies," Catra pointed out, capped claws drumming on the table's edge. "Vultak's capitalizing on them, sure, but I came up with them."

"Under mind control, girl," Netossa snapped, arms crossed. "You said yourself Shadow Weaver hates doing that. It means she couldn't manipulate someone."

"That doesn't get back Elberon, or push those troops off the Snow Kingdom border, or liberate the Crimson Waste." Catra sighed. The fury she'd been trying to ride drained away, leaving only guilt and frustration she thought she'd beaten. The adopted princess fell into her chair, eyes dull and arms limp on the armrests as she stared at the map. "I...don't know how to fix this," she admitted.

Juliet walked over and sat beside Catra, placing a hand on her shoulder. Catra's ears shot up – it was the first time the general had made contact outside sparring. "We'll figure it out," she insisted. "You got us this far. From here, we do this together." Juliet looked over the map. "Let's break it down. Where do we start?"

"Elberon's the obvious choice," Catra said, drawing attack vector lines. "Problem is, Vultak knows it. The mothfolk are fragile as fff...flowers," she swapped. Nails drummed again. "The whole place is made of hostages. Do they even have a princess?"

Netossa snorted an almost-chuckle. "Kinda. Flutterina is an adopted princess, like you."

"She was–" Glimmer yawned as she walked in. "–at Princess Prom." Catra froze, tail lashing, while the bleary-eyed princess sat down with her usual pile of sweetened pastries for breakfast. "She had a tux kinda like yours, only pink."

Great. So the princess of our best bet at cracking this assault only ever saw me blow up Fractal Keep. Catra held her head and groaned. "Hordak's taken over. Vultak's still helping, but look at how meticulous this consolidation is." She pointed out the expanded forces on the new edge of Horde territory. "Half the gains we made in the last year, gone in a week."

That woke Glimmer up. Catra could almost imagine her ears straightening. "Hey, it's not all bad, right? You got the secret of runestone tapping out of Shadow Weaver's head!" Sparkles waved her father's staff, the fragment Entrapta had "grown" using First One crystal formula stuff glinting in the head's center. "Besides, you'll come up with something devious and awesome, then whoosh, zap, we send them running." Glimmer slashed the staff around for emphasis, almost knocking over her sweet-roll.

Catra couldn't help a wan smile at Glimmer's faith in her. "Yeah, I guess." She turned back to the map, eyes flickering over the still-trying-to-stab-her-eyes-out pink hologram. With a snarl she

couldn’t hold in, Catra slammed both hands onto the table, only her nail caps preventing severe gouging. *Stupid, useless FREAK!*

Glimmer’s eyes flew wide. “What did you call me?” she gasped.

Catra gaped at her. Netossa and Juliet turned worried looks toward each other. “You? How are you any of – wait, I said that out loud?” the Bubastis blurted. Then she groaned, facepalming. “I meant *me,* Sparkles.”

There was a brief pause. Catra wondered if disappearing into her hand was a magicat trick. “Ugh! You’re impossible!” Glimmer snapped, then vanished in a sparkly burst.

Catra looked up, but Glimmer was already gone. She looked at the general and other princess, ears and tail drooping. “Don’t look at me, Wildcat,” Netossa replied, half-smirking. “She’s your sister.”

“She would probably welcome an explanation, though,” Juliet added.

“Thanks, Jules,” Catra replied, racing out the door. *So, first question – does Glimm want Bow to find her or not?* She guessed *not* and raced upward.

Two minutes of climbing later, Catra heard familiar sniffling from the castle’s highest peak. *Called it.* She ascended more slowly, knocking on a column before leaping in. “Hey, Glimm.”

Glimmer was huddled in a ball, arms around shins, much the way Catra did when she was miserable. The only thing missing was a tail around her ankles. “*sniff* Catra.”

“You mind if I stay?” Catra asked. Glimmer shrugged, and Catra padded over, sitting half a body width away – close enough for hugs, far enough for space. “You wanna talk about it?” Glimmer shook her head. “Okay.” The magicat curled up a little differently, so she wouldn’t look like she was mocking Glimm.

After about a minute, a humorless laugh escaped Glimmer. “I hate Shadow Weaver,” she said.

Catra snorted. “Always a good answer,” she smirked, “but, any reason this time?”

“Why do *you* think you’re any of those things?” Glimmer asked.

Catra chuckled, also without mirth. “Everyone except Adora and Kyle, but Shadow Weaver’s the top three reasons, yeah.”

There was a little more humor in Glimmer’s snort. “You would have had more friends if it weren’t for Shadow Weaver, too.”

Catra sighed and let her head loll back, staring at the ceiling. Someone had painted a pretty lavender starburst up on the dome. “Nah. I was a pretty vicious kid.”

“And if Shadow Weaver hadn’t zapped you every time you were kind or nice...” Glimmer added. Catra shrugged. “I hate watching you do that to yourself, you know,” Sparkles muttered.

“Yeah, about that,” Catra retorted, “why in Bast’s name did you think I meant you? Has anyone ever called *you* a freak?” The pause rang alarm bells in Catra’s skull, and she looked at Glimmer to find her sister’s eyes squeezed shut. “Wait, they *have?* Who do I have to kill!”

Glimmer opened her eyes again, staring back in shock. “Catra!” she yelped.

“Not kidding. These caps come off.” Catra wiggled her claws.

For a long moment, Glimmer gaped. Then she sighed and uncurled, arms and legs flopping out. “I’m...not exactly any...one thing,” she explained. “I’m half-angel. Or half-immortal, or something. I’m not really sure what Mom is, but I’m definitely not all human. And my Dad was – is – the famous lost sorcerer. And I was never really good at magic until you saved him. And I have wings, only they’re these stupid little birthmarks that don’t do

anything. And I'm the only princess who needs to recharge. *And,* kids used to think I'm fat."

Catra snorted an almost-genuine laugh. "Take it from someone who fought you. It's all muscle," she replied.

Glimmer didn't even laugh, and worry erupted in Catra's innards, though Sparkles did manage a tiny smile. "I got teased when I was a kid. A lot." The smile faded away. "I didn't have any real friends until Bow. Then Adora showed up, and...well, I'm really glad you switched sides, you know?"

"Yeah," Catra admitted, her own voice subdued. "Me too."

"Catra, I am so glad you saved my Dad, okay?" Glimmer said, closing her eyes again. "It's just, they're both so much better than me at, like, everything. Bow's a literal genius. Adora's..."

Catra did laugh, then. "She's Adora."

"And I know we talked about this, but – all you had was Adora, and you turned into an awesome genius martial artist who became a super-sorceress the moment Aunt Casta pulled Shadow Weaver's magic out of you," Glimmer blurted. "I had all – *this,"* she snapped, waving wildly at the castle around them, "and all they got was...me." Glimm curled up again, dropping her forehead onto her knees and sighing.

"Okay, no," Catra shot back. "Yeah, no, not having it. We did talk about this, remember? YOU. FOUNDED. THE PRINCESS. ALLIANCE."

"But–" Glimmer began.

"You got Mystacor into the Alliance. You're there for all of us in ways I don't think you even get," Catra half-growled. "Do you have any idea what you mean just to *me?"*

"If I'm so great," Glimmer growled back, "why do you still think you're 'just' anything? Why is it my fault that Shadow Weaver

captured you!”

Catra gaped at Glimmer for a moment, then slapped her forehead again. “Glimm, I got captured because I let my guard down like an idiot. No matter how nice she was, Scorpia was a Force Captain. I should’ve been ready for her.”

“They came after me,” Glimmer whispered, finally leaning into Catra’s offered arm. Catra gave her sister a gentle hug. “You protected me, but I couldn’t–”

“You brought the entire Princess Alliance to the Fright Zone, saved me, and extracted everyone without losing anyone *and* got Scorpia and our old squad out,” Catra noted, curling her tail around Glimmer to rest it on one knee.

Glimmer let out something that was equal parts laugh and sob. “Netossa got us in. You got us out. I’m just the sparkles.”

“Glimm, quit it,” Catra said, hugging her closer. *Bast, I’m bad at this,* the magicat lamented – then froze, ears twitching. *Shadow Weaver? No, I can tell when it’s her.* She rubbed Glimmer’s shoulder. “Look, let’s find Mom and Dad.”

Glimmer paused. “Okay.” She teleported them, Catra pushing back the sensory overload, and the sisters landed in their parents’ living room. “You felt that too?” the princess asked.

Catra grinned. “Half angel, half sorcerer. Comes in handy, huh?” She nudged Glimmer’s shoulder with hers.

“Uuugh.” Glimmer glared at the ceiling. “I take it all back. You’re terrible.”

Catra’s grin turned into a smirk. “Warned you.”

“Glimmer? Catra?” Angella’s voice flowed out to them. “Is that you?”

"Yeah, Mom," they said in unison. Then they looked at each other and grinned.

Both monarchs entered the room, smiling back for a moment. Then Angella gasped and rushed to Glimmer, Micah just a step behind. "Glimmer, you've been crying!" Angella stroked the princess's cheek. "What's wrong?"

"I'm dumb," Catra sighed, "that's–"

"Don't you dare," Glimmer snapped. Then she smiled at her parents. "I was feeling useless. Then Vultak helped me with that."

Both parents stared. "I missed a step," Micah replied. "How did Vultak help?"

"Dad, could he get shadow spies past our wards if they couldn't do anything but listen?" Glimmer asked. Micah gasped, then slowly facepalmed. "But they can't get in *here,* thanks to Mom and your privacy spells."

"So you want us to replicate those same spells across the castle, is that it?" Angella asked.

Glimmer grinned. "Yes..." she began.

In an instant, Catra recognized that smile, so much like her own, when no one realized how clever she was, but they were *about* to. *That made us the worst enemies...and the best sisters.* Together, they said, "...but not yet."

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora tried desperately not to worry as her team watched Elberon, the city overrun by Horde forces. Again, Grizzlor was wearing that glowing harness, but the crimson of his Horde symbol was more ominous, and he looked...bigger somehow? Again, she looked at Glimmer.

Again, Glimmer turned a desperate, apologetic look back at Adora. "I know, Adora," she said, "but please trust us, okay?"

Adora nodded. "Okay." She made a fist, turning her mind on the comforting presence of the Sword in its bracer form. Tamping down her fear (utter panic, if Adora were honest) at Catra's absence was harder. *Magic circles on all our backs, while no one says a word, is part of the plan. King Micah knows what he's doing. Catra* always *knows what she's doing, no matter which side she's on. It'll be fine.*

Adora didn't believe a word of it, but she forced herself to believe in Catra, leading the other half of their team in storming the fortress overlooking Elberon. Catra, Bow, Netossa, and Micah were the stealth team – Micah had become a master on Beast Island, and Netossa was amazingly sneaky for a woman who created giant glowing forcefields – while She-Ra, Glimmer, Spinnerella, and Scorpia served as the powerhouse team.

Lonnie led their reinforcements, aided by Entrapta – physically in the field for the first time since Catra's rescue – on modified skiffs to bring them in where needed. *I just hope Catra has a plan for getting caught.* There was only one backup team, and two forward units. Adora's stomach was doing cartwheels.

Then Vultak's laughter echoed through Adora's ear-comm, and the panic shot straight to the surface. "Foolish child!" he mocked, and Adora knew it was Catra dodging blasts of shadow magic. "As though you could outwit me!"

"Wouldn't be the first time, Buzz," Catra retorted. Vultak paused, letting out a brief grunt. For an instant, Adora could picture Catra's confident smirk – *she asked me to trust her, to trust Glimmer – they have a plan,* Adora prayed – and then the world erupted in brilliant light and that familiar pop of Glimmer's magic.

Except the pop roared in the distance, and the magic circle on Adora's back flared to life, then vanished. When everything came into focus, Adora was by Catra's side.

It was a fortress very much like one Scorpia had defended on the river that led to Brightmoon's moat. Made of brighter steel and more fluid lines than the Fright Zone, it still had that blunt, pragmatic design the Horde favored. Vultak and Styrax froze, staring at She-Ra's sudden appearance. "Impossible!" Vultak gasped. "Even if you were capable of such magic, you couldn't possibly have been prepared for–"

Vultak recoiled, wings and arms flailing, as darkness boiled around him. "Hey, Dad was right," Catra quipped. "You are bonded to your shadow spies. I guess I owe him dinner." She turned to Adora, smirk growing. "I didn't think even Buzz was that stupid."

Vultak stared at Catra, eyes wide with terror. Styrax darted between the Force General and the two princesses. "You...you knew. You knew we were listening, and you set me up."

"Actually," Catra replied, glancing at her claws as though examining them, "Glimmer caught you. And this was her idea. I just handled the details." With that, Catra's demeanor transformed from smirking confidence to raw fury, and she slammed into Styrax. "Adora! Take him down!"

Adora's fear vanished. "Love to." She summoned the Sword to hand and leaped for him. Predictably, Vultak took to the sky, firing shadow bolts at She-Ra. Forming platforms of light beneath her feet, Adora leaped into the air after him, sending him fleeing with a squawk. "Give it up, Vultak. You're done."

"Shadow Weaver! I need you, *now!"* Vultak cried. Below her, Adora felt as much as heard darkness and lightning form a vortex in Styrax's shadow.

Adora sighed. "Spinny, you're up," she called, then plunged toward Catra and the Horde commanders.

Behind her, Vultak yelped as Spinnerella flew to where Adora had been, turning the very air against him. "Hi, Vultak! Remember

me?" Spinnerella mocked, Vultak transforming into shadow to evade her.

Beyond the walls, she saw Lonnie leading her force atop the outer walls. *Glimmer was able to teleport them too? Wow!* Adora almost smiled. *That was some spell. This was some plan!*

The smile died aborning as she faced the one enemy Catra had given Adora blanket permission to protect her from. "Shadow Weaver!" Adora howled, Sword plunging into the floor where Shadow Weaver had been half a second ago.

"Adora," Shadow Weaver gasped, almost flying backwards as Catra pounded Styrax like a training dummy, "you cannot want to do this."

"You hurt her," Adora hissed through clenched teeth, Sword tearing the space between them, "every week, every *day,* for being the daughter of someone *you* betrayed."

"That ceased to matter years ago!" Shadow Weaver wailed, throwing paralysis spells at Adora in bulk. She-Ra sliced through them with contemptuous ease. "Her ignorance took every mote of satisfaction from – you would show mercy to all but me?" the witch pivoted. "I who raised you, gave you everything?"

Adora considered answers. She let the Sword speak for her, slashing and thrusting. Even then, some part of her was forced to respect Shadow Weaver's agility – few on Etheria could have survived She-Ra this long.

Catra slammed Styrax's head to the ground with her foot. "Of course she would," Catra snapped, "if you surrendered, but if you were able to, Kyra would still be alive!"

"You never knew her," Shadow Weaver hissed, "even when you had your memories – AH!" Adora slashed the Sword across Shadow Weaver's mask, leaving a long, diagonal slice across it that glowed the blue of Catra's eye. "Adora," the witch trembled, "would you spare me, were I to yield?"

Adora considered it briefly. When Catra made a choked, horrified sound, She-Ra sighed. “I suppose,” she conceded.

Shadow Weaver nodded once. Then she melted into the shadows and fled. Adora turned to give chase – but Grizzlor landed in front of her, bigger and more glowy than ever. He roared even as Shadow Weaver vanished into the darkness. “Adora! That’s Black Garnet magic!” Catra warned.

Adora rolled her sword arm shoulder once. “Good,” she grunted. Then she and Grizzlor charged, both roaring.

Every time the two had fought before, Grizzlor had been little more than a distraction. He was about as strong as Adora, but not quite as fast, and based on their fights, he hadn’t improved much beyond since his heyday in the early years of the war. He didn’t stand a change against She-Ra. Now, though, he was almost as powerful as Scorpia, and definitely faster, and way tougher thanks to some kind of Garnet lightning shields.

As they traded blows, She-Ra’s staff against his electric gauntlets, Adora had to work not to enjoy the challenge. Vultak, Shadow Weaver, even Hordak, they all had agendas and cruel plots and awful tricks to their powers. Grizzlor just wanted to win. Adora could respect that, and *Stars,* had she missed clean, straightforward fights.

“Adora!” Catra blurted in exasperation, bouncing Styrax off a rampart. “You’re allowed to enjoy yourself!”

Adora blinked. “Oh. Oh, yeah!” Love for Catra swelled alongside the glee she felt at an honest challenge.

Grizzlor chuckled, a low, menacing thing. “Oh, love, you’re not going to enjoy what comes next.” He erupted towards her, metal-shod fist a cannon blast aimed at her heart.

Adora transformed the Sword into a shield just in time, smirking at Grizzlor’s wince as his fist clanged against it. “Yes. Yes I am,” she retorted.

She did.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"That. Was. *Amazing!"* Glimmer cheered. "It went even better than we hoped!"

"Indeed," Angella agreed with a faint smile. And if her hand was entwined with Micah's in an inescapable grip, who could blame her? "The keep is ours, the Horde's forces routed, and Elberon is within our grasp."

Catra nudged Glimmer with a shoulder. "Your plan, sis." Catra chuckled when she discovered that even her sister's blushes could sparkle. Bow made goo-goo eyes at the sight, of course. "So, feeling better?"

Glimmer chuckled and shrugged. "I guess. I mean, I'm still a freak," she said, and their parents both looked worried for a moment until Sparkles' smile grew, "but 'us freaks have to stick together,' right?" She returned Catra's nudge. Catra laughed, Adora's eyes mirroring Bow's. "I mean, I still wish I had wings that *work,* but the rest – I can handle the rest." She teleported in the middle of the Best Friends Squad and somehow got her arms around all three of them, pulling the group into a hug.

"Dear, your wings will grow in one day," Angella insisted.

Glimmer's sigh was explosive – typical for the princess. "Yeah, in about a hundred years."

Catra's ears shot upright. Mercifully, neither Bow nor Glimmer noticed, but Adora was stupidly tall even without She-Ra. Adora tossed Catra a questioning look, but Catra just mouthed "later" and returned Glimmer's hug. *Wings, huh?* Catra thought, keeping her expression and tail neutral as Glimmer turned back to their parents, chattering double-time about Adora's duel with Grizzlor. Catra gripped her girlfriend's hand, tail swaying at the thought of *girlfriend,* and guided her down the hall. "You okay, kit?" Adora asked. Catra froze, stunned that only fond memories rose from

the endearment she hadn't heard in years. "Whew!" the blonde blurted. "For a second there, I was afraid I made you upset."

Catra flashed a genuine smile at her love. "Dork," she teased. Adora's smile beamed back. "Listen, Adora, I've got an idea. I think Micah and I can come up with a spell for Sparkles, one that'll let her summon wings."

Adora blinked, then her smile broadened. "That's great! So why did we come back here?"

"Because I can't decide whether to surprise her with it," Catra admitted, tail slashing the air behind her, "or bring her into it." Adora blinked, then gestured for Catra to continue. "I...don't want to give her hope, then disappoint her. Plus, it'd be an awesome surprise." The Bubastis took a deep breath. "But, I really get the whole 'personal agency' thing, and Glimmer would probably want to being part of the design."

Adora beamed. "Aw. Perfuma would be so proud."

"Shut up," Catra groaned, shoving Adora's shoulder. Adora just laughed. *Dork. Definitely.* "Look, I'm great at dealing with complicated stuff. You want a messy problem solved, I've got it handled." She held one arm with the other in a half-hug. "Doing the right thing's...a work in progress. You, Adora…that Razz lady knows what she's talking about. You're not She-Ra because of a dumb sword, you're She-Ra because you know what's right. Always."

Adora gulped, eyes wide. Then Catra found herself in a hug to rival Scorpia's. "I love you *so much,"* she breathed. *She can't see me blush if my face is in her bicep,* Catra thought, purr escaping for a moment. "Okay," Adora continued, letting Catra go. "I don't think either way is *wrong* exactly–"

"Adora." Catra crossed her arms.

"*But,* I think going to Glimmer first would be better," Adora continued, her bullheadedness more comfortable than ever. "This

is about her being what she wants, right? So she should be a part of it."

Catra shrank into herself a little. "And if it doesn't work?"

"She'll love you for trying. For thinking of her." Adora's smile returned, wide and bright as ever. "I know I do."

"Dork," Catra repeated, at a rare loss for words, and purred.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Angella's smile beamed as her husband and daughters workshopped wing designs. Micah, bless the man, was trying to convince Glimmer to try out beetle wings ("They're more agile than you'd think!"), but the girls had narrowed their choices down to harrier and falcon.

"I'm just not sure," Glimmer pouted. Angella held back a chuckle. "I mean, I'll probably be faster and more agile with falcon wings, and they'd probably be better in a fight."

Catra's smile lacked its usual smirking challenge. "Buuut…"

"I'll glide better with the other ones, I could fly longer, they'll probably be stronger..." Glimmer sighed, looking down at the beautiful designs Catra had drawn for them. "...and they look cooler."

Catra put a hand on Glimmer's shoulder. "No wonder you're friends with Adora. Glimm, it's okay to want something that isn't about winning fights." She pointed out some of the runes in the circle. "Besides, this is about more than what you want. Personal spells like that–"

"–are about who you are," Glimmer and Micah finished with her.

Micah chuckled and rubbed the back of his neck. "Catriska's right, baby girl," he agreed. "Beetle wings aren't you, and I don't think those falcon ones are, either." He gazed fondly at Angella, then

hugged Glimmer. “Magic like this needs to be about your true self.”

Glimmer hugged him back, then nodded to Catra and stood. “Okay,” she said, going over the drawings and spell circles one last time. “Were you always this good at drawing, Catra?”

Catra’s ears and tail shot out. Angella guessed she was blushing under the fur. “Sh-shut up!” the magicat yelped, eliciting a giggle from Glimmer. “It’s just some stupid thing I always did. Comes in handy for maps, that’s all.”

“Your work is beautiful, Catra,” Angella insisted. “It is hardly something to be ashamed of.”

“Got it!” Glimmer blurted, tracing the spell in the air before anyone could respond. For a moment, Angella’s eternal fear for her first, beloved daughter cried through her. *Glimmer has never drawn a spell so quickly, so naturally,* Angella realized.

Magnificent wings of purple and silver burst from Glimmer’s back, shining with a radiance that left even an angel in awe. Catra’s jaw dropped, and Micah watched with love and pride that Angella understood entirely. Glimmer floated into the air, a single flutter of her pinfeathers taking her nearly to the ceiling. “Oh, wow,” her daughter gasped, eyes wide and unfixed. “Oh, *Stars.”*

Then, with a whoop of utter joy and freedom, Glimmer shot out of the room, racing down the hall. “Whoo! Go, Sparkles! GO!” Catra cheered, laughing and jumping in place. Angella shared a knowing smile with Micah, who nodded. Then the queen flew after her daughter, watching as she soared, twirled, spun, and raced into the sky.

Glimmer laughed. “Stars! Mom, why didn’t you tell me flying was this much *fun?”*

And torment you with a freedom I thought you would not know for decades? Angella thought, but smiled instead. “How could I possibly explain it?” she asked.

Glimmer accepted the response with a gleeful laugh, soaring through the sky once more. “This is even better than I dreamed!” To Angella’s amazement, her daughter came to a halt mid-air. “Um, Mom? Do – do you think this spell would work for...you know, someone who isn’t half-angel?”

Angella’s smile faded, but she refused to let it vanish. “Your generosity does you credit, Glimmer, but you know quite well that it was designed for your advantages in particular. Perhaps another method of flight would work for those you are thinking of.”

Glimmer paused, Angella’s heart overflowing with love and pride. Then the princess lit up – literally as well as figuratively – and smiled again, eyes widening. “Entrapta?”

Angella laughed. “We can but ask.”

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra examined her new, upgraded harness with amazement, almost as surprised that she let herself show the admiration as at Entrapta’s most extraordinary work yet. *Okay, just a tiny bit biased here,* she admitted to herself, as the Best Friends Squad gathered for their first group flight.

The new harness was a tenth the weight of the old. It was metal and impossibly thin, largely deep blue with gold and lavender trim. At the buckle was a small First Ones crystal that let it change shape like Hordak’s new suit, allowing her to be fully armored in an instant, extend her whip-grapples with a thought – or grow the falcon wings Glimmer had decided against. Bow and Entrapta, being the massive geeks they were, preferred beam-jet packs like the ones Hordak used. Adora, as the team dork, was mounted on Swift Wind, refusing to fly without him unless lives were at stake.

She looked at Glimmer, who grinned back, wings glowing. Sparkles hadn’t retracted them since casting the spell yesterday, even sleeping in them. *How is this my life now?* she wondered yet again. For the first time, the answer – a single flip of a coin in

Light Hope's systems – didn't hurt, even knowing that it would again some day. Instead, Catra indulged in a dramatic sigh. "We can make them awesome, Glimm, but we'll never make them cool."

Glimmer burst out laughing while Bow turned a faux-betrayed look on them. "I am *so* cool!" he cried, posing "heroically" in a way that was so spectacularly dorky that it almost looped around *back* to cool. Then Catra joined in, and even Adora snorted out laughs of her own.

"And I'm..." Catra looked at the four of them, unable to contain her gratitude. The snark she'd been about to lean on vanished. They all smiled back. "...luckier than I ever imagined," she whispered.

She shook her head. "Okay, enough dumb feelings and crap. Let's fly," Catra said. With a mix of laughs, yelps, and cries for equine revolution, they took to the sky together. *Tomorrow, we'll save Elberon. We'll stop Hordak. We'll make Shadow Weaver and Vultak pay for what they've done.*

But today...today we're free! Catra and Adora laughed as one, soaring free above their home, friends playing alongside them, and Catra knew they both wanted this to be their life forever. And maybe one day, it would be. *It'll never get too bad to handle, as long as we're together.*

And for the first time in years, Catra truly believed it.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Epilogue:

Adora woke to find Catra staring at the Sword, one capped claw running along its side. "You okay, kit?" she asked.

Catra's tail lashed behind her. "Yeah. ...no." She lowered her head, and Adora's heart clenched to see her love so forlorn, especially

after such an amazing day. “I hated this thing for so long, even after I joined the Super Princess Pals.”

“And now?” Adora asked.

Catra sighed. “I don’t hate it. I am so glad this thing keeps your reckless tail in one piece. But...some days I’m still a little jealous.” Adora sighed back. “I know!” Catra blurted. “I know I’m better at some stuff than you now. I have a family, real friends, respect that’s mine...” Catra’s free hand clasped Adora’s. “...you...” Adora beamed. “...but you’ll always be the perfect She-Ra everyone loves, and I won’t. I know it’s stupid.”

“It’s not,” Adora insisted, pulling herself up and giving Catra a one-armed hug. “And for the record, I think you’d make a great She-Ra.”

Catra stared. “Ha!” she laughed, shaking her head. “Yeah, right. Like I could hold up the Sword and say something as corny as ‘For the honor of Grayskull–’”

The room filled with golden light. Adora fell out of bed, blinking the radiance away. Her jaw dropped.

Standing before her in a copy of Adora’s outfit, except blue where hers was white, stood Catra – as She-Ra?!

They stared at each other in disbelief. As one, they said the only thing that made sense: “What the FU–”

Chapter End Notes

> The title is taken from a classic Bloom County / Bill & Opus story, where Opus has similar angst to Glimmer's.
>
> Wow, this chapter was packed, huh? Anyway, I wanted to end my pseudo-Season Three with a very different (read: happier) vibe from canon S3, though the idea for the stinger came late in the development process. And yes, this means that if I get there, a Cat-Ra AU timeline will be in the works.

I may write some between-season interludes again, but I promise that either way, the next update will bring Trouble. *g*

Interlude: Unprepared for Trouble

Chapter Summary

> Vultak hires mercenaries, and gets more than he bargained for.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"The useless parents named me Highcliff," the muscular Kamelian said, smirking, "but you can call me False Face."

Vultak swallowed a sigh. *Reduced to meeting a spy-for-hire in the lands Hordak insisted were empty,* he thought. *I'm going to take years to drain those defectors dry.* The back room consisted of a table just large enough for two, and a thick curtain that might dampen some sound separating them from the rest of the bar.

Deena entered with their drinks, and Vultak smiled. *At least the view has advantages,* he mused as she served them. "Anything else, honey?" she asked, smiling at the Horde commander. Highcliff scowled.

"I'll let you know," Vultak replied, patting her hand. Deena smirked and sauntered out, waitress outfit swaying with her. With a touch of reluctance, he returned his attention to the mercenary. "So, 'False Face,' what exactly am I paying for?"

False Face transformed into a flawless replica of Vultak himself. "I'm not just any Kamelian," he replied in Vultak's voice, the smirk almost identical to the Force General's own. "Do you want intel? Sabotage?" The copy's smile grew. "Corpses? Whatever you want done, I'll handle it." Highcliff returned to his own form. "For the right price, of course."

"Of course," Vultak drawled, expression flat. "You'll begin with a simple infiltration." Deena returned, along with hints of a good

mood. She took her time replacing their bowl of nuts. Vultak considered leaving her a tip. “Provide me with actionable intelligence on Commander Catra’s next assault. Cash on delivery. Prove yourself, and I might have real work for you.”

False Face’s smile vanished. “Who do you think you’re talking to, wing boy? I’m the deadliest Kamelian in the Crimson Waste.”

“But nowhere near the smartest, darling,” Deena said in a completely different voice. False Face froze, then leaped upright, turning his hand into a blade and pointing it at the girl’s throat. “Honestly, all either of you want is an ear on the door and a knife in the back? Imagine, instead, the possibilities of...” Deena melted away, revealing a slender, exquisite non-binary Kamelian in a black bodysuit. *“...chaos.”*

Vultak straightened in his chair, smirk returning. “Well played, Mx…”

The slender Kamelian smiled back with sharp, gleaming teeth. “Trouble. Double Trouble.” They took a bow with unmatched grace. “I will confess that Cliffy has a certain blunt skill, but if you want your enemies to destroy themselves, then you want to hire an artist.”

False Face snorted in frustration. “No one asked you, *Rebekkah.* Stupid mind games don’t destroy the enemy. Firepower does that.”

Double Trouble shook their head. “That is the problem, though, isn’t it? The Horde doesn’t have all the firepower any more.” They transformed into the original She-Ra in the bike shorts. “The Princess of Baubles found some fashion,” they said, switching to the current She-Ra, “along with more power than all your tanks. Then there’s the fun one,” Double Trouble continued, changing into Catra, “taking apart all that order you’re so fond of. She lures your people to their side, then takes apart your nice neat battle lines with confusion and inspiration. Catra’s blowing you up with your own precious ‘firepower,’ isn’t she?”

Vultak's good humor vanished. "If you have some intention of getting near a point, make it," he snapped, forcing himself not to wince as he realized he was quoting Shadow Weaver.

Double Trouble flowed back into their own form, their smile crescent moon wide. "Wouldn't you love watching the Princess Alliance turn on *their* own for a change, Vultak? Insert me as one of their own. Sweet as honey," they continued, transforming into Sweet Bee, "or bringing hope with guiding light." Double Trouble transformed into Peekablue's pre-transition prince form. "A few words to erode confidence here. Some rumors to turn friends on each other there." They changed back. "Just think of the possibilities! Or," they rolled their eyes at False Face, "you could send an extra to do a leading actor's work."

"I'll give you extra, you unprofessional–" False Face snapped, lunging.

Double Trouble flowed around the attack, turning their arm into a dozen needles around False Face's head. The bigger Kamelian froze, while Double Trouble turned a cold, deadly glare on him. Then they threw a dramatic arm to their forehead. "Unprofessional? How dare you! Just because I take pride in my art doesn't mean I neglect my craft!" They shifted their other arm back, and False Face relaxed. "That's why I charge five times what this slab of meat does." They pointed at False Face, who snarled.

"Enough," Vultak said, standing and slapping the table. "I'm hiring you both for a job in Elberon. You bring me intel, and I'll decide your assignments based on how well you do." He stared at one, then the other. "If either of you betrays the mission for any reason, including selling out the competition, I'll feed you both to Silver Storm." False Face gulped and nodded.

Double Trouble's eyes gleamed like their smile. "Ooo, I love it when employers make interesting threats. Who's Silver Storm?"

"My favorite pet dragon," Vultak replied. "By the by, Double Trouble, Peekablue's a woman, though I haven't let her complete

transition since I captured her.”

False Face stared. Even Double Trouble’s expression went neutral. “Peekablue disappeared fifteen years ago,” the male Kamelian whispered.

“Indeed,” Vultak replied, smile returning cruel and sharp. “The prize of my collection. She’s quite stubborn, alas, which is why I would appreciate more direct eyes on the Rebellion.” The two Kamelians looked at each other. “So. Are you ready to cause some trouble?”

Double Trouble recovered first, laughing. “It’s right there in the name, darling.” Again, they bowed. “And...scene.”

Chapter End Notes

Yes I just posted yesterday don't ask how this happened.

I blame Double Trouble. *g*

More 1985 She-Ra trivia: False Face is the Horde shapeshifter from that series, probably more like SPOP DT than the original female Double Trouble (who also provides the name "Rebekkah" that False Face taunts them with). Highcliff was the name of the main sucker False Face impersonates, a name I repurposed. "Kamelian," however, is a name I made up for DT's species (obvious play on chameleon is obvious).

Interlude: With Mighty Sword and Flame

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Catra go to Light Hope for answers. They get more than either dreamed of.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Bow was worried.

True, Bow rarely looked worried, but he cared about his friends too much *not* to worry sometimes. And while the others – the Best Friends Squad, Super Pal Trio, royal family, and Queen Castaspella, all gathered in the Crystal Castle – could all tell that Catra was upset, Bow was pretty sure they didn't know why. *She doesn't think she deserves this,* he thought, listening and waiting for an opportunity to suggest his observation, *and she's worried that Adora's trying to fix everything. At least Catra knows that it wasn't on purpose.*

Casta and Micah were maintaining some kind of examination spell on Catra, while Entrapta worked to unlock more of Light Hope's She-Ra files. Bow did his best to help. *It's not as much as I'd like. These systems are amazing, but I guess that's why they're so complicated.* He blinked at a crystal circuit that glowed more red than the others. "Entrapta? Should this look–" he began.

"Aha!" Entrapta cheered, racing to his side with a hair-grapple. "That must be the shackle program I was looking for."

Catra's ears shot straight up. "'Shackle?'"

"That's what the crystals that keep Light Hope spidery say," Adora muttered, looking at the floor.

Catra swatted Adora's thigh with her tail. "Quit it, Adora. You're not responsible for thousand-year-old First Dorks."

Angella chuckled. "Indeed."

"I still don't know why you're upset, Catra," Adora added, glancing over where Bow and Entrapta worked. Bow glanced back at the crystal. *Of course. The glow is because of the magic. They designated red for control, for some reason. Maybe the Black Garnet?*

Catra huffed and looked away. "Look on the bright side. At least I'm not jealous now."

Light Hope appeared over her usual projector. "Greetings, Adora, Entrapta. What is your query?"

"I turned into She-Ra!" Catra blurted, the magic circle beneath her turning more quickly. "How does that happen?"

Light Hope flashed red for a moment, but Entrapta frowned and yanked out the offending crystal with her pigtail. Bow smiled at her. "Sometimes, the simplest solution is the best," he agreed. Entrapta's responding smile gave her the most adorable dimples.

"Flirt later," Glimmer retorted as Light Hope turned blue again. "Any ideas?"

Micah and Casta looked at each other. "She-Ra's magic seems to be flowing through a...gap, of some sort," Casta explained.

"My analytical systems concur," Light Hope added, looking Catra over. "Have you suffered a metaphysical wound since our last encounter?"

Catra's eyes flared wide. "Shadow Weaver. Vultak. *Void-Catra.* When those creeps stuck her in me, I wasn't really alive or dead. I didn't finish dying until evil me threw me into that other timeline."

Adora gaped. "Wait wait wait, what? You *died?"*

Catra blinked at her, then smirked. "I told you I have nine lives, Adora." Her smile vanished while Bow's blood ran cold. "Well, five, now."

"That was *real?"* Adora yelped.

"You've already died four times?" Micah added, staring. "How?"

"Shadow Weaver killed me for the first time on my sixteenth birthday. I burned a life escaping from Adora at Princess Prom," Catra explained. Adora paled.

Scorpia stared. "So that's how you did it! Wow, you scared half a life out of *me,* Wildcat."

Catra rubbed the back of her neck, her smile returning with a sheepish twist. "Sorry about that, Snaps. Anyway, the spiders here killed me once before I escaped them." Adora turned almost dead white. "Evil me makes four. Five to go."

"Conclusion: your defeat of counterpart designated 'Void-Catra,' concurrent with a simultaneous death, left a conceptual gap that the power of She-Ra could fill," Light Hope explained. "That, combined with moral growth that appears to have made you a worthy Princess of Power and a sympathetic bond to the First One bearing the Sword of Protection, has made you capable of transforming into She-Ra."

Entrapta stroked her chin and nodded. "A logical theory."

Catra stared briefly, then threw up her hands. "There's nothing logical about it! First of all, there's no way I've had enough 'moral growth' to become She-Ra."

"Catra, you kinda *did* become She-Ra," Bow pointed out.

Entrapta nodded again. "Data never lies."

Catra groaned, burying her face in both hands for a moment before looking up again. "Okay, maybe I've been...doing

more...feelings stuff," she admitted, "but I still jump into fights claws-first. I *like* jumping into battle claws-first."

"She-Ra is a force meant for warriors," Light Hope explained. "intended to fight for Etheria's defense, invoked by one of the most formidable apex predator species in the universe."

Catra glanced at Adora. "Huh. If Adora's people are anything like her, they must be incredible soldiers," the magicat admitted, "but I'm not sure I'd call her an 'apex predator.'"

Angella stared. "Catra...Light Hope did not mean the First Ones." Catra and Adora both froze, turning astonished gazes back at Brightmoon's queen. "She-Ra predates them."

"And there was only one civilization here when the First Ones showed up," Adora whispered, looking at Catra with what Bow guessed was a mix of awe and guilt. "Catra, your three oldest gods are Bast, Sekhmet, and–"

"Ra," Catra gasped. "The only guy in the pantheon big shots. She...Ra."

"Correct," Light Hope confirmed. "According to Eternian records, the Bubasti have a legend of a powerful ritual. They did this to create a champion for a war against ancient spirits of evil. Their queen became the first She-Ra, while the master smiths of Purrsia forged the Sword of Omens and the Claw Shield for her consort. The tale states they won their war, driving the spirits from their world." Angella nodded.

"But, then, how did the First Ones end up with She-Ra?" Adora asked, somewhere between pleading and demanding.

"The initial Eternian explorers came in peace," Light Hope explained, "and earned the friendship of the Bubasti. After three generations, Queen C'yra III led a second ritual to allow a woman of any species to become She-Ra, if she possessed certain requisite qualities."

Angella smiled at Catra. "Courage. Honor. Loyalty. Perseverance. You have them all in abundance, Catra."

"Not like Adora," Catra muttered.

"But I thought you needed a First One," Adora pointed out, almost glaring at Light Hope. "If anyone can become She-Ra, why did you take me?"

Light Hope looked away. *It must be bad if Hope's using human body language,* Bow realized. "The First Ones initially created the Sword of Protection to further strengthen the Princess of Power, as a gesture of gratitude to the magicats. However, the Horde War made one Etherian faction desperate. The so-called 'Masters of the Universe' successfully created a male, Eternian counterpart to She-Ra, but still they were forced to retreat from Horde Prime. When a satyr She-Ra refused to leave Etheria to join an offensive, they reprogrammed the Sword of Protection to accept only First One candidates."

Adora quivered as though struck. "How...why…?" she asked.

"The first Light Hope systems were created as part of that process," Hope replied. *Not the question Adora was asking, probably,* Bow thought, while Hope glanced at Catra. "Perhaps...as your diverse squadron has helped to free me, you have, collectively, unbound the power of She-Ra as well. A powerful, skilled Bubastis champion, one with strong attachments to the current She-Ra, the Princesses of Power, and my personality matrix, is the most likely candidate for such a divergence. The circumstances around Catra's victory over her counterpart also made this possible." Light Hope paused. "Other sequences of events might also make this event feasible."

"So there could be timelines where Catra became She-Ra first?" Entrapta blurted, smile beaming. "Fascinating."

"A relevant concern, given that our Catra remains temporally entangled," Light Hope said.

Adora jumped to stand in front of Light Hope, arms held out. "Okay, stop!" she demanded. The hologram froze. "Are you telling me that the First Ones – our people – *stole* She-Ra from the magicats?"

"No," Light Hope replied, stopping Adora. "At that point, She-Ra was bound to all female Etherians. Technically, the First Ones removed the bond from all other species on this planet."

"Great!" Adora threw up her hands, then flopped into one of the chairs Scorpia had brought on Susan. "Just wonderful."

"Adora," Catra sighed, grabbing her wrist and leading her away from Light Hope. "We'll be back in a minute." Bow chuckled and waved while Adora looked back, confused. *Take care of her, Catra.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"Catra, what the heck?" Adora complained, only her frustration with her girlfriend pausing her spiral.

Catra rounded the first corner, then stopped, whirling on Adora and jabbing a finger at her. "Stop. Blaming. Yourself," the magicat demanded.

"But–" Adora blurted.

"No!" Catra cut her off. "No buts! This happened thousands of years before you were born! You are not doing this again, Adora."

"It was supposed to be you!" Adora snapped. Catra froze, eyes wide. "You actually want to be She-Ra, and it should have been you!"

Catra's mouth opened, then closed, tail lashing behind her. "I don't – not want it," she replied, rubbing the back of her neck, "but I'm really not jealous now, Adora, I swear." She blinked. "Wait, don't you want to be She-Ra?"

"No!" Adora paused. "Well, I'm glad I can help more people, but you keep telling me to be honest about what I want, and – and..." she let her back thump against the wall, leaning on it, letting the cool crystal soothe her nerves. "It's so much, Catra," Adora whispered. "People keep telling me it's not destiny, but the way I found the sword, how I found out about – about the Horde, when I should have known so long ago, and – and all of it."

Catra hugged her. It felt like being carried out of the Void. "Okay. For starters, I am so proud of you for being honest with me." Adora hugged her back, sniffling once. "And I think I get it. You feel like you have to be a perfect She-Ra, or you'll let everyone down."

"Literally everyone, Catra," Adora admitted, letting her eyes fall closed. "She-Ra is supposed to save Etheria, and the Horde...I have to stop them."

"Bull," Catra retorted. Adora could almost feel her smirk. "You've got me, and Sparkles, and Bow, and the whole dorky rainbow friendship alliance. We've got your back."

"But you'd be so much better at this than I am," Adora insisted, eyes opening again, "and–"

"Okay, no, *stop."* Catra let go, grabbed Adora's shoulders, and locked eyes with her. "Better at being a big, strong fighting machine? Than you? Bast and Sekhmet, Adora, are you that messed up?" Catra stared for a few seconds, then groaned. "Of course you are. Mom wasn't kidding about Shadow Weaver's A+ parenting skills."

The statement was so incongruous that Adora spluttered something that was almost a laugh in spite of her shock. "What?"

"That witch taught you that you were only worth something if you sacrifice everything for the mission," Catra explained, hands gripping Adora's shoulders a bit more tightly. "Seriously, Adora, there's some things I'm better at than you, but can you see me

fighting with a big, shiny crystal?" She laughed, and Adora's heart lightened. "I'd die of embarrassment before I beat anyone."

"You're wearing a tiara," Adora teased, already feeling less awful.

"It's a diadem!" Catra snapped. Then they both laughed. "Okay, you got me, but come on. You were better than me with every weapon but blasters. I can only handle you in unarmed combat with my claws."

"Yeah, and I can only take you if I can use my fingers," Adora retorted, "what's your point?"

Catra chuckled. "Bast, I love you," she said, and Adora's heart hammered in her chest. "Point is, She-Ra doesn't need to be a strategist or a sorceress or a survivor. You are the greatest fighting machine on Etheria." Again, Catra unleashed her pointy finger. "You're a brilliant tactician, you're made of courage, and you're more inspiring than the *literal angel queen* who leads the Rebellion." She crossed her arms, sparing Adora more pointing. "I don't know about this destiny crap, but if anything, She-Ra was meant to be you, not the other way around."

Adora froze. Then she wrapped Catra in her arms and kissed her before either of them knew what she was doing. Catra twitched for a moment, then melted into the embrace. "Stars, I love you," Adora said, smiling at the love of her life. "How are you so good at this?"

"Pfft," Catra retorted, squirming. "I'm kinda good at noticing the obvious."

Adora smirked, earning a glare from the magicat. "Nuh-uh, we're having a feelings thing here," she said, holding Catra fast. "Talk." Catra looked away, head tilting upward. "You look really cute like this," Adora continued sing-song style, swaying a little. Catra looked back, eyes wide. "I bet Bow would love to see–"

"Okay! You win, freak, just put me down!" Adora's smile grew as she let Catra drop. Catra smoothed out her gorgeous mane for a

second. “Look, you’re just – naturally good, okay?” Catra held her forehead in one hand’s fingertips. “I have to actually think about it. Figure it out.”

“But you’re great at figuring things out,” Adora replied, smile slipping.

“Not everything,” Catra muttered. Adora grunted, crossing her arms. “Look, the point is, you don’t have to argue with yourself about how to do what’s right. You just do it. I’m still upset a lot, but Mom and Dad...and maybe Perfuma, but if you tell anyone that I will show everyone what you look like in a Horde hospital gown,” she warned, wiping the forming smirk off Adora’s face, “...taught me how to talk myself down when I’m spiraling.”

“But you still spiral,” Adora pointed out.

“It doesn’t always work,” Catra snapped. “The point is, I can’t just punch out my feelings on the heavy bag like you. I have to actually think them through and shut them up.” She shrugged, the heat of her argument cooling to a kind, gentle warmth. “So I...maybe sorta thought I might be able to help you with your stupid martyr syndrome. And kinda wargamed a bunch of your freak-outs in my head. I didn’t think I’d have to convince you not to give me She-Ra – and Adora, if you really can’t handle it, we’ll talk – but if you honestly think you aren’t literally the best person on Etheria for it, I’m gonna start calling you ‘dummy’ again.”

Adora froze again. Kissed Catra again. “I am the luckiest woman on any world,” she said, smiling at her stunned girlfriend.

“S-sap,” Catra stammered, but she was purring and her tail was swaying.

“And I still think you’d make a great She-Ra,” Adora insisted, fingers stroking the fur on Catra’s cheek.

“Well, duh,” Catra replied, smiling back. “I’m awesome like that. You’re still gonna be better at it, is all.” She slapped Adora’s shoulder with one palm. “Not kidding about the talking about it if

being She-Ra is too much for you, though. If you really need someone else to help, I'll practice turning into her again."

Adora nodded. "I'm actually a lot better now," she said, "but I'll let you know." Again, Catra purred. *That reminds me!* Adora suddenly remembered, good mood swallowed by irritation, crossing her arms again. "Now that that's over with – you died four times?"

Catra groaned. "Adoraaa..."

Chapter End Notes

I know this is kinda...lore-dump-y, but there's no way the Rebellion would sleep on "Catra can turn into She-Ra now?" when Entrapta has spent the last year unlocking Light Hope cheat codes. That's part of why I threw in all those Feelings(tm). Besides, I was rough on our girls at the end of the last real chapter. They deserved a sweet moment, especially with so much Trouble incoming.

Oh, and the Thundercats references are largely Easter eggs. Thundera is a magicat colony in this continuity. Unless you folks have an interest in me doing something with that should I ever reach Season 5, it'll be a background element (and maybe a one-shot spin-off at some point), unnecessary for following the main story.

Interstitia: The Perils of Peekablue

Chapter Summary

> When an old friend cries out for help, how will one rescue change the course of the war?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Casta smiled as Catra traced the kinetic circle with perfect precision for the third time in a row. "Wonderful, Catra. Third time's the charm, as we say in Charm class." The queen giggled.

Catra chuckled as well, though she groaned and shook her head at the same time. "Bast, those jokes run in the family," she replied.

"I'll have you know that Micah and I were considered *quite* the pranksters during our time as students," Casta said, indulging in a bit of a smirk.

Castaspella was rewarded with Catra's eyes widening. "Wait, both of you? *Micah* played pranks?

Casta's smile grew. *I am definitely holding that over him later,* she thought, satisfied. "Yes, even the unflappable King Micah. If anything, his reputation was greater than mine. He startled King Norwyn with an illusion of an eel once." She winked. "In the bath."

Catra laughed outright. *That is adorable,* Castaspella thought, but knew her adopted niece well enough not to say it. "Didn't – you know, not-evil Shadow Weaver, 'Light Spinner,' get all disappointed in him?"

"Disappointed? She took notes," Castaspella stage-whispered. Catra's jaw dropped, then she covered her mouth, only for more

laughter to splutter through. “Light Spinner was...a very different person.”

Catra’s laughter died away. “You sound almost fond of her.”

“She was never cruel to me...not deliberately,” Casta explained, “but I know what it’s like to be in the shadow of her favorite student,” she admitted, sighing and sitting. Catra joined her. “Her encouragement could slice deep at times – ‘you’ll never be Micah, dear, but you have talents of your own’ – but at others, she made me feel like I could do anything.”

“Is that...why you like helping me?” Catra whispered, biting her lip. “Because of her? I mean, I’m glad there’s someone else who understands, but–”

Casta reached over and put her hand on Catra’s. “You are my niece, and I love you,” she assured the magicat. The purr was reward enough. “Besides, you always seem happier to see me than Glimmer.”

Catra chuckled. “You can come on kinda strong, Aunt Casta,” the magicat said, chuckle growing as the Queen of Mystacor huffed like a Bubastis. Then she shrank into her chair. “It’s just...I didn’t know Light Spinner. Shadow Weaver...the closest I ever got to praise was ‘adequate.’ Came in first through an obstacle course? I ‘used my bestial talents for once.’ Broke the record in third year target practice? ‘Passable performance.’ Beat the best cadets three years ahead at Command and Conquer? Like I said, ‘adequate.’ I don’t remember her ever saying anything to encourage me. Not once.”

Castaspella tried to keep the horror off her expression. *How far did you fall, Light Spinner?* she wondered. Instead, she forced a smile. “Then allow me to do so,” she replied. Catra’s eyes widened. “I have little understanding of strategy, but I am the Queen and Head Sorceress of Mystacor. If you were one of its students, Catra, you would already be among its finest, even with your attention divided.”

Catra stood up, staring at Castaspella as though she'd appeared from the heavens. Catra took one step towards her–

A beam of lavender light erupted from the floor above them, leaving a shining trail over the cliffs. "mom?" Catra whispered. *That makes no sense,* Castaspella thought. *Angella never leaves the castle, unless...* Casta turned to Catra to tell her to stay there, but the girl had already leaped to her feet and out the window, her harness growing wings. "Mom!" she cried, rocketing after Angella.

With a grimace, Castaspella pulled up her dress and raced toward Glimmer's room. *Who else would she be after?*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra turned herself into an arrow, pulling her body as taut and narrow as possible. She set her wings to maximum speed, driving Catra through the sky with a speed that frankly terrified her.

It wasn't even close to enough. Not only did Catra not see her adopted mother, the trail above had begun to fade. She risked tapping the communication crystal, slowing herself down a fraction. "Entrapta, I need you!"

"Hm? Wha?" Entrapta mumbled. *Of course I interrupted her in, like, her one hour of sleep.*

"'Trapta?" Bow asked, and Catra couldn't help a smirk. "What...Catra? What's wrong?"

Catra's smirk vanished. "Angella took off towards the western Horde lands – Vultak's turf – alone! I need to catch up!" She grimaced. "Sekhmet, she is *fast."*

"Ah..." Entrapta rummaged through something that made a lot of clanking and sliding sounds. "Sorry, I didn't add beam projectors to your harness. It was risky enough with Bow's and mine."

Catra blinked. “Right, something about Despondos not liking flying weapons,” she muttered.

“But only tech!” Entrapta added with the familiar offended tone. “Bird-horses, sorcerers, princesses, and giant bugs are just fine, apparently.”

“Not the time, ’Trapta,” Bow cut in. “I’ll call–”

Glimmer appeared beside Catra, wings spread and staff pointed behind her. “Here, Bow,” Glimm said, offering Catra her hand.

“Gods,” Catra breathed, taking Glimmer’s hand, “am I glad to see–”

The world erupted in blinding lights, taking form again with Angella just visible in the distance. “– guh.” Catra had amazed herself at how quickly she’d adapted to that sensation, but in the sky, it was just a little too much. “Mom?”

“Sorry,” Glimmer said, her smile sheepish. “She’s up there.” Catra managed to focus on their mother, just as Angella broke into a desperate dive. Maces and hammers of light formed around her. That brought Catra back to the present. *She only breaks out big guns for big bads,* she thought, eyes focusing as the sisters followed.

Angella slammed the weapons into the ground, driving back a flowing winged shadow. “Vultak,” Catra snarled. Then she realized that the attacks had formed a half-circle barrier around someone who’d been pinned to the ground by that shadow.

The figure was almost entirely blue, with white trim and a red lining on the feather-cut coat. Angella landed, forming a sword in one hand and a shield over the other. “Get *away* from her!” she cried, power roaring around her.

Vultak emerged from his shadow, dark lightning crackling around his fingers. “Come now, my Angella, I don’t want to have to drain you.”

"Not yours, monster," Angella snarled, hints of tears gleaming in the air around her. "*Never* yours."

"Mom?" Glimmer called as the pair landed by the blue figure. Catra gave them a quick once-over; they looked feminine, but the magicat couldn't peg a gender for the figure.

Angella turned, eyes wide with horror. "Glimmer? Catra? What – you can't be here!"

"Angella, I'm sorry," the blue figure wept. "I couldn't – couldn't go back."

"You'll be fine," Catra said, claws flaring and caps flying into their pouch. "Hey, Buzz. You're outnumbered."

Something loud and deep and *mad* howled in the distance. Vultak's smile reminded Catra of her own worst. "Not for long, pussycat," he mocked.

"Glimmer, Catra, take Princess Peekablue and go!" Angella ordered, forming a half-dozen more maces in the air above her.

Vultak chuckled. "'Princess?' Truly?" Peekablue curled up on herself, shivering. *I'm gonna* kill *him,* Catra hissed. She took a quick, deep breath. *Wrecked princess first.* With a gesture, she summoned the caps back onto her claws, then rushed to the shaking princess' side while Vultak continued. "You really will indulge the most ridiculous–"

With a heartbroken roar, Angella threw herself at Vultak, weapons flying at him in swift, furious arcs. Vultak squawked and literally flew back, firing bolts of darkness to parry even as he fled. "You will *pay* for this, you–"

"Mom!" Catra cried. "They're coming, we've gotta go!" She'd managed to get Peekablue upright, one arm over Catra's shoulders. More howls joined the first.

Angella looked over her shoulder, once again bordering on panic, then back at Vultak. Whatever the buzzard saw on her face made him recoil. “This is not over!” Angella said, then flew back to her daughters. Glimmer had already completed a teleport-boost circle beneath them, and as soon as their mom landed, she held onto them all and pulled them through magic and light–

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Angella stroked Peeky’s hair, newly-grown to cascade down her shoulders. She continued to shiver, even unconscious and under blankets. Micah stared as he entered, almost staggering in the process. “Is that – is she –”

A miracle, Angella thought, able only to nod. Netossa and Spinnerella were only moments behind Micah, rushing to Peekablue’s bedside and gripping the railing. “You had them finish her transition,” Spinnerella gushed.

Angella made a fist with her free hand. “Vultak was misgendering her. Deliberately.” They all tensed up. “It is unlikely to be the worst thing done to her over the years.”

“She’s been drained. A lot,” Catra added, still shrouded in a corner’s shadows.

“We thought she was dead,” Netossa replied. Then she frowned. “Is misgendering a Horde thing?” Netossa asked, almost growling.

“No,” Catra replied. “Transitioning’s no big deal there. Even Shadow Weaver never pulled that crap.”

“Are the three of you all right?” Micah asked, eyes locking onto Glimmer sleeping in a chair. She hugged her staff almost like a stuffed animal.

“They are well, Micah,” Angella assured him, smiling. “You would have been so proud.”

“Sparkles did all the heavy lifting,” Catra said with a smile. “She’s sleeping it off. She earned it.”

Peekablue woke with a gasp. “No – please,” she whimpered. Angella took her hand, focusing the long-lost princess on her. “Angella?” She looked around, still wild-eyed, until she spotted the others. “Micah? Tossa? Spinny,” Peeky gasped. “I made it. You saved me.” She threw her arms around Angella and sobbed.

The queen held Peekablue, smiling as she rocked the princess gently. “You’re safe now. It’s over.”

Peekablue shook her head. “No. It’s just beginning,” she said, clinging to the queen. “The Horde found the Sword of Protection. Hordak thinks it’s the literal key to finding his master.”

“We know, Peeky,” Netossa said, putting a kind hand on her shoulder. “She-Ra’s here.” She grinned. “Not exactly the way you predicted, but eh, close enough.”

It took her several seconds more, but Peekablue slid from Angella’s grip, hugging herself. “I know the Alliance is doing well again, but...I saw them die.” She covered her face. “Ivy. Crystal. Mercia. All gone, and I couldn’t do anything but watch. Bee was the only one I could protect.”

Catra straightened. “The First Alliance?” she asked.

“We didn’t have a Glimmer or an Adora,” Spinnerella explained with a shrug. “We just...happened, I guess. Angella and Micah brought us into their lives, and we managed to slow down the Horde for a while.”

“Then I got caught...” Peekablue whispered. “...it was stupid, I should have known it was a trap...”

“How did you escape?” Catra cut in, stepping closer. *Bless you, Catra,* Angella thought, grateful for the distraction.

Peekablue smiled. “I owe that to you and Princess Glimmer, it seems,” she explained. Catra blinked. “Vultak and Shadow Weaver used my Farsight to enhance their shadow spies. When you banished them, he left to hire mercenaries, I think. He was gone for long enough that I could gather a little magic. That got me out and let me reach Queen Angella’s mind. The rest you know.”

”Shadow Weaver?” Catra whispered in horror. After a moment, though, she nodded. “Makes sense. The Horde doesn’t really have spies. Hordak’s idea of espionage is building more advanced bots and barking orders to sorcerers.” She looked Peekablue over. “Vultak must have been gone a while. Any idea where he went?”

Peekablue closed her eyes. “I think...no, that can’t be right,” she muttered. “The Crimson Waste hasn’t been inhabited since the fall of Halfmoon.”

Catra chuckled. “That’s what Hordak thought.” She nodded to herself, piquing Angella’s curiosity. *This is helping distract Peeky, but Catra is looking for more. What do you see, daughter?* The magicat flinched. “Sorry. You should probably rest.”

“It’s all right,” Peekablue insisted, a touch too quickly. “I want to do something.” Catra nodded at that as well. “I just wish I could help Bee.”

Netossa grimaced. “Why can’t you, hon?”

“The Hive’s still in the Meadowlands,” Peekablue explained. Catra grimaced. *As far from Brightmoon as possible while remaining on the mainland,* Angella realized, *or across the whole of the Growling Sea.* Peeky sat up straighter, looking into the distance. “They retreated to the coast, but even if I could find her, the Rebellion has no way of bringing hundreds of Andreenids halfway across Etheria.”

Spinnerella looked as horrified as Angella felt. “‘Hundreds?’ That’s all they have left?”

"The Horde captured a lot of them," Peekablue sighed, curling up again. "My Sweet Bee doesn't know how to give up, but..."

Catra's eyes widened for a moment. "I've gotta go talk to Entrapta," she said, striding out a moment later. Angella stared. *Do you have yet another miracle in mind, Catra?*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora frowned as Bow, Entrapta, and Catra worked to complete their repairs to Mara's ship. A flickering Light Hope hologram watched from one corner, frowning as Entrapta yelped at an electrical arc escaping some wires. "You know," Adora said, glaring at her girlfriend, "you're almost as good at avoiding as you are at strategy."

Catra chuckled. "You really know how to flatter a cat," she retorted, holding some crystals against a panel while Bow used a device that looked like a stun baton to lock them in place.

"I'm serious!" Adora blurted. "First you fly off without telling anyone–"

"I told Entrapta, and someone had to go after Mom!" Catra objected, humor vanishing.

"–and now you want to take Mara's ship up for the first time in a thousand years so we can, do what exactly?" Adora snapped.

Catra sighed and held her forehead. "Okay. I kinda rushed the explanation, so let me try again. Princess Peekablue was Vultak's prisoner since before Halfmoon fell. Mom rescued her last night. Everyone thought Peekablue was dead except the bee princess."

"Sweet Bee," Adora filled in.

Catra smirked. "Yeah. So Sweet Bee's been trying to rescue Peekablue, but her people are in the Meadowlands." The smirk faded away. "There's only hundreds of them now, but even

Salineas couldn't evacuate that many people across the whole ocean."

"But Darla can!" Entrapta gushed. "It'll be a tight fit, but she's got enough room for a thousand refugees, if it's a short flight and they're willing to get cozy."

Adora blinked. "Darla?"

"I named the ship 'Darla.' It just felt – right," Entrapta 'explained.'

"It could get *really* tight, if they're in the high hundreds," Bow admitted, "but the ship – uh, Darla – should manage."

"We should be there in less than an hour!" Entrapta gushed. "This could revolutionize travel on Etheria!" Her broad smile turned small and sheepish. "If we could, y'know, replicate First Ones tech. Which I can't. Yet! Probably. But I have ideas!"

"Princess rescue first," Catra insisted, "crystal experiments later."

"Okay!" Entrapta tapped on some buttons with her hair, while Bow sat in the main chair, controls appearing in front of him. "And here – we – go!"

Darla took off, Entrapta cackling with joy as the ship soared, racing toward the ocean.

"Fine. We're helping – Peekablue and Sweet Bee, apparently," Adora muttered, grabbing Catra by the wrist.

"Hey!" Catra objected, though she followed Adora without struggle.

"So now, we have most of an hour to talk about how *you died four times,"* Adora insisted, letting go of Catra once they were off the bridge.

"Look, it's not as big a deal as you're making it out to be," Catra said, folding her arms. "Void-Catra probably stole one of my lives

yanking me through time. I got stabbed by a robot spider when it pulled me through the stupid mirror. I used one up escaping from Princess Prom."

"You died instead of letting me help you?!" Adora blurted, eyes wide.

Catra scowl-pouted as only she could. "I know I was a mess, all right?" She snickered. "I mean, if you're upset now, imagine poor Scorpia when I smashed onto the floor of her Sting-Flyer. Man, the look on her face when I got back up!"

Adora couldn't help a brief chuckle of her own. Then she shook her head. "Oh, no. I'm not getting distracted this time. That's why you were so messed up that birthday?"

Catra sighed again, found a chair, and sat down. "Look, she knew I wouldn't stay dead, okay? She kinda made a big deal about it."

"That was the night you asked me to leave with you," Adora whispered. Catra blinked at her, and for a moment, the magicat's beauty took Adora's breath away. *Focus, Adora,* she thought, steeling herself. "Why did you stay when I wouldn't go?"

Catra laughed. Adora's heart lurched, but it wasn't bad – she just had to work not to kiss Catra yet. "Bast, Adora, that was the one time you said you needed me. Remember?"

Adora stared. "Huh?"

Catra raised an eyebrow, crossing her arms. "It was the last thing you said before you fell asleep. Seriously? It turned one of the worst days of my life into one of my best in five seconds, and you don't even remember?"

Adora went pale. "Catra, I was trying to tell you that I needed you to be more careful," she whispered. Catra's smile vanished, and she stood, ears straight up and tail lashing. "I didn't know that Shadow Weaver had *killed* you, but I knew it was bad and I was

worried about you, and please don't be mad I know I was wrong now I'm sorry!"

The silence that followed went on long enough that worry made Adora's skin crawl. Catra's tail took more than a minute to stop slashing the air. She took a deep breath, then let it go. "You didn't know," Catra said, as much to herself as Adora, and the panic started to fade. "If you had finished that sentence, though, I probably would have left."

Adora bowed her head, shame weighing it down. "You should've," she muttered. "I didn't deserve you." *I still don't,* Adora thought – but then Catra had grabbed Adora's head, the first clue she had that Catra had gotten up, forcing her to look into those gorgeous blue and gold eyes.

"I actually hoped for a minute that you weren't trying to guilt-trip yourself again," Catra growled.

"Catra–" Adora began.

"Stop!" Catra snapped. Adora obeyed. "Yeah, I'm a little mad about it, but I could be a real monster sometimes and you put up with me *too.* We didn't know. They *raised* us not to know! So how about we stick to blaming Shadow Weaver, okay?"

Adora hugged Catra for all she was worth. "Let's blame Shadow Weaver," she agreed. Catra nodded over her shoulder. "I just...wonder if it would've been better if you'd gotten away."

Catra huffed and pulled out of the hug, glaring at Adora again. "It doesn't matter, Adora – oh." The glare vanished, and Catra facepalmed. "Ugh. The stupid time thing. It actually might." She shook her head. "Later. Let's just find the bee princess and go home, okay?"

"I guess," Adora said. "It's just, now that I think about it, there was something on the Princess Prom scroll about Sweet Bee and Peekablue being there. I wonder what that was about?"

Catra gave Adora a considering look. “That is...actually kind of a good point.”

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Micah had thought he’d become accustomed to life in Brightmoon since his rescue. Family, beds, other people, and a 90% reduction of bugs in his diet (though they would pry his beetles from his *cold dead fingers)* were all adjustments he’d taken in stride.

Still. Peekablue was alive. Peekablue and Sweet Bee were together again. Peekablue and Sweet Bee were standing in the gateway to Brightmoon, kissing after fifteen years apart, while General Juliet led the last free Andreenids to the barracks.

“So Sweet Bee went to Princess Prom for both of them?” Adora asked, Netossa smiling while Spinerella nodded. “And Peekablue was her ‘honorary’ plus-one?”

“Bee never gave up on her,” Spinny said, watching the two kiss under the great arch.

Catra watched with an impassive air that would’ve fooled Micah not even a month ago. “This was easy,” she noted.

Micah joined her, watching the younger princesses gather with excitement, asking Angella about the new arrivals. “Too easy?” he asked.

“I...don’t want to jump to conclusions,” Catra replied, rubbing the back of her neck. “And after that weird thing that happened when they kissed, it’s pretty obvious blue girl’s not an impostor.”

Micah chuckled. “Peekablue can touch the minds of her friends. It’s how she contacted Angella,” he explained. “When they finally kissed, I think she just...couldn’t hold it in.”

Catra laughed. “I’m not touching that.” Micah shook his head. *I walked right into that,* he thought. “It’s just, the Horde doesn’t seem all that upset about the Rebellion picking up two new

princesses and a small army." She grimaced at the sight of the ragged Andreenids, grateful for even a moment's respite. "A very small army, but still. Vultak should have expected us to try something. And if Shadow Weaver was involved..."

"Casta and I checked her mind," Micah pointed out. "They're not controlling her now."

"But they did," Catra pointed out. "She had it even worse than us. If they are up to something, it's not her fault." She held her chin, tail lashing. "But if this is part of the plan...then what are they doing?"

Neither of them noticed one of the Andreenids blink sideways.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"Cliffy managed not to trip over his own feet," Double Trouble said, smirking at Vultak's image in the tracker pad. "I suppose a spear carrier suits him. Well, there are no small roles."

Vultak smiled back. "Everything is going according to plan. We will begin Phase Two once we have successfully inserted you in Elberon."

Double Trouble laughed outright at that. "Oh come now, birdie, you can play those dullards back home and poor old Cliff, but don't kid a kidder." Vultak's smile vanished. "You would never have let the 'prize of your collection' escape when you could have faked it with one of us."

"Neither of you would have been able to fake Peekablue's Farsight," Vultak retorted, eyes narrowing.

"Except you gave me 'access' before her escape," Double Trouble pointed out. The Force General seethed. "Oh, don't sulk, darling. Improvisation is the true mark of genius. So Peekablue escaped? We just use her to expand our options, as you already devised." The clouds over Vultak's brow lifted. "For a while there, I was afraid you would be boring."

“Well. Succeed, and you’ll be rewarded with riches and the opportunity for all the excitement you could dream of. Fail, and you’ll find I’m not boring in the least,” Vultak warned.

Definitely not, Double Trouble thought. *I almost hope I have an excuse to double-cross you.* They didn’t mention any of that, of course. Betraying employers without a good reason was poor form for a professional. “I’m on my way there. I do hope I run into the magicat. She seems like fun!”

Vultak’s smile returned, more malevolent than ever. “By all means, have all the fun you want with her. Just showing Catra how she was played might be as devastating as stealing her plans, and her thunder.”

“Then it’s time for my grand entrance,” Double Trouble agreed, signing off. *Raise curtain, and take our places. The show will soon begin!*

Chapter End Notes

> Wow. This thing is less an interlude and more of a mid-season special. It wasn't supposed to be almost full-episode long, but one thing followed after another until it turned into this.
>
> Fun fact: the original 1980s Perils of Peekablue is about the title character being mind-controlled by Shadow Weaver. I did not know that when I started writing this chapter.
>
> First Alliance note: Mercia was the name of Mermista's father in the 80s, but I couldn't find parents for Perfuma and Frosta, so they got DC villain references: Ivy as in Poison, and Crystal from the first Killer Frost. Both Etherian princesses were heroines, of course, but, well...we don't see any parents other than Glimmer's. So. Yeah.
>
> I have no idea why I felt the need to patch the entirely harmless micro-discontinuity of Peekablue and Sweet Bee's Princess Prom references, but I did, so here we are. Sweet

Bee having been there will probably be a minor thing at some point, since it was Catra-1's big villain moment in this timeline.

And finally: why yes, that story about Catra's sixteenth birthday will in fact play into the Turn Right Cat-Ra timeline. Funny you should ask...

Super Pal Trio

Chapter Summary

Season 4 BEGINS!

The eponymous hero trio liberate Elberon and make a new friend...or do they?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Move in," Catra whispered.

"Roger," Scorpia replied, Catra's earpiece picking up her voice as though the Scorpioni was right there. "Hey, you ever wonder who Roger is? Was he with the Horde or the Rebellion?"

Catra groaned. "It is a curious etymology," Entrapta agreed, the beginnings of a headache forming behind the magicat's brow, "but I have correlated the sound Catra made with an effort to contain frustration and remain goal-oriented."

Catra blinked, her headache clearing up. "Whoops! Sorry, Wildcat," Scorpia said.

"It's cool. We're all learning." Catra scanned the village. *No loose mothfolk,* she realized, smirking. Styrax had moved all the civilians into three large communal buildings in the center of town. *Good old Horde efficiency.* "We can look it up afterward. I'll bet Bow'll help. For now, we need you two, and those force walls, in place."

"Just about...there!" Entrapta cackled. Her projector mini-bots were, indeed, around each of the three buildings. "Just give the order."

Catra's smirk grew. "Now."

The soldiers scrambled away from Entrapta's Brightmoon-purple shields, drawing their stun batons with admirable speed. "And the lightning rods are out. Snaps?"

Scorpia unleashed her magic, the batons drawing her power right to the troopers. Styrax croaked out a howl and dove for the scorpion princess.

My turn. Leaping and calling on her wings, Catra shot at Styrax, slamming him through a knot of soldiers that were still standing. "Hey, Styrax," she drawled, landing on her feet while he sprawled in the dirt.

Styrax spat out dust and stood. "Catra," he snarled.

A satyr soldier gaped, obvious even through her helmet. "Catra? The Living Arsenal?"

"Ooo, I like that one," Catra laughed, summoning her grapple-whip to one hand and a smoke bomb spell in the other. "I'll beat you up the least."

Catra beat her up the least.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"So," Lonnie grunted, blowing up regular bots as the team advanced, "anyone want to tell me why Catra's liberating Elberon while we're out here getting shot at by Hordak's new toys?"

"Entrapta wants data on these new regenerating bots, because they're based on her tech," Bow explained, firing his new core-drill arrow into one, "but Catra wants her there to protect the mothfolk." Glimmer teleported him to the other side of the battle, where he took out another drill arrow.

Lonnie shook her head. "I am never getting used to that. You people got Catra to care about civilians?"

"Lonnie." Adora grimaced as she waited for one of the spinning bots to bear down on her. "I'm really glad you guys are on our side, but this part I didn't miss." She sliced the bot in half, then grabbed the crystal shard and tore it out before the First Ones tech could start rebuilding.

"Let's not dwell on the past," Rogelio said, grappling with another bot, *"especially in the middle of a fight."*

"Fair," Lonnie agreed with a grin, then charged at the bots heading for the archer and princess. "I'm just sayin', we could've sent some other princesses to do this and gone to Elberon together. Kyle says they throw good parties there."

Glimmer grinned back as she took advantage of the bots' confusion to use her father's lasso spell on them. "They throw *great* parties in Elberon, but Brightmoon's still the best. Bow, how many more do you want?"

"Two more will be plenty to work out their tech," Bow explained, firing a goop arrow at a bot's legs. *He must be out of those bot-killers,* Lonnie thought, breaking out the saw-weapon Entrapta had given her while keeping one baton aimed at her target. "Are we throwing a party after this, Glimmer?"

"It's been too long," Glimmer replied, "and we can't let Catra have all the fun." She forced two experimental bots together, Rogelio holding off classic bots while Adora approached one and Lonnie headed towards the other. "Besides, I can't let Lonnie's only idea of a party come from the Crimson Waste." Glimmer held her head up, her smile a touch ironic. "I do have some Rebellion pride, you know."

Lonnie chuckled as she dug into her bot while Adora pried open the other. "You flirtin' with me, princess?" she asked.

The princess spluttered, and Adora spun so hard to stare at Lonnie that just her pivot finished ripping her bot open. Lonnie almost laughed hard enough to lose her target.

Almost.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

The Super Pal Trio stared in awe (and a little disbelief) at the massive celebration before them. Most of the crowd cheered at their entrance, the rest too preoccupied with party business.

"It's...a party," Entrapta observed.

"It's a *big* party," Scorpia gushed. As far as she was concerned, there were never enough parties.

Catra's mouth had fallen open. "Is this for us?"

"Ah, there you are. Our heroes," a moth woman in a fancy dress called over, shaking Scorpia's claw, Catra's hand, and Entrapta's hair. "Oh, we couldn't possibly thank you enough for liberating our town."

"Data never lies," Entrapta said, smiling.

Scorpia covered her mouth to hide her smile as Catra blushed, holding the back of her neck. "Hey, you know, all part of the Rebellion gig," Catra explained, eyes darting around. "You – you – you didn't have to, y'know," she waved at the growing party, "do you do this a lot, Your...Excellency?"

"Oh, I'm just the mayor," the mothfolk explained. "It was supposed to be a small dinner. You know, a quiet meal, but then word got out and suddenly everyone's invited. So here we are. Rowdy, calling attention to ourselves, basically sitting targets."

Catra's expression flattened. *Aw, Wildcat,* Scorpia worried while the adopted princess looked around, about to say something when a confetti cannon went off. Both magicat and mayor yelped, Catra whirling while the mothfolk straightened. "What was that?" the mayor gasped before recognizing the rain of confetti. She held her chest and breathed. "Okay, okay. Terrifying booming sounds were probably a bad idea."

"We'll keep you safe," Catra insisted, moving toward the door. "Snaps, ET, you enjoy the party. I'm gonna patrol for–"

"Nope!" Entrapta interrupted, wrapping a hair tendril around Catra's waist. "According to Bow's observations and my correlation, you engage in approximately 40% less leisure time than any member of the Princess Alliance except Adora."

Catra huffed, scowling a bit. "Figures Adora's overworking–" she began.

Entrapta frowned back, crossing her flesh arms. "Adora engages in 25% less leisure time than any member of the Princess Alliance except you."

Catra blinked. "Entrapta, I swear to Bast, if you're counting your lab work as 'leisure time,' I'm going in there with a blow torch and – wait, I'm working harder than Adora?" She fell into a chair, staring in shock at a random wall. "I'm working harder than Adora." She groaned and buried her face in her hands. "What happened to me?"

"You always worked hard," Scorpia insisted. "But honestly, you need a break. And look at this place! It's amazing!"

"Scorpia, if the Horde comes back, even I won't hear them through this noise," Catra pointed out, ears twitching and tail lashing. *Okay, tail lashing is always worry, but ear twitching is usually alert, and she just said – oh, wow, why does Catra not realize she's good now?*

Entrapta hummed in annoyance. "Catra, you asked me to build shield bots to protect the town. How could they do that without proper sensors?"

Catra stared at Entrapta. "Entrapta, are you telling me that the entire town is being patrolled by bots that can detect Horde activity and raise force walls in seconds?"

"Seconds? Hah!" Entrapta pulled out a remote control and grinned maniacally...which was pretty normal for Entrapta. "Try three-tenths of a second!"

"Wildcat, you've been working way too hard after getting hurt way too much," Scorpia pointed out, shoving down the guilt. "You need to take some time to rest and recharge. It's, like, your duty."

"Proper rest and morale cycles are necessary for optimum effectiveness!" Entrapta agreed. "Bow keeps telling me that, and the data definitely supports his commentary." Scorpia smiled again at the inventor's faint blush.

"Well...if it's for optimum efficiency, *and* we've got smart bots on patrol..." Catra's shoulders un-hunched, and she grabbed a mug of something frothy. "Let's party!"

"Yeah!" Scorpia and Entrapta cheered, Emily beeping merrily. Catra went to reassure the mayor about the protector bots, then they all joined the celebration.

Entrapta created holographic displays of abstract art while munching on tiny food, the symbols changing in time with the local music. Scorpia got her hair woven with flowers, wondering if Perfuma would appreciate the look. *Oh, gosh, this isn't plant-insensitive, is it?* She looked at Emily, but the bot just beeped at her. When she found Catra...

Scorpia thought she was going to explode from cuteness. Catra was sitting with the kids and telling stories, gesturing and conjuring the occasional image while the children watched with rapt attention. "Then She-Ra's sword slashed right through the image, doing nothing," Catra whispered, and the kids gasped. "I conjured my best ward circle at it," she continued, doing just that, "but 'poof' – useless!" The circle vanished.

Scorpia sat on the far corner of the gathering, listen to Catra finish the tale of Alwyn. "'Memories of people long gone, going through the motions of their lives, never realizing that their whole

world is gone? That sounds like a ghost story to me,' Adora said. That's when I realized how much I wanted to help her find her people." Catra smirked. "Then Entrapta kissed Bow, and we kinda got distracted."

The kids laughed, a few shouting "Ew!" in the process. Catra shook her head. "Okay, that's enough story time for now. Go play or something." She shooed them off, and the children scattered, laughing and pretending to hunt ghosts.

"Sounds like you've had some wild adventures," a teen pink moth girl said, leaning on a table with a glass in her other hand. She was wearing a pink suit a touch darker than her skin, with white-topped boots.

Catra looked over, then stood, smiling again. "Yeah, well, that's life in the Rebellion, I guess." She stuck out her hand. "Catra."

The pink mothfolk accepted it. "Flutterina," she replied.

Catra froze. "Oh. Crap."

Flutterina laughed, then finished shaking hands. "Relax, Your Highness. All of Etheria knows you switched sides. I mean, if Frosta doesn't hold a grudge, who would?" She nudged Catra in the arm. "Have you *seen* that girl's temper?"

Catra paused, then joined in the laughter. "I know, right? Once she forgives you, though, Frosta's done. She's actually been helping me with my scorch-ice." The magicat demonstrated with a small spike of freezefire, glowing gold and warm above her palm. Flutterina oohed over it. "So, you're the local princess, right?"

Flutterina stared, even pointing at herself. "You've heard of me?" she blurted.

"You came up in liberation planning, y'know, 'cause you were at Princess Prom and all." Catra's ears went back a bit. *More guilt. Oh, Wildcat.* Scorpia bit back a sigh. "We're going to bring in a garrison to protect Elberon. You don't have to fight, you know."

Flutterina looked away, eyes flickering downward. “I wanna,” she replied, gesturing at a few humans on the far end of the room. “I’ve seen what the Horde does. I just...don’t know how.”

A human with a purple bob haircut with matching lipstick walked over, blue eyes going from Flutterina to the ex-Horde princesses and back. “You okay, ‘Rina?” they asked.

Flutterina put on what Scorpia called in her head a ‘morale smile.’ “I’m fine, Swen! We’re just–”

Emily beeped in alarm, eye-light-thing flashing red. “Horde bots detected!” Entrapta cheered.

“Not a good thing, ET,” Catra muttered.

The mayor rushed over. “Oh, we need to evacuate the town. Now.”

Scorpia pouted. “Aw, do we have to?”

Catra facepalmed. Scorpia’s tail drooped. “Rescues first, parties later,” the magicat insisted. The mayor nodded. “Scorpia, Emily, you lead the civilians to safety. Entrapta, you’re with me, let’s find out what these bots are made of.”

“Right!” Entrapta cheered as everyone moved out.

No one noticed Swen blink sideways.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Entrapta laughed as she pried the First Ones crystal shard out of the bot’s remains while Catra shook the frostflame out of her claws. “Faaascinating. It appears that Hordak has worked out a way to get functional power out of smaller First Ones tech. This could revolutionize our power systems!”

Catra glared at the remains. “Yeah, if he doesn’t overrun us with the stupid things.” She glanced back the way they came. “Let’s

head back to Elberon. This was too easy."

"Easy?" Entrapta asked. "That was a larger bot than usual, and a few blows made from ignorance would have resulted in several more of them to fight."

"'Never count on the enemy doing what you expect.' It was the most important lesson I learned from the Horde," Catra replied. "One regenerating bot is counting on the enemy doing what you expect. There should have been at least three."

The friends looked at each other, then leaped onto Susan and raced back towards Elberon.

Entrapta knew she still had much to learn about the vagaries of combat, but she'd been friends with Catra long enough to know a battlefield when she saw one. Catra tensed up and swerved Susan around to a cavern on the edge of town. *She knew where they would evacuate,* Entrapta realized.

Catra exhaled in relief at the sight of the townsfolk safely behind purple barriers, though Flutterina was pressed against the shield with a look Entrapta categorized as 'significant fear for another.' Then Catra tensed up again. "Entrapta, drop the shield," she ordered. Entrapta obeyed, Catra leaping over to the mayor. "Scorpia? Emily?"

At once, Entrapta understood and shared Catra's concern.

The mayor blinked back tears. "They – they held off the Horde so we could get to safety. Scorpia wasn't having any problems until that masked woman appeared..."

Catra's puffed tail and upright ears needed no translation. "Shadow Weaver," Catra gasped. "Stay here, ma'am. Entrapta, give the mayor controls for the shield bots." Entrapta did so with a hair tendril, then whistled for Susan. "We'll be back as soon as we can–"

“Wait!” Flutterina rushed out to mothfolk yelps. “I know I'm small and I'm not a Rebellion fighter, but I wanna help. So, can I come?” Catra looked at one of the few people there shorter than her, tail lashing. “Please? I’m not strong, but I’m fast and smart and I can’t just stay here. I can do something, I know it!”

Catra’s ears pivoted back again. “Oh, I’m going to regret this,” Entrapta’s friend sighed. “You stay low, you do what I tell you, and when the shooting starts, you *get behind us,* is that clear, kid?”

Flutterina responded with an eager salute. “Yes, ma’am!” She smiled.

“Please be careful,” the mayor called as the trio got on Susan.

“Always am,” Catra replied, and then they were racing towards Scorpia, Flutterina pointing the way.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

“It was supposed to be Adora,” Shadow Weaver muttered.

Styrax snorted. “Story of your life, isn’t it?” the fool asked. Shadow Weaver let lightning play between her fingers. The vultureman went silent. They looked over the bots monitoring the temporary base, Shadow Weaver turning her attention to the prison pit and its two inhabitants.

Dylamug and Callix stood guard over their former captain and her guardian bot, the cyborg smirking while the geolonian kept watch. “You know, I always figured it would end this way,” Dylamug said. “Your mothers couldn’t follow orders either.” Scorpia looked up in horror, eyes glistening for a moment. Then she hissed, tail quivering with a warning clatter.

I do believe Scorpia has finally learned something, Shadow Weaver noted. Callix, alas, proved weaker. “Come on, Dyl, leave off,” the geolonian grumbled. “It’s like Prime teaches, primitives can’t help where they’re born.”

“Don’t start again, Cal,” Dylamug replied, eyes narrowing. “This happened because you coddled her. At least Pia’s got a spine, even if she joined the enemy to find it.”

“You don’t get to call me that,” Scorpia snapped. “Not now.”

“Who’s gonna stop me, your girlfriend?” Dylamug mocked, leaning over and glaring. Shadow Weaver sighed and checked the communication pad Hordak had given her. *At least the main plan is viable,* she thought. “Oh, wait, she’s in love with the blonde idiot!”

That’s when Dylamug screamed, and his robot arms fell to either side of him. “Snaps is my friend, Scrap-face,” Catra hissed, having landed behind the cyborg. Freezefire burned along her claws, no longer sheathed in trauma-caps.

Callix turned and cracked his knuckles while Dylamug’s new First Ones systems kicked in, pulling the arms back and repairing the damage. “Loyalty. Commendable,” Callix replied, “but foolish. You can’t defeat us alone.”

Catra’s smile was a feral leer. “Only one way to find out, rubble-brain,” she snapped, throwing frostflame in his face and backflipping away from them. The duo gave chase, falling for the obvious distraction. *Well, I didn’t request them for their intellect.* Shadow Weaver gestured to Styrax, who dove towards the battle. Then she scanned for their undercover agent–

The mothfolk brat led Entrapta toward her pets. Shadow Weaver felt a smile form beneath her mask. *“You must allow the others to escape,” Hordak had commanded, “but should you bring Entrapta to me, I will...overlook your failures.”* She summoned lightning and shadow to paralyze the inventor princess.

“Flutterina! Look out!” Shadow Weaver looked up to find ‘Swen’ throwing bits of metal debris at her. The sorceress tried to sweep them aside, only to find her lightning grounded by the metal.

Her attack stopped 'Swen's,' but the interference remained infuriating. Shadow Weaver glared at Swen. The creature blinked sideways at her. *Earning their trust. Ah well. Perhaps some good can still come of this.* Shadow Weaver dropped down, pressing her hands against the gantry, and sent shadow force rippling towards the spy. Swen cried out.

Catra, determined to pretend heroics, grappled to Swen and extracted them, forced to allow Shadow Weaver to batter her in the process. The smile beneath her mask grew.

Then she saw pellets drop around Dylamug, Callix, and Styrax, exploding into smoke and the capture glue Bow favored. *She anticipated that?* Shadow Weaver raged. Catra smirked even through the pain. "CATRA!" Shadow Weaver screamed. The beast's smirk only grew.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catre knew it was stupid to lose her patience over this. Of course they strapped Scorpia's pincers shut. It would be suicidal not to. And yet, seeing Shadow Weaver's magic pinning her friend like that – *Fine, I guess she is my friend after all,* she thought, grousing even to herself – pushed Catra's temper beyond all limits.

With a roar of fury, she slashed through all three Force Captains *(Seriously, Hordak promoted those two morons? How desperate is he?)*, then blasted the oncoming mixed unit of foot soldiers and bots with a combination of flash-bangs and frostflame. Coating the ground with scorch-ice for good measure, almost laughing as the soldiers yelped at the heat even as they slipped, Catra leaped to deflect Shadow Weaver's magic. "Wow, did you actually figure out Entrapta's smart, or is this just Hordak's orders?" she mocked, counter-circles roaring at her fingertips.

Shadow Weaver's eyeslits narrowed. "I want you to remember, Catra, that *you* made this necessary." She pointed her arm skyward, lighting the heavens with a crimson bolt. *Signal!* Catra

realized, hopping back and crouching. She created scorch-ice shields for the others while she prepared for Shadow Weaver's backup to arrive.

She didn't have to wait long. "Daughter of Angella," a voice Catra had heard once before crooned from above. Catra stared, swallowing. *So that's what they look like.*

Most of the harpies looked tired and worn, bodies covered in thick, dirt-caked down except for their arms and clawed feet. Only their lavender wings were clean, some feathered, others bat-like. Their leader was far cleaner, with her three silvery horns gleaming like a crown, and her down-feather coat a brilliant lilac. She had feathered wings, with dozens of those feathers orbiting her the way Sweet Bee controlled stinger-spears. "Hey, Hunga," Catra guessed, 'rewarded' for being right with a sadistic smile.

"So you are the broken half-champion Angella loves, and the Weaver despises," Hunga mocked, hovering in place. She was the only one who could, her subjects circling. "I will enjoy your ruination."

Catra laughed, erasing Hunga's smile. *That's it, look at me, pay no attention to the genius doing the job,* she thought, putting hands on hips and putting on her best mocking smirk. "I'm right here whenever you're ready, *princess."*

Hunga shrieked. "Gayda! I want her claws!" she cried. The largest – and most worn – of the harpies pointed a spear at Catra. The whole flock howled, diving at her.

Catra backpedaled, flaring her suit-wings, until they'd committed to their dive. Then she stamped her foot, summoning the largest, thickest wall of scorch-ice she'd ever managed. Catra had given them just enough time to pivot away – *I don't want to kill them* – but every last one crashed into the wall. "Keep trying, princess," Catra retorted.

"Miserable stray of Angella!" Hunga shrieked. *Wow, even the evil princesses don't like it when you mock their title,* she noted, tail curling behind her. *Come to think of it,* my *backup should have been here by now. Where are you guys?*

That was when Hunga's feathers shot at Catra like a swarm of arrows. Catra yowled and dodged, shattering most with frostflame, but at least a half-dozen slammed into her back. They tried to dig into her flesh, but Entrapta's harness turned into light armor, throwing them off. "Thanks, ET," Catra whispered.

"Fools! Catra is distracting you!" Shadow Weaver had spent the time Catra used up fighting harpies to gather the full power of her magic. Casting a quick telekinesis circle, Catra braced herself to dodge–

Scorpia *exploded* out of the pit they'd kept her in, flying by riding columns of Garnet lightning. Catra couldn't help staring as the Black Garnet princess glared silently at Shadow Weaver. Without a word, she unleashed her power on the sorceress, who couldn't even deflect the full blast with all her magic. Catra halfheartedly bounced from one enemy to another, unable to take her eyes off the one-sided mismatch. *Awesome. But scary. But awesome!*

Hunga flew beside Shadow Weaver, making a shield of *feathers* somehow; while no match for Scorpia's Runestone-born power, it held long enough for the pair to dodge aside. Catra fell back to protect Entrapta, Flutterina, and Swen while they used a lasso of ET's hair to haul Emily out of the pit. Flutterina gasped and ET gulped when Catra planted herself between them and Dylamug, Callix, Styrax, an entire squad of angry harpies, and a full platoon of soldiers.

With timing rare for the Alliance, Perfuma rolled in on a veritable river of plant life carrying Bow and Rogelio, scattering the entire Horde force. "How dare you treat our friends like this!" she cried, Shadow Weaver tried to hit the trio with a dark spell, but Scorpia moved faster than Catra had ever seen any princess move, and she was just *there.* A single crimson bolt shattered Shadow

Weaver's spell, and Perfuma stared up at Scorpia with stars in her eyes. Catra grinned for a moment, taking the opportunity to grab the shard she'd sought with her TK spell. *Wait, where are the others?*

Glimmer appeared over Entrapta and the locals, Adora and Lonnie releasing her shoulders when they arrive. For once, Adora was already in She-Ra form. Catra cackled. "And fight's over," she said, smirking at Shadow Weaver as she closed her hand around the stone she'd stolen. "This is the part where you run."

"Foolish beast," Shadow Weaver hissed, "this is only the beginning!" She shrouded the battlefield with a wave of her hand.

With a fierce roar, Adora plunged the Sword into the murk, burning it away in an instant. The Horde was already in full retreat by then, the princesses cheering and hugging.

Perfuma turned her attention back to Scorpia, eyes more alight than ever. "Goodness, Scorpia, you were amazing!" she gushed.

Scorpia almost blushed the color of her carapace, rubbing the back of her neck. "Oh, wow, gosh, it was nothing. Besides, Catra and Entrapta had to rescue me first." She looked down. "And...I used up most of my lightning. It'll be a while before I can do that again."

Catra grinned. "Don't be so sure." She held out her hand to show Scorpia the fragment of the Black Garnet she'd stolen. Scorpia gasped. "I knew the witch would slip up sooner or later."

"Aw, Wildcat..." Scorpia's eyes brimmed with tears.

"Well. Y'know. What're friends for, right – oof!" Catra grunted at the sudden, entirely expected hug. In spite of the laughter, she smiled. *Us freaks have to stick together.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

“Isn’t this amazing, Swen?” Fluttterina gushed, spinning in place in one of Brightmoon’s many overwrought halls. Double Trouble forced themselves not to laugh at the little pest. “An orphan princess and a Seaworthy refugee, heroes of the Rebellion!” She stroked the ribbon Catra had pinned on her with one thumb, pride almost glowing from her. “This is gonna be great!”

“Sure, ‘Rina, but first, we should get some sleep.” Swen yawned, nudging Flutterina towards her bedroom.

“But I’m not–” Flutterina yawned with perfect timing. “–tired.” Double Trouble kept their smirk inward as they led her on. *I’ll give you this, Pinky, you do hit your cues.* Flutterina rubbed her eyes. “’M not a little kid, y’know. I’m fourteen. I’m not even the youngest princess in the Alliance.”

“Of course, ‘Rina.” It was simplicity itself to get a warm drink into the girl, and the girl into her bed. “Just a nap, then? For me? I need the rest.”

Flutterina sighed as Swen pulled up a chair and leaned back with another yawn. “’Kay, Swen. For you. Always wanted...a best friend...”

For just an instant, Double Trouble froze. *Too easy,* they told themselves, pushing aside the brief attack of feelings. They faked sleep with perfect ease until the child followed. Then they stood with a wide, sharp grin that was all theirs. “‘Peekablue...I see you,’” they whispered, transforming into Flutterina. The real thing’s breathing grew soft and careful, while Double Trouble draped the covers over her head, and knowledge of every interaction she’d had with the castle’s residents filled their mind. *This almost feels like cheating,* they thought, *and there’s no such thing in acting.* They strode out, wandering the castle with Flutterina’s empty glass until they came across Catra and Glimmer in the dining hall.

“Lonnie?” Catra sighed, scratching her mane. “You’re going on a date with Lonnie, for Bast’s sake?”

“She caught me off guard!” Glimmer objected, throwing her hands in the air. “Yeah, I had to tell her off about you, but then she was really nice about it, and she’s like made of muscle, and did you *see* her fight those bots?”

“I get it, she’s hot,” Catra groaned, going from scratch to facepalm, “why do you think I was jealous of her when we were all in the Horde together? Lonnie was my only real competition for Adora.”

Glimmer laughed. “News flash, Wildcat, you didn’t have competition.”

For an instant, Catra’s ears twitched and her tail lashed. “Could’ve fooled me,” she muttered, sighing and looking away. *Oh, just hand me this one, why don’t you?* Double Trouble thought with delight.

“Hey,” Glimmer began, putting a hand on Catra’s shoulder, “it’s like you always say–”

‘Flutterina’ stumbled into the room, dropping her glass. The adopted sisters stared. “I wasn’t listening!” ‘she’ blurted, shooting upright. Glimmer giggled while Catra raised an eyebrow. Double Trouble looked away, seeming abashed. “...on purpose,” she muttered.

“Listen, ‘Rina, life was weird in the Horde,” Catra explained, glancing away. “Rough. Me and Adora–”

“Adora and *I,”* Glimmer corrected.

“–have a lot of stuff to work out, but we’re gonna be fine,” Catra insisted, briefly glaring at Glimmer.

“Well, obviously!” Flutterina gushed. “You’re dating She-Ra! She’d fight anyone to protect you!”

Catra swallowed. “...right. Thanks kid I’m going to bed now.” She walked out, but it bordered on running.

Glimmer sighed and shook her head, while Flutterina stepped behind the glitter princess. “Is she ever going to get over that?”

Double Trouble blinked sideways at Glimmer’s back, just because they could.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Peekablue couldn’t move.

She was bound in bands of shadow, writhing in terror while Vultak and Shadow Weaver ran cold fingers along her jawline. “Give in,” Vultak whispered, his smile a nightmare made flesh. Peekablue couldn’t even shake her head ‘no.’ *Please...please...* she begged.

“Pathetic seer,” Shadow Weaver mocked, “least of all princesses.” Stroking fingers gave way to vice-like grip. “You thought to play the hero, and now you belong to us. Forever.” *no. please...*

Vultak’s face filled the universe. “Peekablue...” *Help...someone...anyone....* “...I see you.” *Please! Help me! Too long! Too much! I can’t! Not anymore! Get him away from me! Don’t let him touch me! Help me! HELP ME!*

“PEEKABLUE!”

The Farsight princess shot bolt upright in her bed, gasping and flailing in terror. *Not bound – not held – free – Sweet Bee! Where–*

“I’m here, love,” Sweet Bee said, stroking Peekablue’s cheek with those fingers, so very soft for a heroine of living armor. “We’re in Brightmoon. You’re safe. He can’t touch you. I’m here.”

The real world came back into focus, her awful dream vanishing at the sight of the room Angella had so kindly given the couple. Her Sweet Bee, golden and beautiful, gentle and fearless, holding her safe. “I’m okay now, hon,” Peekablue exhaled, quaking in Bee’s arms. “It’s just…”

“...for a moment, I would have sworn Vultak could see me.”

Chapter End Notes

Dun Dun DUN! Foresight! Foreshadowing!
Fore...sight...shadowing?

Metaphor got away with me. Anyway, I had a lot of fun writing the SPT bonding as good guys.

Next time...HALFMOON!

Magicats

Chapter Summary

Princess Felicia and Sir Percival arrive to join the Alliance. Shadow Weaver Does Not Want That.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra stared as Peekablue adjusted the holo-map, turning down its eye-stabbing pink to an infinitely more tolerable mix of lavender and violet. "Bast, I wish I'd known about you sooner," she blurted, fingers probing the adjusted image.

"It's probably just as well," Peekablue whispered, though she flashed a shy smile, Bee still holding her hand. Netossa and Spinnerella hummed with joy in their seats. "I'm just glad I can help."

"You know we missed you, right, girl?" Netossa said. Peekablue nodded, eyes down but still smiling.

Angella sighed, leaning forward. "Catra, dear, *please* tell us if something here overwhelms your senses."

Catra shrugged, scanning the map. "I'm used to it," she muttered, analyzing the new battle lines.

"Catra," Angella insisted. Catra looked up to find the entire room staring at her – well, except Swift Wind, who was glancing around, clueless.

It was such a little thing, but Catra felt so – *What's the word? Right* – she felt *seen. Like I matter, even when I'm a freak.* She nodded. "Yeah, okay. Now." The others relaxed as Catra traced progress lines through active units. "The good news is that we've retaken all the civilian regions Void-Catra overran, and we're in a

better position to advance on the eastern front." She zoomed out, then tapped the western region. "The bad news is that Hordak's taken almost the entire west, including the Crimson Waste and the Meadowlands."

"My kingdom is ready to kick Horde bu – I mean, push toward the Valley of the Lost," Frosta reported, sitting a little straighter.

Catra scowled. "I know, Frostbite," she agreed, "but we have literally one ally in the Waste. Worse, Lashor sided with the Horde instead of Scorpia." The Bubastis zoomed in, scanning the Waste-Fright Zone border. A hint of hope flickered in the back of her memory. *Eh. Probably nothing–*

Peekablue uncurled, sitting bolt upright. Her eyes glowed the blue of Adora's. "They come!" she cried, looking up with a gasp. The glow seemed to pull her to her feet. "A princess of land and blaze! A knight of sword and staff!" Half the princesses were already on their feet. "Darkness hunts them, fears alliance with Alliance – NO!" Peekablue collapsed back into her chair. "There," she whispered, pointing at the exact location Catra had been staring at. "Allies. Shadow Weaver fears them. The Horde will send its strongest."

"What allies?" Angella asked, staring. "Dear, you and Sweet Bee are the only Princesses of Power who were still missing."

Peekablue shook her head, eyes fluttering half-shut. "No. There is one other." She leaned into Sweet Bee, barely conscious. "Halfmoon..."

All of Catra's fur stood up at once. "Magicats," she breathed, need and terror warring in her heart.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora clung to Swift Wind's neck, eyes firmly on Susan.

Overhead, Darla carried Entrapta, Frosta, and Adora's squads old and new. Below, Catra, Scorpia, Netossa and Spinnerella roared

across the desert on Susan. Catra raced onward with a speed and skill that made their first skiff ride into the Whispering Woods seem absurd.

(It *was* absurd, thinking about it now. *I wonder if we'll ever find a timeline where we just stayed home.)*

"Wildcat to Overwatch. Anything?" Catra asked, a faint crackle in the comms.

"Nothing yet, Commander," Lonnie reported.

"That reminds me, when are we getting back to the game?" Frosta demanded. Adora smiled in spite of herself.

"Belay that, Frostbite," Catra replied. "We need this princess."

"Yeah," Glimmer agreed, "I would *not* mind having an army of Catras on our side."

Adora could almost hear Catra twitch. "Just remember, they can make us stay dead," Catra reminded them. "That's why the Horde used tanks to invade Halfmoon. And flamethrowers." Soft growl. "And Shadow Weaver."

"We have data!" Entrapta cheered, and Adora sat upright, Sword springing to life in her hand. "Five degrees starboard from straight ahead, 700 meters and closing, Horde tech signatures, and, yes! Two forms of element control."

"Two?" Catra whispered. "Why does that sound...right?" Adora could just make out Catra touching the cheekbone below one eye. "Later. Prep for combat, ice floor under the rearguard and wind to push 'em back, BFS tackles the front line, the rest of us are zone defense. Anyone still breathing, we keep 'em that way."

"Roger!" they all cried.

"The Horde used it for the letter 'R,' shorthand for 'received and understood,' did you know that?" Scorpia added, charging up as

they closed.

"Contact!" Catra barked just as Adora caught sight of the battle. A Horde company fired on a rock outcropping that protected some weird skiff-cart, only half its levitation systems active.

It's them, Adora realized. Two figures crouched behind the cart, one a feline person like Catra, the other a huge cat, both wounded. Two more fought the Horde – a big, muscular figure, gray furred with white points, golden eyes shining while he fought wielding a staff like Huntara's. Beside him, a slender, feminine magicat with purple fur and blue eyes summoned more stone from the earth, flickering flames around her ears. *That must be the princess. Except for the colors and straight hair, she could be Catra two years ago,* Adora thought. "Percival, if I don't embrace the flame–" the princess began.

"No need, Felicia – backup has arrived!" the big one – Percival – cheered, pointing at them.

Adora shifted to jump, but Swift Wind shook his head and dived. "Oh no, you're not doing the jumping thing again. For the Rebellion!" he shouted, charging at the nearest knot of tanks.

Crimson lightning crawled around a squad in the back as Adora braced herself to cut through the cannons. "Catra! It's her!"

"I see her," Catra agreed. "'Tossa, you're with Frostbite and your wife. Nail that witch."

"Wildcat, it'll be my pleasure," Netossa said. Then they engaged, and Adora was too busy tearing through tanks to worry about quips.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Felicia stared, barely able to believe her eyes.

For fourteen years, she had dreamed of finding her childhood best friend-slash-big sister. Her first thought after bonding with the

Eyes had been rescuing Catriska, who had sacrificed more than her life to keep Felicia safe.

Now here she is, protecting me again, Felicia thought, watching the Rebellion drive back the Horde's mightiest forces. Shadow Weaver's lightning fractured a howling windstorm while a titanic blonde drove back the vile Grizzlor. Vultak emerged from the shadow of a Scorpioni princess, only for a woman with living hair and another armed with stun batons to drive him back. A Horde soldier Felicia didn't recognize rushed towards the battle between Vultak and the two Rebels, propelled by purple tentacles extending from her odd harness.

The battle only grew more chaotic from there. Felicia created a stone platform to watch from over her ice-reinforced wall, drawing fire to her palms. "Catriska! How can I help?"

"Can you take out cannons on your left flank–" Catriska began, then froze as their eyes met. "I – I know you–" She snarled and winced as Weaver-lightning sparked in her mane.

"Triss!" Felicia and Percival cried as one. Cannons turned on the stumbling heroine. Percy transformed and leaped out with fantastic speed, reaching Catriska at the same time as the huge blonde. A living sparkle bomb dropped a bot on Grizzlor from two stories above, then reappeared to help an archer. The blonde unleashed massive golden beams while Percy carried Triss back toward the wall.

"I'm fine," Catriska snapped, then looked at Percy and froze outright. "You – are you – an uncle – mine?" She clutched her head and rolled behind the wall, hissing.

Tears ran through Percival's fur as he sheltered Catriska with his massive tiger frame. "Oh, Triss. I am, I'm here, and I'm so sorry I wasn't before."

"Catra!" Shadow Weaver howled. "Attend me! You remember Kyra today, for you *have your mother's eyes."*

Felicia thought Catriska had frozen before, but this time she was utterly paralyzed. Then she screamed, the lightning shooting from her skull into the heavens. She kept screaming, thrashing in Percival's embrace. "Catra!" the blonde cried, rushing to kneel at her side. "Stay with me!"

"...four words…" Catriska – *Catra,* apparently – sobbed. "...or the end of the world...i'm sorry, mom..."

The sparkly one appeared next to the blonde. "That was a trigger command, Adora. I think she just made Catra remember everything."

Catriska nodded. "hurts. 'll get better. go get 'em," she insisted.

Adora and Percival shared a look. "I will protect her with all my lives," Percy swore. Then he looked up at Felicia. "Hey, Felicia. You know how I told you to hold back your Roar-Fire? Now, *don't."*

Adora strode towards the front line. "Princess Felicia, make a wedge up the middle." She pointed her crystal sword at the center of the Horde formation, swarming with bots. "We'll pry them apart."

Felicia let a growl rumble in her throat. "Gladly!" She called all her flame between her palms, held them up…and Roared.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra groaned, vision starting to clear.

"Catriska C'yra D'riluth!" Mom huffed, shaking her head while Triss hid under a pile of sheets, giggling. "I'm going to ground that girl until her First Change, I swear..."

Blobby figures began to take recognizable forms – Adora, Glimm, the magicat princess.

"Look, Triss-sis, I caught it!" Felicia cheered, the small fish flopping in the kitten's claws while Catriska watched with pride.

The blacksmiths forging armor between her ears finally started calling it a day.

"That's it, Triss – extend, swing, retract, aim, jab *– perfect!" Catriska beamed as she went through Uncle Percy's clawsword drill side by side with him.* I'm gonna be the best champion, just like Mom,*the young magicat decided.*

"Catra," Adora breathed, relief writ in everything from her voice to her legs, all relaxing in a single wave. "How do you feel?"

"Like a tank battalion ran drills inside my skull," Catra drawled, managing to sit up. She glanced around. Everyone she'd worried about was there, even the two Bubasti who'd been down. Entrapta and one of the magicats Catra didn't recognize were fixing the skiff-sled-carriage thing. "Worth it if everyone's okay."

"Your friend was impressive," Felicia said, tucking some loose hair behind Catra's ear. "The Horde sent most of its elite forces, but she pulled us together enough to drive them back." The magicat princess chuckled. "Then she landed your ship on them."

Catra's eyes bulged. "You didn't," she gasped.

"We didn't just beat them. We beat them with *Kyle,"* Lonnie quipped.

Catra laughed, pain be damned. "Cool." She moved to stand, and Uncle Percival helped her up while Adora and Glimm frowned. "Relax, Adora, I'm not stupid. I just want to reach New Halfmoon on my feet."

"Just 'Halfmoon,'" Felicia added, smiling as she beckoned Catra to the skiff-sled-carriage thing. "No one calls it New Halfmoon now."

Catra held her head, and the world only spun a little. "Meh, whatever works. Glimm, can you do the diplomacy thing? That tank battalion's down to a company, but I'm not the ambassador type on a good day."

“Relax, sis,” Glimmer replied with a grin, though Felicia huffed and glanced away, “I’ve got it covered.” She patted Catra gently on the shoulder. “Besides, you’re their long-lost hero.”

“Walk away, child,” Shadow Weaver warned, dark magic swirling around her hand. “I offer this one final mercy for a love long lost, but if I cannot have a princess, revenge will suffice.”

Catriska thought about Felicia quivering in the vent behind her. She looked up at the horror she faced, then did the only thing that made sense. Leaping onto the sorcerer’s leg, Triss bit down, digging in with all four sets of claws.

Catra blinked. Then she smirked, ruined only by the headache. “Huh. Way better than Shadow Weaver’s ‘abandoned in a box’ crap.”

Felicia snorted. “That’s the best the witch could come up with?”

“Creativity isn’t her strong suit,” Catra shot back, the magicats grinning at each other. Her smile vanished when she needed Adora or Percival (definitely not both, but how was she going to argue that with them?) to help her onto the skiff-sled-carriage thing. “So, what is this, and how did you get it working?”

Entrapta pulled herself out from under it with her hair, grinning like the mad genius she was. “It’s called a driftwagon! Oh, I have so many ideas for the SKS fleet!” Catra blinked and stared. “Susan’s Kid Sisters. It’ll be a whole fleet of skiffs! Or driftwagons. Or something completely new!” ET laughed.

Catra shook her head, smiling in spite of the tank squad rumbling behind her eyes. She held onto the railing as they took off, a weird energy field keeping her steady. “Okay, I gotta ask. How does this thing work?”

“Stored kinetic energy!” Entrapta gushed. “They program gemstones with magic to work like *science!* Driftwagons use them to levitate and protect cargo, and they collect energy from the wind as they move. It’s amazing! And efficient.”

“I gave them a recharge while you were out,” Spinnerella explained, her smile gentle.

Catra nodded, summoning her nail caps back on. Even with blurry vision, she could tell Felicia and Percy were staring in horror. “Trauma caps?” Felicia whispered.

Huh. Catra nodded. “Sounds right. Long story. Later?” she asked, and they nodded.

A few moments later, they slid to a halt in front of a very ordinary looking cliffside. Percival whistled five notes, and the stone shifted aside to let the driftwagon through. “Handy,” Catra noted.

“And tricky to mimic,” Percival explained with a grin. “Most species can’t hear all the reverberations.” They floated down a dark tunnel that led to darker corridors. Catra relaxed, her eyes adjusting as the constant sensory overload of her life faded away.

“Wow,” Bow whispered. “It’s kinda...quiet.”

“And dark,” Glimmer agreed.

Felicia chuckled. “We’re nocturnal hunters.” She gestured ahead, only walls that looked like sandstone to either side of them. “Besides, this is the Labyrinth Ward. Old Halfmoon had one, but...” her smile faded. “...well, the Horde proved it wasn’t enough.”

“And magicats can just...get through this?” Lonnie asked, waving ahead.

“Oh, yes, Bubasti possess highly accurate environmental memory,” Entrapta explained, sprouting flashlights from multiple hair tendrils. Glimmer lit up her hand. Halfmoon’s darkness seemed to resist the light. “Where reduced input would hinder invaders, most magicats could memorize the path in one trip.”

Catra blinked at Entrapta. “Huh. I always wondered why everyone kept getting lost in the Fright Zone. Not sure why Brightmoon

gave me trouble."

Percival laughed. "Hint's in the name, Triss." He reached out, and Catra let him put an arm around her shoulders. "You must've spent half your life dealing with too much of everything."

Catra nodded, then straightened. "Hey, my head doesn't hurt!"

Adora beamed while one of the formerly-wounded magicats turned from the controls to grin at her. "The Labyrinth juices up our regeneration," he explained. "Greer's better too," he added, pointing a thumb at his partner.

"You got hit worse than me!"

"Eyes front, Tyrone," Percival chuckled, and Tyrone turned around, fur flaring. Catra steadied herself on Adora. *It's a whole...kingdom, of people like me,* she realized.

"Ho, the gate!" Percival cried as they reached what looked like a dead end. Again the wall slid away, and Catra stared, overwhelmed. *I made it.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora stared at the city, jaw slack.

Towering spires covered in lapis lazuli pulled streams through the air to fill overhead aqueducts, forming shining arches of liquid that left tiny rainbows in their wake. Long buildings of crimson brick were lit by crystals called tiger's eyes, soft golden light shining between red bands, lighting stone columns. Above them, archways of sand-colored stone held up bridges between the buildings overhead. There, Bubasti rode graceful skiffs, elegant driftwagons, and amazing steeds called Takdryl – basically half-dragon, half-horse, wings and all.

All around them, magicats watched the procession as they floated through bustling market streets and passed silvery temples. A full quarter of those watching had become large cats of several kinds.

“Bast,” Catra whispered, and Percival’s smile grew further, “how many of us can do the changing thing?”

Felicia and Percival both stared at Catra with horror. “She...even denied you the First Change?” Percival gasped.

Before Catra could answer, they rounded a corner past a tower, and the palace ahead took Adora’s voice with Catra’s. It was a massive stepped pyramid – *a zigguat,* Adora remembered – ten stories tall, with staircases going up all four sides, while more lapis stretched from the stairs to flow over the corners. At the top was a citadel covered in tiger’s eye, glowing gently from above.

When the Rebels stepped onto the stairs, they *moved,* carrying the group up. Again, Catra and Adora clung to each other...a bit more closely this time. Adora blushed. They straightened, but Catra’s tail curled around her waist, and Adora nearly burst from the love surging through her.

Soon, they were before twin thrones. The queen had raven hair and lavender fur, dressed in an elegant blue wrap with a gold belt and trim. Her eyes were a striking scarlet, and her crown a golden band adorned with a single sapphire. Her king was a massive, tawny man with a fierce crimson mane. He wore blue armor trimmed with steel, the only gold his bracers. Standing on the queen’s other side was an old-looking magicat, his fur silver-gray, wearing a dark gray robe and leaning on a cane. “Catriska, you stand before Queen Selina and King Claudus, rulers of Halfmoon and protectors of the Eyes of Qadi,” Percival explained, then turned to the monarchs and straightened. “Your Majesties, it is my great honor to escort home Princess Catriska D’riluth, born to Champion Kyra, adopted by Queen Angella and King Micah of Brightmoon.” They all bowed.

The court gasped as one. Selina braced herself. “Micah lives?”

Glimmer strode forward and curtsyed with a grace Adora envied. “Yes, Your Majesty. My sister and Princess Entrapta devised spy-

bots for intelligence. They found my father on Beast Island, and Catra, Adora, and Bow rescued him."

Selina stood, her smile a silver-white beacon. "You must be Princess Glimmer. We are overjoyed that your family has been reunited, doubly so that our beloved Catriska made this possible." She turned to Catra, who straightened. "Bast. You look so much like your mother."

"Um. Thank you Your Majesty." Catra gulped, then pulled Adora to her side. "This is Adora."

Selina's smile didn't vanish, but faded by half. "Ah, yes, the First One chosen by the Runestones to be Princess of Power."

Claudus stood. "Please tell us, Your Highness, how you came to Etheria."

Catra's fur rippled, claws peeking from her fingers for an instant. "She's with me," Catra said, stepping halfway in front of Adora.

"We were raised in the Horde together," Adora added. Quickly. The Bubasti monarchs' eyes widened, and they – relaxed? *They're less afraid of the Horde than the First Ones?* she wondered.

"If you can call what Shadow Weaver did 'raising' us," Catra muttered.

The entire court looked on in horror. "Of course," Selina whispered. "My deepest apologies, to both of you," she continued in a stronger voice. "I assure you, Adora, Halfmoon is well aware that your – the First Ones produced both heroes and villains, just like every people. Now." She folded her hands and smiled. "Since the monarchs of Brightmoon have embraced you as we intended, Catriska, let us merely say that you will always have a place in our court and home."

Cloudfoot gently cleared his throat.

Selina glanced at him, eyes narrowing a fraction before returning to the entourage. “Please, rest and enjoy the hospitality of Halfmoon. We thank you for aiding our daughter, and will discuss Alliance membership in the morning.”

“Yes!” Glimmer whispered. Cloudfoot cleared his throat slightly less gently.

Catra huffed, and Adora stiffened. “What?” Catra demanded, hands on hips. “If this is about Adora–”

“No,” monarchs and advisor insisted.

A knight almost as big as Percival stepped forward. Aside from his green eyes and white diamond forehead tuft, he could have been Catra’s brother. “This is about your Champion status.” He flinched when Selina and Felicia hissed as one.

Catra scowled. *Uh-oh,* Adora worried. “Someone’s got a problem with me,” Catra said.

“With respect, Princess Catriska,” Cloudfoot explained, “you were raised by the Horde, then became the Rebellion’s chief strategist. You wield Freezefire, yet cannot Change. Hero of Elberon and Thaymor, you shattered Princess Prom and nearly took Salineas with one ship.” He sighed, leaning on his staff. “Surely you understand how some councilors might be concerned.”

“I wouldn’t believe you if you said *everyone* here trusts me,” Catra retorted. “What’s this about?”

“Political nonsense,” Selina half-growled. “You are a *princess,* and would be welcome here regardless.”

Glimmer teleported beside Catra. “Then why do they care?” Glimmer asked.

The white-tuft-guy sighed. “Because if you took the Champion trials–” he began.

“Sir Tao!” Felicia blurted.

Catra throat-growled. “You don’t think I can do it,” she hissed.

Uh-oh! Selina’s eyes widened in time with Adora’s. “Catriska, you cannot even Change,” the queen noted, claws knitting the air.

Catra yanked off her capelet, tossing it aside. “Shadow Weaver murdered Catriska. My. Name. Is. Catra. Let’s get this stupid thing over with.”

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra hung upside-down from an outcropping, turning the last dial. She smirked as the sixth door opened. “And that’s all the ‘mental’ tests. Is this trial gonna get serious now?”

Selina’s grim image appeared. “I fear so...Catra. The trials next test your heart, your spirit.”

“You weren’t supposed to fight all eight drones...” Tao muttered behind the queen.

“That was three trials ago,” Catra laughed. “Get over it.” She swung down and darted through the opening.

The chamber was an empty brick-red cavern the size of Adora’s room. Catra blinked and walked toward where the door should be.

Horde-Catra appeared in front of her. “Hey, Catra,” she mocked. Catra stared briefly, then walked through her to probe for an exit. “Yeah, no. You don’t get to ignore me. Three fights, easy. Three puzzles? Boring.” The fake Catra’s smile was murderous. “Now? Me.”

“You’re the easy one,” Catra retorted. “I’ve been listening to you for too long already.”

The Force Captain badge vanished. “No! You don’t get to ignore me!” the younger Catra howled.

Wait, younger? Catra wondered. The figure had started almost identical to her, but had become a fraction shorter. "Ugh. Not more memory crap."

"Figures! Leave me behind like everyone else!" That snapped Catra back to the present, even as her counterpart shrank to 14, rail-thin after three days in the Box. "How am I not good enough even for *you?"*

Bast. She is a little real, Catra realized. *I can...feel her.* She shook her head. "You became good enough. You became *me."*

Horde-Catra was 10, wearing the training vest from the Crystal Castle memory. "I'm still here!" she cried, shaking her head. "You won't forget the stuff you did, but you wanna forget everything else?"

"Wouldn't you?" Catra whispered, staring at the image.

She became Catriska, five years old, in a tattered Halfmoon onesie. "D-don't you wanna remember me, at least?" Catriska held out her hands, eyes wide.and tear-filled.

Catra shivered, feeling pathetic, broken, *weak.* She took a trembling step back, and "Catriska" fell to her knees, sobbing. *No,* she thought, desperate to walk away from her wounds. Catra sighed and kneeled beside her childhood self. "Yeah," she admitted, holding out her arms. Catriska jumped into them, her sobs turning into tears of relief. The two became one, Catra holding herself. *So much for–*

The seventh door opened into a room of white stone and golden light. Catra gaped. "I...passed?" She shook her head. *Don't complain, dummy,* she thought, rushing in.

Adora stood in front of her, tears staining her cheeks. Catra felt stabbed. *Sekhmet, that was the* easy *one,* she realized. "Catra, please, you don't have to do this."

"You're not Adora," Catra retorted, tail lashing.

“That was a part of you,” Adora said, waving behind Catra. “I’m...a promise.” Catra only wished she felt stabbed, then. “Why do you still feel like you have to prove something? Aren’t we enough?” Promise-Adora walked up to Catra, and Catra could feel her fingers in the fur on her cheek. “Aren’t I enough?”

“Was I?” Catra snapped. Adora shuddered as if stabbed herself. *Down, stupid,* she thought. “Sorry. It’s just...I get it, now.” She shook her head. “I wish our lives were...sane, or free, or even normal, Adora. But they’re not. I wish I could give you what I have here. Maybe one day, I will. But right now, Selina and Felicia are trying to protect me from–” Catra chuckled. “–protecting them, I guess.”

“You know who it has to be, right?” Adora whispered. “After me. The only one who’d be worse.” Catra paused, then nodded. “Please, Catra. Why can’t I protect you?”

“You can,” Catra replied, stroking Adora’s chin. “Just not always. You have to trust me...” she leaned in. “...and I have to trust you.” Catra smiled. “I love you, Adora.”

Catra kissed her. *It really was Adora,* she thought as the image faded away.

The last door opened. It was, of course, almost entirely dark, lit only by crimson lightning. Catra squared her shoulders and marched in.

The door closed behind her. Familiar chuckling echoed around Catra, her scars glowing the crimson of Garnet lightning. It made Catra look almost clothed in them, only the most sensitive areas around her face, chest, and hips not alight. “Insolent child,” Shadow Weaver hissed. “Ungrateful beast. Nuisance. *Disgrace.”*

“Play another song,” Catra retorted, hands on hips, “that one’s old and pathetic. Like you.”

Shadow Weaver snarled. “Cowering in Halfmoon will not save you.” She stepped out of the darkness, illuminated only by

lightning. “You can never escape me.”

Catra huffed and paced around the illusion. “Actually, that has to be why I’m here. Obviously.” She looked up and down the hateful figure, mind racing. “I just can’t figure out how. This isn’t supposed to be a puzzle, but...I’ve beaten you.” Catra smirked. “Like, a lot.”

Shadow Weaver chuckled. Catra’s smile vanished. “Oh, Catra. You never listen.”

Catra bristled. “Right, that’s why I’m *winning–”* Lightning lashed out, burning across Catra’s back. “OW! What the–” The magicat’s bravado vanished. *The first room was a little bit me. Same with Adora.* She leaped back and crouched, summoning frostflame to one hand and a countermagic circle in the other. *Crap.* Her eyes narrowed. “If I’m so ungrateful, why bother with me?”

“You have disgraced me for too long,” Shadow Weaver said, firing more bolts. Catra parried, returning fire with frostflame, but the magic passed harmlessly through the image. Shadow Weaver laughed. “Fool. Only my mind is here. Your lifelong dream has only led you to your doom.”

Catra cackled to hide the terror freezing her blood. “My ‘doom?’ Seriously, how does Hordak put up with–” she yelped and dodged more lightning. *Think think think! If I can pass the test she’s gone.*

With that, Catra froze. “Hah!” Shadow Weaver cheered, firing another blast.

Catra took it with a grunt. “Oh. *Oh.”*

Shadow Weaver’s eyeslits widened. “No!” She fired another bolt.

It tingled as it passed harmlessly through Catra. “I wasn’t supposed to forget my past.” She shrugged off more lightning. “I couldn’t ignore Adora.” She strode through Shadow Weaver. “But you...you don’t matter any more.”

Shadow Weaver screamed and vanished, the darkness flowing away as the final door opened.

The Eyes of Qadi stared back from a chamber much like the throne room. One was a brilliant, sculpted lapis with a golden streak through the center, set in dark stone. The other was amber with a sliver of blue leaf at its heart, lined with flickering flame.

Between them stood Kyra, smiling with joy. "*Hijita.* My beautiful Catriska."

Catra couldn't move. If Shadow Weaver showed up again, she'd have been dead. "mom?"

Kyra walked up and stroked Catra's cheek. She leaned into the ghostly touch, eyes shut yet crying without shame. "Champion of Halfmoon. I'm so proud of you." *If Adora didn't need me, I think I could die happy right now.* The touch faded, and Catra looked up again.

"Sorry, Percy, but I'm guiding her through the First Change," Kyra said, grinning. She held out her hand. Catra took it, some magic making it solid. "So many think you're small, but they only see the surface," her mother's memory continued, grasping the shadows cast by the fire. "It's in the name, Catra. We're more than we seem. *Bigger on the inside."* She held out the shadows for Catra to claim.

Catra took them, able to hold the darkness in her hand. "This...isn't the usual trick, is it?"

"We're in a hurry. It's a two-for-one." Kyra smirked. It was almost a mirror. "Spinner wanted you to fear the darkness, to take it from you." She nodded toward Catra's hand. "Take it back. Let the greatness inside you roar free." Kyra faded. "I love you, baby."

"I love you too, Mom," Catra replied. Then Kyra was gone. She held the darkness, no longer afraid of it. She pulled it in, just like Freezefire, just like sorcery. *I really am a princess, huh?*

Catra Roared.

A lifetime of being trapped in her skin fell away. At last, Catra had something that didn't demand to be controlled or held back or reined in. Her body grew, muscle and bone shifting to hint at the true grandeur within. She became part-lion, part-tiger, hair rippling down her back, might in every claw.

At last, Catra Changed, and was free.

All her friends and half the court burst in through the exit, rushing to her side. "CATRA!" Adora cried, holding onto her as if for salvation.

Catra laughed, Changed back, and kissed her without shame.

The others babbled about how worried they were, some wizard apologizing for the Shadow Weaver thing, but all Catra heard was Adora. "We were about to break in when–" Adora began.

Catra laughed again. Kissed her again. Really, there was only one thing to say.

"Hey, Adora."

Chapter End Notes

A few quick notes:

1) I keep each main chapter to about 5,000 words for a few different reasons, so I had to decide on which stuff stayed here and which got moved to the next chapter. Don't worry, there will be more magicat history before we go.

2) I've been planning that trial for *months* now. It didn't go exactly the way I modeled it, but I think it worked. And you can take my "magicats speak Spanish" fanon from my *cold dead keyboard.* ;-)

3) Yeah, I used a lot of the descriptions from Better Angels, but they're the same place in different timelines. I tried to tweak them for clarity.

4) Don't worry about the Obstructive Bureaucrat councilors. They won't be an issue again, not after Catra basically moonwalked through most of the trials. Cloudfoot and Tao are actually on Catra's side, which will hopefully be clearer in the next chapter.

5) The five notes Percy whistles are the beginning of the Fire Emblem March. Just because. :-)

Next time: The Horde isn't done with the magicats, and Shadow Weaver is not out of tricks, not by a long shot...

Halfmoon

Chapter Summary

> In the Second Battle of Halfmoon, Hordak will leave nothing to chance. This time, he leads the Horde himself.

Chapter Notes

> Me: I have the most important writing deadline of my life coming up
>
> Also me: I need moar magicats

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Shadow Weaver forced herself not to panic.

Hordak is in the field, she worried. *Stars,* Hordak *is in the field.* The Horde Lord looked over the ragged force, literally run over by a skyship. He scowled. "I trust you did not flee that encounter empty-handed."

Vultak gulped, but Shadow Weaver bowed. "Of course not, Lord Hordak," she assured him, holding out one palm. An image of the Halfmoon Labyrinth appeared, crimson light tracing the correct path – and defenses – through it. The image spread, tracing through the heart of the kingdom, into the palace, then deep below it. "The memory restoration spell included tracking magic. I always suspected we would need it if Selina retrieved her."

Hordak nodded. "An acceptable outcome," he agreed, examining the entrance to the underground city. "We will bring the magicats to heel." He glared at Shadow Weaver. "This time, *without* needless slaughter." The sorceress nodded. *Kyra is...gone. There is no point, now.*

Vultak cleared his throat. "Ah, my lord, urban warfare is not my strength, let alone underground–"

“I will lead this assault myself,” Hordak snapped, silencing the wide-eyed Vultak. “Clearly, my technical efforts will have to wait until the Rebellion is properly brought to heel.” The vulture nodded, swallowing, but Shadow Weaver smiled behind her mask. *Victory will mollify our “lord,” while he can only blame himself for defeat,* she observed. *And Halfmoon is the perfect opportunity to reclaim Adora...and rectify a mistake left festering too long.*

She made a fist. *It’s time for Catra to die.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

To Catra’s surprise, Tao laughed and slapped her shoulder. “That’s showing those council stuff-shirts!” he cheered, grinning.

Selina huffed. “You are too pleased by half, Tao Extalian.”

Tao’s smirk was familiar. “She’s a D’riluth, Your Majesty. There’s no way she’d turn down a challenge, or fail one like that.” He waved at the Eyes almost dismissively. “Hiding it from Catra would’ve only pissed her off.”

Catra’s tail lashed. “It’s not that,” she corrected, making her tone as gentle as she could. “I need to do stuff, to help – to *matter.”* Tao’s smile vanished, tail lashing with worry or guilt. Both monarchs sighed. “And – you guys can call me Catriska, if you want,” she said, lips pressed together. “I...don’t wanna forget.”

“Oh, sweetie,” Selina replied, “you don’t need to fight to matter.”

“She’s right, Wildcat,” Glimmer leaped in before Catra could deflect. “So, hey, what about these Runestones?” Catra rolled her eyes, but couldn’t help smiling. *Thanks, Glimm,* Catra thought, letting Adora hold her. Glimmer, however, took a closer look at the Eyes. “Uh, I was gonna mention that you’ve got two, but...why do they feel weird?”

Felicia’s smile finally returned. “Because they’re not really Runestones.”

“Wait,” Frosta blurted, “is that why you get two powers? Why are we stuck with one?”

Glimmer sighed while the other magicats’ ears pivoted back a fraction. “Any princess can learn sorcery, Frosta,” she said. The younger princess rubbed the back of her neck, grin sheepish.

Adora sighed. “There’s more to the story, isn’t there?” She hugged Catra a bit closer. Catra let her. *Oh, Adora.*

The other Bubasti looked at each other. “Perhaps we should make this part of touring Halfmoon,” Cloudfoot suggested, glancing at the queen.

“Yes,” Selina agreed. “As impressive a victory as this was, I see no point in lingering.” Catra shivered and nodded. *Too much Shadow Weaver, all at once,* she thought as they returned to the palace.

Now that they weren’t dealing with the twin blows of finding the magicats and the alien majesty of Halfmoon, Catra took the chance to look over the city from the pyramid’s peak. The castle was at the center of a complex with smaller buildings of nearly identical design around a central plaza. “The Eyes were once part of a tradition of Tenantin, or Mother Stones. The ancient magicats discovered how to draw ether from the earth and shape it into elemental magic. We believe that’s the origin of Etheria’s name,” Selina explained. Felicia rolled her eyes and gave Catra a nudge, but even with her memories restored, Catra felt like the time Adora had brought her three ration bars when she was recovering from the Box. *Like I’m starving, and all the food in the world just got dropped in front of me.*

“So the First Ones got the idea for Runestones from your Tenantin?” Adora asked.

Cloudfoot sighed. “The records indicate that the First One explorers wanted to combine the Tenantin with their ‘magitech,’” he explained, the stairs carrying them back down. “It was meant

to be the best of both worlds: their advanced science, our mastery of ether." Catra smiled at Entrapta's overjoyed squee.

Bow's eyes were dancing between buildings. "You must have spread across Etheria by then," he noted. "That word...Tenantin, it's not Halfmoon or Candilan."

"Candilan?" Catra asked.

"Your mom said 'hijita.' It means 'little daughter,' but the diminutive is about affection, not size," Bow explained.

Catra's eyes widened. "Wait, you heard all that? Saw it?" Adora hugged her a little tighter. Catra hugged her back.

Bow nodded. "And look at the architecture," he continued, pointing out different districts. "Those aqueduct archways are classic Candilan, but the only stepped pyramids I've read about are from the Valley of the Lost. The temples and obelisks are different too, with the columns and sloped lines." He swept an arm to take in the city. "Salinean. Brightmoon. Those look pre-Scorpioni. There's even some that look like pre-Snows ruins."

"Good eye, son," Claudus agreed. "Once, the Persis Empire spanned all Etheria." He huffed as they headed towards the market. "That collapsed long before the Eternians – excuse me," Claudus added, snickering once at Cloudfoot's stare, "the 'First Ones,' ever arrived."

Adora looked from Claudus to Cloudfoot and back. "Is it...not okay to call them Eternians?" Her eyes widened with a gasp. "Wait, you know about Eternia?"

The magicats stared. "The surviving records are...were inconclusive," Cloudfoot explained. "The name Eternia is – or was? – controversial from a scholarly standpoint, not a cultural one." Bow grinned.

"We got the info from Light Hope," Catra jumped in. "Entrapta and Bow have mostly freed her from the, uh, bad guy First Ones." She

relaxed with the other magicats. "Gah. We need a better name. But I'm *definitely* not calling them 'Masters of the Universe.'" She snickered. "Or 'Evil Warriors.'"

Percival moved a little closer as they left the plaza, walking towards the city center. "Some of our legends call the evil Eternians 'Dread Ones.' For my part, it suits my sense of poetry."

"'Point Dread,'" Catra muttered, remembering Scrambler's intel. Entrapta nodded.

"But this world was all magicats before they showed up," Adora insisted. Catra's throat rumbled in frustration.

"The 'Dread Ones' suborned the First Ones' work," Selina filled in as the smell of food took the edge off Adora's guilt and Catra's worry. *Is that fish?* Catra wondered as Selina continued. "They could not conquer Halfmoon, but took most of the other kingdoms. The Skeletor could not destroy the Heart-Blossom, so he was forced to convert it–"

"Wait wait wait," Catra blurted, snickering along with Glimmer, Frosta, and Netossa, "I'm sorry, really, but the *Skeletor?* That's what they call their boss?"

The magicats weren't laughing. "He blighted the other Tenantin, to be devoured by the Dread One Runestones," Cloudfoot replied. Catra's mirth died. "His servants bound the might of She-Ra to the Sword that was once the First Ones' gift. The Skeletors were cruel, racist tyrants, dragging millions from countless peoples to Etheria in chains. The worst Skeletors drove entire worlds to the Horde's embrace."

To Catra's surprise, Selina smiled again. "Yet that was their undoing. A heroic alliance of First Ones, magicats, and freed captives drove the Dread Ones off Etheria. Without the many peoples the Skeletors brought here, we might never have been free."

“But that doesn’t explain why there are so few of us left,” Catra replied. “Wasn’t there even one magicat surface kingdom?”

Their smiles vanished again. “Yes,” Felicia admitted. “Candila.” The Alliance heroes stared, Glimmer’s horror obvious. “After the Rebellion – well,” she shrugged, “the first Rebellion – the victors decided the Spirit Ember was a natural choice for the Bubasti princess. When the Dread Ones returned, trying to enslave the last She-Ra, Princess Tartara became obsessed with defeating them.”

“So the story is...kinda true,” Glimmer said.

“She ordered her remaining civilians to safety as the Spirit Ember resonated with the Golden Eye beyond Tartara’s control,” Selina explained, “but much of her army remained as the Dread Ones descended from the sky. The story says that, with everyone she loved gone, Tartara lashed out in one last effort to protect them.” Selina shook her head. “Even the power of the Sapphire Eye cannot heal the land now. It is barren down to the bedrock.” Just as the smells neared overwhelming, and they turned a corner to find a row of food stalls two blocks long. “Enough sad tales. I’ve never known a teenager not to be–”

Catra rushed towards the best-smelling stall, mouth watering. “–hungry,” was the last thing she heard Selina say before Catra, Adora, and Felicia found themselves staring at the most delicious-scented food she’d ever found. They looked like pastries, but they smelled of fish and beef, with hints of garlic and other spices Catra didn’t even recognize.

“This is *pastelillo,”* Felicia explained, buying two for each of them. “It’s a...tough pastry fried around filling, in this case spiced fish and fowl.” Catra dug in without hesitation, purring at the first bite. The stall owner’s smile shone bright. “It was a favorite in the Candilan Archipelago back when they had a shoreline.” Catra nodded, still purring.

Adora's smile put the stall lady's to shame. "You feel safe purring," she whispered, eyes wide and shimmering.

"I think I'd feel safe here even if you were in Brightmoon," Catra replied, licking her fingers. "Being here *with* you? I never even imagined feeling this safe befor–"

Explosions echoed from the Labyrinth Ward. Civilians gasped, the older ones hunching with tails lashing. Catra scowled. "I had to open my stupid mouth." She shoved the other pastry-thing into her mouth and summoned her shadows. *They are gonna be* so *sorry for this.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Glimmer stared at the descending army and forced herself not to panic. She almost didn't manage it.

It's him.

She saw Hordak during Catra's rescue, of course. Glimmer remembered trying not to think about him fighting She-Ra head-to-head. *I used to think Hordak was a fraud. That he took advantage of how long we'd been at peace,* she thought, watching the magicats fall back.

He really is that dangerous, isn't he? Glimmer realized.

She looked to Bow, who had more arrows than he'd arrived with, and Felicia, riding a floating stone platform and holding flame in one hand. "Where's Catra?" Glimmer asked, trying not to worry.

"With Mom, advising on strategy," Felicia assured her. Glimmer relaxed a little. *Okay. Everyone's being smart. Good. We can do this.* Both magicat and best friend offered Glimmer their hands. She took both and pulled.

That's what it always felt like, a tugging just behind her bellybutton. Glimmer pulled through there, and went where she needed to go. This time, they appeared on a defense tower,

magicats firing beams of light at the Horde while cannon fire tore through buildings. Hordak stook on the lead tank of a rolling wedge, crawling towards the Halfmoon front line. With Hordak was every major commander left that Glimmer knew of – Shadow Weaver, Vultak, Hunga, Styrax, Grizzlor, Dreer, Dylamug, Callix...even Octavia, in spite of the nearby desert. There was also another sorcerer and the bald woman with the weird tentacle harness. "Jitat," Felicia whispered.

Bow glanced at the magicat. "What does that mean?" he asked.

Felicia's cheek fur went flat in what Glimmer had come to recognize as a magicat blush. "It's, uh. Rude." Her expression went hard, and she crouched, claws out. "Cover me." The tower's light-beam fire became more scattered, keeping Horde forces at bay. Bow nodded and started firing area-suppression arrows like flares and goop-explosions. Glimmer joined in with reflection circles, turning Horde fire back on the attackers. The attack was intense enough that each spell began to crack the moment she went to the next one.

With a roar, Felicia sprang upright, slashing the air as she thrust her arms skyward. A wall as thick as the tower was wide erupted from the earth. It sealed off the entire city, stretching from one side of the cavern to the other and reaching all the way to the roof of the cavern far overhead. Felicia fell to her knees, panting. "That was...woo...harder than I thought," she panted.

Bow stared, eyes wide. Glimmer just stared. "I can't do *anything* like that," she pointed out.

Felicia grinned, weak but satisfied. "And I can't teleport Shadow Weaver to the daymoon, what's your point?" she asked.

Glimmer grinned back. "I can't make it *that* far, but, point taken."

The wall began to glow a sickly green, several points shining brighter. Felicia's smile vanished. "I knew it would only slow them down," she muttered. "Now what?"

Glimmer bit her lip. “We ask your mom?” she asked. Felicia nodded, they both offered their hands again. Glimmer took them, and *pulled.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora bounced on the balls of her feet, all nervous energy and need to stab things.

(Especially Shadow Weaver things.)

“Bast, you guys are good at this,” Catra was saying, relieved, but Adora was only half-listening.

Claudus chuckled. “Hey, Selina, you’ve got a fellow Pesedjetan.” Catra replied with the *cutest* *mrrp?* The king’s chuckle rolled onward. “Follower of the Old Gods. Most religious magicats worship Saz.”

The queen rolled her eyes. “You just noticed now?” she drawled.

Claudus’ smile vanished as he fumbled for a defense. Catra laughed. “You’ve got one too, huh?” she asked. Selina raised a delicate eyebrow, and Catra pointed her tail at Adora. Adora’s eyes went wide while Catra drew advisory lines on the battle map. It was nearly identical to Brightmoon’s, except the topography was deep blue and markers were a burnished gold.

Glimmer appeared with Bow and Felicia. “Wall’s up,” Felicia groaned, “but it won’t last five minutes.”

“That’s okay, baby,” Selina assured her. “We’ll have the civilians clear in three.”

A rumble echoed in Catra’s throat, not quite a growl. “Still weird you have all your military buildings right outside the Labyrinth,” she muttered. “Sure, a lot of them, but–”

“No magicat child will ever again suffer as you have,” Selina replied. Catra’s eyes went wide, tail dangling limp. “I need to keep

Hordak out of the city proper for ten minutes. How do we do that?"

"Zone defense," Catra said, attention snapping back to the war map. "Adora goes after Hordak," she continued, Adora nodding, "Scorpia takes on Grizzlor, I'll grab Vultak, 'Tossa and Spinny handle the other fliers. Have your brightpaw rangers go after tank treads, hit the infantry with lots of smoke bombs and the like. Once the infantry is confused, we mess up the wedge point with mines, earth magic, lightning fields – everything we've got." She shook her head. "Shadow Weaver's the wild card. Getting past the Labyrinth had to be her..."

"I'll stop her," Glimmer insisted, punching her palm.

Catra glanced over, tail lashing to mirror Adora's worries. "You sure, Glimm?"

Bow smiled. "Nothing the Best Friend Squad can't handle."

Catra and Adora looked at each other. "I'll go with them," Felicia said before either of them could object. "I've waited my whole life for a shot at that witch."

Catra swallowed. "Don't underestimate her." They all nodded. "Okay. Move out."

They obeyed, Queen Selina's smile wry as Adora leaped, forming platforms of light beneath her as she raced towards Felicia's wall. The whole thing was glowing green by then. Adora landed about 20 meters back, forming a shield just before the stone exploded.

As Sir Percival and King Claudus led a small army of magicats against the Horde's heavy armor, clawswords and brightpaws flashing, Adora leaped at Hordak, jumping from one conjured platform to the next, glad Swift Wind was on Darla with Kyle and Rogelio. With a scream of fury, she called forth the Sword and interrupted Hordak's orders with a descending slash. "She-Ra!" he snarled.

“Congratulations!” Adora snarled back, thrusting. He parried with his own shield. “You can recognize an eight-foot-tall glowing princess!” She kicked the shield, then killed the tank he’d been riding with a downward thrust.

“You insignificant traitor,” Hordak snapped, firing a crimson beam at her. She parried, pushed back even with Catra’s strength twined through hers. “You will perish, and the Horde will forget you existed.”

“You *are* the Horde, monster!” Adora howled, transforming the Sword into a clawsword and spring-thrusting it through Hordak’s shield. He grunted and trapped it in a pincer. Adora bound the pincer in a lasso, which he escaped by shrinking the appendage back into his armor. *Stalemate. Again,* Adora thought, furious and frustrated.

“I am an instrument of Prime’s will,” Hordak retorted, glaring. Adora’s fury cooled, remembering Light Hope’s warnings about Horde Prime. “You could have been beloved in his sight. Instead, you have chosen the shadows.”

Catra leaped from the darkness in full lioness form, slamming Vultak out of the sky. Joy pulsed through Adora’s heart. “Hordak,” she said with a smirk, “you have no idea.”

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Don’t enjoy this, Catra orders herself.

It doesn’t work.

Finding out Vultak was stalking Queen Angella – her *mom,* and gods that still feels strange – was bad enough. But Peekablue...

Catra bounces him off a tank, then throws him into Grizzlor. Scorpia was already blasting the ursid, resulting in two shocked Force Captains. “Hey, Vultak,” she mocked.

Vultak took one look at Catra, then raced towards Scorpia. *Uh, no.* She lassoed him with darkness and pulled him back. He squawked in terror just before Catra Changed, smashing an Adora-strong paw into his face. A light on her harness turned purple. "Entrapta, do the thing," she quipped.

Half the tanks lit up purple, cannons whirling around to aim at Horde bots. Cannons flashed, their beams shorting out bots rather than blowing them up. Catra's smirk vanished. "ET?" she called.

"Hordak's redesigned his bots!" Entrapta cheered over comms. "He replaced the network with an optical communication and hardened them against wireless interference. It's so exciting!"

Catra shrank out of Vultak's claw slash, then did a handstand-kick into his jaw growing to normal. "But you hacked them," she pointed out, watching the shorted-out bots turn purple and join Alliance forces.

"That's what took so long with the tanks," Entrapta explained. Tentacle-harness-lady rushed over to the lead tank, end-claws whirring. "I had to redesign the cannons to carry a direct electromagnetic payload with a full reconfiguration system. I needed a few minutes. Sorry about that."

She...just... Catra gaped at the glowing tanks. It distracted her enough that Vultak almost caught her off-guard. She drove him back with Freezefire. "ET...do you have *any* idea how brilliant you are?"

"I do," tentacle-harness-lady said, the tank she was on turning green again. Catra gasped, then snarled and leaped. Vultak darted away, Catra tracking him by hearing, but the bald lady wove her tentacles in a cunning whip-like defense.

Just before Catra tumbled backwards to go after Vultak, she met the lady's eyes. Magenta...exactly like Entrapta's. Realizing she was bald to accommodate some kind of headpiece for the harness

was an afterthought. “Entrapta! Tentacle lady’s got your eyes!” she warned. “Might be a clone thing!”

Tentacle-lady laughed as Catra hunted the buzzard. “Oh, Catra. Tell the princess her Aunt Estra is here to bring her home.

Catra’s mind reeled. “Entrapta–” she began.

“I heard,” Entrapta replied, more shaken than Catra had ever heard, “but that’s impossible, Aunt Estra died during the First Alliance.”

Catra gasped. “Queen Selina! We need Takdryl cavalry on Hunga’s people, Netossa and Spinnerella are about to...” She trailed off, landing on Vultak just as the Takdryl riders engaged with the harpies and the wives of power descended on “Aunt Estra” in a fury.

As if Catra didn’t have enough to worry about, Shadow Weaver darted in from behind a drill-engine, firing lightning at her. Catra dodged by shrinking to housecat-size, then formed a shield of darkness and Freezefire. Shadow Weaver unleashed more lightning...and the shield *held.* They both stared.

I’m not sure which of us is more surprised.

Catra was even more surprised when Shadow Weaver didn’t say anything. She just started drawing countermagic circles. “Huh,” Catra muttered, forming her own countermagic.

Glimmer interrupted by coming down on Shadow Weaver like divine wrath, screaming and pummeling the witch with sparkling fists. “Get! Away! From! My! *Sister!”*

Catra’s smile died as it was born. “Glimm, I lost Vulta–”

A stone fist slammed Vultak to the ground beside her, the buzzard tangled in a familiar net arrow. “Styrax! *Backup!”* he cried, trying to escape as shadow. Blazing flames pinned him by surrounding

him in light. Bow smiled and flashed Catra a thumbs-up, then fired a flare arrow at Shadow Weaver.

The witch snarled, batting the arrow aside with shadows, but flinched from the burst of light. "Fools. That feral thing is no princess," she hissed, still trying to retreat. Glimmer redoubled her assault.

"Just push them back," Catra said, firing frostflame at the descending Styrax. "Hordak's targeting Halfmoon's military infrastructure, he's already wrecked more than half their defenses." She tapped her ear-comm even as she blasted at Styrax. "Uncle Percy, we need to slow them down more, where's the worst advance?"

"Left flank," Percy replied, "Octavia's forces."

Catra's ears flattened. *Slag, 'Tavia's good even on land,* she realized. Mind racing as she drove back Shadow Weaver with frostflame and slowed down Estra with scorch-ice, she flew over the battle for a more comprehensive look at the fight. Estra was reclaiming a bunch of tanks at the point of Hordak's wedge, but the reprogrammed bots and Adora's duel with Hordak made a mess of the assault. Their fight with Shadow Weaver, Vultak, and Grizzlor had forced the right wing into retreat.

Catra's smirk returned. "Have Queen Selina send her strongest troops – and I mean like physically strongest – after Octavia. I'll pin 'em down until they get there." She fired a grapple into Vultak's net.

"How – Catriska!" Percival yelped. Catra dove at Octavia, throwing Vultak into her troops. Then she slammed them with scorch-ice, leaving the two staring each other down.

Octavia's glare was somehow more impressive with that Force Captain badge for one eye. "Hey, Octavia," Catra drawled, gathering shadows.

“Hmmph.” Octavia crossed her arms. “Get real, Catra. We both know you’re too soft deep down.”

Catra raised one eyebrow. “How’s the eye?” she asked.

Octavia, to Catra’s disbelief, smirked. “You mean the one you stole the parts for?” She tapped the badge while Catra’s jaw fell open. “It’s better than the original. I’d say thanks, but I think the Blind War Games were enough, don’t you?”

“How did you–” Catra blurted before she could stop herself. Octavia’s smirk grew. *Great.* She crouched, claws out. “Fine. Sure, I don’t want to hurt you. Here’s the thing: you know I will if I have to. The Horde’s run by lunatics and sadists, ‘Tavia. A woman who gave hope to the animal who clawed out her eye doesn’t belong there.” Behind Octavia, King Claudus sliced a tank in half with his sword.

Octavia’s smirk vanished, sympathy in her expression. “You’re not an animal, Catra. Shadow Weaver and Vultak can’t hurt you any more,” she replied as they circled each other. “Hordak is the future. He’s not the bad guy.” Percival scattered a bunch of green bots with rapid slashes.

Catra’s eyes narrowed. “Right. Hordak didn’t shove Void-Catra into my soul. He just stood there and *ordered* them to do it.” Octavia’s eye widened. “It’s not just those two, either. Hunga, Dylamug, Dreer, that Estra witch–”

“Professor Tempus,” Octavia snapped.

“*Whatever.* They work for Hordak, and they’re monsters, so what does that make him?”

That stopped Octavia cold. The two stared at each other.

The world shook.

Queen Selina floated on a slab of stone with flame roaring beneath it. “Alliance forces, fall back to defense line Gamma,” she

ordered in a voice Catra wished she had.

"We'll pick this up later," Catra grinned, obeying. She and Felicia flanked the queen, mother and daughter rippling with earth-shaping power. Catra poured her darkness magic into theirs. *Huh. I'm almost out of my other magic, but the shadow stuff is still there. I could get used to this princess thing.* She-Ra and Claudus interposed themselves between the trio and the Horde.

"Lord Hordak!" Selina demanded. "You have won a partial victory this day, striking at our military equipment and reserves. Take it and go."

Hordak strode forward, glowing with crimson power. "Queen Selina. I...acknowledge that permitting Shadow Weaver to command the assault on Halfmoon was an...imperfect decision."

Selina's eyes flashed. "'*Imperfect?*' Tell me, would you rather I begin with the betrayal of our trust, the slaughter of our civilians, the torture of my best friend's daughter, or the murder of that friend – and my *mother!*" Etheria shook harder.

"Yours is not like other nations on this benighted world," Hordak replied, beam lenses forming around his shoulders. "In every military, political, and technological field, Halfmoon proves itself a worthy member of the Horde. Join us, and the Bubasti will again dominate Etheria."

Catra didn't have time to worry before Selina laughed. "You are millennia late, villain," she said, raising her arm in time with Felicia's. "One day, we will reclaim Candila. Until then, it is time we were rid of you." As one, the magicat queen and princess thrust their right arms forward. The ground the Horde was on slammed backwards some fifty meters.

Then the roof of the cavern came down on them.

While Catra gaped – *I don't* think *they're all dead, Hordak must have had force shields or something for that* – Selina and Felicia pivoted their hands as if turning dials.

Halfmoon *moved.* The entire city, and the caves behind it, shifted and rumbled as the royal family twisted the land it rested on. The entire Princess Alliance could do nothing but stare. A few minutes later, the rumbling stopped, and the two royals collapsed into Claudus' arms. "Love?" Selina whispered.

"We're safe, my queen," Claudus assured her. Felicia shrank to large housecat size and snuggled into her father's elbow.

Selina nodded, then turned her head to smile at the Rebels. "Thank you all for helping protect my people," she breathed. "Catra, Adora, you two in particular have my gratitude for halting Hordak's advance."

"Right, I'm sure that compares to crushing an army, then moving an *entire city,"* Catra blurted.

Selina chuckled. "We cheated," she explained. "This Halfmoon was...prepared."

Once more, Catra could only stare. *Sure, why not?*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Shadow Weaver panicked.

Hordak's grip on her throat was literally inescapable. "'The magicats lack the power to move so much earth,' you said," he hissed. "'They are barbaric fools with no strategic mindset to speak of,' you said." His grip tightened, and each breath pulsed down her throat thin and frail. "Give me one good reason not to be rid of you *right now."*

"I understand their magic, their culture," Shadow Weaver wheezed. "I still channel the Black Garnet. My sorcery reinforced the shield that saved us."

Hordak glared for a long moment, then released her. Shadow Weaver collapsed, rubbing her throat. "You have been moving steadily from asset to liability since Catra's defection," he growled.

"Give me a victory, Shadow Weaver. I would relish a chance to repay your...creative interpretation of my orders."

Shadow Weaver nodded, mind racing. *I am on my last chance,* she realized. *I must not lose to them again.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"Estra Tempus," Netossa snarled, "was never an official member of the Alliance. She helped us with tech – nothing like Entrapta, but she was smart." The princess shook her head. "I thought Vultak bought her loyalty, but this…is new."

Catra rubbed circled on Entrapta's back, the princess still sobbing while Bow hugged her. "She was my biological mother's sister," Entrapta explained. "At least, that's what my bot parents said."

Adora shook her head. *I hate feeling helpless.* She turned to Queen Selina, as much for something to do as anything. "Can we help with...I dunno, repairs, or resources, or something?"

Selina smiled again, legs still shaky. "Fear not, She-Ra. The caverns I kept Halfmoon connected to are the true secret of our people." She cast a spell, and an image of a vast underground woodland, combining orchards and farmlands, appeared overhead. They had an artificial daymoon of blazing flame, with a rotating stone shield to bring night. "We will be well."

Claudus scowled a fraction. "We did lose considerable military resources. Thundertanks, brightpaws, clawswords, lineshields, armor...it'll take half a year to manage a proper offensive after that."

"It's my fault," Catra whispered. Adora felt punched in the heart. "Shadow Weaver's spell let her trace me–"

"We all saw what she did to you," Percival insisted. "None of us thought to counter it before."

“But you’re free of her now,” Felicia gushed, giving Catra’s free hand a squeeze. “And the Alliance has me and Percy, so, still a win!”

Catra gulped, but Entrapta hugged her with her hair. “It’s just data,” the genius insisted. “But...thank you. I’m glad we’re friends.”

Catra nodded, getting up when Entrapta turned her full hug-attention to Bow. Adora watched, worrying, as Catra approached. “Hey, Adora. You okay?”

Adora’s mind whirled between concern and frustration. “Me? You just had – like, five life-changing revelations, and – almost lost your people! Again! Why are you worrying about me?”

“Because you had a few revelations too,” Catra retorted, hands on hips, “I know how good you are at feeling guilty, and...”

They froze. Adora could feel how hard Catra worked at not looking away. “...and I love you,” she whispered.

“I love you too,” Adora whispered back, meaning it more than ever. *You’re all I want. Forever.*

Chapter End Notes

Design commentary:

1) "Extalian" is a reference to the cat species from Fairy Tail, which I'm also a huge fan of (if the 400,000 word fic wasn't a giveaway).

2) The castle complex is a mix of El Castillo from Chichen Itza and the Pyramid of the Moon -- basically, imagine if the former were atop the central portion of the latter, except adorned with lapis lazuli and tiger's eye:

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/El_Castillo,_Chichen_Itza
https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Pyramid_of_the_Moon

2a) Yes, lapis being part of the water magic is a Lapis Lazuli/Steven Universe reference. :-)

3) “Jitat” is from Pirates of Dark Water. It's supposed to be pretty dirty.

4) Yes, Skeletor is basically a Nazi. Yes, that will be relevant in Season 5, if I get there.

5) Pastelillo is from Puerto Rico, and I still remember almost purring myself the first time I had one on the side of a long stretch of road on the way to my mom's family when I was much younger. Projecting my own feelings onto Catra? Me? Nah... (reads, like, the *entire* fic)...okay, maybe.

6) I forgot to mention, Selina looks like Panthera from Thundercats (2011), though her garb is completely different, obviously. Claudus also looks like his Thundercats 2011 namesake, almost identical except he doesn't have a Thundercats symbol on his armor.

7) "Estra Tempus" is a mix of Entrapta's "real" 80s name ("Es'tra Vesselak") and other 80s mad scientist Professor Tempus. Also, some "Into the Spider-Verse" Liv-Ock, because why not?

I'm kind of unhappy with the battle, but it got the point across, I think. Oh well, at least exposition and Feelings were satisfying.

Next time: Adora wants to have a Serious Talk with Catra. A pity she's terrible with Feelings. Good thing she has lots of wonderful friends. (There's also Plot with Catra, Octavia, and Salineas, but I know what folks are here for. *G*)

Her Greatest Power

Chapter Summary

> Adora resolves to have a Serious Talk with Catra. The universe, apparently, has other ideas.

Chapter Notes

> So it's been a while. The past month has been INSANE. My regular job went utterly bananas. I got the opportunity of a lifetime. I...lost someone.
>
> But here it is, a chapter I've been looking forward to for a long time, finally going up. I hope you all enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Hey, Adora!"

Adora turned from where she'd been speaking with Tao, locking up at the sight of Catra. *Wh–whuh–she–* Adora spluttered while Catra twirled as she approached. Her love was wearing a new, fitted crimson blouse, tight indigo pants, *shoes* – but open-toed and with a heel like a claw, and an OG She-Ra-style micro-skirt. It showed off Catra's flowing figure like nothing before...and there was more figure than ever. "Look, I have *curves* now. Felicia thinks it's Brightmoon food after all those ration bars." She made a muscle with one arm next, showing off an impressive bicep. "Bulked up some, too. Apparently it's something about being an 'obligate carnivore,' but there's ursids and lizard-folk who need meat too, so who knows?"

Adora opened her mouth, then closed it. The tiny part of her brain still working was divided between hoisting Catra over her head to show off how awesome her girlfriend was, and carrying Catra off so no one could take her away. *Not here,* Adora told herself, noting Felicia behind Catra, watching with a grin. "Uh. Wow. You're. *Beautiful."* Adora managed instead.

Catra stared for a moment, and then...that laugh. The one that always made Adora's heart race. "You'll make me blush," Catra drawled, not remotely serious. She slunk up to Adora, almost melding with her.

Felicia huffed. "Later, you two," she nudged, "Mom's waiting."

Adora's mind wandered as they entered the throne room. Entrapta set up twin image projectors so Angella and Micah could attend, finally meeting with Halfmoon's monarchs. The fostering ceremony was surprisingly simple, but Adora had learned that few magicats had patience for bureaucracy.

Then the court cheered, and there was smiling and hugging and crying, and Adora's heart felt so *full* even as it ached. *She finally has a place where she belongs,* Adora thought, swallowing, *I mean, it's not like she* doesn't *belong in Brightmoon–*

"Princess Adora," Queen Selina said when the celebration had died down enough.

Adora came to attention. "Your Majesty."

"King Micah was the last outsider to be made an honorary citizen of Halfmoon, and it had been centuries before him," she continued, smiling. "It seems the least we can do for the She-Ra who fought off Hordak, and is beloved of our foster daughter."

"Yes!" Adora blurted, not even minding the few laughs she got. "I mean, of course, I'm honored, I...hope it's not too much?" *I – I belong here too, now,* she realized, overjoyed.

Selina blinked while Claudus laughed. "'Too much?' We'd foster you as well, except that would be awkward. Besides, it will hardly matter for long, will it?"

Adora looked to Catra, who blushed. "It's something to do with that marriage thing," Catra explained, tail lashing. "Apparently, siblings aren't supposed to do it." Adora kept staring. "Don't look

at me, I don't make the rules out here. Besides, marriage is just a promise, and we did that when we were six."

"That's not marriage!" Glimmer exploded, Felicia muffling a laugh. Netossa and Spinnerella had satisfied grins, but Frosta was looking between the other princesses in utter confusion.

"Whatever," Catra groaned, rolling her eyes. "I'm Adora's person, and she's mine. We don't have to be all princessy about it."

Glimmer's explosive expression melted into a sly grin. "Says the most princessy princess *ever!"* she retorted, triumphant.

Catra gaped. "What?!"

"You're princess of two kingdoms now!" Glimmer explained, pointing at Catra. "You are the biggest princess in the whole Alliance!" The others stared in shock.

"You take that back!" Catra howled, leaping. That left everyone laughing as Glimmer teleported out of the way, the formal ceremony falling apart as Catra chased Glimmer all around the throne room. Adora's mind, on the other hand, raced, looking from the amused Selina and Claudus, to the mortified images of Angella and Micah, to a smug Netossa and a wistful Spinnerella. *It's a promise,* Adora thought, humor giving way to determination. *Maybe...I can fix what I broke.*

And I want to be with Catra forever–

Entrapta held up a beeping tracker pad, laughing. "Catra! It's finished!"

Catra froze from where she'd pinned Glimmer, looking up. "Huh?" she asked, just before Glimmer slipped out and teleported away, laughing.

"The temporal dysjunction resonator!" Entrapta explained. Catra's ears shot up. "It's fully integrated with Darla's engine!"

Catra's smile was as wide as Adora'd ever seen. "You're the best, ET!" Catra gushed. "Your Majesties, I'm sorry, but we have to go."

Selina's tail swayed. "I expected this to be soon, but why so suddenly?"

"It's a long story, but the short version is, remember I explained about the other Catras I met?" Catra asked. The monarchs nodded. "Well, they have Micahs and Peekablues that need rescuing, and the sooner the better."

Adora gaped. *Oh! That's brilliant!* Her smile fled as soon as it came. *But now I have to wait...*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"Don't stop!" Catra ordered the odd group rushing toward Darla.

The pookas had given up, but that was because a giant snake-thing with a smiley-face-mask-shell hiding a lizard head was chasing them. Catra threw frostflame at it while Percival and Micah-2 dropped illusions behind them. Angella-2 and Adora were, to Catra's horror, rearguard, but...*They're the powerhouses, no question,* Catra admitted with fierce reluctance.

Angella-2 proved it with one final light-wall, and they raced onto Darla. "ET! Floor it!"

With a cackle, Entrapta hit a control, and Darla tore through the sky, towards (temporary) safety. Then ET turned. "You know Darla doesn't use pedals, right?" she asked.

Catra nodded, collapsing into the pilot's chair Entrapta vacated. Micah-2 was still holding his Angella, staring in disbelief. "This...isn't a hallucination?" he breathed.

"No, my heart," Angella-2 whispered, tears falling. "I'm here. I'm real." She kissed him.

Percival laughed. “Is it possible to be a seventh wheel?” he quipped.

“Hey, you wanted in,” Catra pointed out. Adora slid into the captain’s chair, Catra grateful Entrapta had duplicated the controls for Catra’s seat.

“So, Brightmoon first, or the Menagerie?” Adora asked, looking to Angella.

Angella’s expression became stern. “The Menagerie. We are rescuing Peekablue *now.”*

Micah stared. “Peeky’s alive too?” Then the rest hit, horror filling wide eyes. “And Vultak has her?”

Catra glared at Etheria blurring below them. “Not for long.” She looked over the controls. “This took about an hour last time, but Entrapta’s been working on upgrades–”

“Have I!” Entrapta crazy-laughed, hitting a few buttons with her hair. The warp-jump wasn’t...quite as bad as the first time Sparkles teleported Catra, but it was close. *Maybe I’ll get used to this, too...*

The Menagerie towered below them, ten stories of monsters, soldiers, and bots. Catra blinked at the scanners. “Wait, no Vultak?” she asked.

Angella chuckled. “You were in such a hurry, I never had a chance to tell you. Vultak leads the Horde now.”

The others stared, gaping in disbelief. “What?!” Adora blurted.

“After some...drama,” Angella chuckled, “your mercy proved fruitful. Hordak sued for peace, but Vultak usurped him. Hordak and the...Super Pal Trio...lead the Horde defectors who followed them to Dryl. Vultak freed Shadow Weaver, but they are busy in the Fright Zone. A moment.” Angella erupted from Darla, tearing a hole through the top of the tower, and returned with a stunned

Peekablue. The psychic princess froze for a moment, then sobbed as the queen and king held her. “Now we can go home.”

They ended up with Sweet Bee and her people anyway, though Angella provided most of the transport for them, Darla towing. Catra shook her head in amazement. *Right, sure, Mom’s just the stay-at-home queen, no biggie. Hah.*

Landing back at Brightmoon-2 was controlled chaos, turning into a mass of hugging, laughing, and crying. Glimmer was a complete (and completely understandable) mess, ‘Tossa and Spinny were somewhere between shock and ecstasy, and the two Bows were chattering with high-speed excitement.

All except Adora-2, looking at the group with wistful joy, hugging herself with one arm. Catra loped over, freezing when Adora-2 twitched. “Hey, Adora, You okay?”

Adora-2 did her fake-almost-smile thing. “Of course! This is great, thanks!”

Catra sighed and crossed her arms. “Adora...”

Adora-1 approached with a Huntara-like grunt. “What did you do?” she demanded.

Catra thumped Adora-1’s thigh with her tail. “Quit it. What’s wrong, Adora-2?”

“It’s...not important,” Adora-2 sighed, glancing away. “My Catra’s on our side, and that’s what matters.” Adora-1 glared. “Look, she’s in Dryl with her friends and Hordak. Glimmer, Brightmoon, they need me here. It’s just until the war’s over.”

“Yeah, and then she’s going to be with *me,”* Catra-2 cackled from Adora-2’s tracker pad.

Adora-2 blushed while Catra-1 cackled. “Catra!” their Adora yelped, pulling out her pad..

"What? I warned you it was set to pick up goody-goody me," Catra-2 quipped.

Catra-1 glared. "'Goody-goody?'"

"Have you *looked* in a mirror?" Catra-2 drawled.

"Okay," Adora-1 jumped in, "it sounds like you two are doing well."

Catra-2 shrugged. "It got rough for a while. Story of my life." She grinned, one fang peeking out. "Adora chose me. It's not her fault Sparkles is a wimp who needs She-Ra to hold her hand."

Catra-1's glare wiped the smirk off her counterpart. "I know what you've been through and how far you still have to go, so I'm gonna let that slide. But the next time I drop by, I'm going to remind you what you said. Unless you haven't apologized–"

"We apologized to each other," Adora-2 jumped in.

The two Catras glared at one another for a moment. Adora-2's pleading gaze melted Catra-1's frustration. *Fine,* Catra-1 sighed. "One last thing. You're not the last magicat." Catra-2 *mrrped* in confusion, so Catra-1 drew the Halfmoon spell circle. "This will tell you – and just you – where the old and new Halfmoons are. Don't let Shadow Weaver track you, she's got a spell that will restore your memory and trace your movements."

Catra-2's jaw dropped open. "Wait, wha–" she began, but Catra-1 completed her spell, and the flood of knowledge cut her counterpart off.

Catra-1 grinned at her Adora. "That takes care of them. So, Etheria-3?" She laughed at Adora-1 shaking her head. *I'll take that as a yes.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

That was almost easy, Adora thought, still caught in disbelief.

Once more, she watched as Glimmer hugged her parents. Netossa and Spinnerella were, again, laughing with Peekablue and Sweet Bee. The Bows compared notes while their Entrapta took them. "Is this weird for you, Catra?" Adora asked.

Catra huffed and shrugged. "Define 'weird,' Adora." Adora snorted a chuckle.

Adora-3 walked over, looking…"forlorn" was the only word that seemed to fit. "Hey, Catra. And, um, me."

Catra laughed. "Hey, Adora." Adora-3 blushed.

Adora-1 scowled. "Where's your Catra?" she asked, glaring at her counterpart. Adora-3 wilted – until Catra thumped Adora-1 with her tail. "What?"

"Be nice," Catra insisted.

Adora-3 sighed. "Still in Halfmoon. I mean, I know she's okay, she came by to...apologize, for everything she did. I apologized too, but...well, Catra doesn't have a lot of friends here, and she wants to save Entrapta, who...also doesn't have a lot of friends here."

Catra sighed. "And ET doesn't *want* to be saved, right?"

Adora-3 nodded. "She's happy with Hordak. That'd be great, except he's still trying to, y'know, conquer Etheria. I'm just glad he's not as good at it without you. Um, our Catra."

"Don't worry. Halfmoon's amazing," Catra explained with a grin. "Once they're ready, the magicats will turn things around. Speaking of which." She turned back to her Adora. "We've done everything we can for the alterni-dorks. Let's go home."

"That sounds great," Adora-1 agreed.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"Catra, we just got back," Adora grumbled as they headed for the war room.

Catra snickered. "Aw, am I working too hard for the mighty She-Ra? Maybe you could use a nap." In spite of how close they'd become, Catra couldn't help feeling satisfaction hearing Adora's complaint. *Maybe now she'll appreciate how hard I work–*

"I was just hoping we could have some time together," Adora explained, wiping Catra's smirk away. "You know, just the two of us."

Catra blushed. Mercifully, Adora didn't react. "oh." The magicat's heart pounded. *Maybe...I do get to be happy.* She smiled and stroked Adora's cheek, her tail winding around the hero's knee. "Just this one more, okay? After that, I'm all yours."

"You promise?" Adora whispered.

"I promise," Catra replied, taking Adora's hand and leading her into the war room.

It wasn't quite a full house – Perfuma was back home protecting Plumeria, and Frosta was gathering the Snow Kingdom's armies to aid Halfmoon – but the other princesses were there, as were their closest allies, and Generals Juliet and Sunder. Uncle Percival was there as well, leaning on the wall to their right as they entered.

Catra's smile faded away. Glimmer looked like she was swallowing her anger, Netossa turned a cool glare on Sunder, and Sweet Bee was clearly avoiding looking at Mermista. Peekablue and Spinnerella were giving each other worried looks. Bow exhaled in relief the moment he spotted Adora and Catra. "Hey, tone it down, you princesses are way too cheerful," Catra quipped. Only Angella chuckled once, the others only staring. *Tough crowd,* Catra thought. "Not sure what happened here, but if my plan works, we can deal with it later."

Felicia's ears shot up, the young princess' smile brightening the room. That got the others' attention as well. "You've got

something, Wildcat?" Netossa asked.

Catra walked up to the map and zoomed in on Seaworthy. "We've got the east under control, and the west is beyond our reach for the moment," she explained. "Bringing down the Fright Zone is our endgame, but if we can clear the seas, the Alliance can hit Hordak on both sides."

Mermista smirked. Sweet Bee scowled, but somehow it softened her previous stony expression. "A tall order," Sweet Bee pointed out, waving a hand over the map. "Scurvy and Octavia control the Sea of Sigh, and we lack the naval forces to dislodge them."

Catra grinned. "A year ago, we didn't have the armies to liberate the eastlands, either," she explained. "With Sunder and Scorpia on our side, we've pushed the Horde back to the old Garnet Kingdom." She tapped a few controls, and Octavia's profile replaced the map. "I shook 'Tavia during the Battle of Halfmoon. Let's shake her loose."

Sea Hawk leaped to his feet. "Indeed! *Adventure!"*

Mermista groaned, smirk vanishing. "Isn't Octavia, like, stupid loyal to Hordak?"

Sunder nodded, his expression grave. "She was one of the first to join the Horde in her youth. Whatever reasons Octavia had for joining will not be so easily undone."

Catra huffed. "I scratched Octavia's eye out. I didn't mean to, but in the Horde, that's a lifelong grudge. Instead, she gave me chances to prove myself."

"She might have wanted you to fail, Catra," Adora worried.

Catra shrugged. "So? A chance is more than anyone else but you ever gave me." She scratched her chin. "Sure, she figured out I stole the parts for her eye implant, but still. Octavia's not Shadow Weaver or Vultak. We give her the right out and she'll take it."

“And then perhaps we can sway Admiral Scurvy as well!” Sea Hawk gushed.

Catra looked up in surprise. So did everyone else except Peekablue and Mermista. “You know him?” Catra asked.

“Indeed. We sailed together for many a moon, raiding Horde transports as the most daring pirates in Etheria!” Sea Hawk’s enthusiasm melted away. “We had something of a falling out over a Horde warship I set aflame. Scurvy wanted it as a prize. Still!” He smiled again, fist in the air. “Surely, one grudge will not keep so fearless a commander at Hordak’s side.”

Mermista groaned again. “He’s a jerk, Hawk,” she retorted. Sea Hawk took in a breath. “Don’t!” she snapped, stopping him cold. “Scurvy never cared which side he stole from. Seriously, he named himself after a disease.”

Catra coughed to cover a chuckle. Adora joined her. “Wait, he what?”

“You can’t go after him,” Mermista insisted, looking worried for the first time Catra remembered.

Sea Hawk took her hand in both of his. “We shall seek Octavia’s aid first, my love,” he replied. “On that, you have my word.” Mermista grimaced and looked away. Sweet Bee’s frustrated grimace melted away, replaced with sympathy.

“Great! We have a plan,” Catra jumped in. “Misty, you head to Salineas with ‘Tossa and Spinny to prep our backup. Adora, Glimm, Bow, you’re with me and Hawk.”

Flutterina bounced once in her chair. “I wanna help too!” Scorpia and Entrapta both looked up as well.

“Deep water and insect-hybrids don’t mix, ‘Rina,” Catra pointed out, ruffling her hair. “You’ll get your chance, don’t worry.” She looked up to the rest of the Super Pal Trio. “Snaps, I need you to back up Perfuma.” Scorpia blushed. “ET, you focus on Project High

Ground, okay?" Entrapta brightened and nodded, hair tapping away on her pad. "Great. Let's move out."

-SR- -SR- -SR-

If the stakes hadn't been so high, Bow would have squee'd.

Sea Hawk stood at the bow, a dashing figure as ever, while Catra watched from the crow's nest. Entrapta had modified her suit to keep her fur dry underwater, a helmet ready to unfold from her back.

The coastline past Seaworthy was the perfect backdrop for their epic quest, a curving mix of jagged rocks and bronze-colored beaches. *And if Catra's right, we'll make a new friend today,* Bow hoped, glancing up at where Catra glared at her pad, muttering something Bow couldn't hear.

He refused to let worry eat away his excitement. *Even if things go bad, we're the Best Friends Squad. We'll be fine.* He glanced back at Seaworthy; Bow couldn't see Glimmer watching with Adora through a spyglass, but he knew she could reach them in an instant. Farther out, Mermista was in an underwater bubble with Netossa and Spinnerella. *We'll be fine,* he repeated, willing it to be true.

In the distance, Octavia's massive ship and dark sail dampened Bow's mood. He could almost feel the Force Captain glaring at them, her badge glinting in place of an eyepatch. "She's not shooting at us," Sea Hawk noted. "That is a good sign, yes?"

Catra leaped down. Bow squeaked at the drop. "As long as it lasts," she replied, strapping on a shield made of a coiled-up cable. *A magicat lineshield,* Bow remembered. "Wait here. Bow, cover me." With that, she uncoiled the line with a snap of her arm and grappled up to Octavia's battleship.

Swallowing another yelp, Bow mimicked Catra's grapple-leap into the crow's nest, communicator flaring to life. "Hey, Octavia," Catra drawled.

“Catra,” Octavia replied, crossing her arms. Two tentacles held stun batons. “Give me one good reason not to blow up Chicken of the Sea down there.”

“I gave you a bunch three days ago,” Catra pointed out, “but hey, if that’s how you want it.” She traced a magic circle in the air. Octavia’s crew leaped back, weapons out.

Catra’s spell brought memories to life. They were all Catra’s, from a tiny kitten to a gangly teenager, tortured again and again by Shadow Weaver. Lightning. Shadows. Paralysis. Hunger. Bow shuddered, choked on horror. *Oh, Catra,* he mourned. “Go on. Tell me again how Hordak’s the future.”

Octavia stared for several seconds, her good eye gleaming. “He didn’t know,” she finally replied, “any more than Adora did.”

“Adora dedicated her *life* to making up for something that isn’t her fault,” Catra snapped, bristling. “This is what Hordak did after he knew.” Catra formed another image, this one of Shadow Weaver and Vultak pouring a magicat-shaped hole into their Catra’s chest while Hordak watches, hands clasped behind him. “Don’t bring Adora into this.”

Octavia scowled. “The princesses aren’t any better,” she snapped.

“Yeah, the queen of Brightmoon adopted the woman who gave her daughter to Shadow Weaver, try again,” Catra growled.

Octavia’s eye narrowed. “She adopted the world’s greatest strategist.” Catra’s eyes widened, tail swaying. “You ever ask Mermista about her grandma?”

Catra blinked. “Her what, now?”

“Grandmother. A parent’s mother,” Octavia explained. “Mercia’s mother was Queen Clea, a monster who tried to destroy my people.”

“Sounds terrible. Also sounds dead,” Catra drawled. “Misty’s cool.”

"How cool's 'Misty' gonna be when she finds out I killed her father?" Octavia retorted.

Catra gasped, ears going flat. "*Jitat,* Octavia," she whispered. "You didn't."

There was a pause, and Catra's ears swiveled back up. "I strangled him in Octopus Cove," Octavia continued, "where his psycho mom drove off my people."

Bow gulped. "Guys, tell me you're still there," he breathed.

"Just say the word," Glimmer growled.

Catra leaned in, eyes narrowing. "You're...you're lying," she muttered. Octavia flinched. "Why are you–"

The ocean screamed. Mermista erupted from a howling whirlpool, slamming into Octavia as part of a watery fist the size of a Beast Island beetle. The two went overboard just as Netossa and Spinnerella flew overhead. "Sekhmet," Catra cursed, summoning her helmet and diving after them.

"Sea Hawk!" Bow cried just as Glimmer and Adora appeared on their deck. "We have to go after them!"

"I want nothing more, brave Bow," Sea Hawk said, his voice eerily quiet, "but we have our own problems." He pointed his sword at another sailing ship as it approached. "That, I fear, is Scurvy."

-SR- -SR- -SR-

I hate water, and I hate cold, Catra thought, blasting at Octavia with Freezefire, *So what in Set's name am I doing down here?*

Catra knew full well what she was doing, of course. Octavia pushed through Mermista's power with incredible strength and a body suited for seas. *It's still stupid,* Catra grumbled, using her wings to fly towards Octavia.

It wasn't flying, though, and Bast, was that a problem. Her momentum was all wrong. Turning was weird, too slow then too fast. Octavia actually laughed before swatting her aside with a tentacle. *I can't out-fight her down here. Think, idiot, think!* She lashed out with more frostflame, which at least slowed Octavia down a little. *I don't have anything in this dank crap...oh. Duh.* She pulled the darkness around her and pushed the water back.

Now it was like flying. Catra slammed into Octavia, then slid away, sheathed in shadows that she used to blind the Moraturian as she hit Octavia from every direction. "Hey, Octavia," she quipped

A roar and a wild swing of all Octavia's tentacles sent Catra flying into the air. Her shadow-shell popped like a bubble in the sunlight, helmet retracting. "Wha–" Catra grunted, shaking her head clear.

She-Ra and Netossa had gone in after Mermista, as had several aquatic soldiers on both sides. A quick scan caught Sea Hawk dueling with Admiral Scurvy, while Bow held off another Moraturian and – a magicat? One in a fancy outfit, no less.

Adora can handle Octavia, Catra hoped, dropping onto Scurvy's ship. "Squall!" Scurvy yelped. "Deal with her!"

The magicat grinned. "With pleasure, Captain," they said, leaping at her. Catra shifted out of the way, but Squall matched her shape for shape, the two leaping and slashing at each other.

After they traded claw rakes, Catra getting the worst of it given her trauma caps, she skidded to a halt. "Okay, screw this." She summoned Freezefire in both hands. "One chance, 'Squall.' We can–" Squall didn't let her finish, using their transformation to leap at Catra with phenomenal speed.

Catra sighed and blasted Squall with frostflame and scorch-ice at once. That slammed her foe back into the railing, allowing her to focus on helping her friends. "–know you're better than this, Scurvy!" Sea Hawk pleaded, locking swords with his old friend. "Surely, our sacred code means something to you."

Scurvy raised an eyebrow. “It doesn’t.” He lunged, Sea Hawk darting aside with agility that impressed even Catra. “Slippery idiot. Don’t you know who killed your girlfriend’s father?”

Sea Hawk gasped, freezing. Scurvy smirked and slashed again. Catra coated the deck below him in scorch-ice, sending the creep spinning. “Oh look, it’s an idiot, slipping,” she quipped, striding over. Squall shook himself loose, so Catra fired another blast of frostflame at both them and the Moraturian guy. “Octavia said she killed Misty’s dad. Which is it?”

Scurvy blinked as he retreated from her. “She said that? Huh. Now that’s loyalty.” The admiral smirked. “Still, I’m not letting her take the credit for my kill, even to protect me. I cornered Mercia in Octopus Cove. Lured the idiot there with an offer of truce.” Sea Hawk’s eyes shone with tears.

Catra’s eyes, however, narrowed. “You’re...not lying,” she realized. Then she blasted the deck in front of the approaching Moraturian with regular flame.

“Seven Devils,” the octopus-man yelped, “how many kinds’a magic you *got?”*

Catra laughed. “Oh, I’d be more worried about my brains if I were you. For instance.” She tapped her ear just before Mermista emerged from a column of swirling wave and foam, eyes blazing. “Live comms. Thanks for the confession, sucker.”

“Abandon–” Bow began, but Misty picked them all up and dropped them on the Dragon’s Daughter V just before flinging Scurvy’s ship halfway across the bay. Catra grinned.

Her grin vanished when she saw Octavia on her battleship, sailing away from the fight. And Catra. “Sekhmet,” she swore, leaning against the railing.

Adora leaped onto the deck in She-Ra form, somehow looking amazing even soaked from hair poof to boots. “You okay, Catra?” Adora asked, failing to sound casual.

Catra huffed. "Not really," she muttered. "We'll...get 'em next time, right?"

"Of course," Adora insisted.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra finally felt dry after several hours of towels and sunbathing. *All that work Entrapta put into my suit,* she mused, *and Misty soaks my fur with one grab. Ugh.* She flopped onto the bed, arms and legs splayed out. *Saving whole other worlds? Easy. Getting through Octavia's thick skull? Forget it. UGH.*

Someone knocked. "Come in," Catra called. "I'm not decent, but I am dressed."

Adora snorted a laugh as she came in. "You're plenty decent," the blonde said as she went in.

Catra laughed back. "You know you don't have to knock to come into your own room, right?" she asked, waving her tail in a way she hoped was inviting. Based on Adora's blush, it worked.

Then Adora shook her head, put on her 'determined Adora' look, and straightened. "You promised we could talk after the Octavia thing," she said, looking implacable but a little scared.

What the heck? Catra wondered, panic shooting through her as she sat up. "Are you breaking up with me?" she blurted.

"What? NO!" Adora yelped.

"Whatever it is – oh," Catra trailed off, confused. "Then why are you, uh, worried?"

Adora gulped and tugged Catra to her feet. Then she fiddled with something behind her back. Catra relaxed. *You got me a present and you're worried I won't like it, aren't you? Dork,* Catra thought fondly, noticing she'd changed belt buckles again. *Adora's idea of*

a fashion risk. "Catra, you mean everything to me," Adora began, jaw quivering a fraction.

"You mean everything to me, too," Catra replied, brushing the end of her tail against Adora's hip.

"And...and I don't think I ever really understood what our promise meant to you until today," she continued, a tear escaping one eye, "seeing what you showed Octavia."

Catra gasped. "You *saw* that? You weren't supposed to – oh Bast, Adora, it wasn't your fault, Shadow Weaver didn't want you to–"

"Catra." Adora took Catra's hand in one of hers, the other still behind her back. "I don't want to…I mean, I'm glad I saw it, now. What you went through to stay with me. Because this time, I want to keep my promise. Forever."

Catra blinked. "I...don't understand."

Adora got down on one knee. *The heck?* Catra wondered. "In the Alliance, when two people want to join their lives together – like Netossa and Spinnerella – they have a ceremony where they exchange tokens, things they wear. They promise to love one another for the rest of their lives, and always be together." Catra froze. *Wait, is she–* Adora held out her other hand, opening a long, thin box. It was her wing buckle, the one she'd swapped out. "Catriska D'riluth...will you marry me?"

For an instant, Catra couldn't have been more frozen if she'd doused herself in frostflame.

Then inspiration struck. She slid her mother's ribbon from her brow, took the wing, and placed her diadem in Adora's box. The gasp and smile Catra got back were worth everything. "Yes," Catra whispered. "YES! Yes yes yes–"

Catra pounced, tackle-kissing Adora right into the door. Which swung open. And left them sprawling in a hallway where every

single one of their friends was leaping back, caught between guilt and joy. “Hey!” Catra snapped. Adora gasped.

“Sorry,” Bow shrugged, grinning.

“It’s about time!” Glimmer cheered, teleporting to hug them both. Scorpia followed, scooping them up in her massive arms. In seconds, Catra and Adora were being smushed together by all their friends.

The two looked at each other, smiling in spite of the insanity. “So. We’re getting married,” Catra noted.

“Yeah. I guess we are,” Adora replied, breathless.

“This ceremony thing. Do we need them there?” Catra asked, nudging Glimmer with her shoulder.

That freed them from the circle, Glimmer spluttering in wordless outrage. “You’re a Princess of Brightmoon!” Sparkles cried, hands in the air. “This is a big deal! You can’t just elope!”

“‘Elope,’ huh?” Catra retorted. Glimmer’s eyes widened. As the others laughed and argued over whether it would be Glimmer’s fault if they did ‘elope,’ Catra caught Adora’s eye again. Her smile was brighter than all the moons. *Our real promise,* Catra realized, her heart so full she wondered if it might explode. *Forever, this time.*

Chapter End Notes

Yep! That happened. :-D

So I was originally going to have the next "episode" be 100% wedding fluff, but any wedding takes a while to plan, and this is a ROYAL wedding. Catra's adopted family isn't going to skimp on the pomp *or* circumstance. So next time we go back...Into the Catraverse!

Into the Catraverse: Salineas Burning

Chapter Summary

> A working vacation becomes all work and no vacation when, for the first time, Catra slips through dimensions without being pushed...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"So, did anyone tell *you* what a 'honeymoon' is?" Catra asked as they headed toward the Salinean palace.

Adora chuckled, glancing up at the cannons bracketing the castlle. "Yeah, something about the couple getting time alone together after the wedding. Also, none of the moons are made of honey."

Catra's laugh had its usual wonderful effect on Adora's heart. "Yeah, Glimm told me it's got something to do with the mirror moon, of all things." She shrugged. "Not like we're going to get a whole month off, even after the war, but I'm good with this 'pre-honeymoon' thing if you are."

Adora failed a battle with a growing blush. "I don't know why we need to *practice* being married," she muttered.

Catra's laugh was deeper this time, more throaty, but it still sent tingles all over Adora's skin. "One of the few things the princesses and the Horde have in common, Adora: 'Practice makes perfect.' And I want to...*practice...*all – over – you."

She punctuated those last three words with gentle finger pokes to Adora's collarbone.

Adora couldn't help herself. She kissed Catra again. *I have standing permission,* she reminded herself when Catra stiffened, but then her girlfriend – no, *fiancée* – melted in Adora's arms and

kissed her back. *I am the luckiest person in Etheria,* Adora decided.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra's nose twitched at the smell of smoke.

Someone's burning breakfast, the magicat thought, turning over and burying herself in Adora's skin and scent. She pulled the covers over them both. *It's been perfect for three days, one messed up breakfast is...still better than ration bars,* Catra mused, chuckling as she tried to go back to sleep.

The smell kept getting worse, though – and then sounds followed. Machinery, muffled bursts, and – screams?

Catra bolted upright, sleep burned away in an instant. Smoke obscured most of the balcony's view, so she ran over and cast a gust spell as Adora stirred. "Wha...Catra? Is it Reveille already?"

"Rebellion doesn't do Reveille, Adora–" Catra said, locking up as her magic cleared her line of sight.

Salineas was burning.

SALINEAS WAS BURNING.

"Wh–how–" Catra blurted, leaping to the balcony railing and looking along the palace for the cannons. *They're gone?* she realized, eyes scanning past the tanks to the bay filled with Horde ships. *This is impossible! Where are the ramparts? The robo-mines? Why are Misty's troops using sticks instead of stun staffs?* "Adora, it's the Horde! The defenses are gone, the Sea Gate's a wreck, and there's tanks everywhere!"

From the corner of her eye, Catra saw Adora wake up in an instant. "For the honor of Grayskull!" she cried, becoming She-Ra and rushing to Catra's side. "How?"

"No idea," Catra hissed, glaring as she waved at Salineas' utter helplessness. "Look at this, it's like I was never here–" her tail went limp as realization struck. "Oh. OH. *Jitat."*

"Language, Catra," Adora admonished.

"Bite me," Catra sighed, though without heat. "We've slipped into another timeline. I pushed too hard to help 2 and 3, and now we're in...I'm just gonna call this one 4." She scanned the battlefield, scowl deepening when she found her confirmation. "And there's Catra-4, being completely evil," she said, pointing out her counterpart.

Adora paled. "We can save her," she insisted. "Please, Catra." Catra glared at her. Adora took her hand, eyes pleading. *"Please.* She's *you.* There has to be good in her."

"There really doesn't, Adora," Catra grumbled. "Look at Salineas!"

Adora didn't look at Salineas. Just Catra. Then Adora kissed her.

Catra purred until Adora let her go, her followup glare half-hearted. "I should never have taught you to cheat." Adora's smile was as weak as Catra's glare, but at least she had one. Catra sighed. "Come on, we have another world to save."

Together, they leaped down to fight an entire invasion.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora had never thought she'd get tired of slicing through tanks, but the Horde had brought a *lot* of tanks to Salineas-4. *I hope we find Catra-4 soon–*

"Hey, Adora."

Catra-4 leapt onto Adora's back and *raked.* "Ow!" She-Ra yelped, spinning and turning the Sword into a lasso. Catra-4 vanished into the smoke. "I'd forgotten how much trouble you are when you're serious."

“Oh, I’m serious, Ador – AH!” Catra-4 leaped away, barely dodging a burst of frostflame.

Catra-1 strode into the rubble-filled street with a vicious smirk. “Hey, Catra,” she quipped, forming a shadow-whip in her hand.

“That’s low, Adora,” Catra-4 scoffed. “You replaced me with, what, a bot? A magic copy?”

“Oh, I’m you, Catra,” Catra-1 sneered, cracking her whip. “I’d explain different timelines and crap, but I’m on a schedule.” She rushed Catra-4, who dodged, returning fire with a stun baton.

“Catra, you promised,” Adora reminded her.

Catra-4 froze. “Don’t you *dare* talk to me about promises, you–” she snarled.

“She meant me, idiot,” Catra-1 sighed, forming the memory restoration spell out of light and shadow. She cast it at Catra-4, just before a house exploded in crimson light.

They all went flying, Catra-4 screaming, as Hordak strode through the ruins. “Commander,” Hordak said, voice as robotic as a drone, “explain yourself.”

Catra-1 bared her teeth while She-Ra pushed a wall off her shoulder. “Your Catra’s getting a little history lesson,” she hissed, Hordak’s eyes going wide. “You? *You,* I get to *kill.”* She crouched with both hands outstretched, claws bared and caps off, frostfire gathering in one palm and lashing shadows in the other. Hordak aimed his cannon at her, glowing with power.

Adora’s eyes went wide. “Catra, wait,” she urged. Catra turned and gaped. Hordak stared, cannon lowering. “We – we don’t have to kill him.”

Catra narrowed her eyes. “Seriously, Adora?” she growled. “Look at what they did to Salineas. We’re at war.”

"We can be better than this," Adora insisted. "*You* are better than this."

Catra sighed, she and Hordak-4 glaring at one another. "I'm really not, Adora." She crouched to leap, Hordak's cannon glowing with power–

"NO!" Catra-4 howled, leaping to her feet and throwing debris in all directions. Catra-1 tensed, until her counterpart continued, "He's MINE!" Then she leaped at Hordak, claws flaring.

Hordak yelped and leaped back, firing the beam wildly. Adora and Catra-1 dodged while Catra-4 ducked, then hit Hordak with an uppercut. "Traitor! After all I have given you!"

"Given me? You! Killed! My! *Mom!"* Catra-4 slashed wildly, tearing gouges out of the cannon.

Hordak's eyes went wide, his fury melting into fear. "Shadow Weaver did that!" he protested, swiping at Catra-4.

"Yeah? And whose idea was that?" Catra-4 snarled.

"Hers! Think, Catra – whom does she serve now?" Hordak-4 cried.

Catra-4 froze. Hordak leaped back just as tanks rolled into view. "Scut," Catra-1 hissed. "Fine, that's crap, but he still let her keep you, Catra. There's somewhere you can go to get away from all of this, where you can have a *home."*

Catra-4 glared at the engaged pair. Then she laughed without humor. "Home? After *this?"* She waved at the devastation around them.

"You saved Felicia," Catra-1 reminded her. "So, yeah."

Catra-4 looked around. She saw Hordak pointing the cannon at her, tanks crushing houses, people screaming as they ran. "Yeah," she sighed. Adora-1 slumped in relief. "I thought victory would

be...different." With that, she shrank, vanishing into the smoke as a wildcat.

Adora-1 pulled them back, then gave her fiancée a quick hug. "Yeah, I love you too," Catra-1 sighed. "Come on. We've got to help as many of these people as we can, then rescue Dad – Micah – and Peekablue."

Adora grunted. "That's gonna be hard without Mara's ship."

Catra shrugged. "So we improvise. What else is new?"

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra sighed a growl as they approached Brightmoon. "Walking straight up to the castle isn't exactly what I had in mind, Adora," she pointed out, trees thinning as they got closer.

"Relax, Catra, I'll vouch for you," Adora said, trying to reassure her.

Oh, for– Catra rolled her eyes. "Which will work great right until their Adora comes out and they all start screaming about the impostor with the evil Horde commander."

"Come on, Catra, it can't be *that* bad–" Adora began.

On cue, guards started screaming. An instant later, an oddly-dressed Glimmer teleported overhead and fired a massive laser beam at them.

Catra didn't bother even implying an 'I told you so,' just dodging so she didn't die again. Adora took shelter behind the Sword-turned-shield. "For the honor of Grayskull!" she cried, transforming into She-Ra.

"Nice try, impostor!" Glimmer snarled, teleporting again and firing another blast.

"Sparkles!" Catra called up. "We surrender!" *And hope we don't spend the rest of the war in a cell,* Catra thought. *Then again, without me on their side, security is probably useless–*

Glimmer's eyes narrowed, teleporting to earth. "I don't think so, Horde scum," she snarled, her voice choked with rage and hate that froze Catra's spine. *What in Bast's name–*

She didn't have time to think of anything else before the beam sliced at her again. Catra dodged, Changing to shrink-dodge, then melting through shadow to rejoin Adora. "Okay, that's bad," Catra muttered while Glimmer gaped at her and Adora gaped at Glimmer.

She-Ra held up the shield, blocking another blast. "Glimmer! What are you doing?" Adora demanded.

"Making her *pay!"* Glimmer screamed, blazing with deadly light.

"Glimmer, wait!" Adora-4 ran up. "What's going – on?!" She froze at the sight of Adora-1, Bow and Perfuma skidding to a halt behind her. "For the honor of Grayskull!"

She-Ra-4 leaped at Catra, who raised her hands. Before she could surrender again, though, her Adora lassoed Adora-4 and pulled her over, catching her counterpart. "Okay, no," She-Ra-1 said, freeing She-Ra-4 and standing beside Catra, arms crossed. "So do you want to listen and get our help, or should we just go home?"

Bow stared, looking from one Adora to the other and back. "Uh, Adora? Is that another shapeshifter?"

Catra blinked. *Wait,* another *shapeshifter?* she wondered. Adora-4, mercifully, changed back from shock. "No," she said, staring at She-Ra-1. "I think she's...me."

"How can that be?" Perfuma asked.

"Uh, maybe we should ask them?" Scorpia suggested, walking up.

Catra smiled in relief. “Thanks, Snaps.” Scorpia stared in disbelief.

That was when Perfuma pointed at Scorpia and screamed. “Horde soldier!” she cried.

Catra groaned. *Here we go again.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

“So let met get this straight,” Glimmer sneered, Shadow Weaver beside her. From across the war room, Bow and Adora-4 gave each other nervous glances while Catra clenched her fists. “You’re from another – ‘timeline,’ where *Catra* is one of the good guys.”

“That’s right,” Adora-1 explained again, gripping her patience with all of She-Ra’s strength. Perfuma and Frosta shared glances while Scorpia somehow wrung her claws.

“You’re here to rescue Entrapta, and supposedly my dad, who’s *alive* on *Beast Island.* ‘Probably.’” Shadow Weaver’s eyes narrowed. “And over there, the Rebellion is winning, all because of *her?”* Adora clenched her teeth at the contempt in Glimmer’s voice.

“I know how the Horde works,” Catra explained. “While Adora was studying tactics, I practiced strategy. It’s not that I’m important by myself. When Adora and I are a team, we’re unbeatable.”

“And ‘my’ Adora never mentioned this because…?” Glimmer snapped.

Catra looked at Adora-4 with open, sorrowful sympathy. “Because it hurt too much,” Catra whispered. Adora-4’s eyes went wide.

Shadow Weaver stared at Catra for a long moment. “This tale is unlikely, Your Majesty,” she said, to a hiss from Catra, “but it is not impossible.” Catra stopped hissing, staring in disbelief.

Glimmer did the same. “What? You don’t think they’re really from another – whole Etheria!”

“Alternate timelines are quite real, Queen Glimmer,” Shadow Weaver began.

Catra’s eyes blew wide. “‘queen’?” she whispered.

Bow’s eyes sparkled, the archer not having heard Catra. “They are? I have so many questions.”

Shadow Weaver sighed. “That does not make their story true, but it could be.”

Glimmer thought for a moment. “Fine. If you’re from this ‘alternate timeline’ thing, then there’s another me there. If anyone can come get you, she – I – can.”

Adora-1 looked at Catra, forcing down her sudden burst of worry. Catra, mercifully, just looked thoughtful. “That...should work,” she agreed. “My Glimm practiced a spell with me in case this happened again. Stand back, Adora.” Adora-1 obeyed, and Catra sat on the floor, closing her eyes and concentrating.

“‘Glimm’?” Glimmer-4 grumbled, while light and shadow wove in a beautiful, intricate pattern around Adora’s love, blossoming into a network of blue, gold, and violet. Then Catra’s eyes snapped open, and the criss-crossing lines of blue and gold ran through her fur again. Once more, the beauty took Adora-1’s breath away. From Adora-4’s gasp, she wasn’t alone.

Their Glimmer appeared with a pop and a burst of sparkles, gripping Catra’s shoulders. “Ha!” Glimmer-1 gloated. “Told you it’d work, sis.”

Glimmer-4 paled. “‘Sis?’” she gasped.

Glimmer-1 turned and smiled with bright joy. “Oh, hi! You must be me.” Their Glimmer teleported over and hugged Queen Glimmer. “I hope these two didn’t give you too much trouble. They never get along with themselves. I’m sure we’ll be pals, though.” She teleported back to Catra.

“I doubt it,” Glimmer-4 drawled, voice oozing with contempt.

Shadow Weaver sighed, placing a hand to her brow. “My Queen–”

Glimmer-1 gasped and turned. “What? AH!” She teleported over Shadow Weaver, punching her five times in two seconds, then pinning her to the ground in an arm lock. “Don’t worry, I’ve got her!”

Adora-1 groaned while Catra grinned. *This is going to take a while,* Adora decided while the others started babbling at each other.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

“Aargh!” Glimmer-1 threw her hands up as the three princesses from Etheria-1 trudged down the Brightmoon corridor, Scorpia-4 trailing behind. “How did I become such a *bi–”*

“Shadow Weaver,” Adora-1 and Catra said in unison. Catra put a hand on her sister’s shoulder. “It’s not your fault, Glimm,” she insisted.

“It is *totally* my fault! Her fault. Uuugh.” Glimmer buried her face in her hands. “Okay, I get it, Mom’s stuck between dimensions or something. What is she doing listening to that – that – monster?”

“I dunno, but she must be good at it,” Scorpia pointed out. “That’s how, um, ‘my’ Catra got in trouble with Hordak.”

Catra’s mood dropped into a bottomless pit. “Right. This part I remember. Possession,” she explained with a grimace. *Maybe Void-Catra survived. I know Catra-4 isn’t her – I could tell – but...Mom...* Catra shook her head. “Look, we can do this. Adora super-charges my spell, which powers up your teleportation. You get the four of us to Beast Island, we rescue Dad and Entrapta, they help us rescue Mom, and we all go home.”

Glimmer-1 growled. “Because *someone* is being an idiot about Mara’s ship. Adora’s ship!” Again she threw her hands in the air. “I

am never making fun of you two for not liking your counterparts again. Seriously, how did I get so–”

“She’s going through a lot,” Bow said, coming around the bend ahead of them. “But that doesn’t mean what she’s doing is right.”

Glimmer-1 lit up, almost literally. “Bow! You’re here to help us, right?” she asked.

Catra rolled her eyes. “And disobey his Glimmer? His ‘Queen’ Glimmer? I don’t think–” she froze, mouth half-open, as Bow grinned and held up a First Ones crystal. An access crystal to Adora’s ship. “Crop Top, you devious little rebel you,” Catra grinned back, leaping over and giving him a one-armed hug. “I’ll turn you into a troublemaker yet.”

“I’m actually pretty good at trouble,” Bow replied, his smile turning shy. “Huh.”

Catra blinked. “What?”

“You’ve got a really nice smile when you’re not being evil,” Bow explained.

Catra yelped. “Sh-shut up!” she blurted, shoving him. Adora, Glimmer, *and* Scorpia all laughed. “Traitors!” she hissed at them. “I’ll remember this!”

“Don’t worry, Catra,” Adora said, smiling and taking her hand. “I’ll make it up to you.”

Catra purred in spite of herself.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora-4 paced, worry roiling in her stomach while Glimmer-4 seethed. “What was he thinking?” Glimmer blurted for the sixth time.

“However unwise his decision,” Shadow Weaver soothed, her hands on Glimmer’s shoulders. Adora stiffened. “I am sure he had your best interests at heart. Even if she thinks herself ‘good,’ do not underestimate how manipulative Catra can be.”

“Gee, I wonder where she learned *that* from,” Adora retorted, arms crossed.

“I agree,” Perfuma added. To Adora’s amazement, one hand was clenched into a fist. “Your negative energy is not helping in this environment.”

Shadow Weaver sighed with that condescending air that always made Adora feel queasy. “I spent most of my time as Catra’s caretaker attempting to instill discipline in the ungrateful creature. Adora poured a lifetime of devotion into their friendship. Salineas proves how well that worked.” Adora forced back tears, unable to come up with a defense. “Some beings are simply beyond salvage.”

Perfuma took in an angry breath, but the roar of First Ones engines cut her off. Adora-4 swallowed, caught between relief and fear. *She has to be wrong about Catra,* Adora thought, holding onto the remnants of their friendship.

As the ship landed, Glimmer -1 teleported to Adora-4’s side and grinned. “I’ve got good news!” she cheered sing-song, then turned a cool glare on their world’s Glimmer. “Assuming your messed-up version of me can avoid committing a war crime for half an hour.” Glimmer-4 took in a breath to rant–

“Glimmer?”

Both Glimmers froze. Glimmer-4 stared in disbelief at a man in ragged clothes, leaning on a rounded staff. Behind him, Entrapta chattered excitedly with Scorpia and Catra. *Not our Catra, she’s not our Catra,* Adora-4 reminded herself, heart clenching as the other Adora took Catra’s hand. Adora-4 was actually grateful when Shadow Weaver gasped. “Micah?” the old sorceress whispered.

Micah's eyes narrowed. "Here's a hint," he half-growled, drawing a spell. A cage of violet light formed around Shadow Weaver.

Adora-4 couldn't help a smile. "Oh, I like him," she admitted.

The Micah turned to Glimmer-4, eyes wide as he gulped. He looked up the ramp at the other Glimmer, who flashed him a smile and an encouraging wave toward their Glimmer. He marched over, straightened, forced out a frozen smile and held out his hand. "Hi. I'm your dad," he blurted. Catra-1 sighed.

Queen Glimmer stared for a long moment. She raised a trembling hand to Micah's cheek, eyes wider than his. "daddy?" she whispered.

"You survived," Shadow Weaver said, her voice low and quiet as well. Adora-4 thought she sounded...proud. "Alone of all those sent to Beast Island, you survived."

King Micah looked up to glare at Shadow Weaver, but then Glimmer hugged him, and no one cares about Shadow Weaver. ...except Catra-1, who laughed from atop a massive mechanical beast. "Not alone, Shadow Loser," she drawled, as the hatch opened to reveal Entrapta and a woman who was almost all blue. Entrapta cackled as she leaped down, most of the others carrying large slabs of gear. Most of it looked like First Ones crystals, but some of it resembled the arch Entrapta and Hordak had created to reach beyond Despondos. "Your stupid island couldn't handle my girl E.T."

"'Your' girl? The one you betrayed?" Shadow Weaver retorted. Micah made a fist, pulling the web-cage in, but Shadow Weaver slashed out with a hand-chop, disrupting it.

"Oh, no, that was our Catra," Entrapta explained. "I've been talking to the Entrapta from this Catra's timeline. It's so exciting!" Again she laughed, starting work on the new gateway while Catra levitated pieces over to a clearing with shadow tendrils.

Adora-4 gasped. “No, wait wait wait, you can’t,” she blurted. “I want to rescue Angella, so much, but if you open a portal to another dimension, it’ll destroy everything.”

“I’ve got it covered, Adora-4,” Catra replied. “There’s a lot of complicated, annoying math–”

“You mean *amazing* math!” Entrapta cheered. The other princesses, mostly gathered by then, turned dubious glares on the inventor princess.

Catra-1 rolled her eyes, but it was fond. She-Ra-1 and Scorpia did the literal heavy lifting, each carrying one of the two largest crystal slabs. “– but the short version is, we’re not trying to reach other dimension, we’re reaching the gap between dimensions, where mmm...the queen is stuck.” She stared into the distance, shadows flickering deep in her eyes. “Since all this weird timeline stuff has me going through that every time, I can serve as a, like a conduit. You know, a pipe or–”

“We know what a conduit is, angry cat girl,” Mermista said, voice even but tight.

Catra’s ears and tail drooped as the team put all the pieces in place. Micah joined them, sharing a look with Catra. “I’m sorry, Misty,” she whispered. “Hordak and evil-me dropped an army on Salineas.” She made a fist and shook, eyes tightening. “I guess we’re not that unbeatable, after all.” Mermista blinked, stance softening. Adora-4 looked at her counterpart, who just glared for an instant before helping Entrapta finish her device. *It is my fault,* Adora thought, jaw quivering. *What did I do wrong?*

“Can you do it?” Glimmer asked suddenly, teleporting beside the other Catra. “Can you save her?”

“I *will,* Glimm,” Catra-1 whispered, staring into the empty arch with a determination more fierce than their Catra’d had during the Battle of Brightmoon. “Whatever it takes.”

Adora-1 turned a wild, frightened look on her Catra. "Wait, what? Catra, you have to be careful," she warned.

Catra laughed. "Always am," she insisted. Then she roared – no, Roared – and magic of light and shadow exploded out from her alongside it. The power filled Entrapta's machine, bringing it to life.

"Ugh!" Glimmer-1 cried, joining Catra and reinforcing her magic. "You're *never* careful, Catra!"

The Adoras looked at one another in shared panic. "Amaaazing," Entrapta reported. "Systems operating at 142% projected capacity!"

Adora-1 rushed over as Micah joined the spell and a holo-Entrapta appeared to help the biological one. "Catra, what are you doing?" the other She-Ra blurted.

"Saving mom," she snapped. Adora-4 gasped in time with her Glimmer. "You wouldn't let me kill their Catra or Hordak? Fine. I'm getting their Angella back, no matter what!"

"Even Hordak, Adora?" Glimmer-4 sighed, more resigned than angry, as she joined the others in the spell. Shadow Weaver watched, eyes narrow, as the other princesses gaped in amazement. The demi-portal came to life, revealing an expanse of almost-nothing with a handful of floating rocks in the distance.

"We're the good guys," both Adoras said as one. Adora-4 looked at She-Ra-1 and while neither smiled, each gave the other a nod. "Give me a line?" Adora asked. She-Ra transformed her Sword into a lasso and obliged. Adora held up her Sword. "For the honor of Grayskull!" she cried.

"Be...careful...Adora," Catra warned, teeth clenched. Adora-4 nodded and leaped into the void.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra clenched her jaw, dug her claws in the ground, and held onto the magical void howling inside her. “Catra,” her Adora whispered.

Catra chuckled through a hiss. “S’Fine, Adora,” she insisted. “Worst that happens is, four lives left.”

Suddenly, Adora braced herself as the line went taut. She gripped the Sword-cord with both hands, and a few seconds later, Adora-4 appeared with a thin Angella in her hands.

Their spell collapsed when Glimmer-4 teleported to Angella’s side, Micah rushing behind her. “Mom!” Glimmer-4 sobbed, throwing her arms around the (former?) queen.

“Glimmer,” Angella whispered, stroking her cheek. Then she looked up at Micah and sighed. “Oh. I’m still hallucinating.”

Catra dropped to her knees, colors turning hyper-saturated around the edges. “Peekablue, you’re on,” she groaned. The psychic princess gave her a brief look, then nodded and rushed over to the royal family. Angella gasped, and they all hugged, mobbing Adora-4 in the process.

“Catra!” Glimmer-1 blurted, gripping the magicat. “What’s wrong?”

“Think we’re...done here. Adora? Time to go home.” Adora-1 let She-Ra go, nodded, and rushed to take Catra’s hand.

The last thing Catra heard from Etheria-4 as it became all swirls and blurs of rainbow light was Glimmer-4 looking up to cry, “Thank you! And I’m sorry!”

Catra smiled and tried to nod back before they were gone, but by the time it all registered, they were back home in the field outside their Brightmoon. It was *her* Bow next to an Entrapta in a weird simulation rig and *her* Perfuma and Scorpia holding hands (well, hand in claw) as they watched *her* Flutterina break up an argument between Frosta and Sweet Bee….

Catra sighed, stood, then put her fingers to her mouth and whistled. "Catra!" Entrapta rushed over and hugged her with arms and hair alike. "Adora, is she emotionally distressed?"

"Their Catra conquered Salineas before we got there," Adora sighed. "So, yeah."

Catra shook her head. "Later. Frosta, Bee, what were you arguing about?"

Sweet Bee glared at the younger princess. "This child accused *my* people of dereliction," she said.

Frosta glared back, hands on hips as the air chilled around her. "I did *not!"* she retorted. "She's the one who said *I* didn't care about the Waste!"

Catra groaned as Entrapta let her go, held her head, and whistled again. They both stopped. "Neither of you said that stuff. Odds are we've got a shapeshifter messing with our heads."

Bow and the princesses stopped and stared at Catra. "What?" Perfuma blurted.

"Etheria-4's Glimmer and Adora caught a shapeshifter messing with them. We've probably got the same thing going on here," Catra replied, the world tilting and pulsing beneath her. *Oh, wait, it's just me. Bast. That's probably bad.* She stumbled back, only for Adora and Glimmer to catch her. "Sorry, I overdid the magic cleaning up their Catra's messes. I'm..."

Everything went black.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Glimmer glared at Catra's unconscious body, passed out on an infirmary cot. *Again.* She glanced at Bow, and they both turned sympathetic smiles on an Adora turned nervous wreck. Mom was with them, stroking Catra's hair, while Entrapta turned a determined look on a tracker pad and Lonnie rubbed her shoulder.

“Goodness,” Angella sighed as Catra’s leg twitched. “Catra does push herself, doesn’t she?”

Glimmer clenched her fists. “That’s what the Horde does to people,” she choked out, vision blurred by tears. “It convinces them they’re not worth anything, no matter how awesome they are.” Adora nodded until Glimmer locked eyes with her for several seconds. The princess was proud when Adora blushed and looked away. The pride melted to nothing at Catra’s tiny whimper. “Mom? Promise me Shadow Weaver will *never* be part of the Rebellion.”

Angella spluttered for an instant. “I – what?”

“This is the second timeline they found where – when – Shadow Weaver was working with us,” Glimmer explained, shaking her head. “All she does is making things worse. I...I was horrible there, Mom. The other me. You were gone, and Shadow Weaver was there, and I was *listening* to her–”

Angella hugged her first daughter. “Glimmer, I want you to listen to *me* for a moment. First, I have complete faith in your ability to handle that – woman if need be.” Glimmer swallowed. “Secondly, we must give everyone a chance to change,” she continued, and Glimmer took in a breath to argue, “but, that does not require us to abandon our good judgment. If Shadow Weaver surrenders to us, or we capture her, the Rebellion will treat her as we would any prisoner of war – with honor and decency.”

“But we’re gonna keep her away from Adora and Catra, right?” Glimmer insisted.

Angella smiled. “Oh, I intend to keep her away from a great many people,” she agreed, “my family chief among them.” Glimmer nodded, burying herself in the hug.

“Hey…” Catra mumbled, and suddenly they were all on their feet around her bed, “...how’m I supposed to tear her face off if I can’t see her?”

Glimmer and Adora almost slammed their foreheads together rushing to hug Catra, who failed to hold back a purr. Angella sighed, but did not stop stroking Catra's hair. "If I were concerned that you would do such a thing to a defenseless prisoner, dear, I would reprimand you for that."

Catra huffed. "I'm your bad guy. It's what I'm good for," she muttered, turning her head aside.

Glimmer stood in an instant, crossing her arms. "Catra!" she blurted. *Ugh! I hate Shadow Weaver so much!*

Angella shook her head. "Of course, Catra. That is why you sacrifice to the point of infirmity more than any princess in the Alliance." Catra jolted at that, staring at their mother.

Adora's grin was as bright as the daymoon. "Hah!"

Felicia burst in, looking half-wild. "She's awake!" the magicat princess called, and Glimmer smirked as she teleported out of the way of the stampede. Angella flowed through the mass to stand by her side, both of them grinning while Micah wagged a finger at the chagrined adoptee.

Glimmer's grin faded away. "Mom?" she whispered. "Should we tell her about the, um, 'Swen suit' Sea Hawk found this morning?"

Angella shook her head. "Later. This time, Catra is going to rest until she is better, if I have to send Netossa here to sit on the girl." Glimmer nodded. *And maybe Adora, too,* she thought. "Once she is ready, we will find our clever saboteur of morale, then put an end to the Horde's evil once and for all."

Chapter End Notes

Spoiler alert: it won't be as simple as Angella thinks.

Also, it turns out that being able to write full-time for a living, as wonderful as that is, can consume your life. Consider this my oblique Catra-like apology for the incredible lateness of

this chapter, and a hope that I will put the next one together sooner.

As is probably clear by now, each setting more or less diverges in the season that matches its number (technically, Etheria-3 diverges in the last episode of Season 2, but the divergence repercussions are primarily in the equivalent of Season 3).

Next time: Kill the Bat (or, magicats are terrifying assassins)

Kill the Bat

Chapter Summary

> Glimmer accidentally convinces Catra to try to assassinate Hordak. It doesn't go well.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Flutterina bit her lip, then moved her knight. "Hm. Not bad, 'Rina," Catra agreed, tail thumping on her cot as she considered her next move. "You okay?"

"M' fine. And you promised not to hold back," Flutterina pointed out, taking a sip of lemonade. One of the healers smiled at the pair, as did Peekablue.

Catra nodded. "That's why I'm taking my time, princess," she retorted, models of possible maneuvers playing out in her mind. *There.* She slid a bishop into place, careful to keep her focus on the kid. Flutterina's eyes widened, then she looked over the board again, scowling. *Thanks for looking out for her, Peekablue.* Catra kept her smile as gentle as she could. "Trust me, 'Rina. I'm here to teach you, not coddle–"

Superhuman hearing caught the sound of people running towards the infirmary. Catra's heart froze, and she sniffed the air. *Wounds. Ozone. Burnt clothes.* Catra leaped to her feet just before the door opened. "Catra?" Flutterina asked...

...then she gasped as a train of princesses and soldiers poured in. "Clear!" Sea Hawk cried as they brought Mermista in on a stretcher. Catra gasped at the sight of Adora leaning on Scorpia, the two strongest princesses both bruised and ragged. Adora's arm was in a sling, and Scorpia's tail was bent, drooping to one side.

It tore Catra in half not to leap to Adora's side, but after fifteen months, she had enough experience with Brightmoon's healers to know they were nothing like the Horde's. Instead, she pounced from ledge to ledge, staying overhead and out of the way until all the princesses were settled. Mermista and Spinnerella were the only serious injuries, and neither of them were critical – Misty had several broken ribs on one side and Spinny had a messed-up leg. Once the healers managed to get Adora to sit on a bed, Catra dropped down beside her and half-guided, half-pushed her to lie down. "If you don't rest, Adora, I'm going to kill you."

Adora snorted in that way Catra hated and loved. "Well that's counterproductive," she quipped.

Catra blinked tears away, trying to hide them behind a snarl. "You think that's funny?" she hissed.

Adora's eyes widening told Catra the blonde had seen her fear. "Catra, I didn't mean–"

"I know what you meant," Catra retorted, biting back a growl. The tears rising in Adora's eyes brought her to a halt, Scorpia's worried glance a serious reminder of who Catra used to be. She closed her eyes. "Adora, I have spent the last three days down here because we need to be at our best to stop the Horde."

"I know Catra," Adora blurted. "And I know you worry about me. I do."

Catra nodded. "Okay." She opened her eyes, gave Adora the most gentle kiss she could manage, and stalked out of the room before the sight of Misty and Spinny had her spiraling again.

She missed Peekablue watching her leave, blinking sideways.

In spite of her best efforts, Catra gouged four long claw rakes in the wall before she realized what she'd done. *Ugh.* With a shake of her head, Catra summoned the trauma caps back on to her claws.

Glimmer appeared beside Catra. She glanced at the gouges, then the floating nail caps. "Good. It's you," Glimm said, putting a hand on Catra's shoulder. An instant later, the rush of light faded, and the two were in their spot in Brightmoon's highest tower.

Catra glanced at the wards. "Huh." She looked over at Sparkles, then summoned bits of freezefire and shadow. "We can't assume the shapeshifter doesn't know any magic," she reminded her sister.

Glimmer sighed. "It's fine, Catra. I know it's you." She straightened, and Catra's eyes widened a fraction at the grim, determined set of Glimmer's jaw, and the crystal glint in her eyes. "I need your help, sis."

Catra nodded. "Anything, Glimm," she agreed.

Glimmer's jaw trembled for just an instant, but then she made a fist, and worry rushed through the magicat. *What is she*– Catra wondered. "I have to kill Hordak," Glimmer said.

"Ugh," Catra groaned, holding her forehead. "If I knew how to kill our Hordak, Glimm, he'd be dead. Best I can give you is eyes and throat, his anatomy is enough like–"

"No." Glimmer gripped Catra's hand, her resolve somehow more implacable in spite of the quiver that rushed through her. "Not out there, in the field, where he's got soldiers and tanks and bots."

Catra's fur flattened against her skin. "You – you mean–" Glimmer nodded, her certainty unwavering. Catra shook her head. "It won't work. You don't know the Fright Zone–"

"That's why I need you!" Glimmer insisted. "You can map it out for me, teach me how to get in, and then I can–" Glimmer punched the air, causing a small explosion. "–end the war."

"Listen to me, Glimmer," Catra said, scowling. "The Fright Zone is a deathtrap. You're brilliant, but that's not enough." The magicat recognized the rush of contradictory reactions, Glimm's joy at the

compliment clashing with her frustration. "Codes and patrols change every week. The black market messes with stuff, but they're still loyal to the Horde, otherwise they would have defected. It's impossible for anyone who doesn't know how the Zone works, every secret corner, someone devious and sneaky and–"

Both princesses froze. "Catra, no," Glimmer gasped.

With a sigh, Catra gave Glimmer's hand a gentle squeeze. "It has to be me, Glimm. You know that."

"No! I didn't want – you can't – if Shadow Weaver catches you…" Glimmer's eyes widened in horror.

To her own surprise, Catra smiled. "It's okay, Glimm. This feels like – why I'm here." She shrugged. "Adora was always the chosen one, the one with a destiny, a *purpose.* Ever since I got my head out of my tail, I've wondered. Why was I the lucky Catra?"

Glimmer yanked her hand out of Catra's. "You are *not* the bad guy, Wildcat!" she snapped.

"We can win this thing," Catra pointed out, letting her nail caps slide off one by one. "If Hordak dies, the Horde will turn on itself. Vultak and Shadow Weaver will fight over his throne. We might even be able to get a couple of other jerks to make power grabs." She looked at her claws, forcing herself not to tremble. *I can do this. They* need *me to do this.* Catra's smirk was wry. "They'll beat themselves."

"You can't kill him.," Glimmer replied, fists clenched.

Catra's head snapped up, and she glared at her sister. "Excuse me?"

Glimmer waved her hands in desperation. "No, I don't mean 'I won't let you,' I mean, you literally can't! You keep telling us how terrible you are while you keep almost killing *yourself* for us! You

can’t even kill Shadow Weaver, what makes you think you can kill Hordak?”

Catra’s eyes went wider than Glimmer’s had. *Oh.* Again, she swallowed a growl. “Of course I can,” she insisted, crossing her arms. “If evil me can almost–”

“Stop right there,” Glimmer demanded, grabbing Catra’s arms. “She isn’t you, any more than ‘Queen’ Glimmer was me.” Catra’s tail lashed, uncontrollable. “Back when we rescued Entrapta and you were still, like, evil-adjacent, you went for Shadow Weaver’s crystal instead of her throat.”

A hiss escaped through Catra’s teeth. “I can *do* it,” she insisted.

Glimmer scowled back and crossed her arms. “Really? Okay, promise me.”

Catra froze, except for her lashing tail. “Glimm...”

“Exactly. This isn’t you, Wildcat,” Glimmer said, relaxing.

Steeling herself, Catra took a deep breath. “Okay, under one condition.” Glimmer’s eyes widened again. “This was my idea.”

Glimmer gaped. *“What?!”*

“Mom is going to go nuts over this,” Catra explained. “Everyone will get over it faster if they think I did this myself. You promise me that you’ll let me take the heat for it, and I promise I’ll...kill Hordak,” she finished. *That should not be this hard,* Catra thought in frustration.

“Mmm, how about no?” Glimmer retorted, glaring. “This was my idea, I’m not letting you–”

Catra grabbed one of Adora’s tricks and hugged Glimmer. Her sister gasped. “You’re Mom’s heir. You’re...you *are* the Rebellion, Glimm. It has to be me.”

"Oh, I'm so going to regret this," Glimmer groaned. "Okay, I promise."

Catra took a deep breath, let it go. "Me too," she said.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

With a roar, Hordak smashed the globe responsible for his latest failure. "Useless!" he snarled.

Imp cackled. "Useless! Useless! Useless!" he echoed. Hordak roared at the little beast, glaring. Imp recoiled, darting away with his wings fluttering behind. *Reduced, not to mere child manipulation, but terrorizing my sole surviving creation.*

The crude text communicator Entrapta contacted him with came to life on a nearby screen. He stared at the monitor for several seconds before trudging over to it.

ET: So did it work

Hordak almost smiled. *Brilliant enough to extrapolate the frequencies required for inter-dimensional communication. Strange enough to struggle with punctuation.* With a snarl, he shook off the moment's emotional weakness.

Scrambler: The globe burned out rather than exploded. I am not certain if that is progress.

ET: I will need more data before performing a proper analysis

ET: However, my first hypothesis is that it is not

ET: In my experience, explosions are a sign of progress

Hordak chuckled before he could stop himself. *I still cannot decide if Catra is a good influence or a bad one,* he mused.

Scrambler: Are you relying on anecdotal evidence, Entrapta? "Trusting your gut?"

ET: I prefer to think of it as emotional honesty

ET: I will confess that mathematical data on the subject is questionable

ET: My failed experiments cause explosions at sufficient rates that non-explosion failures do not make up a sample size sufficient for statistical analysis

Hordak couldn't help himself. He laughed outright at that.

Scrambler: Be that as it may. Here is the recorded data from the most recent failure.

ET: FASCINATING

ET: This indicates an external interference pattern

ET: which supports my model of the First Ones tech barrier

ET: This is so exciting

Scrambler: That would appear to present an insurmountable problem. My own findings confirm yours that Etheria's interior is replete with First Ones terraforming technology. I suspect that they used underground Bubasti structures after betraying them.

ET: Oh that reminds me

ET: Catra has infiltrated the Fright Zone and is in the process of sabotaging military production

ET: Should I ask her to investigate anything for you

Hordak stared at the screen, eyes wide. His armor grew claws, which dug into the metal in front of the screen. "What," he snarled.

ET: And if you have changed your mind about extraction, she is eager to aid you in a departure from the Fright Zone

Hordak's eyes narrowed. *Yes,* he thought, enraged. *I imagine she is.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Glimmer looked from one screen to the other, making a fist to cover her nerves. *This is getting out of hand,* she worried.

Her idea of recruiting Entrapta brought in Kyle, of course, but then Bow arrived, and Glimmer couldn't think of a way to get her best friend (and Entrapta's boyfriend) to leave. Then Scorpia showed up with tiny cupcakes, and now they were having a party while Catra infiltrated the Fright Zone by herself.

One screen provided a shoulder's-eye view of Catra's infiltration; Entrapta "did a thing" so the camera remained in place regardless of her Changing. At the moment, Catra was padding through vents at domestic cat size, lines of dim light breaking up otherwise-impenetrable darkness.

The other screen had Entrapta's so-called "chat log" with Scrambler. He hadn't responded for almost half a minute. *I don't like this,* Glimmer thought, grimacing, while alarm slowly spread across Entrapta's expression. "Scrambler?" she whispered, then resumed typing.

ET: Scrambler are you there

Scrambler: Preparing audio-visual feed. One moment.

Bow and Glimmer shared a look. "That's...unexpected," Bow noted.

"But exciting!" Entrapta gushed, tapping at her keyboard-thing with phenomenal speed while throwing the occasional switch. "Catra, are you there?"

"Yeah," Catra replied, terse and quiet. "Keep the line open."

"Well, obviously," Entrapta said with a faint huff. Glimmer's concerns turned into all-out worry. "I wonder how treatment for his condition is progressing–"

The chat screen flickered, static consuming it for a moment. Then it resolved, and they were staring at Hordak!

Glimmer couldn't help it. She screamed. It was a relief when Kyle, Scorpia, and Bow all joined her, turning into a four-way panic hug.

Entrapta blinked, turning to her panicking friends, then back to the screen. "Your hair, eyes, and teeth have changed color." She brightened. "Oh, is this the result of our treatments? You said that Hordak's condition was not as advanced as yours–"

"I *AM* HORDAK, YOU INSUFFERABLE SIMPLETON!" Hordak roared, his snarl like a gleaming knife.

Entrapta went so pale Glimmer worried that she'd collapse. "...what?" she gasped.

Hordak's expression melted into a cold smile. "To be fair, 'simpleton' is an oversimplification. You have unmistakable signs of genuine intelligence, unlike the rest of the pathetic savages on this miserable world." The hug began to melt as the quartet remembered that Hordak could not attack then through the screen, and Entrapta needed them. "I must thank you for all your donations to the Horde cause. Our bots, weapons, and power systems have all advanced in measurable ways thanks to your assistance. In addition, I could never have built this armor without you." He tapped his chest plate with one talon, smile vanishing as he glared with undisguised fury. "As Catra will soon be dead, however, I no longer require your assistance."

"Catra get out of there!" Entrapta cried, her terror mirrored by the others.

Glimmer was more grateful than ever she hadn't shared Catra's plan with the others. "I'm going to kill you, Hordak," she whispered, striding up behind Entrapta.

"Glimmer!" Bow objected.

Hordak looked at her with a moment's unconcerned confusion. "Princess Glimmer," he said, as if working out her identity. "The bioluminescent teleporter."

"It's not b–" Entrapta began, then clamped her hands over her mouth. Tears ran over her fingers before she let go. "Three percent. The odds were only three percent," she whispered. Hordak's smile returned, more cruel than ever. "But...you're my friend," she choked out.

Hordak twitched. *Or...did he flinch?* Glimmer wondered. "Friend? *Friend!* You ridiculous fool! I am the hand of Horde Prime, greatest general in all his armies. I neither have nor need *friends."*

Kyle swalllowed, then took a step forward. "Y-you're losing to Catra!"

"A teenager," Scorpia added, crossing her claws.

Glimmer smirked. "Sounds like the 'greatest general' could use some friends after all."

Hordak's eyes narrowed. "Entrapta, your position in the Horde is now terminated. Catra's life will soon follow. The Horde thanks you for your service." Entrapta broke down sobbing just before Hordak slammed his fist into the console, shutting off the connection.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra choked back an overwhelming urge to growl. *You...YOU...* She glared at the frozen Hordak, fist still planted in the console where he'd smashed the off button into a useless mass of wire and plastic.

You made Entrapta cry.

The thought burned away what doubt remained. *It wouldn't matter anyway. I made a promise.* With inhuman silence, Catra removed the last duct grill between her and Hordak. A last flicker of thought ensured that Imp was still sleeping off the slumber spell the magicat had cast on him. She crouched, her feline form ready to pounce. Hordak remained motionless. With deliberate care, she pictured the arc of her leap, body shifting to humanoid form, the talons of her left hand outstretched to plunge through the vulnerable neck area just above his armor, and below his skull. Hordak would be dead before he knew what happened.

Better than you deserve.

She dove at Hordak, a silent arrow aimed at the monster who'd ruined Etheria, ruined *her,* body growing and rippling as she fell towards the heartless tyrant–

A single tear fell from Hordak's cheek, splashing against the ruined console.

Catra's assault fell apart, claws retracting and posture curling just before she crashed into Hordak. She slammed his face into the console, driving one of his arms into the screen, but Catra herself rolled across the jagged wreckage, taking a handful of scratches herself. *Ugh! What's wrong with me?* she wondered, springing to her feet as Hordak recovered. "What – you!" the alien snarled.

Catra popped her claws again. "Aw," she sneered, her smile mirroring the one Hordak had flashed at Entrapta. "Does the mighty Horde Lord have a sad?"

Hordak bared his teeth. And claws. And arsenal. His adaptive armor bristled with crimson lenses, each threatening to unleash a beam of raw destruction. "What are you babbling about, magicat?" he demanded. Catra's smirk grew, and she tapped her cheek, then pointed to his. Hordak's snarl grew until he touched the thin tear streak. He recoiled in horror, staring at the hint of moisture on his fingers as though it were a mortal wound.

"Don't worry, Sore-dak," Catra mocked, then crouched, freezefire in one hand and shadows in the other. "In a minute, you really won't need friends. Or anything else." Her smirk melted into a snarl to rival his. "EVER AGAIN!" Catra leaped at Hordak, frostfire and razor darkness lashing out.

"Catra, what are you *doing?!"* Bow blurted as Hordak returned fire. That forced Catra to dodge, and both combatants evaded the blasts.

"Run, Wildcat!" Scorpia begged. Alarms howled across the Fright Zone.

Catra chuckled, forming the trigger from her own suit. "Whoops. I guess backup's coming." Hordak leaped sideways, firing more beams at her. She created a scorch-ice slick under him, but Hordak was smarter than the pirates, forming spikes on the soles of his boots. "Oh, wait." She pressed the button, and explosions rocked the Fright Zone's three automated factories. "Guess it's just you and me, Snoredak."

"Catra, please," Entrapta sobbed, "I can't lose you too."

Catra grimaced and shrank, ducking behind debris. Four tanks shattered as another beam tore through the room, dumping frail Hordak-like bodies around her. "You won't, ET. But a long time ago, I made a promise to Adora. That promise kept me alive. It's time I kept it." Glimmer's wince was audible.

"Ah, the legendary promise of a magicat," Hordak sneered, throwing aside an entire bank of machinery. "Is that was sustains you, weakling? Do you imagine that next time, you will not hesitate? To think I was ashamed at the suffering you endured." Catra stalked through the rubble, small and shrouded by shadow. "I will invent new forms of agony for you to–"

Catra darted between his legs, sprang to full size, and slashed at the back of his head again. This time, she struck, but not cleanly, as the armor sprang up to produce a helmet. *I felt bone, that*

time, Catra thought, covering her horror in satisfaction. Still, she flinched at the white fluid covering her hand. Hordak cried out and fired several beams, wild and desperate. "Glimmer isn't going to kill you, Hordak," she hissed through the smoke rapidly filling his throne room. "I am. Today. *I made a promise."*

"Lord Hordak!" Vultak howled, pounding on the doors. "Are you unharmed?" Catra grunted, then began gathering her full sorcerous might.

"I sense magic gathering," Shadow Weaver warned. In spite of the many greater threats gathering, Catra's fur bristled beneath her suit. "A princess is behind this assault."

"Catra," Hordak explained. "Assassination attempt. Do not enter. The Horde can ill afford to lose you. I will deal with her."

Catra scoffed while her friends in Brightmoon gasped. "Y'know, Hordak, I like it better this way – a real fight, where you find out just how good I *really am."*

"The door's jammed!" Vultak shouted. "Get Grizzlor!"

"We all know how good you are, Catra," Kyle said, "please, you've gotta get out!"

Catra shook off the warmth she felt at their concern, leaping at Hordak. Each raked the other's armor, both coming away with slashes and cracked ribs. "Mission's not done, Kyle. Not until Hordak's cold cuts."

"Catra," Glimmer whispered. The magicat could hear her crying.

Catra didn't know why, but she smiled. "It's gonna be okay, Glimm. Once Hordak dies, we can all finally live."

It was as though someone had flipped a switch in Entrapta's lab. Catra could almost hear the inspiration spark through Glimmer. "Catra, I release you from your promise!" Glimmer cried.

Every muscle in Catra's body froze for an instant. All her willingness to kill Hordak vanished, like some diabolic magic trick. *No – I can still –* Catra crouched low, forcing her claws out (when had she retracted them?). She prepared to leap. Her legs trembled.

Sekhmet!

Catra ran.

Hordak froze as well, beams lancing out far too late. By the time he'd even thought to take advantage of her retreat, Catra was racing through the vents, following the smell of super-heated metal. "Where is your bravado now, Princess of Brightmoon?" Hordak shouted, his laughter mocking her as Catra raced to the rendezvous point.

"Hurry, Glimmer," she heard Bow pray over the comm unit.

"What do–" *pop* "–you think–" *pop* "–I'm doing, Bow?" Glimmer gasped, the sounds of her enchanted wings intermingling with the snap of her teleportation.

Catra leaped into the night air, smoke billowing in all directions. Horde firefighter teams focused on dousing the flames, while patrols raced in erratic search patterns that Catra almost found insulting. She darted through the pathetic attempts to find her, leaping atop the massive Fright Zone rampart. Just to taunt them, Catra used her claws to slide down the outer wall, Entrapta's helmet design protecting her ears from the worst screeching.

"It's her!" a cadet shouted from above. "All units, the Living Arsenal is escaping down the east wall, send backup!" Catra couldn't help a grin at the nickname. Then she activated her wings, flying so fast that no Horde gunner would have a chance of hitting her even without her shadow shroud.

Glimmer appeared beside Catra, grabbed her hand, and pulled them into the light.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"What were you *thinking,* Catra?" Angella demanded, tears glistening in her ageless eyes.

Glimmer felt sick. The War Room was full, Mermista and Spinnerella wearing casts so they could participate. Adora was pale, her horrified expression driving daggers through Glimmer's gut. Poor Felicia was shaking. Even Lonnie's hand in hers felt undeserved.

Catra folded her arms and glanced away. "I was thinking that if Hordak dies, the war's over." Her lashing tail betrayed her nonchalance.

"As though another would not rise in his place?" Mom cried, slamming her palms onto the table.

Catra chuckled at that, a hint of her confidence returning. "That's just it. A bunch of people would. When they were done fighting, all we'd have left is cleanup."

"And what about you?" Mom shook her head, wings trembling. She only calmed when Micah put his hand on hers. "Catra, your mission was in other ways a tremendous success. Your sabotage bought us weeks, if not months. Yet you chose to conceal this effort from the council. If something had gone wrong..."

Catra raised an eyebrow. "Shapeshifter. It was on a need to know basis."

"And how many of them knew you were planning to kill Hordak?" Spinnerella asked, voice soft.

Catra snorted at that. "How many do you think?" she asked. Glimmer swayed, the shame threatening to drown her. "I was the only one who could do it. I was the only one who *would."*

"Except you didn't," Dad pointed out, his smile faint. Catra looked away, everything from ears to tail to fur giving away her

embarrassment.

“Come on, Wildcat, you shouldn’t have tried this if you couldn’t follow through,” Netossa objected.

Catra’s tail puffed out completely. “I flinched, okay?”

Perfuma gasped. “You are not suggesting this was a positive effort, are you?”

Netossa glared back. “I’m *suggesting* we’ve been at war for thirty years, Perfuma,” she retorted. “Hordak’s killed more people than anyone can count. The problem wasn’t the plan–” she stopped when Spinnerella flinched.

“This is not who we are,” Mom insisted.

“Yeah, tell that to my dad,” Mermista snapped, *“oh wait.”* Glimmer’s mouth went dry as Mom winced.

“What about us?” Entrapta asked, her voice soft and broken as she pointed at herself, Scorpia, and Catra with her hair. That brought the whole argument to a halt. “In those other timelines, we were with the Horde.”

Catra looked around, tail lashing and pupils shrunk to slits. “Okay, everybody, beside the point, I blew it and there’s no second chance on this. There’s no point in arguing over it.”

“Isn’t there?” Peekablue whispered, and all eyes turned to her. “Entrapta, none of you started this war. You’re all its victims. Like – like me.” She shuddered. “Hordak did it. All of it. If we have a chance to stop – so no one else–” she pulled Flutterina closer, as if she could protect the girl with one arm.

“Peekablue,” Scorpia began, voice gentle. Sweet Bee stood with thunderbolt speed, eyes flaring all the same. Felicia was already rounding on her, claws out.

"ENOUGH!" Catra roared. The whole room came to a halt. "I pulled this stunt, I screwed it up, no one's going back into the Fright Zone again after that, it's over!" She slammed her hands onto the table, almost exactly like Mom. "The Queen punishes me, and we *move forward."* She looked around at the other Rebellion leaders. "This is exactly what the Horde's spies want – us, at each other's throats. You want to win? Don't *give* the enemy what they want."

Mom sighed. "Catra, I am proud that you work so hard to bring us together, that you could not do...what you went there to do, and that you are willing to face the consequences of your actions." Catra looked up. Mom didn't. "But I am so...very disappointed that you chose this course of action in the first place." Catra's eyes were moons-wide, ears and tail dropping entirely. Adora looked like she was trying to say something, but nothing came out. *This is crushing Catra, and I can't–*

Wait! If she's not bound by her promise, then neither am I! Glimmer realized, teleporting beside her sister. "Mom, wait!" she pleaded.

Mom and Dad sighed in unison. "Glimmer," Mom began.

"Glimm, *don't–"* Catra began.

"It wasn't her idea!" Glimmer blurted, and Catra shrank into herself, tail curling around her waist. Mom and Dad both looked up, shock giving way to realization. "It was mine." She looked at Catra. "I released you from your promise. That means mine doesn't count, either."

The disappointment in her parents' faces was awful, but it was better than the guilt had been. Adora's glare, however, scared Glimmer a little. "What," Adora growled. That scared Glimmer more than a little. "You sent Catra–"

"No! I was gonna go!" Glimmer objected, waving her hands at Adora. That mollified the Princess of Power. "I wanted Catra to

teach me how to infiltrate the Fright Zone. She figured it'd be better if she went instead."

"You were going to…" Mom shook her head, her smile sadder than her tears. "Of course you were." The queen opened her eyes, and her glare had both sisters standing at attention. "Catra. This...does mitigate your circumstance somewhat, but you still chose this...questionable, and inexcusably dangerous, action. You are demoted to second in command of special forces, answering to Netossa." Catra sagged in relief, nodding. "Glimmer. You are relieved of command entirely." Catra gasped. "You are also both grounded, for a month, and by the *Stars* if you argue I will double it." She straightened, wings folding behind her. "Dismissed. All of you."

Adora rushed over to Catra, the two already arguing over the dangerous mission. Bow took one step towards Entrapta before she wrapped herself around Glimmer's best friend, sobbing again. Glimmer dropped into her seat, exhausted. Lonnie tapped her on the shoulder, and Glimmer looked up with a gulp.

To her eternal relief, Lonnie's glare was just annoyed. "Do you not get what a bleeding heart Catra is?"

"I figured if she could promise, she could do it," Glimmer admitted.

Again, Lonnie surprised her with a snort of laughter. "I guess that's fair." She helped Glimmer up, and the princess had never been more grateful for the Horde scum in her life. Then Lonnie's expression became serious. "That was some serious drama," she pointed out. "Is the Alliance gonna hold together?"

Glimmer watched the other princesses leave. They weren't glaring daggers at each other, but Frosta was – ironically – the only one not radiating a cold shoulder. Even Netossa and Spinnerella seemed upset with each other. "It will," Glimmer insisted. "It has to."

-SR- -SR- -SR-

“Report.” Hordak was growly and stoic even in Double Trouble’s mind.

“Glimmer’s in trouble with Mommy Dearest,” Double Trouble said, smirking at the curled-up Peekablue’s unconscious form. “Catra’s only demoted one rank, though.” Their smile was a wide array of dagger-like teeth. “Ooo, she’s so much fun!”

Hordak’s glare was far more half-hearted than Double Trouble had expected. “‘Fun.’ That is not the word I would use for her. Has Queen Angella restricted their movements?”

“Indeed she has,” Double Trouble replied, grin widening in the psychic communion. “Besides, you did some damage to the kitten. She needs some down time.”

“Good.” Hordak glanced to one side, where Shadow Weaver emerged from the psychic realm’s gray mist. “Since she has managed a few successes since Halfmoon, I have chosen to give Shadow Weaver one more chance. Activate False Face.”

Double Trouble blinked in both directions. “That spear-carrier? Whatever for?”

Shadow Weaver slid forward to narrow her eyes at them from Hordak’s side. “Why, to bring Adora home, of course.” Double Trouble refused to feel a chill at the sorceress’s words.

“Catra was right about one thing,” Hordak snarled. “It is time to end this war once and for all. As capable a leader as the magicat may be, She-Ra will decide the victor.” He held out his hand, and a tiny She-Ra took form in it, fighting with all the dramatic blonde’s might. “It is time to put an end to their pitiful rebellion, once and for all.”

Hordak made a fist, and She-Ra vanished.

Chapter End Notes

Not much to say at this point. Being a full-time writer leaves less time for my own writing than I would've thought.

Next time: Shadow Weaver makes her big push, and if the Rebellion doesn't push back, they will lose Adora -- forever!

(Oh, come on. It's me. Of course they're going to...save the blonde. ;-)

Save the Blonde

Chapter Summary

> Shadow Weaver and False Face capture Adora. Catra's patience dies an ugly death. Both sides face a battle neither can afford to lose.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Push forward!" She-Ra ordered, smashing through a super-bot as she advanced. The Horde's forces pushed back, a mix of desperation and firepower managing a stalemate. *Not for long,* Adora swore, diving right into the tanks forming the central wedge of Hordak's battalion. Glimmer and Bow raced around the battlefield, paste arrows trailing after beams of light. Netossa and Spinnerella applied their usual devastating teamwork, nets penning in Horde platoons for Spinnerella to blow them away. Mermista and Sea Hawk crashed into the opposite flank with drenching waves and Sea Hawk's agile slashes–

Don't think about Catra not now, Adora ordered herself–

–while Felicia and Sweet Bee drove into the bulk of the infantry, leading magicats and Andreenids into them. It looked like they'd worked out whatever issues they had during the last meeting.

Or Catra got them playing nice, Adora thought. She grimaced, tearing through tanks and wondering where Grizzlor was. *Something's not right here. Why is Hordak leading this assault with, like, three Force Captains?* Only Hunga, Octavia, and Dreer were fighting alongside him.

Several meters to Adora's left, one of the Andreenid warriors cried out, his rough landing leaving a divot in the ground. He clutched one leg…Adora's eyes went wide when she realized he was holding *half* a leg. "Hang on!" she cried, rushing over. "Glimmer–"

Glimmer and Bow teleported between Adora and the advancing Horde forces. “We’ve got your back, Adora!” she promised.

Conflicting feelings rushed through Adora. She stamped them down. *She’s working extra-hard to make up for the Hordak thing,* she reminded herself, sliding to kneel beside the Andreenid. “Hold still,” Adora instructed him, wishing once again that she could heal, the way the stories said She-Ra could.

Adora barely felt the stings at first, just aware of the sensations in her back and leg. Then light began to swirl and blur, the world tilting. Her eyes widened at the sight of the Andreenid’s leg growing back, extra limbs whirling out to grab her sword, cover her mouth, and pin her arms. *Shapeshifter!* Adora realized, more angry than frightened. He was strong, but no match for She-Ra in raw might. The problem was, he knew it, flowing around to maintain leverage and keep her from calling for backup. Not that Adora would have needed the backup if he hadn’t poisoned her.

Crimson lightning crackled on the edge of Adora’s vision. *Oh, no.* Adora collapsed, vile shadows draining her strength along with the toxin. “Time for you to come home, Adora,” Shadow Weaver whispered in her ear.

Everything went dark.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra steered Susan towards Candila, Darla racing overhead. For the first time, the thought of her many friends brought no comfort.

“What does the Horde want in that wasteland?” Sweet Bee asked, her prior fury forgotten. A little late, Bee, *Catra thought, before forcing her resentment back.*

“There is only one thing there worth taking,” Micah said, expression grim as he gazed at the war map. “The Spirit Ember.”

"But the Ember is broken. Useless," Angella replied, shaking her head.

"Adora," Catra whispered. "That's why they needed Adora." The others gasped. "Shadow Weaver always wanted her back, but now, she thinks Adora can repair the Runestone. And she's probably right."

Glimmer put a hand on Catra's shoulder. "She's going to be okay, Catra," Glimm insisted.

Catra's jaw clenched, more from fear than wind or sand. The Candilan Waste blurred around them, only the towering mountain a distant peak on the horizon. "I should've been there," Catra hissed.

Glimmer flinched, then stood tall. "We'll be there now," she replied.

Entrapta tapped a few instructions into her pad, and readings from her monitor drones appeared. Shadow Weaver led a small army, with every elite Captain alongside her. She even had the shapeshifter, only Hordak (and Scurvy, if you counted him) absent in the force. "How do we save her?" Felicia whispered. The couples all held onto each other in desperate need – even Glimmer and Lonnie, at this point.

"Together," Catra insisted. "Peekablue's still not up to field operations, and there are no plants in Candila, but–"

"What? No, please, I can help!" Perfuma begged. "There must be some way–"

"I'll stay with Peekie," Sweet Bee cut in. "Felicia can bring healthy soil on Darla to carry plant life into Candila, and I...need to make sure there aren't any other impostors in my hive." She looked away.

Catra nodded. "Just remember, this is no one's fault but Hordak's," she insisted. "Everyone else, we go in ten. For Adora."

"For Adora!" the others agreed.

Catra's arm trembled on the stick. Not for the first time, the magicat was grateful that Entrapta had moved Susan's controls to the front of the skiff. "We'll make it," Bow reassured her, flashing his best Bow smile. "We're the Best Friends Squad."

Catra nodded, not quite believing it – until she spotted Shadow Weaver's forces in the distance. Even with their numbers, the Horde division was a mere speck, but she could *see* them. "There!" Catra shouted, pointing them out. "Entrapta! Bury the needle!"

With a cackle that warmed Catra's terror-frozen heart, Entrapta did something that increased their speed. *Hang on, Adora. We're coming. I'm never leaving you again!*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"At last," Shadow Weaver crooned, gazing almost lovingly up at Mount Candila. In spite of the ferocious heat, Adora felt a chill.

They'd manacled her wrists and ankles, leaving Adora helpless and surrounded by almost all the Horde's might. Worst of all, Shadow Weaver had the Sword. The sorceress had placed a tiny flake of the Black Garnet on the Sword's Runestone, crimson lightning flickering within the crystal blade. "What did you do, Shadow Weaver?" Adora demanded. The shapeshifter guy – False Face, apparently – chuckled and counted gold discs in a bag.

Grizzlor huffed and tucked Adora under one massive arm, as though she were a child. "You're in no positions to ask questions, traitor," he muttered. *Does he sound...disappointed?* she wondered as the Horde forces marched up the blighted mountain.

"Now Grizzlor, it is a fair question," Shadow Weaver said, even the tilt of her head mocking. "After all, she will be far better able to aid my efforts if she knows what they are."

“Go suck exhaust, Shadow Weaver,” Adora spat. Grizzlor, Octiavia, and Callix all chuckled.

Shadow Weaver spun and glared, still heading up the mountain backwards. “Insolent child,” she hissed. “Catra has all but ruined you.” She drew herself up, taking a calming breath before continuing. “You still lack so much of your potential. The Sword of Protection can do so much more than you know. You, Adora, are capable of so much more than you realize.” She steepled her fingers, a gesture Adora imagined going with a smug smile. “For example. While a Runestone exists, it can be repaired.”

“I don’t see Entrapta,” Adora snapped.

“We don’t need her,” ‘Aunt Estra’ retorted.

“Estra,” Shdow Weaver continued, eye-slits tilted to resemble an eye roll, “might be of assistance, but we are unlikely to need her either. You see, the power of She-Ra holds sway over every Runestone. With your magic, Adora, you can heal anything that channels Etheria’s power, whether it is flesh, or enchantment.” She gestured up the mountain with her free arm, cradling the Sword like an infant with the other.

“And what makes you think I’d cooperate, even if I knew how?” Adora asked, smirking.

Shadow Weaver glared, eyeslits narrowing. Crimson lightning crackled between her fingers. “As ever, I will do the thinking,” she replied. “You need simply not resist.”

“I’m not sure if you’ve noticed, Shadow Weaver,” Adora said, smirk vanishing, “but resisting is kinda my thing.” She grimaced at the electric threat. “And if Catra could endure that to stay with me, I’ll fight it forever if it means I can protect her!”

Shadow Weaver sound back around, facing the mountaintop again. “We shall see, Adora, as we are here.” She waved her hand, and dust blew aside to reveal a cavern entrance. Adora set

her jaw, refusing to let Shadow Weaver see her fear. *I have to hang on. They're coming. I know they are.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"Okay, all princesses and partners, team up," Catra ordered.

They did. Angella and Micah. Glimmer and Bow. Felicia and Perfuma (even if Perfuma glanced over at Scorpia). Scorpia and Entrapta (even if Scorpia turned a worried look toward Perfuma). Netossa and Spinnerella. Mermista, Sea Hawk, and Frosta (Misty wasn't going to have much water otherwise). Lonnie stood beside Catra, something that would have stunned the magicat just a few months ago.

Sunder and Uncle Percival walked up, Rogelio and Kyle behind them. "You sure you want me here, Triss?" Percy asked her. "Shadow Weaver's up there."

"Lonnie's got my back," Catra said. Lonnie held up a fist. Even now, Catra rolled her eyes, but she gave her squadmate a fist-bump all the same. "I need you here leading the magicat forces." She turned a worried look on the massive force Shadow Weaver had left ringing the mountain base. "If that division crawls up our tails, I'm not sure even we could make it back down."

"We'll take care of them, Commander," Sunder replied with a salute.

"Just...all of you, come back in one piece." She glanced past knight and general at her two male squadmates. "That means you, Kyle."

"Aw, come on," Kyle groaned, to chuckles from Lonnie and Rogelio.

"Right," Catra said with a nod. "Let's do this." The Princess Alliance boarded Darla, while the Rebellion military prepared to engage the Horde. She walked over to Netossa, tail lashing. "Hey, 'Tossa,"

she muttered, frostflame lapping at her bare claws. "You okay with this? Angella put you in charge after–"

Netossa laughed, patting Catra on the shoulder. "Girl, I know I'm great. You're still the best."

Catra's eyes betrayed her with a glance at Angella. "You sure?" she whispered.

"This is no time for ego or politics," Netossa insisted. Lonnie rolled her eyes so hard, Catra was almost worried she'd hurt herself. "So you messed up. We've all done it. Let's go save your girl. Commander."

Catra took in a breath, then nodded. "Okay, everyone," she said over comms, "we're keeping this nice and simple. Drop in, grab Adora, get out. Making a mess has only one purpose – confuse the enemy so we can save Adora. No grudge matches, no secondary goals, no distractions. In, Adora, out. Any questions?"

"What about the Runestone?" Frosta asked, raising her hand.

"*After* we extract Adora," Catra replied, "if she can turn into She-Ra and Shadow Weaver hasn't blown up the mountain, we can reassess. Anything else?" Everyone took a step forward, Darla moving into position. Something bothered Catra for an instant, but she shook it off. "Okay. Ramp." Entrapta lowered the ramp, Hunga, Vultak, and their winged units howling in mockery. "Mom?"

"Give the word, Commander," Angella replied, in a tone that was as clear an *I trust you* as any words.

Catra ignored the lump in her throat. *I won't fail* any *of them again.* She crouched. "Flare!" she cried. Angella's magic flashed out, blinding the harpies and vulturekin. "Green!" Felicia and Perfuma used a wave of earth and vines to extend the ramp to the mountain, and the crimson lights flickering in the cavern opening. "GO!"

With a roar, the Alliance charged. Angella and Glimmer exploded through Hunga's aerial forces, while Micah rode a platform to blast Vultak and Bow used his beam pack to engage Styrax. With each arrow he fired, however, the beams weakened a little more. *Right, Etheria doesn't like flying tech used with ranged weapons,* Catra growled, rushing down the ramp with the rest of the team.

What she witnessed would haunt Catra for the rest of her life.

With one hand, Shadow Weaver pressed the Sword of Protection against the Spirit Ember. With the other...she tortured Adora, lightning shocking the love of Catra's life. Even some of the Horde soldiers looked disturbed, Octavia's eyes wide while Grizzlor turned away. Little grunts of agony escaped Adora's throat, her body convulsing beyond her control, but she refused to scream.

Catra screamed for her, clawing a bot in half. "Stick to the plan!" she howled, firing bolts of frostflame and shadow at the gathered Horde elite. "Mess 'em up!"

"You!" Shadow Weaver snarled back, dropping Adora and firing lightning at her.

"She is the least of your worries!" Castaspella cried, countering Shadow Weaver's magic with shields of force. Flutterina carried her in, face scrunched up with efforts as she beat her wings with desperate speed. Even that only allowed a slow descent.

"Casta? 'Rina? What are you *doing* here?" Catra blurted, blasting Tavor into a wall. Entrapta worked to turn bots to their side, but Estra went after her, distracting the tech princess and forcing Scorpia to defend her.

"You – didn't tell me *not* to come," Flutterina pointed out, "and Kyle wanted to be with the troops, and someone had to pilot Darla!" The shapeshifter darted towards the child, and Catra blasted him with frostflame.

That's what was bothering me, Catra groaned, carving through bots and clawing through soldiers as she moved towards Adora.

"Ugh, fine, you're with Frosta. Frosta! Watch Flutterina's back!"

"What am I," Frosta complained, freezing Callix to a wall, "a babysitter?"

"I'm older than you!" Flutterina retorted, jumping on Horde soldiers' helmets like that 'pad game' Bow was working on.

"LATER!" Catra roared, scanning the room. Grizzlor stepped in her way, but Catra gave two gesture-commands, and Scorpia plowed into the big guy, while Felicia and Perfuma moved to protect Entrapta. "Casta–"

"Juliet will be fine, dear," Aunt Casta said, drawing circles with fantastic speed and confidence. "As will I. Save Adora."

A quick scan had Catra send Spin-Tossa after Dreer and Estra, then with a nod, she raced around the sorcerous duel towards Adora. *Get in, get Adora, get out. Simple.*

Half the ceiling exploded. Vultak, Angella, Styrax, and Bow plummeted towards them, all reeling. Catra caught Bow and her mom in ripples of shadow, darting between falling masonry. "No plan survives first contact," Catra muttered, shielding them with scorch-ice as the rest of the aerial battle moved towards the Runestone.

Shadow Weaver did – something – with the Sword, and a beam of light and flame shattered Casta's shield. "Grizzlor! Protect the Sword!" the witch ordered while Catra cried out in horror. Fortunately, Angella was aware enough to carry Bow and Casta to safety while they recovered. Less fortunately, the chaos gave Shadow Weaver time to drag Adora to the opposite end of the Runestone chamber, the Sword still attached to the Spirit Ember. Grizzlor stood between the room and the Sword, arms crossed and grinning the way Catra used to when her bestial fury was at its peak.

Another check assured Catra that the rest of the battle was under control for the moment. Glimmer and Micah had the harpies under

control above, while Netossa and Lonnie were pushing the Horde's remaining ground forces back. Lonnie gave Catra another easily-readable glare: *What are you waiting for?* her gaze demanded, nodding sideways towards Shadow Weaver and Adora.

There was, however, the slight problem of Shadow Weaver having more power than ever. Bolts of electricity, flame, and light lashed out for Catra as she darted toward Adora. It took every trick in Catra's arsenal, from changing shape to extreme flexibility to throwing literal sand, to avoid getting fried. "Beast!" Shadow Weaver shrieked, her aim growing more erratic. "Guttersnipe!" She fired an entire barrage, forcing Catra to dodge through Horde bots. *"Freak!"*

Catra cackled when Shadow Weaver's assault slowed down. "That's Commander Freak to you," she mocked, racing towards the witch in full lioness form. *Got you!*

Vultak rushed beneath Catra, tearing at her life force. "Catra!" Adora and Angella cried, the queen blasting Vultak away, but the damage was done. Catra stumbled to her feet, forced into her natural shape.

"Stick to the plan!" Catra warned, pointing Frosta and Mermista at Estra and her remaining bots with a Freezefire arrow. Then she carved a counterspell circle in the air, barely deflecting Shadow Weaver's followup blast.

"Oh?" Shadow Weaver drawled, slithering towards her. Adora thrashed in her cuffs, tears vanishing into the dead earth. "Your only hope was your monster's flesh, but now you think to overcome me with sorcery?" She summoned a shadow spy. "Fool!"

Catra dispelled it with an exorcism circle. *Thanks, Magidad,* she thought, stalking forward on shaking legs. "Adora saved me," she hissed, "so many times, in so many ways. This time," she snarled, carving her next spell in the air, "I am going to save her."

"You did," Adora whispered, "more times than I can say."

“BAH!” Shadow Weaver roared, firing off some kind of snake-like coil of darkness. Catra set off her countermagic circle and moved in closer. “No animal can defeat the greatest sorceress Mystacor has ever known!” Once more, she prepared an elaborate spell.

Catra didn’t let her finish this time, countering it before she was complete. “I hate to admit it, but you really are good at this crap,” she said, forming a circle in each hand. Shadow Weaver’s eyeslits widened. “When it comes to the complicated stuff, I’m the runt of the litter in my family.” With a howl, Shadow Weaver threw another spell at Catra. She countered it with another abjuration, then fired her simple illusion spell, forcing Shadow Weaver to flinch. Catra indulged in a knife-sharp smile, moving still closer. “Problem is, this isn’t a sanctum, Shadow Heaver.”

“NO!” Shadow Weaver screamed, firing bolt after bolt of raw force. “Fall! *Fall,* you miserable failure!”

“The only failure I am is *yours!”* Catra screamed back, drawing counter after simple counter. “When it comes to combat? Doing what’s fast, sharp, clean, right?” She moved in, taking apart Shadow Weaver’s assault spell by spell. “I am the *best there is!”* Catra was so close, but didn’t dare let Shadow Weaver see what she was doing. “You thought I was like you, but you’re wrong! You tried to turn me *into* you, but you *blew* it!” She drew in her magic for one final spell, pulling in her shadows for energy. Wailing, Shadow Weaver did the same.

Shadow Weaver unleashed a massive burst of crimson lightning. Catra ducked, completing her circle – a simple illusion of a golden lantern, blinding Shadow Weaver with its radiance. In that moment, Catra took one last step forward – and slashed through Adora’s ankle cuffs with her toe claws. “All you ever see is power, Shadow Weaver,” Catra whispered as Adora rolled behind her. “All I had to do...is turn my darkness into light.”

While Shadow Weaver screamed, Adora squirmed to pull her hands in front of her. Catra winced when Adora almost dislocated

her shoulder, but she managed to get the cuffs past her feet. "Hold still," Catra ordered, preparing to turn.

"Wait," Adora begged, eyes wide. "Focus on Shadow Weaver. I can get She-Ra back."

Catra's eyes widened, the memory of Adora enduring that lightning howling through her. "Adora–"

"Please, Catra. I can't – I can't let her do that to you again," Adora whispered, tears brimming. "I'll make it. I *promise."*

Catra grunted, nodding with fierce reluctance. "Go. Go!" she ordered, advancing on Shadow Weaver as strength flowed back into her limbs. *You will never hurt her again, Shadow Weaver!*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora was endlessly frustrated as she rushed through the battle. Even as she watched Catra duel Shadow Weaver with one hand and direct the Princesses of Power with the other, Adora felt like she could barely fight off soldiers or bots. Sure, she'd knock one guy out here, then trip a bot with a sweep there, but it was all so clumsy. *Focus. Catra needs me. Everyone needs me.*

"Adora!" Lonnie rushed over, weirdly-curved stun batons blazing away. "What's the play?"

"I need to reach the Sword," Adora said, grimacing at the sight of the healing Spirit Ember. "Cover me?"

"It will be my genuine pleasure," Lonnie agreed, firing at Shadow Weaver with one baton and Grizzlor with the other. Adora dashed through the battle, ducking under a stream of Scorpia's lightning, then leaping over lashing vines. *Almost there,* Adora thought.

Grizzlor threw a bot at Lonnie, then grabbed Adora's cuffs and hauled her into the air. *Oh no! I promised!* Adora thrashed, kicking Grizzlor in the harness, but he merely grunted. "I hate to do this,

little human," he grunted, "but you understand duty before pleasure."

"Adora!" Catra cried as chaos reigned around them. "Did I need the Sword?"

Adora swallowed. "But – it was supposed to be you," she replied, still struggling.

"Bull!" Catra threw all her might into her duel, but still managed a glance at Adora. "Remember Razz! Trust me! You're not a Sword, Adora – *you* are *She-Ra!"*

With a gasp, Adora realized she could feel something between her hands – a force, a power, a light – sparked by love. She looked up, gold light tinged with blue swirling between her palms. Grizzlor didn't even try to stop her, just staring in awe at the magic. Adora closed her eyes. "For the honor...OF GRAYSKULL!"

The magic coursed through her, gentle as a stream, mighty as the daymoon. Grizzlor dropped her, but she only fell two inches. The cuffs were gone, a Sword of Light in one hand. With a smirk, she reached out her free hand, and the Sword of Protection flew into it.

Grizzlor flashed a savage grin and jumped her. She threw him aside. "We'll play in a minute," she promised him, then glared at Shadow Weaver. "Get away from her," Adora growled.

Shadow Weaver gasped, then tried to unleash all her power on She-Ra. Catra, never one to ignore a distracted foe, leaped and slashed her mask as well as both sleeves. Three Garnet shards shattered, and Shadow Weaver screamed again, falling to her knees. "That was for both my moms, and my dad," she said, crouching. The two former Horde soldiers nodded to each other and smiled.

It took less than ten seconds to turn the tide of battle. Catra leaped onto Estra, ripping apart the control harness on her head. Adora parried a blow from Grizzlor while entangling Hunga in a

lasso of light. False Face tried to stop Catra by turning into a giant lizard-beast; she slashed both his arms and kicked him in the jaw. Grizzlor barreled into She-Ra, trying to pin her; Adora threw him into the ceiling. Catra reunited the Super Pal Trio, smashing through Dreer's magic and forces. Adora rejoined the Best Friends Squad, tossing Dylamug and Callix aside.

"Vultak!" Shadow Weaver cried. Vultak became a vast, swirling shadow, their combined magic pulling the entire Horde force into a single point.

They vanished, and with that, the battle was over.

Rebels cheered, hugged, and sobbed. Adora found herself mobbed for a few moments, friends gushing over her new trick. Then they parted, and all Adora could see was Catra. She smirked, because of course she did. "Hey, Adora," she said, tail beckoning.

Unable to resist, Adora kissed her. This time, there was just cheering.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"I'm sorry, Felicia," Perfuma sighed, hand on the ground. "Even my magic can't heal the land."

Felicia shrugged, pulling a clump of soil over with her own powers. "Mine either," she admitted, glancing over at the others. Entrapta was examining the now-healed Ember, chattering to her boyfriend with excitement. Mermista poured water into the ground for several seconds, the stream provided by Frosta's ice, until she threw up her hands and groaned. Angella was hugging a blushing Adora, who was clearly struggling with how much she appreciated the gesture.

Catra was pacing around the room, glancing between princesses. "Have you got an idea, Wildcat?" Scorpia asked.

“Hm. Maybe,” Catra said, turning to Perfuma and Felicia. “Hey, Felicia. No one princess is able to fix this, right?”

She could almost hear the crystal light up over Perfuma’s head just as Felicia got it. “But maybe we can together!” Felicia blurted.

Catra grinned and nodded. “Hey, mom, can I borrow my girlfriend for a minute?”

“Fiancée,” Adora corrected with a satisfied grin, walking over. “What do you need?”

“Princesses,” Catra admitted with an eye roll. “Oh, the irony.” Most of the group laughed. “Okay, Frostbite, Misty, you give us water. Felicia and I’ll make sure it soaks into soil instead of sinking to wherever. Perfuma, you run your plants through everything, bring it to life. Everyone else, just add magic.” The others nodded.

“Oh, but you should bond with the Spirit Ember first!” Entrapta insisted. “That should restore the balance of etheric energy.”

Catra nodded. “Okay, Felicia, you’re on.”

Felicia bit her lip. “Catra...I want you to have it,” she insisted, straightening.

“What?” Catra blurted, eyes wide and ears straight up.

Oh, Sekhmet, Felicia swore. “You’ve given so much, lost so much – let me do this for you,” she pleaded.

Catra shook her head. “I – I don’t think that’s a good idea,:” she said, glancing at the Ember. “I mean, Freezefire is scary enough. Real fire – that’s not...”

“Share it,” Adora blurted. Both magicats looked at her in amazement. “Look, there’s already princesses sharing Runestones,” she pointed out, gesturing at where Angella and Glimmer were standing. “But this way, you’ll both have connections to Halfmoon’s and this one.”

“Adora,” Catra purred, “you total not-dummy.” Felicia grinned as well, and waved for Catra to join her at the Spirit Ember. Together, they placed their hands on the Runestone. Their power rushed out through the land, the might of their fellow princesses following. Cheers from the soldiers outside, Bubasti in particular, were proof enough, but Felicia didn’t need it. She could *feel* the kingdom being reborn beneath them.

Catra gasped. “So that’s what it’s like,” she whispered. Felicia’s smile grew. *The Horde took their shot, and we beat them,* she thought. *Now it’s our turn.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Hordak leaned against the wall, watching the monitor, and waited.

Vultak helped Shadow Weaver plod towards the Black Garnet chamber while the Force Captains retreated to their bunks. All glared at the sorceress as they left the pair. “That...*miserable* monstrosity,” Shadow Weaver groaned, barely remaining upright.

“You need to take her seriously, old friend,” Vultak warned. Hordak’s eyes narrowed. *It is far too late for that,* he growled. “Our next plan must be more cautious.”

Shadow Weaver stared at him, eyeslits wide. “‘Next?’ I will be lucky if Hordak merely demotes me to Force Captain.” Hordak snorted as she continued. “I need the Garnet. I must have all my faculties when I plead my case.” She straightened, putting her hands in her sleeves. That was a nervous tic Hordak had not seen in years.

“I can handle Hordak,” Vultak scoffed. Hordak’s blood boiled, his last shreds of patience reduced to nothing in the fires of his fury. “For now, you focus on how best to slip False Face back into Brightmoon. At this stage, Double Trouble is our most valuable asset, and I don’t want the Rebellion to find–” they reached the door together, freezing when it opened. Hordak could not blame them, given that he was in the Black Garnet chamber waiting for

them. “Lord Hordak!” Vultak blurted. “My Lord, don’t do anything hasty or rash,” he continued.

Hordak snarled at the vultureman. “Hasty. Rash. You were supposed to bring the Sword here, to *me,* not traipse off to claim a broken Runestone for your own purposes!” He strode up to the duo, glaring. “Do not speak to me of rash, you scheming toad.”

Vultak cleared his throat. “If I may, Lord Hordak,” he tried again, placing a hand on Hordak’s arm.

Hordak slapped him into the wall. “You may not.”

Shadow Weaver recoiled. “My Lord,” she cowered, “the losses are not as severe as they seem.”

“No,” Hordak retorted. “They are much worse.” He grabbed Shadow Weaver’s collar. “The mistrust Double Trouble has spent months sowing is all but healed after the bonds forged in Adora’s rescue.”

“Surely that is an exaggeration–” Shadow Weaver babbled.

“I was only recently in contact with the Kamelian, sorceress,” he snarled, hoisting the witch into the air. “I assure you, it is not. The Horde has lost equipment and materiel for an entire division. Several Force Captains doubt our cause after your reckless display of sadism in the Spirit Ember sanctum. But worst of all – most *inexcusable* of all – you may as well have handed the magicats their lost *Runestone!”*

“Lord Hordak, *please,”* Shadow Weaver groveled, “I can still be of use!”

“Use? To whom, Shadow Weaver?” Hordak tossed her aside, where she landed with a grunt and the shattering of delicate glass. She moved as if to wipe something from the floor. “The Horde, or the Rebellion?” He snapped his fingers, and four guards strode in. “I warned you, witch. Failure is when something ceases to serve a purpose. And you – have – failed.”

“We shall see, Hordak!” Shadow Weaver cried. The floor glowed beneath her hands, and she vanished in a burst of light.

The guards stared in shock. Vultak stood with a grunt, brushing himself off. “Huh. I thought she used it all extracting us from Candila.”

Hordak turned and glared at Vultak. “Where. Is. She,” he demanded.

Vultak swallowed. “Uh, Shadow Weaver has most likely fled to the Rebellion, my Lord.”

Hordak pondered this for several seconds. “Good,” he decided at last, striding towards his throne room.

“‘Good?’ My Lord, she has extensive knowledge of the Horde’s operations!” Vultak objected, rushing to follow. “This is a disaster!”

Hordak stopped, turning and smiling at Vultak. His fellow crewman froze, staring. “Shadow Weaver always delegated administration,” he noted, “and as I have learned in the past year, her very presence is toxic. It may be that defecting to the Rebellion might be the best way she can serve the Horde.” Hordak turned and strode off. *It is time to activate Double Trouble in earnest. I will tolerate this Rebellion no longer!*

Chapter End Notes

> I have been waiting so long to tell this story, with Catra beating Shadow Weaver in *sorcery* while Adora realizes she is not a weapon at long last. I hope everyone enjoyed it!
>
> Of course, this isn't even *the* Wham Episode. Next time on Turn Right, the heroes get a VERY unwanted guest, and learn of an existing one, in Black Holes and Revelations!

Black Holes and Revelations

Chapter Summary

> Shadow Weaver defects...but will that be a blessing or a curse for the Rebellion? And what will Double Trouble do when they are revealed?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The slight disruption in the air almost didn't wake Catra. After the near-debacle in Candila, however, her every sense was on high alert. Still keeping a hand and her tail on Adora's sleeping frame, she scanned the room, just in case it was not a gust from the window, but–

SHADOW WEAVER?

Shadow Weaver had just finished taking form in the room, one arm rising. Catra didn't waste an instant, leaping and yowling as she knocked the sorceress over. Changing to her war-cat form, she pinned Shadow Weaver to the floor, one paw just below her throat.

Adora was sitting bolt upright, dagger in hand. "Catra? Is that–"

"GUARDS!" Catra roared. Before Shadow Weaver could utter a word, Adora had become She-Ra and four of Juliet's finest were pointing those silly polearms at the sorceress. Catra padded back, flaring her mane and planting herself between Adora and Shadow Weaver.

The witch didn't get up. Indeed, she hardly moved, groaning where Catra had knocked her down. With a huff, Catra returned to her base form. "Huh. Her magic smells different."

Glimmer appeared in their room, staff in hand. “Are you guys okay – SHADOW WEAVER!” Glimm cried, pointing her now-glowing staff at the witch. “She’s...not moving?”

“I’m not sure she can,” She-Ra replied, looking grim.

Catra shrugged. “Fine. We’ll take her to a holding cell, then bring in a healer.” The guards looked at one another with oddly chagrined expressions. “What? Did I miss some protocol thing?”

“Your Highness,” Ser Marika said, glancing away, “we don’t have a holding cell.”

Catra blinked. “You’re kidding.”

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Marika wasn’t kidding.

Adora stared at the ‘spare room’ the Rebellion had converted into something like a jail. Catra huffed, folding her arms and glaring. (She’d just thrown on a shift, where Adora had pulled on her uniform, and in spite of the scare they’d had it was *very* distracting.) “This is what we’re using as a prison?” Catra asked.

“Well, technically it's the spare room, but it is more than adequate as a holding cell,” Angella replied, smiling. “We removed the cushions!” There was a pause. “Most of the cushions.”

Catra and Glimmer looked at each other, seeming as dubious as Adora felt. Then Catra looked at Micah and Castaspella. “We drew the containment spell together,” Micah explained, gesturing to his sister. “Shadow Weaver isn’t going anywhere, especially in that state.”

“What state?” Adora blurted, eyes widening.

“I could always take her in a physical fight,” Catra replied, “but Shadow Weaver was never...frail, before.” With another huff, she strode up and threw the door open.

"What – *Catra!"* Angella objected.

"The sooner we find out what she's up to, the sooner we can get back to sleep," Catra said, tail lashing. Glimmer chuckled. Bow gulped and looked at Adora, the two following the sisters.

Shadow Weaver groaned and stirred. "Where...where am I?" She tapped the cylindrical shield containing her, which hummed at her touch.

Catra hissed briefly and put her hands on her hips. "You know where you are," she snapped.

For a moment, Shadow Weaver stared at Catra. Then she chuckled. "Is...is that a chemise?" She shook her head, but to Adora's astonishment, none of Catra's anger tells showed, ears and tail remaining still. "This is what you wear to an interrogation? I knew Brightmoon had made you soft, but clearly I underestimated how far you had fallen."

Sheer *rage* howled through Adora as she took a step forward, but stopped at Catra's outstretched hand...and the smile that followed. Catra's chuckle built into a surprisingly healthy laugh. "Wow. You used to be good at this, Shadow Weaver," Catra drawled, striding towards the magic prison. "I'm not here to interrogate you." She paced around the prison, eyes locked onto Shadow Weaver in the process. "We're here to let you beg for your life."

Shadow Weaver moved to stand, hands on armrests, then...didn't, eyeslits narrowing instead. "You weaklings are not going to kill me."

Catra's smile vanished. "No," she replied, coming back around to face Shadow Weaver again. "You're dying all on your own." Adora gasped, in time with Micah and Castaspella. Shadow Weaver just grunted. "I can smell the curse on you. It's rippling off in waves. You pushed the Obtainment thing too far, and now it's eating you

alive.” Her grin returned, small, thin, and sharp. “I’m picturing some groveling, with a side of pleading.”

Micah stepped forward, drawing a complex triple-circle with as many symbols as Adora had seen in any single spell. “But...I don’t see how we help her,” he muttered, peering through the central circle. “The Spell of Obtainment is magic beyond sorcery. It’s not power any mortal was meant to claim.”

Shadow Weaver sighed, shaking her head. “I may have pushed you at too young an age, Micah, but the spell *would* have worked. Deep magic is power beyond sorcery...as She-Ra proves.” Catra hissed and stepped between Adora and Shadow Weaver. *Oh, Catra,* Adora thought, torn between gratitude and worry. “Only Adora can help me now.”

“But – I don’t know how,” Adora replied, looking at the Sword’s hilt. Its central gem, so much like the Moonstone, seemed to call to her, in spite of Light Hope’s warnings of restraint. *It didn’t start that way,* she reminded herself. “I’ve been trying to learn to heal, but nothing’s worked.”

“She thinks she can teach you,” Catra said, taking a step towards Shadow Weaver. Her claws were out, and Shadow Weaver glanced at the trauma caps with a head tilt Adora couldn’t place. “Shadow Weaver has to figure she can help you work it out. Then get her hooks back into you.”

Adora stepped forward to stand beside Catra. “That last one? Not happening, Catra.” She turned the Sword back into a bracelet and held Catra’s hand.

“And then we are meant to trust you, Shadow Weaver?” Angella scoffed, her wings spread out so bright they tinted the whole room lavender. “If Adora restores your strength, what assurance have we that you will not return to Hordak and torment more children?”

“‘Torment?’” Shadow Weaver echoed, shaking her head. “What tales has Catra–”

Glimmer appeared between Catra and Shadow Weaver in a burst of light, Micah’s old staff pointed at her. “Give me an excuse, you *witch.”*

Catra laughed and hugged Glimmer from behind with one arm. “Come on, Glimm, don’t compare innocent witches to Shadow Weaver. You’ll give them a bad name.” Somehow, Adora could tell Shadow Weaver was rolling her eyes even through the mask. “Besides, we can make sure she’s not going back.” Catra folded her arms again. “She’s gonna give us intel, something actionable, that Hordak would never forgive her for turning over.

Shadow Weaver steepled her fingers. “You still have a shapeshifter problem,” she said, sinking into the seat. “False Face was the secondary operative, living up to his name in a rather real manner.”

Catra’s eyes flew wide, tail lashing. “He was a smokescreen,” she whispered, swallowing. “The real spy’s the one who’s been turning us on each other this whole time.”

“No way,” Glimmer blurted, knuckles white on her staff. “One bad guy couldn’t do all that to us!”

“They call themselves ‘Double Trouble,’” Shadow Weaver drawled, “and they live up to their name. False Face was clever enough to capture Adora right under your noses, and he is an amateur compared to this creature. They used ‘Swen’ to hide behind Princess Flutterina, then remained in her orbit to use her as a distraction.” She shrugged. “They also had help. With Vultak’s assistance, I programmed Peekablue to psychically link Double Trouble to those they copied. Their early escape prevented us from imprinting absolute compliance, but all the Kamelian need do is whisper the code phrase, ‘Peekablue, I see you,’ to access their gifts.”

The allies stared in horror. Glimmer screamed and glowed, but Catra threw her arms around her sister. "No! No, Glimm, don't let her get to you."

"Did you hear what she *did?"* Glimmer howled.

"Yes, and she's going to help us undo it," Catra insisted. "She wants us angry and unbalanced so she can manipulate us, but she's telling the truth about defecting."

"Well," Angella whispered, her voice cold fury incarnate, "if you are right about her scheming, daughter, Shadow Weaver should be careful what she wishes for."

"'Manipulate,'" Shadow Weaver scoffed, shaking her head again. "Please. I have nowhere left to go. Vultak abandoned me. Hordak cast me aside. I want to take them down. And helping you is the best way to do it."

Adora looked at the Sword, then Catra. "Adora, I…" Catra swallowed, then straightened. "No one can tell you to do this. It has to be your decision. But, I think she's telling the truth for once. And if she can teach you to heal, maybe…" Catra shrugged. "I dunno. Maybe it'll be worth something."

"If you think we should do it," Adora agreed, "then okay." Catra gulped, nodded, and stepped aside. Micah and Castaspella brought down the shield. Glimmer and Bow circled around, weapons ready. Angella floated above them all, power gathering to hand. "Okay. This will be the last time you tell me what to do...so do it."

To Adora's surprise, Shadow Weaver merely nodded. "You are a Princess, so you have a Runestone. Yours dwells within your sword. With it, you channel the elemental magic of Etheria." Catra's tail lashed, but she said nothing, so Adora let Shadow Weaver continue. "Let it flow through the sword and into you. You must learn to concentrate. Focus your power."

"I've tried this before," Adora snapped. "I can't get it to work."

“Calm down,” Shadow Weaver ordered. “Your frustration will cause the energy you produce to become destructive if you're not careful. There must be peace in your mind if you are to heal. Come closer and allow me to help you.”

“It’s killing me to admit this,” Catra sighed, “but she’s not wrong about being at peace. Emotions affect magic, that’s what makes healing sorcery so hard.” She smiled, staying beside Adora the whole time. “But I know you can do it, Adora.”

“You are afraid, but refuse to admit it. Afraid of your power spiraling out of control,” Shadow Weaver instructed, pausing to cough. “Let yourself feel it, then move past it. You are greater than your fear.”

Adora concentrated, channeling the power from the Runestone as well as her heart. Shadow Weaver gasped, as did Micah and Aunt Casta. *It’s...amazing,* Adora realized, the love of her friends, the family she’d found, and *Catra,* always Catra, at the center of all her happiness. *This...energy, this vibration...it’s singing. Playing. It’s less joyful, and more joy itself.* With one deep breath, she let her heart sing with the magic, a hum of love, peace, and happiness. *Serenity,* Adora remembered, *Perfuma calls it serenity.*

With a gasp, Shadow Weaver stood, rolling her shoulders and twisting at the waist as though she could not believe what she felt. “I am...whole? By the Maker. In all my years, I have never been witness to such a feat of magic.”

Micah smiled. “Nor I. You are a miracle, Adora.”

Catra chuckled. “I could’ve told you that. But you were wrong about one thing, Shadow Weaver.” She smirked. “Adora is way more than a Runestone.”

To Adora’s shock – and if Catra’s ears were any indication, hers too – Shadow Weaver merely nodded. “So it would seem,” she admitted.

"We'll extract more intelligence from her later," Catra growled, tail lashing again. "We have to heal Peekablue, then find 'Rina."

"Don't be a fool," Shadow Weaver hissed, moving towards Catra. Micah and Castaspella restored the magic prison before she was halfway to the circle that conjured it. "If you deactivate Peekablue, the Kamelian will know they have been exposed."

"Which should rattle them enough to slip up," Catra snarled back, "besides which, it won't *matter* what 'Double Trouble' knows once Peekablue's Farsight is free of you." This time, it was Adora's turn to stand between Catra and Shadow Weaver. "You are so *obsessed* with the idea that kindness equals weakness, that you've become *incapable* of seeing when being kind is the same as being *smart!"*

Adora could count the times she'd been happier on one hand, when Catra's retort left a speechless Shadow Weaver to fall back into her chair. "Adora, you get Peekablue. I'll go find 'Rina before…" she snickered. "'Double Trouble' can grab her." Adora nodded. "Ask Peekie to set up a mind link with me while you're at it, okay? Just to be sure."

"Of course, Catra," Adora agreed. It was difficult, splitting up with Shadow Weaver's...presence so recent, but she chose to have faith in Catra. *No matter how bad it gets,* she reminded herself, *we'll be okay as long as we have each other.*

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"'Rina?" Catra called, trying not to panic. "'Rina, come on, stop messing around!"

She hadn't been in the sparring room, or the library, or with the Andreenid soldiers. Flutterina's scent trail was fainter than Catra would have liked, and she was running out of favorite spots to pull the mothfolk princess from.

At last, 'Rina's scent grew stronger, with that scent that Catra always associated with nerves. *Observatory,* Catra realized,

shifting to full beast-form and rushing up the stairs. The little princess was sitting in one of the windowsills, feet kicking idly as she stared towards what would soon be sunrise. "'Rina, thank Bast," Catra panted, changing back to humanoid form.

Flutterina looked over her shoulder, smile forming as she leaped back into the room. "Catra? Do you need my help?" The smile vanished as her eyes widened. "You're not mad at me about Candila, are you?"

Catra sighed. "Not mad, just worried, upset…" she chuckled, "...and maybe just a little proud. That's exactly the kind of thing I would've pulled if Shadow Weaver – well." She nudged 'Rina along as they headed back downstairs. "Look, we've got another shapeshifter, and from what we've heard, this one's way more dangerous than Falsies."

Flutterina giggled. "'Falsies.'" She slowed, eyes widening again. "Wait, is that the one who was...Swen?"

Catra sighed. "Probably. We need to get you – *everyone* – into groups of at least three. I'd prefer five. You'll be with my family, plus Bow and Aunt Casta, until we know more."

'Rina tapped fingers together, biting her lip. "Do you think maybe this other 'shifter...might not be as bad as False Face?"

"That'd be nice," Catra conceded, tail lashing as they walked slower than she liked (though the mothfolk girl was keeping up a brisk pace given her shorter stride), "but we have to catch them before we can try anything else. Our...intel source hasn't told us much yet, but everything she said screamed 'consummate professional.' We need to be careful–" A muffled thumping in the room ahead slowed Catra. "Stay behind me," the magicat whispered, and 'Rina obeyed with a hint of trembling.

With a snarl, Catra threw the door open, spell in one hand, and clawsword in the other. Something – or one – was moving behind a sofa near the back of the room. Only one light was on, leaving

most of the room in shadows. *Trap,* Catra thought, eyes narrow. "Stay back," she ordered. "If anything goes wrong, you run for help, and don't argue." Flutterina's jaw snapped shut, and she nodded with a gulp. *Here goes nothing.*

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Double Trouble watched Catra enter the room with a fascination that bordered on morbid. The magicat was on high alert, preternatural senses honed to a blademaster's edge. They couldn't remember the last time they had been this excited. *One mistake, and she could shatter me with a spell,* they thought, the frisson of thrill running through their whole frame.

Catra stalked forward, as professional as any soldier DT had ever seen. With a snarl and a leap, they leaped around to face the figure behind the sofa. The Kamelian knew they would only have an instant, given magicat reflexes. All the same, it couldn't have gone more perfectly, as Catra froze at the sight of the manacled and gagged Flutterina before her, crying out a muffled warning. *"'Rina?"* Catra blurted.

With timing born from a lifetime surviving in the Crimson Waste, Double Trouble struck, abandoning Flutterina's form. In a single fluid set of motions, they slammed the door shut, pinned Catra's arms and legs with limbs grown specifically for the purpose, threw her to the ground, and manacled her in Horde shackles intended to resist even her claws. Catra snarled and thrashed for a moment. "You flarking – that scent wasn't stress, it was you!"

DT gasped, one hand over their mouth for effect while their tail retracted from the door. Then they grinned and honored Catra with their most indulgent bow. "Oh, you've been a magnificent foe, my dear kitten," they gushed. "I'm honestly unsure if I could have fooled you all this time without poor Peekablue's unintentional assistance."

Catra glared, hissing. "I am going to claw your face off," she snarled, wriggling in her bonds.

Double Trouble sighed as theatrically as they had gasped. "Honestly, kitten," they said, turning the dial on the sound baffle to make the room wholly soundproof again, "does anyone still fall for that?"

"Unlock me," Catra growled, "and I'll show you some falling."

Double Trouble leaned over until they were almost nose-to-nose with the orphan turned princess. "You know," they whispered, "it took me a while, but I finally figured out your character." Catra raised an unimpressed eyebrow. "Oh, you think your personality is simple in spite of all your genius, but you have more depth than anyone in this castle." They stood, becoming Shadow Weaver. "You think you're the redeemed monster, Brightmoon's predator on a long leash," they explained, becoming Adora, "but what truly drives you is love and loyalty." Catra bared her teeth when they grinned. "Oh, you're genuinely dangerous, I'll grant you that," they admitted, becoming Scorpia, "a match for a mountain of muscle, claw, and stinger. You've got real bite, honest anger, oh, the layers!"

Then DT took Catra's form and crouched back down beside her. "But cut through all the defenses, the scars, the competitiveness, and you get a woman with the biggest, softest heart of all."

Catra raised an eyebrow and huffed. "Do I look like Adora to you?"

Double Trouble shook their head. "Your Adora likes her friends, but she's all about her causes and crusades. You care about people, whether it's a mighty queen with a broken heart, or a little girl desperate to be useful." They gestured at Flutterina, who curled up in terror. DT flinched.

"And what do you care about, 'Double Trouble?'" Catra asked, voice disturbingly neutral.

"Money," they said with a shrug. "Which brings me to my point. You should be yourself...while you can."

Catra's eyes went moons-wide. "What do you mean, 'while I can?'" she gasped.

"I'm going to steal the Sword," Double Trouble said, in Catra's neutral tone. "Hordak needs it for some weapon of his. Everything you've fought for will be destroyed." They placed a muzzle over Catra's mouth, briefly becoming themselves again, smiling. "I really should leave before that happens," they said with cheer, giving Catra's nose a little finger boop. "And...scene." With that, they stood, becoming Catra again, and sauntered to the door.

Glimmer and She-Ra were waiting outside. "Glimm!" DT blurted, clearing their throat to cover Catra's muffled cries. "Have you seen 'Rina? I haven't–"

The sparkly princess packed a surprising punch, knocking DT halfway back into the room. "Adora! Look for the real Catra!" Sparkles cried, teleporting in and launching an assault on the Kamelian.

While DT evaded with flowing grace, She-Ra rushed in just as Catra managed to leap to her feet. "Catra!" the blonde cried, leaping toward her fiancée. DT managed to throw Glimmer into the sofa, darting towards the door.

She-Ra tore off the manacles as though they'd been *papier-mâché.* "Don't let them escape!" Catra cried, throwing a shadow-shield up in front of the door. DT did their best reverse-body-shift turnaround, startling Sparkles, but Catra leaped almost to the ceiling and conjured another circle. DT dodged that one as well, but only just, and Sparkles punched them hard enough to stop them for a moment.

A moment was all the sisters needed, summoning a cylinder of light and shadow that even they couldn't flow through. They sighed, smiled, and bowed again. "Bra-*va,* Catra darling," they admitted while Catra freed the mothfolk child. "Masterful performance. I truly believed you didn't know it was me."

Catra stood, their glare less angry than DT had expected. "I didn't," she admitted. Double Trouble raised an eyebrow. "But I knew you had to be as good as they come to turn people like my friends on each other. So I developed a contingency plan that even you couldn't work around." She smirked as Peekablue walked in, her tearful fury almost enough for DT to feel bad for her. "She contacted me just before I entered the room. No matter who you were, thanks to Peekablue and Glimmer, my backup was only a thought away."

"Magnificent," DT gushed. "And now?"

"Now," Catra whispered, holding a sobbing Flutterina close, "you and Shadow Weaver are going to tell us what Hordak is up to."

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"Hordak has been working for years to build a machine capable of opening a portal between dimensions," Shadow Weaver explained. "He intends to bring the true Horde's armies through this portal and use them to conquer Etheria, once and for all."

Catra stared at her anti-mother, but she didn't feel too bad, considering the others did as well. DT was the sole exception, examining their nails in the nearby force-prison. "Th-that's insane!" Catra blurted. "You all saw what happened in Void-Catra's timeline. No one can open a portal, it'll destroy the world! Maybe this whole universe!"

Shadow Weaver made an odd grumbling sound. "While I agree with you in this one instance, Hordak has been studying the problem since we summoned your counterpart. He believes, not entirely without cause, that between the new information acquired from your 'dimensional dysfunction' and that gained through contact with Entrapta as 'Scrambler,' he can overcome the obstacles."

"And call in the real Horde," Catra whispered.

Double Trouble was no longer looking at their nails. “Sounds bad, kitten,” they said, displaying no tells Catra could divine. “If the bat-man’s wrong, he blows us all up. If he’s right, he wins.”

“In, like, an hour,” Glimmer muttered, glancing at Catra.

DT looked the gathered princesses over. “You don’t seem terribly surprised,” they noted, smile returning with glacial speed.

“We have some data,” Catra admitted, pacing. “ET? Do we have enough?”

While Scorpia rubbed nervous claws together, Entrapta ran numbers on her pad. “No,” she admitted, “but Hordak currently has a low likelihood of success. I would estimate somewhere in the five to ten percent range.”

“Look, guys, he can’t do anything without the Sword,” Adora reminded them, holding up her left arm, with the Sword wrapped around it as a bracer. “And now that I can, y’know, make swords out of light, I can just leave it like this!”

“Unless he captures you again,” Frosta reminded her. Adora winced. “We can’t let Hordak get away with this!”

Catra looked Double Trouble over again. *We need an edge.* She padded over to the shapeshifter’s prison looking them over. “You work for the highest bidder? That’s it?”

DT grinned. “You want to hire me, darling?”

“That would be spectacularly unwise,” Shadow Weaver huffed.

Glimmer pointed her staff at the sorceress, head crackling. “Keep your creepy opinions to yourself, Shadow Weaver,” the princess snarled.

“She’s not *completely* wrong, though,” Catra muttered. “We’d have to turn them.” Peekablue and Sweet Bee gaped at her, and Shadow Weaver facepalmed (mask-palmed?). DT laughed. “I need

a minute alone with the prisoner." Before anyone could object, she gripped the forcefield cylinder with her magic and dragged it across the room, DT lounging on the couch in the process. Then she created a force wall to grant them privacy. *Okay. Time to find out if I can really be as good as everyone thinks I am.* Slowly, she began pacing around DT's prison. "You know," she said, "it took me a while, but I finally figured out your character."

Double Trouble stared for an instant, head turning to follow Catra. Then they laughed. "Oh, do *tell,* darling," they said.

Catra stopped, meeting their eyes. "You don't have one," she noted. They blinked in both directions. "Oh," she continued, resuming her pacing, "you borrow characters all the time, *darling.* You steal them. You *use* them. But you don't have one of your own."

They paused, double-blinking again, then laughed once more. "It's called acting, kitten. That is my character."

"No," Catra replied. "That's a job. Oh sure," she continued, cutting off their effort to interrupt, "it takes art and style and blah blah blah, but what about the rest of your life? Oh wait, you don't have one!"

DT froze. "You don't know that," they gasped.

Catra chuckled. "You caught feelings for the kid you were manipulating. You kept Peekablue out of the loop as much as the job let you. You complimented *me,* instead of leveraging my self-worth issues. Someone as good at this as you are letting all that happen? That's not someone with a life. That's someone desperate to have one and terrified to admit it. Trust me, I've been there."

DT scoffed, the façade cracking at last. "And who's going to trust me, Catra? Even in this ridiculous place filled with idealistic princesses and stupidly-noble warriors, *no one* will give the shape-changing actor-spy a chance."

"No one ever has, have they?" Catra asked, pushing down as much of the sympathy as she could. *Stars, that sounds familiar.* She sighed. "Look, I could invoke psychic Peekablue powers, but I'm not going to. I'll trust you." DT's jaw dropped. "You're a professional. As an actor and a mercenary, give me your word that you're on our side."

"You...can't mean that," DT whispered.

Catra shrugged. "Why not? You say no one's ever trusted you, but obviously you got hired often enough to become the best, which means when you make a deal, you keep it." She stopped in front of DT, meeting their eyes again. "Besides, I've been where you are, in more ways than one. All I wanted was a chance. I'm willing to bet on giving you one." She smirked. "Not to mention, you've got style. I'd really like to get to know the person you can be if you give yourself a chance." She lifted the force wall, praying she hadn't just put a knife at the Rebellion's throat. "Think about it."

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"What did you say to them?" Glimmer blurted.

Every time Adora thought she couldn't possibly be more proud of Catra, the love of her life proved otherwise. *Two days. It took her two days to get this super-shapeshifting-spy on our side!* Catra grinned. "I appealed to their professionalism. Maybe said a few things I wish someone had said to me when I was in the Horde."

"But now I have a conscience," DT complained, arching backwards and pressing the back of their hand to their forehead. "I *hate* it." Flutterina grinned and held their hand.

Catra laughed outright, and Adora's heart soared. "You'll get used to it. It's not even that bad. Eventually." DT stuck their tongue out at Catra, to more laughter from the princesses.

It didn't last, though, Catra's smile vanishing as she looked over the war map again. She zoomed in on Vultak's Menagerie Tower. "This is the key," she hissed, glaring at the keep. "Especially now

that we have magicat forces in Candila backing Huntara's push to retake the Crimson Waste, we've got a real chance to hit the Fright Zone from both sides."

"I'm sorry, Wildcat," DT admitted, "but there's not much spying can help with Vultak's creepy collared creature collection."

Peekablue nodded after a brief glare at DT, relenting when the shapeshifter wilted in their gaze. "Now that I'm truly free of their indoctrination, I can provide guidance in truth – and my telekinetic powers are finally restored – but this has always been the key to Vultak's strength. He can afford to focus entirely on offense while the seat of his power remains invincible."

"No fortress is invincible," Catra growled. "It has to have a weakness, some way to get the collars off the prisoners, something."

"Oh, I could get the collars off," Entrapta explained. "The technical end should be relatively simple. The problem is the indoctrination Peekablue described. Most of the Menagerie's captives are non-sentient. They cannot resist the way Princess Peekablue did." The azure princess blushed at the compliment, Sweet Bee holding her close.

Catra shook her head, the brief chuckle humorless. "Man, what I wouldn't give for a princess who can make nice with animals, the way, like, half the fantasy books in the library say."

Adora's jaw dropped while Glimmer and Bow looked at each other in shock. "Uh, Catra?" Adora asked, raising her hand.

Catra turned a wide-eyed gaze on Adora, most of the others staring at her as well. "You're kidding."

"I haven't thought about it in – in years," Adora admitted, "but literally the first princess-y thing I did was calming down a giant beetle."

Glimmer laughed. “Back when she thought being a princess was *contagious.”*

“Could – do you think you can calm them all?” Catra asked, looking vulnerable. It made Adora’s heart ache. “Or at least most of them?”

Adora’s entire soul cried out to tell Catra *yes, yes, anything for you, yes,* but the soldier in her insisted on a rational assessment. Numbers. Volume. Power. Range. She went over their intelligence, won through poor Peekablue’s long captivity.

And then she realized that she could give Catra the answer she wanted. “With the way my power’s grown since you joined us?” Adora said, smiling. “Absolutely.”

Catra turned back to the map, staring at the tower. Her smile came out slowly, but with a light to rival the daymoon. Felicia was all but vibrating in her seat from excitement. Perfuma had her hands clasped, like that praying thing. Even Mermista’s eyes burned with triumphant light. Catra herself seemed to glow with this sense of...rightness, satisfaction, maybe even joy. “I...I know how to win the war,” she whispered. “We can really end this thing. I *finally* know what to do.” She turned that smile toward Adora. “And we’re both going to do what we’ve always wanted. Save everyone we love.”

Every time I think I can’t possibly *be more proud of Catra...*

Chapter End Notes

I have been looking forward to this chapter for so long. SO LONG. Yeah, getting to have everyone go "nope, Shadow Weaver, you don't get to hurt these two again" was good, but my Double Trouble plans *finally* come to fruition, and I've wanted to write that "I know how to win the war" line for over a year!

Next time: At long, LONG last, Vultak (starts to) get what's coming to him.

Menagerie

Chapter Summary

> Catra shows off her strategic prowess. She-Ra talks to animals. Vultak gets the first installment of what's coming to him. The tide turns. Trigger warning: panic attack. Everything else is all comfort and no hurt. :-)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra looked over the war map one last time, just her and Adora. Vultak had almost certainly added security measures since Peekablue's escape, and it was already ten stories of captivity, terror, and death before that. A few swipes of her claws moved platoons from one area to another, switching princesses around. With a sigh, the magicat restored the most recent save state, summoning the original plan back into place.

"Try to relax, kit," Adora assured her, rubbing circles in Catra's back. For the first time since Salineas, Catra didn't fight back the purr. "It's an amazing plan. It'll work."

It better, Catra worried, *Or Hordak's going to get all his momentum back.* She didn't say that, of course. "Yeah," she replied instead. "Hey, let's check on the others," Catra added, nudging Adora with her tail. Adora chuckled and followed. "Don't start," the magicat huffed, rolling her eyes. "I'm just trying to be a responsible leader or whatever."

"What? I, I didn't say anything," Adora chuckled, flashing that stupid (hot) smirk as she followed.

Catra groaned and paced through Brightmoon's halls, by then almost used to knights coming to attention as she passed. (No amount of assurance had gotten them to stop. Catra hated how much she liked it.) It wasn't long before they reached the room

Peekablue and Sweet Bee shared. “Come in,” Blue said, almost scaring Catra out of her fur. “Sorry!” Peekablue added, sounding chagrined.

Catra opened the door, swallowing a huff. Peekablue, Sweet Bee, Netossa, and Spinnerella almost looked like they were having a sleepover, with blankets and pillows strewn across the floor. Only the portable battle map in the middle ruined it, a small copy of Catra’s plan glowing the lavender-pink the war room map used to be. “Hey,” Catra said, trying to sound casual. “Just checking in with everybody before the big day tomorrow.” She grinned and put one hand on her hip. “Is there any point in telling you to relax?”

Sweet Bee rolled her eyes, but even not knowing Andreenid tells, between the twitching antennae and fingertips tapping the floor Catra could see that the hornet princess was worried sick. “Not really. Peekablue isn’t going to change her mind, either.” Catra tried to conceal her own worry, but her tail lashed behind her before she could stop it. Adora rubbed more circled in her back. “I tried.”

“I know you’re all worried about me,” Peekablue admitted, “and I am so grateful for that, but I have to do this.” She chuckled. “Besides, it’s me or Angella, and it’s *not* going to be Angie.” The older princesses all gave Blue glares that were somehow understanding. “I’ve been – *cowering* here–”

“You haven’t been cowering, Peekie!” Spinny gasped. Netossa huffed and crossed her arms, her glare turning more fierce.

Peekablue sighed and shrugged, melting into a hug from Sweet Bee. “If this works, and it probably will, the war will be near its end.” The azure princess clung to her fiancée, at least accepting comfort. Catra swallowed her worry. “I have to know. I have to know they haven’t broken me.”

“Well, they haven’t,” Catra insisted. “If they had, I would’ve said no, and you’d be staying here. Besides, take it from someone

who's been broken. You can heal from it." Peekablue turned a look so grateful on Catra, it made her almost not regret sending Peekablue in as Double Trouble's 'captive.'

Almost.

Sweet Bee cleared her throat. "Well, with that settled, I wondered if you knew how you wanted to distribute our realms' forces once we have freed them," she half-asked, gesturing to Peekablue and herself.

"Defense, probably," Catra replied, shrugging. "It really depends on how many of them are still combat-ready. Vultak's...a monster." The magicat shook her head, biting back a hiss. "At least we know they're still alive. But defense is okay. If we can clear the Meadowlands, that'll let Frosta move in from the north and Halfmoon advance from the west, while we help Huntara get the Crimson Waste under control. Ish."

Netossa chuckled at that. "Yeah, hon, I think 'ish' is about as close to 'under control' as the Waste is ever going to get."

Catra laughed, fist-bumping the net princess. "Good thing, too. Can you imagine how boring Etheria would get after we beat the Horde, otherwise?"

They all laughed at that, even Adora. Maybe especially Adora. "Get out of here, Wildcat," Netossa warned, "before you conquer the Waste by accident."

Adora snorted a chuckle, making Catra's heart leap. "Trust me," she said, "if Catra takes over the Crimson Waste, it won't be by accident."

Void-Catra's memories eroded Catra's good mood. "Anyway, have fun with your battle plan sleepover," she quipped to hide her worry. "I need to check on the others."

Just as they turned to leave, Peekablue leaped to her feet. "Catra wait," she blurted, reaching out for the magicat's hand. Catra

accepted the offer. "I know, that you're worried about me," the blue princess said, "and that you don't feel like you really rescued me, but you were part of it. And I am so grateful, in so many ways."

Catra took a deep breath, let it go. "It's okay, Blue. I get it. Shadow Weaver's in a cell, and I've beaten her a bunch of times. Vultak's...still out there." She pointedly did *not* mention the evil buzzard's psychic coercion. "We've got a plan, and it'll work. You're gonna be okay." Peekablue nodded, and Adora guided Catra out, the quartet going back to their warrior-sleepover.

"Man, the castle's quiet…" Catra sighed, once again taking point. Her ears twitched, searching for hints–

–like Felicia and Flutterina laughing together. Catra relaxed a fraction and followed the sound to a balcony, where the two princesses were still chuckling, Uncle Percival and Double Trouble grinning at them. "Hey, Felicia," Catra said, walking into the guest room, only to get half-tackled by the two younger princesses. "What did I miss?"

"Oh, I was making fun of you two," Double Trouble said, pointing at Catra and Adora with their tail. Felicia and Flutterina blushed while DT turned into Catra. "I still have *so much* to atone for!" Catra's ears shot up, tail sticking out, while Adora shook her head and smirked. Then DT changed into Adora, and the real thing's smirk vanished. "No, I was far worse! I'm a terrible girlfriend!" They became Catra again. "You fought off the whole Horde by yourself, and I...wore *kitten heels!"*

Catra yowled. "That's not a thing!"

Felicia spluttered out a laugh. "Um, actually..."

Adora gulped when DT turned into her again. "Your genius saved us all, and look at this hair poof!" The real Adora's eyes bulged when her copy's 'do doubled in size. DT turned into Catra, raised

one hand with a pointy finger and opened "her" mouth...then closed it, lowering their arm. "Fair," copy-Catra said with a shrug.

Catra and Adora locked eyes for an instant. Adora spluttered out a chuckle, clamping her hand over her mouth, but that got Catra to giggle through a clenched jaw. Two seconds later, they were both laughing so hard they were in tears, holding onto each other for balance. Felicia and 'Rina adjusted their hug to include Adora.

DT grinned, turning back into themselves. "You two take yourselves much too seriously, darlings," they pointed out, draping one arm over an amused Percival's shoulders. "Learn to relax. Read a book. Go down...stairs," they drawled.

"Ooo, ooo, was that innuendo?" Flutterina gasped, letting go of the others and looking at DT with wide eyes.

"And scene," Catra snapped, glaring at DT. They raised their hands in surrender, still grinning. 'Rina pouted. "I'm just checking on everybody one last time before getting some sleep."

Percival laughed. "Relax, Triss. We're fine, Peekabee and Spintossa are having a sleepover together, Julie and Cass are catching up, and everyone else is playing some board game of Bow's." Catra blinked and he shrugged. "Something he made up with a bunch of figurines?"

"Are they…" Catra muttered, then shrugged. "Whatever. Thanks, Uncle Percy. Night, Felicia, 'Rina." She raised an eyebrow at Double Trouble. "At least *try* to stay out of trouble, Deetee?"

DT rolled their eyes. "Where's the fun in that?" they scoffed, still smiling.

Adora chuckled again and tugged Catra out by one arm before she could lean into her fretting. "Come on, Catra, they're fine."

Catra indulged in a half-hearted grumble, but she let Adora guide her away. Then she heard Aunt Casta moan, the magicat's ears

shooting up again. She darted down the hall, skidding to a halt as she prepared to drift around the corner.

"Room, Juliet, room," Casta groaned. Someone rattled a doorknob.

Worried, Catra peered around the corner – then froze, eyes wide. Juliet had Castaspella pinned to the wall beside a door, their lips crushed against one another while the general held Casta's wrists over her head. Juliet's free hand lashed at the door, finally getting it to open. Adora's head popped around the corner over Catra's, the two ex-Horde soldiers paralyzed.

The older women parted enough for them both to speak, not to mention breathe. "Get in there, 'Your Majesty,'" Juliet whispered, smiling more than Catra had ever seen. *This doesn't look...like a...problem?* Catra wondered, fantasies about doing to Adora what the general was doing surging through her.

Casta smirked back, stumbling a little as she retreated into the room. "Yes, mistr–"

Juliet had them both inside, and the door slammed shut, before Casta could finish.

Catra looked into Adora's eyes again. The blonde's blush left her entire face tomato-red, and the magicat had rarely been so grateful for her fur. "Let's…" Catra began.

"Find the others," Adora blurted. Catra nodded, and the two moved briskly through the halls, pretending to try and forget what they'd seen.

"A hamster?!" Frosta blurted from down the hall.

Relieved (but also a little disappointed), Catra headed towards the sound. "Of course!" Sea Hawk cried. "This tank-bot is a fine engine of destruction, so why not a pilot who can make unique use of it?" Mermista indulged in her signature groan.

“Are you messing with a hamster,” Catra quipped, and the group gasped, “and no one told me?” She swung the door open.

All the remaining princesses, plus Mom, Dad, Bow, Sea Hawk, and Lonnie, were gathered around the Overwatch HQ map. They had several books open over it, and three small piles of paper in front of Scorpia, Sea Hawk, and Lonnie. “Catra!” Frosta cheered. “Adora! You’re just in time!”

Catra could *hear* Adora blink. “We are?” Adora asked.

“Oh, yes,” Perfuma agreed, smiling and holding Scorpia’s pincer. “We’re helping our new players create their characters, but you know the system best.”

“And Sea Hawk wants to play a wrecking ball,” Mermista drawled.

“I am playing a hyper-intelligent hamster!” Sea Hawk insisted, standing and posing with his foot on his chair. His grin made his mustache glint, as usual. “He merely drives a wrecking ball.” Mermista groaned again, head dropping onto the table. Most of the others laughed, Angella giggling behind one delicate hand.

“Uh, I’m a big gal named Zarya,” Scorpia explained, nudging her character sheet towards Catra. “Omnics overran her home town, but she’s learning to get over her prejudices with help from her new friend Echo.”

Lonnie grinned. “That’s me. The last creation of the woman who invented the Omnics. Since this ‘role-playing’ stuff is important–”

“Obviously!” Frosta huffed.

“–the big gal and I joined Overwatch together.” Lonnie chuckled and pointed a thumb at Sea Hawk. “Not sure about him.”

“As part of the same project that created the extraordinary Winston,” Sea Hawk explained, brushing his hair back with a dramatic flourish DT would’ve approved of, “Hammond clearly sought out his friend.”

Entrapta looked up from a chart on her data pad. “Don’t worry, the character data is all balanced,” she reported. “Though the sailor who claims he is a pirate even though he doesn’t do any pirating wanted incendiary ammunition for his hamster wheel.”

“Wrecking ball!” Sea Hawk blurted. “And I do so pirate, I raid Horde ships all the time!”

“Sinking isn’t raiding, Hawky,” Mermista replied, chuckling.

“You have to make allowances for the war, Princess Entrapta,” Micah said, his tone as patient as Angella’s smile.

Entrapta rubbed her chin with a few strands of hair. “I guess that makes sense,” she admitted.

Catra grinned, this...*joy* bubbling up inside her. Adora hugged her as smile gave way to laugh, strange and healthy and clean in a way she didn’t think she’d ever felt before. “You...guys…” she shook her head.

Cold, relentless terror shattered the joy, taking grip inside her chest. Catra pictured Brightmoon burning, her friends screaming, tanks rolling over the ruins like in Salineas–

“Catra!” Adora cried, holding her up before she could collapse. The world became a tunnel that crushed Catra’s chest and roared in her ears and she was so *scared useless weak*–

“Don’t crowd her!” Angella warned, flying to Catra’s side and taking her hand while Adora held her. “Catra, follow my voice. Breathe. Tell me five things you see. Breathe.”

“You,” Catra replied. “Adora. Glimm. Scorpia. Entrapta.” The others looked up to find Entrapta dangling from the ceiling by her hair so she could examine Catra, wringing her hands. “I...I’m sorry, I’m supposed to...”

“Hey. It’s okay,” Micah insisted. “You can tell us what’s wrong.”

"I...just...I never had…" Catra clamped her hand over her eyes, as though it could stop the tears from streaming out. "...so much...all of, of this, of *you...*if I mess this up – I was never supposed to have – I can't lose you. *I can't."*

"We love you too, Catra," Angella whispered.

The dam broke, and Catra sobbed, and they all held one another.

And somehow, it really was okay. "Thanks," Catra whispered, and the Alliance slowly pulled back. Adora helped her to a chair. "I think...I'm good." The smile returned by degrees, slow but warm, melting the fear away. "I really am." She managed to smirk at Sea Hawk. "You can have your hamster, but ET's right – no incendiaries." Sea Hawk sighed and dropped into his chair while Mermista hugged him. "So. How about one more adventure with Overwatch before we head out?" Frosta cheered while the others gathered around the table. *I can do this.* We *can do this.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Peekablue quivered in Double Trouble's grip while the elevator brought her up to the control center that had been her prison for 15 years. *I am not afraid of him. I. am. NOT.* She wriggled against her cuffs.

Method acting, bluetiful, DT encouraged her through the Farsight bond. *You're doing great.*

Fortunately, Peekablue was too scared to blush at the compliment. The glass wall displaying Vultak's many bestial captives showed the psychic princess so many miserable creatures it made her want to cry, but the worst was also the most magnificent. Bound to the central shaft was a gleaming silver dragon, mighty and elegant and indomitable and helpless. *Silver Storm has endured her captivity so much better than I...*

One golden eye slid to watch Peekablue as the elevator neared the top floor. *Peekablue, are you aware of the approaching Alliance forces?* Storm asked.

Peekablue stared. It had been years since Silver Storm had reached out to her mind. *Yes,* she replied, holding to the remnants of her courage. *Stay calm. Have faith.*

Take your own advice, love, Sweet Bee replied, half-commanding, half-pleading. Once again, Peekablue envied her Bee's strength, her courage and wisdom and determination. Charisma rolled off her like tidal waves, keeping her soldiers – a minuscule fraction of her people, the vast majority still enslaved by Vultak's collars – ready to fight for Bee no matter the odds. *You've got this.*

Peekablue gave a mental nod, and then the doors opened, her heart freezing once again. Vultak was sitting at his desk, and he had only two guards with him. That was good. He also had four 'servants' attending him: one human, one Andreenid, one of Peekablue's Gar, and one faun. All were attractive women, downcast and terrified.

Peekablue's fear burned away in her fury. "Still imagining substitutes for Angella, I see," she said before she could control her mouth.

Don't panic, Catra said, her tone more encouraging than admonishing. *He's already distracted, just keep his attention until Entrapta and Adora do their thing.*

The way Vultak turned a furious glare on Peekablue, that wasn't going to be hard. He stood in a rage, the chair skittering away behind him. The Force General strode up to Peekablue and grabbed her chin. "Have a care, *princess,"* Vultak hissed, tightening his grip. "Now that your transition is complete, you might learn to regret what you wished for."

"My friends are coming for me," Peekablue said, shuddering in Vultak's heartless grasp. She felt his cruel pleasure grow in the face of her fear. "This isn't like last time."

Vultak leaned in, snarl transforming into a smirk. "Let them come," he crooned, leaning in until his lips were just beside her ear. Peekablue wanted to shower for a week. "I haven't had an excuse to unleash my menagerie in years."

Double Trouble yanked Peekablue back, and she was so grateful she almost forgot to struggle. "You do whatever you want to the princess," DT interjected, sounding bored, "*after* I get paid."

Glare renewed, Vultak snapped his fingers, and one of the guards threw him a bag, which he then tossed to DT. They grew an extra arm to count the coins. "You're lucky to be paid in coin rather than bolts, Kamelian," Vultak snapped, "after fleeing so swiftly."

It wasn't part of the plan. It wasn't even how she'd expected to react. Somehow, though, Peekablue giggled. Vultak recoiled as the giggle became a chuckle, then a laugh, then howling outright. Everyone in the room stared, even DT. "Oh, you...sad, pathetic, little man," Peekablue gasped between laughs. "I've been scared of you for so long, but – you ambushed a *teenager,* and you still needed Shadow Weaver, Grizzlor, Styrax, and a whole *company* to capture me." She shook her head. "All this time, you've been just as pitiful as Hordak. More, honestly. *He's* not hiding behind *you."*

Bee, Angie, and – Catra, of all princesses – almost panicked. Vultak, meanwhile, choked on fury for precious seconds. "Clearly I was too kind the first time," he growled, reaching out to grab her.

DT! Catra cried, and Double Trouble undid Peekablue's cuffs. She punched Vultak in the jaw, then lashed out with a column of telekinetic force that slammed him into the wall.

DT followed up by literally throwing the coins in Vultak's face. "Sorry, hon," they smirked, "but I got a better offer." They glanced at Peekablue when the two guards advanced, stun batons out, but Peekablue slammed them into the ceiling and let them drop. Then she tore the collars off Vultak's servants and carried them to the elevator in a kinetic bubble.

With a roar of fury, Vultak threw rubble and coins off him in a burst of shadow power, darkness gathering around him. “You will pay for–” he began, but froze when the entire wall of the menagerie cracked open. Glowing collars went dark and detached themselves from his countless beasts, falling through the shaft like rain. The titanic doors swung open, revealing She-Ra standing on a glowing platform with her magnificent steed and archer friend. Her eyes blazed with golden light to rival the daymoon. Vultak laughed. “Fools! I might almost forgive your trespass for handing me She-Ra this way.” He slammed his palm on a button, and the observation window retracted. “Bring me Angella alive,” Vultak ordered his creatures. “Kill the others! Feast, my horrors!”

None moved. Their eyes shimmered with gentle light, each gazing upon She-Ra with reverence clear even among those who were truly animals. Vultak gaped in disbelief. “Wh-what are you waiting for? Attack!”

Glimmer appeared with her mother, and while no triumph would erase her trauma, Peekablue felt truly free at last. “Once, Vultak,” Angella said, her wings shielding the other Allies, “I tried to explain the power of compassion. You mocked me for a fool.” Even behind the queen, Peekablue did not need Farsight to sense her cool fury, eyes narrowing on the Force General. “Do you think this folly now?”

Vultak screeched, his cry piercing their ears with the depth of his rage. “All forces, converge on the Menagerie! The princesses are attacking! *Destroy them all!”*

Angella smiled. “Catra, Glimmer, now.”

Blessed light brought Peekablue back to Sweet Bee, both the Andreenids and Gar freed by the thousands when Entrapta released their collars. The forces of Halfmoon, the Crimson Waste, the Hive, and the Brightmoon Rebellion rose up around them, concealing spells vanishing with their advance. With a sweeping flourish, Sweet Bee pointed her sting-spear at the Menagerie. Its captives fled on wings, paws, and fins. “For Etheria!” she cried.

“For Etheria!” Peekablue, and a thousand soldiers, joined the cry, then charged.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

The instant the last creature was free of the tower, Catra, Perfuma, and Felicia cracked the Menagerie’s base with stone and vines. Mermista flowed water from the river to release the aquatic prisoners from their tanks, while Spinnerella helped fliers with weaker wings glide to freedom. Frosta, Sea Hawk, Netossa, and Micah guarded them.

Light and shadow waged brief war at the tower’s peak, Mom slamming Vultak into the sky. On cue, tanks and skiffs raced towards the tower from the south and northeast. “Units Overwatch and Meka, engage, Plan A.” Catra watched in amazement as Magicats, Andreenids, and Brightmoon forces took apart the initial assault like Entrapta with scrap to play with. “Bast. Did we rattle Vultak that badly? Overwatch, prep for wings.”

“Yes, ma’am!” Sir Tao agreed, Spinnerella carrying ‘Tossa on a net while Micah flew under his own power to join the Andreenids. Styrax and Hunga flew at them with a squadron of harpies, but the Alliance had them contained, and Huntara was leading a howling Waste swarm at the ground forces, so Catra turned her attention southward.

Angella rose from the tower just before it collapsed, 30 years of Horde dominance in the west crashing down with anticlimactic ease. With a cackle, Catra leaped over to Scorpia and Entrapta, Snaps standing guard while ET laughed. “Systems disabled with complete success! There have thus far been no explosions.”

Scorpia gulped, but Catra’s smile broadened. “Good. Time to change that.” Catra pointed south. “Think you can make some tank engines go ‘boom,’ ET?”

“I can’t wait to find out!” Entrapta cheered, leaping onto Susan.

Scorpia joined the genius, though the big gal stared as Bow flew down to land beside her. “Wait, you’re not coming?” Snaps asked.

Catra’s smile faded. “I’ve gotta be responsible, Snaps,” she sighed. “I’ll send Felicia and Perfuma to back you up. I need to stay here and make sure we don’t get hit by any–”

The huge silver dragon landed in front of Catra, the earth shaking with its power. “–surprises…” The dragon stared at her with golden eyes as wide as Scorpia’s chest. “Um...hi?”

Adora rode Swift Wind to land beside Catra like lightning. Her eyes glowed golden, as did the dragon’s.

Her name is Silver Storm, Peekablue sent as her people crashed through the second armored platoon from the northeast. *She’s on our side.*

They stared at one another a few seconds more, Catra at once terrified and drawn to the astounding being before them. “I would bond with you, twice-chosen princess,” Silver Storm replied at last, “if you are willing.”

Catra blinked. “Um...what?”

Swift Wind let out a horsey-sigh. “You’re part She-Ra now, Catra,” Feathers explained. “She wants to establish a sacred bond.”

Is this really the time? Catra wondered...but also, she felt kinship with Silver Storm already forming. Trapped by the Horde for so long, tormented and enraged, but wanting to be better...Catra reached out before she could stop herself, hand pressing against the dragon’s strangely graceful snout.

Sorcery had given Catra hints about the ‘sacred bond’ Adora shared with Feathers, but they hadn’t prepared Catra for the...wholeness, acceptance, *devotion* that sprang to life between them. It was more than gratitude, Stormy knowing that Catra had worked herself to exhaustion planning the Menagerie breakout, but also a hunger to belong somewhere.

To not be alone any more.

Silver Storm shrank to Swift Wind's size, gleaming scales reshaping themselves along her back to form a crude saddle. *Jump on,* Stormy offered, and Catra couldn't have resisted if she wanted to.

Together, Adora and Catra took to the skies, blasting right through Vultak's aerial forces. "Woo-hoo!" Catra cheered, thrusting her arms skyward.

Hunga's right-hand harpy – *right, her name is Gayda,* Catra remembered – circled, but Hunga glared and made a fist, and Gayda's horns glowed with heat. "None of your scheming, 'sister' mine!" Hunga yowled. "Attack!"

Catra's cheer burned away with it. "Set take you," she snarled, summoning her own magic. *Stormy, I need Hunga busy for a minute.*

Gladly! Stormy roared and dove at Princess Hunga, who screeched and fled.

Catra spread her own wings and flew at Gayda, the big harpy tackling her. *Not as strong as Scorpia, but flarking strong enough,* Catra groaned, concentrating while Adora gasped and followed them on Swift Wind. "Hang on, Gayda, I've got you," she grunted, managing an analysis circle while Gayda squeezed.

Except Gayda stopped squeezing. "Wh-what?" the harpy stammered.

"I know what it's like to be on a magic leash," Catra explained, pausing when she realized that the curse ran deep. The solution formed in an instant, and she smiled. "And I'm not putting up with that kind of crap any more." Catra formed Dad's exorcism circle with a gesture and a flicker of freezefire.

Gayda changed the instant the spell set her free. Her feet became more human-like, her down receded to a fine layer, and her wings

– her wings became *light,* like Mom's. She let Catra go, who hovered while the newly-freed angel stared at her now-clean hands. "You – you saved me?" Tears trickled down the warrior-woman's cheeks.

"It's what she does," Adora gushed, and Catra felt like she could've fought the whole Horde single-handed in that moment.

Where Gayda had screeched and howled before, this time she *sang,* and almost half of Hunga's harpies become the Rebellion's *angels.* Mom froze in mid-air, staring in shock, an instant before the angels turned on the remaining harpies and vulture-folk.

In terms of raw power, Gayda's liberation didn't change the distribution of forces much, but seeing a third of their aerial allies change into dozens of Angellas broke the Horde's morale. The already one-sided battle became an utter rout, Horde forces fleeing as fast as they could. Vultak wailed as he rushed to escape, gasping, "Wait for me!" even as he shot past his own troops.

Catra landed, Adora and Feathers close behind. Silver Storm circled lazily down, shrinking until she was the size of a small housecat, then perching on the magicat's shoulders. Adora's awed gaze was molten ecstasy in Catra's heart, the two of them standing in the heart of a cheering Alliance. Thousands – *tens* of thousands – of Andreenids and Gar were sobbing with joy and relief, Rebellion forces tending to them with kind attention. Impromptu celebrations were breaking out all around them, princesses at the heart of singing, dancing people of every species on Etheria. Only Catra's enhanced senses let her perceive this, Adora the heart of her universe.

Honestly, there was only one thing to say. Catra smirked. "Hey, Adora."

Adora kissed the smirk right off her face.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Hordak stared at the war globe, despair trying to settle in his veins, his bones.

Vultak knelt behind him, trembling in terror. The debrief had been as humiliating as it was obvious. *The work of half a lifetime, undone in minutes,* Hordak thought, staring at the flow of data. The trickle of desertions was becoming a flood. Societies ranging from baronies to villages were throwing off Horde dominion all across Etheria.

This had never happened to the Horde, of course, but the histories of a million worlds told the story. Regimes could last for centuries yet fall in days. Momentum was against them. It was only a matter of time. And the humiliating truth was, Hordak didn't have enough strength left to start from ruins again, even if he survived.

There was no path to conventional victory for the Horde. The war, as Etheria knew it, was lost.

"M-my lord?" Vultak swallowed.

"Do you remember Mantenna, Vultak?" Hordak whispered, caressing one section of the globe with his thumb. "He was not quite as brilliant as the magicat, but he would display occasional bouts of inspiration not consistent with Horde teachings. Yet they worked far more often than not." Hordak placed his hand on the power switch while Vultak stared. "I never understood why he liked to 'roll the dice,' as he put it, but we are out of options."

Hordak pressed the switch, and Etheria vanished into darkness. *Time to roll the dice.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

The celebration went on for three days, even after they returned to Brightmoon.

I cannot believe I so enjoyed fighting Vultak, Angella thought, holding Micah's hand as the children cheered around the

Overwatch game map. Their combined effort had brought down Catra's 'Null Sector,' a particularly enthusiastic Frosta describing her character playing in the snow created by the destruction of Null Sector's super-machine.

Micah looked at her, and the thought of so many undeserved miracles almost moved Angella to tears. *Gayda a cousin again at last. My husband by my side, and the children...* She shook her head as Glimmer played out introducing 'Mei' to the new characters. Percival laughed. "'Ice' to meet you!" he boomed, Adora letting out a suitable daughter-like groan at his antics on her character's behalf.

Catra's smirk melted into the most gentle smile Angella had ever seen in her adopted daughter, looking over her friends with joy she no longer hid behind the shell that accursed Shadow Weaver had forged around Catra's heart. *She's not likely to have a panic attack this time,* Angella thought in relief, while Silver Storm snored gently atop Catra's shoulder. "The Sûreté officers walk back over. It looks like the guards have clean-up under control." That got the heroes' attention. "Bow, Winston finds that old picture in the rubble. It's singed, but all the figures are there." Somehow, her daughter's smile grew gentler still.

A lump formed in Angella's throat. For just a moment, she thought she saw Ivy, Crystal, and Mercia behind their daughters, smiling and at peace. The First Alliance sprang unbidden to mind, arguments and laughter and courage and loss. *We fell,* Angella thought, *but we did not fail, my dear friends.* Her gaze fell briefly on Entrapta, watching with rapt attention. *Imperfection, it seems, truly is beautiful.* The images of her lost friends vanished as Catra continued. "The human guard takes a step toward you as Winston rejoins the team. 'Monsieur,' she asks, a little tentative, but a lot hopeful, 'does this mean, Overwatch is back?'"

Bow grinned. "Winston looks at his friends, and his smile just keeps growing," the boy said, his own expression reflecting his characters.

“We smile back, right, guys?” Adora asked.

A chorus of “Yeah!”s and “Of course!”s spilled out from the princesses, except for one “Duh” from Mermista.

Bow nodded. “Winston turns, giving the guardswoman an encouraging smile. ‘Heh. *Yes.* Yes, we are!'”

The table became absolute pandemonium, the princesses and their friends cheering far more than triumph in a tabletop game. Catra wiped a single tear aside, then yelped as Adora pulled her into the mass, rolling hug. “We...we really are going to win in the end,” Catra whispered.

Angella hugged Micah, overwhelmed by happiness she had thought she would never feel again. *Yes,* she thought, smiling at the echo of Bow’s words, *yes we are.*

Chapter End Notes

The story isn’t over yet, but for today, everything is good and nothing hurts. :-D

“Gar” are blue-skinned Eternians from He-Man/MOTU. It made sense to me, considering the powers I gave Peekablue, that she would most likely be a Gar, so I made her kingdom primarily Gar who turned against the Dread Empire in days of old.

That last session of Overwatch is based on the Overwatch 2 cinematic trailer. It's awesome -- like the Avengers film in 8 minutes.

And yes, Melog will make an appearance in Season 5, but they’ll bond with someone else.

Into the Catraverse: Opposite Day

Chapter Summary

> It's the Cat-Ra setting crossover! What will our Turn Right heroes do when they find a timeline where Catra's the hero and Adora's the 'villain'?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora found that reaching new levels of happiness had almost become routine. Like, the *best* routine, but still. Catra's triumph at the Menagerie had pulled a cornerstone from the Horde, and the whole thing was just collapsing. Soon, when Adora went to sleep feeling that soft, divine fur against her body, it could last as long as they wanted...

Huh. Catra's not here. Bathroom? Adora wondered.

Glimmer screamed, and someone punched Adora in the face.

"Huh? WHAH?!" Adora yelped, turning her bracer back into the Sword. "For the honor of Grayskull!" She leaped to her feet, looking for Catra.

Bow and Glimmer, oddly, were freaking out, hugging each other. "She kept the She-Ra thing?" Glimmer cried. "Catra, do something!"

"Catra?" Adora asked. That's when Adora found Catra...who had gone full-She-Ra, her costume mimicking Adora's, except the top was red with a white lining for her half-skirt, while the leggings were blue. And holy Stars, it left Adora's mouth dry to see the magicat built like a buff goddess (instead of her usual lithe goddess look). "Oh. Oh, wow. That's...I mean, you look, you look good," she continued, managing a wavering smirk. "Finally

embracing your inner She-Ra?" Then her smile vanished, rubbing her bruised cheek. "Hey. Ow. Who hit me?"

"Um, maybe *me,* Horde Scum?" Glimmer snapped, teleporting in front of Catra, fists raised as she glared at – Adora?

"Wait wait wait, what?" Adora babbled, looking around. *What's going on?* she wondered, her half-awake brain still trying to make sense of her surroundings. The sketchbook – which had to be Catra's – managed to reboot Adora's thought processes. "Oh. *Oh!* This isn't – I'm not – Bow, could you explain alternate timelines to them, please?"

Catra's expression turned thoughtful. "The portal fragments," she muttered.

Adora's eyes went wide. "The – portal? You had a portal?" Catra nodded. *Queen Angella,* Adora thought, heart pounding. "Okay. Okay, okay...we need Entrapta, and my Catra…" she looked at a still-ferocious Glimmer, feeling her heart crack down the middle. "We'll save your mom, Glimmer."

Glimmer shuddered. "My mom's fine, Horde Scum," she huffed, glaring at Catra. "Someone decided to *literally* tear herself in half instead!"

Catra huffed right back. "You're welcome, Sparkles," she snarked, arms crossed.

"The portal…" Bow said, biting his lip. "...guys, alternate timeline theory states that major decisions – or even minor ones, if they have major repercussions – can create different branches, each possibility existing on a different – time frequency, I guess?"

Catra nodded. "Thanks, Best Boy," she smirked. Bow blushed.

Adora nodded. "Something like that. My Catra, she's kind of vulnerable to that stuff because of a thing that happened in the Crystal Castle. It let me apologize to her and get her to join the Rebellion, but because of that, we keep ending up in these…" she

trailed off, smile growing as she looked at Cat-Ra again. "…'fragments' where she stayed in the Horde. But not here!" Adora laughed, almost cheering, while the Cat Friends Squad looked at her like she'd turned into Razz. "Here, you're She-Ra, and let me guess. I stayed in the Horde like an idiot, right?"

"Close enough, She-Dora," Glimmer quipped. Adora laughed again.

After several seconds of staring at Adora, Catra groaned, indulging in a double-facepalm. "Only you would be happy about something like that, Adora."

Adora shrugged. "The last three worlds we've been to, Catra was the bad guy, and she was *really* good at it." Her smile vanished. "And that's not even counting the portal Catra – Void-Catra – Shadow Weaver used to possess my…" Adora made a fist, while Catra's eyes went wide. "Doesn't matter. Maybe now she'll finally see how *good* she is!"

"Good luck, She-Dora," Glimmer sighed, glaring at Cat-Ra. "We've been trying to convince ours that she's a hero, and a friend, and *loved,* for *four years,* and it still hasn't stuck."

Catra stared at them all, eyes wide and shining. Then she flinched, hissing and stumbling back. Her Cat-Ra form wavered like heat rising from the Waste, and then it *shattered,* leaving Catra in her normal form – except she looked like Void-Catra! "Catra!" they all cried, as the Alliance's greatest hero collapsed, curling into a ball.

"Okay...I'll admit," Catra admitted with a hiss, "this isn't good."

"I'll heal you," Adora promised, concentrating on the Sword, "and then we'll get you to the infirmary."

"Wait, we can heal?" Catra blurted.

Bow nodded, expression grim. "Hey, good Adora?" he asked. Adora spared him as much of a glance as she dared while she

concentrated. “If you’re here because your Catra keeps falling into different timelines, where *is* your Catra?”

Adora gasped, the healing magic vanishing. “Oh no.”

-SR- -SR- -SR-

The bed had finally gotten lumpy – Catra blamed Adora’s sleep-fighting – but Adora was the best mattress, so she didn’t really care. *Smells are weird, though.* It didn’t matter, not while she was snuggled up to Adora, who pressed into Catra as though trying to merge together.

“C–Catra?! Adora blurted, leaping out of Catra’s embrace and standing.

Catra rubbed her eyes and smirked. “Hey, Adora,” she drawled, the fog clearing from her senses.

They were in the Horde barracks, in their old bunk, the rest of their squad waking up to stare with widening eyes. For some reason, Tavor was there too, in the bunk above Lonnie’s. Catra’s smirk vanished. *Oh, Sekhmet,* Catra thought, just before Lonnie and Rogelio jumped to their feet and charged.

It wasn’t exactly *easy* to defeat them both, but it wasn’t as hard as Catra had expected. Rogelio was the muscle and Lonnie the speed, and Catra was faster than Lonnie had ever dreamed of being. The magicat swept Lonnie’s legs fast enough to shock the cadet, then Catra threw her straight into Rogelio’s face. “You really don’t want to do this,” Catra warned, brandishing her claws.

Tavor drew a magic circle as Adora came up from behind, so Catra leaped onto her old bunk and bounded into the sorcerer. She planted her foot in Tavor’s gut, knocking him off and onto the floor with a pained grunt. Catra turned to face Adora, then put her toe-claws on Tavor’s wrist. Adora skidded to a halt. “Okay, maybe you are stupid enough to want to do this. Someone wanna tell me what’s going on?” Catra demanded.

The clapping brought the entire fight to a halt. Shadow Weaver glided in from the corridor, bringing her hands together with one final clap. "Impressive, Commander," the witch drawled. Catra leaped back, hissing. Her eyes went wide at the sight of two new slices of gemstone on Shadow Weaver's mask, one a forest green and the other pale blue. "Come now, Catra," she continued, "surely you can see that you are not...where you expected to be?"

"I'm not the only one," Catra snarled, the cadets gathering around Shadow Weaver like puppies hiding behind a – mother. *She must think I'm a Horde Catra. I'd better play along,* she guessed. "Who let *you* out of your cell?"

Shadow Weaver laughed. "I was never in one, child," she explained, "not in this timeline."

"Time what?" Adora blurted. Catra's eyes narrowed.

"Imagine time is a river," Shadow Weaver explained, creating the illusion of a thick crimson stream above them. "Most choices are merely rocks dropped into the water, vanishing beneath the inevitable flow of destiny. However," she continued, flicking one finger up and splitting the course with a blue spike, "sometimes a decision carries such weight that it changes the course of history. Imagine, if you will, a Catra who did not abandoned the Horde."

Catra gaped. "WHAT?" she blurted, not having to act this time. "I would never–" her eyes flickered to Adora for one dangerous moment. "She left *me!"* Catra improvised, feeling the familiar icy grip of guilt inside when the local Adora gasped.

Shadow Weaver nodded. "Yes," she replied, "but this is not your Adora. In my 'time stream,' Catra left after her secondary maturity test." Somehow, Catra managed to control her reaction, narrowing her eyes as her heart pounded like a cannon. *"I was trying to tell you that I needed you to be more careful," she said,* Catra remembered. *Looks like it matters after all.* Shadow Weaver steepled her fingers together, her gesture that replaced a smug grin. "Our Catra found the Sword, became She-Ra–"

Catra choked on empty air. "That's *impossible!"* she yelped.

"Yeah, definitely not our Catra," Lonnie quipped.

"You – my Catra – tried to give me the Sword," Adora explained, literally wringing her hands. "I didn't take it."

Catra clenched her fist, felt her nail caps dig into her palm, let go. "Good call," she hissed. "Come on. Obviously, you idiots haven't had anyone to do your thinking for you."

"Have a care, Catra," Shadow Weaver snapped, frost wafting from one hand as lightning writhed like tentacles – or vines – in the other. "We can give each other what we want, but do not assume that I will tolerate your insubordination."

Catra smirked at her, and it was all her. "How much ground have you lost since 'I' became She-Duh?" she asked. Adora gasped, but Shadow Weaver's eyes narrowed. "Yeah, that's what I thought. Since you don't have Entrapta, I'm going to have to improvise. I want every heat bomb Hordak's willing to spare."

They all stared, even Shadow Weaver. "Heat bombs? Why?" Adora asked.

"We're going to light up the Whispering Woods, Brightmoon, and every princess between us and the Moonstone," Catra snapped, stomping towards the armory. "I thought I hated my Adora, but she left *you?* I'm going to make Cat-Ra watch every one of her stupid princess pals *burn,* and then it'll be *her* turn!" She was careful not to smirk at the look of horror on Adora's face. *Hang on, Adora,* she thought, *I'll get you out of here. Even if I have to make you hate me to do it.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora watched the local Catra flex her void-covered arm, the magicat with a grimace and the First One in horror. *Why can't I heal her?* she worried, the healers whispering among themselves

while Micah cast magic circles over Catra, muttering something about sacrifices.

Angella watched the proceedings with as much terror as Adora herself, though Adora only noticed because Catra had pointed out the immortal's tells. *Please don't be in the Fright Zone,* Adora prayed, but nothing else seemed likely. Adora approached the queen, clearing her throat when Angella didn't notice. "Oh. Yes, child?" Angella whispered.

"Is she going to be okay?" Adora asked, jaw tight.

"You have been a tremendous help...Adora...but the damage runs deeper than mere wounds, even if it is less harmful than it appears," Angella explained, hands clasped in front. "Her trick saved us all, but Catra's willingness to risk everything on wit and nerve caught up with her at last." The queen's eyes tightened with all too familiar pain. "I almost wish she could not fight as She-Ra for now."

Adora sighed. "Because no matter how much she insists she's not a hero, Catra is probably the greatest one in Etheria."

"I heard that!" Catra snapped, leaning up. Micah gently pinned her down by her good shoulder. "Hey!"

Adora and Angella looked at each other and laughed, Angella sounding almost like pealing bells. "I am grateful for your presence, dear, but don't you have to return to your own timeline?"

Adora set her jaw, eyes glittering. "Not without *my* Catra," she insisted. Her expression softened when their Catra winced at something, Glimmer teleporting over instantly. "Maybe I should try healing her again."

"You must recover your strength first, Adora," Angella insisted right back. Her smile returned. "Catra was right about you." Adora swallowed and looked up at the queen, uncertain. "Aside from a short period after Perfuma's...captivity, Catra has defended your

counterpart without fail, certain that she is merely blind to the Horde's evil – more accurately, blinded by Shadow Weaver's cunning."

"Yeah," Adora grunted, unable to keep bitter frustration from leaking out. "A blind, stupid coward, that sounds about right."

Angella huffed, crossing her arms. *"Adora."* The blonde stood at attention, eyes wide at the queen's tone. Her sigh, and the way she held the bridge of her nose between thumb and forefinger, were painfully familiar. "Neither she nor I said any such thing. Catra might complain incessantly about our Adora's loyalty, but her skill and courage are not in question, *nor are yours."* The queen shook out her half-folded wings, taking in a long breath and letting it go. "Have faith in yourself as well as your friend."

Adora slumped, looking away. "Not the first time I've heard that. It's a...work in progress," she admitted. Her eyes widened. "I almost forgot! You rescued Micah, but Peekablue's alive – probably, different timeline – but in the other worlds, Vultak had her in the Menagerie!"

Angella *whimpered,* her own eyes wide with shock. "Stars," she half-sobbed.

With a grunt, Catra shoved Micah back. "Yeah, not sitting that one out. For the honor of Grayskull!" She hissed in pain, but managed to pull She-Ra back together.

"Stars, Catra," Micah objected, moving back as Cat-Ra leaped to her feet, "we still don't know if that's helping or hurting!"

"It's helping, mostly," Catra insisted. "I have to balance it out, but Ado-Ra–"

"I prefer She-Dora," Glimmer interjected, smirking.

"–healed me enough that I can rescue one lost princess. Let's move," Cat-Ra ordered. *That...is so hot,* Adora thought, then slapped her cheeks. *Focus!* she ordered herself, following She-Ra.

The others grumbled, worried for their friend, but joined Adora all the same.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"Move it!" Catra snapped. "Those heat bombs won't load themselves." Adora scowled while the rest of their squad obeyed, Scorpia doing her best to load bombs into the troop transport without letting them fall through her pincers. She would have been more upset about Catra not helping if she weren't hard at work putting together some weird harness, *while* going over one of Shadow Weaver's books on magic.

Adora walked over, crossed her arms, and tried to smile. Based on Catra's flat expression, Adora wasn't sure she'd succeeded. "Wow, Catra, I don't think I've ever seen you work this hard."

"I'm second in command," Catra snapped, "or did you think I just napped my way through the ranks after you–" Adora winced, and the alien Catra looked away. "Right, you stayed."

Adora's scowl melted away, and she sat beside Catra. "Hey," she said, bumping shoulders when Catra paused in building her harness-thing. "I missed you."

For a moment, a tiny smile escaped Catra's mood, but it vanished as quickly as it appeared. "You missed *your* Catra," she muttered, returning to her work. "Go load heat bombs. I have work to do."

"I could help you?" Adora blurted. Catra's head whipped around, eyes wide for an instant, then narrowed to peer at her. "I just..."

Catra sighed. "Hold this here," she ordered, pointing at the chest piece with her tail. Adora obeyed, and other-Catra started attaching the shoulder piece. "Um. Thanks. You want something else?"

Adora kept the device in place, determined not to disappoint Catra – any Catra. "My Catra left, but you didn't. Why not?"

Catra scoffed. "I thought you needed me. I was wrong, *obviously."*

"But...why didn't you leave with your...me?" Adora asked.

Catra slipped, her hex driver jumping off a bolt. "I wasn't good enough for you to leave for me," she hissed, casting a quick spell. Adora stared in horror at the scars the glowed from almost *every part* of Catra's body, except her most delicate areas. "Why should you have been good enough for me to leave for *you?"* Catra finished tightening the bolt.

Adora nodded, feeling lightheaded, stomach churning. "I'm not," she whispered. "Excuse me for a minute."

Catra froze, all her fury melting away as the blonde strode towards the transport. "Adora?" she gasped. Adora waited until she was behind the vehicle, then threw up as quietly as she could. *No. No no nonono.* She coughed as Scorpia rushed over, babbling something in concern. *Oh, Catra...*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"We've got you, Peekie!" Netossa cried, shielding most of the rescue team while the She-Ras drove off Vultak and his beasts.

Weird to think of more than one She-Ra, Catra mused, still amazed at how perfect her coordination was with an Adora she'd just met.

That's just it, though, isn't it? Catra thought, punching Styrax and a giant beetle into a wall while She-Dora blasted Vultak aside with a beam-slash from her sword. *Whatever else has changed, she's still...Adora.* Catra chuckled, stepping backwards towards the others while Micah and Glimmer worked on a teleport circle together. "Almost done!" Micah warned, looking up. "Adora, over here!"

With a frustrated snarl Catra sympathized with more than she could say, Adora leaped back, landing beside Catra. Together, father and daughter completed the spell, and the team vanished

in a whirl of rainbow light, reappearing in the field outside Brightmoon.

Glimmer pumped a fist in the air. "Woo-hoo!" she cheered, while Netossa and Spinnerella hugged a sobbing Peekablue. "You were *amazing.* It was, like, two She-Ras? Pfft, go home, evil." Catra fist-bumped Adora, while Bow took Glimmer's hand and Micah looked over the three other princesses. Angella swooped down, her expression an almost perfect mix of guilt and relief. Glimmer's joy drained away as she took in the ragged Peekablue, still holding onto her two friends. "Um, is she gonna be okay?"

Micah stood and hugged his daughter. "Someday, baby girl," he whispered. "She just needs time."

"Um, about that," Adora jumped in, rubbing the back of her neck, "now that we've rescued Princess Peekablue, my Catra's still probably in the Fright Zone?"

Peekablue stopped crying as if switched off, sitting upright. "No," she gasped. "Your Catra is with the Horde." Adora stared, gaping. "Not like that!" the princess added, waving one hand in denial. Then her eyes glowed royal blue. "Shadow Weaver...she wanted a Catra you once met, loyal to Hordak, in a harness...and...a 'super pal trio?' That can't be right."

"No, it is," Adora blurted. "Can – I'm sorry, but can you tell me if she's okay?"

Netossa glared, but Peekablue put a hand on the fierce princess' shoulder. "It's okay, 'Tossa. Please, I want – need – to help." She met Adora's gaze. "I can connect your minds, but...She-Ra," she continued, looking at Catra, "I don't know if I can keep you out."

Catra shrugged. "Then don't," She-Ra agreed. "Let's do this."

Peekablue took a deep breath and nodded–

At first, it reminded Catra of the portal, a field of grass swaying in the breeze, hanging in nothing. But that 'nothing' was a swirling

rainbow of color and chimes, vibrant light yet soothing in rhythm. The other Catra, wearing some Brightmoon livery but with a mix of something more primal, stood in the center, staring around her. "Whoa – what – where are we?" Catra-1 blurted.

(Catra got the number from context, thanks to Peekablue.)

Adora-1 rushed over and kissed Catra-1, hugging her close. "I was so worried," Adora whispered.

Catra-1 chuckled. "Hey, Adora," she whispered back.

Cat-Ra couldn't help but smile. "Love," she replied, one tear escaping down her jawline. "You're in your love." She chuckled. "Peekablue chose a place Shadow Weaver could never find you."

Catra-1 laughed. "Wow, you're sappy," she quipped as the pair released each other. Cat-Ra laughed back, waving at the *everything* around them. Catra-1's eyes widened, ears darting up. "Sh-shut up!"

Cat-Ra smirked. "What? I didn't say anything."

Catra-1 huffed. "You know what? You're Catra-A." Adora-1 looked at her in confusion. "This timeline jumped the track, so I'm not giving it a number," she explained. "The others were all in order, more or less, plus this is the world where you stayed, so 'A' for Adora, too."

"Yeah, not important right now," Cat-Ra replied, raising an eyebrow. "Your Adora wants you away from Shadow Weaver, and I don't blame her."

"Where are you, Catra?" Adora-1 asked, holding her Catra's hand.

Catra-1 smirked again. "On my way to the Whispering Woods with Adora-A, her squad, Scorpia, and about half the heat bombs in the Fright Zone." Catra-A gasped. "Hey, I had to come up with a plan that sounded good. Look, I think their Adora's ready to bail,

finally," she continued, throwing Catra-A a glare, "but I want to make sure she's committed."

Adora-1's jaw tightened. "How?"

"By being me," Catra-1 explained, smirk growing as she put one hand on her hip. "Well, Horde-me. She was already on her, like, fourth second thought, and watching me be mean has definitely shaken her."

Cat-Ra growled, taking a step towards her counterpart. Adora-1 stepped between them. "Define 'mean,'" she hissed.

"Relax," Catra-1 insisted, holding up her hands. "I'm just snapping at everyone, coming up with plans that sound horrible. I haven't hurt anyone, and those heat bombs should keep Shadow Weaver busy – even with all the extra powers – long enough for us to get the All-Dorks Squad out of the Horde."

Adora-1 sighed, but the sound was so fond it almost made Cat-Ra cry. *I really do miss her that much, don't I?* she realized. "Catra," Adora-1 complained.

Catra-1's expression turned serious in an instant. "Trust me, Adora," she pleaded. Adora nodded without hesitation. Catra-1 nodded, then turned to Cat-Ra. "Listen, Me-Ra," she quipped, "I can keep your Shadow Weaver busy with my Adora's help, if you think you can reach your Adora."

Catra-A flinched, looking away. "I...I don't know," she muttered. "I've tried so many times, but I keep messing it up."

Catra-1 slid her hand out of Adora's, then walked over to Cat-Ra. *Stars, am I really that small?* Catra-A wondered, looking down at her non-transformed counterpart. "Believe in her," Catra-1 insisted. "Believe that she's still the dork who patched you up, who promised to look out for you, who always believed in *you."*

Cat-Ra took a deep breath, then let it go. "Okay." She looked at Adora-1, her fellow She-Ra. "Come on. Let's go save us."

Adora's laugh was...*everything.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra-1 focused on being angry as she organized unloading heat bombs, checking her combat harness one last time. *One slip, and Shadow Weaver will figure it out,* she thought, risking a sideways glance at the serene witch. *If she hasn't already.* She looked over Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle. None of them looked happy with the situation, sharing familiar glances. *We learned to talk with our eyes, because the witch was always listening,* she remembered. *We just weren't as good at it as we thought.*

Scorpia walked over, whistling in what Catra assumed was an attempt at innocence. She didn't bother snapping at her. *This Scorpia never became friends with–* she thought, but then Scorpia started talking. "You know, I always kinda liked our Catra," she admitted.

Catra indulged in a glare, tail lashing. "Are you serious? What is wrong with you?"

"Nothing!" Scorpia blurted, half-jumping in place. "I, I, I just thought she was nice for, you know, a Rebel. It was always fun fighting her, too."

"That part's the only thing you said that makes sense," Catra growled, testing a grapple-whip just to be sure. Scorpia yelped. "I've never been 'nice.'" She shook her head. "Maybe the stupid Sword kills brain cells or something."

"It doesn't," Adora insisted, striding over in her own combat harness. It crackled with crimson lightning, making Catra twitch. "She's been behind most of the Rebellion's strategies."

Catra couldn't help preening just a little. "Well, duh. I'm probably smarter than any of those annoying, sparkly princesses even with half a brain." Adora chuckled, and a shiver ran down Catra's spine. *Sekhmet. What is wrong with me?* she wondered, clenching her fists. *It's so...easy, being the old me.*

“I...just…” Adora-A looked over at Shadow Weaver. The sorceress was moving the Whispering Woods out of the way, a few trees at a time, then literally freezing them in place. “...do you really like being in the Horde? I mean, you were always the one who wanted to leave.”

Catra huffed. “Looks like we never get to the top together, but I made it without you, Adora,” she pointed out, walking over to the transport. Tanks rolled into position behind it. “You can make it without me.”

Adora grabbed Catra’s hand. Scorpia gulped, but her eyes did that weird stars-thing Bow’s could sometimes. “But are you happy?”

With a snarl, Catra yanked her hand away. “Is anyone happy in the Horde, Adora?” she demanded.

Adora looked at Scorpia, and Catra sighed, ears and tail drooping...until Scorpia glanced at Shadow Weaver. “Well, I used to be, before...before,” Scorpia muttered, rubbing her pincer tips together.

“Shadow Weaver!” Cat-Ra roared, landing in her path like a thunderbolt. The local Best Friends Squad joined her, as did Perfuma and Mermista. “Still trying the same old tricks?”

“Oh, Catra,” Shadow Weaver mocked, “you never learn.” She snapped her fingers, and Catra-1 used her harness to swing over. “I think you’ll find that this situation is not one you’re prepared for.”

“That’s what you think!” Adora-1 cried, leaping at Shadow Weaver as She-Ra.

“What?!” Shadow Weaver cried, racing back on a platform of vines. “Impossible!”

Catra-1 laughed. “Oh, Shadow Weaver,” she mocked right back, “you always think you know everything, and you’re never right.” With a savage yank, she used her Earthshadow to control the

transport, driving it right at the sorceress. When Shadow Weaver swallowed it up in most of her vine-mass, Catra-1 smirked and snapped her fingers.

The explosion impressed even her.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra-A rushed toward her Adora, not daring to use her super-speed in case her She-Ra form shattered again. The rest of Adora's squad joined her, Scorpia looming behind them. "Adora," she gasped, skidding to a halt, "I know I've sucked at this, and I'm – I'm *sorry* – because I always made it about us, but it's not. I get that now. Please, the Horde is hurting people, *everyone,* and you can't want to be a part of that!"

Adora lowered her staff, pulling off her lightning vest. "You're right," she sighed, throwing the vest aside.

Lonnie gasped. "Adora, are you serious?" she cried, darting beside the blonde with arms thrown outstretched. "The Horde is our home!"

"A prison's not a home, Lonnie," Catra replied. Lonnie snarled at her, stun batons out.

Scorpia put one gentle pincer on Lonnie's shoulder. "Lonnie. Adora's right. They're...the stuff we've been doing, that Shadow Weaver's been doing, it's what they say the princesses do."

"And what have they done – what has Catra done – besides protect people?" Adora said, dropping her staff. "From us?"

Lonnie froze, looking at Kyle and Rogelio. The big guy shrugged, holstering his baton. Kyle just nodded. "Has fighting Catra like this ever felt right to you, Lonnie?" Kyle asked. Lonnie took a shuddering, angry breath. Cat-Ra just caught a glimpse of Tavor aiming a spell at Adora.

“Look out!” Catra cried, rushing between Tavor and Adora. The spell shook the fractured She-Ra magic down to her core, leaving the mighty Champion of Power shaking and frozen.

With a cry of absolute fury, Adora kicked her staff back into her hand and slammed it into Tavor’s skull. He went down with a quiet whimper.

The world flickered and wavered in Catra’s sight. “Heh. Nice one...Adora…” She-Ra vanished, and Catra-A couldn’t help taking a nap on the spot.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Etheria-1.

“So what did you do next?” Glimmer demanded, fists pumping in front of her. Flutterina was literally on the edge of her seat, eyes wider than even Catra’s could go.

“Shadow Weaver was so messed up by the explosion, Adora cut through all three of her Runestone shards, easy,” Catra explained, Adora holding onto the magicat as though she might disappear if Adora let go. “When Adora-A defected with her squad, that sent the rest of them running.”

Adora frowned. It was almost a pout. *And it’s cute, which gives me something to hold over her the next time she calls* me *cute,* Catra thought. “Their Shadow Weaver got away, though,” Adora said, foot tapping. “We were able to stop her from finding Halfmoon this time–”

“You took them to Halfmoon?” Felicia gushed. “Oh, Bast, that must have been perfect!”

“Well, yeah, except their Catra was still messed up from the portal,” Catra admitted. “Look, guys, I’ll tell you the rest later, but right now we’ve got a Fright Zone assault to plan.” She smiled down at the war map. They had retaken all of Etheria except for Horror Hall and the old Scorpioni kingdom. “Everything’s riding on

this attack. Tomorrow, if we get it right, we finally end this stupid war."

Adora took Catra's hand and smiled. "We will, Catra. You'll see."

"Etheria has not been so united since the time of the stars," Angella assured them. "For all the horrors the Horde has inflicted on us, you have all taken your suffering and transformed it into bonds of fellowship. With your courage, kindness, and devotion, all of you have made it possible for the coming age to be one of progress unlike anything Etheria has seen before."

"Like, nice speech, Your Majesty," Mermista drawled, "but can we kick Hordak in the head, first?"

"Dibs on Dreer!" Frosta cheered.

"Uh, guys? I'm excited too," Scorpia joined in, "but are we sure Catra's not going to get stream-napped again or something?"

"I thought of that!" Entrapta gushed. "King Micah helped."

Micah chuckled at that, leaning on the table with his hands clasped. "Entrapta and I added an enchantment to the First Ones crystal in Catra's armor. It should protect her from further...unwanted trips through the multiverse."

"Couldn't the multiverse buy me a drink first?" Catra quipped. Everyone laughed except Adora, who somehow pulled her closer. "Everyone, get as much rest as you can. In the morning, we march on the Fright Zone. When the daymoon goes down, so does the Horde."

The cheer was almost everything Catra had ever dreamed of. Adora in her arms was the rest.

Chapter End Notes

For the rest of Adora and Catra's excellent adventure in the Catra timeline, check out the upcoming SCOP Chapter 6:

Reunion.

And next time on Turn Right: Our heroes make their long awaited final assault on the heart of the Horde. With the full might of a united Etheria behind the Alliance, victory seems all but assured. Yet Hordak started with far less than he has now, and rose to conquer half the world. What horrors might he and his most dangerous agents have prepared for the Rebellion? Find out in our next chapter: Frightzoned!

Frightzoned

Chapter Summary

The fall of the Etherian Horde!

TW: Two minor villain deaths. No blood or gore.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra stood atop Lonnie's tank as the Alliance army completed encircling the Fright Zone. Adora brought Swift Wind down beside them. Silver Storm peered from Catra's shoulder to watch the winged horse land, then relaxed. Catra absently stroked the dragon's side with her thumb. "Hey, Adora," Catra said, looking up at the massive walls of what was once their home. "Remember when we thought we'd be doing this to Brightmoon, as Force Captains?"

Adora laughed with the hint of a snort that made Catra's heart beat faster. "Yeah. I like this better."

Catra smiled. "Me too." Her smile vanished. "Dunno why Sparkles wants me to make the big speech, though. That's usually her thing."

"It's been a while since you called our Glimmer 'Sparkles,'" Adora pointed out, still grinning.

As if summoned, Glimmer appeared on the tank beside Catra and hugged her sister. "Relax, Wildcat, you'll do great! Besides, this is *your* moment."

"It's everyone's moment!" Catra blurted, throwing her arms in the air the instant Glimmer let her go. "It's a battle, not a party!"

Bow swung over with one of his silly rope arrows. “You’ve got this, Catra,” he said, giving her one of those Bow-smiles.

Lonnie popped her head out of the tank, half-smirking at them. “Yeah, come on, this whole angst party for one isn’t you. Do the stupid princess friendship thing so we can kick Hordak in the face and go home.”

Catra smirked back. “You’re literally dating a princess, Lonnie.” Lonnie’s smile vanished as she spluttered, not quite managing a glare.

I’m stalling, Catra realized with a sigh. With that, she waved upward, and Lonnie raised the tank’s cannon as high as it would go. The magicat leaped to the barrel’s rim, then whistled. Chatter died down throughout the Alliance forces. Catra ignored her heart pounding like thunder., casting the spell to project her voice. “About a month ago, I tried to assassinate Hordak,” she began, to widespread confusion. “I convinced myself that it’s why I was here, that being the good guys’ bad guy was why I’d been saved. That it was my *destiny.”*

“That was core-scut, obviously,” Catra quipped with a smirk. That broke the tension and got them laughing. She stowed the smirk and pushed ahead. “For the longest time, I believed that violence was my destiny. *Our* destiny. This?” She gestured at the walls of the Fright Zone. “None of this is ‘destiny.’ It was a choice. A choice by Hordak’s creator to crush love and hope and peace. Our choice, to stand up to it. No, today is not our destiny. That comes tomorrow!” She punched a fist into the air. “Love? Hope? Peace? *Those* are our destiny! A destiny that was stolen from us! Today we choose to take it all back! And when the daymoon rises tomorrow, we’ll finally have everything we were supposed to before the Horde came to take it away! *FOR ETHERIA!”*

The cheer almost knocked her off the cannon. *“FOR ETHERIA!”* the Alliance roared back.

Catra slid down the barrel, then sat beside the hatch. “Lonnie?” she asked, and her rival-turned-friend drove them up to take point on the Fright Zone’s eastern gate. “Hordak!” she called, Silver Storm leaping off her shoulders to land beside the tank at Swift Wind size. “This is your last chance. Call a cease-fire, and we can discuss the terms of your surrender.”

A hologram of a helmet-wearing Vultak appeared to loom over Horror Hall, sneering down at them all. “Foolish little girl,” he hissed. “You have come all this way only to die.”

“Y’know, Lonnie, it’s only polite to knock,” Catra smirked.

The tanks in the vanguard unleashed a volley that left Catra’s ears ringing, and the great Fright Zone gates bent inward in eight different places. Vultak’s sneer vanished, his eyes gone wide. “Kill them all!” he ordered, then vanished.

Catra sighed. “Hey, Lonnie. Knock *harder.”* She leaped onto Silver Storm’s back.

This time, the volley included tanks, bots, sorcerers, archers, magicat Freezefire, and the combined princess powers of Glimmer, Perfuma, Scorpia, and Adora. The gate disintegrated in the face of the assault, as did several meters of wall to either side. With a thought, Silver Storm carried Catra skyward. “East, west, and north vanguards, move in! Main forces, approach as planned!” Catra ordered, and an entire world’s armies obeyed.

It was terrifying. It was exhilarating. It was everything Catra had yearned for...and dreaded. “Princesses, champions...attack!” she cried, holding her clawsword high.

With a roar, they obeyed, Glimmer bringing Bow in atop the wall as Adora flew through the ruined gate, firing beam-slashes with her Sword. Perfuma and Scorpia followed while Catra flew ever-higher, Silver Storm growing until she was at full size, rivaling a Horde cruiser in mass. “Advance!” Catra ordered, and the Alliance obeyed again, using their overlapping blaster fire and sorcerous

defensive screens to push in without casualties. “North squad, west squad, tech squad, report.”

“North squad here for ADVENTURE!” Sea Hawk cheered, the distant cries from Salinean and Snow forces echoing around him. “We are advancing magnificently. Frosta’s powers are combining with my darling Mermista’s to devastating effect. Netossa and Spinnerella are working their usual magic. Have at you!” There was a brief sound of power-saber clashing with steel. “I, of course, am Sea Hawk.”

Catra rolled her eyes, unable to be truly mad at Mermista’s boy toy. “Fliers?”

“None yet,” he replied, “though I expect them soon given the damage we’re doing. I’ve already set four tanks on fire!” More saber on metal action. “Five! Ha-HA!”

“Great. Don’t die. That’s an order,” Catra replied. “West squad?”

“No surprises yet,” Sweet Bee reported, sounding almost grim. “Resistance is just about as expected.”

Catra’s smile vanished. “Too easy?”

“Too easy. Worse, they’re trying to make it look like it’s not,” Sweet Bee replied. “Sure, Felicia’s a powerhouse and Huntara’s a force of nature, but we should be facing more resistance.”

“Try not to worry too much,” Catra soothed. “Some professional paranoia’s okay, but don’t let the buzzard get into your head just by losing. You’ve got Halfmoon, your Hive, half the Waste, and most of the Gar with you on top of your side’s defectors. That army could win this by itself.”

“I know, I know,” Bee sighed, while Catra flung spells below and Stormy breathed lightning at artillery emplacements. “It’s just, your uncle is cutting a swath through everything in his path, as are my rangers, but there is no sign of Hunga or her forces.”

Catra nodded. “Still no fliers, then. Tech squad?”

“Bored, bored, *bored,”* Double Trouble whined. Entrapta cackled something Catra couldn’t make out, but the red Horde-bot lights turning Brightmoon-lavender were answer enough.

“All clear for now, ma’am,” Kyle added. Rogelio hissed something. “Flutterina reports movement on your south flank.”

Catra’s smirk returned, spotting the flanking maneuver with a quick glance in . “About time Buzz tried using his brain. Tech squad, protect ET. Angel-bomb, go.”

With fierce cries, Angella and Micah came down on the ‘surprise’ attack, scattering them and leaving the exposed forces defenseless against a combined Juliet-Sunder pincer move. They’d surrendered before Catra could adjust her tracker pad for long distance. “Team Brightmoon, expect an aerial assault.”

“Oh, I was quite hoping you would say that,” Castaspella gushed, reminding Catra of Perfuma’s incongruous love of plant-punching.

“Thanks, Commander – found them,” Peekablue chimed in.

“I knew they’d try this sooner or later,” Catra muttered. “I want to thank all three of you for staying behind.” She turned her grin on the shadow atop Stormy’s wing.

Vultak’s darkness-projection squawked. “Wait, three?” he blurted.

“Hey, Buzz,” she quipped, banishing the shadow with a wave.

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Castaspella grinned as the harpy invasion crashed against Mystacor’s spellwork, windstorms and forcefields halting their advance. The harpies were carrying advanced stun batons, though, threatening to overwhelm the castle from above. Hunga herself managed to dart past the counterattacks, aiming her

feathers at the sorcerers while Brightmoon knights and ex-Horde soldiers moved to defend them.

They needn't have bothered; Gayda slammed Hunga out of the sky with a single blast of solid light. "Hello, 'sister,'" Gayda growled. "We've been expecting you." Half the angels who had followed Gayda gathered around their new princess.

Hunga screeched, taking to the sky again. A knight rushed to Castaspella's side, leaning on her knees to catch her breath. "I should never have spared you, traitor!" Hunga cried, returning to the skies.

Casta was so caught up in the spectacle outside, she didn't realize there was anything wrong in her own tower until False Face wrapped a dozen tendrils around her! "Not that it matters," he gloated, terror gripping the sorceress as much as the Kamelian himself. "This is the part where you surrender." His cruel smile grew. "Or the part where I kill your spare queen. I don't care which."

In an instant, a sapphire-blue glow pried the yelping False Face off Castaspella, freeing Mystacor's queen. Peekablue strode in, the embodiment of composure. "I apologize for the late arrival, Casta," she said, floating overhead with the Kamelian still in her grip. "Princess Hunga. It's time you left."

Hunga stared, then laughed. "Against the seer princess? What are you going to do, think at me?"

To Casta's surprise, Peekablue smiled. "Yes, actually." She threw False Face at Hunga, sending them both sprawling. "It's true that I don't have the natural bending talents of other princesses, conjuring or animating natural forces on a whim. But with my mind, I can move anything I wish, if I am strong enough." She reached out with one hand, and all the harpies' stun batons flew from their grips, forming a sphere of crackling metal beside the Farsight mistress. "And I *am* strong enough, now." Hunga screeched again, unleashing her feather-darts, but Peekablue's

eyes glowed as her hand had, and the weapons scattered. “I am a Princess of Etheria, and I will protect my home!”

”Sorcerers! Volley three!” Castaspella ordered, and together they unleashed a flare that left the harpies blinded. With that, Peekablue swung her baton-sphere like an electric wrecking ball, scattering them. “Commander Catra,” she reported, smiling, “Brightmoon is secure.”

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With a joyous laugh, Sea Hawk set his ninth tank on fire and advanced beside Mermista and young Frosta. Netossa and Spinnerella remained overhead, providing covering fire upon rare necessity, while their armies advanced. Frosta, as promised, defeated Dreer with a single burst of her ice magic.

To Sea Hawk’s surprise, stone warrior Callix was proving a more dangerous foe, albeit an honorable one. He proved quite resilient in the face of princess might, with Dylamug providing firepower from behind his implacable partner. The cyborg seemed less concerned with nobility, forcing the princesses to shield their forces and each other. As ever, of course, Mermista proved extraordinary, dragging a tidal wave up with a grunt and unleashing it with a roar. That knocked both warriors back, Callix bogged down in what had become mud.

Scurvy chose that moment to appear, attacking Mermista along with his officers, while his crew bolstered the weary Horde soldiers. Sea Hawk gasped and parried Scurvy’s thrust – aimed at Mermista’s heart! “Ugh. I had him,” Mermista objected, though she struggled to hold off Squall and the Moraturian.

Scurvy’s chuckle was cruelty incarnate. “You really didn’t, princess,” he mocked, trying to pivot around Sea Hawk. The pirate hero intercepted, dueling one-handed while minimizing his profile. “I’m gonna sheathe my sword in your heart. I’m going to do it over this idiot’s rotting corpse. And I’m going to enjoy every – flarking – second.”

“Scurvy, please don’t do this,” Sea Hawk whispered, swords singing as the captains danced with death. Callix and Dylamug kept Spin-tossa occupied while Frosta held off the remaining tanks and soldiers. “You were my friend. You could be again. Catra–”

“We were never friends, you fool!” Scurvy snarled, his dueling style growing erratic as he failed to penetrate Sea Hawk’s defense. “I tolerated you because there was money in it, and your stupidity was hilarious. But you’re not funny any more. And Catra’s with the people who exiled Squall, so she’s next.” They locked blades, and Scurvy sneered at the horrified Sea Hawk. “Y’know what? I’m not going to kill you first. I think I’ll cut off your arms, so you can watch Mermista die while–”

Something broke in Sea Hawk. He shoved Scurvy back and changed his stance to one more suited to thrusting. Mermista had driven back Scurvy’s crew, but most of them were focused on her now, not just the officers. “I won’t ask again, Admiral,” Sea Hawk warned.

Scurvy hesitated. Then he sneered again. “Look at it this way. You can’t break her heart,” he said, shifting for a lunge, “if I do it first!”

Sea Hawk thrust his saber into Scurvy’s chest first. Their hearts broke as one.

Scurvy gaped like a hooked trout, his sword falling from nerveless fingers. He stared at a passive Sea Hawk in disbelief just before he fell, eyes wide and frozen.

Squall screamed and leaped at Sea Hawk, only to be washed away by Mermista’s fantastic talent. The rest of Scurvy’s crew broke and fled, as did Dylamug when Netossa locked down Callix. His beautiful princess stared in disbelief. “Hawky...”

Seeing the field was quiet, Sea Hawk sheathed his sword and bowed. “Forgive me, Mermista, but I could not risk his success, unlikely as it seemed.”

To his amazement, Mermista hugged him. “I’m sorry,” she whispered.

“You never need apologize,” Sea Hawk replied, only twitching once, “for the decisions I make in your service.”

“I...get it,” Mermista said, “but I’m allowed to feel bad for you, okay?” Sea Hawk could only nod at that.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Felicia hammered Horde soldiers with earthen fury, careful to only wield flame against weapons and vehicles. Shadow Weaver’s younger student Tavor fired bolts of cold at her; Felicia easily parried them with Freezefire. *Now that’s just insulting,* she thought, encasing him up to his neck in stone.

“Ah, the Princess of Halfmoon,” Estra crooned, striding over on her mechanical tentacles. Felicia snarled, her efforts to control them thwarted by plastic sheaths and alloy cables. “I’ve been looking forward to this.”

“Really?” Felicia huffed, throwing two bots at the engineer with pillars of rock. “’Cause Mom never mentioned you.”

Tempus chuckled as she dodged. “Such a transparent jibe. But no, it was not on your mother’s behalf I sought you.” She plugged into the bots with two of her tentacles, returning them to Horde service, then lashed out at Felicia with spinning blades on her remaining tentacles. Felicia blocked them and dodged at the same time, yet it was still closer than the magicat liked. “No, it was Micah’s friendship that you will suffer for.”

Felicia scoffed, firing stone spikes at the mad scientist. “Bast, Ra, and Sekhmet, please tell me this isn’t some creepy love triangle thing.”

Estra looked nauseous for a moment. “Stars, no!” she objected, throwing a bot back at Felicia. *Yow! Gods, she is strong!* the princess thought as she dodged. “I sought to combine science and

magic, but Micah would not share his knowledge with me. We could have united all Etheria with such power!”

“So the short version is, you’ve always been a fascist creep,” Sweet Bee snarled, zooming overhead. “Felicia, can you take out those tanks, please?” the older princess asked, waving at the incoming armor.

“Uh, sure,” Felicia agreed, ripping and melting through tank treads with earth and flame.

Estra laughed, turning one of her blades into a blaster and shooting at Sweet Bee, who dodged. “The joke tells a joke. At least it was funny!” She plugged into one of the bots, which turned into a suit of armor for the genius. “Much like Peekablue’s efforts to keep me loyal to the Alliance. As if I could not see through her false friendship, or your false intellect.”

“The only one false was you,” Sweet Bee snarled, conjuring and unleashing a storm of needles. Estra dodged, but the needles followed her, tearing through her tentacles and forming spikes to pry at her armor.

Estra gasped. “What – how–”

“How did I get past your interference field?” Sweet Bee’s expression was colder than Freezefire. “Maybe my ‘intellect’ isn’t as false as your thought.” Estra screamed, exploding the armor around her.

The smoke obscured the battlefield for several seconds, and Felicia could hear Tempus fleeing via skiff. “Sweet Bee, she’s running!” Felicia cried.

“Good,” Sweet Bee replied, clearing the smoke with two passes from above. Estra raced away from the Fright Zone. “We can collect her later. Let’s finish up here.” With a savage howl, Bee surged forward, impaling Horde bots and tank treads with her stingers.

Sir Percival laughed, pouncing on a Minotaur Force Captain in full battle cat form. “Never underestimate Andreenid warriors,” he said.

No kidding, Felicia agreed.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

It was the first time that Adora’s laugh didn’t make Catra’s heart soar. She was throwing hands with Grizzlor, her Swords both gauntlets, and it was hard to tell which of the two was enjoying it more.

Catra wasn’t enjoying herself at all. “Octavia,” she whispered, Freezefire coursing around one hand and Earthshadow seething in the other. “Come on, it’s over.”

Octavia glared, wielding something that was more of a stun mace than baton. “What kind of coward do you think I am, to give up just because we’re losing?”

“You’re not just losing,” Catra insisted, circling the Moraturian. “You’ve lost. The only question left is what price we pay.”

“You don’t know everything,” Octavia snarled, “magicat!” Catra had only an instant of lightning and ozone surging from Octavia’s eyepatch-badge before she fired a stun bolt from it. Catra almost evaded, catching the blast on the tip of her tail. “Hordak brought us together when he had almost nothing. Now, you have no idea what he can do!”

With a grunt, Catra gathered new magic between her palms, twin circles forming at the tips of her claws. “I’ve got some tricks up my own sleeves, ‘Tavia,” she sighed, then cast the spell. An electric bolt, its natural blue a defiance of Garnet red, struck Octavia in the artificial eye. The Moraturian shrieked, shuddering once before collapsing. Catra rushed over, checking her pulse. *Just unconscious. I got it right. Thank Bast.*

An instant later, Catra caught Styrax's scent from a swirl of wind and looked up. He was taking aim at Adora with a long, ugly weapon like a staff with a baton handle underneath it. Some part of Catra's mind recognized the shape from one of Micah's novels, something called a rifle. The magicat didn't spare time for analysis until later, however, leaping between She-Ra and Styrax and blasting the weapon with frostflame. Styrax snarled and threw the weapon at Catra, who dodged – but it exploded, driving shrapnel into her left leg. *Ow.*

Shadow Storm landed in front of Catra, hissing in fury, but Glimmer beat her to Styrax, blasting him point-blank with her staff's full power. The vultureman flew through the air with a scream, one wing shattered. Glimmer teleported to Catra's side. "Sis! Say something!"

"I think you got him," Catra replied, managing a smile for an instant – until an ugly bone-snapping sound echoed to her magicat ears from where Styrax's arc had taken him. *Silver Storm, tell Juliet to not let Glimmer find out about that.* The dragon shrank back down to horse size and nodded, rubbing her right side with her cheek.

"Good," Glimmer said, eyes hard and bright as gemstones. She helped Catra onto Stormy's back just as She-Ra threw Grizzlor into the air, then drove an uppercut into his chest plate. His Runestone harness shattered as the Force Captain howled, flying seven meters into the air before coming down with a jarring thump.

Catra chuckled once. "Ouch. Harsh, Adora."

"Catra!" Adora cried, leaping to her side and healing Catra before she could stop the idiot. The shrapnel flew from her wounds as they healed, bouncing off She-Ra's super-tough skin. "Are you okay?"

"*Jitat,* Adora, you're supposed to save your strength for Hordak," Catra objected, flexing her leg. "Most of the heavies are down or gone. It's just Vultak and his Hordiness now."

Adora sighed, stroking Catra's cheek. Both women blasted incoming bots without looking away from one another. "I'll be fine, Catra."

"Then you won't mind taking the Best Friends Squad with you," Catra huffed, flexing her leg.

"Aw, look at you, being all considerate," Adora teased, indulging in that flarking hot smirk of hers. "It's almost like you like me or something."

Catra smirked back. "This is not because I like you." Her smile vanished as she caressed Adora's cheek in kind. "It's because I love you. Come back to me, Adora."

She-Ra's nod was serious enough to almost calm Catra's pounding heart. "I promise," Adora swore, then turned the Sword of Protection into a shield while the Sword of Light took its natural form. "Glimmer. Bow." Glimmer teleported over to kiss Catra on the cheek, then grabbed the others' arms, and the Best Friends Squad vanished.

Lonnie popped out of her tank, looking over as Catra turned Silver Storm towards the largest remaining knot of Horde soldiers. "They gonna be okay, Catra?" she asked.

Catra turned just long enough to smirk at her...friend. *I'm friends with Lonnie,* she mused. *It really is the end of the world.* She laughed. "They beat *us,* Lonnie. They can do anything."

Lonnie laughed back, and they led the charge into the last remnants of their childhood nightmare.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Horror Hall was empty.

Oh, there was equipment, to be sure. Bunks, clothes, gear, even some ration bar stashes scattered through the corridors as the Squad moved forward. Yet not a single person remained. There

wasn't even a bot patrolling the halls. "So!" Glimmer blurted, her smile bright and nervous. "Is this creepy, or is it just me?"

Bow peered around a corner, the same paste arrow still nocked. "Nope, not just you, Glimmer," he admitted.

"We'll be fine," Adora said, as if commanding it to be true. "As long as we stick together, we can handle anything." They reached the doors to Hordak's sanctum. With a chill, Adora realized she'd only been here in an alternate timeline. The Fright Zone's familiar hum was still there, but softer, dimmer. "Go." The trio breached the doors in, ironically, perfect Horde squad fashion, Glimmer and Bow covering Adora as she took point.

Vultak smirked down from Hordak's throne, with two squads and about a hundred bots there waiting for them. The Menagerie's former master was wearing a helmet for the first time. It looked odd to She-Ra for a moment, before she recognized the Black Garnet shard over his forehead. Then Vultak stood, and...clapped, slowly. "A picture-perfect entrance, traitor. The very embodiment of the avenging hero. So sad you've come all this way…" the lights dimmed, darkness swirling around him as crimson lightning flowed around his arms and wings. "...to *die."*

Glimmer chuckled and rolled her eyes. "Stars. So *dramatic.* Kick his butt so we can go home, okay, Adora?"

"Love to," Adora agreed, leaping at Vultak with a roar. Vultak snarled and fired lightning at her, but years of fighting Shadow Weaver made blocking it easy, especially now that She-Ra had a Sword *and* a shield.

Of course, having half the bots come after her at once slowed her down a bit.

Even She-Ra struggled to fight Vultak and, like, fifty-ish bots at once, but Adora wasn't going to let that keep her from looking out for her friends. Of course, these were *her* best friends. Glimmer was utterly demolishing her opponents, flying through them,

blasting away with her staff, and teleporting every time a soldier or bot drew a bead on her. Bow was just as devastating, moving with a grace to rival a magicat and unleashing arrows with aim that bordered on the magical itself. He stuck soldiers to bots, tangled legs in cables, slammed them into each other with carefully-aimed oil slicks, and generally made fools of them.

Vultak was the greatest challenge, even for She-Ra. Whatever he'd done with the Black Garnet did more than grant him lightning. It made him almost as strong as Grizzlor and nearly as fast as Catra, and he still flew like he'd been born in the sky. Adora managed the occasional glancing blow, but every time Vultak retaliated, even the brush of his talons pulled strength from She-Ra's skin. "You are a formidable opponent, girl, but I have been Beloved for six centuries, and you are a half-trained child."

Fortunately, She-Ra's might kept Vultak's vampiric magic from weakening Adora much, but between his genuine skill and the platoon of bots firing on her, the battle was wearing her down. *Mara, Razz...* Adora focused all her strength, drawing the Sword of Light back into her. *Catra...help me. Give me strength. We're so close. I'm so close! I have to do this. I promised!*

The Light flowed into She-Ra, filling her, burning and embracing her all at once. For a moment, she thought to ask Glimmer and Bow to pull back, but...*No. It won't hurt them. This is...it's...it'll do what I want. I can win this. I will!*

"Wh-what is this?" Vultak blurted, his darkness scattering as She-Ra's radiance expanded. Bots convulsed and collapsed at its touch. The few soldiers who could, ran. "You – you can't – it's not *possible!"*

"Watch me!" Adora shouted, the glow filling the entire sanctum. His Garnet bolts melted to nothing before they could reach her. "Your cruelty – your tyranny – your *lies* – they all end NOW!"

The glow became an explosion of Light and magic. Vultak screamed, becoming scraps of darkness as he fled.

Systems exploded with electricity throughout Hordak's sanctum. Consoles shattered, panels erupted, and conduits burst, throwing metal everywhere and plunging the room into darkness the moment Adora's daymoon-bright flare faded.

Bow held up a torch-arrow, illuminating the sanctum. Together, the three heroes looked around. All the bots were down, and the remaining soldiers were prone, either groaning or breathing softly, unconscious.

Glimmer's eyes widened, the first hints of tears forming alongside a hesitant smile. "Did...did we just...is it over?"

"I think we won," Bow breathed, as if he didn't dare believe it. Adora knew how he felt, unable to say the words herself.

"We did," Glimmer replied, saying it for them all. "We won." She scooped up Bow and Adora, wings spread wide as she carried them into the air. "WE WON!" They laughed as they landed, cheering and crying as one.

Metal screamed above them, and for a moment their cheer vanished, turning all their weapons on the ceiling. Silver Storm, at full size, had torn away the entire top of Horror Hall, peeling it away with massive talons. "Glimm! Bow! *Adora!"* Catra cried, leaping down. "Say something!"

"Hordak's a coward," Glimmer quipped, "and Vultak ran with his tail feathers between his legs."

Catra glared at all three of them for half a second, then managed to pull them all into a hug., Silver Storm chuckled and flew off to circle the Fright Zone from above, Angella soaring to join her. "You three scared me out of another life," she half-hissed.

"Hey," Adora soothed, letting She-Ra go, "hey, we're all here. Where do you need us?"

Catra looked up, too relieved to be smug. "Please," she scoffed. "It's all over but clean-up. You think I couldn't handle a few

thousand scrubs without you?”

The next bout of laughter was nervous, then more than a little manic, all four holding onto each other as much in relief as joy. “We did it,” Glimmer whispered.

After several more seconds, Bow pulled back. “I should check on Entrapta,” he noted.

Catra laughed again. “Yeah. It’d suck if we won the war just for her to blow us up with Hordak’s toys.”

Glimmer groaned. “Stars, this job’s half-babysitting. I don’t know how you do it, sis.” She grabbed Bow’s hand, and the two vanished.

Adora looked at Catra, feeling more joy than she had ever imagined. Even then, though, her beloved was still thinking, starting to pace as her tail lashed. “The war’s...not really over,” Catra muttered, “not yet. Hordak’s AWOL, Vultak bailed, and I heard a few others got away–”

Adora kissed her.

Catra’s eyes went wide, then squeezed shut, and they were in heaven.

They both emerged from the kiss breathless. A slow, beatific smile dawned across Catra’s lips. “Adora. This is the end of the Horde.”

“I know,” Adora gushed.

Catra chuckled and shook her head. “Adora. The world where everyone’s at war because of the Horde? It’s gone. That Etheria is over.”

Adora’s eyes went wide. “You and me at the end of the world.”

Catra stalked up to Adora, wrapped her arms around Adora’s waist, and purred, tail curled over her wrist. “You and me at the

end of the world.”

They kissed again as the world began anew.

Chapter End Notes

Adora: And nothing bad ever happened again.

Catra: Except we don’t know where Hordak is. And Vultak got away. And we don’t know where Hunga, Dylamug, and Estra are – mmph.

Adora (hugs Catra so tight she’s muffled by Adora’s shoulder): AND NOTHING BAD EVER HAPPENED AGAIN.

(I have been planning that "you and me at the end of the world" exchange for so long. SO LONG.)

Next time: Hordak makes his last, desperate play in...No Princess Left Behind!

No Princess Left Behind

Chapter Summary

Sooo...where is Hordak, anyway?

It's the Etherian Endgame for our season 4 climax!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra chuckled as she wormed her way out of Adora's embrace. "Okay, Adora, just let me adult a little longer, then I'm all yours."

Adora's smirk was somehow cockier than ever. "Wow. It's almost like you like me or something."

"I will *not* say I like you," Catra retorted, reaching for her comm.

Adora laughed. "Hey, that's already better than 'this is not because I like you'!"

It was Catra's turn to smirk. "Is it, though?" she quipped, tapping the comm in her ear. Adora stuck her tongue out at her as Catra turned her attention to command once more. "All direction leaders, check in," she ordered.

"East leader here," Glimmer cheered. "Lots of grumbling, but no trouble."

"West is secure, Commander," Sweet Bee added, tone as crisp as Adora's salute.

"North is good," Netossa added, tone surprisingly grim, "though I want a counselor for Sea Hawk."

Catra sobered on the spot, as did Adora. "What's wrong?"

“Scurvy went after Mermista,” Netossa explained. “Sea Hawk made a call. It was the right one, but Scurvy wasn’t the only one with his heart torn out.”

Catra winced and adjusted her comm. “Perfuma, we need a – whatchacallem, therapist – north side, stat.” Perfuma’s sigh was as good as an acknowledgment. There was a pause Catra didn’t like. “Tech squad, report.”

Nothing.

“Tech squad, come in,” Catra repeated, already reaching her mind out to Silver Storm. Swift Wind landed beside a nerve-wracked Adora. “ET. Kyle. Ro. DT. ‘Rina. *Report.”*

Still nothing.

“Set,” Catra swore, leaping onto Silver Storm. Together, she and Adora raced over to where the tech squad had been hiding.

Kyle, Rogelio, and Flutterina were all battered and unconscious. There was no sign of Entrapta or Double Trouble. Forcing the growing panic to sit down and shut up, Catra crouched, checking their vitals to ensure none of them were getting worse, then sniffed the broken harness arm beside Kyle. *At least he just lost the armor, and not the arm,* she noted – then froze.

I know that smell.

Bow and Glimmer appeared in a shower of sparkles. Bow didn’t even say anything – his gasp was as eloquent, and agonizing to Catra, as a speech. Adora just stared, one fist opening and closing.

“Okay. We know what Hordak was up to, now,” Catra reported, voice as calm as she could manage. “That tang you might smell is the hint of ozone and plasma from his cannon. We need a medic on these three stat, and a strike team assembled five minutes ago.”

Kyle groaned.

Catra even beat Adora to him; poor Bow seemed paralyzed. "Ohhh. Ooo. Ow," Kyle grunted.

"Hey, Kyle," Catra whispered with a smile, not bothering to hide her relief. Adora was already healing Rogelio.

Kyle raised an eyebrow. "I hate Shadow Weaver," he replied. When Catra stiffened, eyes wide, he blurted, "It wasn't her!" With a wince, Kyle waved in Catra's general direction. "Just...y'know, who you are, and who you were, and...Adora was right about you."

Catra forced back a blush. "Great, Kyle, but I need you to focus. Where's Entrapta and DT?" Adora moved on to Flutterina.

"He took them," Kyle breathed, curling up a bit. "Hordak. Rolled over us like a tank."

"Not your fault, Kyle," Catra insisted. *It's mine. This was* my *plan, I should've been more careful with – with my best friend – and now...* She shook her head. "Did he say anything?"

"Just something about 'finishing what he started,'" Kyle coughed. "He didn't even recognize us. Just Entrapta and Double Trouble."

"Hold still," Adora said, healing Kyle. His bruises and cuts faded, and he passed out again. "Kyle?" Adora gasped.

Catra held her arm. "He was using the pain to stay awake. You did fine, Adora." She stood and scanned the area.

Mally arrived with medical teams, while the princesses and their champions (even a disturbingly grim Seahawk) had gathered for the rescue. Of the Princesses of Power, only Sweet Bee and Felicia remained in the Fright Zone to clean up. *We can do this,* Catra told herself, straightening. "Okay, listen up, because we're in a rush," she explained. "Hordak grabbed Entrapta and DT and bailed

with them. He mentioned 'finishing what he started,' and since the Horde's scrap, that can mean only one thing."

"The portal," Bow explained, to several gasps.

Catra nodded. "Exactly. He's still trying to reach 'big brother Prime,' and he'll shatter Etheria if that's what it takes."

Scorpia raised a pincer. "But where would he go, Wildcat?" she asked, tail twitching nervously. "The Fright Zone's the only place that has–" she stopped, gasping, eyes wide and pincers covering her mouth.

Bow nodded. "Dryl," he agreed. *I think they're almost as freaked out by mission-mode Bow as Entrapta getting kidnapped,* Catra thought. "Entrapta's tech is just as advanced as Hordak's."

Catra nodded again, then whistled. Silver Storm darted overhead, then grew to her full size. "Okay. Queen Angella, how many can you carry to Dryl from here?"

Mom frowned just a fraction. "Four, safely," she replied."

With a glance, Catra wondered the same thing to Silver Storm. #I can bear another four without difficulty, in addition to you.#

Thanks, Stormy, Catra thought, leaping up to the 'saddle' Storm made for her. "Okay, here's the plan. The queen will carry King Micah, Netossa, Spinnerella, and Frosta. Storm and I will take Scorpia, Perfuma, Mermista, and Sea Hawk. Swift Wind, you can carry the Best Friends Squad, so I'm going to trust you with them." The bird-horse snorted, but didn't complain, so Catra counted it as a win. "When we get there, I'll sneak in with Bow. Adora, you're in charge of everyone else. If you can reach Entrapta before us, great, otherwise, keep Sore-dak busy and knock down what he sets up."

"Me?" Adora blurted. "But–"

"I'm trusting you to keep Hordak's forces busy." Catra shuddered, hands gripped on the ridge Stormy made for her. "This is why I stopped calling you a dummy, Adora. You're not. You're the best tactician in the Rebellion. Besides. Entrapta's my best. Friend," she choked out. "Me and Bow, we're the stealthiest members of the Alliance."

Adora stared goggle-eyed at Catra. "He wears a golden breast plate!" she cried, throwing one hand in the air.

Catra managed a wan smile. "And he can still hide from the rest of you," she retorted.

Adora looked a touch pale, but nodded back with conviction. "Okay. Okay. We'll save them, Catra."

Everyone mounted up. "Let's go save our friends," Catra said.

"For the Alliance!" Swift Wind cheered, and they took to the sky, Catra praying they weren't already too late.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"I didn't know you were so kinky," Double Trouble mocked, wriggling above their containment disc.

Hordak pointed a rear beam cannon at the shapeshifter while he worked on portal alignment. Entrapta, dangling from the cables he'd used to keep her captive, typed intermittently with her two free hair strands. "Ahhh...I shouldn't...but…" the princess gasped.

Hordak's smile was not as intimidating as he'd intended. "The intellectual problem is too interesting a challenge, is it not?" he noted.

"It's *fascinating!"* Entrapta gushed, typing at full speed once more. "The interference patterns bear a clear resemblance to those that disrupt flight systems used in conjunction with technological weapons! One appears to piggyback off the other in a way that

enhances both! AH-hahahaha!" Her laughter stopped as if deactivated. "Which I should not have said. Uh-ohhhh."

"Fear not, Entrapta," Hordak replied, continuing her calculations where she left off. "I suspect that Horde Prime himself will value your genius."

"Oh, no doubt Entrapta will appreciate Horde 'conditioning.' That won't impede her creativity at all, I'm sure – eep!" Double Trouble grew silent at the sight of Hordak's arm cannon three centimeters from their nose.

An explosion rocked the Crypto Castle.

Hordak sighed and activated his override protocols. In moments, Dryl's robots became his. The few elite soldiers he'd been able to move into place would delay the princesses, but not stop them. *This was always going to be a race against time,* he noted, turning his full attention back to the portal dilemma. Entrapta's intermittent typing resumed, devotion to her unworthy allies clashing with her passion for knowledge. *I will not fail you again, Lord Prime.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora tore the tank in half with a grunt, the soldiers within staring at her in disbelief. Glimmer managed a dark chuckle. "You're surprised? Have you *met* She-Ra?"

"Glimmer, back up Mermista," Adora ordered. Glimmer tossed her a salute that was only a little sloppy and went to the water princess' aid. *Mermista and Sea Hawk are managing for now, but I can't risk them to a distraction. That thing with Scurvy...*

Adora tried, and failed, to not imagine a similar end with Catra. *A one came up zero, and I lucked into the right words,* Adora thought, smashing through bots. *Now, Catra trusts me with almost everyone we love.* She-Ra's eyes narrowed as a huge bot designed to look like a three meter tall Hordak stomped towards her. Another strode towards Angella. "Hello, Force Captain."

“Hordak,” Adora snarled. “You’ve hurt the people I love for the last time.”

Even as She-Ra, a Hordak more than twice her size chuckling at her was intimidating. “You Etherians and your primitive ways. It appears that I could not cure you of them, even with a lifetime of education.” He punched down at Adora, the giant fist a piston meant to crush her.

She-Ra blocked it with her shield of Light, not even having to think to summon it. “It would have worked, if you’d been paying attention!” With a roar, she sliced the arm in half, length-wise, with the Sword of Protection. “Instead, you gave me Catra, and that saved me.”

“Catra,” Hordak rumbled, nudging the lost half of the arm aside, then kicking at her. She-Ra sliced at the foot as well, but he pulled it back to open fire with blasters in the bot’s chest. As surprises go, it was a predictable one, and Adora dodged and blocked the beams. “I should never have let Shadow Weaver keep her.”

“Hey, wow, we *agree* on something!” Adora snapped, leaping up and stabbing the bot in the chest. “Queen Angella, aim for the bot’s neck, sensors are in the head!”

‘Hordak’ snarled and spun, throwing Adora off, but she landed on her feet, her legs no worse than sore. “I should have left you to die in that field,” he hissed, crouching and pressing his functioning arm to his side for a low jab. Adora saw it for the feint it was, but he spun with a grace that surprised her, and she had to focus on blocking the spin-kick rather than going for an opening. “You were meant to be a champion of Prime’s light, but now you defend the shadows!”

Adora bared her teeth. “‘The only one here defending shadow and chaos is you,’” she spat.

That paralyzed Hordak for long enough that Adora was able to slice the bot from skull to hips with a single blow. She-Ra walked

through the explosion, glowing like a moon, and soldiers threw down their weapons wherever she approached. *Hang on, Entrapta,* she thought. *We're coming. We will never leave you behind again!*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra was worried about Bow.

Not because of the bots, mind you. (Catra had just gotten to the point where she thought she'd stopped underestimating Bow, and he just...fired three arrows at once. Three flarking arrows with different heads, which meant each of them had a different weight and spin, and they *all* hit the parts of the bots he was aiming at, and for Set's sake, *how?)*

But Bow wasn't just not smiling – of course he's not smiling, even Bow's gonna be a mess when Lord Flarking Hordak kidnapped his girlfriend – he was grim. They were carving through the security bots like slicing bread, and flowing through the Crypto Castle's maze like walking down a corridor, and Hordak didn't seem to know they were coming, and Bow looked like a walking pre-murder checklist.

"Hey." Carefully, knowing that if the situation was reversed Bow would risk getting clawed for what Catra was about to do, she reached out for his shoulder. She froze when he flinched. "Bow. I'm not gonna ask if you're okay. You still with me?"

"Yeah. I just...it's just…" Bow shuddered, arms down and fists clenched. Catra winced at the red stain on his namesake's handle. "I thought it was over. We won, everyone was safe, and...Entrapta..."

"Bow, look at me," Catra whispered. He turned, and Catra learned that she still had a heart to break. Bow was a mix of terrified and *enraged* that was like looking in the mirror for her, and seeing Best Boy like that was a dagger between her ribs. "You've got

this. We've got this. Hordak needs her in one piece. We can save her."

"I…" Bow seemed to realize he was breathless, and fixed that with a long, deep inhale. "I want to kill him, Catra." The quiet in his tone froze Catra's blood. "I want to put arrows in his eyes and watch his skull light up. Oh, Stars, what am I?"

"Human," Catra insisted, reaching out again. Bow didn't flinch this time, and she put one hand on a shoulder and the other on his arm. "We both know you're not going to do that. There's no shame in being angry, Bow. You've been there for me more times than I can remember. It's my turn now. We're gonna save Entrapta and DT, make Hordak squeal like a pig, and sashay home like it's Princess Prom." That got a laugh from him, and she grinned back at him. "And then you'll have all the time in Etheria to fall apart. I've got your back, Bow. I..." she swallowed, refusing to mess this up. "...I *promise."*

Bow's eyes flew wide, and he threw himself into hugging her. "You're a good friend, Catra," he whispered. "Don't you dare let that witch tell you different."

Catra chuckled. "You know, I never told you that you were right." Bow made a questioning sound that wasn't even as coherent as a 'huh?' into her shoulder. "About apologizing to Adora. It took a while, but I did – I do feel better. For it." They de-hugged, and Bow stared at Catra in surprise. "I love Adora, and Glimmer, and Entrapta, for all the things they've been to me, but if I've turned into a good friend, it's because you taught me how." Bow's eyes gleamed. "Come on. Let's finish this."

Bow nodded and followed her. It wasn't long before they reached Entrapta's control room (she didn't even have a stool, let alone something you could call a throne), where the princess was dangling from cables like some strange, cute dragonfly caught in a spider web. Two braids typed, then stopped, then started again, while Entrapta hummed in distress, trying to resist working. DT was in their default form, arms and legs pinned by Horde-red

energy rings that held them above a disc glowing the same color. Hordak stood before another console, tapping away, while another, smaller portal machine hummed in front of him. “Plan?” Bow whispered.

“You go into the vents. I distract Hordak, you rescue Entrapta and DT, then we kick that can of his from here to Brightmoon.” Bow blinked. Catra shrugged. “Hey, they can’t all be Erelandia,” she noted. He shrugged, nodded, and disappeared overhead. *Okay. One last showdown. With Hordak. And his First Ones armor. And two hostages. No problem.* She straightened, forced a smirk to form, and opened the door to Entrapta’s chambers. “Hey, Hordak,” she drawled.

All three turned and stared, DT and Hordak agape at her audacity. “Catra!” Entrapta gushed. “I have been unable to remove my hair from these bonds which is very interesting but also disconcerting because I’m so close to resolving the interference dilemma and I know I shouldn’t but–”

Hordak interrupted Entrapta by forming his arm cannon and trying to obliterate Catra. Entrapta and DT screamed, but Catra dodged by shrinking below the beam, then leaping in and returning to her human shape to plant her fist in his jaw. Hordak tried to scream, but with his mouth forced shut, it came out as a long, frustrated grunt.

Hordak’s instincts were good, though, and he rushed her rather than trying to back away for a better shot. For all Catra’s magic and skill, he was simply stronger than her in that armor. She dodged away again, hitting one of his arms with frostflame and the other with regular fire. His suit compensated with some kind of energy distribution system, but that looked like it interfered with his blasters, since he charged again, a helmet clanking into place. *Great, he’s learning.* This time, Catra was able to evade, but her claws merely nicked his armor. “Catra!” DT cried as the battle rounded the corner. “I know I look ravishing in peril, but I don’t like this any more!”

"I'll get you both out!" she promised, ducking a swing by such a narrow gap it slapped the tips of her ears.

"You will not!" Hordak howled. "You have interfered with my plans for the last time, you miserable, deceitful stray!"

The world turned red, and Catra slashed right through the soft point inside his left elbow to tear into his ravaged body. Hordak screamed. "I am not a stray, you reject!" she snarled back. "You murdered my mom and made me your *slave!* And *deceit?* You torture people for hiding things from you when you built the Horde on lies! Thrown away for getting sick, you abandon your own wounded! I am going to rip out your guts and *strangle* you with them!"

That panicked him, the mighty Horde Lord screaming and flailing back, beams lancing out almost at random. Catra permitted herself a feral smile and hit him with more fire, dousing the beams as his suit vented smoke and mist everywhere. "Catra, please don't kill him!" Entrapta cried. "I know he's done bad things, but he just misses his home."

For Bast's sake! she raged, slinking through the pseudo-fog. "Fine, he gets one chance," she conceded. "Can you set up communications without letting the rest of the Horde in?"

There was a pause. "That was a necessary step, actually," Entrapta explained.

"Fine," Catra sighed. "Finish that, then *stop.* I wanna talk to Horde Prime."

Hordak, who had been very still until then, began to circle where he thought Catra was. It was closer than she liked. "You...will hear Prime's words?" he asked, sounding almost reasonable.

"Yeah," Catra agreed, "but probably not why you think." She counter-circled, keeping Hordak in front of her. "All this time, I thought you were like Shadow Weaver, but I've been thinking about it. About you."

"Oh?" Hordak formed his arm cannon again, but kept it pointed down. "To what end?"

"You never had a childhood," she explained. Hordak froze, causing Catra to pause as well. "You were 'born' – created – with Prime's indoctrination in your head. And in some of those other worlds, you were friends with Entrapta. With Scorpia. Even, in one, with me." She slunk backwards, giving them both some space. "Maybe...you're not like Shadow Weaver. Maybe you're like me. And you just need a one to come up zero when you're ready to listen."

There was a moment of silence eerie enough to make Catra's fur stand up. Then Hordak...laughed. "Like you? Like some pathetic remnant of a beaten people, who does not belong anywhere?"

Catra huffed. "Actually? *Exactly* like that."

"And how is letting Horde Prime into your misbegotten universe going to help you?" he demanded.

"If I'm right, and you're like me, you have a Shadow Weaver," Catra guessed. "And there's only one real candidate."

Hordak's armor lit up red, all his weapon systems coming alive. "You DARE!" he snapped.

"Is that you, little brother?" Hordak's voice echoed through Dryl's speakers, but it was not Hordak. This voice was...not just confident, but confidence incarnate. Calm, commanding, and cruel as Garnet lightning. "I thought you had perished."

"...Brother?" Hordak – mighty, terrifying, all-conquering Hordak – was in tears, seeking the voice with his eyes, his entire body, twisting, yearning in ways that punched Catra in the gut. *He is like me,* she realized. "I was pulled into a shadow dimension. All this time I have been trying to return to your side. I...failed you, but I can at least give you this world before you judge me."

"'Before,' little brother?" Calm, commanding...contempt, this time. A hologram appeared before Hordak, and its sheer presence seemed to disperse the fog. It was like some super-Hordak, muscular and arrogant, with two extra eyes and tubes in place of hair. "I received your transmission, but I could not determine its source. Until I detected a signal like nothing I have ever seen before. Only to find that you created some mockery of the Horde there, and a failed one at that."

"But *I* have not failed you, Brother!" Hordak cried, falling to his knees before the image. "I gave everything I built, a generation bent to my will, so that you could overcome the She-Ra and take this world's power for your own!"

Prime frowned. "To *your* will. Blasphemy. You have given yourself a name. You tried to create an empire of your own. That magicat creature even made you doubt me, is that not so?"

"No, Brother. I did it, all of it, for you," Hordak whimpered, crouching lower even as he reached one hand out.

"You have forgotten what you are. You wish to stand beside me, failure that you are? I made you in my image, but you have become an abomination," Horde Prime intoned. "The only service you could give me now is to erase your errors. Self-destruct."

Hordak stared. "...what?"

"You heard me," Horde Prime said, as though placing an order for parts. "She-Ra is there, is she not? Detonate your armor and the castle around you. Perhaps you might eliminate some of her allies."

"Yep. Shadow Weaver," Catra interjected, causing both Hordaks to look at her. "Called it."

"Ah, and you must be Catra," Prime said, his smile at her so condescending she could feel it across universes. "The supposed prodigy. What scheme do you have in mind, magicat?"

“Redemption,” Bow replied. He had, as planned, rescued Entrapta, who was still working on the signal, and DT, who was artfully clinging to Bow’s leg and looking up at him with adoring gratitude that Catra suspected was only mostly for show. “You really don’t get what’s happened here, do you?”

“Hordak,” Catra said. The Horde Lord looked at her. “Your brother doesn’t care about you, or Etheria, or the millions who believed in you. He’s ready to throw you away on the off chance you can hurt Adora. There are people here willing to give you a chance – a *real* chance, at life and happiness – if you let them.” Catra paused, to make sure she was telling him the truth. “Us.”

Horde Prime laughed. “Pathetic. I hoped you might have a modicum of rational thought, but alas, it seems that you must all be purified.”

“Entrapta. Shut Mr. Purity here up,” Catra said. With a fierce cackle, Entrapta yanked on some wires, and Prime’s smile vanished an instant before he did. She turned to Hordak. “Well?”

The arm cannon was still there, still glowing. “Give my people a chance for amnesty. Those who surrender, aside from myself, are not to be judged for their loyalty,” Hordak insisted.

“Done,” Catra agreed.

With a sigh, Hordak deactivated and retracted the cannon. “Then I yield,” he sighed, lowering his head.

And just like that, the war was over.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora woke up to the best of sounds – Catra purring beside her. It was the quiet purr, though, so... “Hey, Catra,” she whispered.

“How do you know when I’m awake?” Catra groaned.

Adora smirked. “I’ll never tell,” she replied.

Catra shook her head, but smiled all the same. “Why do I put up with you?” she quipped.

“Because you *looove* me,” Adora laughed, kissing Catra’s belly. No, that *laugh* was the best sound. *Happy Catra. That’s the best sound,* she decided.

“As long as you know it’s *not* because I *like* you,” Catra quipped back, catching her breath. Alas, she sobered quickly. “Come on, Adora, let me up. The civilians can keep celebrating, but we’ve got a meeting.”

Adora’s joy leaked away as well. “A trial, you mean,” she grumbled. “Brightmoon security is weird.”

“It’s called ‘justice,’ Adora,” Catra sighed. Together, they got up and headed for the spare room.

Octavia, Grizzlor, and Callix were there with Hordak, who was in his own magical barrier in the center. Angella, Micah, Castaspella, and Juliet were already there, all looking grim. “Are you certain you will not change your mind, Lord Hordak?” Angella asked, looking genuinely concerned.

“Yes,” Hordak insisted. “There is no question of my guilt, and given my input on punishment options, I refuse to accept imprisonment. If your colleagues are mad enough to permit me to attempt restitution, then at least I will be of use, and I have no fear of death.”

“Lord Hordak,” Grizzlor rumbled, glaring at Micah like he wanted to take another shot. Micah’s return gaze was cool and implacable.

“No one’s killing anybody if I’ve got anything to say about it,” Catra insisted, “and I kinda do.”

“You really think you can do this, Catra?” Octavia asked, fists clenched.

Catra grinned. “I told you, ‘Tavia, they’re not what you think. Today, I’m gonna prove it.”

Adora wasn’t sure if she wanted Catra to be right as Brightmoon’s forces marched the four Horde prisoners into the war room. *Not like we can decommission it yet, with Vultak still out there,* she thought, looking over the princesses. Scorpia and Entrapta were on Catra’s side, no surprise there, and even if Perfuma wasn’t in love with Scorpia, she was the most forgiving person Adora knew. Spinnerella’s concern was a welcome surprise. But Mermista, Sweet Bee, Netossa, and Felicia looked ready to fight for the chance to cut off his head themselves. Glimmer, Frosta, and Peekablue were the wild cards, all upset, but none looking ready to kill Hordak.

“So.” Catra guided Hordak to her seat, shocking almost everyone (including Hordak). “This isn’t a trial, he’s pleading guilty, it’s a sentencing, but I understand we’re doing this kind of like a trial, so the pro-death side goes first, right?”

Sweet Bee snorted. “Sure. He’s Hordak,” she said. Catra folded her arms and raised an eyebrow. “Thirty years of war. Child enslavement. He sent Micah to Beast Island, gave Peekie to Vultak, and left *you* with *Shadow Weaver.* Hordak’s killed thousands and stole freedom from millions.”

“He killed ten percent of our entire species, Catra!” Felicia cried. Catra flinched.

“And you want him to do, what, community service? Really?” Sweet Bee waved at Hordak. “We get it, you think you could’ve been him, but only because of him!” Catra’s tail lashed. “Fine. Defend him if you want.” The Andreenid princess sat, taking Peekablue’s hand.

“Hordak was never a child,” Catra began. Adora tensed at the mix of gasps and confused looks. “That’s not a metaphor. I mean that literally.” She nodded to Entrapta, who called up a hologram of a clone tank. “Horde Prime creates his soldiers in these cylinders,

grows them to adult size, and pumps them full of training and propaganda. That's all Hordak knew until he ended up here."

"How does that justify–" Mermista began with a hiss.

"*Not* justification. Forgiveness," Catra reminded her. "Hordak was an...experiment of Prime's. When he got sick, Prime threw him away."

"Hordak was the first clone to join the Beloved," Callix explained, "Lord Prime's elite forces. He was unusually clever and successful for a member of the hive mind."

"Horde clones spend their entire lives with their minds connected to each other," Catra continued, "which Hordak lost on Etheria. So, indoctrinated, then rejected, sent on a suicide mission, and traumatized just by ending up here," Catra explained. "No one is arguing that what he did was wrong, but it took Hordak all this time to realize it was wrong because the Horde was *all he knew.* And yes, Sweet Bee, that's how I would've ended up like him."

"As a matter of clarification," Entrapta jumped in, "it is inaccurate to describe Hordak's restitution sentence as 'community service.' His genius can revolutionize organization, information, and *science* on Etheria! Catra told me that you might consider this implausible, but Hordak could do so much good, it would surpass all the damage done by the Horde."

Netossa scoffed. "'Implausible' is the kind version, Entrapta."

Catra folded her arms. "'Tossa, I love you, but be serious. Not trusting him is understandable, but Hordak started with six surviving soldiers and the scraps from half a flying ship. Before Adora found the Sword, he conquered half the world, and without She-Ra, he'd be putting you on trial right now. Anyone really want to argue that he's not brilliant?" No one answered. "Good. Quick reminder, no one's talking about being stupid here. Entrapta can fill his armor with trackers and health monitors, for his safety as well as ours."

Glimmer leaned forward. “And you wouldn’t object to this, Hordak?” she asked, her voice intense, with a hint of strangled.

Hordak sighed, shrinking in his chair. “Of course not, but...” he looked up at Catra with the ghost of a smile. “Catra is most eloquent in my defense. However,” he continued, turning his attention back to the other princesses, “the question is moot, is it not? Your people demand blood. Half of you want me dead.”

“Imprisonment would’ve been fine,” Sweet Bee noted, voice colder than Frosta’s magic. Adora gulped.

“Death is kinder to me,” Hordak replied, expression calm. “Knowing, *understanding* as I do now, I accept the wrong I have done, but not all Horde virtues are lies. I cannot abide to be useless.” He straightened in the chair, and his eerie acceptance convinced Adora that Catra was right. *He does deserve a chance,* she thought as he continued. “It would be folly beyond reason not to monitor me if you spare my life, but I do not see why you would. I have asked not to be imprisoned, yet as you pointed out, I subjected others to decades of helpless torment. Swift execution is already more mercy than I expect or deserve.”

Sweet Bee looked at Peekablue. “I won’t enter his mind without permission,” the Gar princess explained, “but I know he is telling the truth.” That shocked the entire Alliance into silence.

Catra stepped forward and leaned her claws on the table. “Are we the good guys?” she asked, tone soft, and Adora stood amazed at the attention her love commanded. “Hordak has changed, and you all know it. Yes, he did horrible things, but he’s not the same person who crashed here, before most of us were even born. Sure, you have a right to be mad about everything we’ve been through, but admit it – some of the mad you’re feeling now is because you *wanted* him to be unrepentant.”

The assembled Princess Alliance stared at Catra, a room full of women born to rule with fantastic power in awe of the girl Adora had found in a box. *That’s my fiancée you’re all staring at!* Adora

gushed, smile so wide it ached. Mermista groaned and let her forehead hit the table. "Ugh. Fiiine. It's not like we can't kill him later if he's really evil or whatever."

It was Hordak's turn to gape. The other ex-Force Captains followed. Netossa's sigh was explosive. "As long as we're not stupid about it. Entrapta, his suit better have more bugs than Beast Island."

Micah groaned. "Great, now I'm hungry," he quipped. The tension almost broke as several princesses laughed, but Sweet Bee summoned a sting-spear, killing the humor.

Peekablue put a hand on Sweet Bee's arm, her gentle touch causing the spear to vanish. "Bee, I know why you're so upset," she whispered. "Belonging to Vultak was a...nightmare. But he kept me away from Hordak for a reason."

"He wanted your power for himself," Sweet Bee snapped.

Peekablue shook her head. "Vultak knew," she explained, gesturing at Hordak, "that there was this...potential, in him. Besides, Catra asked us a question, one that really means, 'who are we?' Do we want vengeance, or peace? Will we choose fear, or hope? Rejection, or trust?"

"Shadow Weaver isn't here," Catra pointed out, "because she refuses to accept the chance to change. She refuses to admit that she did anything wrong. When Hordak surrendered, he asked that we grant amnesty to his people, not him. That's who he chose to be. What about us?" She sighed and wrapped an arm around Adora's waist. "Who are we going to be?"

Sweet Bee groaned and fell back into her seat. "If you betray us," she said, glaring at Hordak, "you'll wish we killed you."

Felicia sighed and nodded. "What she said."

Angella's smile suited her name. "That appears to be unanimous consent?" the queen asked. The princesses nodded. "Lord Hordak,

we remand you to the care of Princess Catra and her friends, the Princesses Scorpia and Entrapta. May you prove Entrapta's faith true."

Hordak stood, staring at the assembled heroes in disbelief. "You...I...." he buried his face in his hands and sobbed.

Adora watched in amazement as Grizzlor and Callix approached Juliet – *probably to join the military,* she thought – while Octavia came over and clapped Catra on the shoulder. "Scut, Catra, that was a performance right out of the Blind War Games!"

Catra chuckled. "I won those too, remember?" she noted. Her eyes flickered to Octavia's patch. "Um. You know. Adora could probably fix that."

"It's not broken," Octavia retorted, grinning. "It's better than the old eye, and admit it, I rock the look." The three former Horde warriors laughed as one, free at last.

"Okay," Glimmer interrupted, mischief alight in her eyes, "no one has to leave, but I don't know if you 'no feelings' Horde types will want to be here for the next order of business."

Catra blinked. "What next order?"

Glimmer punched the air with both hands. "Wedding plans!" she sang.

Adora and Catra blushed in unison while most of those present – even Grizzlor and Octavia – laughed. "Oh," Catra muttered, tail curling around Adora's wrist. "Yeah. That."

Unable to contain her joy, Adora grabbed Catra's waist, picked her up, spun her around to the most adorable squeal ever, and kissed the love of her life. *Horde Prime might still be out there,* she thought distantly, *but that is a problem for future Adora.*

Chapter End Notes

Quick worldbuilding note: I imagine that normal pre-Horde punishments included imprisonment, "direct" restitution (providing assistance to the wronged party in proximity) and "indirect" restitution (like a fine, but that could be worked off elsewhere, if proximity might trigger either party). The judged can remove one option from the list, however, and that is generally imprisonment (though given the therapy and re-training available, some accept it). For crimes against sentience, the death penalty remains an option, but with the same stipulation, which is why it was never taken off the books -- it was just assumed that no one would leave death on the table. (Shadow Weaver certainly didn't.) Hence, the Hordak dilemma.

Here's another chapter I planned months ago, but that still took me weeks to build up the energy to write, *but* but, that I wrote in two discrete sessions on two days, one last week and one today.

The Etherian war's over, and Horde Prime won't show up again until Season 5, but our alternate Season 4 has one episode left. I do believe I promised you folks a wedding... :-) Next time: 90% extreme, tooth-rotting romantic fluff, 10% (metaphorically) beating on Shadow Weaver for...Wedding Day!

Wedding Day

Chapter Summary

> 95% Tooth-rotting romantic wedding fluff. 5% Keeping Shadow Weaver out of the tooth-rotting romantic wedding fluff.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra stared in the mirror, more terrified than she'd been since Shadow Weaver dragged her before Hordak...*something like two* lifetimes *ago,* she thought in wonder.

The magicat princess wore a proper suit for the first time since Princess Prom. This one was black with red trim, and the tie was in a proper knot (thanks to Glimmer's help), but otherwise, it was like a flashback. *It's not the same,* I'm *not the same, not any more,* Catra insisted.

Glimmer appeared in a pop of light and magic. "How's my baby *sister?"* she sang.

"I'm a month older than you," Catra drawled, shaking her head. Her hair, now contained in a royal blue headpiece with golden eyes, kept her hair in place. Her ponytail wasn't quite identical to Adora's old one, but Catra made it work. *Not sure how I feel about that.*

Glimmer laughed. "It's the principle that counts."

"Well, the principle is I'm older than you," Catra quipped back. Her smile died aborning. "Am I doing the right thing, Glimm?"

Glimmer stared for several seconds. Then she *double*-facepalmed and groaned. "Bow owes me five pence," she sighed.

Catra scowled. “I’m serious, Glimmer,” she hissed.

“I knooow,” Glimmer groaned. “How can someone as smart as you be this *stupid?”* She ignored Catra’s glare. “Do you love Adora?”

Catra’s ears drooped. “More than anything,” she whispered.

Glimmer’s second sigh was explosive as she crossed her arms. “And does she love you?” Catra choked on her answer, doubt stealing her voice. She thought she’d have gotten it back eventually, but Glimmer didn’t wait, instead pressing her hands to Catra’s cheeks and matching her glare. “The answer to that is ‘yes, obviously, *more than anything.’* Dummy.”

Catra’s retort died in her throat. “Are you sure?”

Glimmer’s frustrated scream left Catra perched on the highest shelf in the room, fur puffed out. “By the *Stars,* Catra!” She looked around, then found the magicat staring from near the roof. “Catriska D’riluth Brightmoon, you get down here this instant.” Glimmer pointed at the floor for emphasis. Catra dropped back down, landing on all fours. “I can’t believe I have to remind *you* of this, but Shadow Weaver is not invited to your wedding.”

Catra blinked, standing upright before she could rethink it. “I...don’t…” she mumbled. But she did understand. “I can’t help it, Glimm.” She hugged herself, biting her lip. “What if she’s right–”

Glimmer grabbed Catra’s arms, frustration giving way to a knowing smile that was almost exactly their mother’s. “She’s not,” the princess insisted. “You beat her. Inside and out. And there is nothing Adora wants more than to be married to you today. Okay?”

Catra hugged Glimmer and nodded. “Okay.”

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora stared in the mirror, looking at the dress she wore. It was elegant, graceful, and beautiful, like Catra. *But not like me.* She

looked at the image, her joy and excitement drained away. Instead, she felt cold. *It's a lie.* I'm *a lie. What am I doing?*

There was a knock at the door, and Bow peeked in. "Is it safe?"

Adora's laugh surprised her with how genuine it was. "No Horde bots present, Commander Bow," she reported. He didn't move. "Also, I'm dressed."

"Whew!" Bow blurted, coming in. "After that one time with Entrapta – I mean, it ended well, but we lost like three days work, sooo…" he walked over and smiled. "How's it coming?"

Adora beamed at him. "Great! Everything's perfect."

Bow sighed, his smile fading. "Adora…" She gulped. "It's okay to be nervous."

"Nervous? Pff," Adora waved him off. "Why would I be nervous? It's just a ceremony. And the tokens. And some words." She swallowed in spite of herself. "A lot of words. I mean, *so many* words." Bow raised an eyebrow at her. Adora's facade disintegrated. "Okay, maybe I'm a little nervous. Just a bit!"

"So, you're not having any thoughts about not deserving Catra, then?" Bow didn't move; in fact, his smile returned, if slight and mild. "I mean, that'd be understandable, but you know those are just from Horde propaganda, right–"

Adora pulled him into a hug that was half-tackle. "I ruined her life!" she sobbed, clinging to Bow as though the Void was pulling her in. "I don't deserve one of her claws! *Which she pulled out because of me oh Stars Bow!"*

"air," Bow gasped, tapping her on the back. With a yelp, Adora let him go, clutching her hands together with wide eyes. He took a deep breath, let it go, smoothed out his jacket, and made sure his belly button was still showing. "Adora. You know Catra loves you, right?" Adora nodded, unable to say anything. "And you love her, right?"

“So much,” Adora blurted. “It’s like I can’t *not* be happy when I’m with her. Except sometimes she’s miserable anyway and it’s awful and why do I look good in this thing it doesn’t feel real and Catra’s so *perfect* and I’m just the hitting-things person and why does she love me, Bow?”

Bow chuckled. “Because you’re Adora,” he said, taking her hands in his. “You’re not just the hitting things person. You’re the inspires the entire Rebellion person. You’re the everyone can rely on you person. You’re the gets excited about chocolate and butterflies person. You’re the friend everyone wants to have person.” His smile grew. “And I promise you that right now, anything Catra is thinking that isn’t feeling like she doesn’t deserve you–” Adora half-growled at that. “–is thinking that you get to spend the rest of your lives together, and that makes her the luckiest person in the universe.”

Adora’s smile took several seconds to return, but it eventually did. “You know, you’re the friend everyone wants to have person too,” she whispered. This time, she was far more careful hugging him. Bow hugged her back, his warmth driving something dark and cold away. “‘Shadow Weaver’s not invited,’” she reminded herself.

“Shadow Weaver’s not invited,” Bow agreed.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Shadow Weaver looked up from her book to find Micah standing before her. “Ah, Micah,” she drawled, placing the bookmark with care and setting the book down beside her. “I’d invite you in, but I’m afraid my cell isn’t very inviting.”

“It’s better than anything in the Horde,” Micah replied, eyes narrow but voice cool and controlled.

“True.” Shadow Weaver stood. “My 10’ cube has passable amenities, but the bars and guards detract from the décor.”

“You could help clean up the mess you made,” Micah retorted, setting his staff to float beside him and folding his arms. “All of it.”

“I might have,” Shadow Weaver said, raising an eyebrow, “if I was not expected to grovel before princesses lacking a tenth of my skill.”

Micah’s eyes widened as he stared. “Are you serious?” He shook his head. “You’re going to waste all that ‘skill’ in here because you won’t sacrifice even a fraction of your pride?”

“I have little else left,” Shadow Weaver explained, pressing her fingertips together. “This is an odd day for you to visit me, Micah. Is your ‘daughter’ not marrying Adora in a handful of hours?”

“I’ll admit, I’m here to make sure the wards on your cell are intact,” Micah explained.

Shadow Weaver indulged in a grunt of frustration. “Even if Vultak were a worthy leader,” she replied, “do you think me fool enough to take part in an assault on the combined might of the Princess Alliance? In the heart of their strength? Either Adora will see what Catra is in time, or...”

Micah paled a fraction. “‘Or?’” he asked, a flicker of hope behind his eyes.

Had it been anyone but Micah, she would have denied everything. “Or,” she admitted, “Adora’s glory is enough to tame even that creature.”

Micah sighed. “That is...not the explanation I hoped you would give yourself for misunderstanding Catra’s nature, but I’ll take it.” He turned, plucking the staff from the air. “Goodbye, Shadow Weaver. I don’t know when we’ll see each other again.”

Shadow Weaver permitted herself a chuckle. “I’m hardly going anywhere, now am I, Micah?”

He nodded as he walked towards the door. “No. For today, at least, that will have to be enough.”

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Angella watched Casta flit about, checking every detail, and forced herself not to smile. *If there had not been that minor difficulty with the programs,* she thought, *I would think this day is going too well.* Micah strode up beside her and gave Angella's hand a gentle squeeze. *And the sorceress is safely penned.*

Glimmer appeared beside them in a burst of light, then collapsed into her chair. "They're impossible," she groaned.

"What'd you expect?" Lonnie asked, striding over. Glimmer looked up, gaping just a fraction. "Stars, you taught us how awful the Horde is. Was. Holy Hordak." The woman shook her head, adjusting her tie. "Still not used to that. Do I look okay in this thing?"

"You look *amazing,* Lonnie," Glimmer insisted, almost leaping upright.

Lonnie's eyes widened, and Angella was pretty sure the girl blushed as she rubbed the back of her neck. "Uh. Thanks! And you – hey, you look great in your gold – cloak thing." Angella's smile grew; she'd imagined Glimmer being crowned in that garb one day. "How bad is it?"

Glimmer's smile vanished as yet another groan escaped her. "I had to kick Shadow Weaver out of her head. *Again.* Seriously, how can those two be so dense?"

"They're doing better," Bow said, entering with Entrapta's hair around one arm. Angella blinked; Entrapta was wearing a suit in Brightmoon's colors, but had braided her hair into a single lengthy ponytail. "I'm really glad they've been getting therapy, but the things they've been through take time to control."

"And they are both feeling intense emotions today," Angella noted. She smiled and gave Micah's hand a return squeeze. "I was quite the wreck on my wedding day, myself," she admitted.

Glimmer gaped. "You? But Mom, you're never – I mean, I've never seen you, not in control."

“Oh, I was in tatters,” Angella chuckled. “I wrapped the ribbon from my bouquet around my wrists to keep my arms from flailing about.”

“So it’s not just me!” Entrapta gushed, her braid quivering behind her. “It’s just so hard to keep them under control with an event like this to study.” Bow chuckled.

Micah laughed. “I didn’t even notice until she tried to *throw* the bouquet,” he noted. Angella’s eyes widened, a hint of a blush escaping her as well. “I was afraid Juliet would think I was trying to kidnap her or something!”

Lonnie blinked. “But what about your exchange?” she asked.

“I thought of that,” Angella explained. “By–”

Perfuma’s magic decorated the room in lilies and red roses, and everyone forgot about the monarchs’ token exchange. “Wow,” Scorpia whispered as the duo entered. “That was amazing, Perfuma, even for you.”

Perfuma beamed even as she looked down. “Do you think so? The couple chose the flower types, but I tried to ensure an elegant balance.”

“You succeeded, I assure you,” Angella said. The others nodded.

Glimmer yelped and looked around. “Wait, are we that close to the ceremony?”

“That sounds like a cue if I ever heard one,” Double Trouble said, grinning as they walked in on Hordak’s arm. The former Horde Lord was in an elegant black dress over his most basic survival armor, while DT wore a deep purple version with a short boa over their shoulders. With a spin that showed off their heels, they bowed to Hordak on the way to the piano. “Have to give those two silly kids a proper sendoff.”

Glimmer frowned. “They’re not leaving, Double Trouble,” she pointed out, crossing her arms.

“But in a way, they are,” Angella noted. “When you wed, every decision takes your family into account. Even if they live here, Catra and Adora are moving on from their old lives. Today, they claim freedom from their past, to chart the future they dream of. Together.”

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra was used to every form of music being subtle torture. The idea non-cats had of ‘on-key’ left everything to be desired most of the time. She was not used to whatever DT was doing at the piano. It didn’t just sound good – it was amazing.

After swearing to herself that she wouldn’t need any help getting to the poduim, she let Micah guide her forward, where Angella stood to officiate. The great hall of Brightmoon was packed, ranging from family like Percival, to dear friends like Sweet Bee and Peekablue, to distant acquaintances like Mayor Duplis. It seemed like every important person on Etheria was in attendance. *Well, we did save all of them at one point or another,* she realized.

Bee and Blue were the only princesses that weren’t part of the wedding party. It had been interesting watching them divide themselves up; there was never any question that it’d be an even number for each, but some had truly agonized over which side to join. In the end, Perfuma, Mermista, Frosta, Netossa, Spinnerella, and Bow had joined Adora’s side, while Scorpia, Entrapta, Felicia, Flutterina, Sea Hawk, and Glimmer were Catra’s “attendants.” Which was weird, but whatever.

Dad gave her a kiss on the cheek and sat down beside Uncle Percy. Both were more than a little misty-eyed. Catra fiddled with the hem of her jacket, long enough to give a hint of skirting at Aunt Casta’s suggestion. *Suit or dress? Why not both?* Catra thought, smirking for a moment. Glimmer offered a subtle fist-bump; Catra accepted.

Then the music DT was playing changed, and Casta led Adora to the archway. Catra couldn't breathe. All her life, Adora had been the most beautiful thing in it, but in her gown, she looked more like a goddess than She-Ra ever had. Ever *could.* Glimmer nudged her in the back, getting Catra to start breathing again. Adora met Catra's eyes, and the nervous set in her jaw melted away into a smile of pure, unmitigated joy.

All of Catra's doubts burned in the light of that smile. Not only was Catra happier than she had ever been, she was happier than she had ever *imagined* being.

After an eternity, Adora was there, both by her side and facing her. Catra didn't bother trying not to purr; it was quiet enough not to disrupt the ceremony, anyway. Angella smiled. "Beloved friends, companions, family all. We are here to bear witness to a miracle."

The queen spread her wings wide, bathing the betrothed in their gentle light. "There were times when it seemed all the evil of our world was striving to destroy this love, this joy, this union. All the evil in the universe would have failed against them." Catra's heart pounded like a hundred cannons. "Catra and Adora emerged from a place of cruel malice to bring hope to us all, and then peace. They have been our miracles. It is time, at last, for them to be the miracle each wishes to be for the other, and find the joy in the peace of their union."

Catra's hand burned for her token, but it was not quite yet time. "As is traditional, both have prepared their own oaths. Princess Catra?"

Her name jolted Catra from her haze. "Adora," she breathed, all but blinded by the light of her love's eyes. "You saved me." Adora's smile slipped for a moment. "It was so hard for me to admit that, for so long, because it never felt like I deserved it. That I deserved you." Unable to suppress the impulse, she took Adora's hand. "You didn't just save me from the Horde. You saved me from that place inside me, the one that tried to get me to destroy myself. You never stopped believing in me, Stars alone

know why. You got me to see that there was something good in me, something worth fighting for, something worth believing in. You believed in me when no one else did." Slag it, her vision was getting blurry – those were probably tears. "Not even me."

She took a deep breath. "But you did so much more than that. When the world screamed, you were my quiet place. When I was despair, you were my hope. When there was nothing but sorrow, you were happiness. She-Ra might be Etheria's hero...but you're mine. You always were, and you always will be." Adora's eyes were saucer-wide as Catra let go, took the diadem from Glimmer, and slipped it over Adora's forehead. "I love you. I promise."

Angella beamed. "Princess Adora?"

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora panicked.

Catra's oath was beautiful – and terrible. *It was – she was – oh, Stars, Catra, can't you see there was never a me without you?*

On the spot, Adora threw out her entire oath and started over.

"You know, I've lost track of how many times people have asked me how I turned out 'good' in the Horde," she began. Bow blinked behind her; he knew she was off-script, but Stars bless him, he didn't even flinch. "So many times, it's 'how did you do it' or 'why did you resist' or something." Catra's eyes widened. "I didn't. I believed. I believed everything the Horde told me. Until you."

Adora took Catra's hand as she had taken hers. "You taught me to resist. You taught me to *think.* I'm *your* hero? You showed me what a hero was! That was my whole life – it *is* my whole life – you being there for me, fighting for me, loving me before I knew what love was. There is no me without you. That bad place inside you? It's the hurt you took, protecting me, and I want to spend the rest of my life replacing that voice with mine. I want you to hear 'you're amazing, you're brilliant, you're wonderful' every day for the rest of your life." She reached back. Bow, Stars bless him,

didn't miss a beat, handing Adora the wing-pin. "I love you," she whispered, pinning it onto Catra's lapel. *"I promise."*

Angella's smile was brighter than her wings. "Seal your union with a kiss," she commanded.

Adora put her arms around Catra, but Catra dipped Adora before the Princess of Power could react, and the magicat's kiss was everything she'd ever wanted.

"To Catra and Adora, Princesses of Brightmoon!" Angella cried. The cheer drowned out all the lies of their youth, leaving them only joy.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"So, are you going to ask anyone why it's called a 'reception?'" Catra asked as they danced.

Adora laughed. "Not today," she admitted. "I'm not dealing with any 'I forgot you grew up in the Horde' stares right now."

Catra felt like she could fly, wings or no. She joined in Adora's laughter as they spun across the dance floor, but stumbled back when they almost ran into Bow and Entrapta. *Kinky,* Catra thought, not for the first time, as she smirked at Entrapta's quivering braid. "Meh. Pretty sure everyone's used to it." She pointed with her tail at where Lance had cornered Grizzlor, questioning him about Horde record-keeping.

"Oh, no," Adora blurted, failing not to laugh again. "Should we rescue him?"

Catra kissed Adora again. "Nah," she said, laughing as she led her wife – her *wife!* – to where Glimmer, Lonnie, Perfuma, and Scorpia were chattering with excitement. "Okay, what are you four up to?"

Lonnie put one arm around Adora's shoulders and the other around Catra's, pulling them down a conspiratorial fraction. "You see Kyle or Ro anywhere?"

"They ducked out a few minutes ago," Catra replied, eyebrow raised and ear twitching. "Figured they wanted some time to themselves."

"Yeah," Lonnie said, smirking, "but not just to get away from you two being disgustingly cute."

Catra took in a breath to object, but Adora put her hand over Catra's mouth. "So what are they doing?" Adora asked, then removed her hand.

"Sea Hawk got Rogelio that neck thing a while back, remember?" Lonnie pointed out. Catra blinked; from the look on Adora's face, she didn't get it either. "Let me put it this way. I'm surprised you're not wearing Catra's old mask, Adora."

Catra huffed. "She would've looked ridiculous in–" They got it at the same time. "Wait, is Ro–"

"YES!" Kyle cried from somewhere.

Lonnie let them go, and the newlyweds shot upright, Adora's hands over her mouth. "Woo-hoo! Go, ROGELIO!" Lonnie shouted.

"Go, *Kyle!"* Catra joined in.

The two stumbled back in, both looking a bit shell-shocked. Kyle was wearing the neckerchief, while Rogelio had a glove from Kyle's workshop. "I, uh, we're engaged."

There was a thorough, wonderful round of hugging. "About time," Catra whispered to Rogelio.

"Look who's talking," Rogelio hissed back. It was anyone's guess which of them was blushing worse, though mercifully few of the humans could tell.

Once that was taken care of, Adora and Catra found themselves sitting at a corner table, taking a moment to breathe as the party

wound down. “This...I mean…” Adora waved to take in their friends, and the entire reception. “Wow. We’re married. *Wow.”*

Catra chuckled. “That was kinda the plan, Adora.”

“Well, mission accomplished.” Adora’s cocky smirk had rarely been so inviting. “I’m really looking forward to the next part, too.”

Catra laughed outright at that. “Hopefully with 100% less dimension-hopping this time.”

“I guess that’s why we practiced, then, to get that out of the way,” Adora decided, still smirking.

Catra couldn’t help it. She laughed, then kissed the smirk right off Adora’s face. “I love you so much.” She looked around–

–to find Hordak backing towards them, eyes locked onto Double Trouble. The Kamelian was chatting with Sea Hawk. *About music, probably,* Catra deduced. *Maybe DT can teach Sea Hawk what a ‘key’ is.* She smirked at their former lord and master. “Hey, Hordak,” Catra drawled.

Hordak yelped, leaped, and spun around. “Oh,” he gasped when he realized what had happened. “I. Should leave you be.”

“Nah, relax,” Catra said, waving him over. “We’ll protect you from Deetee.”

Hordak blinked. “I am in no danger from the Kamelian.”

“Well, no, but you were still retreating from them,” Adora pointed out, grinning.

Hordak sat, slumping down. “I...yes, I suppose I was. Double Trouble is...”

“A lot,” Catra agreed.

Hordak stared for a long moment, then nodded. "I understand you are going to take some leave time – a 'vacation' – once this revelry is complete." Both brides nodded. "To which kingdom will you travel? It might be a simple diversion for you, but such a decision could have political ramifications."

"It wouldn't, even if," Adora said, but slowly, biting her lip for a moment.

"And it won't," Catra explained, "because we're going everywhere." Hordak turned his attention to the magicat. "We always wanted to see Etheria. Now we can, without getting shot at."

"We're spending a few days in each major kingdom," Adora added. "It's a bit of a world tour." She chuckled. "Hard to imagine touring a whole world, but here we are!"

"We're even spending some time in Scorpia's old kingdom, now that you've fixed up the old palace. Snaps says thanks, by the way," Catra said.

Hordak nodded and stood. "I see. In that case, I wish you both well on your voyage. I should catch up with Scorpia–" All three stopped and stared, frozen at the sight of the blossoming vines curling around Perfuma and Scorpia. To be fair, thanks to the enormous petals around them, the three ex-Horde memebrs were probably the only people in the room who could tell that they were kissing. A lot.

Catra stood as well. "That's our cue." She grabbed Adora's hand and guided her upright. "How about we get to our happily ever after?"

Adora's loving smile was *everything.* "I can't wait," she gushed.

At long last, Catra believed it.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Two days later.

Adora stretched as dawn and wakefulness arrived in sync. *It's so nice to not have to get up before first light,* she mused, checking Catra's spot on the bed–

No Catra. Adora leaped out of the semi-literal flower bed, looking around their bungalow. It was woven from Perfuma's vines, but was as luxurious as their Brightmoon suite in its own way. That included the balcony, with its blossom-like curtains that Adora shoved aside.

Catra turned from where she had been crouched, looking out over Plumeria. Even through her relief, Adora noted (not for the first time) that it was a stunning view. Aside from the ocean of green, flowers appeared to be in season for every kind of tree, placing them in the center of a spiraling rainbow of life. (Adora's favorites were the cherry blossoms, especially the ones that would swirl in the wind below their perch.) Catra grinned, one fang peeking out. "Hey, Adora."

"Catra," Adora replied, not bothering to hide her relief. "You're...up. Early. Like, before me early."

Catra chuckled. "I'm fi – I'm really okay, Adora." She shook her head. "It'll sound weird."

"Right, because I'm the embodiment of normal," Adora quipped. Catra laughed, and it was the sound of happiness to Adora.

"Fair," Catra admitted. "I...didn't have a nightmare." Adora stared. "Like, not even a little one. I kind of woke up a little about half an hour ago, and realized...I wasn't afraid. It wasn't there. *She* wasn't there." Catra's smile grew. "All I could hear...was you."

Adora couldn't help it. She started crying, overwhelmed with joy (and to be honest, relief). "Catra..."

"And I was so tempted to just lie there and snuggle with you, but I...just wanted to see it, all of a sudden." Adora's head tilt must

have asked the question for her. “The world. Etheria. Plumeria.” Catra stook and took Adora’s hand. “Dayrise. Without wars or trials or even the wedding. Just...another day. At peace. With you.” Catra curled up beside her, and Adora was just overwhelmed with emotion. “This is our life now. We get to have this, to *be* this, together. Finally.” Catra looked into Adora’s eyes. “It’s everything I ever wanted.”

Adora smiled and kissed Catra. Together, they turned and watched the daymoon come up. “Yeah. Me too.”

Chapter End Notes

Whew That took a while. Not too long, I hope...

looks at date from last chapter

dies of embarrassment

I am so sorry. Life has gotten away from me these last two months, between work and holidays and the world going nuts yet again. Anyway, here is, at long last, the promised wedding. I'll probably do a few mini-chapters after this "season" as well, but I still have plans for Season 5. That *will* be my final season, wrapping up Turn Right's universe, but there's still Horde Prime to deal with and Eternia to find. (Since I used Revelation Part 1 for Better Angels, that version of Eternia will remain more-or-less canon for Turn Right, but I am going to ignore Part 2 more or less entirely, especially since Our Heroes will get there before Skeletor blows up everything.) Stay safe!

Honey Moon

Chapter Summary

Tooth-rotting romantic honeymoon fluff. *g*

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra stretched, yawned, and snuggled closer to Adora, spooning against her back. *Wow.* The daymoon was just coming up, filtered through the curtains (which were properly closed for once) to give their suite a warm golden glow. Catra put her hand over her mouth as realization struck, careful not to wake Adora as she laughed. *It's the color of honey. The* daymoon *is the honey moon.*

The magicat had almost drifted off to sleep again when the smell of medium-grilled swordfish wafted in. *Oh, that's not fair,* she groaned, burying her face in Adora's flowing (beautiful, divine) hair. Adora's scent, tinged with lavender, almost drowned out the swordfish. Almost. *Nope nope nope ignoring you. Snuggling now.*

Adora stirred. Catra couldn't decide whether she was happy about that or not. *More swordfish or more snuggling?* she wondered.

The overwhelming joy that followed threatened to explode from her. *That's what I have to decide now? Not "how do I avoid getting tortured by Shadow Weaver" or "how do I save everyone I love," but...swordfish or snuggling. Wow. WOW.*

That joy diminished for a moment when Adora gasped. "Catra? Are you okay?"

Catra blinked. "Uh, yeah?" she half-asked, half-answered. "What's wrong, Adora?"

"You're...you're crying."

Catra (reluctantly) pulled back from Adora's hair and touched her cheek fur. *Oh.* She blushed. "I. Um. Guess those were. Rrm. Happy tears?"

Adora gasped again, but this time it was clearly happy rather than worried. She pulled a bounce-turn to face Catra and kiss her.

Catra decided that Adora was trying to turn kissing her into an art form. Her wife *(MY WIFE!)* tried something new on a regular basis. Deep, passionate kisses; peppering her cheeks with loving pecks; soft, reverential presses against her neck; individual, gentle kisses to her forehead; light-yet-lingering brushes between their lips (like this one)...*When did she get so creative?* Catra wondered.

Adora backed away, then sat up, nose twitching almost like Catra's. "Is that swordfish?" she asked, her smirk as smug as ever.

"Ugh." Catra threw a pillow at her laughing wife. "Of course it's fish, we're in Salineas. You're lucky I'm so in love with you."

Adora's smirk melted into a smile made of pure, inescapable love. "Yes," she whispered, wiping away a happy tear of her own. "Yes I am." Catra lost a fight with a blush. *Dork,* the magicat thought, but it was as loving as Adora's smile.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora stared in disbelief from the scaffolding that had once been their place. *Our secret place, together,* she remembered. Her joy was so overwhelming, Adora felt like she had to hold on to the railing to keep from floating away. Catra chuckled beside her, the genius she married *(WE'RE MARRIED!)* shaking her head. "What did you expect? Have you *seen* the way Petals and Snaps have been lately?" Adora could only shrug.

The Fright Zone was unrecognizable.

Horror Hall was just *gone,* replaced with the castle that bore the humble name of Scorpion Hill. That name was only accurate in the

sense that Scorpia's castle was the size of a hill – one that was not a mountain on a technicality or something. It was also a magnificent stronghold, its burnished crimson metal plates shaped like the chitin of Scorpioni. To Adora's experienced tactician's eye, it also looked even more impregnable than Salineas Castle. Sting-cannons lined its walls and Scorpion Fliers rested on its parapets.

The eternal gloom was also gone, replaced with bright morning skies populated by a handful of fluffy clouds and a loop-de-looping Swift Wind. Some of the walls were still there, but the rooftops that had contained interior buildings had mostly been removed. Crumbling roads had been repaired and re-paved to give them a cheerier bronze look. And everywhere, *everywhere,* there were flowers amid fields of grass between roads and buildings, decorating the kingdom in every color.

It was the people who shook Adora the most, though. Former soldiers who had lived their entire lives caught between terror and duty were smiling and waving to one another. Only about one in ten still wore armor, the Horde symbols replaced with Scorpia's family seal (a regular scorpion with its claws spread wide rather than out to strike). Grizzlor of all people was giving directions to a construction crew in his traditional gruff manner. *I don't even want to spar with him,* Adora realized. Then she smirked. *Today,* she amended.

It was good to know she was still herself.

But even that wasn't the best part. No, the best part was her and Catra, up here looking out over it all, and they weren't afraid who saw them. Catra's smile just made Adora...*giddy. I'm giddy!* Adora laughed, her happiness impossible to contain, and Catra shook her head again. "Stars, you are such a dork, Adora."

"I am," Adora agreed. "I'm your dork." Catra laughed that heart-melting laugh of hers, and Adora couldn't help herself – she grabbed Catra by the waist and held her up for the whole Scorpion Kingdom to see. "I AM MARRIED TO THE MOST AWESOME WOMAN IN THE WORLD!"

Catra shrieked. *"Adora!"* she cried, burying her face in her hands. "Put me down!" Adora obeyed, of course, but the cheering was already echoing below them. "Why did I marry you?!"

Adora kissed her. She didn't even think to try something new, just went to her standard 'I-want-our-lips-to-merge' kiss. Catra purred. "Oh. Right," she whispered once their lips parted. "Hey, Adora." Catra smirked. "Let's do it on Hordak's old throne."

Adora's face felt on fire. "Catra!" she gasped. When Catra didn't laugh it off, Adora felt the blush go right down her collar bone. *Oh no. She's going to talk me into it. How am I going to explain this to Scor–*

Catra kissed her back, obliterating all hope of rational thought.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra chuckled. "When did I get used to the cold?" she asked, looking out over the Kingdom of Snows. Its aurora polaris was especially spectacular in the setting sun, green and white mingling with pinks and oranges in ribbons that stretched across the northern horizon.

Adora laughed, because of course she did. "You learned to snuggle," she whispered, nuzzling into Catra's neck.

The magicat laughed, her urge to deflect unraveling before it could form. "Huh. Yeah." Catra purred, pressing herself as close to Adora as their parkas allowed. "I guess I did." She smirked for a moment. "I mean, I did marry a human furnace, so – oh! Mmm." Adora's nuzzling took on a distinctly aggressive style. "Glutton," Catra whispered as her smile grew gentle.

"I'm pretty sure that's not the sin I'm working on," Adora whispered back. Catra could *feel* the blonde's smirk against her neck.

"It's not a sin. We're married," Catra insisted.

Adora chuckled into the muscles standing out on Catra's neck. "I guess I'll have to work harder, then." Catra huffed. *Overachiever,* she thought – but then Adora...worked harder. Oh. Oh, *Stars.*

Clanging bells rang below them. Adora stopped with the suddenness of a light switched off. "Dinner! Catra, they have this thing called a smorgasbord, we have to…" Catra turned a glare that she knew she was trying to not let be furious. "...I'll make it up to you later?" Adora blurted, sheepish. "I mean, don't you want me to have all the energy I'll need to – mmph!" Adora gasped through the hand Catra clamped over her mouth.

"Oh, you're going to make it up, all right," Catra whispered in Adora's ear, rewarded by the First One's helpless shudder. "But I'll decide if you need the energy after we see how well you beg." Adora's nod was downright eager. With a frustrated huff, Catra let her go. "Come on. Frosta's still too young to watch us 'flirt.'" Adora laughed, taking Catra's hand and tugging her down the staircase. *Dork. Glutton was definitely the right sin.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"No, Catra," Felicia hissed, arms crossed.

Adora laughed, knowing that Candila's magicats knew perfectly well how deeply Catra was blushing. "It would just have taken a minute," the thrice-princess muttered.

"Which would have turned into half an hour!" Percival laughed. "It's a good thing you married a saint!"

It was Adora's turn to blush. "Not really," she replied, but she was *definitely* not muttering. ...as badly as Catra, anyway.

"You. Are. On. Your. Honeymoon!" Felicia snapped, pointing at the Takdryl waiting beside Swift Wind. The alicorn was trying to talk the other winged steed into joining his revolution. "You're here to go riding together, so ride! Shoo!"

She towed Catra over to the Takdryl, who Adora would have sworn chucked at her wife. "Gonna have to come back to fix that guard formation anyway," Catra grumbled.

Adora gave Catra a quick kiss on the tip of one ear. The way Catra's *everything* reacted, Adora knew she'd have to remember that one. "They'll be fine for one week. Come on, I've gotta let Swifty show off at least once on this trip!" Swifty neighed happily. Catra rolled her eyes and mounted the royal Takdryl, patting her neck. It let out a draconic rumble. "Hey, where's Stormy?"

"Taking some time away from our 'raging hormones,' according to her," Catra explained with a chuckle. Then her smirk grew. "Like I need the most awesome sacred bond partner to keep up with you two, Feathers."

Swifty's eyes widened, then he snorted. "Oh, it's on now, cat-girl," he said. Catra just laughed.

Adora smirked. *So that's how you want to play?* she thought. Without taking her eyes off Catra, she felt what she wanted Swift Wind to do. The alicorn took off with a neighing cheer, flashing across Candila's sky. "Cheater!" Catra cried, spurring the Takdryl to give chase.

They wheeled over Candila's plains, farmlands and hunting grounds sprawling beneath them. Both princesses laughed and raced one another without contest or finish line. It was joy. It was freedom. It was everything Shadow Weaver had taken from their childhood, and they took it all back.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra watched with a shake of her head and a hand on her cheek as Adora fought a dozen sparring bots in Dryl's central courtyard. *For her, that's fun,* Catra mused. She blinked. *I...don't need this any more?* Catra wondered, eyes widening.

Oh, it was obvious she'd need to keep her skills sharp. Horde Prime was still out there. Adora's family was still out there (Catra

hoped), fighting some anti-magicat bigot. Named *Skeletor.* Who knew what else they were up against once they broke out of Despondos. It was part of her job as a princess.

But...I'm happy doing logistics crap, Catra realized. *Just taking care of people.* She watched Adora, happy that her wife took pleasure in the training they were raised on, but...*I just want it. I don't* need *it, to prove myself. To myself, or...anyone.*

Melancholy hit Catra like a tank. *Will Adora ever stop needing this?* she wondered, trauma caps drumming on the railing. *Does she ever get to have peace?*

Hordak's armor made distinctive noises, but Catra could tell he was making a particular effort to ensure she heard him without pushing his presence on her. It was a pretty cool flex. "Hey, Hordak."

"Catra. Something troubles you," he observed. It was why Catra managed to be friends with him – well, that and his friendship with Entrapta. It came from the complete lack of talking around stuff that other people did because it made them comfortable somehow. Something Hordak and Entrapta shared, now that she thought about it.

"Yeah," Catra admitted. "I don't...I know my people need me to keep my fighting skills sharp, but I don't need it for...myself, if that makes any sense?"

Hordak shrugged. "You have enemies," he pointed out. "I presume you are speaking of some emotional need, given the context."

Catra nodded. "Yeah. I 'need' to know how to fight so I can tear apart idiots who think they can take me. I don't need that to feel like I'm worth something." She sighed and watched Adora go through a minotaur-drone like an blaster through paperwork. "I'm worried that Adora won't ever get there."

Hordak sighed and nodded. "Please understand that what I am about to say is not an effort to evade my responsibility for the

suffering you and Adora have endured. That said, no one goes through life without pain, and pain leaves its mark.” Catra nodded back. “We all have our wounds, our scars, our...imperfections.” They both smiled just a fraction at that. “I have found that ‘healing’ does not come from erasing the harm done to us, but surpassing it. Transcending it, if that does not sound too pretentious.”

“Nah, you rock the look,” Catra agreed. Her melancholy faded at the smile on Adora’s face as she met every challenge in the arena. “Besides, you’re right.” Adora dropped the last bot with a spear, then reset the Sword to its usual post-rescue shape. She turned and granted Catra a beaming smile. “Imperfection is beautiful.”

“Imperfection is beautiful,” Hordak agreed.

“Come on, Catra! Don’t you want to play too?” Adora called, waving her down.

Catra smiled past tears that she no longer felt shame over. “Yeah,” she agreed. “Yeah, I do.”

She leaped down, ready to begin anew.

Chapter End Notes

I'm not dead! ^_^

I know this doesn't really move plot along (after THREE months I know please don't kill me I've been doing the professional stuff), but I really wanted to show these two being happy on their Etherian world tour. They've got one more big adventure ahead, but sometimes you just want your fictional babies to get some love. (And even the between-season adventures won't all be 100% fluff.)

Stay safe out there.

Shadow, Unwoven

Chapter Summary

> Shadow Weaver does time. It's not as hard as she deserves...until it is.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Hey, Shadow Weaver."

The sorceress looked up from her novel to find Catra standing outside her cell with her meal and another book. She raised an eyebrow at the Bubastis, glad that her mask's magic made the gesture visible. "To what do I owe the displeasure?"

Catra huffed and frowned. "I found out no one's visited you since my wedding." She slid the food through the magical barrier. It was decent fare, so Shadow Weaver accepted it. "I figured you could use another book, too. You've only had those all month." The magicat waved in the general direction of the dozen tomes that constituted what remained of her 'library.'

"I have preoccupied myself with efforts to compensate for your shortcomings when this 'Horde Prime' arrives to subjugate us all," Shadow Weaver drawled, snapping her book shut.

Catra snorted. "Right, by groveling to him and doing whatever he wants. I'm sure that'll work out great." She slid the book through the cell barrier. "It's obvious you're not in a mood to talk. I'll come back another time."

"Please do," Shadow Weaver replied, shaking her head. "You at least make a fine source of amusement." She picked up the book while Catra pretended not to rush away.

Shadow Weaver froze at the sight of the title. Catra had brought her Spritina's Final Treatise. *She could not possibly know this is my favorite book. Could she?* A quick flip through its pages confirmed that the tome was not some cruel joke or poor forgery. *This makes no sense. Why would she give me this?*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

It was another month before Catra returned. This time, Shadow Weaver was anxious enough to acknowledge her. "Is this some manner of scheme, D'riluth?"

Catra blinked. "What are you talking about?" She smirked. "You must be upset if you used my actual name."

"I could believe that no one would speak to me in the weeks after your wedding. It has been two months!" Shadow Weaver blurted, leaping to her feet. Her pathetic desk shook from the sudden motion.

Shadow Weaver was infuriated when Catra's ears pivoted back and she looked away. "Look, you're not exactly popular right now. I figured Dad – Micah would visit." She shrugged. "I brought you another book, if you want it." This one was Mortella's Ember Grimoire. *My second-favorite magical tome.* "They didn't want you to have this one."

Shadow Weaver let out a huff that was almost a chuckle. "As I am, I cannot work magic without materials," she pointed out, taking the half of the book Catra held through her barrier. She placed it with the others. "A moment." Relieved Micah had indulged her with pen and paper, Shadow Weaver wrote up a quick list. "Here."

Catra scanned the paper. "It's a list of more books." The sorceress permitted a faint groan. "It's...short."

"I can request others from the guards if I grow bored enough. This should also end your sad efforts to appease me with tomes," Shadow Weaver explained.

Catra's sigh was almost sad. "Right." She paused at the last item, smirking. "Gardening?"

"A hobby. Angella denies me access to reagents, but the guards walk me to your adoptive mother's conservatory during my exercise periods."

Catra snorted something that was almost a chuckle of her own. "Sure, why not?" She rolled up the list and headed for the door, taking one last look at Shadow Weaver. The elf opened Mortella's tome and pointedly began to read. The magicat took the hint and left.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Shadow Weaver looked up from Mortella's Grimoire in surprise. The approaching stomp of iridium was familiar from decades of service. Catra would likely cut off her own feet before wearing metal boots, and Brightmoon's guards were more light-footed. *Never show him weakness,* Shadow Weaver reminded herself. She placed the ribbon marker and closed the tome an instant before the broken Horde Lord appeared before her. "Hordak," she drawled.

"Shadow Weaver," he hissed. The frail monstrosity looked even angrier than usual. Hordak's eyes practically glowed their deepest crimson, and one fist trembled beside his hip.

She couldn't help it. Shadow Weaver laughed. "Oh, *this* should be good," the sorceress replied, steepling her fingers. "What do you want, you broken shell of a fool?"

Hordak's eyes narrowed. "Why?" he rumbled.

Shadow Weaver raised an eyebrow. "You're going to have to be a bit more specific, clone."

"What was your real reason for offering your services?" Hordak snarled. "Did you always intend the slaughter of the Bubasti? Was Catra your target from the beginning? Why did you join the

Horde, Shadow Weaver?" She chuckled again. "Tell me the *truth,* witch!"

"Ah yes, your famous saving grace of 'truth,'" she said, shaking her head. "You filled the minds of all those children with lies of propaganda and indoctrination, and yet–"

Hordak punched the frame of her cell. Shadow Weaver's guards jumped to attention and pointed their useless pikes at him. *"Answer me!"*

Shadow Weaver sighed. "I told you the truth from the beginning," she explained. "Did I appreciate the opportunity to 'thank' my treacherous ex-partner and her feral people for their rejection? Of course. Catriska, who was yet unborn when I joined you, was a piquant bonus for all of two hours before her lack of memory stole all satisfaction from taking her. I joined you to save the magic. Nothing more, nothing less."

To her surprise, the rage in Hordak's eyes dimmed, fading to their healthier red. The hissing from his armor resumed a more even rhythm. "I...see," he replied, looking her over with a critical eye. "Very well." He turned to leave.

That got Shadow Weaver's attention. "You believe me so easily after such overwrought drama, Hordak?" she asked, regarding him with a curious tilt of her neck. "Why?"

"Bio-scanners designed to pick up signs of deception, in part," Hordak explained. Shadow Weaver huffed. *As if I could not fool such crude methods,* she thought. "In addition, after some discussion with those familiar with Light Spinner, it does match your profile." Again, he turned.

"But why do you care?" Shadow Weaver asked.

Hordak paused. "You were my greatest mistake," he whispered. Shadow Weaver bristled. "I wanted to know how I erred. It was simple ignorance at first, then neglect. You appeared efficient enough to manage affairs while I completed the portal."

“And how was that a mistake?” Shadow Weaver demanded.

“Aside from permitting your bottomless malice free reign?” he snapped, turning one last glare on her. “I overestimated you.” Hordak left while Shadow Weaver seethed.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Shadow Weaver’s third monthly visit from Catra was a brief affair. She had already sent the books up with breakfast weeks before. The accursed magicat watched while Shadow Weaver read. “Aren’t you lonely?” Catra whispered.

“I might enjoy a conversation with a knowledgeable sorceress,” Shadow Weaver admitted, “but I am not so desperate as to engage in idle chatter with *you.”*

Catra took a deep breath. “Right,” she sighed, then turned to leave.

Curiosity got the better of the skywing elf. “I know why Hordak cared to visit. What about you?” Shadow Weaver asked. Catra froze. “You’re not still looking for some acknowledgement or acceptance from me, are you?”

“No,” Catra whispered, the word so fractured and wounded Shadow Weaver knew it for the truth. “Not any more.”

“Then why?” Shadow Weaver insisted.

“Because it could have been me in there,” Catra explained, “and no one should be completely alone.” It almost made Shadow Weaver laugh. A part of her wondered why she didn’t when she waved for the beast to leave. Catra obeyed for once in her life.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

After almost fifteen weeks, receiving a visitor worth noting was as much shock as relief. Princess Glimmer arrived looking curiously diffident and carrying a tracker pad. The sorceress stood and

bowed with all the formal grace she'd retained since childhood. "Your Highness," Shadow Weaver greeted. "To what do I owe the pleasure of this visit?"

Glimmer looked at Shadow Weaver with but an instant's surprise. She schooled her features with admirable speed for a child, but the lingering fear brought a smile to the elf's ruined face. She knew a loop for a hook when one presented itself to her. "This isn't a social call," Glimmer insisted, sitting and activating a function on the pad. "According to Hordak and Callix, Prime and some of his 'Beloved' are master manipulators. No one I know is better at cruel manipulation than you are. So you're going to teach me."

Shadow Weaver held herself as still as she dared. *This is too perfect of an opportunity. Is that Double Trouble? Could it be some trap?* The sorceress sat back down. "Am I, now?"

Glimmer straightened in surprise. "What?" she blurted.

Shadow Weaver's smile returned. *Definitely Angella's daughter,* she realized. There was no trap of Micah's or Double Trouble's here. The girl was desperate, afraid, and unsure. *Perfect.* The elf sat back down. "I will give you one lesson for free: the second lesson never is. That is, in fact, the lesson." She steepled her fingers again. "Or, to put it more succinctly...what's in it for me?"

The princess scowled. "Uh, not dying when Prime shows up?"

"Why would he kill me?" Shadow Weaver asked, waving around her. "I have no attachment to my prison. I merely fled to avoid Hordak's wrath. The clone is the one who betrayed his maker. I might well find a place in Horde Prime's empire. Vultak thought it possible." She leaned forward just a fraction. "Offer me something, daughter of Micah. Surely you didn't come here empty-handed?"

"Of course not," Glimmer admitted, looking away. *Oh, and such* potential *in spite of Angella's terrible influence,* Shadow Weaver

exulted. “But you won’t get much to start. Just more garden privileges for the first – second lesson.”

“With more to follow if my lessons have value,” Shadow Weaver agreed, nodding. “Then we shall begin your first true lesson with transactional bargaining. ‘Manipulation,’ you see, is nothing more or less than skill in bargaining.”

Glimmer’s eyes widened. “That’s – that’s not true!”

Shadow Weaver was as grateful as ever that no one could see her roll her eyes behind her mask. “I have little doubt your mother taught you that bargains are supposed to be fair and equitable. That is not how life works, Your Highness.” She leaned back. “Everyone wants something, and they all want the better part of the deal. The endgame is to make others want what you can offer without giving more than time, but at first all manipulation is about leverage.”

In spite of herself, Glimmer leaned forward. There was a clever gleam in the girl’s eyes. “Leverage,” she muttered, glancing at the pad briefly.

Ah – she’s recording, excellent! Shadow Weaver realized. “Indeed. ‘Give me a lever and a place to stand, and I shall move the world.’ It applies to people as readily as objects. Perhaps moreso, depending on the person and the lever...”

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra stormed in for their fourth monthly meeting. It was the most satisfaction Shadow Weaver had felt since fleeing the Horde. “What are you doing to Glimmer?” she demanded in that shrill tone she yielded to when afraid for another.

Shadow Weaver didn’t bother looking up from her gardening manual. “I believe it is called ‘teaching,’ mongrel,” she explained. The guards bristled, armor rattling. The insult didn’t even make one of Catra’s ears twitch. “Be serious, Catra. Do you think for a moment that Micah or even that milksop Angella would–”

Catra's claws popped out, the effect all but ruined by her glossy scarlet trauma caps. "Insult my mother again," she hissed. "I dare you."

"Glimmer came to me," Shadow Weaver pointed out. "I know you would have examined her for magical influence."

"Just to be sure," Catra admitted. "We both know that magic isn't what *really* makes you dangerous."

Shadow Weaver blinked. In spite of herself, she smiled. "By the gods. I do believe that you finally learned something."

"Yeah. I did." Catra's trauma caps fell off one by one. Each bounced once on the wood floor with a notable clack before the next dropped. That was...rather more effective than Shadow Weaver wanted to admit. The elf held very still. "I want to help you, Shadow Weaver, Bast alone knows why. *But."* The guards looked more nervous than Shadow Weaver felt. "If you hurt Glimmer again? No one will ever know what happened to you."

It took all of Shadow Weaver's training to keep her laugh from sounding forced. "You would never disappoint your dear 'mother' that way, especially after your failed attempt on Hordak."

"I let you hurt Glimmer once, Shadow Weaver. Never again. *Never."* The trauma caps levitated off the floor and orbited the magicat's wrists. "Tell me you understand what I'm saying."

"Oh, I understand perfectly," Shadow Weaver agreed. "I do not believe you for an instant, but I quite understand."

Catra's claws twitched once. Shadow Weaver maintained her calm facade until the magical left, trauma caps returning to their places. The sorceress was grateful that the barrier hid how badly her heart hammered in her chest. *A dangerous game,* Shadow Weaver admitted to herself, *but I have not played any other kind since I was 19.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Shadow Weaver was more surprised by Adora's arrival than all the other visitors combined. *After this much time, I did not think she would ever…* The sorceress forced her wayward thoughts to heel, standing to face her student. "A*do*ra," she welcomed. The First One's features were frozen in stone, her body rigid. *Ah. Upset about something. Catra, or Glimmer?* Still, she smiled, allowing the expression to affect her eyes. Adora's jaw twitched once; she'd noticed. "To what do I–"

"–'owe the pleasure of this visit?' Spare me," Adora snapped. The Sword rested on her arm in its bracer form, but it hummed in the ether with She-Ra's displeasure. "You know why I'm here."

"Not entirely," Shadow Weaver admitted. Adora grunted once. "Tut tut. Lost all your manners in Brightmoon, did you? Pity. Is it Catra or Glimmer?"

Adora glared, stomping one step forward. "You think I don't know that you're messing with both of them? What are you *up* to, Shadow Weaver?!"

"Oh by the Maker," Shadow Weaver sighed. "I am teaching Glimmer in order to earn greater privileges as a prisoner. I certainly hope to earn a place in the court, but that will take decades given the enmity Angella has towards me."

Adora's eyes narrowed. "And Micah."

That stung more than Shadow Weaver cared to admit. "As for Catra, she visits for her own puerile reasons. Why should I not amuse myself with her antics?"

The Sword sprang to life in Adora's trembling hand. Shadow Weaver's guards gasped, reaching for their pikes. Adora turned a furious glare on the Sword, and it returned to its bracer shape. *Curious. A reaction rather than a deliberate threat.* Disappointment and frustration followed. *Catra has won. Adora is hers now. Even if I have no part in her demise, should Adora lose Catra within my lifetime, she will assume my involvement.* The

sorceress glanced away. *Eighteen years of work, for nothing.* The Runestone pulsed in the bracer. *Almost nothing. If I can touch the Master Runestone for but ten seconds...* Adora took a step closer. "That can't be all you're up to," she demanded.

Shadow Weaver blinked. "Whyever not?"

The elf's sincerity brought Adora up short. "You're...you're *Shadow Weaver.* You don't do small plans. It's what made you so terrible at logistics."

Shadow Weaver bristled at that. "Insults. Spare me. I am a reviled prisoner. Did you think I was born a master of my domain? I was always a person of import, but children have limits adults do not regardless of their genius. I learned to understand the full nature of my position, whatever it might be, at a young age. I will develop plans commensurate to my advances, I assure you, but for now my only plot is to spend more time in the libraries and gardens."

Adora was so shaken she didn't even respond. The Princess of Power simply turned and left. *What a waste,* Shadow Weaver sighed, returning to her gardening manual.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra looked tired when she walked in. Shadow Weaver observed carefully while she sat in front of the skywing elf's cell. "Glimmer's been visiting once a week, right?" Shadow Weaver took great pleasure in nodding. "Which means you don't need me to visit."

Shadow Weaver scoffed. "I never *needed your absurd charity."*

Catra's sigh was somehow less gratifying than Shadow Weaver expected. "Right," she huffed, turning to leave.

Glimmer appeared beside the magicat in a burst of sparkles. Catra yelped and jumped. "Sis! Perfect. You're right on time."

"What – you – on time for what?" Catra snapped. Shadow Weaver's eyes narrowed on the mismatched princesses. *I knew she had an ulterior motive,* the sorceress thought, long-banked suspicion roaring back to life, *but why would it have something to do with Catra?*

Glimmer smirked. "Shadow Weaver's lesson."

"Your lesson is tomorrow, Your Highness," Shadow Weaver replied. "I–"

"No," Glimmer snarled, eyes almost ablaze. "Today I'm giving *you* the lesson." She smirked at the magicat. "And Catra too, but she might enjoy hers."

Catra facepalmed. For once, Shadow Weaver sympathized. "Sparkles..."

"It pains me to agree with Catra, child, but you are being ridiculous," Shadow Weaver added. Catra, of course, hissed in response.

Glimmer turned to glare at Shadow Weaver again, but this time here gaze was colder than the entire Kingdom of Snows. "Am I." Her voice was flat and murderous. Shadow Weaver found herself genuinely concerned for her own well-being. "You spent a lifetime trying to ruin a child – your best friend's *daughter* – and I'm the one being ridiculous."

Alarm rang within Shadow Weaver. *She's up to something,* the sorceress realized. *She's been up to something from the beginning.* She cleared her throat. "That did not seem to concern you before," Shadow Weaver noted.

Glimmer's smile was as cold and sharp as Shadow Weaver's had once been. "That's because I didn't want you to see my 'concern,' witch," she replied.

Catra groaned and used both hands to facepalm this time. "I love you too, Glimm, but it's Shadow Weaver. She doesn't learn, it's

kind of her thing." Shadow Weaver glared at the magicat, hating her own lack of power.

"She'll learn this time," Glimmer said, voice low and dangerous. Catra looked back up, staring at her 'sister' in alarm. "I've been paying attention to her lessons, and there's one that stood out to me. 'Implications,' she calls them."

Shadow Weaver couldn't help it. She blinked again. "I 'call' them? And what do you call them, child?"

Glimmer's gaze, somehow, became colder. "Lies. No matter what Catra did, you told her it was wrong, but you never told her *what* was wrong."

"Princess Glimmer," Shadow Weaver sighed.

"I thought it was just sadism at first," Glimmer continued, ignoring Shadow Weaver's attempt to restore rationality to the conversation. "That you got some kind of sick pleasure out of hurting her. I mean, you're enjoying stringing her along *now* because you've got literally nothing else, but you actually believe all your crap rationalizations about 'teaching' her. Making her miserable to make her strong, because you think that's what you had to deal with it. *Lies,* witch."

That blunt insult wore at Shadow Weaver's patience. "Is that so? Then tell me, o all-knowing princess, what you believe the truth to be."

Glimmer smirked in triumph. "Oh, you had lots of reasons, I know. Bigotry towards magicats, love curdled to hate, all that garbage. Revenge on Kyra, but you're telling the truth about how unsatisfying it was. Using her to control Adora? Definitely. But you gave away the game with your biggest half-truth, way back in Mystacor – because she reminded you of yourself."

Catra gasped. "That's – wait, that's *why* she did it? I don't get it."

Glimmer's sneering grin vanished, and she turned to Catra with wide eyes on the edge of tears. "Oh, Wildcat," she whispered, teleporting into a hug. "It wasn't your fault. None of it."

Ah, Shadow Weaver realized. "I see. You're doing this as some sort of revelation for your supposed 'sister's' sake."

Glimmer released the magicat and whirled on Shadow Weaver, eyes literally blazing with enchanted light. "She is my sister, and if you *imply* she's not one more time I will break your nose right through that stupid mask." Shadow Weaver knew when she'd pushed a subject to her limit and stopped talking. "And the revelation is for you just as much, because for all your supposed insight, you're more blind to your real reasons than Adora was at her worst." That elicited a huff out of Shadow Weaver in spite of herself. "You know you're a monster. Somewhere inside, Light Spinner sees what Shadow Weaver is, and she's horrified. But you've buried whatever good was in you so deep that you can't even punish yourself subconsciously. So you take it out on Catra."

Catra and Shadow Weaver both stared. *No. NO!* The mighty sorceress took in a breath to retort, but at first all that came out was an outraged splutter. "That's – it's absurd – you cannot possibly – utter madness – it would be pointless!" Shadow Weaver blurted.

"The really weird thing is, I think it did hurt you a little to do it," Glimmer continued with a glare, ignoring Shadow Weaver's non-retort. "And that's what you got out of it. This perverse 'doing it for her own good' lie to her *and* yourself while you got that bit of revenge and pretended to get some kind of catharsis out of it." The princess crossed her arms. "How am I doing, 'teach?'"

Shadow Weaver had rarely been more grateful for her mask, denying the two princesses the sight of her gaping, jaw working helplessly. After several seconds, Catra laughed. "Stars, Glimm, you broke her!"

Glimmer laughed, hugging Catra again. "She literally did it to herself. 'Know your mark,' she taught me. I bet she never thought that'd be her."

"I – you – that is –" Shadow Weaver stammered.

"As much as I'm enjoying this scintillating conversation," Glimmer said with as much faux-sophistication as she could muster, "I do believe we're done here. Princess Catra?"

Catra looked from Glimmer to Shadow Weaver and back. The sorceress was utterly at a loss for words. Then Catra got this sly grin, and Shadow Weaver's innards churned. "I do still have one question, actually. What is a 'guttersnipe,' anyway?" Shadow Weaver could only stare while the insufferable princesses laughed.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Half a year.

Shadow Weaver had been in this cell for six months. Oh, Glimmer had kept her word on garden privileges, to be sure, but the sorceress was isolated even there. No one to work with. No one to ingratiate herself to.

No company but the accursed half-angel's revelation, and its corrosive, inescapable truth.

It had been a month since then, but this time, Shadow Weaver knew, Catra would not return. That had, after all, been the entire point of–

Soft footsteps punctuated by faint clacking sounds. Magicat footsteps. *No. She wouldn't. Would she?*

She would. Catra walked in with a tracker pad, and an incongruously sad expression. "Um. Hey, Shadow Weaver," she said, voice as soft as her fur.

Shadow Weaver stared in disbelief. “You’re here. Even after...why?” she asked.

Catra rubbed one arm. “Same reason as before. It could have been me in there, and no one deserves to be completely alone.” She twitched. “Not even you.”

“But – you believe that I…” Shadow Weaver trailed off. The guilt that Glimmer had rightly diagnosed as entirely unconscious had burrowed up to the surface in the month since her last visit. “But I hurt you,” she admitted at last.

Catra shrugged. “Yeah, but...you still let me be with Adora. Even if you only did it for her, that was...everything, to me. Even if I almost screwed it up. Anyway.” She waggled the tracker pad a fraction. “There were some pretty serious arguments about this, but I managed to talk the others into letting me give you a pad.” She rubbed the back of her neck. “I mean, I know you have library privileges and all, but I thought you might want, I dunno, some variety. Music, or plays or whatever.”

The guilt, manageable until then, threatened to tear free and swallow Light Spin – Shadow Weaver whole. *No. I will not cry. I will show no weakness.* She stood. *I can, however, show gratitude.* She held out her hand. “Thank you.”

Catra looked up in surprise, then produced a tiny, sad smile as she handed the pad through the force screen. “Sure. No problem. I mean, you’re welcome.” She took a step back. “So. I guess I should leave now...” Catra glanced to the door and back. “...if you want.”

Shadow Weaver sighed. *It is not as if my options are expansive,* she justified to herself. “I suppose you can stay,” she conceded, and for all Catra’s denials about craving her approval, the magicat’s ears shot up, “if you wish. I will confess that your magical prowess caught me off-guard while I still served the Horde. How did you overcome your...aversion to it?”

Catra’s smile beamed. She sat and levitated a book over to her. “Funny story. It actually started with my first trip to Mystacor. That feeling when Aunt Casta helped me fill myself with ether? I can’t even describe it.”

“No sorceress can,” Shadow Weaver admitted. “Either you have not experienced it, and no words are sufficient, or you have, and none are necessary.”

“Exactly!” Catra blurted. It reminded Shadow Weaver of the bright, eager child the girl had been in those first months before.... “And then I started casting spells, and it’s just, boom! Instant feedback. You did it right or you didn’t. It’s like magic teaches you all by itself!”

Her shining smile was so like Adora’s it ached. Catra was...she was...

What have I done?

Chapter End Notes

> Me: Shadow Weaver doesn't deserve a redemption arc
>
> Also me: But what would a Shadow Weaver redemption arc look like?
>
> Ugh. I hate Shadow Weaver with an all-consuming passion (and the SCOP version of her is going down SO hard), but my writer's pride demanded that I give this a shot. Also, I apologize for how long this took, but I have a "fun" condition called Bell's palsy where half my face stopped working right and it has messed me up something awful. Next time: my unapologetic homage to the 80s series with Vultak's Wacky Scheme! (That's not the episode's name.)

Vultak Attack!

Chapter Summary

> The Vultak misadventure. Vultak still hopes to overcome the Princess Alliance, targeting Peekablue yet again. Fortunately, the heroes are ready for him.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Eek! Help!" Peekablue cried, wriggling in what she hoped looked like fear.

Vultak sneered. "No one will save you this time, princess."

Peekablue took a breath to play along, only for his last word to derail her. "Wait, I'm 'princess' now? You misgendered me for 15 years!"

Dreer turned a sharp look on Peekablue's captor, but Vultak merely scoffed. "I'm not an idiot, Peekablue. I did that to weaken your resolve. Now that you've fully transitioned, there's little point in continuing." His sneering grin returned. "Especially since your willpower is irrelevant to our use for you." He yelped and cursed as Angella bombarded their transport with blasts of light. "Estra! Faster!"

"I can do that, if you *want* to die," Estra spat back, desperately steering to evade the furious angel's assault.

Hunga snarled and held her forehead with surprisingly delicate fingers. "No vehicle can escape Queen Angella in an atmosphere. It's a miracle we outran Sweet Bee."

Dylamug scowled. The sight spreading across his entire tors0 would have made Peekablue laugh if she hadn't been bound from

shoulders to ankles. “She’ll catch up soon enough. That Andreenid is obsessed with this ridiculous girly Gar.”

“Hey!” Peekablue retorted. “There is nothing wrong with being girly.”

Vultak fired a shadow-blast at the princess’ feet, eliciting a frightened shriek from her. “There is when you’re trying to pretend you’re a warrior, Peekablue. You’re nothing but a pathetic seer desperate for heroes to protect you.”

“Yeah, so pathetic,” she muttered, “it’s not like I’m going to be traumatized for the rest of my life after years in your box or anything.” Her ensuing shudder was all too real.

Estra joined in the scoffing this time. “Please. Even Vultak couldn’t have left you in a single cell all that time.”

Vultak turned a confused look on the inventor. “Why not?” he asked. It chilled Peekablue to hear the sincerity in his question.

Another blast rocked the transport. “Release Peekablue!” Angella demanded, her voice echoing right through the carrier’s armor. “The Alliance has little enough patience for you as it is!”

“Estra…” Dreer warned, casting a reinforcement spell on the transport.

“Twelve seconds!” Estra shouted back. Peekablue stared. *Twelve seconds? To what?*

“I’ll trade the seer for you, my queen,” Vultak retorted, using his shadow magic to make himself heard.

Angella’s pause frightened Peekablue more than anything the others had done. *Angella, you can’t!* the Gar sent.

The light from the driver’s cabin dimmed. “Ha!” Estra cheered, pumping a fist while her tentacles took the wheel. “Ditched her. We’re clear all the way to Tomb Rock.”

Dreer glared at Peekablue. “Should we talk this openly in front of Etheria’s most powerful telepath?” he asked.

Vultak smirked. “The metals in this mine interfere with the passage of psychic powers. They will learn nothing.”

-SR- -SR- -SR-

“They’re headed for someplace called Tomb Rock,” Entrapta reported, tapping away at Darla’s controls. Sweet Bee’s wings hummed with furious speed. Adora knew how she felt.

Catra nodded. “Good work, ET,” the magicat replied, going over Darla’s scanners while she flew. “Bee? You still in touch with Blue?”

Sweet Bee nodded. “The connection’s a bit hazy, but Vultak underestimated my beloved. Again.” She turned a sharp gaze on Netossa and Spinnerella. “You’re *sure* we’re not going to lose her again.”

“That’s why we planted a tracer on her, Bee,” Netossa pointed out, glancing towards Entrapta.

“The first sign of trouble, I’ll pull the plug,” Catra insisted. “I *promise,* Sweet Bee.” That mollified the Andreenid princess somewhat. They all knew how seriously Catra took promises.

Adora more than anyone. “You okay, Catra?” she whispered.

Catra scowled while Spinnerella calmed Sweet Bee’s nerves. “I think so. I’ll feel better when we prove Project High Ground worked.” She sighed and took Adora’s hand. Even after months of marriage, that simple act of comfort (for both of them) felt better to Adora than becoming She-Ra. “Ugh. Caring is hard.”

Adora smirked. “But you’re so good at it,” she quipped.

Catra glared at her. “The worst part is, I can’t even *joke* about wondering why I married you,” she admitted. That only made

Adora's smirk grow...

...but only for a moment. "It's still hard? Even now?"

Catra groaned. "How many times have we almost lost people, Adora? Bast, we got lucky with Entrapta–" the magicat froze for an instant, then her shoulders slumped. "Yeah, I was still a bad guy back then, but the point stands."

Adora huffed. It was almost exactly like Catra making the same noise. "You weren't a 'bad guy,' Catra," her wife insisted. Catra glared, but Adora only smirked. "Nope. Not gonna give you that one."

"What is wrong with you?" Catra grumbled, but it was without heat. She sighed. "I didn't think anyone had it worse than me until I met Dad and Peekablue. I really don't like this plan."

Adora took a breath – to reassure Catra, she thought – but Glimmer's voice came in through comms. "We're almost past Mount Candor. You're gonna want to see this."

Catra growled to herself and stalked over to the captain's chair, where Adora took her post. They crested the mountain, and...

"You have *got* to be kidding me," Catra blurted.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Estra's strange tunneler emerged from beneath Candor into a field of smashed grass, atop which towered...four mechanical legs?

"Behold, the Horde's latest weapon, the Tank Walker!" Vultak exulted. Peekablue angled her neck to look up the legs at the, yep, large tank atop the legs. Except it had two tentacles in addition to the massive turret and missile launchers on each side.

Peekablue couldn't help it. She laughed.

Estra glared at the princess, but somehow that didn't diminish Peekablue's mirth. "Seriously?" she asked. "Who looks at a tank and goes, 'you know what that needs? Feet.'"

To the princess' surprise, Vultak smirked back at her. "We have our reasons, my dear," he said, voice drenched in satisfaction. *Huh.* Peekablue watched with a critical eye while they approached.

The only other change appeared to be replacing the Horde's old spherical bots with bulky humanoid robots with a chrome finish. They had heads like finned helmets embedded in the torsos, their eyes barely peeking over where the flare armor where the neck would be if they had one. Peekablue's psychic powers filled in the term *bevor* for the flared neck armor piece. They still had humanoid soldiers, but there were few enough that she didn't need to be psychic to know why they'd supplemented them with bot soldiers. Except... "What's with the new robots?" she asked.

"They're more in keeping with the Galactic Horde's robot trooper model," Estra explained, no longer huffy due to the lack of mockery on Peekablue's part. "Thanks to my programming and hardware design," she continued, straightening in her seat (from pride, no doubt), "they also double as repair units."

Peekablue nodded back. "Now those make sense. I'm kind of surprised Hordak didn't use them." Her grin returned. "Entrapta's going to love those."

"Once we had sufficient resources, Hordak preferred specialization," Dylamug scoffed. "Simple designs were easier to manufacture. Probably a mistake."

"Nah," Peekablue replied, grin returning, "the Alliance will take them apart as easily as the ball-bots."

That earned her several glares. "The Alliance will never find you," Hunga snarled, "unless Vultak's master decides to imprison all of you together."

"And he'll find us in Despondos because…" Peekablue prodded. *They're not going to fall for that,* she wondered, *are they?*

"Why do you think the tank's on legs?" Estra crowed. "It is the perfect mobile antenna," she continued, while Vultak facepalmed, "utilizing Etheria's ambient magical energy to signal Horde Prime!"

"Will you please not feed intel to the psychic princess?" Vultak groaned. Estra blushed, eyes wide.

"Oh!" Peekablue gasped. "I take back my leg critique. That's actually clever. Mobile transmission without using a flying vehicle that asks to be shot down." She concentrated. *Princess Glimmer? Do you need any more information from–*

Brightmoon's princess appeared in a literal flash in response. The gathered Horde villains gaped. "Gotta go, my ride's here," Peekablue quipped. Before any of them could leap at her, Glimmer teleported them both back to Darla.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora smiled in relief while Catra and Sweet Bee cut Peekablue loose before Glimmer's magic had faded. "You are never doing that again," Sweet Bee said, throwing her arms around her fiancée.

"Catra?" Adora asked, transforming the Sword back into its usual shape.

"Weapons free!" Catra cheered. Entrapta cackled and pressed a button, opening the hatch. Several teleportations later, the gathered princesses were ready to literally leap into action.

"For the honor of Grayskull!" Adora chanted, becoming the Princess of Power. Swift Wind swooped down for her to leap onto, and the pair dove to carve through the Horde's new trooper bots. "Woo-hoo!"

"I'm just glad you're not jumping off of me at unsafe heights any more," Swift Wind called back, skimming the ground as She-Ra prepared to barrel into a knot of the robo-troopers.

The others had already joined in the fun. Netossa and Catra used their magic to ride platforms down – Catra hadn't brought Storm out of fear that Vultak would detect her – while the other princesses flew in under their own power. 'Tossa was already circling the Tank Walker with a nigh-unbreakable line while Spinny provided cover with miniature tornadoes. "How's this for a plot twist, Vultak?" Spinnerella quipped.

Netossa groaned. "Spinning puns, honey? Really?"

"I'm getting a bit bored with simple knockout counts, darling," Spinnerella replied with a smile, Adora smashed through a squad of troopers, sending wire and armor flying. "I thought we could ruffle their feathers with something else."

Hunga shrieked. "I'll show *you* ruffled, you ridiculous pink puffball!" She fired a volley of her blade-feathers at the wind princess, which was exactly as effective as Adora expected.

"Oh, you did *not* just come for my wife," Netossa snapped, throwing magic at the evil princess. Hunga yelped and retreated.

"Did you really think I wouldn't prepare for princesses, secrecy or no?" Vultak said, pressing a button on his belt. The tank's tentacles lashed out at the assault force, firing blasts when they weren't trying to entangle the heroes.

"Netossa! We need to wrap this up!" Peekablue joined in, her grin as wide as Spinnerella's.

Adora snickered while Netossa sighed. "I'll give you a pass, you've got the sense of humor of a teenager," Netossa replied, catching Dylamug in a net with a squad of troopers.

"I'm not sure how to take that," Glimmer noted, harrying Dreer with blasts from her staff. Then she grinned. "Not that it matters.

They don't have a *glimmer* of hope."

Catra, who had been studiously ignoring the quips while the Horde agents grew increasingly enraged, gaped at her sister. "Ugh! That wasn't even a pun, Glimm!"

Glimmer's smile grew. "Sure it was! Come on, sis, do a cat pun!"

Catra punched Hunga in the face, catching three of her subjects in a grip of soil. "No," Adora's beloved replied, deadpan.

Adora carved her way toward the frantic Vultak while Glimmer laughed. "Please, Catra? It'll be purr-fect."

"Hey, Netossa, can we give them to Scorpia?" Catra asked, using a rock to slam one robo-trooper through an entire platoon of them.

"Sorry," Netossa said, shrugging while she tightened her grip on the mechanical legs, "no substitutions, exchanges, or refunds. It was in my wedding vows."

"Hey, leave Adora out of it," Catra shot back, slicing through more robots. "She hasn't gotten into this craziness."

Oh, now I have to, Adora decided, smirking. Catra glanced over in horror. "Yeah, I'm too busy trying to *de-feet* this tank."

Mercifully, Vultak howls in fury, depriving Catra of the need. "I will not be mocked by you rebel scum!" he screamed.

"Hey, you're the rebellion now," Catra retorted. "We've got the world, and you've got a tank-antenna-thing,"

"Come on, Catra," Glimmer said, blasting at a mechanical tentacle, "you can do better than that!"

Vultak's eyes narrowed. "Open fire on the First Ones ship," he ordered. She-Ra gasped, her interest in quipping burned to the ground.

Catra, on the other hand, smirked. “Hey, ET. High Ground time.” Adora’s eyes widened. *Oh!*

Netossa cackled in a very Catra-like way while she tightened the lines wound around the walker’s legs. Entrapta was no doubt laughing as well when she returned fire on the tentacles. The entire Horde contingent gaped. “WHAT?!” Estra cried. The enormous machine wobbled.

Catra’s smirk redoubled as she launched herself at Dreer again. “ET cracked the shooting-while-flying curse thing. Hey, Adora.”

“That’s my cue,” Adora replied, matching Catra smirk for smirk, then shoulder-rammed a walker leg. The entire thing toppled over, crashing and breaking open. Damaged robo-troopers stumbled out through the cracks.

Vultak gaped at the ruins of his mobile transmitter. “My Tank Walker! Nooo!” He pumped both fists in the air. “Curse you, She-Ra!”

Catra burst out laughing from where she crouched atop Dreer. “Holy Bast! Did you actually just say ‘curse you, She-Ra’ like, on purpose?”

Adora joined in the laughter, unable to remember the last time she’d enjoyed a real fight this much. “I’d say that’s good practice…” her humor vanished. *We have to end this,* She-Ra realized. “...but you’re done.”

“That’s what you think!” Vultak cried. “Horde! Vanish!” His shadows leaped out to engulf all the living Horde forces, and they disappeared into the darkness.

Some of the princesses cheered, but Catra and Netossa frowned in sync. “Well, that’s going to be a pain in the tail,” Catra grumbled.

“We’ll have to bring Angella all the way in next time,” Netossa added. “Micah and Glimmer won’t like it–”

“Mom’ll be fine with us around,” Glimmer said as she appeared. “I just can’t believe *our Wildcat* didn’t join a competition.” Catra rolled her eyes. Glimmer smile and gaze took on equally sharp edges. “Oh well. I guess you had to be bad at something.”

That made Catra pause. “Well,” she said, crossing her arms. “If you’re going to make it purr-sonal.”

Adora gaped for a moment, then the entire group burst into laughter.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

“Did we get through?” Vultak demanded, glaring at the sparsely-outfitted cave around them.

Estra examined her monitors. “Hard to be sure,” she admitted. “We certainly did not receive a response.”

Vultak ground his teeth. *It will not end like this,* he thought, furious. *It cannot! I* refuse *to spend the rest of eternity trapped in this sinkhole of a reality! Lord Prime must hear us!* He sat with a weary sigh. *He must...*

Unbeknownst to Vultak, two galactic superclusters away, a figure with four eyes sat on the throne of a trillion worlds. He went over a signal received from a monitoring station in the orbit between Eternia and Oa, home of a lost planet.

And Horde Prime smiled...

Chapter End Notes

It's all fun and games until Horde Prime shows up...

Design notes: Most of you have probably guessed that the Tank Walker is a reference to She-Ra 1985, a bizarre weapon that appeared in a single episode. The "new" robo-troopers are based on the Horde Trooper design from the OG series as

well, though they showed up in almost *every* episode. The horrible quips are...obvious, I believe. ;-)

Next time: Season 5 BEGINS! After a year of joy and (near-)peace, Light Hope detects an anomaly unlike anything to penetrate Despondos before it. The true Horde wants Etheria, and the Princesses of Power are the only ones standing in his way. What price will they pay to stop the Emperor of the Universe from defeating his most ancient enemy once and for all?

The Probe

Chapter Summary

Season 5 begins as the Galactic Horde finds Despondos and Etheria! What terrible sacrifice will the Alliance have to make to save their world? Content Warning: MAJOR CHARACTER DEATH. Please note the tag change.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"The Junker Queen's snarl turns into a fierce grin," Catra said, moving the figurine up a hex, "and spins her lightning axe by using her magnetic gauntlet. 'So, the snowflake has teeth after all,' she says, crouching for a charge. 'I like it!' she laughs, then–"

"Wait!" Adora blurted.

Frosta glared at Adora, while Bow chuckled and Glimmer sighed. "Come on, Adora, I wanna get to the fight!" the Princess of Snows objected.

"That was in-character, Frosta, I'm trying to talk to her!" Adora explained, waving in Catra's direction.

Catra groaned. "She's not me, Adora. *Or* Huntara."

"But she's obviously 'inspired' by Huntara," Adora pointed out, doing actual air quotes, "and maybe there's a little of you in there?"

Catra rolled her eyes and grabbed some dice. "Yes, fine, *but* she wants a good fight, so you're gonna have to show her what you're made of before you can talk. Besides, there's no way I'm gonna deny Frosta the battle she's been looking forward to since–"

Entrapta burst in through the window. “Ah! There you are.” She shook her hair loose while the others turned and stared. “Brightmoon really needs more air ducts.”

Bow’s smile was tolerant, yet loving. “’Trapta, honey, we’ve talked about this.”

Entrapta’s blush caught Catra off-guard. “They’re convenient,” she muttered, twiddling her index fingers while she pulled tracker pads from multiple pockets with hair tendrils. “Besides! This is major data! We have a dimensional anomaly!” she continued, perking up.

Catra’s casual demeanor vanished, ears shooting up and tail lashing as she stood. “Wait, like, a ‘blip’ anomaly, or ‘like the portal from Cat-Ra’s timeline’ anomaly?”

“I don’t know! Isn’t it exciting?” Entrapta gushed. The others looked at each other. “Though based on the energy readings, my preliminary hypothesis is that it is closer to a ‘portal’ anomaly.”

Frosta pouted. “See you later, Junker Queen,” she sighed.

It took less than ten minutes to get everyone in on the war council. With her powers enhanced by her staff, Glimmer brought in Scorpia, Perfuma, and Mermista. The others appeared by hologram, another benefit of Entrapta’s passionate experimentation – and a lot of hard work from Kyle, who was becoming a renowned tech-master in his own right. *I don’t think I’ll ever get used to competent Kyle,* Catra thought, giving the virtual presences a quick glance. Most looked okay, though Hordak seemed distracted. Then Catra spotted DT going through multiple shapes behind him while Imp and Flutterina played in the background. *Oh,* she realized, almost smirking.

The data Entrapta pulled up on the map kept her focused. “Am I reading this right?” Catra asked, frowning at the parts she didn’t understand. The conclusion seemed pretty clear, though. “This says that something is sending a signal out of our entire universe.

And before that, something came *in,* like when Hordak and Adora showed up. How do we even have that information?"

"Some records survived from my ship," Hordak explained. "Light Hope provided corroboration." Adora tensed up.

"Hey, ET, can we hook up Light Hope to this thing?" Catra asked.

Entrapta blinked. "Light Hope's systems are the foundation of the network," the inventor explained. "Bow thought we shouldn't 'spring her' on everyone else."

Adora glanced away. "Meaning me," she muttered. "We really need to get her perspective," she added with more confidence.

Catra started to look around the table for confirmation – then saw that her mother was already doing the same thing. Glad only Adora and Felicia would recognize her blush, she stopped sticking her tail into Angella's work and sat down. Angella's brief glance toward Catra looked worried, but she took the cue. "Princess Entrapta, if you would?" the queen requested.

Entrapta did something on her tracker pad, and Light Hope appeared over the war map. *Don't call her "Lite Brite," she doesn't like it,* Catra reminded herself, but couldn't help a faint smirk at Cat-Ra's snarky nickname for the living hologram. "Administrator recognized," Light Hope said. Catra's smirk vanished. "What is your query?"

Adora's frown mirrored Catra's. "Let's start with 'are you okay?' Because you don't sound okay," Adora replied.

Light Hope's slight smile got the married heroes to relax. A bit. "I am simply being professional, She-Ra. Please state your query."

"The Galactic Horde successfully transmitted a probe into Despondos!" Entrapta gushed. Bow put a hand on her shoulder, and Entrapta sobered in an instant. "It has established a line of communication back to the outside universe. Do you have any data to share about this incident?"

Light Hope's smile joined Catra's in oblivion. "I was unaware of this incident. That is disconcerting. It should not be possible for an inter-dimensional anomaly to occur on Etheria without my knowledge. Analyzing."

"That sounds bad," Scorpia noted.

Entrapta shrugged. "It's more data. My current hypothesis is that freeing Light Hope from her programming shackles affected her access to some First Ones systems."

"Meaning stuff the 'Dread Ones' stuck in her," Catra hissed as she stood again, stamping down the protective wave she was starting to feel.

"Analysis complete." Light Hope's interjection brought a halt to the Super Pal Trio's crosstalk. "The probe utilizes a quantum entanglement communication system to maintain connection through the dimensional barrier. It is designed to permit hyperspace tunneling from Etheria's birth universe to Despondos and back."

A quan-tangle-what now? Catra wondered, but Entrapta brightened at the explanation. "Amazing," ET said, smiling. "The device must have containment systems beyond our ability to model if it can maintain an entangled quantum packet."

"Based on the energy flow and data transmission required to transmit starships into Despondos," Light Hope replied, "the probe most likely has four to five dozen entanglement packets."

Catra had never seen Entrapta shocked by technological advancement before. It did bad things to the magicat's stomach to watch her friend's jaw drop. "But...that...the resources alone for such a feat of subatomic engineering...I can't calculate them without computing systems. And more data."

"That sounds bad," Mermista drawled, as deadpan as ever.

“Horde Prime is ruler of the known universe,” Light Hope reminded them. “Given the extent of his empire a millennium ago and the information Hordak provided to the Alliance, my conservative estimate of his resources suggests an expanse of approximately 100,000 galaxies housing over 100 billion planets containing exploitable resources.” A hologram of Etheria’s old home system appeared, panning back until it was a starfield. “Once his scientists overcame the intellectual challenge, the logistics of building such a transmitter would be trivial for the Horde Empire.” The hologram panned back further to reveal the shape of a galaxy...then several...then the galaxies were dots like stars. Catra swallowed. “Further, it is likely that Horde Prime anticipates the destruction of his probe and is prepared to send others.”

Adora’s grimace was downright furious. “Let’s not disappoint him,” she said, bringing the Sword to life in her hand.

“Slow down there, princess,” Catra jumped in before Adora could jump into trouble. “It sounds like we’re dealing with a Galactic Horde fleet one way or another. ET, Light Hope, do we have any options besides Rebellion 2.0?”

To Catra’s surprise, Light Hope responded first. “We do,” the hologram replied, replacing her own image with one of the Etheria system. “Now that I am free of my programming shackles, I can reconfigure the planet’s First Ones defenses. Rather than harnessing the Runestones as a weapon, I can generate a force screen around the planet.” A shimmering blue sheath surrounded holo-Etheria. “However, even my systems cannot withstand unlimited Horde assaults indefinitely. We must therefore activate Project Reversion.” Entrapta’s high-pitched squee almost made Catra’s ears flatten against her head.

“Returning to the universe Horde Prime rules?” Queen Selina asked, one delicate eyebrow raised. “That seems reckless.”

“A calculated risk,” Catra explained. “Now that Prime can reach us in here, he can keep throwing those flying ships at Etheria until

the planet looks like the crater moon. Out there, we at least have a chance of finding allies."

"Horde Prime devastated Eternia and Oa, but was never able to conquer them," Light Hope agreed. "Princess Adora's existence proves that Eternia had at least one viable society at the time of her arrival. Each potential ally is one more than we have in Despondos." Queen Selina nodded, as did most of the others.

"I feel an obligation to remind you that Project Reversion requires attuning the Elemental Princesses to their Runestones in a manner identical to the method required to activate the Dread Ones' super-weapon," Hordak pointed out. DT waved from behind him with a wide smile. "There should be no remnants of Light Hope's counter-programming, but if we missed a single subversion crystal, the danger could prove catastrophic."

"We have several backup plans, big guy," Catra replied. "Queens Angella and Selina will turn over their Runestone bonds to their daughters, but they can jump in as soon as we need 'em. I'm a backup reconnection for both. Adora can use She-Ra's healing magic to break the connection between the Sword and the network. Light Hope's got extra Entrapta boosters to hunt down any loose mind-whammy crap." She paused. "Worst thing that happens is, we have to let Shadow Weaver leech off a Runestone until we get other stuff settled."

"That's actually pretty bad," Adora said. Catra could almost feel her working to not give Catra side-eye.

"Horde Prime is worse," Hordak said, though Catra could feel the effort he put into saying it. *I can relate,* she thought, remembering their handful of shared therapy sessions. *It was a lot for him to admit Prime was his Shadow Weaver.* He glanced aside for just an instant. "Prime's hubris is as limitless as the universe beyond. He truly believes it is both his right and destiny to rule it all, and he has come farther than any other to succeeding by several orders of magnitude."

"Which is why the risk is worth it," Catra reminded them. Angella smiled. "If Prime gets his claws on the Heart, what he'll do on purpose is way worse than anything we'd do by accident."

"Very well." Angella glanced around the table. "All of you know what to do. We shall signal you again when the time is right." Perfuma and Scorpia shared a mournful look, but everyone nodded, and the holograms vanished. Bow and Glimmer looked at each other in what Catra guessed was sympathy, then Entrapta snared the archer in one of her hair tendrils while Lonnie rushed – well, *walked very briskly* – to Glimmer's side.

Catra couldn't blame them, considering the relief she felt with Adora's sudden presence. "You okay, Catra?" she asked.

Catra smirked at her. "You're asking *me* that, princess?" Adora's expression fell. Catra's tail lashed, and she dropped the facade. "I'm just the backup. I'm fine. Are *you* okay?"

Adora nodded. *She's a little nervous,* Catra realized, *but it's normal pre-mission energy, not suppressed panic.* The magicat relaxed a fraction. "We've got a plan. A good one. It's just, Horde Prime is…" Adora glanced at the hologram. At a hundred thousand motes of light, each one a hundred thousand *million* Stars. Just one of those lights had millions of Etherias. And Prime ruled them all.

No. Not all of us. Not yet, Catra reminded herself. "Yeah. He's got a lot of stuff. But he's still one guy. Single points of failure, remember?" She nudged Adora with her shoulder, and her wife smiled back. "There's my Adora. Now let's go get him." Adora nodded, still grinning.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Bow couldn't pretend he wasn't worried.

As always, they had a great plan. Catra, Netossa, and Queen Angella (it was really hard for Bow to think of her as just "Angella," even though she'd been like a mom to him for so long)

were brilliant together. It took Bow a little work to really picture the old Horde Catra – that version of her was almost as alien to him now as Horde Adora. Only his kidnapping let pretend-villain-Catra live inside his head at all, and she *still* thought she needed to make up for...

No. Stop avoiding, Bow, he told himself, turning his attention back to the Crystal Castle and Entrapta. 'Trapta hadn't asked him for technical help for a bit, though she still kept one belt-wide lock of hair around his waist. It comforted them both, he knew, providing her an emotional anchor while it reassured him that she was safe. Emily hovered beside them with her two new pouches, one for tools and the other for arrows.

At least, 'Trapta was as safe as anyone on Etheria could be at the moment. Nothing had followed the probe yet, at least insofar as Catra's map and Peekablue's Farsight could tell. On the other hand, the holo-projector in Catra's hands displayed Vultak's entire Horde remnant gathered around a cylinder the size of Darla, one end of the chalk-white drone pulsing green from a long antenna. Catra scowled at the image again, tapping some commands into her pad.

Adora was unnaturally still – for Adora, anyway – holding the Sword in front of her as if trying to use its Runestone to see Prime's intent. Only her eyes moved, glancing at Catra with love and concern in between long staring contests with a rock. Bow could see her breathe if he concentrated.

"Spanner," Entrapta muttered. Bow pulled his spanner arrow from his quiver and handed it to the princess before she finished reaching out for it. They shared a brief smile.

"You have a *wrench* arrow?" Catra chuckled.

"Spanner," Entrapta repeated, sounding insistent.

Bow grinned. "Hey, you'd be amazed how effective it is against some of Hordak's older bots." Emily made some satisfied-sounding

beeps.

Catra grinned back, shaking her head. "Only you, Bow," she said, chuckling again. Her cheer vanished. "Three ships," she muttered. Bow let out a wordless questioning noise.

Adora, however, gasped. "She means that's the most ships we can handle if they can land troops. The 'resistance threshold,' we called it in the – in 'our' Horde," she explained. *Hordak's Horde was so much more than we realized.*

Adora looked to her wife. "That's it, Catra?"

Catra's nod was glum. "We haven't had the time or the training," she replied, her hiss almost too faint for Bow to hear. "Etheria has Darla and *one* squadron of competent fighter pilots. Yeah, we've got the angels and the Andreenids, but Mom's the only flier who can stand up to the Galactic Horde's speed and weapons." She shrugged. "Well, Spinny and 'Tossa are a match for a whole ship by themselves, but they have to be together, and…" Catra tapped something on her pad. Four ships appeared over holo-Etheria, and rained down blaster fire from the same orbit as the cloudmoon. "They could bomb us into submission. Or extinction. And Prime has, for our purposes, limitless ships."

"So our only hope is getting the shield up fast enough to keep him from overrunning us with numbers," Bow finished.

Catra's ears pivoted down, the end of her tail twitching. "Yeah." She looked from Adora to Entrapta and back. "And all I can do is plan for things we're trying to keep from happening while my wife works on not panicking."

Bow smiled. "She'll be fine. She has you." It still took enormous amounts of willpower not to squee when the hair on Catra's face flattened. *So. CUTE!*

"Bow, Catra, we have data!" Entrapta cheered. The two rushed over to where Entrapta was waist-deep into Light Hope's access shaft, feet shifting while she made adjustments. "According to

Light Hope's scans, the force screen will not stop the probe's signal, but it will block Horde ships from teleporting in. She calls it 'warping,' oh that is so classy."

Bow could feel Catra clamping down on her desire to rush Entrapta's explanation. "Okay, mostly good news. What do we do now? Is it time to activate the shield?" she asked.

"Well, it isn't *not* the time," Entrapta replied. Bow raised an eyebrow. "You should be aware that activating the force shield requires transporting Etheria back to the outside universe. That is not a mechanical requirement of the shield generation, but reconfiguring Light Hope's systems to give her authorized access to the necessary energy sources *without* escaping Despondos would take at least 64 hours."

"That's why you can't say that it *is* time to hit the switch," Catra muttered. "It's a strategic decision, not a scientific one." Bow's eyes lit up. *Oh!* Entrapta nodded and hummed in agreement. Catra took in a nervous breath. "Adora? You ready?"

"For me, sooner is better," Adora said, still glaring at the Sword's Runestone.

Catra nodded. "I'm calling it. Bow, send the signal, ET, Light Hope, do the thing."

Bow sent the "go" message from his tracker pad. Entrapta cackled with joy and used an arc welder on one of Light Hope's crystals. Light Hope appeared in the center of the room. "Balance configuration matrix repurposed," the AI reported. "Runestone countermeasures disarmed. Planetary alignment system control transferred to administrator She-Ra." Light Hope turned to Adora. "You have the power."

Adora swallowed. "Right. No pressure or anything. Bow?"

"When the princesses are in full control, Adora," Light Hope explained, "you will know."

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Glimmer glanced at where she held Lonnie's hand. Her mom and dad had their arms around each other's waists. "I'm not holding too tight," Glimmer suddenly worried, "am I?"

Lonnie chuckled. "You're strong, princess, but do you have any idea how many times I got beat up by Adora *and* Catra? I'm fine, and you've got this."

Glimmer's tracker pad sent the signal. With a gulp, Glimmer touched the Moonstone with the staff that held its sole independent shard. "Mom–"

Angella's smile was serene as the Stars themselves. "I have awaited this moment since they moment I first held you in my arms," the queen said. Her wings flared wide, and–

–Glimmer could *feel* Etheria. For an instant, it was overwhelming. She could sense every bird, every fish, every gnat and whale and blade of grass. In less time than it took her to blink, the awareness receded to a distant knowing. Glimmer's own wings had grown to the size of her mother's, and she could go to anywhere the light had ever touched. Even buried Halfmoon was within her reach, since her magic had been there. "Whoa," the princess gasped, turning to look at Lonnie.

The warrior was shielding her eyes. "Stars, girlfriend, turn it down!" Lonnie blurted.

Glimmer obeyed, pulling the magic back in. She felt a bit like a living moon herself. "Is that happening everywhere?" she asked.

Micah smiled. "I'm pretty sure it's just the princesses for now, baby girl."

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Felicia floated between the Tenantin, blue and gold flowing around her much like her foster sister. Earth and fire, changing magic and

stable cornerstones, all bent to her wish. It felt like the fire was in her veins. Her skin was stronger than steel yet fluid as silk. "By Saz," she whispered.

"That's my girl," Queen Selina whispered, her smile as bright as any moon. Princess Felicia thought she could take on the whole Horde by herself.

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Gosh, I wish Perfuma were here. Or Catra. Or Entrapta, Scorpia thought, pulling the full might of the Black Garnet into her powerful frame.

Fortunately, she wasn't alone. *"You can do this,"* Rogelio insisted. *"The Garnet belongs to* you, *and no other."*

"And Shadow Weaver can deal with it," an uncharacteristically bold Kyle added, nodding.

Scorpia nodded, smiling, and concentrated. The lightning leaped out, crimson and jagged – but then it wrapped around her, winding, comforting...embracing. Like a hug.

"I *am* a princess," Scorpia whispered, letting the tears trickle freely. *"I am a princess!"* she cheered, both pincers punching skyward. She was, quite literally, radiant.

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"Moonstone online," Light Hope reported. "Fractal Flake online. Heart-Blossom online. Sea Pearl online. Spirit Ember online by Mother Stone proxy. Black Garnet online." There was a pregnant pause. "All planetary Runestones online. She-Ra, you may activate Crystal Asteria when ready."

Adora knew. The Sword of Protection *called* to her, pulling, shining, *demanding* to be used. Worse, she knew that this inexorable vortex of power was not what she would be feeling if Light Hope hadn't undone the commands of her own people. The

next thing she felt was the power of the Heart – and oh Stars, she felt *sick* when she realized what the First Ones had done to Etheria. *They took something beautiful, miraculous and flowing and alive – and turned it into a weapon. They stole magic and forged it into a Sword.*

Inspiration thundered through Adora. *That's it! I can change the Sword!* She changed her Sword into a shield. Catra glanced over and let out a questioning *mrrp,* raising an eyebrow. Adora grinned. "We need a shield, right?"

Catra groaned, but she smiled all the same. "Time to save the world, dork," Adora's wife retorted, the tip of her tail curling.

"Yes, ma'am," Adora said, saluting with her free hand. Then she concentrated, picturing the terrible lance of power the Heart was meant to unleash. *No. That's not the real Heart. It's a shackle they mocked the magicats with by naming it after the true Heart of Etheria.* Imagining that infinite spear of power in her hand, Adora reshaped it, flowing it around all of Etheria. Something rumbled within Light Hope's systems, the last elements of hardware resistance defying She-Ra's control. "Right, the Despondos thing. I'm ready when you are, Light Hope."

"Beginning transit," Light Hope reported. The world spun beneath She-Ra's feet, and by the way the others teetered, they felt it too. Even Catra held out her arms a bit, tail lashing the way it did when she needed to keep her balance. The swirling stopped as suddenly as it began. "Transit complete."

It astounded Adora how simple the next part was. The moment she turned her attention back to her the image of the shield-bubble, the power rushed out. "Shield active," Light Hope reported.

"That's not all!" Entrapta cheered. "Look!" She pulled up another screen, this one a large overhead image of the sky. Five moons hung overhead, as they had before – but this time, countless lights shone beyond them.

“Stars,” Adora gasped. “Those are stars.”

Entrapta watched, head tilting sideways a fraction, while Adora, Bow, and Catra rushed outside. They all stared up at a sky unlike any of them had seen before. *Except...it’s like I can almost remember...this is how it’s supposed to be.*

“Wow,” Bow gasped.

“Whoa,” Catra agreed.

“They’re beautiful,” Adora whispered.

A larger white spark appeared in the sky, a brief streak behind it – no, not a light, more like a diamond-shaped moon reflecting Etheria’s glow. Then another appeared. Ten more. Dozens. *Hundreds.*

Adora’s eyes widened. So did her friends’. “That’s...a lot more than four,” she whispered.

“BATTLE STATIONS!” Catra roared, darting back into the Castle. Adora changed the Sword back to its default shape while Bow flipped his weapon into his hand. “Light Hope, status!”

“Approximately 3,700 Horde battleships have emerged from hyperspace to surround Etheria,” Light Hope replied. “Each has an average of 250 fighter craft, 10,000 clone troopers, and 10,000 automated drones, evenly distributed between flying and ground units.”

“Good thing the shield’s up, then,” Bow muttered.

Catra’s ears were flat against her head, tail whipping behind her in near-panic. Adora swallowed. “That’s a...*lot* of forces.”

“We can’t win a normal war against that,” Catra whispered. “It’s not even a fight. Light Hope, is there a command ship? Prime sounds like a top-down kinda monster.”

“Capital ship identified,” Light Hope reported, glowing blue for a moment. “Starcraft Carrier Jakus Nuru, commanded by High Admiral Glieeb-Tolio of the Beloved.” Catra swallowed, only worsening Adora’s nerves. “Code name: Mantenna.”

After a moment absorbing that, Catra laughed. Adora couldn’t help a snicker of her own, nor could Bow. “You made that up,” Catra accused, raising an eyebrow at Light Hope.

“I do not ‘make up’ data,” Light Hope insisted, sounding almost a touch huffy. “According to Eternian intelligence files, Admiral Tolio is a powerful mentalist, possibly stronger than Peekablue, and a highly capable strategist.”

Adora gasped. “Wait, did you say ‘Eternian,’ Light Hope?” She rushed over to the hologram. “Can you – do you know – my parents, my brother, are they okay?”

Light Hope flickered. “King Randor, Queen Marlena, and Prince Adam are all active in the resistance against the Horde and Evil Warriors.” Adora’s eyes filled with tears. *They’re – they’re alive!*

Entrapta squeed. “I have so many questions...”

Catra huffed. “Have any of the ships gotten through the shield?”

“No.” Light Hope dimmed for a second. “Vessel interdiction successful.”

Catra relaxed for an instant, ears flicking and tail curling. “Okay. So we’ve got some time. We’re gonna need to put a team together to knock out *Mantenna,* because apparently that’s a thing. A thing someone chose, because Admiral Tolio has a perfectly functional person name, but anyway. Once we take the Jakus Nuru or whatever, we mess up...a fleet that’s got more starships than all of Etheria’s ocean ships combined.” She ran fingers through her mane to center herself, and Adora fell in love with her all over again in spite of the dire situation. “We’ll have to split up the–”

Light Hope flashed deep blue again. "Alert. New vessels detected. Six – correction, twelve – hold please." Catra's eyes widened, tail lashing. Adora's grip on the Sword's hilt almost hurt. After several seconds that seemed to take minutes to pass, Light Hope returned to normal. "Update. Horde fleet has summoned 36 Devastator-class drill-beam projectors. They are designed to penetrate planetary defense screens and crack open the worlds beneath."

Adora, Bow, and Catra gasped. Entrapta's eyes gleamed like the newfound stars. "Faaascinating," she gushed.

"And bad," Catra added, jaw set and tail lashing with greater distress than ever. "Can they penetrate the shield? Will Prime just send more if we take them down?"

"It will take the Mantenna Fleet at least 1 hour to penetrate the shield given the power differential," Light Hope explained. Adora could almost feel the bottom fall out of Catra's stomach. *From 'never' to an hour. Oh, this is so not good,* Adora worried. "Based on available data, the collected Devastators are the sum total of the Galactic Horde's supply. Horde Prime rarely needs more than one in a single galaxy. It will take the Horde several months to build and deploy a single replacement."

Catra nodded with a frustrated growl. "Assuming we survive the next hour. Okay, new plan is a slight modification of the old plan. We still go after Mantenna, but our top priority is using his command center to devastate some Devastators. Adora, you're with me. Bow, I'm sending Perfuma and Frosta here to help you protect Entrapta." Bow looked conflicted for a moment before nodding fiercely. "We're going to need Glimmer and Scorpia to storm the Nuru. We'll also have Swift Wind and Silver Storm. Once we have the bridge, Entrapta, I'll turn the controls over to you and Light Hope."

"What do we do here in the meantime?" Bow asked.

"Whatever it takes to keep that shield up," Catra hissed. "Drills apply localized damage to widespread armor. Since this is a force shield, you should be able to focus the energy, push back against their assault."

Entrapta rubbed her chin with a lock of hair. "That makes sense," she muttered. "We're already redirecting power designed for a focused beam."

"Right. Let's go, Adora," Catra ordered. She-Ra nodded and walked beside her wife, trying to look confident. *We can do this,* Adora told herself, almost believing it.

They all missed Light Hope flash dark blue again.

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Glimmer swallowed just after they appeared in the strange Horde ship. The corridors were all polished steel lit in a creepy pale green. Even the Horde symbols were green instead of Hordak's red.

I'm not alone, Glimmer reminded herself. Adora in full She-Ra mode, her sister Catra, a Scorpia crackling with crimson lightning, Swift Wing, and a tiny Silver Storm curled over Catra's shoulders were all with her.

What they didn't have were enemies. No soldiers, either Hordak-alikes or regular troopers, no bots, not even flying drones came after them. "So...where are the bad guys?" Scorpia asked, as refreshingly direct as ever. Glimmer let out a breath she hadn't realized she'd been holding.

One of Catra's ears did that flick-twitch thing Bow cooed over. "I'm hearing a lot of bodies packed together up ahead. Sounds like it's mostly bots, but there's definitely some meat soldiers in there with all the metal."

Glimmer sighed. "Well, there's a lovely image I'll never get out of my head," she replied. "How are we doing this?"

"With that much steel, it's easy," Catra explained, pointing down the corridor that her godlike ears could apparently pick out individual Horde scum down. "Muscle first. Scorpia does her wrecking ball thing with the lightning while Adora does her She-Ra zap-magic on the Hordaks. We follow up with magical blasts. Swift Wind and Storm pick off stragglers. Once we breach the bridge, I help Scorpia hold the door while you and Adora blitz 'Mantenna.' Bast help me."

"Keep it simple. Got it," Adora agreed, and they followed Catra's ears. Glimmer blinked while they ran. *That's simple? Stars, the Horde was weird.* She grinned. *And here I am, following three princesses who used to be* in*the Horde.*

Dealing with the bots was hardly even a fight. Scorpia crushed most of them into a ball with her lightning, and Adora dealt with the rest. Glimmer and Catra barely managed to bring down a few of the flying drones before the battle was over. Punching through the armored door revealed a tougher fight, and Mantenna.

Glimmer was familiar with every species on Etheria, but Admiral Tolio was unlike any being she'd ever seen. He was an unfamiliar mix of reptile, insect, and centaur, with four legs, enormous ears, sharp fangs, and two-toned skin. Mantenna would have been fascinating were it not for the cold, deadly look in his eyes. "Ah. The traitors and the rebel princess," Mantenna noted, one eye extending from its socket about an inch. "Take them."

This time, there were clone soldiers, and they had more powerful weapons. It hardly mattered between the four princesses, Swift Wind, and Silver Storm. Even the admiral recoiled when Storm grew to Swift Wind's size, the two 'steeds' charging through the Horde's ranks.

That was when Mantenna unleashed his own power. Both eyes extended from their sockets, throwing around raw force Peekablue would have envied. He seemed to share a portion of her future-sight as well, based on his ability to evade them. "Hm. You

‘princesses of power’ are more capable than Vultak’s intelligence suggested.” Tolio focused his full psychic might on Catra.

With a howl of fury, Glimmer teleport-blitzed Mantenna, punching him with dozens of sparkle-blasts while the others dealt with his squad. Catra managed to draw a countermagic circle, disrupting Mantenna’s assasult. The princess of two kingdoms (three, if Adora’s parents still reigned on Eternia) reeled, but managed to hold herself together. “Impossible,” a retreating Mantenna snarled just before She-Ra slammed into him and brought him down. “What I do is no form of magic.”

Catra pulled off a sneer even in her dazed state. “Yeah? The ether disagrees with you. Got him Adora, Glimm?” Glimmer nodded.

She-Ra held the Sword over one of his eyes. Both retracted back into their sockets. “Oh, we’ve definitely got him,” Adora replied.

“Good.” Catra leaped over to Tolio’s computer, cast a scrying circle, and started punching in controls. “Heh. ‘What use could a spell of console understanding serve?’ Wait until Shadow Weaver sees this.”

Mantenna’s eyes narrowed. “Clever. More clever than I expected…” his smile was cold. “...but not more than I anticipated.” A green flash of light swallowed the admiral, and with that he was gone.

Catra stared. “Sekhmet!” she swore.

“He teleported,” Glimmer said, scowling. “No magic, but he still teleported.”

Scorpia wrung her claws. “Yeah, but you’ve got control of the ships, right Wildcat?”

With a scowl, Catra’s fingers sped up on the console. “The regular ships, yeah, but the Devastator things aren’t on the network, which doesn’t make sense because Prime’s whole thing is obsessive control!”

Speakers echoed with Mantenna's chuckle. "You poor thing," Tolio said. "Lord Prime rules all because he sees all. He knows he can trust his Beloved, and I read your files." The others paled while Catra's fur flared out. "Yours in particular, magicat. She-Ra might be intelligent and powerful, but you are *clever,* and that makes you dangerous."

"Yeah, how's this for clever," Catra muttered, transmitting orders for the regular battleships to open fire on the Devastators. "Light Hope, ET, a little help?"

Mantenna scoffed. "An obvious ploy. Devastators are the Horde's world-breakers. Their shields can withstand entire fleets." Catra pulled up observation screens, proving the admiral right. She hissed.

Glimmer's fists blazed with fury. "Maybe I can get us onto them."

Catra shook her head. "Of course you can. That's not the problem. We'll never take them all down before they punch through the shield."

"We needed five minutes to take this ship, and Tolio wasn't ready for us," Adora explained. "Even if we can keep that pace, we'll barely take down a third of them before the Horde reaches Etheria."

"Well we can't just give up!" Glimmer insisted, fists still glowing. "There's got to be a way to stop them!"

"They threw every planet-buster Prime's entire Horde has at us," Catra said, one fist trembling while her tail lashed. "I'm working on it, but unless we can hit them with the Heart *without* dropping the shield, this is going to be bad."

Adora's eyes widened. "Maybe I can do it." The others looked at her, eyes widening. "I mean, I can conjure a shield and keep the Sword at the same time now. This is the same thing, only – bigger."

“A lot bigger,” Scorpia added, rubbing the back of her neck.

A Light Hope hologram appeared in the control room. “Inadvisable,” she said. “Even as She-Ra, you are at your capacity in wielding the Heart’s power. Perhaps one day, you will be able to control such energy, but with your current abilities, you would not survive the attempt.”

Catra gasped. “Adora, don’t you dare.”

Before the stricken Adora could respond, Light Hope glowed a shining royal blue. “That will not be necessary,” the program replied. “Given a short amount of time, I can reconfigure Adora’s shield to reflect attacks back on the assailants.”

Glimmer cheered. Scorpia fist-pumped (or at least claw-pumped). Switf Wind pranced in place. Adora and Catra looked at each other, worry mirrored in each other’s eyes. “Light Hope,” Adora asked, “how can you do this safely when I can’t?”

Light Hope’s pause crushed Glimmer’s enthusiasm. “I cannot, but my ‘safety’ is not a priority.”

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra’s hiss didn’t hide her distress, even to herself. *Why are they* all *like this?* she raged, consumed with worry. “Great example you’re setting for Adora, Light Dope,” Catra snapped. “Quit being dumb and help me figure this out.” She went to the controls, working on taking control of the regular fleet’s ships.

“Our situations differ significantly,” Light Hope replied. Glimmer and Scorpia looked at each other, hoping the other had an idea. Adora’s grip on the Sword tightened enough that her knuckles were almost white. Swift Wind whinnied with distress of his own, stamping in place. “I was aware of this possibility and have accepted it.”

“Well I *haven’t!”* Catra snapped, turning several battleships on each of the planet-busters. “You’re one of us, and in case you

haven't noticed, the Alliance doesn't leave its own behind. Not even me."

Adora looked up from the Sword. "Catra!" she cried, magic rippling around her. *Oh. She's trying to protect Light Hope with She-Ra's magic. Clever,* Catra thought.

"Don't pretend I wasn't the bad guy, Adora," Catra replied, noticing Mantenna's counterattacks on her stolen forces. She worked around them as best she could, ordering clones to abandon ships before using them to ram the Devastators. She wasn't doing anything more than scratch damage.

Light Hope's expression showed real emotion for the first time since she admitted dragging Adora from Eternia. "My failures outweigh yours by far, Catra, but let us set morality aside for a moment." That gave Catra pause, and she looked up at the hologram. "I am tired, child. My purpose was programmed into me, then reprogrammed against my will. I fell in love, and was forced to betray that love. I was trapped, locked away from my entire universe and all my sisters, alone for a millennium. I would not discard my existence without reason, but there is no other way. Either I make this sacrifice, or She-Ra does."

"No!" Catra sobbed, ripping gashes through inert parts of the console. "We can figure out something else if you let us!"

"Entrapta and Bow contacted Mystacor. Etheria's magic and technology combined remains insufficient to this dilemma in the time remaining." Light Hope flickered. "How would you feel, if you had to live a thousand years without Adora?"

Adora gasped. Catra fell paralyzed, and she probably knew the sensation better than anyone on Etheria. "You saved me, Light Hope. There's no way I'm not saving you!"

Light Hope smiled. "You already have, Catra." Her flickering intensified. "Thank you. For my freedom. For Adora. For *everything."* She vanished.

Catra whirled to activate the comm link. "Entrapta! We need options!"

There was a long pause on the other end. "I'm sorry," Entrapta said.

"There's nothing we can do," Bow added with a sniffle. "You need to get back inside the shield before..."

Catra and Adora looked at each other, both minds racing. *We can't let this happen, not now! I don't care what any of them say, there has to be a way to save Light Hope!*

"Forgive me," Glimmer whispered, and shimmering light carried them all home.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Light Hope ran more simultaneous calculations than she ever had before, even when Mara transported them all to Despondos. In all of Eternia's histories, there was no record of the Horde deploying more than six Devastators at the same time – and they were only known to have used that many four times in their billion years of existence.

Any one of them, Light Hope's sensors told her, could crack a continent. Two could obliterate a world. More than that was overkill unless a planet's defenses could hold them off. Like, for example, Etheria.

Light Hope's original plan had been to reflect the attacks back on the Devastators. None of their defenses could stand up to their own world-breaking cannons. There was one quite significant dilemma regarding her original plan, however: if a single attack penetrated Etheria's shield, it would ravage the planet. *Mara would have said 'devastate,' then formed an awkward grin,* Light Hope thought. If she had been an organic being, she would have smiled without thinking.

Light Hope never did anything without thinking. For the first time, she imagined that natural reflexes have advantages.

It was fortunate for her new plan that it required neither the Devastators to fire nor herself to act in a spontaneous manner. The concept was simple in theory: rather than wait for the Horde ships to fire, channel the reflective energy up through the weapon systems into the Devastators. Attempting to wield two planetary systems through the Heart simultaneously was the danger. She-Ra could not be compromised in this manner. Adora...*I will not allow her to perish now, when her life has begun at last.* She would take one final secret to deletion: how much Adora and Catra reminded Light Hope of Mara and herself. *Please be happy for us.*

In one last act of self-indulgence, Light Hope formed a hologram on Mantenna's bridge. The Rebrunkan extended a single eye slightly, a gesture equivalent to raising an eyebrow. "The artificial intelligence. What is the meaning of this?"

"An extremely unprofessional act," Light Hope confessed. "I am gloating."

Tolio scoffed. "Prematurely? I have already detected your feeble attempt to reflect the Devastators' attacks. Futile. How can a synthetic being, even one as ancient as you, be so foolish?"

"Slight amendment," Light Hope added, shifting the energies in the shield. Crystals maintaining her integrity began shattering the moment she began. "I am destroying your vile engines at this very moment." Mantenna turned his attention to readings, his jaw dropping while her image flickered. Light Hope's last expression was a smirk, copied as directly from Catra as her digital face allowed. "It was fun distracting you, though." Mantenna screamed in fury and frustration.

Reality glitched, blurred, and dimmed. Somewhere in the dark, though, a light shone in the distance. The light grew to reveal three towers rising over vast green fields, all gleaming beneath a beautiful azure sky. As this apparent paradise grew closer and

took form, one humanoid figure came into focus, her smile joyous and arms outstretched–

Mara!

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra screamed and punched the war table. Adora held her while she sobbed.

Glimmer had reunited the princess through rapid teleportation. From what Adora could tell based on the holo-globe, Light Hope's sacrifice worked. All of the Devastators were gone, and what remained of the fleet was in disarray. Ships were fleeing in ever-increasing numbers. Based on what Light Hope told them, it was a victory unlike any in the history of the Horde.

And all it cost them was the woman who'd saved them countless times. *It's not fair,* Adora raged, still hugging Catra while looking around the table. Perfuma cried into her hands, Scorpia giving the flower princess a one-armed hug. Mermista glared at the map, Sea Hawk holding her hand while tears welled in his eyes. Frosta curled up in her chair, her gaze bleak. Glimmer stared aimlessly, Micah offering comfort from one side while Lonnie rubbed her back from the other. Bow had just taken his seat; Entrapta was in her room, still mourning.

Only Queen Angella remained stoic, the droop in her wings belying her calm demeanor. "I understand that this is little comfort, but Light Hope's sacrifice was not in vain. Etheria's skies are clear of Horde vessels. Based on information from the First Ones' network, it will take the 'Beloved' several years to replace the lost Devastators. Our world is safe for the time being."

Catra took in a long, shuddering breath. "Yeah," she whispered. "Okay. Let's assess." She punched in some commands, and the map image zoomed out to display all of what Entrapta called a 'solar system,' with several planets orbiting a new daymoon called the sun. "So the daymoon shut down or something to make up for

this star-sun thing. When Entrapta's...better, she can go over our options for using it to defend Etheria from a second invasion. Until then," she continued, taking a deep breath, "we should prioritize alliances." She pointed out the two worlds with orbits nearest Etheria's. The one farther our was labeled "Oa," and seemed barren except for an energy signature rivaling the power of the Heart.

"As impressive as the readings from Oa are, it's the planet one 'orbit' closer to the sun that's our best bet." Catra pointed at the large, warm, diverse world in question. "This is Eternia. Based on our intel, the First Ones are still here, alive and mostly well. They're still fighting the Dread Ones, but we can help them with that, and then they can help us with Prime."

Adora nodded. "Okay. Unless anyone objects, we're going to Eternia. We'll deal with the Skeletor, ally with the First Ones–" *and hopefully, my parents,* she thought – "and put an end to the Horde's tyranny. *For Light Hope."*

"For Light Hope," they all agreed.

Chapter End Notes

So that happened...

Don't worry, I'm not going to go grimdark on you. I'm not planning on having any canon SPOP characters die who didn't die in the series, if that helps. I've been planning this for a while, and it felt appropriate to give Light Hope closure. (Also, anyone who's seen Revelations probably has an idea where she ended up.) Updates probably aren't going to come any faster any time soon, since I've had some serious throat issues on top of the Bell's palsy. Yay. At least that seems to be getting better finally.

Next time: the Eternia Saga begins! Adora finally meets her family, including loving parents, a wonderful brother, and an uncle who's the most dangerous villain in the universe this

side of Horde Prime. But who's this boy She-Ra they've got defending the last free First Ones? Find out in Eternia Saga I: the Most Powerful Man in the Universe!

Eternia Saga I: the Most Powerful Man in the Universe

Chapter Summary

> In which Adora and Catra completely derail MotU: Revelation and carve a new path for Eternia. Because there's no way Adora's going to lose her birth family now that she's found them and they're not jerks, and there's no way Catra's going to *let* Adora lose them.
>
> Now if only Catra didn't see old patterns reappearing with Adora's father and brother...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When Adora walked onto Darla's bridge, Catra was still using her comm screen. *And she complains about me overworking,* Adora griped, striding towards her wife. "I said *no,* Peekablue," Catra insisted, crossing her arms. Darla herself was still on autopilot. "You're doing more than enough as Etheria's human early-warning system."

"But as a Gar–" Peekablue tried again.

"We are not indulging any speciesist crap," Catra replied. "I get it, you're trying to use your ancestors' privilege for good, that's great, you still haven't recovered from *15 years* of Vultak. Stay with Sweet Bee." Peekablue lowered her head and nodded. Catra exhaled and shut off the comm, then leaned on the console, one hand over her eyes.

"So," Adora said, causing Catra's head to dart back up, "while we're on the subject of self-care..."

Catra looked away. "Adora. I need to work. I have to – whenever I stop, I think of…" Slowly, gently, Adora wrapped her arms around

her wife. After several seconds, Catra mastered herself. "Okay. Listen, Adora, we're on final approach to Eternia. How are *you* doing?"

Adora let go and shrugged. "It's weird. I'm sad about Light Hope, obviously, but my feelings about her are more...complicated than yours." *What with the whole "kidnapping me as a baby" thing.* Catra took a deep breath and nodded. "And I know I'm supposed to be freaking about now that I'm finally going to meet my birth family – probably – but I dunno, it's just not real yet."

Bow walked onto the bridge. "We should be in sensor range of Eternia in a few minutes, Adora," he reminded her.

Adora nodded and dropped into the captain's chair. Mara's chair. *This is it,* she thought, but the nerves still hadn't kicked in. "I know. Is everyone ready?"

"Entrapta and Lonnie are in the engine room," Bow explained. "Scorpia and Sea Hawk are in the kitchen getting last-minute food and preparing themselves. Glimmer, Perfuma, and Mermista just finished going over the little we know about Eternia's royal protocols." He smiled. "It sounds like they're pretty laid back for royalty."

Adora let out a breath she hadn't known she was holding. "I'll take all the good news we can get," she said, one hand lightly tapping her armrest.

As if it had been waiting for Adora to relax, the alarm sounded. "Distress signal detected," Darla reported. Bow yelped and raced into the gunner's seat. Catra groaned.

"Report!" Adora ordered.

"The Skeletor has breached Castle Grayskull. Evil Warriors engaged in full assault. Reinforcements urgently requested," Darla explained.

"On it," Catra said, flying Darla into a steep descent. "Huh. Eternia's systems are good. I have a location for Castle Grayskull." She turned a brief grin towards Adora. "And hey, now we know what honor you're fighting for." Glimmer appeared on the bridge in a burst of light.

"Incoming drones," Bow reported. "Trying to signal – never mind," he sighed, Catra spinning Darla to avoid blaster fire. Bow returned fire in several quick bursts. "And that takes care of the drones."

"They came from Team Skeletor, not like we didn't know who the bad guys are," Catra added, her grin growing fierce as they approached the surface. A decent-sized army was besieging – *You're kidding,* Adora thought, staring at the castle with a gray skull shape covering its entire front wall. Twin First Ones crystals hovered over the front towers, unleashing blasts on the siege while thousands of troops returned fire. "Not exactly Brightmoon, is it?"

"Get us down there, Catra," Adora ordered. "Bow, weapons free. Entrapta, keep Darla in one piece. Everyone else, with me." She glared at the image of the Dread Ones attacking Mara's legacy. "We're going to teach that Skeletor a lesson he'll never forget."

"I can't teleport everyone down at once," Glimmer reminded her, "but I can bring us down in pairs."

Adora nodded. "I'll go first, then Perfuma and Scorpia, then Mermista and Sea Hawk. Join me with Lonnie." She grinned at Catra. "Don't take too long, kit, or you'll miss all the fun."

Catra laughed for the first time since they lost Light Hope, the sound warming Adora's heart. "Like that would ever happen."

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra and Bow had just barely managed to land Darla and join the fight when the not-ridiculous First Ones showed up. *Seriously, the Skeletor guy makes all his soldiers wear jackal skulls or whatever for helmets? That's messed up even by Horde standards.* She

couldn’t help but admire some of their armored vehicles, though. The hovercraft with the spinning blade around the whole thing were pretty cool, and those micro-fighters smaller than Swift Wind made large-scale aerial attacks economical. The pseudo-tanks with the catapult-like arms that didn’t actually shoot anything, though? Those were ridiculous.

Fortunately, the good guys had an actual army of their own. *That’s refreshing,* she noted, the foot soldiers’ orange-and-green armor easily distinct from the Dread Ones’ purple. There was an Adora-like brunette leading some elites into the battle while Perfuma and Mermista created barriers that stopped the enemy cold. Catra leapt from one grunt to the next while she helped Bow reach Glimmer. *Entrapta will be fine,* she told herself while she rushed toward She-Ra. Adora was most of the way to Castle Grayskull.

An old guy with a mustache that could eat Sea Hawk’s for breakfast turned to look at her. “Identify yourself,” he demanded.

Catra huffed. “You’re welcome,” she retorted. “We’re from Etheria.” Dude gasped in surprise. “The golden goddess saving your castle is Adora, who’s She-Ra right now.” Dude was even more surprised by that. “Ligh–Dread Ones tech stole her when she was a baby. We just got – look out!”

One of the wrecking ball tanks darted in front of mustache guy, driven by a magicat-looking dude so ginormous he made Uncle Percy look small. Catra tackled mustache guy out of the way, but a human muscle-tank like boy She-Ra *caught* the wrecking ball and threw the whole tank. Magicat-looking-dude jumped up and pulled out a whip, cracking it. Catra laughed. “Nice whip. I think I’ll be taking it.”

“You will take nothing from Beast Man but – agh!” Catra never found out what she ‘would’ take from Beast Man, because the absolute *biggest* cat she’d ever seen tackled him. With a sigh, she rushed past them to catch up with Adora. He-Ra smiled with a

cocky grin that was almost exactly like Adora's and turned to face the entire army.

"You're with Adora?" Mustache man asked while ran towards the castle behind Catra. She nodded. "I'm Duncan."

"Catriska," she replied, not willing to get into the whole 'Catra' thing with him. "I'm her wife – holy Bast, Adora!"

Adora was just finishing off a robot that looked like a cheap He-Ra knockoff and his...robot horse? "Catra, you made it," she replied with the same cocky grin.

Catra grinned back. "Duh. Who's the bird lady?"

"The Sorceress," Duncan said, and Catra could *hear* him capitalize the title. "Are you all right?" he called to her, and Catra picked up the love and worry in his voice. "Did they hurt you?" The Sorceress smiled back; clearly, the feeling was mutual.

When Catra caught the scent of dark magic, she tackled Duncan again, this time shoving him out of the way of a lightning blast. "Shadow Weaver!" she howled, Freezefire in one hand and Earthshadow in the other.

Duncan's assailant de-cloaked, and she was...not Shadow Weaver. Her magic smelled a lot like Shadow Weaver's, but she was all direct power instead of cunning and cowardice. *She did go invisible, though,* Catra reminded herself. The witch smirked. "A magicat? How quaint," she said, firing another bolt.

Catra smothered it with Earthshadow, wiping the smile off the witch's face. "Please, I could tank that crap when I was twelve." Then the brunette dressed like She-Ra took down the evil sorceress in three moves.

"Good work, Teela," Duncan said. "I'll contain Evil-Lyn. The rest of you, find Skeletor!" He pointed at the stairs leading down.

Adora (being Adora) leaped down to the next level. It was eerily pretty, a wide shaft of mirror-like crystals embedded in walls covered in plants. *Perfuma would loves this,* Catra thought as she raced down the stairs to follow, Teela close behind, only to find She-Ra pressing Sword-to-staff with a guy who *had* to be Skeletor.

The guy had a skull for a head, which you'd think would be enough, but he was wearing a purple cloak, had a harness with a skull and crossbones thing in the center, and his staff was topped with a ram skull. *All in on the skull thing, huh,* Catra mused, while he pushed futilely against She-Ra's defense. "What are you supposed to be," he snapped, somehow glaring at Adora in spite of his lack of eyeballs, "She-Girl?"

"It's She–" Adora pushed back with all her power, throwing Skeledork back several steps, "–Ra!" She glared back, and Catra realized she's only looked that mad at Shadow Weaver before. "Uncle Keldor."

Catra winced – *Oh, right,* she realized, remembering Light Hope telling them this part – but the Skeletor guy froze, jawbone dropping. "Adora?" he whispered, eyeholes widening. "How?"

"It's a long story," Adora replied with her trademark smirk. She pulled a fist back. "I'll tell it to you when you're in prison."

Skeletor caught her punch in some sort of magic hole, and Teela had to dodge the blow when it came out of another hole beside her. "You know," Skeletor said while She-Ra yanked her arm back, "I take pride in my evil. Spreading fear, crushing hope, it's all part of the Skeletor gig!" He chuckled and dodged back out of Sword-slash reach. Adora and Teela moved in side by side, nodding to each other. "But I must confess to a single, solitary flaw in my otherwise-pure villainy."

Teela's eyes narrowed. "Children. You don't go after children."

Skeletor laughed. "Score one for the cheerleader in the epaulets!" He turned serious in an instant. "So if you want to fight me, dear

niece, make sure you're doing it for the right reasons."

"You didn't give me to Light Hope," Adora whispered.

"I didn't give you to Light Hope," Skeletor agreed. "Besides, I would never use anything with a name that dumb!" He laughed again.

Catra wasn't amused. She leaped onto his shoulders, raked his back with her hind claws, and tore grooves in his skull with her fore claws. While he howled in pain and fury, Catra leaped to her Adora's side. "You sure you should be making fun of other people's names, Skele-dork?" she quipped, summoning the frostflame to hand again.

"A magicat?" Skeletor yelped. "How many of you Etherians are there?"

He-Ra leaped down and smashed Skeletor into one of the wall sections that didn't have any crystals. "Don't you have other problems, Skeletor?"

Skeletor spat out some dirt and turned to face Muscles. "He-Man!" he blurted, eyeholes widening again.

Catra laughed. "Wait, wait, you call Muscles *He-Man?"* Adora groaned at her wife's signature cackle. He-Man merely shrugged. "Okay, *his* name you can make fun of." She crouched. "At least, while you still have a jaw. Ready, Adora?"

"Be nice, Catra," Adora said. "Well, to He-Man. With Skeletor, let yourself go."

"Bah!" Skeletor snarled, slamming the butt of his staff onto the stairs. A purple cloud enveloped him. He-Man leaped into the cloud, a clear and familiar impulse, but he came out the other side, and when the cloud was gone, so was skull-head.

"Well. At least we drove him off again," He-Man said. He grinned and offered Adora a beefy hand in greeting. "He-Man."

Adora took it. “She-Ra.” They did a little bit of jock strength-testing, eliciting mirrored eye-rolls from Catra and Teela alike, but neither overdid it, so Catra didn’t call Adora out for it.

He-Man’s giant cat partner leaped down and Muscles got into the saddle. “I’ll be in touch,” he said, flashing a salute even Catra was forced to describe as ‘jaunty.’ Adora responded with...finger guns. Catra facepalmed, but couldn’t help the smile that formed beneath her hand. *I married this dork,* she thought, no longer trying to pretend the feeling didn’t fill her heart to bursting.

Duncan-the-mustache jumped down right after He-Man leaped up. “Well. Excellent work all around.”

Teela scowled. “Not quite. It wasn’t exactly a banner first outing as Man-at-Arms for me.”

Duncan beamed at her. “I told you before, Teela, that today was the proudest moment of my life. That hasn’t changed.” The smile vanished when he turned to face Adora. “That said, in spite of Skeletor’s near-success today, I’m afraid your first day as the royal family’s sword isn’t over yet. Is it, Adora?”

Catra darted between Duncan and Adora, keeping her hiss to a minimum. Adora put a hand on Catra’s shoulder and let She-Ra go. “Um...maybe?” she asked, her smile a familiar sort of awkward. “Light Hope said my parents are still alive here, and my brother?”

“Father, what does this have to do with – wait.” Teela looked from Duncan to Adora and back. “You don’t mean...”

“I’ve already scanned her,” Duncan explained. “She’s telling the truth. Which means we have a very delicate announcement to make to the royal family.” He offered Adora a modest bow. “Or should I say, the rest of the royal family. Princess Adora.”

Teela’s eyes bulged wide. Adora gulped and nodded. Catra sighed. *Oh, here we go.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

The Etherian heroes faced the massive gates to the royal courtroom, standing in a courtyard that rivaled anything in Brightmoon. Adora's nerves were a greater enemy than the entire Horde had ever been. *I'd rather fight Hordak, Shadow Weaver,* and *Vultak. In the Fright Zone. Without the Sword.* She made a fist so tight it hurt. *But still...I want this, too. So much. Ugh! Why am I such a mess?*

Catra's hand slide over her fist, gently coaxing her fingers apart until they could twine them together. "Hey. Adora," she whispered, and her anxiety...was still there, but it receded to a more manageable terror. "It's fine. We're here. You're gonna be okay, no matter what happens."

Adora looked into Catra's eyes, the most beautiful sight in the universe *(yes, I'm biased, so what?)*, and smiled. "We can get through anything because we have each other," she whispered back. "Our real promise."

Catra nodded. "Our real promise." Duncan didn't quite glance back over his shoulder, but Adora thought – felt? – that he radiated sympathy. Teela was behind them with an honor guard that included a woman whose arms were also wings, two cyborgs that Entrapta had finally stopped gushing over, and an Andreenid warrior. They all seemed wary, but Adora didn't think they were hostile. Duncan looked particularly hopeful behind his helmet and forced neutral expression.

Then the huge doors swung open, and the pair who *had* to be the king and queen emerged. Adora's heart sank. *Not much of a family resemblance,* she thought. *Maybe Light Hope was wrong?* Still, the king's smile was wide and friendly, while the queen's was more clever and knowing – almost like Catra's, which immediately endeared her to Adora. In spite of her anxiety, the soldier in her noted their combat-ready bearing with approval. *They've both seen battle, and they're still in good shape,* she noted. "So," the

king said, “these are our Etherian heroes, who appeared in our darkest hour.”

Catra cleared her throat, and Glimmer strode to the front of the group. Most of Adora relaxed. “Your Majesties,” Glimmer said, offering a shallow bow. “I am Princess Glimmer of Brightmoon. We have come to both offer and request alliance, in the face of the Dread Ones and the Horde.”

The queen smiled. “Greetings, Princess Glimmer,” she replied, bowing to pretty much the exact depth Glimmer had. “No need to be so formal in Eternos, though. Duncan probably told you this, but I am Marlena, and this is my husband, King Randor the First, protector of Grayskull.”

Randor snorted an almost-laugh. “Ha! Protector, she says.” He gave her a quick kiss on the cheek. “I do my best, but I fear Eternos relies on He-Man and the Defenders of the Universe:”

“They, like, seemed to be doing okay against the bad guys. It looked like skull-head only got in to the skull-keep with a sneak attack,” Mermista replied. “So what’s up with Eternia and skulls, anyway?”

Several Eternians locked onto Mermista, but Queen Marlena laughed, breaking the tension. “They way they told it to me,” Marlena explained, “before the Skeletors, the skull was a symbol of devotion so deep that even death could not overcome it. And then, well, Skeletors.” That earned a fair amount of laughter. Adora managed a smile, but her nerves were kicking into overdrive. “So you must be the She-Ra,” Marlena continued, and her smile spread, growing warmer. “You don’t need to be so nervous, dear.”

Adora swallowed. “Adora,” she blurted, and both monarchs froze. “Sorry! I didn’t mean to just – blurt it out like that! It’s just...that’s my name. Adora. And I...”

“She was told by several of those who served as something akin to caregivers,” Duncan explained, "that she appeared from a portal created by Etheria’s Light Hope system.” Catra flinched.

“We got confirmation data from the Crystal Castle,” Entrapta added. “Data never lies.”

Randor had gone pale. “I...we still need to be certain,” he whispered. “Records can be forged – Dread Ones reprogrammed several Light Hope units across the galaxy...”

Marlena’s eyes were wider than Catra’s, and then...she began to sing. “Hush, little baby, don't you cry, mama’s gonna sing you a lullaby. Hush, little baby, don't say a word, mama's gonna buy you a mocking-bird. And if that mocking-bird don't sing–”

Adora’s eyes got wider with each word until she sang in time with Marlena, “Mama's gonna buy you a diamond ring.” Both women gasped, Randor echoing them a moment later. Adora threw herself into Marlena’s – her mother’s – arms, and they both sobbed. “Mom,” she whispered.

“My baby,” Marlena whispered back. “Oh, my baby.”

“Okay,” a young man’s voice called from the gates, “what did I miss?” Adora looked over Marlena’s shoulder to see a guy who looked like a slightly more buff Kyle – but at least *he* had a family resemblance to Adora.

Randor – her *dad,* Adora realized – cleared his throat. “Adam...I would like you to meet Adora. Your twin sister.

Prince Adam’s jaw went slack. “By the power of Grayskull!” he gasped.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

In spite of every effort Catra made to lean on her innate paranoia, she found herself really liking Adora’s parents.

Going through their complicated history had been...difficult, but Marlena's summation had been as simple as it was comforting. "You were there for Adora when we couldn't. You suffered to protect her and stay by her side. The rift you endured means nothing compared to what you are together."

Randor's was almost as welcome: "You're Adora's wife. That means you're our daughter." And that sounded like the end of it.

And, well, the Eternians had some amazing stories, some to rival theirs. Apparently, Marlena was from a planet in a whole other *galaxy,* with a dull name but an exciting history. The galaxy with 'Earth' in it was one of the few still resisting Horde Prime, and it had lots of people with mutations that granted them princess-like powers. Marlena herself was an explorer, one who crash-landed on Eternia when she was about Adora's age, while testing an experimental space engine. (Entrapta wanted to know *everything* about it, to no one's surprise.) It was just a few months after Randor's brother had gone bad, but a few years before he became the latest Skeletor.

That brother, Keldor, was a *much* less fun story. He was the first-born and 'rightful heir,' whatever that was supposed to mean, but the Council of Eternos denied him the throne because of his magical talent. Catra winced. They didn't discuss him much – Randor sort of collapsed into himself every time they called him Keldor instead of Skeletor – but it was pretty obvious the guy had been a hero before he turned into the villain. "He beat the old Skeletor," Adam whispered to her, in a gentle voice that implied he knew how to whisper to a cat. Cringer curled up under the table, still licking his lips after finishing off his steaks. "That's how he was able to get the Havoc Staff in the first place."

Catra shivered. "There but for the grace of Saz," she muttered. *What would I have been, if I'd gotten my claws on magic while I was still with the Horde?* They'd even dismissed what her alternate selves had been like, joking about how they'd encountered alternate dimensions of their own. *Now that's a story I want to hear later.*

Still, something was nagging at Catra, even if she couldn't place it. "I can help with your emotive matrix if you like!" Entrapta cheered to Roboto, Duncan's strategy-bot turned Defender. *Well, it's certainly not Entrapta,* Catra thought, unable to resist a smile at her dear friend's antics. She and Bow shared knowing looks, their grins nearly identical.

"Careful, Duncan," Adam joked, leaning back into his chair. His plate was as clean as Catra's. "Teela's already got your old job. Princess Entrapta might make you obsolete."

Duncan laughed. "This old dog still has a few tricks up his sleeve, Prince Adam. I'm not ready to be put out to pasture yet."

That was when Randor turned a cool glare on his son, and Catra's insides turned into a giant knot. "Better to have worked hard enough to retire than not at all, Adam," he scolded. Adam's smile vanished, and the way he shrank into himself was *much* too familiar to Catra. She managed to bite back a hiss, glancing at Queen Marlena to see if she was taking the same attitude.

She wasn't. Indeed, when Marlena looked into Catra's eyes, the queen's widened, and she shook her head subtly enough that only Catra picked it up. *So it's a secret that Adam's He-Man,* Catra thought, glancing down at Cringer again. *Are most Eternians just that dense? Sure, I'm the only one who'd notice that their scents are the same, but Bast and Ra, Cringer and Battle Cat have the same stripe pattern.* Adora, gods bless her, noticed the tension and jumped in. "So! Did I mention the time I killed a bed in Brightmoon?"

That got everyone laughing again. "You what?" Teela asked, grinning.

"Did you try to cast a spell?" Orko, the court sorcerer and 'buffoon' asked, sparkles coming out of his fingers. Catra groaned through a chuckle and hid her face behind a hand.

"What? No! I grew up in barracks. The softest surface in my whole world was Catra's fur." Lonnie cackled at that – *(the traitor,)* Catra groused. "Then suddenly, I'm in this weird golden castle where everything is round and they make beds out of giant pillows! I thought I was going to drown in the silly thing!" Adora objects, hands waving in the air for a moment. "So...I maybe kinda sorta stabbed it."

Catra shook her head, but she was still smiling. "Truly your greatest victory in the entire war. Bast, Sekhmet, and Ra, Adora, why do you love telling that story so much?"

Adora huffed. "I don't! It just feels honest!" she objected.

That elicited more laughter, drawing out a sheepish smile from Adora. "It sounds as though your fluff-bed experience was a microcosm of your adjustment in changing from the 'Fright Zone' to Brightmoon," Marlena replied. "Perhaps it quickly tells the tale of your first days there."

Adora shrugged. "I guess? I never thought of it like that." She grew thoughtful. "Huh. But I think you're right."

Teela chuckled. "I'm more interested in how you ended up with a magicat Champion. What is it with the Grayskulls and cats?" Cringer sighed and curled up beside Adam's chair.

"Yeah, that's not a fun story," Catra sighed. "You must have noticed how much we talked about Shadow Weaver? She kinda kidnapped me as a child." That sobered the entire table. "Eh. It's okay. We worked it out before things got terrible."

Adora took Catra's hand. "You have no idea how much I wish that were true," she replied, her voice soft and guilt-stricken. "I should have seen it."

Catra gave Adora's hand a squeeze. "You were an infant when the witch got her claws on you," the magicat reminded her. "You didn't know anything else." Marlena quivered in her seat. Catra

grinned. “Wow, is someone as ready to rip Shadow Weaver a new one as I am?”

“More,” Marlena said, her voice colder than the Fractal Flake, “given that you showed that monster mercy she didn’t deserve.”

Glimmer shrugged. “We’d all love to bury her in Etheria’s deepest dungeon,” the princess explained, “but she surrendered and provided genuine intelligence that helped us stop the Horde. Doing more than keeping her locked up wouldn’t be right.”

“Besides,” Adora said, beaming, “Glimmer and Catra might be getting through to her.” Adora turned a look of adoration Catra felt into her claws – one she felt utterly undeserving of – and somehow, her smile grew. “I married a living miracle.”

“Uh, which of us is She-Ra, again?” Catra asked, glad most of them didn’t recognize her blush. That restored the table’s good humor.

Adora laughed. “Both of us,” she reminded Catra.

“When do you two find time to sleep?” Adam quipped, shaking his head.

“If we didn’t have sleepovers, I wouldn’t be sure they knew how,” Glimmer quipped back.

Randor’s eyes narrowed. “Some people have duties to attend to, Adam.” Once again, Adam collapsed a little into himself.

Catra felt cold and hot at the same time, like her blood was half-fire and half-ice. She leaped to her feet, chair rattling behind her. Cringer yelped and leaped back. The magicat had rarely been more grateful for her trauma caps, because her claws were out and she would have torn grooves into the Grayskulls’ table without them. “I need some air,” she hissed in place of snarling words she could never take back, and all but ran from the dining hall.

Adora was halfway out of her seat before Catra had made her escape. “Catra!” she cried, but Catra couldn’t stay (at least not without going for Daddy Dearest’s eyes).

“I’ll go get her,” Adam said before she was out of earshot. *Sometimes, the super-hearing isn’t fun,* Catra thought as she took her usual escape route – up.

The round palace design made the main structures basically really wide towers, which meant that the main building didn’t really have a part that was taller than the rest. *Ugh, who designs a fortification without a lookout point? Do these people use magic for everything?* Catra settled on leaping out a window on the top floor, planning to climb the rest of the way.

“Wait!” Cringer yelped, leaping up the last few steps from below and sliding along the floor on his belly. Catra tried to swallow a laugh, but a snicker escaped all the same. “How are you...so quick...on two legs?” he panted, covering his head with one paw.

“You should see me when I use all four,” Catra retorted with a smirk. Cringer groaned.

Adam stumbled up the stairs behind his friend, gasping for breath. “You...are...really...fast,” he noted, taking a deep breath between each word.

“And your point is?” Catra asked. Adam collapsed next to Cringer, flopping onto his back. “Hey, Adam. Can you secure this site?” Adam raised an eyebrow and waved at the attic space. He couldn’t have said ‘it’s a storage room’ more eloquently if he’d used words.

“I can,” Duncan said, heading up behind Cringer and Adam. He pushed a button on his gauntlet, and a golden-orange forcefield took form around them.

“So. Uh. Duncan, right? You know...who he...about…” Catra waved at Adam. “You know Adam’s secrets?”

Duncan raised an eyebrow. Adam gulped and sat up. “Man-at-Ar – I mean, Duncan knows all my secrets.” Cringer huffed. “All the important ones, anyway,” the prince added, blushing.

Catra cackled. “If he doesn’t know you’re in love with his daughter, he’s too stupid to save,” she quipped. Adam’s blush deepened. Duncan rolled his eyes and smiled. Catra’s grin vanished. “Look, I get that no one else has a nose like a magicat, but come on, Cringer and ‘Battle Cat’ have the exact same stripe pattern! Is everyone on Eternia denser than iridium?”

Duncan’s smile broadened. “Battle Cat is twice Cringer’s size, much like He-Man is to Adam.”

Catra scoffed. “At least the only thing He-Man and Adam share is the eyes.”

Adam’s stare grew more astonished. Duncan rubbed his chin. “You noticed that, did you?”

It was Catra’s turn to blush and look away. “It’s how I knew we could trust him. They’re the same as Adora’s. In both forms.”

“Look, I appreciate you being...sympathetic,” Adam said, standing up, “but my dad’s okay. He’s probably just looking at Adora and thinking I should be more like her.”

“Yeah, no,” Catra retorted, “it’s *not* okay. Anyone who reminds me of Shadow Weaver, even a little,” she continued, Duncan bristling and gaping in horror at the same time, “needs a reality check.”

Duncan spluttered for a moment. “King Randor is not like Shadow Weaver!” he objected.

Catra scoffed. “*Skeletor* isn’t as bad as Shadow Weaver. At least he doesn’t torture kids. It doesn’t make what Randor’s doing right.”

“He’s just trying to help,” Adam whispered. It burned Catra from the inside to watch boy-Adora – Eternia’s greatest hero – shrivel

up defending his own mistreatment. “He doesn’t know.”

“We all love Randor dearly,” Duncan added, “but keeping secrets is...not his strongest trait.”

“So what?” Catra huffed. “Adora never kept She-Ra secret, and she managed just fine.”

“Adora had you,” Cringer replied. “Her castle was protected by magic woods, and you spent most of your war protecting her.”

“And the one time you applied your knowledge of her vulnerability during your time as a Force Captain,” Duncan reminded her, “you outmaneuvered the entire Princess Alliance. Skeletor might not be your equal as a strategist, but he is also more blunt and ruthless. He would not hesitate to kidnap any of the people Adam loves to force him to turn over the Sword.”

Catra’s blood ran cold again. *Shadow Weaver never realized how much Adora cared about the others. Hordak didn’t understand. And I...guess I wasn’t as evil as I thought I was.* She thought about the stalemate that Eternia had been trapped in for the last several years. “Hmph. Well then. I guess we just have to win the stupid war. Again.”

Cringer and Duncan stared, jaws dropping, but Adam laughed. “Just like that?” the prince asked.

Catra smirked “Just like that. Hey, Duncan, you’re the brains around here. You’ve got profiles on Skeletor’s – I can’t believe I’m saying this – ‘Evil Warriors,’ right?”

Duncan’s cunning smile was better than a yes.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

“We were so CLOSE!” Skeletor screamed, blasting a gargoyle to rubble. Evil-Lyn sighed, almost daring to mock him, while his other Dread Ones scattered in terror. “The Hall of Wisdom was open! The Sorceress was a captive in her own castle! The Orb of

Power was practically *in our grasp!* And then She-Ra chooses *that exact moment* to return after a thousand years!" He fired another havoc bolt into the wall. Snake Mountain shook with his wrath. "It's not fair!"

Evil-Lyn shook her head while Skeletor collapsed back into his throne. "Think of this as an opportunity," she crooned, stroking the crystal ball on her staff. "The Sword of Protection is more ancient and formidable than even the Sword of Power. She-Ra is unschooled in Eternian intrigue. And your brother's long-lost daughter could be the perfect leverage given the right…" Lyn smirked. "...opportunity."

"Bah!" Skeletor threw his Havoc Staff into its holding cylinder. "Adora is a warrior born and trained. She made He-Man look like a child playing dress-up. And that magicat of hers has cunning enough for ten Champions." He growled deep in his throat. "Our only hope now is distraction. We must endanger enough so-called 'innocents' that they cannot resist rushing to their aid when my warriors are ready for another assault."

"Another possibility exists, Lord Skeletor," a new woman's voice interjected. Evil-Lyn pointed her staff at the sound, where darkness pooled in a far corner. "Adora and Catra are not as invincible as they might seem. They have weaknesses..."

A woman in red robes, wearing an all-concealing mask, emerged from the roiling void. "...if one knows how to exploit them."

Skeletor raised an eye ridge at the interloper. "How convenient," he drawled. "Who are you, woman, and why should I listen to you instead of relieving my stress by trying out new havoc spells on you?"

The woman bowed, low and respectful in appearance at least. "I am Shadow Weaver, Lord Skeletor," she said, then straightened, "and between my knowledge and your power, we can triumph where the fool Hordak failed."

Evil-Lyn sneered at the newcomer. “And you are doing all of this from the kindness of your heart, of course,” she mocked.

Shadow Weaver chuckled. “Hardly, child,” she retorted, holding out a hand palm up. Darkness from the Spell of Obtainment itself reached out in hunger. Skeletor sat up straight. *She survived the–!* he realized, giving the Etherian his undivided attention. “Never have I found a sorcerer with the power to relieve my...condition. All I want is the mastery of magic long denied me. Promise me that, and I will give you Eternia, and the universe entire.”

And Skeletor laughed...

Chapter End Notes

Dun dun DUN!

(Yes, Shadow Weaver's playing Skeletor. Of course, Skeletor is playing her, too.)

Don't worry, I'm planning on resolving the Adam/Randor/He-Man situation. That's too awesome of a rock not to throw into the Eternian pond.

Next time: Etheria's greatest strategist turns the war between Grayskull and Snake Mountain inside-out, changing the course of Eternia's history almost overnight. Skeletor's not going to take that sitting down...

(Well, except he kinda is. Slouching on that throne is a thing for him.)

Eternia Saga II: Revelation

Chapter Summary

> Catra and She-Ra turn the tide of Eternia's war. Skeletor plots to turn it back. Shadow Weaver "helps." Mayhem ensues.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"This is unlike him," Duncan rumbled, staring at the war map along with the gathered Eternian court and allied princesses.

Catra glanced over to the First One and raised an eyebrow. "What, Skeletor's never tried a two-pronged assault before?"

King Randor huffed. "It was always clear which attack was the distraction." Adora's father folded his arms and glared. "He sends foot soldiers and a lesser Evil Warrior to endanger civilians, knowing we must respond."

"Yeah, but you'd know you didn't need to send He-Man," Catra pointed out, tail lashing.

Adora frowned. "That depends on how many people the Heroic Warriors needed to protect," she noted. "If Point Dread attacked with enough forces, they could need He-Man just to make sure they don't lose anyone." The Princess of Power shivered. *And I actually thought Catra was a bad guy when she stayed in the Horde. Stars.*

"Fortunately, he almost never has the forces to spare," Teela explained, zooming in on the Tahryn region. "It's unusual for him to send both Tri-Klops and Beast-Man on a feint." She grinned. "And yeah, they also have Trap-Jaw and Spikor, but come on, it's Trap-Jaw and Spikor."

Mermista beat Catra to the cutting retort with, "I'm gonna guess that they're, like, not the bright ones."

"Beast-Man's not stupid, exactly," Teela added, and Catra winced for some reason – *oh,* Adora realized when she caught Catra send a lightning-quick glance at Scorpia – "but Tri-Klops is the only one of them I'd call smart." She sighed. "Unfortunately, he's downright brilliant, especially with technology. Honestly, if Skeletor didn't have him, Dad and the monarchs would probably have won the war back when I was still a kid."

"Ooo, I can't wait to look at his designs!" Entrapta gushed.

Catra chuckled. "So if they're the feint, we've got heavy hitters moving towards Avion, right?"

The woman with the arms that were also wings, Delora the Stratos, replied with a grim nod. "We've spotted Skeletor, Evil-Lyn, Clawful, and Whiplash headed for the Mystic Mountains, and it looks like they have other Evil Warriors leading their troops as well." She glanced away, and the expressions on the other Eternians turned as grim as the Avionian. "The last time Skeletor attacked Avion with a force of this size, he unleashed the demon Molkrom. Defeating that horror cost my brother his life."

The Etherians stared in horror. Even Catra shuddered. "Whiplash killed him. He was the previous Stratos," Adam explained in a hushed voice, "and a good friend."

Catra took a deep breath, then let it go. "Okay. I'll head for Tahryn. Tri-Klops and Beast-Man are the two 'Evil Warriors' that looked the easiest to turn, so I'll work on them with Bow and Entrapta. Adora, you'll take the rest of the princesses to Avion–"

Every alarm in Adora's mind went off at once. "What? No! I'm staying with you!"

Catra's jaw tightened. "Adora, listen, I'm already gambling with Avion by going for the soft armor. Skeletor might not be much of a

strategist, but he's competent and stupidly powerful. The Eternians need you there."

Glimmer pouted, cheeks puffing up. "Oh, come on, Catra!" she objected. Adora was almost ashamed at how relieved she felt. "We're going to have Perfuma, Scorpia, and *Mermista* there, plus me, Lonnie, and Sea Hawk backing them up. That's not even counting Teela and her Defenders. Stop being a martyr and take Adora!"

Catra's blush was only obvious to Adora and Glimmer, her facial fur going flat while her ears pivoted back. "Look, I figured they could spare Roboto and Orko," she muttered. "I can handle one flanking maneuver."

Orko gasped, eyes widening in excitement. "You want my help, Catra?" the little wizard blurted.

Catra's smile was gentle, and Adora's heart welled up with love and pride. "Yeah, duh. For a guy who's all about 'the Power of Havoc,' Skele-dork really can't handle chaos in the back ranks. You're good at chaos." The other Etherians watched Catra, Glimmer almost glaring. Adora forced herself not to giggle when Catra unleashed her most dramatic sigh. "*Ugh,* fine, I'll use easy mode and bring Adora." Adora's relief made her shrink a full centimeter. Catra scowled at her sister. "Be careful, Glimmer, okay?" Glimmer smirked back. Catra's glare sharpened. "I'm serious, Glimm. Sure, I make fun of him, but this Skeletor creep is bad news. My fur stands up just being around him."

"Keldor has never shown any personal issues with Qadians – magicats – but the Skeletors rose during our first encounter with Etheria, so long ago that all the tales are left to myth and magic," King Randor explained. "It is only natural that a magicat with your etheric strength and prowess would react to his presence."

"Okay. We have our teams. I'll take Adora, Bow, Entrapta, Roboto, Orko, aaand...the cyclone guy, if he's up for it," Catra decided.

"Sy-klone," Adam filled in, Orko spelling the Defender's name with magic light.

Catra snorted while Adora grinned. "Of course it is," the magicat drawled. "Everyone else who's not protecting Eternos goes to deal with bone-head."

"I'm going with you too," a new voice called. Adam's eyes widened in alarm while everyone turned to face the newcomer. She was a lithe but muscular woman, similar to Catra in build, with lavender-highlighted green hair peeking out from under a crystal-adorned battle helm.

Adam straightened. "Krass'tine–"

"Don't, blondie," Krass'tine snapped, grim expression turning into a scowl. Catra chuckled. "I'm not allowed to fight Skeletor? Fine, I'm helping the cat lady."

Catra smirked. "Oh, I like her." Krass'tine's scowl became a bright, excited smile. "You got one of those ridiculous battle names?"

Her smile only broadened. "Mine's extra-ridiculous! I'm Ram Ma'am."

Catra laughed outright. "I *love* it." Adora threw her wife an exasperated look. "What? She's Ram Man's kid. It's kind of an obvious flex."

Adora stopped glaring, looking from Krass'tine to Catra to Adam and back. *oh.* Adora swallowed. "Oh. I. Um. I'm sorry."

"It's okay, because she's *not going,"* Adam insisted.

Ram Ma'am glared back. "Until I master my power, right?" she retorted. Then she turned into a human rocket, darting around the room with expert precision. Krass'tine raced over Randor's head, stopping to hover over a chandelier, then zipped to hover beside Orko, grabbing a leg of roast bird before racing to Catra's side. There she halted, their almost-matching jackets blending

into one another while Ram Ma'am put one arm around Catra's shoulders and took a bite from the bird leg with the other. "I. Have. The power."

Adam's grin was sheepish while he rubbed the back of his neck. "Been practicing?"

Krass'tine smirked back. "Been practicing."

Catra sighed, though she relaxed when Adora rubbed her back. "Okay! Unless someone has questions, Team Tech will head for Tri-Klops' research base while Team Magic moves into position to ruin bone-head's day." Adora relaxed – a little – when no one had questions. *This is going to get worse before it gets better,* she worried.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

It was weird, having someone new join Adam for this moment.

"You gonna be okay without Adora, Muscles?" Catra asked. Krass'tine snickered, because of course she did.

Adam raised an eyebrow at the magicat. She remained unimpressed. Orko and Kringer shared a look Adam couldn't decode. Duncan's gaze was as inscrutable as ever. "I've been doing this without another Champion for a while, Catra," he reassured her, putting on his most disarming smile. "I'll have plenty of backup. We'll be fine."

Krass'tine glared. "You know it's a trap, right?" she snapped. His smile vanished. "I mean, seriously, he's not even trying to hide it!"

Adam indulged in a frustrated huff. "Of course it's a trap. It's always a trap. I can't let Uncle Keldor hurt innocent people, Tina."

The end of Catra's tail twitched. "So, how do you two know each other?" she asked, keeping her voice light, but Adam noticed that her fist was opening and closing.

Krass'tine did her usual snorting laugh. Catra's ears shot straight up. Her tail lashed when Tina bumped shoulders with Adam. "Are you kidding? We've been buds since we were kids. I can't believe so many people bought his 'Zorro' thing."

Catra raised an eyebrow. "What's a Zorro?"

"A fictional hero from my mom's world, Earth," Adam explained. "He pretended to be an irritating airhead so no one would realize he was this masked rebel hero." His uncertainty melted away when he drew his Sword and held it aloft with a grin. It was less crystal and more metal than Adora's, but the core binding its two halves around the Runestone made Adam wonder how – or if – the blades were related. "Not that I need a mask. By the power of Grayskull!"

The familiar column rushed down, and Adam felt himself grow. Royal garb gave way to his armored harness. It still amazed him that the transformation didn't hurt. His ribs, heart, spine, lungs, even his skull, they all expanded like something Orko pulled from his hat. *I wonder if Adora feels like this.* Almost of its own will, the Sword of Power pivoted and bathed Kringer in the light, transforming him into Battle Cat.

"It still amazes me he can pull off a loincloth," Krass'tine quipped. Adam rolled his eyes.

"Eh. I blame the magic," Catra replied with a shrug. Duncan laughed. *Who's side are you on?* Adam wondered – but he was smart enough not to say anything.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Maybe this wasn't such a great idea, Catra thought, leading her team into the abandoned laboratory. The weird part was how much of the place was built with stone bricks.

Adora placed her hand on Catra's shoulder. The magicat bit back a hiss and let She-Ra take point. "Stay close," she whispered anyway.

“Always,” Adora whispered back, smiling. Catra clamped down on her suddenly-racing heart. Then She-Ra turned and glowed brightly enough to light up the corridor.

Krass’tine whistled. “What a mess,” she noted. Catra had to agree; the hallway was half-collapsed, only passable because so much of the rest of the structure was also in ruins.

Sy-Klone pulled some debris out of the way with his wind powers. “That is to be expected,” he said, scanning around them. “What precisely are we looking for?”

“Intact computers,” Catra explained, “especially anything connected to a security system. I want footage, reports, anything that might indicate if or how Skeletor conned Tri-Klops. His whole thing doesn’t make sense.”

Entrapta, who was probing every stone with her hair, looked up at Catra. “What ‘thing’ are you referring to? That sounds like a colloquialism.”

Catra let an uncertain hum escape. “It’s more of a shorthand. Tri-Klops was the only other member of Queen Marlena’s Earth crew to survive the landing. Their galaxy had just started fighting the Horde, and the Earthans were looking for allies.” She huffed and held an ear almost to the one intact wall. “Apparently, Tri-Eye decided Skeletor was a better choice for fighting our buddy Prime.”

“The ‘buddy’ part was sarcasm,” Bow added.

“Ooo! I think I picked up on that!” Entrapta cheered, hair still threading into every crack within reach. Catra couldn’t help a tiny smile.

“I believe I have detected computer equipment approximately 20 meters to our right,” Roboto reported. Entrapta let out a little squee.

Adora tapped the wall on their right with a smirk. “So, is this structurally important?” she asked. Ram Ma’am rolled here eyes while Roboto shook his head. She-Ra grabbed the base of the wall and lifted – for the whole thing to collapse around her.

“Adora!” Catra rushed over, but Adora just popped out of the pile of rubble and laughed. Catra huffed and crossed her arms. “Definitely not a support structure,” she added, glaring.

“Aw, were you worried? It’s almost like you like me,” Adora quipped back.

Catra facepalmed. “Why did I marry you?” Adora’s smile vanished, her eyes widening. “Relax. Not serious. Mostly.”

“You guys are cute and all, but can we get back to your security computer thing?” Ram Ma’am asked.

“Ooh, I know!” Orko cheered, stretching out his arms and wiggling his fingers. “Rocks revert, become dirt!” he chanted.

The Eternians gasped, even the robot guy. “Orko wait–” Sy-Klone began.

Magic of incredible power rushed forth from Orko’s hands to do his bidding, but Catra could hear and smell a twist in the ether. One flow of energy was reversed from the rest, disrupting the spell. The stone bricks spat dirt at them from all directions until they were all ankle-deep in soil and mud. Krass’tine wiped a large glob off her face, scowling at the little sorcerer. “Great job, Court Buffoon,” she snapped. Orko lowered about 20 centimeters, eyes hidden under his brim.

“Okay. That was...weird,” Catra muttered, shaking the grit out of her exposed fur. “Why is one frequency of your ether backwards from the rest?”

The Eternians stared, Orko looking out from under his hat with huge eyes. “Curious,” Roboto said. “You can distinguish between

individual etheric energies while a spell is being cast? I have no record of this in my data banks."

Catra shrugged. "All magicat sorcerers can, they tell me," she explained. "I'm really good at it for…reasons." She rubbed one of the deeper electric burns on her ribs. "Anyway, I've never seen anything like that."

Orko floated back up to his full 'height,' meeting Catra's gaze. "I'm from Trolla. It's a reverse-dimension connected to Eternia, except the magic flows backwards there. Why would one etheric band go in reverse to all the rest?"

Catra hummed and drew a magical analysis circle in front of Orko. Its mirror image formed behind the Trollan, with the only difference being the triangle in the centre was upside-down. "It's you," she whispered.

Orko wilted. "Me? There's something wrong with me, isn't there?"

Catra gasped. "No. That's it. There's nothing wrong with you." She smiled and put a hand on Orko's tiny shoulder. "You've been trying to reverse yourself with everything else, because you thought you were the problem, didn't you? But you're not." His eyes went even wider than before. "You're okay *just the way you are."*

The other Eternians stared while Orko looked at Catra with wide, gleaming eyes. Entrapta scribbled notes. Bow grinned. And Adora…Adora was staring at her with the lovey-dovey eyes that Catra hated admitting sliced right through all of her defenses. Luckily, the little Trollan came to her rescue. "Can…can you help me?"

"Sure thing, Orko." She put her hand on his arm, helping him feel the realignment of the one ether thread he needed to let go while inverting the others.

Orko concentrated, and holy *Stars* he was strong, like Glimmer-level strong. "Come on, rocks, no time to play, move aside, show us the way!" The Eternians braced themselves, but that one

strand of Orko-ness snapped into place the way it was always meant to be, and the stones literally paved a pathway to what sure looked like a computer. "We did it!"

"*You* did it, little guy," Catra said, patting his shoulder. Orko started to rush forward, stopped, rushed back to hug the astonished Catra, then darted ahead again toward the computer. He shot tiny multicolored sparks from one finger, as if to test them, while he went ahead.

"Hey, wait for us!" Krass'tine blurted, running over to catch up. Roboto and Sy-Klone looked at each other, then followed in a brisk walk. Bow tossed Catra a thumbs-up while guiding a still-note-writing Entrapta.

Adora was still looking at her with goo-goo eyes. "I, am married, to the most *awesome woman in the universe!"* She picked Catra up for a whirling hug.

Catra thought her face was going to burst into flames from the blush. *"Adora!"* She blurted, burying her face in her hands. Adora took pity on her wife and put Catra down. "C-come on, we still have work to do," she insisted, tugging her wife forward by one arm. Even not looking, the magicat could *feel* the dopey smile on Adora's face.

When they got there, Entrapta and Roboto were already working on accessing the computer. The casing was shot from water damage, but the First Ones crystals inside were intact. Catra grinned. "So, how many seconds do you think it'll take you to get the data out of those?"

"Somewhere between 80 and 120," Entrapta estimated. Catra's smile grew.

Roboto nodded. "I concur."

Krass'tine rolled her eyes, but her smile was fond. "Oh gods, now there's three of them."

Adora blinked. “Three?”

“Duncan, Roboto, and now your friend,” Ram Ma’am explained. “Adam’s going to have a nerdsplosion.”

“Aha!” Entrapta cheered in triumph. “I overestimated the number of seconds.” She stuck one of the crystals in a port that wasn’t rusted.

An image of Tri-Klops fighting Keldor appeared, except Tri-Klops was wearing a helmet with no eyes at all. He was wielding a sword with phenomenal skill, parrying magical blasts even through he couldn’t see. Trydor smirked. “You shall not pass,” he said.

Keldor gathered more power for a second, but let it dissipate. “I am Keldor, warrior,” he said, “rightful ruler of this land. Why do you stand between me and that traitor?”

“I have my reasons,” Trydor replied. “Besides, you stink of the Horde.” He swung again, and Keldor barely parried and dodged back. Keldor opened a gateway behind him, its counterpart forming behind Trydor, allowing a blast to finally strike home. The burst knocked Trydor’s helmet off. “No!” the human shouted, dashing to catch it. His organic eyes were sealed shut with glowing purple energy.

Keldor cast another spell – but it was countermagic, and Trydor’s eyes stopped glowing. The human opened them, blinking. “Let me guess. The technician here told you that helmet kept the spell from destroying your senses.” Trydor’s mouth worked. “He lied. I joined the Horde once, yes – to learn their ways and sabotage them from within. Prime, d’ast him, found me out, and I had to come back here to gather forces against him.” Trydor straightened, listening anew. “That man works for my brother. He kept you blind and dependent on him with that helmet. It held the spell on you. A minor curse like that would have come undone in days.”

Trydor circled Keldor, sword wavering. “Why should I believe you?”

Keldor’s smirk was far darker than Trydor’s. “Why did I free you?” he asked.

Trydor’s eyes widened, then narrowed. “My sight is still limited,” he admitted.

“An aftereffect of the curse being forced on you for so long,” Keldor replied. “Besides, you will hardly need it to overcome a mechanic. No doubt he intended to force you into my cowardly brother’s service.” Catra was grateful for the trauma caps when her claws tried to dig into her legs.

Trydor raised an eyebrow. “‘Cowardly?’”

“He is afraid to fight Prime,” Keldor explained, smirk vanishing. “I am not.”

Trydor glared at the ceiling. “Is that so.” He sheathed his blade. “Let me introduce you. I’m sure we’ll have much to discuss.”

“Pause.” Catra glared. “Crap. That’s a good scam.”

“Was Skeletor telling the truth about the spell?” Krass’tine asked.

Catra shook her head. “No. It would’ve gotten worse without the helmet. Not sure how to prove it, though. Fast forward to the part with the engineer.” She frowned. “Entrapta, you night not want to watch.”

“It’s just data,” Entrapta said, jumping to the next bit before Catra could reply. The inventor panicked at the sight of Keldor, pulling a blaster. Trydor parried the blast, which made the guy panic even more. Trydor cut him down without another word. Entrapta paled, but they all kept watching. After Trydor left, though, Keldor lingered, scanning the room for something. He smirked again, using a spell to open a cabinet. A new helmet, one like the cybernetic eye replacement Tri-Klops wore in the present, floated out.

Catra's own smirk returned. "Now that is pretty solid evidence. Come on, team, we've got some Evil Warriors to de-evil."

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Lonnie didn't like any of this.

Sure, they had a *lot* of princess-level warriors. Besides Glimmer, Scorpia, Perfuma, and Mermista, they had Man-at-Arms and her predecessor-dad, Delora the Stratos, the faces guy, a cyborg calling herself Extendar, and the Andreenid champion (Lonnie could *not* make herself call him "Buzz-Off"). Teela swore up and down that He-Man would be there. Lonnie just wanted to swear up and down, period. She looked at Sea Hawk. The lunatic gave her a thumbs-up. Lonnie looked skyward and rolled her eyes. "I don't like any of this," she muttered.

"Problem, soldier?" Man-at-Arms Teela asked, her voice carrying a steel any Force Captain would have envied.

Lonnie stood at attention and saluted. "No ma'am!" she said. "There's no better place for our defense than here." Glimmer teleported to her side.

Teela raised an eyebrow. "But?"

Lonnie gestured at the gently rolling hills around the river bank they stood beside. "It's still a horrible place for a defensive position, ma'am," she reported. "It doesn't matter how many princesses – and princes, I guess – we have, the Skeletor's reported military strength means he'll be able to roll right past us. He'll take serious losses, sure, but it's obvious he considers them acceptable."

Teela smiled. "And Catra's the military genius in your group?"

Lonnie stomped down the budding jealousy with both boots. Twice. "Yes ma'am. I'm competent, trained in the Horde officer-cadet corps since I was nine. And you don't have to be Catra to

see this is a wide, open plain that's perfect for rolling armor across. I don't see any armor on our side, ma'am."

"For gods' sake, just call me Teela," she said with an air of surrender. Lonnie relaxed a fraction. Glimmer relaxed a lot more, Lonnie realizing she'd had sparkles glowing around her fists until then. "Besides, Team She-Ra's had hours to catch up with Tri-Klops, and we'll have heavy weapons if we need them. Look up there." Teela pointed up and behind them at a small cloud in the distance. "That's Avion, the sky city." Lonnie's eyes bulged. Even after Mystacor, seeing that up there – especially after being told Avion was the size of Eternos before they left – left Lonnie gaping. "If we can't stop Skeletor's forces here, they'll have the forces we need to pin his army down."

Scorpia's eyes crackled with scarlet lightning. "Whoa! That's a lot of juice. I think those are machines incoming? I mean, wow, tons of 'em."

Teela nodded. "When I give the signal, Scorpia, pull the plug, just like we planned." Scorpia nodded back. Lonnie activated the new armor Catra had commissioned for her and extended her stun staff. *I hope Entrapta didn't leave any surprises in this stuff.* Teela raised her sword. "For Eternia! Open fire!"

Lonnie obeyed, most of the others unleashing their own blasts. Perfuma used the grass to entangle tons of the enemies, while Mermista hit the Roton skiff-tanks with bursts of water from the river. "Adventure!" Sea Hawk cried – because of course he did – and unleashed heat beams from his saber. More gifts from Entrapta.

"Man-at-Arms? They're still coming," Lonnie reported. Glimmer lost patience and teleported into the mass of enemy forces, jumping from one Roton to the next. She was taking them out as quickly as she could appear. Lonnie was impressed, and maybe turned on just a little.

Skeletor wasn't going to let them rampage forever, of course. He appeared out of a gateway, smashing his staff into Glimmer's. Evil-Lyn followed, with a bunch of Evil Warriors who only qualified as "elite" thanks to raw power coming through after her.

Glimmer jumped back to Lonnie's side. "Hey, Woman-at-Arms, Skeletor's here with a party of seven," she said, grinning.

"Evil-Lyn. Clawful. Whiplash. Kobra Khan. Webstor. Waspus." Teela listed them off, while their Andreenid charged straight at Waspus. A bunch of Tri-Klops' Doomseekers flew past the two Andreenids to blast them from overhead. "Now, Scorpia!" Their friend obeyed, and vast streams of electrical energy flowed into her. Skeletor's entire mechanized force fell to earth, grounded in more ways than one.

Skeletor opened another gateway, jumping his team through to face them. He did...something, glowing a sickly bruise-purple for a moment, and the cow-skull-head soldiers sank into the ground back with the Rotons and came out of the ground behind him. "A scorpion princess. Cute," Skeletor noted. "Crush them." He jumped into the air, gathering power that rivaled She-Ra's–

–when He-Man leaped seemingly from nowhere to slam into the skull-headed freak. "Come on, Skeletor," the big guy said, grinning, "you didn't think it would be that easy, did you?" Lonnie threw herself into blasting the 'Skel-cons.' The first shattered, and for a moment Lonnie thought Entrapta has messed up her stun bolts, but all that was left were bones, and the blast hadn't been that powerful. She held in her breakfast and kept bringing down the undead legions.

Most of the others were engaged with heavies. Glimmer was enjoying herself giving Evil-Lyn a hard time with her combination of teleporting and disruptor spells. Scorpia grappled with Clawful, which probably wouldn't have been much of a challenge if she weren't also drawing all that energy from their army. She looked a little seasick. Teela and Duncan were fighting Kobra Khan and Whiplash two-on-two, with the father-daughter duo having the

distinct advantage. Perfuma was busy catching Webstor's webs with her vines, while he returned the favor with her offensive efforts. Mermista and Sea Hawk managed one flank of the undead invasion while Delora led the remaining Defenders on Lonnie's side against the other. "Scorpia! How are you managing, big gal?" Lonnie called.

"I'm – urp! – fine, just a little full," Scorpia replied, trying to sting Clawful. Between his reflexes and her wooziness, though, none of her stabs landed. *It's okay, Scorp, you're pinning down his whole tank fleet. We've got this from here.* Lonnie's confidence returned as they pushed the Skelcons back.

That confidence vanished when Shadow Weaver appeared behind He-Man and hit him with a flood of shadow spies! "He-Man!" Lonnie cried, too worried (and terrified) to feel ridiculous. Several other voices cried out at the same time. Glimmer turned to help, only to find Evil-Lyn pressing her advantage. Mermista glared, pulling a massive wave out of the river, but a new guy rushed upriver with a bunch of goons, and he pulled Mermista's wave back with a magic grip of his own. "Man-at-Arms! Orders!"

"Anyone who knows how to deal with the new witch, take her out!" Teela shouted. "Defenders, give the Etherians some breathing room!"

"Too late, cheerleader!" Skeletor laughed. His magic slammed into Shadow Weaver's, both converging on He-Man's magic sword. "You might have stopped me from claiming the might of the Elders, but I learned such fabulous secrets from the archives between the Sorceress and the Orb of Power." Something was happening to He-Man's sword. It was vibrating, and cracking – no, *splitting* down the middle. "Your precious He-Man doesn't come from the light, oh, no. Half the Sword of Power comes from Preternia, true – but the other half was born in Subternia!"

He-Man screamed while Lonnie tried to disengage and attack Shadow Weaver. "This is impossible!" Lonnie complained, fighting her way towards the catastrophe in progress. "Shadow Weaver

wasn't this powerful back when she had Scorpia's Runestone to leech off!"

"Ah, Lonnie," Shadow Weaver said – and Lonnie's heart clenched at the pride in her voice. "You always paid more attention than others realized. Alas for you, this world's magic is not bound as Etheria's is. Even one of our Runestones does not grant the power available from a lesser artifact of Eternia, thanks to our world's false Heart." Her mask glowed crimson, but it was a deeper, more sinister shade than the Black Garnet's. "And the spells one can learn here, if a sorceress has mastered the art of manipulating sources of power? Oh, you cannot imagine, child."

Lonnie's eyes widened. "She's stealing energy from the Sword! He-Man, she's using your own power against you!"

"Th-thanks," He-Man grunted, concentrating. The flow of magic seemed to shift.

"Too late!" Skeletor cried, lashing out and grabbing one of the prongs on the Sword. He-Man grabbed the other one.

The Sword of Power came apart like two puzzle pieces sliding free of each other – if those pieces held the power of a Star inside them. They flashed so bright Lonnie thought for a moment that it would the last thing she ever saw. Then raw force knocked her back, sending Lonnie, and everyone else, sprawling.

When Lonnie's vision cleared, everyone was still prone. They all sat up – and stared. Prince Adam was next to Delora, holding a purple blade with a single steel-like cutting edge. Skeletor held the other half, a golden sword with the same steely metal for its slicing half. *Wait.* Lonnie's eyes flickered from Adam to Skeletor and back. *Oh. Of course. He's Adora's brother, of course he's He-Man. But that was supposed to be a whole secret thing, and – oh, Stars.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Tri-Klops grunted and rubbed his temples, wishing not for the first time that his eyepiece didn't cover his entire forehead. Beast-Man, Trap-Jaw, and Spikor were all howling at Tahryn – literally, in Beast-Man's case. *It's to beat the Horde, just keep telling yourself, it's to beat the Horde,* Trydor reminded himself. His Doomseekers and robot soldiers moved into position. Beast-Man let out another howl, this time gathering his animal army. "You lot ready for this?" he asked.

Trap-Jaw chuckled. "I was born ready, Tri-Klops," he rumbled. Trydor bit back a sigh. *And we're doing cliches today. Great.* He waved his forces onward towards the city-state.

The ram girl slammed into Trap-Jaw's chin, throwing him into the air. Sy-Klone swept up Spikor with the cyborg, the both of them cursing and trying to anchor themselves. Tri-Klops snarled an unkind word and raked the air with his electro-beam. Roboto pulled the blast out of the sky by turning his hand into a lightning rod, so Tri-Klops followed up with an ice-beam from his blue eye, only for the jester imp to block it with a magic shield. "The scut?" Trydor cursed. "Since when are you competent?"

A light-but-strong figure landed on top of his helmet, unbalancing Tri-Klops and forcing him to cut off his ice blast. "Hey, Trydor," the figure crooned, landing in front of him. It was the magicat who had helped She-Ra rescue the Sorceress. All three of his eyes widened. Before he could shout a warning, She-Ra landed in the middle of Beast-Man's menagerie, corralling them with her shape-changing Sword. "You know you're working for the wrong guy, right?"

Trydor turned his lightning eye on the magicat, focusing on her for another electric bolt. "This is new," he retorted. "The magicat wants to tell me that First Ones too gutless to fight the Horde are the heroes?"

Her smile vanished. "He played you, Tri-Klops. The curse was real. The tech guy really wanted to help you."

Tri-Klops drew his sword. “Right. And Keldor helped me because…”

“How much of his army did you build for him?” Catra asked. Her voice was the kind of soft he hadn’t heard in decades. *Even Captain Glenn never tried talking, she was too besotted with that idiot.* The magicat had a point.

But. “You have proof of this? Why am I asking, of course you do.” He froze when she pulled a data crystal from a pouch. The circuitry around it matched tech he’d seen long ago. She played the confrontation in the long-forgotten laboratory. Trydor cutting down his – betrayer? – then walking out. Keldor lingering, magic searching. Finding an optic prosthetic *just like* the one Trydor was wearing in the present. “That – that’s not conclusive–”

Beast-Man leaped away from She-Ra, whirling on Tri-Klops in a panic. “Don’t listen to her! S-Skeletor wouldn’t lie to you!”

Tri-Klops turned and focused his Gammavision on Rqazz. *Elevated heart rate. Increased respiration. Heightened fight-or-flight reaction.* Dread burrowed deep into Trydor’s bones. “You’re lying,” he whispered. Beast-Man’s eyes widened, and he turned to flee with a whimper. Tri-Klops caught him in a single leap, pinning the beastopoid and pointing his sword at Rqazz’s throat. “What do you know, Beast-Man?”

“Nothing! *Nothing!* You know me, Tri-Klops, everyone says I’m too stupid to–” Beast-Man gasped.

Trydor tightened his grip. “Tell. Me.” It was a demand.

Beast-Man swallowed, eyes wide. “Th-the curse would’ve destroyed all your senses. Keldor told me.”

Tri-Klops’s eye glowed a murderous azure. “And my helmet. He stole it, from the inventor, didn’t he?”

Beast-Man gaped. “How did you know?”

Even through his blue eye, fury stained the world red. "You'll never know," Tri-Klops snarled, pulling his sword back.

Catra stopped him with a surprisingly gentle touch. "No, Trydor." He froze, looking at her in disbelief. "He's Keldor's victim, too."

"How do you know?" Trydor (was he even still Tri-Klops?) asked.

Catra closed her eyes, blue and gold light streaming from her eyes like rivers of tears. They pooled in her hands, around her claws, then became a gentle beacon. Scars appeared all over her body, causing Trydor to recoil with a gasp. Beast-Man's body didn't have as many, but they criss-crossed his skin all over, hidden by his fur. "I was him." She guided Trydor back, the fierce warrior's touch still impossibly tender. "They don't love you, Raqquill."

Beast-Man stared, then leaped up with a snarl. "That's not true! My lady cares for me!"

Catra paused. "Maybe," she whispered, glancing at Adora. "Maybe she does. Sometimes, the people we love can't stop others from hurting us. Does she try, Raqquill?" He tensed. "Does she ask Skeletor to stop? Does she want to take the hurt in your place? Is she between you and him when she sees the dark magic coil around his hands?"

Beast-Man flinched. "Lyn…she has greater concerns. The fate of kingdoms. Worlds."

Catra sighed. "Oh, Beast-Man," she said, taking his hand. "Does she care?"

Trydor glanced at the She-Ra. She was watching, her battle come to a halt. All of Rqazz's monsters had stopped as well, their eyes glistening with tears. "I…she…where else can I go?"

"With us," Catra insisted. "I'd bet the Eternians will welcome you both. And if they don't, *we will."*

Raqquill's eyes were saucer wide. For the first time, Trydor felt pity for the man. "You promise?" he pleaded.

Catra's eyes went even wider than his. She-Ra choked back a sob just before the magicat threw her arms around him, as far as they would reach, at least. "I promise," she swore.

"Wimps!" Trap-Jaw howled, managing to throw the ram lady back. She landed after a brief skid, catching herself with her jets. "You think you're gonna turn us, ya useless furball?" Catra's ears shot up, her claws sliding back out. "Me and Spikor aren't a couple of sob stories. We're Gar. We're the *master race."* Old history lessons of Earth's bigotries came to Trydor's mind. He sent his personal override signal to the Doomseekers and robot soldiers. Beast-Man growled and brought his monsters in line. "What're you gonna do about us?"

Catra's smile was as terrifying as her eyes had been kind mere seconds before. "I'm glad you asked. Adora?" The She-Ra – *Adora,* Trydor realized with an awful chill, remembering the name of Marlena's daughter – punched her palm with a fist. The shockwave sent ripples around her.

Spikor gaped. "Uh, Trap-Jaw, I'm not sure about this." Tri-Klops indulged in a dread smile of his own. *You shouldn't be.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"Adam? *You're* He-Man?" The hurt and betrayal in Teela's voice cut deeper than losing the Champion. Adam held up the Subternia Sword, watching Skeletor warily.

Skeletor laughed. "Not any more, Girl-at-Arms!" he quipped. "And while he doesn't dare call down the Power now…" He held up the Preternia Sword. Adam gasped. *You wouldn't,* he thought, incorrectly. "By the power of Grayskull!" Everyone on both sides stared at the void-lightning that crashed down, purple light swirling around him in a column of divine supremacy. "I – have – the POWER!"

Everyone except Glimmer, who blitzed him in a flurry of teleporting staff-blasts. He ignored her, sickly green flame burning from his wrists and shoulders absorbing the blows. One shot to Skeletor's face got his attention, though, and he swept both staff and Sword out to throw her back. Princess Glimmer skidded to a landing on her feet and one hand. "Adam! Can you do that?" she asked.

Adam looked at the Subternia Sword. "This – it's from a place of darkness," he explained.

"Yeah, well, that means Skele-jerk's comes from light, and it's not bothering *him* any! Scorpia!" Glimmer cried.

Scorpia lit up, literally as well as figuratively. "Oh, yeah!" She brought her claws together, a serious glare transforming her gentle features into pure menace. Scorpia hit Skeletor with the full power of all the lightning she'd absorbed. He skidded back about a centimeter, a tiny burn mark on one pectoral muscle. "Ooo, that didn't do much, though," she noted. Worse, the Rotons and killer robots all started to power up.

Skeletor looked at the dot on his chest in disbelief. "I…I felt that?" He glared at the scorpion princess. "I felt that, you annoying bug!" Perfuma tried to rush between villain and princess, but Scorpia held her back with one pincer.

"Adam!" Teela shouted. Adam looked over to her, forlorn. "I'm going to read you all the riot acts later, but for right now, *hit* him!"

He looked at the Sword. "The Spark is me," Adam whispered. "The Sorceress said…" After a last moment's hesitation, he held the Sword high. "By the power of Grayskull!"

The change felt different. Wrong. It did hurt a little, this time, like he was being stretched up but not expanding out. Darkness welled inside him, the lightning and shimmering spirit power balancing it, but it was a forced balance, not the natural one channeled by the true Sword of Power. *Doesn't matter,* Adam

decided, feeling himself become faster, somewhat stronger, resilient enough to survive at least a few blows.

"Brave, nephew," Skeletor said, holding the staff against his Sword, "but courage won't be enough." He merged the two weapons into a spear-like polearm, blazing with the same green fire that burned at the edges of his new body. "You're only the Sword, and that makes you half the most powerful man in the universe. With the Preternia Sword and the Havoc Staff, I am now the Master of the Universe!" Skeletor's laugh was booming and triumphant.

Adam didn't have his full might, but he had speed, so he used it. In a jet-like burst, he slammed his fist into his uncle's bony face. It hurt, but that at least moved him back more than a centimeter. "You're not the master of anything yet, Skeletor," Adam said – in his own voice. He was as tall as He-Man, but it was Adam's build, wiry and lithe.

The others circled, looking for openings. Skeletor tested his jaw with thumb and forefinger, then somehow grinned. "Oh, Adam. If you were any other man, I would relish your powerlessness against me, but it seems I have the chance to teach you something after all. Nephew."

Adam called on more of the Power than he usually dared. Lightning burned through his veins, up his spine, in his lungs. It wasn't enough. "And what's that, Uncle Keldor?"

"I finally know the real secret of Grayskull!" Skeletor cheered for a moment. Then he became grave, the crimson lights in his eye sockets burning deep and cruel. "We want to believe in an ordered universe. Some grand architecture holding it all together." He took a step towards Adam, and again, the only one who did not recoil was Glimmer, fierce and bright. "But alas, there is only Power. Mad, chaotic, naked Power!" He held up his polearm – *glaive,* Adam remembered, *that kind of polearm is called a glaive* – and sent a wave of venomous green fire along it. "And now…*I* have the Power."

Glimmer's eyes glowed lavender for an instant, then she vanished. The others gaped, except for Mermista, who smirked. "Where did she go?" Evil-Lyn asked, pivoting around in clear expectation of an ambush.

"She finally grasped the meaning of discretion," Skeletor quipped, more raw might seething around him. "As for you, Adam, I will give you this one chance. Yield." Adam's eyes widened. "I know, I know, 'I'll never surrender to you,' blah blah blah, *you know what he is."*

"What do you mean?" Adam asked, but the cold shiver rippling from the Sword's darkness knew the answer. Teela turned a worried look toward him.

"Please, Adam." Skeletor straightened, head up, shoulders back, and even with a skull for a head Adam could see a hint of Randor there. The mocking echo of Keldor's voice didn't help. "'When did you become such a disappointment?' 'There's a difference between caution and cowardice.' 'Where is the boy I raised?' Bah." The villain shook his head. "You were Eternia's greatest hero, the *most powerful man in the universe,* and you still weren't good enough for him."

That one, Adam had an answer to. "He didn't know."

Skeletor's eye lights brightened. That made them more terrible, somehow. "Didn't he? Maybe he didn't want to know. Maybe that would have meant admitting he was hiding behind his teenage son."

"I'm 21," Adam shot back.

"You've been at this for three years, boy." Skeletor held out his hand. "Join me."

Most of the others gasped. Adam knew he would never, but…*I'm tempted? How? Why?* It was an awful feeling – until Teela laughed. "Wow. They grow 'em stupid in Snake Mountain, huh?"

Skeletor turned and glared at her. "You. DARE."

"You're just noticing that now?" Teela shot back. "Seriously, have you ever paid attention to anyone besides yourself?" She held up her sword, ready to fight Skelegod or whatever he'd become. "I don't know why he kept this secret. Probably so you wouldn't start coming after us, knowing the kind of coward you are." Skeletor seethed. "But I know this. Grayskull chose Adam for a reason. He'd never give in to *you."*

Skeletor stared for a moment longer…then smiled. It was stomach-churning. "Shadow Weaver," he barked. Darkness flowed towards Teela.

"NO!" Adam cried, calling on his Sword's darkness. It shot him right at the shadow things coming for Teela, and he carved through them before one could touch her. "Don't do this, Skeletor," he warned, pointing the Sword at his uncle. "I don't want to – to – but I know how to use a blade."

Shadow Weaver chuckled. "Honestly, child, you're almost as bad as Adora. You couldn't even slay me, knowing what I am. What makes you think anyone would believe you'd kill your own uncle?"

Her chuckles stopped when Adam pointed the Sword at her. "I know what you did to Catra," he snarled. "Trust me. *I can kill you."* Teela stared at him in horror.

Skeletor looked from Adam to Shadow Weaver. "What is he talking about, sorceress?" he asked.

An enormous flash of light erupted above them. Adora's team, plus Glimmer, Tri-Klops, Beast-Man, and a small army of Doomseekers emerged from the light. "Hey, Skeletor," Catra drawled, then leaped at him.

"What foolishness is this?" Skeletor demanded, blocking Catra with a magic shield her claws tore grooves through. She-Ra roared a battle cry and plunged through the shield, her Sword

crashing against his. "Tri-Klops! Beast-Man! You cannot be mad enough to betray me?"

"Betray you?" Tri-Klops whispered, crimson eye glaring. "Betray YOU?!" He fired a beam of searing heat at Skeletor, somehow not endangering Adora. "I know about the curse, Keldor! About the helmet! About your *lies!"*

Skeletor paused, as if to consider this, even with She-Ra pressing his defenses. "Oh, right," he muttered. "Ah well, easy come, etcetera." He fired a necromantic bolt at Tri-Klops. Adam rushed in to parry it.

Evil-Lyn gaped at their master. "'Easy come' – have you taken leave of your senses? Do you know how much of our army Tri-Klops built?"

Trydor fired a lightning bolt at Lyn. She yelped and dodged – right into Orko, who cracked his knuckles. "We know," Orko said. "But that's not all you missed. Evil liar, feel my fire!" Orko's bolt flew at Evil-Lyn, who dodged with a cry of disbelief, to strike Skeletor in the face. That threw him back almost as far as Adam had.

"What madness is this?" Lyn demanded. "Beast-Man, obey!"

Beast-Man's gaze was sad when he took in the dark sorceress. "My Lady," he said, voice low and soft. "Why do we serve Skeletor?"

Lyn turned a glare of contempt on Beast-Man. "I serve him to claim the power I deserve, dolt," she snapped. "You serve him because no one else will have you!"

Catra pounced on Evil-Lyn, claws slicing through her wand orb. It shattered as though made of glass. "Bzzt! Wrong again, Feeble-Lyn! The correct answer is, 'because you *told* him no one else would have him.' Honestly, could you people be more pathetic?"

Shadow Weaver raised an arm, gathering her monstrosities, and Catra froze. The woman who'd shown no fear in the face of

Skelegod trembled in terror. “Now now, Catra, be nice,” Weaver replied, and Catra stared at the sorceress. “You were little better once. Skeletor, this military campaign is lost, but you have half the Sword of Power. I recommend we take what victory we have and regroup.”

“You’re not regrouping *anywhere,* you–” Adora began, half-turning to face Shadow Weaver. Skeletor didn’t waste any time teleporting those forces still loyal to him away. She-Ra rushed to Catra’s side, vanishing back into Adora. The wives held each other, leaving Adam staring at the Dark Sword.

A furious Teela stormed over, stopping in front of him with her arms crossed. “Skeletor’s gone, Adam. Explanation. Now.”

“Back at the castle?” Adam pleaded. “I’d really like to only do this once.” Teela nodded, but her glare only grew more outraged.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora had rarely been so grateful for Catra just being there for her.

Oh, there were other times Adora had been overwhelmingly grateful for Catra. Her genius, her passion, the kindness she still struggled to show at times, just the feel of her purring against Adora, they were all moments of heart-bursting joy. Right now, though, all she needed was Catra’s hand in hers to keep her grounded.

Angella and the Sorceress of Grayskull were in Randor’s throne room via hologram. Adam had just finished explaining how the Elders had demanded that he keep He-Man secret from everyone except Duncan – the last Man-at-Arms – and the Sorceress herself. But Orko and Kringer had followed him. And Marlena and Krass’tine figured it out. And Catra…was Catra. So there was that. He wasn’t mad (exactly) at Kringer or Catra, and Orko kind of got an out from magic-Trollan-sorcery rule stuff that Adora couldn’t really follow.

Everyone else, though… "So this is my fate?" Randor rumbled. It was like an oncoming thunderstorm. "To be the laughingstock of my own court? My own family?"

"Father-" Adam tried again.

Randor held up a hand. "I am not happy that you kept this secret, Adam. Not happy at all. If the Sorceress and the Elders–"

"Just the Elders, Your Majesty," Duncan cut in.

"*Interrupt* me again, Duncan, and I will cut *you* off with an axe!" Randor roared. Adora recoiled for a moment. Catra hissed. Duncan didn't even flinch. Fortunately, King Randor composed himself. "We could not afford to lose He-Man. The powers of Grayskull held our very world hostage to your behavior. Our family can discuss the rest in private." He glanced at Marlena, who was just as unruffled as Duncan. Randor turned his glare on the Sorceress. "As for you. I trusted you, Sorceress. That was a clear lapse in judgement."

"Oh?" The Sorceress stared back with a raised eyebrow. "Could you have defeated your brother without me, Randor? Held back the Dark Hemisphere? Raised the Mystic Wall? Empowered Eternia's Defenders?" Randor seethed, but said nothing. "With power and privilege come duty and responsibility. The Elders chose Adam. It has been my experience that they chose well."

"He was not given a choice," Randor snapped. "My closest companions lied to me. *You* lied to me."

"I never lied to you," the Sorceress replied. "I told you that He-Man's identity was secret to protect him and all of Eternia. Were it not for Adora and her wife, not even the redemption of Tri-Klops and Beast-Man would save us in this dark hour."

Adora's father looked like he was about to explode, trembling and red-faced. "Hide behind excuses and half-truths all you like, Sorceress. You endangered my son, let me believe he'd become a

wastrel, played us all like pieces on a board. There *will* be an accounting."

"Oh, *shut your mouth!"* Catra snarled. The entire court came screeching to a halt. Randor stared at her goggle-eyed. "You're just upset that you were complete scut to Adam without bothering to understand him. Did you even try talking to him?"

"It wasn't like that, Catra!" Adam blurted. "He did try, at first. I had to…" He fiddled with the Dark Sword. "…I had to…" Their father looked stricken.

The Sorceress' expression softened. "I do regret that we kept this from you, King Randor, truly. Alas, you were never much good at secrecy." She smiled. "Lies do not suit you. That is hardly a slight to your character."

"She's got a point, honey," Marlena pointed out. Randor didn't look at her.

"Your Majesty." Teela took a step forward. "With your permission."

"Of course, Man-at-Arms," Randor agreed with a nod. "You did not lie to me."

"And we can have that out later," Teela said, hand on her sword hilt. "Trust me, Your Majesty, you aren't even close to the only person angry about this, but Skeletor has the Light Sword. That has to be our priority."

Randor's eyebrows became thunderheads. "And this Shadow Weaver, who made it possible. Queen Angella, you intimated that you knew how she escaped?"

Angella nodded, wings fluttering briefly. "She inscribed parts of books she requested with a teleportation circle. Only a small fraction in each, non-contiguous, but enough for her to access once we left Despondos." Catra stiffened, eyes widening in horror. Adora gave her hand a squeeze. Angella smiled at her. "Curiously,

Catra, none of the books she used for the circle were from your donations."

Catra's guilt melted into confusion. "Okay, but why would she care?"

Glimmer's sigh was as dramatic as the princess herself. "Ugh, she probably knew you'd pick it up with your ridiculously overclocked super-senses."

"Technically, overclocking does not work that way," Entrapta added, because of course she did.

Randor grunted. "Well. This is far from a total loss, at least. Scope. Rqazz." Both defectors stood at attention. "You swear to have abandoned Point Dread for Eternos?"

Beast-Man bowed his head. "Yes, Your Majesty."

"He tricked me, so." Trydor glared in three separate directions. "Yeah. All his tech should have melted down by now. His robot armies are your robot armies. I'm going to make Skeletor *pay* for what…he…" Tri-Klops trailed off when Mom walked down the steps from the thrones to face him. "Captain Glenn. Are you ready to hear my report now?" It sounded like an old reference.

Marlena slapped him. Trydor hardly moved. Then she hugged him. "I missed you, you big, obstinate dope," she whispered. His return hug was painfully awkward, but the whole court exhaled in relief.

Catra leaned over to Beast-Guy. "This isn't gonna turn into some stupid love triangle thing, is it?"

"Huh? No, no," Rqazz replied, "Trydor only likes guys that way." Catra exhaled in relief.

When Randor turned his attention back to Adam, he looked half-broken. "Adam. My boy. Is there any point in telling you to stay out of this?"

Adam shook his head. “I still have some of the power. Enough to help. I have to, dad.” He looked down at the Dark Sword. “I have a lot to make up for.”

Teela swatted him on the shoulder. “Just don’t go getting yourself killed, dummy,” she warned him. “I can’t yell at you if you’re dead.”

Adam grinned back. “Now there’s a great incentive,” he quipped.

“Hey, don’t worry,” Orko jumped in, “we’ve got new good guys, and Skeletor lost bad guys at the same time! Your sister is just as powerful as Skeletor, her friends are brilliant and amazing,” he continued, conjuring a tiara for Catra (she promptly swiped it off her head, of course), “and I’m finally in control of my magic! We’ll get the Light Sword back. You’ll see.”

“Thanks, Orko.” The old friends smiled at each other.

“So!” Adora blurted. “Now that that drama’s over with, what’s next?”

“We have two primary objectives,” Teela reported, and with an air of intense relief, everyone gathered around the Eternos war holo-map. “One is Mer-Man. With Tri-Klops and Beast-Man on our side, Mer-Man is the only remaining commander besides Skeletor with his own armed forces. Unfortunately, he rules most of Eternia’s oceans, which gives him as many troops as most of us combined. There is an up side, though.” The image flickered, then changed to show a princess who looked like Mermista’s distant cousin. “This is Princess Nami. Mer-Man has the loyalty of about half the Aquaticans. The other half, he keeps in line by holding her hostage.”

Adam frowned. “When did we get this information?” Trydor turned an unblinking gaze on the prince. Adora chuckled. “Oh. Right. Okay, so it’s rescue time.”

Ram Ma’am laughed. “Wednesday already? Man, I thought we rescued our prince for the week.”

“The other is Skeletor himself.” The hologram changed to display Snake Mountain. “He’s never been more vulnerable, militarily. All he has left are Skelcons. Kobra Khan will change that if we give him a week.” Teela grinned. It was almost like looking in a mirror. “So, we don’t give him a week.”

Catra frowned. “Splitting up again. Not much choice, but I don’t like it. There has to be a way to minimize our risk exposure.”

The holo-Sorceress cleared her throat. “I beg your pardon, but there is one bit of ‘drama’ that remains to be resolved.” Adam’s eyes widened, looking from the Sorceress to Teela. “With He-Man’s secret exposed, it is inevitable that my other great secret will be revealed. Explaining it now will allow us to avoid more dire circumstances later.”

Marlena paled. Randor looked from mom, to the Sorceress, to – Adora herself? “If you had *anything* to do with our daughter’s disappearance, Sorceress,” Randor began.

“This is not about your daughter, King Randor,” the Sorceress reassured him. She turned the saddest smile Adora had ever seen on Teela. “It’s about mine.”

For a moment, almost no one got it. Catra, Mermista, and Roboto all figured it out instantly, with everyone else understanding in a ripple from there. Only Adam and Duncan had known among the others. There was only one thing for them all to say, really: “WHAT?”

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Shadow Weaver watched as the ‘Evil Warriors’ bickered like the children they were. She tuned them out to give Evil-Lyn and Skeletor her full attention. “…can finally kill He-Man!” the skull-headed demigod cheered.

Evil-Lyn whirled on him. “And then what?” she demanded. “So you kill He-Man at last. Why? What’s it all for?”

Shadow Weaver had never imagined a skull blinking before. "You have served me for a quarter-century, Evil-Lyn, and you still don't know?" He waved the Light Sword overhead, and galaxies wheeled above them. "The Sword revealed that I was right all along. Everything is meaningless. Reality came into existence through a mindless, random act of Power. The only thing worse than that truth is the lie that men like Randor and Horde Prime spread." Skeletor glared at the false heavens above. "They pretend to grand design, seeing patterns in havoc." He smiled again, erasing the cosmos with a gesture. "I will tear down their lies and replace them with truth. The universe only makes sense when you force it to." He looked back to a shaken, cowed Evil-Lyn. "And now that I have the Power, I *can* force it to. The havoc will have meaning at last. Through me."

Shadow Weaver cleared her throat. The two sorcerers turned their attention to her. "My lord, if I may, your own grand design cannot come to fruition if the Heroic Defenders overcome you now. Here, on the cusp of your triumph, you are also at your most vulnerable." Skeletor glared, while Evil Lyn, who was still reassembling her staff, paid close attention. *Almost too easy,* Shadow Weaver mused. "With the loss of Tri-Klops and Beast-Man, you have lost most of your land forces and all of your air power. Mer-Man has ambitions of his own, ones that he will be reluctant to risk on your behalf."

Skeletor's eye sockets narrowed. "You have a solution, of course."

"Of course," Shadow Weaver agreed. "Who was the architect of that vulnerability? How did you lose Tri-Klops and Beast-Man? How did Orko transform from joke to juggernaut? Which of Etheria's heroes has caused you so much trouble?" She answered her own question with an illusion of Catra, her smirk at its most smug.

"And yet the damage is done," Evil-Lyn pointed out. "What good will retribution do us?" Skeletor merely stared.

“Retribution? I have abandoned such foolish pursuits. They cost me everything too many times. No.” She summoned images of her shadow spies to surround and consume mirage-Catra. “The Horde turned her by force of magic, once. She is more resistant, now, but you, Lord Skeletor, have the power to overcome any will. Even hers.”

Skeletor’s speed was so overwhelming, Shadow Weaver thought for an instant that he’d teleported in her face. He grabbed her by the throat and lifted her with ease. “How stupid do you think I am?” he hissed. Shadow Weaver struggled to breathe. “I have one line, witch. Children. Did you believe that I would never see what you did to that girl?”

“Sh-she is a woman now,” Shadow Weaver rasped. “Would you… throw away…your chance at godhood…for morality…now?” She clung to Skeletor’s fist, legs kicking helpless in the air. Spots appeared in her vision.

Skeletor dropped her. “No,” he admitted, returning to his throne of bone and collapsing into it. “No, I will not. But she will not be yours, witch. Catra will be mine. She will be evil again, reveling in it again. I will not permit you her misery.”

Shadow Weaver coughed, knelt, and bowed her head. “Of course, Lord Skeletor.” She rubbed her throat…and smiled beneath her mask. *All too easy.*

Chapter End Notes

1) *looks at date for last post* ... *looks at current date* ... *DIES*
1.1) Have a double-sized post to partly make up for it?

2) So, I was using a fictional curse word for Etheria that had...unfortunate other connotations outside the US. I've switched to Guardians of the Galaxy swear words. I'll probably go back and edit the older text at some point.

3) Tri-Klops' origin, and Beast-Man knowing about Keldor's scheming, is from a comic-book tie-in for the 2002 HM&MOTU series. I love the Internet.

4) Yes, that's Ram Ma'am from 2021 HM&MOTU worked into Revelations MOTU (especially since I established that Ram Man is dead back in Better Angels). Come on, they created a Catra expy, how could I *not* use her? ;-)

Eternia Saga III: Revolution

Chapter Summary

> The climax of the Eternia Saga! Skeletor's forces are in retreat – but he also controls half of the Sword of Power. What price victory?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra scowled as she tore through Skelcons. "Does anyone else think this is too easy?" she asked, ricocheting between undead foot soldiers.

Glimmer gaped at her. "*Easy?* We're fighting a horde of undead monsters that keep rising when we take them down, and you call this easy?"

Catra scoffed. "Please. Skele-dork's already running out of charge." She waved at the broad, empty plain ahead of them. "Not to mention the so-called Masters of the Universe all ran away. All we've got left is clean up." She grinned at Beast Man. "Right, Raqquill?" The defector grinned back, then howled at the sky. His beast army swept into the remaining Skelcon forces, shattering them.

She-Ra leaped back from the edge of the battle to Catra's side. "Does this seem too easy to you, Catra?" Adora asked. Catra turned a flat glare at Glimmer, gesturing toward the Princess of Power. Glimmer threw her head back and groaned. "Um, is that a yes?"

Catra smirked at Adora. "It's a yes," she agreed, blasting one squad of Skelcons with frostflame and another with a volley of stone-shot.

“Why. Are you all. So *weird?”* Glimmer cried, blasting another batch of Skelcons. Catra laughed. Adora blushed and leaped back into battle. “Do you really think that Skeletor being stupid is a trap, sis?”

“Not for us,” Catra replied, smile vanishing, “at least not today. Hey, Old-Man-at-Arms,” she called into her comm, “any word from Team Nami?”

“All green so far,” Duncan reported via comms. With her enhanced senses, Catra could just make out the veteran blasting through foot soldiers on the far south end of the battle. “My true concern is for our next advance. The Defenders of Eternos have not come so close to Snake Mountain since Keldor fought on the side of Light.”

“So, trap,” Catra summed up.

“I cannot see any other reason for his quick retreat from this battle,” Duncan agreed, to another groan from Glimmer, “though we can hardly refuse to advance.” Catra hummed a wordless agreement. *What are you up to, Skeletor?* she wondered.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

“Are you still upset, Teela?” Adam asked, still half a He-Man.

Teela gritted her teeth. “Yes,” she snapped, “but this isn’t the time. You’re not invulnerable, so pay attention!”

Adam grinned. “Yes, ma’am!” he said, racing through Aquaticans like a human battering ram.

Mermista groaned while her boyfriend laughed even more like a madman than Adam. “Ugggh. Catra’s totally right. How are they so alike when they just met?”

“Don’t look at me,” Teela objected. “I thought the Horde raised Adora to be a soldier.” They fought through the streets of

Aquatica, the city dome rippling with the flow of the waves above them.

"They did," Sea Hawk replied, uncharacteristically subdued. "Perhaps it was the pressures they endured."

Bow looked around at the jeweled, curving bronze walls, firing tangle arrows into the attacking Aquaticans. "So, um, does anyone know where we're going? We're here to rescue their princess, right?" He dodged blasts from the locals' tridents.

Ram Ma'am ricocheted off soldiers with frustrated grunts. "Yeah, but will that even help? Look at these people. They've got all the personality of Skelcons."

Mermista swept a group aside with a wave from the canals. "It's not them. I can feel their Runestone." She hesitated, Sea Hawk leaping to her side with his saber glowing almost white-hot. "It's, like, someone's using the water in their bodies to brainwash them."

Adam turned to the alien princess. "You can sense the Pearl of Power? Do you know what direction it's in?" Mermista concentrated, then pointed ahead and to their left. "Got it!" With a fierce cry, the prince charged through four walls, carving his way through with the Dark Sword. That only left double doors painted with seahorses in his way, and he threw them open.

Mer-Man was waiting for him at the end of a long hallway, sitting on what was clearly the throne of the woman beside him. Princess Nami was trapped in a sphere of something like glass, resting against what Mermista had identified as a Runestone. It looked like a pearl wider than he was tall, shining with some inner light. *He's imprisoned her right in front of it,* Adam thought, seething. "Ah, He-Man," the villain gloated, stroking the Pearl with one hand. The other held an Aquatican blaster trident. "Or should I say, He-Half? You've made a very foolish mistake challenging me here."

Under other circumstances, Adam would have traded barbs with the long-time Evil Warrior. Without a word, he raced right at Mer-Man, planting his fist in Squidish Rex's face. Mer-Man howled and went flying, allowing Adam to hack at Nami's prison. "The Pearl!" she said, hitting the crystal glass touching the Runestone. "If I can touch the Pearl for but one moment, I can free my people and protect you from that monster!"

"Monster?" Mer-Man asked, his voice low and quiet. Adam had only heard the bombastic conquerer use so quiet a voice once before. "I'll show you a monster, princess." His eyes glowed crimson, and the Pearl of Power mirrored their light.

Through the windows lining the hall, Adam saw a familiar monster take shape outside. "No," he whispered.

"Only once every twenty years can any dare to summon the demon god Bakkull," Mer-Man sneered, "except for one who commands the Pearl of Power! With Nami as my sacrifice, I will rule the oceans forever!" He laughed in triumph.

"Like, thanks for the lore dump, Jerk-Man," Mermista said, rushing at the Pearl by using a fish's tail to swim in along a canal. "Let's see how you do against a princess who isn't in a jar!" Mer-Man screamed and leaped at the Etherian, but Mermista reached the Pearl first, Bakkull's form vanishing the moment she made contact. Squidish howled and reached for Mermista's throat, only to recoil when Sea Hawk's blade flew at him. Mer-Man dodged back just in time to avoid having an arm impaled.

Krass'tine slammed into Nami's prison, bouncing off without apparent effect. *If she left even the slightest crack, though...* Putting his faith in his friend, Adam leaped up with the Dark Sword and drove it into the same spot Ram Ma'am hit. That was enough to spread hairline fractures through the prison orb. With all his might, Adam twisted and pulled, using the Sword to lever the cracks wider. "You...lose...Mer-Man!" he cried. Half a He-Man was just enough, Nami's cell breaking open before Squidish could attack.

Nami pressed her hand on the Pearl of Power. Mermista dropped back, looking exhausted even as she smiled. "NO!" Mer-Man wailed, then dove into the canal and vanished as if he'd teleported away.

"And stay out, creep," Princess Nami whispered, eyes shimmering with the same rainbow colors that her Runestone glowed with now that it was free once more. "Thank you, Defenders. I'd ask how I can repay you, but I think I have an idea."

"Well," Mermista drawled, letting Sea Hawk help her up, "I wouldn't mind hitting the kelp bar before you send your army after Jerk-Man." It was the first time in a while that Adam had heard all his allies laugh at once in the wake of a triumph. It felt good.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora couldn't help but be impressed by Duncan's auto-deployed forward operating base. It had the same green-and-orange motif that most of Eternos' military used, with bulkheads tougher than anything they'd had in Etheria's Horde and blaster turrets more powerful than tank cannons on every corner. "So, you just...have these," Adora said, knocking on a wall.

Duncan smiled. "You flatter me, Princess Adora," he said, still going over scanner data. "Do not overestimate this miniature fortress, however. It can withstand conventional arms, but not the full might of Skeletor."

"And now he has half of Adam's Sword," she whispered, looking at her own Sword in its bracer form. "Is he okay?"

"He will be," Duncan reassured her, placing a hand on her shoulder. Adora gave him a grateful smile. "Adam's tougher than he looks. Living with this burden, having to hide everything he is to protect the people he loves, has made Adam stronger than most give him credit for."

Glimmer appeared with Catra and Orko. “Perimeter's clear for now,” Catra reported, “though since we’re dealing with a guy who can rip holes in the universe with his brain, there’s no such thing as ‘secure.’”

“Gosh, sis, you’re just too upbeat for me,” Glimmer said, rolling her eyes.

“C’mon, guys,” Orko jumped in, flying between the sisters, “we’re doing great. We’ve just gotta be careful.”

Beast-Man loped over, eliciting a moment’s tension from Duncan. “You should listen to Princess Catra, imp,” Raqquill said, eyes just a fraction narrowed. “Skeletor is powerful and cunning. He might grow complacent when he has the advantage, but a rat is at its most dangerous when cornered.”

Duncan nodded. “It is strange to agree with Beast-Man. Skeletor will lash out with all his might in his next assault. Should Princess Mermista’s team emerge triumphant, Point Dread will have lost its last remaining advantage.”

“Then we’ll be ready for him,” Adora said, fingers caressing the Sword’s Runestone.

Catra slunk up to her, shaking her head with a grin. “Just remember the ‘we’ part of that, She-Ra.” She cupped Adora’s cheek in one palm. “Don’t go hogging all the good stuff for yourself, okay?”

“I–” Adora took a breath to respond, but Duncan’s console beeped, getting the attention of all present. “General Duncan?”

The old soldier pulled up a message on his screen. His smile returned. “They did it,” Duncan said, turning and nodding to the wives. “Nami is free. More than half the Aquaticans follow her now. Mer-Man’s army is useless to Skeletor now, even if the old fish stick is willing to spare troops for him.”

Catra nodded. “This is it, then. We need to get our troops into place before that Kobra Khan guy can rally whatever Bonehead has left.” She reached for the war map–

The world seemed to explode. Bruise-purple light blinded Adora, scattering everyone at the prefab base. Her ears rang, smoke billowing around them to make sight even more impossible. The only voice she could make out was Catra’s, sounding almost panicked. *That can’t be right, Catra never panics,* Adora thought, but her wife’s voice made a liar of her. “–ra! *Adora!* Say the words! Are you okay? Where are you? ADORA!”

The light and the smoke and the roaring and the pain all vanished. *Catra needs me!* Adora transformed the Sword and held it high. More lambent fury pummeled her. Adora ignored it. “For the honor of Grayskull!” she demanded. The Swordlight filled her with power, changing her, scattering the smoke and erasing her wounds. She-Ra burst free of the chaos howling around her.

Not chaos. Havoc, Adora realized with horror once she could see again. The Evil Warriors had assaulted their little outpost in force. Skeletor, Evil-Lyn, and Shadow Weaver all surrounded Catra, the love of Adora’s life pinned in havoc light and cruel darkness. Skelcons emerged from the earth and rained from above. “NO!” Adora screamed, charging at Skeletor with all her might.

Skeletor parried her slash, though he could barely stand against her. “Yes,” he cackled, retreating to the portal that Shadow Weaver and Evil-Lyn were carrying Catra through. “Don’t worry though, niece. Once I unlock all that wonderful villainy your wife is hiding away, you’ll see her again!” He disappeared, still laughing. Adora’s Sword crashed into the ground, opening a crack that raced all the way to Snake Mountain. The display of power sent the enemy soldiers fleeing, harried by the forces of Eternos. Adora screamed at the heavens anyway, venting her terror and fury. Only one thought mattered.

Catra’s gone.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

“You have got to be kidding me,” Catra drawled.

Skele-dork and his idiot sidekick had her pinned to a stone slab with bands of glowy energy, yet another skull-tipped magic rod pointed at her head. Shadow Weaver hung back, more the coward than ever. They were in some tech-less antechamber, somewhere deep within the mountain. *Almost dead center if I’ve got it right,* she mused.

Skeletor looked downright impressed, for a guy with a skull for a face. “You know,” he said, tone light and conversational, “most people I capture are a little more scared than this.”

Catra couldn’t help herself. She laughed. “That’s more of a you problem, Skull-for-a-head guy,” she shot back. “You took me alive. That means you want me alive. That’s not gonna work out for you.”

Skeletor leaned in close. Catra worried – just a little – for the first time. “Isn’t it?” he gloated. “This beauty pointed at your head,” he continued, waving at the skull-rod pointed at her head, “is the Skull Staff. It will unleash all the delightfully wicked impulses my niece has tamed in you.”

“Sure it will,” Catra scoffed. “And how can you call something the Skull Staff? All your stupid sticks have skulls on them. Seriously, what’s the difference?”

“Enough,” Evil-Lyn snapped, activating the ‘Skull Staff’ and shooting a beam onto Catra’s forehead. It wasn’t anywhere near as bad as Void-Catra had been, but the magic was more...insidious. The whispers of pain and fury she’d long held at bay grew in strength by millimeters. “Lord Skeletor, if we’re going to emerge from this debacle victorious, we must make ready to face the Defenders.

“She-Ra will stop at nothing to rescue her wife,” Shadow Weaver pointed out. “There is opportunity in that, but only if we use wit

rather than raw force. No one will overpower Adora now."

Catra chuckled, though she could do nothing else while resisting Point Dread's magic. "Hey, look who got one thing right," she breathed, bracing herself to resist Skeletor's control. "Adora is going to roll over you losers like tanks over twigs."

Skeletor laughed. Again. *I am really starting to hate that sound,* Catra decided. "I have the Light Sword, Catra. I have all the power of Point Dread. And very soon, I will have you and Kobra Khan to outwit that dunderheaded Duncan." He spun to leave, shifting his shoulders to make his cape snap dramatically behind him. "Come, Evil-Lyn." Skeletor strode out. Lyn and Shadow Weaver shared a glance before the younger witch followed her 'master.'

Oh, that's cute, Catra thought. *Feeble-Lyn thinks Shadow Weaver's going to help her get the power.* She glared at Shadow Weaver while the witch moved to follow her new overlord. "This isn't gonna work, you know," Catra said.

"You don't even know what 'it' is, Catra," Shadow Weaver replied, though without the cruelty her voice had always held before.

"Betraying everyone for power," Catra explained. "Again. Seriously, Skelegod is going to turn you into a smear on the ground. You can't…" The magicat trailed off, forced to concentrate on retaining control of herself.

"I know what I'm doing. As for you, all you need do is trust Adora," Shadow Weaver said. That brought Catra up short. *What? That's – why would she say that?* The witch turned to leave.

"Wait," Catra demanded, already half-hoarse. "Why are you doing this? None of it makes sense. You don't need Bonehead for magic, not on this planet." Shadow Weaver paused, then kept heading for the exit. "You idiot. You're going to get yourself killed." Catra wanted to shout, but she didn't have the energy, not while she was fighting off the Skull Staff.

"It's too late for me," Shadow Weaver whispered. Catra froze, and it didn't even matter that magic pinned her to the slab. She turned, and Catra wondered if she would ever see the woman again. "But you...this is only the beginning for you." With that, Shadow Weaver left, the magicat too stunned to say anything until she was gone. There was only one thing left for Catra to do.

Trust Adora.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

If we'd just gotten here a few minutes sooner... Adam stared at his sister, who sat behind Duncan, one leg bouncing at a worrisome speed. She-Ra stared into her reflection on the Sword while Glimmer, Duncan, Entrapta, and Tri-Klops (which was weird to think) looked for Catra with a mix of magic and technology. Krass'tine talked with Extendar, both heroines looking as jittery as he felt. Adam fiddled with his own blade for a moment, then gathered his courage and walked over to Adora. When she didn't even react to his presence, he risked sitting beside her. She-Ra's leg stopped bouncing. "Hey. I'm not gonna ask if you're okay. How are you holding up?"

"I'm going to kill them," she whispered. Adam's blood went ice-cold. "Skeletor. Shadow Weaver. I am going. To kill them."

Adam sighed. "Adora, I get it. I do. And if it's the only way to save Catra, then I've got your back, no matter what happens." Adora tensed. "But I think you know where I'm going, right? We both know you're not really going to kill them if you don't have to."

She turned the Sword slowly in her hands. "There's only one thing I've never told Catra, Adam," Adora said, running a finger along the blade's edge for a moment. "Fighting her was the hardest thing I've ever done in my life. Not just because Catra was so much better than anyone ever gave her credit for – not even me – but because I didn't understand. I was fighting a Catra I didn't know, and it was a nightmare." Her knuckles almost turned white from gripping the hilt. "It was Shadow Weaver. She hurt Catra

right in front of me our whole lives, and I didn't see it, not really. Catra stayed there, in her own nightmare, for me, and I left her. If a miracle hadn't happened in the Crystal Castle – a one-in-a-thousand long shot – we would have…*she* would have…" She-Ra stood. Adam joined her. "I was raised to be a soldier, Adam. I was supposed to make the hard choices, but I left them all to Catra. No more. I'm ending this. Today. Whatever it takes."

"Adora, I only met you and Catra a little while ago, but I know she'd disagree with you," Adam insisted. "You've made impossible choices, more times than I can even imagine." He put a hand on her shoulder. He could barely reach it, She-Ra was so tall. "She knows you'll do the right thing, and so do I."

Adora strode out of the FOB and glared at Snake Mountain. "Yeah. I will." Her eyes narrowed. "Wait. What is that?" Adam took out his binoculars. "There's a lizard-folk commander with them. Kobra Khan?"

Adam scowled. "Kobra Khan," he agreed, drawing the Dark Sword and holding it up. Concentrating, he matched its Subternian energy with his spark of light. "By the power of Grayskull!" This time, the transformation was smoother, more complete. He still wasn't entirely He-Man, but Adam gained muscle in addition to height. Instead of his own harness, Adam wore the golden armor of King Grayskull's legendary son He-Ro. "Huh."

Adora looked at Adam, then permitted herself her first, tiny smile since Catra's disappearance. "Not bad. It suits that slimmer body." Her smile vanished. "Are we ready?"

Teela, the Man-at-Arms, walked up with the entire allied force. The Defenders of Eternos – Ram Ma'am, Man-E-Faces, Delora, Roboto, the princess of light Illumina, Sy-Klone, the sorceress Arvela, Raenius the Clamp Champ (though Adam hadn't gotten anyone besides Orko and Kringer to use the nickname yet), Buzz-Off, Extendar, Orko, Nami, and Beast-Man – were with Teela. Glimmer brought the Etherians – Bow, Scorpia, Entrapta, Perfuma, Mermista, Sea Hawk, and Lonnie (who'd gotten the full gear

upgrade from Duncan). Randor and Marlena were landing with a force that included Tri-Klops and two other kings, a magicat and a lizard-man. The combined armies of free Eternia gathered behind them. Teela's smile was thin and humorless. "Yeah. We're ready."

"Then let's end this," Adora said, pointing her Sword at Point Dread. "For Catra! For Eternia!"

Skeletor jumped through a gate and attacked Adam. "For Dread's sake!" the villain sneered, Sword raising sparks on Sword. "Shut these walking cornballs up!"

The final battle had begun.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

No matter how many Skelcons Adora sliced through or Evil Warriors she punched across the battlefield, there seemed no end to them. Skeletor appeared to have replaced Beast-Man with a brightly-furred gorilla man named Gygor, who wore a harness like the one that used to strengthen Grizzlor. Under other circumstances, She-Ra would have enjoyed fighting him. Just then, he was keeping her from Catra. She turned the Sword into a gauntlet and punched him toward Raenius. Whiplash took a swing at She-Ra, so she slapped him into Delora's combat zone. The Avionian avenged her brother with a savage beatdown.

Kobra Khan wasn't Catra's equal, whatever the Eternians said, but he was good enough to slow Adora down, and each delay only infuriated her more. She couldn't help checking on Adam, but his He-Ro form seemed enough to hold off Skeletor, so She-Ra continued to advance.

Glimmer, bless her, teleported to her side with Bow, the duo as reliable as ever. They cleared the area around them in seconds thanks to years of teamwork. "What do you need, Adora?" Glimmer asked.

"She's in the heart of the mountain, right in the middle," Adora said, pointing at a cavern about halfway up the side. "Can you

help–" Before she'd finished her sentence, Glimmer had teleported the trio up to the opening. "Thanks. Head back and help the others."

"Not a chance," Glimmer huffed, fists glowing.

"Trust me," Adora replied, the Sword glowing when she held it before her. "I'll be fine. The moment I free Catra, we're getting out."

Bow looked worried. "What about guards and traps and stuff?" he asked.

She-Ra unleashed a beam down the cavern that left it a smooth, cylindrical hall. Glimmer and Bow stared, eyes wide and round. "What about them?" Adora asked.

Glimmer paused. "Call us if you need backup, got it?" she demanded. Adora nodded, and the duo vanished. She-Ra strode forward, sensing her wife a level above her. Some terrible magic clashed with the shining light within Catra…

…the light…

Adora felt Catra's presence, knowing her beloved with the same certainty that she felt her own existence. If she were honest, transformed into She-Ra, her body felt more alien than Catra's. The Princess of Power concentrated, Shadow Weaver's advice helping in a moment of epic irony: *You are a Princess, so you have a Runestone. With it, you channel the elemental magic of Etheria. Let it flow through the sword and into you. Focus your power.* She heard the guidance in Catra's voice instead of the witch's.

trust Adora…trust Adora…trust Adora…

She-Ra's eyes widened. *Catra?*

The thoughts were in Adora's mind, but she heard them in Catra's voice. *Adora? What the flark?*

Adora couldn't help it. She laughed, the relief erupting through her. *Catra. Thank the Stars. I'll be right…there…* The relief rushed through Catra, but so did frustration and humiliation. *You hate this, don't you?*

Being rescued? Of course not. Needing to be rescued? Duh. Whatever magic had drilled into Catra's mind had run into some implacable defense. *Yeah, that's you.*

It was Adora's turn to be frustrated. *Catra, the Swordlight's yours as much as it is mine, please don't argue right now, I need you to be safe.* Catra bit back a retort. *Shadow Weaver isn't stupid. She must have set traps. But she* always *underestimates you. Call on the power of Grayskull. Please.*

That sparked some inspiration in Catra's ever-flowing mind. *The power, huh?* she thought, and then in the distance, Adora could barely make out, "by the power of grayskull!"

Ahead of She-Ra, the ceiling exploded. Cat-Ra dropped down in front of her, wearing her multicolored armor and wielding a whip of Swordlight. Adora knew what her wife was going to say before Catra smiled or took the breath to say it. "Hey, Adora."

-SR- -SR- -SR-

The battle was a mess.

Catra looked around only to see chaos – havoc – all around them. The Defenders were pushing forward, but Skeletor kept the fight almost even all by himself. "Adora, can you clear out some idiots?" she asked.

Adora frowned. "What about Shadow Weaver?" she asked. Catra's ear twitched. Adora was right – the sorceress was nowhere to be found.

"Until she pops up, we have to focus on Skele-dork," Catra insisted. She forced a smile to reassure Adora. "Relax, Adora. I'm Cat-Ra right now. Shadow Weaver messes with me, she's going to

have a *bad* day." She-Ra nodded and plowed into the Trap Jaw/Spikor duo. Catra leaped to where Teela was pushing back Evil-Lyn with a combination of incredible combat skill and rudimentary magic power. "Hey, Feeble-Lyn." She bounced off the sorceress' helmet and raked Skeletor's legs. "Adam. You're the spark."

"I know, Catra, but I don't see how I can do more than this," Adam replied, Sword clashing against Sword.

Skeletor laughed, bolts of supercharged Havoc scattering Defenders and forcing even Cat-Ra to dodge backwards. "You can't, Adam. Not without me," Keldor crooned. "Together, we'll be invincible."

"Ugh, you are such a pain in the tail," Catra hissed. "The Sword's a great weapon, sure, but Adam, the power chose *you.* Just like Adora."

Adam shook his head. "No, Catra. Not like me. Adora's the real thing, a soldier, a champion, a hero. She's the She-Ra. I'm just the backup."

"And I'm just the sidekick," Catra growled, forming a shield of Swordlight and rushing in to fight by Adam's side, "but look at me!" Adam and Skeletor both stared, Havoc washing off Cat-Ra's tremendous power. "He-Man's not a Sword, Adam – He-Man is *you!"*

Skeletor scoffed. "Fool girl! I still have the Light Sword. Even if he claimed the full power of He-Man, he still wouldn't be my equal, not when I command the power of Preternia itself!"

Catra knew they'd won the instant Adam smiled. "The Sword," he whispered. "That's it."

"Take him down, He-Ra!" Catra cheered, leaping to Adora to fight back to back with her.

"What's going on?" Adora asked.

Catra grinned. “Just watch, Adora.”

“Teela!” Adam cried. “Do you trust me?”

Teela started to respond, then paused. She pushed back a beam of sorcery from Evil-Lyn, then nodded and smiled. “Yes,” she said.

“Defenders, hear me!” Adam called out, locking the two Swords together by their cross-guards. “Today, we end this – together!”

Skeletor focused all his lethal power on He-Ro. “And how precisely do you intend to do that, boy?”

Adam’s smirk grew, looking almost identical to Adora’s at her most cocky. “By the power of Grayskull!”

That made every Eternian sorcerer gape in horror, even while the lightning crashed onto the connected Swords. “Have you gone *mad,* He-Man?" Skeletor blurted. "You can’t call down the power when you already wield it, you’ll kill us both!”

“Unless it has somewhere to go, Skeletor. *We* have the power!” He-Man roared.

The lightning raced out, bringing columns of Swordlight down to Teela, to Duncan, to Ram Ma’am, to Kringer hiding in the royal airship, to Man-E and Delora and Sy-Klone, to Illumina and Orko and Extendar, to *all* the Defenders of the Universe.

With all that, what lightning remained was enough to re-forge the Sword of Power, tearing it from Skeletor’s Havoc Staff. “No!” Keldor cried, reeling. Adam transformed again, becoming He-Man once more. He wasn’t quite the wall of muscle he’d been, but he was close enough – and he wasn’t alone. Teela became a Sorceress in white and gold. Duncan’s armor shifted and glowed, empowered by Grayskull. Kringer became a mightier Battle Cat than ever. Ram Ma’am turned into a living embodiment of demolition, moving like a human meteor. The power filled them all, exalting the heroes of Eternia.

Catra smirked. “Yep,” she said, nodding to Adam.

Adora let out a tiny squee. “I am married to the most amazing woman *in the ENTIRE UNIVERSE!”*

Catra’s smirk vanished. “Adora! Will you stop?!” She was certain that even the humans could see her blush.

Evil-Lyn took advantage of that moment to strike – grabbing the Havoc Staff and summoning what looked like all of Shadow Weaver’s spies. While the Alliance heroes either cleared out the remaining Dread Ones or stared in shock, Skeletor transformed back into Keldor – and Lyn grew like an evil She-Ra, the flesh from her head vanishing to turn her into the new Skeletor! “At last!” Skelyntor laughed. “I am the Master of the Universe!”

Keldor stared, shocked yet somehow unimpressed. “Of course you are.” He looked up. “Please pummel her, He-Man.”

“Not if I don’t have to,” Adam replied. Keldor snorted and crossed his arms like a petulant child. “Lyn, we don’t have to do this.”

Skelyntor smirked, which wasn’t any less weird on her skull than it had been on Keldor’s. “I am the Skeletor now, He-Boy,” she sneered, “and I have advantages that Keldor did not. Shadow Weaver!”

Catra’s bones went cold when Shadow Weaver emerged from the darkness swirling around Evil-Lyn. “My lady, I must warn you, this might not work. Retreat may be in order.”

Lyn scoffed. “To where? *Come, Karak Nul!”* The Eternians all gasped when she slammed the base of the Havoc Staff into the ground, a chasm opened, and a living shadow with bones of green fire emerged from it. He wore a purple cape, skirt, and boots. “Behold, the first Skeletor!”

Keldor sighed. “Goodbye, Evil-Lyn.”

Lyn smirked back at him. “Goodbye, Keldor. I almost enjoyed our time together. Karak Nul! To come forth, you must claim a Skeletor. Behold, my sacrifice!” She pointed the Havoc Staff at her former master.

Karak Nul looked from one to the other. “He is no longer the Skeletor, woman. You are.” He stalked toward Evil-Lyn, whose mirth gave way to terror. “Show me your fear.”

A flash of knowledge rippled through the Champions from – the Sorceress? Teela’s mother appeared overhead, her smile bright and free. “When He-Man shared the power, he set me free,” she explained. “We can end the Skeletor line once and for all with your field of expertise, Champion of Halfmoon. Mercy.”

Catra’s eyes widened, and she nodded. “Hey, Orko! On me!” She rushed Evil-Lyn. “Adora, give Scare Glow there a hard time.”

“Love to,” She-Ra replied, leaping at Karak Nul. The cosmic terror formed an axe from the green flame and parried. He-Man joined in, and he parried that attack with a mace.

Catra grabbed the Havoc Staff from a stunned Evil-Lyn, who found herself protected by Beast-Man. “She’d better deserve this…hey, Orko, time for a transfer. We’re making Nul there the Skeletor.”

Orko started at Catra in shock, then looked at the Sorceress, who nodded. “Okay...Ancient power of awful madness, go back home and bring us gladness!” he chanted. The Sorceress joined in with a swirling beam of mystic might.

Scare Glow leaped back, throwing his mace at He-Man and bracing for an attack from She-Ra, only for Catra to shove the Havoc Staff into Karak Nul’s hand. “Boom. You’re the Skeletor now,” she said, only for Karak Nul to stare at his hand in disbelief. “See? Nobody has to die. You can go home.”

“I am the first Skeletor, child,” Nul whispered. Catra froze, her own hand still on the Havoc Staff. “It was so long ago I no longer

remember what my anger or jealousy felt like, but I became this to steal power from your people. You would still do this?"

For a moment, Catra was tempted. She could *feel* eons of war and death, suffering and despair, rippling from where the magicat princess and the first Skeletor were connected. *I could do it,* she realized. *I could take the power, wield Havoc and Swordlight, make them all pay for everything that's happened to us….* She swallowed, trying to contain her fury, control her grief, looking around her for a reason to–

Adora had stopped fighting. She smiled at Catra with absolute faith.

Catra let go. "Yeah. Sure. Go home, Scare Glow."

The first and last Skeletor smiled. "Thank you, Catriska D'riluth." Karak Nul dropped his axe and placed both hands on the Havoc Staff. His glowing green light consumed him entirely, and then he was gone.

"Well." Catra whirled on Shadow Weaver, who was brushing dirt from the hem of her dress as if this whole business had been cleaning out their quarters. "That was more than a bit of a tangled mess, but it all worked out in the end."

Catra stalked over to the sorceress. "Oh, no. You don't get to pretend this was all some plot to help us defeat Skeletor. You betrayed us, tore the Sword of Power in half, kidnapped me to brainwash me *again,* and almost handed this entire world to a guy with a skull for a head!"

Shadow Weaver chuckled. "Your skepticism is rational, dear, but I assure you, one of my efforts here was a 'plot,' as you put it, to ensure your defeat of Skeletor." Keldor growled and moved to stand, only for Duncan and Ram Ma'am to pin him down. Shadow Weaver leaned a fraction closer to the magicat. "Do you know the right question to ask, Catra?"

Adora moved into position behind Shadow Weaver and nodded to her wife. Catra's eyes narrowed on their former keeper, not giving She-Ra away. "Pretending I believe you, who are you trying to ingratiate yourself to?"

Shadow Weaver pressed her hands together in front of her. She seemed almost pleased. "I'm impressed. That was, in fact, the right question. As a reward, here is your answer." The colors on Shadow Weaver's robes swirled, black becoming green and red becoming white. A gray Horde symbol appeared over her chest. When Adora leaped over to grab the witch, her hand bounced off a force field.

Entrapta, who had been working with Tri-Klops on something about Point Dread's systems, looked over in excitement. "Ooo! That was tech, not magic! Where did you get a force field?"

"Horde Prime," Catra whispered, just before Shadow Weaver vanished in a beam of pale green light. Three Horde battleships appeared in the air over Point Dread. "BATTLESTATIONS!"

Tri-Klops grinned. "You don't need to worry about them, Commander Catra," he said, throwing a switch on the tech duo's console. A force screen like the one covering Etheria shielded them and reflected the starships' fire back on them. He pressed another button, and the snake's head became a massive turret that returned fire with ferocious beams the width of Darla's wingspan. "I joined Skeletor to fight the Horde, remember? I built anti-invasion defenses into the mountain decades ago, and kept them up to spec ever since."

Catra looked up, astounded by the anticlimactic defeat of Horde Prime's scheme. "Huh," was all she could say. The others felt differently, the Eternians cheering with abandon and the Etherians joining in the celebration. She and Adora watched the outpouring of joy in relief, arms around each others' waists. "Stars, Adora, this was just one world," Catra whispered. "How are we going to save the entire universe from Prime?"

Adora kissed Catra on the cheek. "Together," she replied.

Catra nodded. "Yeah."

-SR- -SR- -SR-

The holograms of Leech and Mantenna prostrated themselves before Horde Prime. "Rest assured, Majesty, we will penetrate their shields and make these accursed Eternians pay for their defiance," Leech swore. Shadow Weaver bit back a sigh.

"Don't concern yourselves with these specks, Beloved Leech," Prime said, completely unconcerned. He literally waved off their fear with a casual flick of his wrist. "Pull back the fleet. Follow them to Oa, for they shall unquestionably go there next. If the opportunity arises, destroy them. For now, though, I wish to see what this new She-Ra and her fascinating mate intend to do next."

"Your mercy is as infinite as your wisdom, Lord Prime," Mantenna gushed. The only thing worse than their obsequiousness to Shadow Weaver was their sincerity.

"I appreciate your devotion, Beloved Tolio," Prime replied, the faintest hint of annoyance creeping into his tone, "though rest assured, my mercy is not infinite. You will blockade Eternia. You will follow that relic the She-Ra dares to fly across my stars. And when I give the order, you will bring them all to me."

"Yes, Lord Prime," both aliens swore. Prime dismissed their holograms with another gesture.

Shadow Weaver glided over to Prime's side. "I did warn you that my agent had no time to sabotage Point Dread, my lord," she reminded him. Prime called up a hologram of the simian super-soldier Gygor. "Still, if I may, this is a minor setback at worst. Adora is still young and untried by your standards – ukk–"

Prime cut her off with a casual grip on her throat. "You may not," he hissed, standing. "Foolish, primitive witch. I see all. *I know all.* You might have fooled your wards with that display of callous

disregard, but your heart rate and neural activity give away everything." Shadow Weaver kicked helplessly, unable to breathe, her magic so far beyond her grasp it might as well be back on Etheria. "Skeletor was a minor nuisance, but he was a chance for you to prove that you had the wisdom to abandon your plans for those infants." The edges of her vision began to go dark. "And you – have – failed." – *no* –

"My Lord, please wait," Vultak called, flying over to kneel before Prime. "Shadow Weaver always plans to secure her position, but I assure you that given a proper chance, she can become one of the greatest shadow-binders the Horde has ever known. Her name, her arts, her nature – surely, your destiny has provided us this opportunity."

Prime looked from Vultak to Shadow Weaver and back. "Very well," Prime said, dismissive, and let the sorceress drop to the ground. She collapsed at Vultak's side, too weak and shaken to rise above her hands and knees. "You remained true to my cause and your faith, Vultak, despite being lost in exile for three decades with my failure of a little brother. Therefore, I remand this creature to your service." Even his glare at Shadow Weaver was mild and contemptuous. The sorceress could not keep herself from trembling or massaging her throat. "Remember that she is a parasite of my ancient cast-off form." Shadow Weaver's eyes went wide. *He was the Shakarran Horror?* She stared while Prime continued. "If she attempts to betray us, you are responsible for dealing with her. Do you understand?"

Vultak bowed his head. "Yes, Lord Prime."

"Good. Now go." Prime sat back down and waved with the exact careless dismissal he'd used moments before.

Vultak, at least, guided Shadow Weaver out with something resembling their old camaraderie. "That was close, old friend. Are you all right?"

"Yes, of course," she rasped, "nothing a source of energy won't cure." They left, while Shadow Weaver remembered a fraction of the legend behind the First Fallen, stripped of his divine form by the Makers, calling to mind a tiny handful of the names myth gave the Shakarran One. *Beelzebub, Shaitan, Mephistopheles, Iblis…*

…Lucifer…

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora smiled and turned around when she caught sight of Teela kissing Adam in a corner of the great hall. The celebration was still continuing, though even some of the Defenders had left to find some sleep. Krass'tine and Nami were curled up together on a sofa, not having bothered to find beds. Marlena – Mom – found Adora headed back to where Catra and Orko were coming up with silly new rhymes for spells. "Are you sure we can't convince you to stay?" she asked.

"Maybe someday, Mom, when we defeat Horde Prime," Adora said. "And, I mean, we've got like…three homes, now?" Her eyes widened. "Stars, that's right. First Brightmoon, then Half-Moon, and now Eternos." She shook off the dilemma. *Problem for future Adora.* "I'm sure we'll think of something. But once everyone's rested, we have to go and find more allies." She smiled for her mother. "I mean, we did this on Etheria. It's kind of the same thing, only a little bigger! Right?"

Marlena grinned. "To quote one of Earth's great poets, 'Space is big. Really big. You just won't believe how vastly hugely mind-bogglingly big it is.' Still, I believe in you, Adora." Her smile vanished. "I hate that I missed your childhood, that Light Hope took you and you had to grow up in that horrid place. But we have each other now."

Adora nodded. "Besides," she replied, looking at Catra, "the good thing I found there was better than all the horrid put together." Together, mother and daughter walked over to where Catra laughed at whatever spell Orko had dreamed up. Adora hadn't

quite caught what he said, but all the meat was floating several inches off the table. Just the meat. “Hey, Catra.”

Catra grinned back. “Hey, Adora.”

“So, what planet are you saving next?” Adora asked with a smirk.

Her smirk grew when Catra groaned. “What planet are *we* saving next, dork,” she retorted, “and I dunno. Oa seemed…really barren, so. Maybe that magicat world, Thundera?”

Adora hugged her wife while Marlena and Orko watched them with wide puppy eyes worthy of Bow himself. Catra just squirmed and sighed. “Wherever you want, kit.”

Chapter End Notes

> Ugh. Over two months *again.* I have reasons (if you heard about the D&D OGL mess, let's just say that made certain writing assignments urgent), but I'm still not happy with how long it's taking to get you chapters. At least most of the coming ones, except for a bit of the next story and of course the big climax, will be largely self-contained.
>
> Note: I thought about having Karak Nul kill off Evil-Lyn to show that not every change between Better Angels and Turn Right was positive, but I decided flark it, let's go for the full Paragon ending this time. Also, I really enjoyed vibing off of the new He-Man series with the classic characters, Adam sharing the Power to basically steamroll Skeletor's goons. Also also, don't mess with good Catra or Adora will TEAR DOWN YOUR WORLD.
>
> Next time: It's a comparatively brief trip to Oa, though it will be a substantial one, in which our heroes meet the Guardians of the Universe and Lore is Dumped. Then, it's the beginning of the Battle for Thundera. Who is Mumm-Ra, and what is his ancient connection to Etheria? Stay tuned for: Beware Her Power!

Beware Her Power

Chapter Summary

A trip to Oa reveals more than Darla's crew expected.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Are you sure you have everything you need, Adora?"

"Yes, mom," Adora said, and even though there is the slightest hint of frustration in her voice, the joy she feels in getting this normal moment almost overwhelms her.

'Normal,' of course, is relative given the circumstances. Entrapta is helping Roboto and Illumina load the last crate full of First Ones tools and parts intended to keep Darla running after her complete overhaul and upgrade to modern standards. Adora can't begin to keep track of everything her family's given her friends, but that's what lists are for.

And now I have anxiety. Great. Adora pulled out her tracker pad and went over the list. Mom chuckled. "Oh, I'm sorry, sweetie."

"It's okay, mom," Adora mumbled, checking their supplies of food, power crystals (good for tech and magic!), gear, personal supplies, ship supplies, and weaponry. Only Catra had accepted extra armor besides Adora herself, and that was because they had Qadian armor that suited her.

"You get that from me, Adora," Marlena replied, chuckling again. Adora decides not to say *No, I get this from Shadow Weaver spending my entire childhood traumatizing me,* now painfully aware of how traumatic losing her had been to her mother. Spending an entire hour holding each other and crying had been exhausting, but afterwards it had felt so good.

"Well, I know got your taste in movies," Adora quipped instead. They both laughed. *Frozen* night was the *best.* Catra calling Adam "Kristoff" the rest of the night had been hilarious – well, maybe that had just been Adora. *I'm going to have to ask what 'comphet' is, though–*

"Hey, Adora!" The weight of Adora's wife landed on her shoulders. "Entrapta worked the Qadian armor into my suit while we were on that snack run."

Adam chuckled while he approached. "Snack run. Right," he retorted, eyebrow raised.

Catra's purr was dangerous. "Trust me, Muscles, if we'd been up to something besides a snack run, you'd know. So would the kitchen staff. And the carpenters. And the guards. And–"

Adora grabbed Catra and put her on the ground fast enough to earn an 'eep' from her wife. "Okay!" the Eternian princess said, technically a *little* louder than necessary. Adam's whole face was bright red. "Looks like we're all set. With the stuff. On the list!" She waved the tracker pad overhead for emphasis.

Adam's eyebrow went back up. "You made a list?" he asked.

Catra laughed, and didn't that do dangerous things to Adora's heart. "Be glad she didn't make a chart," her wife answered, draping her arms over Adora's shoulders for a sneak-attack-style hug. Marlena's eyes widened.

Randor joined in the laughter as he approached. "Now that she definitely got from her mother."

"Charts are useful!" Marlena insisted. "This is why I'm in charge whenever we go into space."

"And here I thought it was because you're the trained astronaut," Randor quipped back.

Marlena huffed, and for all the comparisons of mother and daughter, Adora couldn't help hearing Catra in that sound. "Where, do you think, I learned, to make charts?"

Adora couldn't help it. She grabbed father, mother, and brother in one quick swoop and pulled them into a hug. "I am going to miss you guys," she breathed.

"We will always be here for you," Randor said, his voice gruff and just a bit choked.

Marlena and Adam nodded in perfect time. "And if you need us," her mom added, "you'd better call."

"I promise," Adora agreed. She would never break a promise again, no matter how hard it was to keep.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"It's...dead," Catra whispered.

"It's barren," Entrapta disagreed. "That's not the same thing."

Catra was not often inclined to argue with her most brilliant friend, but looking at the lifeless, ruined surface of Oa, it was hard to see Entrapta's perspective. Craters dominated the landscape. Mountain ranges still rose from where tectonic plates collided, but something had torn enormous holes in them. Vast plains that should have had wheat or grass or something on them were just featureless red-brown stone.

The sensors, though, were *sure* that something was on Oa. There was power here, vast and ancient and primordial, not magic but just as fundamental and central to life.

That's when she sees them. Rows of markers, each of them as tall as the Crystal Castle, grey except for the green symbol, a circle sandwiched between two lines, on a white disc. The field of markers has to number in the thousands. Tens, no, hundreds of thousands of markers. "What are…" Glimmer whispered.

“Memorials,” Catra replied, her voice no louder than her sister’s. “Cenotaphs, probably.”

“Why do you believe they are cenotaphs rather than tombstones?” Entrapta asked, curious even when subdued.

“They didn’t bury anyone in that rock,” Catra said. She felt a bit ghost-like herself. *Horde Prime did this.* It wasn’t a question. She knew.

“Wait,” Bow said, a hint of hope in his voice. Catra’s ears swiveled up, and Adora stood from the command chair. “I’m getting a reading just over the horizon. It’s not exactly a life sign, but it’s not exactly *not* a life sign, either.”

“Well that’s perfectly clear,” Catra quipped. Adora’s slap on her shoulder was barely quarter-hearted. No one else said anything until Darla came to a stop in front of a dozen pillars around a platform with the same circle-sandwich symbol in it. Three of the pillars were broken, but the other nine looked like simple thrones for pretty big people. The platform itself was at the top of a tall hill, or a small mountain.

Which made it all the weirder when a little blue person about a head shorter than Flutterina walked up the opposite side of the almost-mountain. They were wearing a red dress with the green symbol on a white disc over their chest. Even without magnification, the look they gave Darla was pretty obviously shade of the “what are you waiting for” sort. Catra looked at Adora, who shrugged. “Bow, is there any place for us to land?” Bow nodded and brought them down, and the whole group headed over to the platform, where the blue figure had made their way to the center of the symbol.

“Finally,” the blue spud said. “I thought you’d never get here.”

Catra had done a lot of work on herself. She was really proud of how far she’d come. Improvements or no, though, *no* one pulled that kind of scut on her without getting a comeback. “Uh-huh,”

Catra drawled. “And where have you been while Horde Prime’s been wrecking the universe? It sure wasn’t at the tailor.”

Most of the others gasped. “Catra!” Scorpia blurted, claws over her mouth. Adora threw a frustrated glare at Catra, but the laughter escaping through her fingers ruined it.

Then the blue spud...laughed. “Oh, you are a willful one. Good. We will need that for what is to come. As for my...sartorial choice, the robe is traditional, though since you don’t recognize it, I suppose it is unnecessary.” With a snap, they changed into a cool red duster with a green shirt and black slacks and boots. “Welcome to Oa. I am Ganthet.” They paused, eyes glowing bright green for a moment. “He/him.”

“Hi, Ganthet,” Adora jumped in. “I’m Adora, she/her, well, I guess being She-Ra’s a bit of a giveaway on that, but we’re from Etheria, and...is anyone else alive here?”

Ganthet smiled. “Follow me,” he said, then turned and started heading back the way he came. Entrapta buttoned up Darla and the team followed him to a smooth spot at the base of the hill. Catra had just enough time to realize it was a circular spot before a green cylinder formed around them and they were headed down a *long* elevator.

“If there aren’t people after all this, Ganthet, you’d better be claw-proof,” Catra warned.

“Or bots!” Entrapta gushed.

The others were staring at them, except for Mermista, who managed to look slightly less bored. “What is wrong with you?” Glimmer blurted.

Lonnie groaned. “Who in Brightmoon thought adopting her was a good idea?”

Ganthet, though, took all this in…and chuckled. “It is quite all right, Your Highness,” he replied to Glimmer, his smile calm and

gentle. *He's like if Bow were a thousand years old, but still Bow,* Catra mused. "You are a lively lot. You remind me of other heroes I once knew." The smile faded. "Some time ago."

Before Catra could interrogate him about that, the lift stopped, the cylinder vanished, and they were in a city that could've eaten Eternos as an appetizer. It wasn't all green, with gleaming silver towers and golden roads, but the same emerald color of the symbol dominated the metropolis. It just went...on, vanishing over the horizon in every direction. "Is this…" Bow whispered.

"Welcome to Oa," Ganthet replied. "Home to the Guardians of the Universe, what remains of us at least, and the Green Lantern Corps."

Mermista blinked. "The what now?"

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Lonnie stared at the collection of flying people in green uniforms. She was beyond shock.

Aside from the thousands of robots that had Entrapta deep into a nerdgasm, there were hundreds of Green Lanterns in every shape and size, ranging from a round crystal being with several tentacle limbs that was about Ganthet's height to a bronze-scaled dragon almost the size of Darla. A majority of them were humanoid, though even the Etherian didn't recognize half of their species.

What Lonnie did recognize was the sparring ring – though 'sphere' was a better term since they could all fly – with several groups facing off in pair vs. pair combat or simulated crises. A Scorpia-sized woman with a hippopotamus face ran the training scenarios in a way that any Horde Force Captain would have understood. Even with the obvious translation tech helping, Lonnie was only able to understand the woman's frustration, and that "poozer" was clearly some sort of insult. After a few moments of this, the Corps Captain flew over to Ganthet. "The new ring wielders are coming along, Guardian," she reported.

“That is good to hear, Kigalia,” Ganthet replied, “though not why I called you. We have visitors, from Etheria.”

Kigalia looked over Darla’s crew. “The ghost planet? It’s real?”

“You’re hiding a whole army down here–” Catra snarked.

“We’re not soldiers,” Kigalia huffed.

“–and you think we’re weird?” Lonnie rolled her eyes while Glimmer and Bow shared a nervous chuckle.

Adora rushed to the front of the group. “Look, we’re trying to unite the galaxy – galaxies? – against Horde Prime, so maybe we could work together?”

Kigalia glared down at Adora, then pointed a ring at her and did what looked like a scan. Catra leaped to Adora’s side and hissed. Kigalia just added Catra to the scan sweep. “Flark,” she cursed. “You both have way too much magic for a power ring.”

“Rings?” Adora asked. “I thought you used lanterns.”

Kigalia grinned. It was surprisingly friendly. “We charge the rings in our lanterns.” The smile vanished as quickly as it came. “Rings and magic don’t play well, though.” Glimmer’s sigh was explosive.

“With one exception,” Ganthet added, “lost on a distant planet long ago.”

“That’s okay, though, you can’t all be living magical superpowers – oh, come on!” Kigalia blurted after adding Glimmer, Perfuma, and Scorpia to her examination.

“We have non-magical people!” Glimmer gushed, and Lonnie suddenly found herself yanked to the front of the group with Bow next to her. They looked at each other, Bow’s panicked expression a perfect display of how Lonnie felt. *Glimmer, I love you, but I swear to Hordak we are going to* talk *about this later,* she fumed.

Sea Hawk stepped forward with a wide smile. “I, too, am both awesome and without magic.”

Kigalia scanned him. “No,” she replied, tone even. It still amazed Lonnie how Sea Hawk’s mustache seemed as animate as Entrapta’s pigtails, the way it could shine and droop on cue. She then turned to Bow and Lonnie. “Hm. Better,” she continued, the green energy flowing around them. “Impressive. Green Lanterns are one in trillions, and you both have potential.”

Bow swallowed. “Isn’t this, you know, a lot?” he asked, nervous. Entrapta took his hand. Lonnie couldn’t help a smile.

Kigalia’s gaze was implacable. “Yes. A Green Lantern must be honest.”

Bow’s nervousness disappeared in a fit of frustration. “That was *one time!”* he blurted. Adora and Catra laughed. Glimmer slapped her forehead.

“A Green Lantern must be fearless. That does not mean never feeling fear,” Kigalia continued when Lonnie took in a breath to object, “but we must never succumb to fear for our selves. Most of all, a Green Lantern must have the inner fortitude necessary to command the Emerald Light of Will.” The scan ended.

A ring shot over, stopping in front of Lonnie’s face. The former Horde soldier yelped. “Lonnie Turron,” the ring said. Lonnie managed not to freak out at this object knowing her family name when she hadn’t used it since she was five. “You have the power to overcome great fear. You have been chosen as a Green Lantern for Sector 1.”

Glimmer made that high-pitched joy-whine Brightmoon called a squee. “I knew it!” She glanced at Bow. “But what about–”

“I’m good!” Bow blurted. “Really, I’m good.”

Ganthet smiled, clasping his hands at his waist. “There is a bit of a tradition,” he said, “of Green Lanterns working alongside archers

with unusual arsenals."

Lonnie reached out to the ring, and it flew onto her finger. Power surged through her, filling her body and offering itself to her mind. An armored version of the Green Lantern uniform took shape around her. She floated off the ground, basic knowledge of shaping the ring's light coding itself into her thoughts. Lonnie formed a stun baton, combat bot, and miniature tank before she realized that her Rebel friends were freaking out a little. "Whoa," she breathed. "Is this what it's like for you, Glim?"

Glimmer did her nervous laugh thing. "I mean, I don't know? Probably, because it's light, but it's also not magic, so, honestly, I have no idea please stop making Horde things."

Lonnie shook her head to clear it, landing back on the ground. Her light constructs vanished. "And there's thousands of you? Us? Who can do all this? How is the Galactic Horde still a thing?" she asked.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"You had to ask," Catra muttered. Lonnie glared, but said nothing.

It had been one thing to see Light Hope's best guess. It was another entirely to look at the reality. "The Horde, or 'true' Horde as I suppose you would call it, has resources unlike any we have faced before," Ganthet explained, the crew gathered around a holo-map with a few of Kigalia's Lanterns. "While the Horde has been a concern for most of universal history, their greatest expansions rarely exceeded ten thousand galaxies. In the last 27 millennia, Horde Prime has expanded to cover 102,518 galaxies, though he only has complete control over 98,693 of them."

"Oh, is that all," Catra whispered. She didn't have the heart to snark at full strength. The others just stared.

Ganthet looked at Catra for a moment. "Your compatriot Light Hope's assessment was sufficiently accurate, given the number of galaxies under partial control, that I can use it as an

approximation. Let us say for simplicity's sake that the Horde controls worlds equivalent to 100,000 galaxies. Each of those galaxies has an average of 10 trillion sentient inhabitants. That gives Horde Prime control of about one quintillion thinking beings." The number – 1,000,000,000,000,000,000 – appeared briefly over the cosmic map. "That does not include his vast non-sentient force of automatons. While liberating our system has an effect greater than its populace, thanks to the presence of Eternia, Oa, and the Great Clock, you can see that his resources have become overwhelming even for Green Lanterns."

The heroes all stared at the image. Even Adora looked bleak. "Hasn't anyone tried, you know, taking out Horde Prime?" Glimmer asked. "Catra's pointed out lots of times that he's their single point of failure."

Kigalia snorted. Ganthet sighed. "While the Green Lantern Corps prefers to avoid the use of lethal force, Horde Prime has many rivals without such compunctions. Even we have lost track of how many times the Horde's enemies have killed its leader's body."

Catra swallowed. "So he's immortal."

"His true form is made of an energy beyond even the knowledge of Oa," Ganthet explained. "We do know that he has long sought to destroy the champions of Eternia and Etheria. Since you have come to us, I surmise that you have not found a solution on either world."

"We were hoping that Thundera might have answers," Adora suggested. "Halfmoon's records speak of ancient spirits of evil that the magicats defeated and imprisoned there. Maybe the people on that world remember why he hates She-Ra."

Ganthet nodded. "Possible. Possible. It is as good a place to start as any." He smiled. "Now. Eternia has supplied you well. I can only offer a handful of technologies that might aid you."

"Oh, I would be happy to debate that. At length," Entrapta gushed. Catra couldn't help a smile at her treasured friend.

"Regardless. Princess Entrapta, since you seem interested, I offer you a data pad with connectivity to the Book of Oa." Ganthet handed her what looked like a slender tracker pad. Entrapta responded with a coo of joy that others could be excused for missing over the whip-like crack of her hair grabbing the device. "Master Bow. Our long experience with heroic archers has inspired the Green Lanterns to device a replicator, that you might never run out of your ammunition of choice."

Bow took a quiver from a Lantern with a bird-like face, his expression one of joy and awe. "Ooo. Thank you. How does it work?"

"Energy replication technology," Ganthet explained. "The quiver has an integrated digital instruction manual." The Guardian grinned at Sea Hawk. "Last, but certainly not least. Sea Hawk." The pirate puffed up his chest. "While we of Oa take pride in our Green Lanterns, the Emerald Light is but the center of a spectrum of emotional powers. I have...some experience with the light of hope." He held out his hand, and this time a blue ring flew to it. "Though not nearly as powerful as the rings of will in most hands, the Blue Lanterns have served with distinction for millennia."

"A ring of hope," Sea Hawk gasped, taking the ring. "I shall honor this with all the skill of Etheria's greatest pirate!" Mermista chuckled and rolled her eyes, but gave him a fond nudge.

"Question," Catra jumped in, forcing herself to behave this time. "What's the Great Clock?"

Ganthet outright smirked. "A marvel of science and sorcery constructed in the exact center of the universe…give or take fifty feet."

They all stared. "You made that up," Mermista accused.

Kigalia shook her head. “If only that were true,” the Green Lantern drill sergeant sighed.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

“Are you sure about this, Mermista?” Adora asked. Glimmer forced herself not to bounce in her seat.

“Like, we were just on a planet with no surface water,” Mermista pointed out. “Sure, Thundera has seas and stuff, but you do know what ‘arid’ means, right?”

“Besides,” Sea Hawk added, striding up with a grin, “should the Horde attempt a foolish return to Etheria, it will have the mighty Mermista defending it, my sword and ring at her side!”

Glimmer stood, in part to burn off some energy, and walked over to where Catra, Bow, and Entrapta were getting them through Light Hope’s world shield. “Everything okay?” the princess asked.

“Yes,” Bow said slowly, Catra nodding more to herself than her sister. “Are you okay, Glimmer?”

“Of course!” Glimmer said as brightly as she could. “It’s just Lonnie’s busy practicing with her ring and we’re trading Mermista and Sea Hawk for Hordak and Double Trouble and we’re trying to save so many people I’d never even *heard* of that number before and–” Glimmer stopped to take a breath, only to find that Catra had looked up, ears pointed at the ceiling, and she and Bow were both turning worried looks toward Glimmer. She hugged them both on impulse. “Okay, maybe I’m not doing as well as I thought.”

“We’re gonna be okay, Glimm,” Catra insisted. “Entrapta’s creating a bubble of shield around us, like an airlock for Etheria, and then we’re going to put Mom in touch with Eternia and Oa. After that, we’ll get Thundera on our side.”

“Then what?” Glimmer whispered. “The Horde is…I can’t begin to figure out how we beat them. Even if we do, I mean, let’s say we

stop Horde Prime. What happens to the literal *billion* worlds he rules?

"I'm working on it," Catra sighed. "I hate to say it, but I think – I think we have to use the Horde against itself. Once we take Prime out, my bet is we can use the hive mind to get everyone on board at once. Like one of Entrapta's computer virus things, but for clones."

"We're through," Bow reported. "Landing in two minutes." Glimmer nodded and watched Darla alight on the field outside Brightmoon. Angella followed them in, already waiting when the hatch opened.

Glimmer teleported out, putting on a brave smile. "Hi Mom!" she cheered. "We did it – well, Oa didn't need saving, but – oof!"

Her mother wrapped Glimmer in a fierce embrace. "I am so glad you're home."

"Mooom…" Glimmer hugged her back. "We're okay. Everything turned out all right."

Angella shifted the hug to hold Glimmer by the shoulders. "I know, but you are going out there again so soon – by the Presence, is that a Green Lantern uniform?"

Glimmer grinned while Lonnie approached, almost back to her old Horde posture. "Yes ma'am. I'll look out for them," Lonnie promised.

"Intel flash, Lonnie, we don't need a babysitter," Catra drawled, striding out with Adora and Mermista. Sea Hawk trailed behind them.

"Do you not?" Angella blurted, rushing over to hug Catra. Glimmer couldn't decide whether she wanted to laugh at her sister or defend her. "Skeletor captured you! *Shadow Weaver* captured you!"

“Mom!” Catra half-yowled. “They had to put so much work into that, it cost them Eternia! I’m *fine.”*

“Then,” Micah said, emerging from the castle gate with several others following, “you won’t mind staying a day so we can make sure of that.”

Catra’s tail lashed while Mom let her go. None of Darla’s crew objected. *This fight against the real Horde isn’t going to be hurt by us taking one day. Stars know how long it’ll take to win.*

Chapter End Notes

Hi! I'm not dead!

...okay, so this is kind of an Interstitial, but it does important set-up, and after ... (checks notes) let's just say *way* too long, I didn't want to wait until I had the entire Thundera adventure written to post this. I intend to get that one up ASAP, but after that, it's going to be a while before the next post again. The perils of writing for a living...

I am planning on condensing my version of Season 5, which is kind of a disappointment to me because I had some pretty interesting adventures planned with all the crossover stuff, but I think I can get everything in with just a few more chapters. No final count yet, but I do still intend to finish Turn Right. Thanks to everyone who's still reading!

Ancient Spirits of Evil

Chapter Summary

Team Etheria and the Horde come to Thundera. Both find more than they bargained for.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"C'mon, people, we don't exactly need more gear," Catra pointed out. "Words I never thought I'd say, but here we are."

"After going to space! And two planets with advanced technology!" Entrapta gushed, hugging a hyperspace engine part with her hair.

Hordak's smile was gentle and fond, which looked downright creepy to the magicat. "While we will find more developments that can assist us, there are few worlds in the universe more advanced than Oa, and Eternia retains an unexpectedly high level of development."

Adora glanced at the old clone. "Why didn't you expect it, Hordak?" she asked.

"The collapse that followed Mara's defection and the subsequent rebellion against the era's Skeletor caused a significant loss of First Ones technology, particularly that using magic," Hordak explained. "In that context, they seem to have recovered with impressive speed, replacing magical energy sources with those based in more traditional physics."

"It's fascinating!" Entrapta added, returning without the engine part. "I've been accessing the Crystal Castle's files on pre-Despondos Eternian technology, and the divergence in Eternos has taken some really interesting paths." She tapped on her tracker pad with hand and hair alike.

Sea Hawk's ring glowed blue for a moment before the hologram of a girl in her mid-teens appeared over the screen. She looked somewhat like a young Light Hope, but with simulated hair in a ponytail reminiscent of She-Ra's, albeit longer. "Greetings, user. Hope systems are online. What is your query?"

Catra felt something cold grip her heart. "Entrapta? Who – what is that?"

Adora gasped and rushed over, while the hologram looked – guilty? "She looks kind of like Light Hope, but also Mara?" Adora leaned closer to Entrapta's pad. The hologram smiled and waved sheepishly. "Hello?"

"Sorry, I couldn't resist," the image replied. "I didn't realize that would mess with Catra. I'm, well, Hope. The Crystal Castle's systems rebooted, and that created me."

Catra stepped closer while Entrapta squeed. That got Bow's attention as well. "You're Hope? Like, your name is Hope?" Catra asked. It felt like her heart started again.

Hope nodded. "The crystals that made Light Hope 'alive' were sorta erased when the backlash from destroying the planet-killers hit. First Ones systems created me from her knowledge and scans of Mara's memories. So that's me!" She smiled again, more bright and optimistic this time.

"Okay." Catra swallowed. *I'm not losing Light Hope's kid.* She crossed her arms. "What do you need?"

Hope stared. "Me? I'm a magitech crystal intelligence. Mostly, I just need contact. I answered Entrapta's query so I could help."

Adora put a hand on Catra's shoulder before the magicat could respond. "She'll be okay, Catra." Adora put on her brave smile. "Hope's got all Etheria looking out for her."

"What about the backlash thing?" Catra asked, ears twitching back.

"I took care of that," Entrapta replied, pulling up schematics that she clearly thought someone who wasn't her could follow. "I didn't expect a new mind to form this soon, but I thought we might want to build a new Light Hope, or backup systems could form one. Which they did! So I separated the power conduits from the cognition systems. Hope can still program them, but psycho-etheric feedback shouldn't be able to harm her."

"I've sent Entrapta some models on engineering principles on Eternia," Hope said, and Entrapta cackled with joy while going over her pad, "and I have some files on Thundera?" Her smile turned nervous again. Catra sighed. *Another mouth to feed,* she decided, though she couldn't help a faint smile of her own. It wasn't Light Hope, but it was...part of her, she imagined.

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"Galactic rim passed," Bow reported. "Thundera coordinates confirmed." He turned and gave Adora a smile. "We should be there in half an hour."

Adora looked around. Her friends manned the bridge. Even Double Trouble was mostly behaving themselves, changing faces while they went over files. Catra still hadn't returned. "I'm...going to get a snack," she said. The excuse sounded weak to her own ears, but no one called her on it, not even Glimmer. Double Trouble did chuckle to themselves while she retreated, but said nothing.

Adora *did* get a snack, of course. It wouldn't do to lie to her friends, and, well, she was hungry! That didn't stop her from making a detour into the training room, Adora's plate full of protein buns balanced in one hand while she walked in on her wife.

Watching Catra pummel her way through simulated foes without a spark of magic was almost as thrilling as that word, 'wife,' still providing a jolt of joy after a year of marriage. The ferocious determination on said wife's expression while she brought down

humanoid drones (Entrapta got weird when someone called them robots, for some reason) worried Adora, though. “Catra?”

Catra yelped and jumped, tail puffed up. They’d been married long enough for Adora not to mention how cute Catra looked, but Adora couldn’t help cooing at her amazing wife. Then Catra huffed and looked away. “What?” she demanded, pulling off her gloves and summoning her trauma caps to her claws.

“I, I, just, you look good.” Adora’s smile came and went in moments. “Are you okay?”

Catra took a breath to answer, then let it go without the “I’m fine” Adora was sure she’d been about to say. Her ears tilted back a fraction. “I’m just concerned. Which is not the same as worried,” she clarified. Adora had grown wise enough over the years since leaving the Horde to not touch that hedge with a ten meter cannon. Catra accepted her silent response and started pacing. “There’s just so much we don’t know about the rest of the universe. Sure, that Ganthet guy loaded up Darla with all kinds of intel, but it’s literally too much.” Her ears pivoted farther back. Adora walked up, offering a hand. Catra took it. “And this Thundera thing is basically me playing a hunch, kind of a crazy one really, because they’re cats, and there’s a guy with the -Ra thing mixed up in it.” She glanced at Adora out of the corners of her eyes. “Ugh. This is why I hate emotions. They’re exhausting.”

Adora couldn’t help a chuckle. “You’re beautiful when you’re grumpy.”

Catra’s eyes flew wide for an instant before she regained her composure and scoffed, though Adora recognized the blush under the fur. “No one’s beautiful when they’re grumpy.”

“You are,” Adora insisted.

Catra tossed her hands in the air, but her ears un-pinned, so Adora called it a win. “Ugh! Will you focus? This is about Thundera.”

Once Catra's hands came back down, Adora took one again and tugged her wife toward her. "Catra. I get it, I promise." That got Catra's attention. "This is...it's so big. Entrapta said something about our brains not being designed to handle this kind of scale. But we've got to start somewhere, and after what we learned in Halfmoon, Thundera's as good a place to start as any. Okay?"

Adora's heart melted when Catra nuzzled her, marking her jaw line. "Okay," the magicat agreed.

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Catra didn't like this.

It wasn't like the planet was empty *per se,* but it was a world of stark hillsides and wide, empty plains. A few cities dotted the surface, there were forests and jungles, and Mermista's fears aside, the oceans covered almost half the planet, but it seemed rough somehow, almost incomplete. From orbit, Thundera looked like it had...seams, or something. She'd never admit it, but it creeped Catra out. "Maybe this was a bad idea," she muttered.

"It'll be fine, sis," Glimmer insisted, doing one of her patented teleport flash-hugs.

"Their largest city is up ahead," Bow reported. "We should see it just about – whoa," he gasped. Catra couldn't help staring a bit herself.

An entire city sprawled within the shelter of a massive castle shaped like the head and forelegs of a great cat. Just the part on the surface was almost the size of the entire city of Halfmoon, and the castle extended into a huge mountain with the top sliced off. *Mesa, it's called a mesa,* Catra remembered, just before she remembered to breathe.

"Incoming!" Lonnie warned, her ring flaring bright. "Three Horde cruisers coming in hot!"

The bridge crew raced into position. Catra could feel Adora worrying about taking the captain's chair – she'd wanted to switch with Catra between worlds – but swapping the chain of command like that didn't sit well with the magicat. Leaping into her pilot's seat, Catra scanned for enemies. "Enemy targets confirmed," Darla reported, and the targeting systems picked up the cruisers entering the atmosphere with thousands of drones accompanying them. Except they weren't heading for Darla, or the city. The entire invasion force was descending into the middle of a barren desert.

"What are you looking for," Catra muttered, flipping through scanner systems until the magneto-resonator picked up a titanic metal pyramid, mostly underground, with four needle-like protrusions around the surface apex. *Weapon systems, probably,* Catra guessed, seconds before they proved her right by firing lightning bolts at the assault force. What she hadn't expected were the tank-like spaceships that rose up to meet them. Blunt, rounded vessels of deep purple with angry red canopies opened fire on the Horde ships. "Those can*not* be Thunderan ships," the magicat hissed.

"Well, they're fighting the Horde, so we should help," Adora said, standing. "It wouldn't hurt to come at them from the opposite side of those other ships, though. Catra, you have the chair. Lonnie, you're with me." Catra took a breath to object, then watched Lonnie change from her duty outfit to her Green Lantern armor. *Oh. Right,* she thought, remembering the power Lonnie wielded.

"You heard her, Bow, prepare to open fire on the rear Horde cruiser. All princesses, to your stations." Catra brought up the pilot controls on the captain's chair. She brought them about, spiraling away from the drone fighters while She-Ra and Lonnie flew through the upper atmosphere with nothing but light made into power. "Fire!"

Bow's targeting skills were as phenomenal as ever. He cleared out the rear drones protecting the cruiser, then strafed the ship's

engines while Catra raced them past it. “Catra, the non-Horde ships are targeting us, but haven’t powered those weapons yet,” he warned.

“Yeah, figured them for hostiles,” Catra muttered. She kept her awe at how Adora and Lonnie carved through Horde drones under control. *That ring can do some* serious *damage,* she thought. “Coming around for another–”

“This is the Feliner calling First Ones vessel,” a deep voice echoed over the comms. “We’re coming in from under the Horde ships, confirm.”

Catra let herself grin. “Confirmed, Feliner. Good hunting, but wow, I thought Catra was a dead giveaway.”

“Your ship’s name is Catra?” a younger voice asked.

Catra cackled as they caught the Horde in a crossfire. The cruisers and surviving drone fighters retreated. “No, that’s my name. The ship’s called Darla.”

The newcomers paused. “Did you say ‘Darla?’” a third voice asked.

“Our engineer decided it felt right,” Catra explained, smirk growing.

“Lion-O. Tygra. Later,” the deep voice sighed. “Follow us in, Darla. We’ll make sure the Plundarans don’t try anything.”

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora kept her agitation to a minimum, only shifting her weight from foot to foot, while the Thunderan champions – literally called Thundercats, which almost made her smile – faced the Plundaran leaders. Reptilians, canines, avians, and humans stood with them, apparently led by a muscular reptilian with a wide face, a tall, slender canine with very short fur, and an avian who looked half-pigeon. A rodent-man stood at the front of the Plundarans, with

most of the same peoples alongside him as the Thunderans, though furred primates followed him rather than the more First One-like people with the Thundercats.

"So you're Lion-O," Catra cut in, getting the attention of both leaders, "and you're Ratar-O, right?" she asked the Plundaran. "Well, you'll both just be zeroes if the Horde wins."

"That sounds familiar," Lion-O agreed, eliciting a grin from the magicat.

Adora took a step closer to her wife when Ratar-O glared at her. "Cats always lair together," he snapped, a sword of dark metal quivering in his hand. It had an empty slot the size of the gem in Lion-O's sword. "The enemy of my enemy is not necessarily my friend."

"Come now, Ratar-O," a new voice added, and the big Thundercat, Panthro, stiffened. His eyes narrowed, glaring at the approaching newcomer. He was another magicat, almost two heads taller than Catra and twice as wide, with a single dagger-like tooth protruding from his upper lip and a mace the size of Entrapta. "We're all friends here. Isn't that right, Your Majesty?" He gave a slight bow to Lion-O, though it seemed mocking. Catra let out a faint hiss. It got worse when a second Thunderan, this one with twin white stripes in her hair, joined the long-toothed figure.

"Grune," Panthro snarled, hand on his twin-headed weapon.

"Pumyra," Lion-O added, sounding half-heartbroken. Adora could relate. Grune smirked. Pumyra glared.

"Now now," a new voice rasped. Pumyra held out a projector, and it formed a hologram of a thin, frail-looking figure wearing bandages and a red cloak. "This is not the time for petty grudges."

"Petty?!" Tygra snarled, taking a step toward the figure before the reptilian leader and slender blonde feline each put a hand on one

of his shoulders. “You ravaged our world, slaughtered billions, enslaved trillions, and you call our outrage petty?”

“Most of your grievances are a thousand years old,” cloak-guy replied, “from before an agent of Eternia wielded the power of She-Ra.” Adora stiffened while the Thundercats looked at each other in confusion. Catra stepped between Adora and the hologram. *I know I was fighting out in front of everyone,* she thought, *but the way he says it makes it sound creepy.*

“Panthera recorded that time in the Book of Omens, Mumm-Ra,” the slender woman said, her voice calm but her gaze fierce. Catra’s ears shot up at the villain’s name. “You offered alliance the last time the Horde came.”

“And it worked, Cheetara,” Mumm-Ra hissed with a smile. “Together, our alliance drove the Horde out of our galaxy in an age that saw Prime triumphant in ten thousand other galaxies. Thundera retained advancements in technology that a million other worlds thought mere legend.”

Cheetara hissed back. She wasn’t smiling. “Then you turned around and put entire species in chains.”

“You would have been first among my peoples,” Mumm-Ra retorted, smirk growing, “if you could have refrained from resisting.”

“As much as I love unsolicited history lessons,” Catra snapped, “this is time we can’t afford to waste. You,” she continued, waving at Lion-O and the other species’ commanders, “can we trust evil He-Ra and the Rat King to keep their word?”

“Slithe?” Lion-O asked, the cat-king’s allies also looking to the heroic reptilian.

Slithe paused. “You trust me?” he asked.

Cheetara chuckled. Tygra rolled his eyes. “I wouldn’t have asked you if I didn’t,” Lion-O said.

Slithe nodded, turning piercing looks on Mumm-Ra and Ratar-O. "Both of them will scheme, deceive, and manipulate. If they give their word, though, they'll keep it – to the letter. Be wary of what bargains you make with them."

Catra smirked. "Well, that makes it simple. You both agree to work with us until we drive off the Horde, with no tricks or double-crosses or weasel word core-scut – until 24 hours *after* we drive off the Horde. Deal?"

The Plundarans and Mumm-Ra's forces stared. To Adora's surprise (and relief), Ratar-O laughed. "For a Cat, cat, you have nerves of Thundrillium!" the emperor said, leaning on his sword. "You have a deal."

Mumm-Ra glared at Ratar-O. "How dare you presume to speak for yourself, rodent, let alone the Ever-Living?" Adora tensed while the two conquerors stared each other down. "I loaned you the Sword of Plundarr to destroy the Thundercats, and I can reclaim it without effort!"

Adora couldn't help the swelling in her heart when Catra smirked. "You just said you've been fighting the Horde and the Thundercats for a thousand years. How's that been working out for you?"

Ratar-O snarled, tail lashing. "And that was with Plundarr beside you," the emperor said, hands tightening on his sword's hilt. "Imagine what fate you will meet with us *against* you."

"Fool," Mumm-Ra sneered. He held out his hand. The sword disappeared from Ratar-O's grip, appearing wherever Mumm-Ra was. The Rat emperor stared at his empty palm while the ancient villain smiled. "I fought the first Skeletor, befriended the champions of Halfmoon, bargained with ancient spirits of evil when Prime rose to challenge us."

Several of the Etherians gasped. "Ancient spirits...of evil...it was you," Catra whispered. "My people created the She-Ra to stop you."

Mumm-Ra shook his head, still smiling. “Though it would amuse me to let you believe that, I must disabuse you of such comfortable simplicity. The vile entity you know as Horde Prime unleashed four great evils upon this universe when he betrayed the Presence: Nemesis, Apophis, Pyron, Setebos. I fought alongside the first She-Ra until I realized she could never ensure true freedom in the universe.”

“You’re a First One,” Adora said, forming the Sword of Protection from her bracer. “Like me.”

While Mumm-Ra’s agents stared at Adora, the sorcerer nodded. “Very much like you, once. I sought only order. I believed that sentient beings must be tamed, forced into obedience, until I saw what Prime did to the minds of his victims.” He tightened his grip on the Sword of Plundarr. “Nothing is evil unless it is chosen. With She-Ra granted power by ancient spirits of good, I sacrificed my very salvation for my friend to ensure that ancient spirits of evil would channel their investments through me rather than Horde Prime. I raid, terrorize, and conquer so that people will choose submission, cowardice, ambition, betrayal – or justice, truth, honor, and loyalty.”

Adora looked on in horror, forcing herself not to glance at Catra for fear she would think Mumm-Ra’s evil could ever be compared to her. “She wouldn’t have wanted that! No She-Ra would ever want that!”

“No. She didn’t.” His smirk was disturbingly, impossibly wide. “Yet we have torn Horde Prime’s conquests down to remnants hundreds of times over the countless eons.”

“Then join us!” Catra demanded, arms wide. “Fight with us! If you did this, became this, to stop the Horde, do it again!”

Mumm-Ra shook his head. “I will not yield my option of treachery. I will, however, help you in my own way.” He gestured again, and the image of a collapsed mountain of black stone and red crystal appeared. “Thundera once had a Mount Plundarr, before Lion-O

and I destroyed it battling over the Swords and Power Stones. For reasons I will not bore you with, the Darkness Stone now resides within its ruins." Ratar-O's eyes flew wide. "The Harpies that obey Vultaire search the plains in that region for the Stone. It is only a matter of time before they find it."

"A Darkness Stone?" Lion-O scoffed. "There are only five Stones. You think you could trick us with this?" He waved at the image in dismissal.

"I only told your ancestor of five, boy-king," Mumm-Ra mocked, reappearing in the hologram. "The Light Stone demands one of Darkness for balance." He pointed at the Sword of Protection. "If you do not believe me, perhaps you will believe your own eyes."

They all stared at Adora. Catra gasped and put her hand on the Sword's hilt. "Your Runestone," the magicat gasped.

Grune's eyes locked onto the Sword of Protection. "Isn't that interesting," he muttered, taking a step toward Adora.

Panthro pulled his weapon, a pair of rods connected by a chain, but Catra interceded first by forming a wall of stone between Grune and Adora. "Back off, snaggletooth," the magicat snarled. Glimmer and Scorpia moved into position behind her.

Grune hissed and began to lift his enormous mace, but Mumm-Ra held up a translucent arm. "Enough, Destroyer," he ordered, and Grune let his mace rest with a grunt. Catra lowered the earthen wall. "A magicat champion. You might understand, then. The Council of Elders, Champions of Halfmoon, and Guardians of the Universe forged the Power Stones before the time of the first Skeletor," Mumm-Ra explained. "To wield but one means commanding power to rival gods."

"It's a trick," Catra snarled, claws sliding out. Several of the Thundercats made horrified meow-like noises at the sight of her trauma caps. "The Stone might be real, but it's got to be evil, especially if it's the opposite of Adora's."

Adora put a hand on her wife's shoulder. "I don't think so, Catra," she said, unhappy to disagree with her, but feeling little choice. "The First Ones were able to use the Light Stone for something terrible. The Darkness Stone can't be any different."

"Yeah," Lion-O joined in, "but there's gotta be a reason Mumm-Ra's sending us after it."

Mumm-Ra laughed and vanished. His people flickered in purple beams and disappeared immediately thereafter. Lion-O and Ratar-O gave one another uncertain looks. "Whiskers," Tygra huffed. "Mumm-Ra's been more trouble than ever since he got his hands on the Tech Stone."

Entrapta charged to the front of the group, eyes wide. "Did you say *Tech* Stone? How does it interact with technology? Creation? Manipulation? Do you have data?"

Adora and Catra shared a fond look. "Oh, here we go," Catra sighed, but they were both smiling. *We're going to be okay,* Adora decided.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"Whoa," Wilykit said, sitting on the top of her seat's back. "You guys have been through a lot."

Catra's tail lashed through the opening in the chair designed for it. "So have you," she insisted, glancing around the Cat's Lair war room. "I mean, Mumm-Ra framed our entire species."

Slithe grunted like a steam engine venting. "It is frustrating, yes? Horde Prime has overrun a quarter of our galaxy, yet the Ever-Living continues to pit world against world. Mumm-Ra tricked me into believing the Thundercats had wiped out my nest, when he did it just to gain my allegiance."

Glimmer stared in horror for a moment, then shook it off – they'd already heard the story once – and went over the galactic map hovering over the meeting room table. "So, we've got the

Interplanetary League, which is basically you guys, the Plundarr Empire – that sounds delightful – and Mumm-Ra, who's pretty much his own faction on account of being stupidly powerful."

"We've managed to liberate all League worlds the Horde conquered," Panthro added, lighting up a few star systems, "but Avista left the Empire to go back to the Horde when some old king of theirs showed back up."

Hordak's eyes narrowed. "Did they now," he muttered.

"Any ideas?" Lion-O asked.

Hordak shrugged, eyes turning yellow-green with misery. "I was merely...reminded of a cruel subordinate I should have reined in. Yet it seems that Lord Prime set him to monitor me for his own reasons."

"It's been our experience that despite Prime's casual disregard for his clones, he gets really upset if they go rogue," their canine ally Dobo noted.

"For a guy who likes to pretend he's above it all, he can get really petty," Tygra added.

Adora leaned forward. "You've fought him?"

Cheetara's chuckle was humorless. "Oh, no, Prime doesn't consider us worthy of his full attention. Three times, after we defeated one of his 'Beloved,' he showed up on a screen to tell us how little our resistance meant to him."

Double Trouble leaned back into their chair and grinned. "So the absolute order guy has drama too," they said, chin cupped in one hand. "Interesting."

"Look, this is all great, but right now we need to focus on the annoying rock," Catra pointed out. She glanced at Lion-O, who nodded and changed the map to one of the continent they were on. "Lion-O's magic sword told him that there's really a Darkness

Stone in that collapsed mountain. Unless one of you can bring in help from another planet, we've got to deal with that first."

"The Berbils might be able to help," Panthro offered.

Slithe, Dobo, and Tygra all groaned. Wilykit grinned. "The who now?" Scorpia asked.

"We met them on Third Earth," Lion-O explained. "They're robot bears–"

Entrapta leaped out of her chair. "Did you say *robots?"*

Panthro chuckled. "Yep. Robot bear engineers. Fixed up my Thundertank, helped build both Cat's Lairs, and even built me a new arm after I lost one shoving Grune into the astral plane." He extended his left arm over to a drink dispenser and got himself a glass of something amber-colored.

Catra's ears shot up before she could control herself, a purr escaping before she could stop it. "I'm gonna want to hear more about this tank of yours." She ignored Adora and Glimmer grinning behind her back. "First, how can the robo-bears help?"

"They're not much in a fight themselves," Lion-O said, "but they can handle just about anything with repair or building you could want. They can also roll themselves up into living wheels and keep up with most ground vehicles." He gestured at a wide cylinder on the far end of the room. "Most important for our purposes, they built a teleporation pad from their village to the Cat's Lair."

"Huh." Lonnie glanced at the weird device. "Sounds useful."

"It's not safe for organic life – no, not even you, Snarf," Wilykit said, leaning down to scratch between the ears of the red and white creature in her seat, "but the Berbils can go back and forth, easy."

"I'll take a look at it," Entrapta offered, pulling several tools out of her hair. Tygra and Slithe exchanged looks.

"Snaps, can you, uh, help ET with that?" Catra asked. "I want to have a look at this tank of Panthro's." She cleared her throat when she saw the grins from Adora, Glimmer, Bow, and Scorpia. "For – for the mission. You know."

"Why don't I pull up some specs?" Panthro offered, tapping a few keys. An image of the Thundertank appeared in front of Catra, with statistics listing its capabilities around it. "She's the toughest thing on this planet," the big Thundercat explained with a proud smile. "Her armor is 100% Thundrillium alloy. Two claw-shots, full scanner suite, particle cannon in the maw, twin cycle pods in front, a dozen missile silos in the back."

"How many of these do you have?" Catra asked, tail lashing in excitement. Adora hugged her.

Tygra and Lion-O grinned at each other. "Oh, here we go," Cheetara quipped, her tone and expression both fond.

"There's only one real Thundertank," Panthro began, chest swelling with pride, "but we've built eight more since our people began repopulating Thundera."

Catra's smile was predatory. "I think I have an idea. Prep Darla and the Feliner. Mumm-Ra's going to wish he'd never tried to get clever with *us."*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"She's not gonna hurt one of my babies, is she?" Panthro asked from his Thundertank's controls, glancing sideways at the tank rumbling beside them.

Adora chuckled and rubbed the back of her neck. "She's better with tanks than she is with skiffs. It'll be fine." She glanced at Lion-O. *I would've figured that we'd want to have the two magic sword people in different groups, but Catra knows what she's*

doing. Lion-O was looking at the Sword of Omens much the way Adora had been examining her Sword just a few minutes earlier. "Um, Lion-O?"

He looked up and smiled. It felt weird seeing him like that for some reason, strangely familiar somehow. "Oh, sure, She-Ra. What is it?" Lion-O asked.

She swallowed. "What do you know about these Runestones, Power Stones – you know," Adora stumbled, waving her Sword at his, "these things?"

Lion-O's smile was wry enough to remind Adora of Catra. "Honestly? Mumm-Ra just told me more than I ever thought I knew. Whiskers, I didn't even know what a Guardian of the Universe was until you showed up with a – she's really called a Green Lantern? Like a human torch?"

Adora couldn't help chuckling. "Lonnie says that a human torch is a whole different thing. Her ring knows stuff." She shrugged, her good humor fading fast. "So basically we're stumbling around in the dark, getting manipulated by bad people so we can maybe stop worse people." She looked out one of the slender windows. "It gets old fast."

"I hear you," Lion-O agreed. "Mumm-Ra's a shapeshifter." Adora winced. "I've lost track of how many times he's almost tricked us into destroying ourselves. We get how Slithe ended up on their side for a while."

"Also, Lion-O's kind of a sap," Panthro added with a grin, "but he makes it work somehow."

"Hey!" Lion-O objected, hands on his hips.

Adora giggled. "My friends call me a sap too. Even Catra, and Scorpia's right when she calls forgiveness Catra's real super-power." She walked up to stand beside the Thundercat king. "We've got to believe in people. Otherwise, what are these for?"

She turned the Sword back into a bracer, holding up her arm to emphasize the Runestone.

Lion-O nodded. "Different perspectives, same issues. Whatever we call the Stones, however we understand them, what matters is what we do with them." He sighed. "Though from what Jaga says, you've got power of your own." He stared into the Eye of Thundera. "Tygra, Cheetara, Panthro – they all have their own power. Everything I can do comes from 'stupid rocks.'"

"Hey," Adora objected gently, putting a careful hand on Lion-O's shoulder. "Catra didn't mean it like that."

Lion-O sighed again. "I know. It's just, Tygra was always better than me at everything. Sure, the Sword chose me, and the Spirit Stone, the Book, the crown...but Cheetara chose him." He managed a wry smile. "We both know he got the better deal. Tygra's probably telling your wife that right now. I can almost see the smirk on his face."

Adora's smile returned, almost matching Lion-O's. "Oh, I hear that. I mean, when we were in the Horde, I was the one who was 'better at everything,' except it turned out that 'everything' was the four things Shadow Weaver wanted me to be good at, and even then she didn't let Catra be..."

"A Cat," Lion-O finished. Adora nodded, her smile leaving her again. "It's an old story. Mumm-Ra and Plundarr have been allies against Thundera for as far back as even the Book of Omens can remember. A lot of people end up hating us for what we are." He ran a thumb over the Eye's surface. "Some of us can get bitter. Good cats turn bad."

"Like Grune," Panthro snarled.

Adora felt an old pain clutch at her. "And Pumyra?"

"No," Lion-O insisted, his ferocity familiar enough to sharpen that pain. "Pumyra has her reasons. I won't give up on her."

"You shouldn't," Adora agreed. Lion-O looked up at her in surprise. "I mean, I've seen enough timelines where Catra went down some...bad roads that I know you can't put up with Pumyra's nonsense." Her fingers went to the diadem on her brow before Adora realized what she'd done. "But if you believe in her, don't give up. You've already admitted your own mistakes. That's important. Don't let Pumyra off the hook for hers, but also, understand why she made them." She brought her arm back down, gazing into what the Thundercats called the Light Stone. "Understand your part in them. You'll reach her. I know it."

Lion-O's smile was like a star. "Thanks, Adora. That means more to me than you know."

Adora grinned back. "You'd be surprised."

Panthro huffed a chuckle. "Are you Adam's sister, or Lion-O's?" he asked, causing both royals to put their Swords away and rub the backs of their necks, almost in perfect synch. "See, that's exactly what I mean – whoa!" He swerved the Thundertank, forcing both Sword-wielders to grab handholds. "We've got Horde!"

Catra's joyful cackle echoed over the comms. A beam cannon's eruption followed. "Right on time!" Adora's wife cheered. "Weapons free – let 'em have it!"

Lion-O smiled and extended his Sword to full length. "She's optimistic."

Adora transformed her Sword back to its base form. "She probably thinks we've got the advantage. Also, she *really* likes tanks."

She pounded her fist on the hatch twice. Panthro opened the back, and the two heroes leaped out. Adora created platforms of Light that allowed the pair to leap toward the incoming Horde forces.

Each sliced, blasted, and punched through the fighters, heading for the lead cruiser. As they approached, the largest ship rose

from the rear of the formation to barrel down on them. “Lion-O!” an unfamiliar voice screeched over comms. “I will have the stone!”

Tygra laughed. “Are you still upset about that? Mumm-Ra stole your stone.”

“Maybe if you hadn’t pulled that stunt with the race, Vultaire would be on our side,” Lion-O grumbled. *Huh?* Adora wondered.

“Hey, it’s not my fault he’s a sore loser,” Tygra replied. “Besides, he was already plotting to sell Avista out to the Horde, you know that.”

Adora glanced at Lion-O. The king shrugged. “Long story,” was all he said.

The two heroes landed on the point cruiser and started running along its hull, tearing massive cuts into it with their blades. “Lion-O? You said this ‘Avista’ rejoined the Horde after their king came back. Do you know who he is?”

They reached the engines in unison. “All we have is a name and a skill set,” Lion-O replied. “Picked it up from intercepted chatter. Some wizard named Vultak.”

Adora’s eyes widened just before they tore out the main thrusters. “Oh no.” Once they landed on She-Ra’s Light platform, her hand flew to her earpiece. “Catra! Vultak’s here!”

“Huh,” Catra replied, sounding unconcerned. “Speedy, Petals, you’re up, wall of thorns time. Adora, keep the skies clear around them. Snaps, I know you’re going to protect Perfuma anyway, so focus on bringing down drones.”

Before Adora can ask, Lion-O does: “Wall of thorns?”

“I was about to–” She-Ra began, but seeing Cheetara plant her staff in the ground and grow roots through the mound of dirt and crystal answered her question. “Oh,” she replied while they blast their way to the command ship. “Perfuma can make plants grow.”

Lion-O paused between lightning blasts. “Big enough to bring down battleships?” he asked.

A massive column of vines and trees lanced up to spear half the remaining Horde forces. Lion-O gaped. “Yep. Also, my wife’s a genius,” Adora preened.

The Lord of the Thundercats stared, fingers of his Claw Shield twitching. “So, uh, do you think you and your friends could return and help us with Mumm-Ra after we defeat the Horde?”

Winged figures erupted from the battleship. About half had faces with beaks, while the most of the others were like harpies, with human faces and arms, and a few were like Vultak, human except for the wings and feathered crests rather than hair. “Sure, but let’s win this one first,” Adora said. They charged into battle again, back to back while knocking Birds out of the sky.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra already missed the Thundertank – *Maybe ET can build a bay in Darla for one,* she mused – but duty called, loudly, in the form of Vultak and his cronies. One of whom was Hunga, princess of murder-feathers. “Daughter of Angella!” she screeched. “I will drink your marrow!” She fired an impressive volley of impaling death at Catra.

“Wow, and I thought Shadow Weaver’s material was getting old,” she quipped, animating the nearby earth to block and encase the quite literally live ammunition. “You really need a new gimmick. Tygra?” Hunga squawked when a force she couldn’t see grabbed her by the ankles and threw her into oncoming drone troopers. Tygra became visible beside her, and the two warriors fist-bumped. “I’ve got to get one of those.”

“We’ll talk,” Tygra replied, his grin matching hers. “Who’s next?” Their Thundertank roared past, plowing through more drones. “Wilykit seems to be enjoying her new toy.”

“Don’t blame her,” Catra said, summoning a handful of freezefire. “Now let’s get the rock before Mumm-Ra sets off his trap.”

“You wield the Freezefire, but not lightning?” A new voice – a woman’s, smooth as Mystacor honey, and Catra would bet she was a sorceress – echoed from the nearest cavern into the former Mount Plundarr. “Summon your might, Thundercat.” She walked out, a Thundercat in fine robes, wielding a metal staff with some kind of spinning device at the top. Another Thundercat followed, this one with blank eyes but sure feet, life energy so overflowing in him Catra could feel it without effort.

“Jagara? Lynx-O? Thank Omens,” Tygra gushed, rushing over to hug the two older Thunderans. “We’ve been worried sick about you since you left Third Earth.”

Lynx-O scratched behind one ear. “I fear the Darkness Stone forced a detour. We would have needed to chase it anyway, but coming across it on the dark side of Third Earth’s moon drew us into something of an escapade.”

Jagara’s smile was wry, even while she held up her staff and cast lightning bolts at the drone fighters. That magnetized them, causing each strike to take out several fighters. “Escapade? More like a calamity. The Darkness Stone warped space and time themselves. We saw two different versions of our reality, as though our honor and ferocity had been split in two. One world was almost parodic in its delineation of good and evil, while in the other we were guilty of many things Mumm-Ra framed us for in our universe. We were lucky to survive.”

Catra and Tygra shared a look. “Mumm-Ra,” they said as one.

“You’ve adapted quickly, young Thundercat,” Lynx-O said, nodding as he punched several clones with a single blow – from twelve meters away. “When did you join?”

“She’s not with Cat’s Lair,” Tygra explained, whip catching a flying drone and throwing it into another. “Catra’s from *Halfmoon.”*

Jagara gasped. “It’s real?”

“Yeah, but we don’t have time to repeat the exposition dump, so the short version is there’s a bunch of us from Etheria allying with the Thundercats, Plundarr’s agreed to a truce, but Mumm-Ra’s too evil and arrogant to fight the Horde with us.” Catra unleashed the massive burst of freezefire she’d been holding on a marching set of drone troopers. Ratar-O’s forces proved her point by closing their pincer maneuver. Ratar-O attacked with a beam from twin daggers, while his generals Addicus and Kaynar leaped in to smash with polearms. Both were laughing like madmen.

“Again,” Jagara said, voice tinged with frustration, “why will you not call the lightning? You are one of the most powerful sorceresses I have ever seen.”

Catra sighed. “Wait until you meet my sister. Anyway, my friend Scorpia handles the lightning.” She used her tail to point at her friend’s crimson thunderstorm, which shielded Cheetara and Perfuma while they created a small forest. “An evil witch tortured me with the stuff most of my childhood. I don’t do lightning.” The magicat was almost used to the looks of horror by then, though Jagara’s seemed more intense than anyone’s except her parents and Adora.

“A pity,” Mumm-Ra’s voice echoed across the battlefield. The ruins of Mount Plundarr shook, piles of pink-red crystal chiming with the quake. “A champion of Halfmoon, unable to summon thunder. It would not have saved you, regardless.” A massive beast covered in bone armor erupted from the ruins. It looked like a giant brown dinosaur under the protective sheath, its arms small but sharp-clawed, and its legs were *massive.* “Nothing can save you – from Sycorax!”

Tygra took a step away from the monster, cracking his whip as much for his own reassurance as to warn the monster. “Whiskers,” he growled. Under other circumstances, Catra would have laughed.

Grune did laugh from atop the beast, leaping down toward them with that massive war club of his. Pumyra and Slithe's rival Sauro followed, taking off in different directions, Pumyra for Lion-O, Sauro for Ratar-O. "I hoped to test my power against yours, little champion," Grune rumbled, twirling the gigantic mace like it was a wand.

"Too bad," Tygra snarled, bracing himself to attack. Then Sycorax spread massive wings, jumped, and flew toward Lion-O. "It flies, too? Are you kidding me?

"Let me handle Grune, Stripes," Catra insisted, waving the Thundercat off. "Take your friends and deal with the dragon-thing."

"But that mace is pure Thundranium!" Tygra objected, watching the approaching Grune with fury that Catra knew hid concern. "The longer you're near him, the weaker you'll get, and one solid hit can knock out Panthro."

"Thundranium consumes Thundercat magic, young sister," Jagara added. "He is a match even for our king."

"Have faith in the magicat," Lynx-O said, surprising the other two Thundercats. "The same marks that convince her to reject the lightning protect her from such evil sorcery."

Grune smirked. "Even better. I almost wish Mumm-Ra hadn't made this thing for me sometimes."

Tygra huffed and dropped back. "If you die, I'll kill you," he snapped. Catra grinned. *I knew I liked him.* He spun the whip around him, disappearing. "Call your friends if he's too much."

"I will," Catra agreed, baring her teeth at the traitor, "but he won't be."

Grune's smirk vanished. "You pathetic little tail-born. I'm going to crush you flat with one blow!" He leaped to swing, power ripping in every muscle.

Catra laughed and shrunk to about Snarf's size, leaping out of the way long before he landed. "How does it feel to be Thundera's slowest person?" she mocked. Grune roared and gave chase. She hit him with fists of earth and blasts of fire, both freezing and traditional heat. Her smile faded away when he tanked her every blow, charging at her with furious abandon. Attacks that didn't roll off his armor or hide broke under his mace-club. *Scut. He's tough, and smarter than he looks.* She backed toward the mountain's wreckage, barely evading more swings and blasts from his weapon. *Good thing the Lynx guy was right about that thing not draining me. It's having some effect, though. My scars feel weird.* She risked a quick glance behind her. They were at the edge of the pit that held Mount Plundarr's ruins.

Grune's smirk returned. "How does it feel to be second best, little champion?" he mocked, raising the mace for a blow that would throw shrapnel all around them. Even Catra would have trouble dodging that.

So instead she collapsed the ground around them. Grune howled in frustration while Catra rode a stone platform under her control down to the crystals. "It sucks," she admitted, "but I'll never be second best to you. *Traitor."* Catra changed back to her humanoid shape, preparing to close the shifting ground over the sinking Grune–

The crystals were singing. "What the flark?" Catra gasped, staring at the Thundrillium. It was glowing. Even Grune stopped flailing, looking around him in disbelief. "Why are they – what is that music?"

"NO!" Grune roared, lashing out with a beam from his mace. It only hit Catra with a glancing blow, but that was enough to knock her into one of the largest clusters of Thundrillium. "You're a tailed freak from another world! Thundera is *mine!"*

"Silence, Grune," a new voice demanded. It was deep, older but strong, with a hint of echo. A translucent blue Thundercat who looked almost as old as Razz appeared between Grune and Catra.

“Greetings, Catriska D’Riluth. I am Jaga, sometimes called the Wise.”

“Yeah? By who?” Catra huffed, crossing her arms. She refused to let the way everything slowed down around them bother her.

Jaga stared for a moment, then smiled. It reminded her of Dad. “I suppose it doesn’t matter, except to say that the epithet was not my idea.” The smile vanished, and Jaga wrapped his cloak around himself. “We have little time, alas, and you have a decision to make. You are a magicat, a sorceress accepted by the Thundercats, and you are surrounded by rare quantities of powerful magic.”

Catra stared for a moment before groaning. “Is this about the lightning thing? Let me guess, Jagara’s your daughter or something.”

“Jagara is a distant relation from my clan,” Jaga replied, “and I am not here to direct you as she would. Rather, I am here to note an opportunity.” He spread his arm expansively to take in the crystals around them. “Thundrillium.” He pointed at Grune’s mace, rising in almost painful slow motion. “Thundranium. And you, here, with a unique potential granted by love, and a unique resistance born from cruelty.” Catra forced back her desire to snarl and listened. “With Power Stones around you and magic flowing as even Thundera has not seen for eons, you can achieve a small portion of advancement here.”

“Okay, and?” Catra asked.

“Earthshadow and Freezefire are two of the glories of once-lost Halfmoon,” Jaga explained, “but the Book of Omens speaks of the wonders our people achieved by finding balance between them. That can be your Roar, or the Swordlight, or any number of pathways. What calls to you, child of Etheria?”

Catra forced herself not to look at the Eye of Thundera. Nothing could equal the place Adora had in her heart, and she could never

imagine leaving her family, but this world – it called to her from the first time she heard the tale of ancient spirits of evil and the Sword of Omens. Nothing had ever taken that from the magicats. Someone else just took it from *her.* "It's not *fair,"* she wailed, tears starting to form on the edges of her eyes. "I hate it! Do you have any idea how hard I have to work to not lose it whenever Scorpia uses that stuff? Shadow Weaver – she – why do I have to keep going back there?"

Jaga looked sad. "You do not," he replied. "I can sense other ways. The kinetic arts of your blue seer friend. Moonlight you could share with your sister. Swordlight can merge with Spirit Ember to grant you sun-flame. Magic of the stars has always called to Cats." He drew back his cloak, the Thundercat symbol on his chest fierce red and black on the blue of his spirit form. "All I can speak to regarding the thunder is this. Would it be in keeping with Shadow Weaver's nature for her to hurt you with the very essence of your greatest potential?"

Catra's eyes blew wide. "She...that witch," she whispered. For a moment, it felt like her scars ached. Then Catra realized that it wasn't pain, just feeling – the numbness of all those electric burns giving way to new life. "She would. She *did,* didn't she?"

Jaga looked into her eyes. It was less creepy than Catra expected. "I cannot say for certain, Catra of Halfmoon. I can only ask you one last time: which gift sings to you? What do you want, champion?"

Catra knew even before the call rang out.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora grunted in frustration. Her power was enough to bat Sycorax around, but she was having trouble knocking the monster out. "What is this thing?" She-Ra asked, forming a platform in front of the creature and standing in its way.

“Sycorax,” Lion-O said, “some kind of ancient demon Mumm-Ra possessed. The last time we fought it, even the Sword of Omens couldn’t really hurt it.” His smile was sour, and his Sword no more than a dagger. “And no Lucy in sight this time.”

Before Adora could ask who Lucy was, the new Thundercat sorceress, Jagara, intervened with some kind of force shield. “Mumm-Ra does not possess the creature this time, my king, though it remains powerful enough that I cannot stop it even with my Regulator.”

“Your what now?” Adora asked. Jagara gave her magitech staff a little shake by way of explanation. “Huh. Okay, so what’s the plan–”

“Ancient spirits of evil,” Mumm-Ra chanted from somewhere below.

“Whiskers,” Lion-O muttered.

“Transform this decayed form – to Mumm-Ra, the Ever-Living!” Dark magic unlike anything Adora had ever seen or felt exploded from the cavern depths like a volcano of evil power. From the column of red lightning and shadow force (and didn’t that tear up delightful memories) came a figure twice Grune’s height, with massive draconic wings and armor unlike any She-Ra had faced before. It was some twisted counterpart to Thundercat magitech, complete with a mockery of the Claw Shield, though it had a variant of Eternia’s familiar skull motif. He bore the Sword of Plundarr in his right hand, with what had to be the Darkness Stone in its round slot. “Now I also bear two Stones, little king, and you still face both the Horde and my demon beast. When I tear the heart from your magicat champio–”

Adora’s patience shattered to dust. With a roar to do Catra proud, she flew straight at Sycorax, channelling all her power, her magic, her fury and terror and love, all into the Sword. Before anyone could react, She-Ra had sliced the monster lengthwise in two. “Whoa,” Lion-O whispered. “I better do my part, too.” He held out

the Sword of Omens, and the hilt spread once more. With each word, the blade grew again: "Thunder. *Thunder. Thunder! Thundercats – HO!"* The Eye of Thundera lit up like a star, its beacon flaring and roaring high overhead.

The Thundrillium sang out in response. This time, everyone heard it, not just the Thundercats. It was a inspiring anthem with a driving beat, not just calling out for victory, but demanding it. Adora spotted Catra below them. The Eye's light echoed within her. Sparks of blue and gold crackled around her. With a frustrated howl, Grune raised his warclub to attack Catra from behind. Adora braced herself to fly to Catra's defense, but the magicat held out a hand toward Grune. Without looking at him, she blasted him beyond sight with an azure bolt. The other Thundercats were glowing as well, their own powers coming to life in ways that frustrated both the Horde and servants of Mumm-Ra.

Vultak shooting out of the Darkness Stone as if from a sling caught everyone off guard, even the Ever-Living. He grabbed the Tech Stone and vanished into the shade of the ruins. Mumm-Ra's armor retracted into his gauntlet, leaving a still-impressive figure of muscle that towered over even Scorpia. "All Horde forces, retreat!" he ordered.

"NO!" Mumm-Ra screamed, firing a blast at the flickering shadows. Pale green beams of light lanced down and snatched up the remaining clones, drones, and assorted Horde forces.

Adora smirked at the undead – semi-dead? – villain while Vultak ran away yet again. "Y'see, this is why you should learn to play well with others."

Catra erupted in golden energy, practically appearing by Adora's side. "We'll need to get the other Stone back, but that's a problem for future Catra and Adora. Right now, we need to bring Mumm-Ra down *hard."*

"Bah!" Mumm-Ra held up the Sword of Plundarr. An explosion of dark power threw everyone around him back. "I will retrieve the

Tech Stone from that copycat. Oppose me at your peril!" With that, he cast shadow tendrils out to pick up his forces. They all vanished.

The Best Friends Squad, Super Pal Trio, Lonnie, and Perfuma all gathered on Adora's magic platform. "What just happened?" Glimmer asked. "Wildcat, why are you all spark-y?"

Scorpia gasped, and Catra's tail puffed out, but before either Adora or her wife could worry, the scorpioni's eyes gleamed like stars and she scooped Catra up in one of her (in)famous hugs. "Lightning buddies!" she cheered.

"Scorpia," Catra hissed, managing to not snap by a hair's width. The big princess put Catra down. "So. It turns out I'm, I dunno, compatible with Thundercats or whatever." She shrugged. "Some ghost guy named Jaga showed up and helped me out with that, I guess."

"Fascinating!" Entrapta cheered. "Did your past negative encounters create more help or hindrance to this ability?"

Catra stared at her best friend for a moment. "Um. I'm not sure? It started out messing with me a *lot,* but then Jaga pointed out Shadow Weaver probably did it on purpose." Adora's grip made the Sword's hilt creak. "After that, well, for all the therapy I've been through, spite is still a flarking great motivator."

"What matters is that you found your gift as a Thundercat," Lion-O agreed from a similar platform Jagara summoned. "That makes asking this harder."

"You can't join the fight against the Horde while that monster is after you," Adora said, letting She-Ra go and turning her Sword into a bracer. Catra's tail curled around her free wrist, a comfort that could get her through Darkness itself. "Trust me, I understand."

Bow shrugged. "There was a Skeletor," he explained.

Tygra held his forehead. "Of course there was."

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra didn't like this. It was *her* plan – with some help from Tygra, who could rival her for sneaky cleverness – and she still didn't like it.

Then again, no sane person would like sneaking into the pyramid-temple-spaceship thing Mumm-Ra used for a headquarters. The first layer of security alone had almost killed Bow and Wilykit. None of it would matter if they let the old horror take off and get another one of those portable Runestones they were dealing with.

And that made some idea tickle the back of her mind. "Tell me about your Runestones again, Leo," she half-asked.

Lion-O sighed while Tygra chuckled. "The War Stone is the Eye of Thundera. Mumm-Ra says it's the most powerful of the Stones, though after watching She-Ra cut Sycorax in half, I'm pretty sure he was wrong."

"Don't be," Catra replied. "She-Ra comes from Adora, not a rock. The Runestone's just a bonus." Adora's smile gleamed in the shadows of the creepy pyramid.

"Yeah," Lion-O agreed, but he sounded defeated. Catra only realized she'd been smiling with Adora when they both stopped at the same time.

Catra glanced at the Claw Shield. She'd wanted one ever since hearing its story in Halfmoon, and watching Lion-O use it only intensified her desire. "What about the Spirit Stone?" she asked.

"It can send you into the Astral Plane," Lion-O explained, "but I mostly use it as a shield. It can make armor and generate force fields."

That's all so – basic. Utilitarian. Catra shook her head. *Great. When did I get sentimental?* she wondered. "So, okay, War

Stone's offense, Spirit Stone's defense. Any idea how they work, or why they have those names? Spirit Stone kinda makes sense from what little I know about the Astral Plane, but War Stone's a little creepy for a magic thing."

"And names are important in magic," Cheetara added, rubbing her chin.

"It's been too much to think about in the middle of everything," Lion-O replied. "Mumm-Ra, Plundarr, the Horde, restoring our people here on Thundera – the Stones work, and I have to keep them out of Mumm-Ra's hands."

"*We* have to, kid," Panthro said, giving Lion-O a nudge on the shoulder.

"Right." There was that beaten-down tone in the king's voice again. Catra's tail lashed. "Protecting the War Stone is probably a Thunderan king's most important duty."

"Lion-O." Tygra looked serious. It was weird to Catra, seeing someone so much like her doing that from the outside. "I know I've given you crap for, well, a lot. And I've had reason, sometimes."

"Great pep talk, Tygra," Lion-O quipped, forcing a smile.

"*But."* Tygra put his hands on his hips. "You're not just a dumb rock either. You're the Lord of the Thundercats. We found the Book of Omens, restored our world, returned billions of our people back home. You beat *death,* Lion-O. There's power in you, too."

That got Lion-O perked up again, if the way his ears swiveled up was any indication. "Thanks, Tygra."

They'd be so much easier to read if they had tails, Catra mused. That, too, sparked a memory. "Hey, what did Grune mean when he called me 'tail-born?'"

Wilykit hissed. "It's mean," she said.

Panthro huffed. “Some Thunderans believed that having a tail made you less civilized, like a throwback to our ‘savage’ ancestors.” He rubbed the base of his back. “Grune cut mine off in the fight where he betrayed me.”

“Well. That’s...scut,” Catra said, ears pivoting back. Memories of her evil counterparts flickered through memories. She pooled lightning in each palm, one blue, the other gold. Like her eyes. “Do you think...”

“He’s not like you,” Panthro insisted, ears straight up. Catra couldn’t tell if his look was more glare or more insistence. “We grew up with a lot of privilege. Grune earned his rank, yeah, but it was never enough for him. I just didn’t see it.”

“He didn’t want Panthro, if that’s what you’re thinking,” Lion-O added, glancing around him with a paranoia Catra understood. They were on a walkway surrounded by darkness that seemed endless. “He just wanted the throne.”

Adora looked away. Catra batted She-Ra with her tail before the First One could get lost in her own head again. “Hey, quit it. You’re nothing like Grune.”

“Grune works for *him,”* Wilykit snarled. It was completely unlike anything the kit had said or done before. *Not like I’ve known her that long,* Catra reminded herself. “He’s gonna pay.”

“I feel like we might have missed something when we were sharing stories,” Bow offered, tone as careful as his words.

The adult Thundercats, aside from Lynx-O, glanced at Wilykit, and the old general’s ears twitched, pivoting toward her. “It’s fine,” the Thunderkitten said in that tone Catra had long since learned meant someone was very much not fine. She’d used it often enough, after all. “Mumm-Ra killed my brother.”

Most of the Etherians gasped. Catra managed to keep her own sympathy to a low whine and a tail slash. Hordak growled, his eyes glowing a deeper red for a moment. DT glared at Catra for a

moment, the *I blame you for this* self-evident ("this" being the conscience they claimed to hate). "When we drove Mumm-Ra from Third Earth, he tried to destroy it, because he's a sore loser. And a monster. Kat stopped him. Saved us all." Wilykit's eyes shone with unshed tears. *I don't care if he's already dead, I'm going to kill him,* Catra swore. The kit hugged a small bag close. "He just...couldn't save himself, too." All her friends looked messed up by that, but Adora looked even worse than Bow. Catra wound her tail around Adora's wrist. That seemed to help, if the way Adora's breathing steadied was any indication.

They reached the next door in silence. Entrapta dealt with the electronic lock while the rest of them readied their weapons. When ET got the door open, they found a large chamber with four statues, a basin of water, and what Catra thought Halfmoon called a sarcophagus. *Just keep your mouth shut, Catriska,* she told herself, but she'd never been good at listening – not even to herself. "You gonna manage in here, Wilykit?" Catra whispered.

Wilykit let one talon play at the drawstring of her bag. "I have to." Catra nodded at that.

Lion-O looked around the room. "I think...this is where Mumm-Ra does magic." He looked up at the vulture-headed statue. "Ancient spirits of evil," he whispered. Then the king looked up and his eyes went wide. Catra followed his gaze. Three stories overhead was what looked like the biggest ship bridge she'd ever seen. Even the Horde capital ships they'd faced didn't have that vast open space looming over them. "He's not up there either? Then where–"

"Trap!" Adora and Catra shouted at the same time, going back to back. On cue, Mumm-Ra's forces attacked. A majority were lizardfolk, but there were passable numbers of canines, primates (ape and human), birdfolk, and Thunderans. Grune, Sauro, and a new canine led them, with Mumm-Ra and Pumyra watching from overhead.

Only when the battle began did Catra realize that about a third of their enemies were undead. "Gah!" Catra yelped, shattering a platoon of zombies with freezefire. "That is disgusting!" More walking corpses climbed out of the water in a basin far too shallow to hold them.

"Bigger problems, Wildcat!" Glimmer cried, blasting in all directions.

"Not really – we don't have to hold back against zombies," Adora pointed out.

"Easy for people without fur to say," Catra griped. "I'm going to be scrubbing for hours."

"No," the canine growled, approaching Catra. "You won't." She tried blasting him with more freezefire to help Adora with Grune, but the Dog just walked right through her cold-flame. To the magicat's endless relief, Panthro tackled Grune with an infuriated roar. Somehow, the big Thundercat seemed to resist the Thundranium stuff through sheer rage. Lion-O's ability to clear out mobs came to a halt when Mumm-Ra flew down at him, the Darkness Stone in the Sword of Plundarr.

"Okay, and you are?" Catra asked, giving the canine a once-over since she couldn't just blast him. He was about Catra's height, maybe a bit taller, but with muscles like Scorpia's. He wasn't dead, but he sure didn't look healthy, with the same almost-decaying flesh of Mumm-Ra's and glowing red eyes, and there was definitely an aura of evil magic around him. He was "dressed" almost identically to his master, with golden bracers on his forearms and shins, and an armored skirt around his waist. Most worrisome was the truly massive axe he wielded, its shaft as tall as Catra and the head as wide as Scorpia's chest.

Mumm-Ra laughed while he pushed Lion-O back. Tygra seemed desperate to reach him, but the big warrior was almost drowning in foot soldiers. "That is my most loyal commander, little champion. Mamutt! Destroy her!"

Mamutt smiled with a mouth full of fangs. “Gladly, master.” He leaped at Catra.

Golden lightning shot Catra out of his way, and sapphire bolts threw him back. That got his attention at last, stunning him a little, but he shook it off before Catra could follow up. She drew her clawsword and lineshield instead. “Gonna be harder than that, Mutt,” she quipped, twirling the sword-staff.

“Defiant Cat,” Mamutt snarled. “I will present your skin to the Ever-Living as a trophy.” He approached carefully, not letting his boast distract him. *Great. He’s the smart one.* Mamutt swung, and when Catra tried to parry, he sliced clean through her clawsword. She fired her lineshield’s cord in desperation, and the canine warrior’s next slash ruined the cable. *Scut!* With the pyramid’s metal defying her Earthshadow, she prepared to rely on her newfound speed.

Instead, She-Ra slammed into Mamutt, knocking him back. “No,” Adora said with ferocity she usually reserved for Horde leaders. Catra managed to clamp down on a purr. “You *won’t.”*

“Keep him busy, Adora,” Catra said, leaping toward Lion-O while She-Ra drove Mamutt back. *I hate to give that monstrosity credit, but most bad guys only take Adora one swipe to go down. She’s got him, though.* She landed beside the Thunderan king, adding her lightning to his. “You’ve got a plan,” she noted.

“Part of one,” Lion-O admitted. “I think I’ll need your help with the rest.”

“Ha!” Mumm-Ra mocked, driving both cats back with a swing of his Sword. Dark energy pulsed out in waves. “The boy king imagines himself a mastermind. You have no chance against me.”

“Blah blah blah, invincible,” Catra retorted before Lion-O could respond, “we get it, you’ve been around. We ended the whole Skeletor line. You’re a speed bump, Dumb-Ra.”

Catra's fur stood on end when Mumm-Ra smiled back at that. "Impressive, child," he said, and Catra's skin felt cold, "but I have survived the fall of ten thousand Skeletors. I will reign when you and the heir of Leo are distant memories."

"Lion-O," Catra pivoted. "Listen, there's only one She-Ra, but you're more than just a dumb rock, too," she insisted, gritting her teeth while Mumm-Ra pushed back against their combined power. "All your friends have magic. I know there's some in you, too." *Though there's something else about the Stones, I know I'm missing something.*

"Sorry. It's just the Sword," he replied, though he grinned. "I do have a few tricks up my sleeve, though. El-Dara!" Lion-O roared.

What? Catra wondered, but then Wilykit opened her bag. Which was a lot bigger than she remembered. "Rokenbass!" Wilykit shouted, pulling the bag farther open than should have been possible. Blue-green light surged from the sack, and a bunch of cute robot bears surged out. "Did you forget my Forever Bag again, Dumb-Ra?" Wilykit mocked, sticking out her tongue.

The aforementioned bears turned into flying wheels, because of course they did, and erupted across the spreading battlefield. Ricocheting between Mumm-Ra's soldiers, the Berbils drove the pyramid's forces back. "Bah," Mumm-Ra scoffed, and Catra couldn't help raising an eyebrow at that. "Using the same trick against me, twice? Foolish!" He held up his gauntlet, and the ship's systems turned on the Berbils. Somehow, though, the weird creatures managed to evade most of the blasts, and survive the few that knocked them down. "What?"

"Like the Berbils wouldn't have been ready for that," Wilykit said, pulling a hoverboard from the bag. "This is for Wilykat!" She raced at him, dashing for the Darkness Stone.

Oh, no, Catra thought, horrified. Mumm-Ra turned to swing at Wilykit, deflecting their lightning with his gauntlet. Out of ideas, the magicat leaped, Changing into her largest form, landed on

Mumm-Ra's chest plate, and Roared in his face. Mumm-Ra screamed and slammed Catra aside with the gauntlet, but that was enough for Wilykit to – change course and catch Catra on her hoverboard? She immediately shrank to housecat size, allowing Wilykit to pull up.

That gave Catra a perfect view of Pumyra diving past Mumm-Ra, the Darkness Stone already in her hand. "Huh," Catra muttered. "I guess she is like me."

"No," Pumyra said, smirking and placing the new artifact in Lion-O's Claw Shield. Lion-O's gauntlet grew a slot for the Darkness Stone. "I was always a triple agent." Mumm-Ra's armor retracted into his gauntlet, leaving the villain in his "normal" war form."You were so busy hunting clerics, you forgot about the monks."

Lion-O's grin joined Pumyra's smirk. "Gotcha," the king said, holding up the Shield. Its power flowed over Lion-O's armor, turning it into a full suit that matched Mumm-Ra's in resilience if not size. "I might not be He-Man or the She-Ra, but I can still beat you, oh Ever-Living one." He extended a force shield around Pumyra with the Darkness Stone.

"That's it," Catra gasped. "Lion-O! You've got the wrong Stone in the Sword of Omens!"

Lion-O turned a confused look on Catra, but Mumm-Ra got it the moment she spoke. "Silence, Cat!" he snarled, firing a bolt from the Sword of Plundarr.

Catra dodged, landing behind the king's magic shield. "The War Stone's about raw power, but the Sword's best at finding things and bringing the Thundercats together, right? Why are you using a weapon for that stuff–"

"When I have the Spirit Stone!" Lion-O finished, snarling in frustration. "That's what Jaga meant. I'm an idiot!"

"We know," Tygra quipped, swinging past with Mamutt's ankle in his free hand, "but you're our idiot. Now swap Stones and blast

the creep!"

"As if I would give you that chance!" Mumm-Ra raised the Sword, his vile magic surging through it.

She-Ra slammed into Mumm-Ra with a shoulder check, locking Swords with him. "Did you not see Tygra dealing with your ax-guy, Dumb-Ra?" she asked, that cocky (hot) smirk turned on the Ever-Living at full force.

"Stop. *Calling.* ME THAT!" Mumm-Ra howled, going at She-Ra with all his might.

Catra's fur stood on end again when she realized he was a match for She-Ra even without a Runestone. "Nope," Adora said, popping the "p" just to be a little scut. *Stars, I love her,* Catra thought, adding her own magic to Lion-O's dark-shield while he swapped the other two Stones. "Catra, go be brilliant! We've still got to deal with this temple-spaceship-pyramid thing."

Catra stared for a moment. "Sure, I'll just – huh," she cut herself off. *Spaceship.* Catra's smile was as cunning and sharp as the Sword of Omens. *Entrapta.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

I thought fighting Grizzlor was fun, Adora thought.

Mumm-Ra was an amazing opponent. He could match her in strength, magic, and blow for blow with a sword. He was fast, tough, capable, and smart. The only thing that dampened She-Ra's enthusiasm was remembering Wilykit's heartbroken revelation. It helped that Mumm-Ra was *not* enjoying himself the way Adora was. "I will destroy you, She-Ra!" he snarled.

"Yeah, right," Adora scoffed, locking Swords with him. "Do you have any idea how many times I've heard that? The only person who came close was Catra, and she *married* me. You're pretty much flarked."

"You're also too late," Lion-O added, dropping his dark shield. There was a new gadget on Pumyra's crossbow-sling, one holding the Darkness Stone. As Catra suggested, the War Stone was in the Claw Shield, and the Spirit Stone was in the now-shrunken Sword of Omens. "Leo let you get into his head. So did I. Thundercats are meant to be a shield *against* war, and this?" He held up the Sword. "This brings us together. Makes Thundercats one. Let me show you how."

Mumm-Ra screamed and threw all his power against She-Ra. Adora pushed back, refusing to give a toenail's worth of ground. "Thunder," Lion-O chanted. Mumm-Ra switched tactics, flying upward. Adora leaped up into his face, turned the Sword into a warhammer, and slammed him back to his weird basin thing. *"Thunder. Thunder! Thundercats – HO!"* When the signal filled the air, it didn't take a Thundercat to feel the difference. The Spirit Stone, now the true Eye of Thundera, united the Thundercats – and even to some extent, the rest of the allies – in purpose and capability. Panthro rallied against Grune with some of Cheetara's speed and Catra's resistance to Thundranium. Tygra added the strength of the others to his own, driving back Mamutt. Slithe threw Sauro into the statue that looked like a crocodile merged with a snake.

Adora landed in front of Mumm-Ra, feeling more powerful than ever. She pointed her Sword at him. "It's over, Mumm-Ra. Surrender." She saw fear in his eyes at last.

"It is not over," the – statues? – said, in four voiced merged to one, "until we say it is!" The crocodile-snake statue came to life, eyes glowing. "Apophis will consume you all!" The others began rumbling.

"Whiskers," Lion-O sighed. "Which one do you want, She-Ra? The Ever-Living, or the ancient spirit?"

"Mumm-Ra's your bad guy," Adora replied, turning to face statue-Apophis and readying her Sword. "She-Ra exists to fight ancient spirits of evil." Lion-O nodded and rocketed into Mumm-Ra with

some of Cheetara's speed, then vanished like his brother. Apophis swung a stony fist crackling with familiar crimson magic. Adora sliced the hand clean off. "You really weren't listening, were you?" she asked with a smirk.

The pyramid's engines weren't quite like Darla's, but Adora was familiar enough with spaceship drives by then that she recognized the sound. That fact astounded Adora for a moment before she caught herself. Entrapta's gleeful cackle followed. "Adora!" Catra called from above, leaning over the edge from the weird bridge. "Time to go!"

"Almost," Pumyra said, leaping over the basin. She put the Darkness Stone into her wrist-sling and fired it into the water. The entire ship groaned and shook. "Okay, now we leave."

"WHAT HAVE YOU DONE?" Mumm-Ra cried, falling back against Lion-O's ferocious advance.

"You wanted the Darkness Stone, Mumm-Ra?" Lion-O snapped, driving the Sword of Omens into the monster's left arm. "Congratulations, it's all yours! Except it's going to drag you down into the Heart of Thundera – with some help from your own engines!"

"What part, of 'time to go,' do you people *not understand?"* Catra yowled. "Entrapta opened a gateway up here, let's move!"

They moved, Wilykit gathering the Berbils back up with her Forever Bag while everyone raced to the bridge. "How did you open a gate?" Lonnie asked, slamming another evil spirit back with a green battering ram.

"I combined the hyperspace engine conduits with the energy field in the fascinating chamber below us, then applied the unique signature of the Darkness Stone to–" Entrapta stopped when half of the heroes dashed for the portal while the other half stared in confusion. Only Panthro seemed to understand, grinning. Entrapta

and Catra shared weary smiles. “I used math,” she finished instead.

“You can tell us the rest in the Cat’s Lair!” Adora shouted, the rumbling of the pyramid growing worse. They all looked down, where a shrunken, red-cloaked Mumm-Ra was retreating into his sarcophagus, then up at the falling debris, then at each other.

“You might have won this day,” Mumm-Ra snarled as his tomb closed around him, “but as long as evil exists – Mumm-Ra *is!”*

“Good for you!” Adora retorted. “See you in a thousand years!” All four remaining heroes jumped through the gateway. Entrapta pulled another gadget out of her hair, with her hair, and closed the portal with the press of a button. “Whew!” Adora sat on the floor in sheer relief. “So, Catra, short version: what just happened?”

Catra’s smirk was cocky and (hot and) triumphant. “We set the engines to fly the pyramid...straight down. The Darkness Stone is drilling into the earth and filling in the tunnel behind it. He *might* get out in less than a thousand years, but it’s going to take him a while – MMPH!” Adora’s kiss interrupted her wife’s gloating, not so much because the gloating was a problem, but because Adora couldn’t stop herself.

Catra purred, so Adora counted it as a win.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

“The Thundercats owe you a debt we can never repay,” Lion-O said, shaking hands with Adora. “Rest assured that we will begin by uniting with you against the Horde.” Out in front of the Cat’s Lair, a new shuttle combining Thundertank elements with First Ones spaceship engines – the Thunderclaw – was docking with Darla thanks to some modifications by Entrapta, Panthro, Hordak, and the Berbils. *Robot teddy bears. Just when I think I’ve run into the weirdest thing I can,* Catra mused.

“Trust me, that’s repayment enough,” Adora replied, then composed herself. Catra rolled her eyes. *Dork,* she thought just

before Adora proved her right. “This is how defeating the Horde begins. When we stand together, the Rebellion can overcome anything Prime throws at us.”

“The Interplanetary League indeed stands with you,” Slithe agreed. His smile was oddly small given his wide mouth. “Ratar-O is also a temporary ally of the Rebellion, so Plundarr will at least not be a hindrance,” he added with wry amusement.

“I’m afraid there’s little we can offer the Darla or her crew, given the resources you already have,” Jagara began.

“I disagree!” Entrapta cheered. That got several fond smiles and chuckles.

“Most of your friends won’t see much use from the Thundrillium crystals,” Panthro pointed out, “or the Thunderclaw.”

Tygra grinned. “Thing is, most of you seem fond of your resident Thundercat.”

Catra’s tail stuck straight out, fur puffing up. “Magicat,” she muttered.

“We understand that your loyalty is to Etheria, Catra,” Lion-O agreed, stepping forward. A squat Thunderan who almost looked like an upright Snarf stood behind and to the left of the king, a sizeable case in his hands. “Yet we would be grateful if you would accept the title of honorary Thundercat. Osbert?” Entrapta let out a little squee when Osbert stepped forward. He twisted a handle, and legs sprouted from the case, turning it into a little stand while it opened. Catra whistled.

“Our gear can’t surpass the Eternians’ tech for everyone else,” Panthro explained with a grin, “but Thundrillium alloy will be almost indestructible in your hands, or as armor, thanks to your magic.” On the table was a set of blue Thundrillium armor plates that would replace the ones from Eternos. They still fit the suit Entrapta had made for her.

Those weren't even the second-best part, though. That would be the replica Claw Shield, blue with gold trim, with a Thundrillium gem that sang to her new lightning magic. Easily the best, though, was her new clawsword, if it was even a clawsword. It was half blue and half gold, like some mix of Cheetara's staff and Panthro's nunchucks. She picked up the weapon while Adora started replacing her old armor plates with the new ones. "Good eye," Tygra laughed. "I did promise you a whip, didn't I?"

"It's a whip too?" Catra blurted. The moment she had a firm grip on the blue end, she felt the shifting bands under the handle. A flick of her wrist revealed an extending chain, and the gold end split into three claw-hooks like bladed versions of Tygra's whip.

"It's all Thundrillium alloy. That's why I used a chain," Panthro explained. "It can't make you invisible, but the parts reconfigure to work like Tygra's whip, your old clawsword, or my nunchucks. The blue end channels your Freezefire, while the gold enhances your lightning bolts. I call it, the Thunderlash," he said with pride. "The same crew that designed the Thunderclaw put this together for you."

"I can't believe you missed the chance to say 'whipped it up,' Panthro," Tygra quipped. Lion-O groaned while Cheetara shoved him on the shoulder.

"I'll leave the dad jokes to you," Panthro retorted. Tygra and Cheetara blushed in unison. *Huh,* Catra thought. *Must be early days yet.* "Anyway, you can also use your magic to generate a force shield with the gauntlet. It won't be as powerful as the Gauntlet of Omens," but it should still come in handy."

"That's more like it," Tygra added. Panthro facepalmed while the others laughed.

"Wait, the Claw Shield has a name?" Catra asked.

"Of course that's what you focus on," Adora chuckled, hugging her wife after putting on the last piece of Thundrillium armor. "Nerd."

“Dork.” Catra gave Adora a quick kiss on the cheek before turning back to the Thundercats. “I don’t know what to say.”

“You and your team just buried Mumm-Ra for years,” Lion-O said. “Maybe decades. We’re honored to join you in the fight against Horde Prime.”

Pumyra walked up and took Lion-O’s hand. Catra and Adora couldn’t help smiling. “Knowing Mumm-Ra’s intel on Etheria, you already have a plan for that,” she noted.

Catra nodded, holstering the Thunderlash and donning her Claw Shield. “Yeah. What we did here? We’re going to do it in a bunch of other galaxies,” she explained. “Push back the Horde where they don’t control everything, and help resistance forces where they do.”

“Once Horde Prime is trying to put out a dozen fires at once, we make sure he knows who lit them,” Adora added.

“And when he comes for us,” Glimmer joined in, “we’ll be waiting for him. All of us, Etheria, Eternia, Oa, Thundera, and all the other friends we’ll make.”

Pumyra whistled. “That’s...a good plan,” Tygra said, though his voice was subdued. “Risky as Void, but good.”

“Any ideas about where we can start more drama?” DT asked, head tilted and smile gleaming wide.

Cheetara froze for a moment. Tygra gripped her shoulder until she came out of it. She glanced at Adora. “My speed is just the combat application of my clerisy training. Sometimes, I get visions.” That reminded Catra fondly of Peekablue, but Cheetara continued before the magicat could unpack any of that. “Have any of you heard of Cybertron?”

Chapter End Notes

Quick note: I don't expect to make a whole lot of use of Thundercats' Power Stones. The universe is a big place, so things like the Autobot Matrix of Leadership will be their own wonders.

So as I've mentioned in responses to comments, Turn Right's Thundercats are a mix of the original 80s version and the 2011 update. They definitely look and sound like their 2011 counterparts, but some of the drama -- and the vast majority of the Cats' horrifying racism -- has been removed from this variant. I also made Avista Vultak's homeworld, because come on, just look at Vultaire. ;-) Also, I have an (estimated) final chapter count! Just don't expect the next update for at least a couple of months; I have pro writing to catch up on. Also also, Tygra *absolutely* told Catra that Cheetara choosing him meant he got the "better deal." Also^3, yes, Cheetara's just gotten pregnant with future!Bengali.

Next time: Our Heroes light those fires across the universe, and begin to grasp the true scale of the challenge awaiting them in a series of crossover vignettes. Witness the beginning of the end in "The Beacons Are Lit"!

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